THE BROKEN EMPIRES

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isbn
979-8-99328-599-3

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special thanks to:

All my playtesters, consultants and supporters:
Ivan Sorensen, Ashley O'Connell, Dan Cook,
Sebastian Kroon, Brian Jaeger, Alex Jaeger, Trevor Legault,
Rob Kenney, Gabor Vida, Ian Young, Craig Matthews,
M. Travis White, Ty McMahon, Simon Ward,
Kelsey Dionne, Professor Dungeon Master,
Dave Thaumavore, Baron de Ropp, and Ben Milton;

All my "Me, Myself and Die!" subscribers, especially my
Patrons and YouTube channel members;

All my Kickstarter backers, who allowed me to take them
along for this exciting ride;

All those previous giants of RPG design,
upon whose mighty shoulders I dare to stand;

My wife Nisa, without whose support and encouragement
I would be neither YouTuber nor RPG designer;

And to Simon, Arn, Edbert, and Veil, from whose stories
this game was birthed, and of whose world I have been
allowed to catch a fleeting, but precious, glimpse.

Printed by Unicool Game Manufacturing in Shenzhen, China.

for additional game resources visit:

www.thebrokenempiresrpg.com

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designer's notes

This is a roleplaying game of "greatest hits". I have taken many of the elements of all my favorite RPGs and tried to make them work together in this new form. Not all elements made the cut; no matter how hard you push, sometimes you just can't fit a square peg into a round hole. As for ingenuity and originality, I haven't tried to reinvent the wheel with the game system. There is already a world of dice mechanics, and endless permutations, variations, and translations of so many different systems that it would be arrogance personified to assume I could think of a truly "new way" of doing things. That said, I like to think I have succeeded in re-ordering some of the aspects of my favorite games in a way that is consistent and fun.

I have been inspired in this game's creation by more RPGs than I can count. In it, you will find the DNA of Harnmaster, Ars Magica, Mythras, The One Ring, Delta Green, Warhammer Fantasy Roleplay, Savage Worlds, Forbidden Lands, Burning Wheel, Traveller, RuneQuest, Fate, GURPS, an obscure little game called Dominion Rules, and yes, even The World's Oldest Roleplaying Game That Shall Remain Unnamed For Fear Of Attracting A Lawsuit. I thank all of those games' creators (and the creators of all of those games that, in my forgetfulness, I have failed to mention here) for providing me countless years of breathtaking exploration of imaginary worlds too innumerable to list.

The Broken Empires RPGwas designed around my own likes and sensibilities. It had to have elements that I enjoyed, without regard to what was currently popular, or on the DriveThruRPG best-sellers list. It needed to play relatively fast, because pace is such an important element for me as a GM. However, fast-moving games tend to be very rules-light, and I confess I quickly grow bored with such games. My system, therefore, also had to be complex enough to hold my interest.

This is a game that is definitely on the "rules-heavier" side of the fence. It is decidedly not an OSR game, nor is it a "story game" (not that I have anything against either of those). If anything, it falls squarely in the "simulationist" camp, but pulled back from the brink of overcomplexity (hence the term "Sim-Lite"). I enjoy many (many!) roleplaying games, especially those with some mechanical meat on the bones. Professor Dungeon Master of the Dungeon Craft YouTube channel likes to say that the dice are simply "math rocks" that determine whether a character succeeds or fails. While I appreciate the pith of this sentiment, I also admit that I really enjoy engaging with game mechanics. They focus my narrative attention and determine the aesthetic of a game. It is true that mathematically there isn't a ton of difference between rolling a d20 and a d100--but anyone who's ever spent significant time playing RPGs knows that they are very different in feel. (And for those of you who claim that 1% increases don't really matter: a one-percent increment in skill value makes all the difference if I need a 63 or less on a d100 to succeed, but I then roll a 64... let alone the fact that the granularity of a d100-based skill system not only more satisfyingly teases out character progression in a more nuanced, gradual manner, but also serves overall verisimilitude... but alas, my inner Grognard begins to run away with me. Winky face, winky face.)

All this to say, I get excited by systems that show me new and interesting ways of resolving situations, and that do a lot of the descriptive heavy-lifting for me. That's what I've tried to create here. This game is designed to shoulder some of the GM's narrative burden by providing die-rolling me-

chanics that tell a lot of the story themselves. The resolution system can provide descriptive shape that helps the players and GM really visualize the characters' actions in the world. "Math rocks" they may be, Professor, but I see in them the oracular possibilities of unrealized worlds!

While the rules of The Broken Empires RPG lie on the more complex side, this isn't a physics engine or a reality simulator. It's still a game: it's designed to evoke the feel of reality without having to deal with all of reality's repercussions. Otherwise, getting in a fight with swords would be no fun at all, as in reality, recovering from sword wounds could lay you out for months. That just isn't fun. Hence, "Sim-Lite": we keep the perceived dangers of a real-feeling world without experiencing all of the true consequences of it.

For you solo players out there, I have enlisted Tana Pigeon of the Mythic GM Emulator and Shawn Tomkin, the creator of Ironsworn, to help me turn this engine into something that can be run solo-style. There is an entire chapter on solo play that gives tools and guidance on how to "Ask the Weave" instead of a GM.

In many places in these rules, you'll see the phrase, "Just be reasonable", or similar. Believe it or not, this isn't just a dodge around good game design. The Broken Empires RPG rulebook isn't a Tome of Ultimate Rulz that will tell you how to handle every conceivable situation that might arise in the game. This isn't Pathfinder 2e! This is a "sim-lite" game: simulation-light. The simulation gives you rules on how to bring the world to detailed life through the mechanics themselves. The lite allows you to be as flexible as you need with those rules, so long as both GM and players are coming to a reasonable conclusion that satisfies all sides. Much of what a Broken Empires GM does is about improvising in the moment and interpreting prompts--be they from a table of random descriptors or from the players themselves--to make a believable, consistent, and satisfying judgement. Your interpretations of the rules are going to be key to your own good judgment, and you must trust yourself and your players to make them.

The magic system, for example, can produce results far beyond what any list of premade spells

designer's notes

can. I can't possibly account for every possible combination of magical effects that you and your table are going to come up with. That's where reasonableness comes in. At some point, you're just going to have to make a call. Is invisibility a matter of changing the light around an object (Change Air), or is it about fooling someone else into not seeing the object (Control Thought)? Or is it something else entirely, or is it not even allowed in your campaign? You won't always find a definitive answer in this book; how the magic ultimately operates is up to you and your group. At some point, you'll have to trust your own interpretations and roll with your decisions. These rules try to give you solid mechanical guidelines to do just that.

So if you want to "break" the game, there are many places to do it. But--presuming you're not just one of those jerks that smash other people's toys for fun--why would you? If you're looking for a game that sacrifices everything on the altar of Holy And Perfect Game Balance, you'd best look elsewhere. That's not what this game cares about. This game assumes mature, good-faith players as its participants, who are looking to experience a world through the eyes of their characters, and who can trust a robust set of rules to facilitate their meaningful choices and support their creativity.

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This is a game of heroic fantasy, though not as many have come to know it. A hero is made by the actions he takes, not the special abilities he has, or the "Level" he has attained. The world of the Broken Empires is hard and dangerous, capricious and random. It spares no one; PC and NPC alike are equally imperiled by the whims of fortune. There is no "plot armor" here, no class-based niche protection. Each character lives or dies by their own choices, and by the unfeeling roll of the dice. This is a game of slow, incremental improvements; of quick, brutal combats whose participants wear the wounds they've suffered; of wild, complex magic that requires both skill and subtlety to master.

In the Broken Empires, the gods of fate are always weaving the strands of reality in ways most pleasing only to themselves. It is a world--and a game--where the dice always tell the story.

Welcome to it.

-- May 2026

cHAPTER 1:

introduction

The Broken Empires RPG (TBE) is a fantasy roleplaying game in which a small group of players, typically three to four, each create and control a character (known as a Player Character , or PC), make choices about their character's unfolding circumstances, and roll dice to determine the outcome of those choices. The Player Characters take action, and the Gamemaster (GM) describes how those actions affect the fictional world, the Non-Player Characters (NPCs) who inhabit it, and the PCs themselves.

The focus of this game is slightly different from your average "dungeon-crawler". This isn't a game about killing monsters, accumulating treasure, and "leveling up"--unless the character's objectives suggest that it is. PCs in the Broken Empires have goals , some individual and some shared with the group. The pursuit of those goals is what this game is all about. Does the character want to delve subterranean caves, plunder

Full Disclosure:

This game assumes a base level of experience with roleplaying games in general. I'm not going to take up space explaining what a roleplaying game is, or what polyhedral dice are, or any of the other introductory elements found in most RPG books; if you're reading this, you likely already know.

If this is your first foray into RPGs, welcome! Luckily, this isn't rocket science, and with a little patience and dedication, you'll pick everything up just fine. One of my very first games at age 10 was Rolemaster by Iron Crown Enterprises--and if a math-challenged little kid like me could grasp the labyrinthine rules of a game that we ominously nicknamed "Rulesmaster", a keen and imaginative beginner should have no problem at all with The Broken Empires RPG .

ancient Seethie ruins, or brave the lairs of mad wizards in search of wealth and power? Or do they want something more personal, like to track down and dispense justice to the noble who ordered the murder of their family? Perhaps they want to find answers to ancient mysteries by exploring the previously inaccessible, but recently revealed lands of the Shroud? Or perhaps they choose diplomacy to forge an accord between two rival Angevarran Great Houses--or turn them against each other to start a profitable war? The possibilities are limited only by the players' imaginations.

Whatever the details, a character's goals give them purpose and reason to heed the call to adventure. They act as a roadmap, a way to channel their choices as they progress through the fictional world. Goals are the driving force behind not only a character's motivations, but also their advancement: only by pursuing their goals can a character improve their skills and acquire new Talents. Consequently, adventures in The Broken Empires RPG tend to be as unique as the characters themselves.

The momentum of this game is powered by the players driving their characters forward. They will make choices and take action, and by doing so, push on the world, which, through the actions and reactions of the GM, will push back--prompting the PCs to respond to new threats. This is the cycle of adventure, and through it, the setting of the Broken Empires is transformed into a living world, one that responds directly and indirectly to the choices of the players, changing and evolving with them.

The consequences of such change can be from the earth-shattering and epic, to the local and personal. The events and stories that emerge from characters pursuing their goals can be as broad or as tightly focused as the goals themselves. If the characters' goals are about overthrowing the naval empire of Tical Dondala and freeing the common people of the Serpent's Teeth Isles, then let it be so. A massive geopolitical shift is a fine demonstration of the world evolving in reaction to PC actions. But, as another example, if the goals of the PCs are centered around the prosperity and safety

of a single small village beset by local threats, then that shall be the world the PCs will push on, and be pushed by. Making a difference in the setting can be as simple as saving the life of a single peasant villager, if that villager's life has meaning to the Player Character and relates to his goals. Not every campaign has to be about saving the world.

This is not a game of fantasy superheroes. Player Characters in The Broken Empires RPG are highly competent at what they do, but they are, in the end, just regular people making tough choices (regardless of their race; Dwarves, Half-Orcs, Ogres, Bolg Fiir, and the Replaced are all "people" too). Nor is this a game of Classes and Levels; no such niche protection exists. Taking your character in whichever direction you want is totally within your prerogative, limited only by your choices and intentions. Does your hard-edged thief want to become a priest and serve the gods, unlocking the Piety necessary to call upon their aid? She can do that. Does your soft-spoken farmer want to learn how to be a deadly shot with a longbow? Practice, practice, practice. Does your blunt fighter wish to unlock the secrets of the Weave and learn to cast magic? He'll never be as good at it as a true-born Spellweaver, but the only thing stopping him from becoming a Fade (one who dabbles in magic) is his own convictions.

As for the violent conflict that is inevitable in fantasy roleplaying games (because: duh, fun!), there is neither plot armor nor system protection in place: the world's threats do not conform to the current power level of the Player Characters. If violence breaks out, there are fun and detailed rules for handling the combat--but be aware that fighting should be thoroughly prepared for by the players and their characters whenever possible, and carefully avoided when not. Lethality is a real threat in this game, and death can come swiftly for the brave and the foolish alike. That said, numerous rules support non-lethal outcomes to even the bloodiest combat: more than one violent confrontation will end with incapacitation or surrender instead of death. And while expiring from infected wounds is certainly a real and bleak possibility, there are ways to mitigate that grisly end, too.

But not all adventure revolves around violence (nor should it). This game has an additional focus on two arenas that often, sadly, get short shrift in fantasy RPGs: Travel and Social Encounters.

An evocative set of travel rules is very helpful in immersing the players in the game world as their characters move through it. Getting there is literally half the fun, as they say, and The Broken Empires RPG leans hard into that idea. Exploring and journeying across the various lands of the Broken Empires should transport the players in their imaginations to an exciting new world, and the travel rules help the GM facilitate that. Will the party reach the city of Ansharir in time for the Vizier's ball, or will the harsh sands of the Red Wastes drain their supplies, sap their resolve, or inflict life-threatening wounds? While on expedition into the wilds of western Dunblaine to explore forgotten territory, what random events will befall them that could lead to profit--or peril? How long can the party stay ahead of the Fae Queen's Huntsmen as the creatures doggedly pursue the Replaced PC in the group, and how exhausted will the party be if and when they finally reach a place of safety? The randomizer tools in the Travel chapter will help the GM keep every new encounter fresh and unpredictable, providing limitless playability for exploration-based adventures.

Social situations are some of the most fun and satisfying encounters the players can experience, and the Intrigue rules provide a fun alternate approach to resolving a conflict. The robust set of social rules included in this game allows for a different type of encounter, far from the repetitive grind of killing yet another monster. Words can be as devastating as weapons in the right situation, and the breadth of social skills available for PCs to master supports a verbally tactical approach when dealing with an opponent in a non-violent arena. Will the characters be able to convince a simmering mob that the party is not, in fact, to blame for the theft of a holy relic from the local church, despite the furious accusations of the priest leading the townsfolk against them? Will the roguish raconteur PC be able to woo the inn-

keeper's daughter and win the secrets she carries about one of the party's shared goals? Can the PCs earn a seat at the tribal council to engineer a peace between the various clans on the brink of war in a lonely mountain valley dear to the Player Characters? The Social Encounter system blends player word choice with character skill to create a tense, rewarding, and enjoyable roleplaying experience for all participants.

And, of course, there is magic. A versatile and flexible magic system allows Spellweavers to craft, in the moment, whatever magical effects they can conceive (as long as they are trained in the particular elements of the spell). But casting a spell is only the first component; the second is controlling the magic. Failing to do so will cause the Weave of reality to react in unpredictable ways, most often to the detriment of the caster. Will the Spellweaver choose to cast a devastating improvised combat spell, knowing that they don't have sufficient Resolve to mitigate the Weave? Can the caster track down the True Name of the wily Void Demon she needs to consult, allowing her to attempt the dreaded Summoning ritual? Will the enchanter decide to rush closer to the inevitable eternal twilight known as the Fraying, just to be able to create a desperately needed magical item? Magic, like any other arena in the game, is full of difficult choices and desperate decisions.

The random predations of the uncontrolled Weave, however, do not concern the Godbound, the servants of the divine. They instead derive their power from their gods, penitently asking for intercession. However, they are largely powerless to shape the outcome of the miracle, putting their faith solely in their deity to come to their aid in whatever manner the god shall choose. And drawing upon the god's power comes with a cost in Piety, which the Godbound must constantly strive to replenish, or risk falling afoul of their deity's favor. The gods of the Broken Empires are powerful, but unpredictable--and very often fickle. "A god helps those who help themselves" is a phrase known all too well to the priests of this world.

what's in this book

This book will show you the Core Mechanics of the game, then detail the Skills and Talents a character can have. Next is an overview of the various races available to a player, the People of the Broken Empires, followed by Goals, the driving force behind every PC. We'll then explain Character Creation, where the players not only detail their characters, but also develop the intertwined histories, Life Events, and future objectives that bind them all together. Experience and Advancement shows you how to improve your skills and acquire new Talents.

After that, we'll look at the Equipment your characters will need to navigate the world of the Broken Empires, including weapons, armor, Supply Dice, and other gear. Naturally, you'll need to know how to handle yourself in Combat, so those rules are presented next--followed by the often-unfortunate consequences of violence, Wounds, Healing, & Perils.

Next, we'll show you how to guide yourselves across the Broken Empires with the detailed Travel rules, followed by the Intrigue chapter, where you'll learn to handle social conflict. Next are the substantial Weave Magic and Divine Magic chapters, which you'll need if you are a Spellweaver or a Godbound. The Gods of the Broken Empires are described in the next chapter, along with their clergy's rites and practices.

Gamemastering the Broken Empires provides many tips, tricks, and thoughts on how best to run your game of TBE, and the Bestiary gives GMs a host of enemies with which to challenge the PCs. You'll find comprehensive rules for Solo Play, followed by the Setting chapter that provides a detailed overview of the Broken Empires as a whole.

We'll finish with the Appendices where you'll find rules for land-based Mass Combat and ship-based Naval Combat, optional Personality mechanics, setting-specific Name Tables, and a series of random tools to generate interesting and adventure-provoking Treasure.

Character sheets and other useful items can be found at: www.thebrokenempiresrpg.com.

cHAPTER 2:

core mechanics

The Broken Empires RPG (TBE) is a skill-based game. Skills are the engine by which your characters try to achieve what they set out to do. There are no inherent "class powers" or sudden "level" jumps in TBE--there are skills. As you will see, to succeed at a skill, you want to roll under and roll high.

This is a kind of "blackjack" system. It calculates degrees of success by simply referencing the "tens" die of the roll: that number equals the Success Level (SL), which has various benefits.

Skill-based games don't limit a character's progression in the same way that class- and level-based games do. They allow you to develop your character in whatever way you see fit.

Keywords In This Chapter

Critical Failure
Critical Success
Degree of Success (DoS)
Extended Roll
Favor
Interval
Limit
Opposed Roll
Percentile Dice
Resolve
Resolve Track
Score
Skill Modifiers
Skill Roll
Standard Roll
Success Level (SL)
Timer Die

S

skill rolls & percentile dice

When a character wants to achieve something, and there is both a chance and a consequence of failing, he or she must make a skill roll to succeed.

This is made with percentile dice. Roll two d10s, counting one die as the "tens" die and the other as the "ones" die. This will generate a number between 1-100 (for example, a roll of "01" is read as "one", "37" as "thirty-seven", "50" as "fifty", "00" as "one hundred").

Compare the result to the value of the skill being used. If the roll is over the skill value, it fails. If the number rolled is equal to or less than the skill value, it succeeds.

A character's skill value is written as the skill name followed by a number (typically between 1-100), like Persuade 67 or Missile 78.

A skill also has a Score (the tens digit of a skill value). The Score is used only in specific cases, indicated when relevant, and is never altered by modifiers.

Percentile die rolls can be made with two standard d10 dice, or with a dedicated tens die and a standard d10 for the ones.

skill modifiers

A Skill Modifier changes the skill's value, and therefore its chance to succeed. If you have a modifier of +10 to a skill of 63, you now must roll 73 or less to succeed. If your skill of 56 has a -20 modifier, you will succeed only on a roll of 36 or below. A Skill Modifier never alters a skill's Score.

sleight of hand	35
stealth	65
survival	50
track	65
willpower	55

Simon has Track 65, which makes his Track Score 6. This Score will determine, among other things, how far he can lead the party before encountering a Travel Event while on a Journey. If his skill was modified by +20, allowing him to roll on a value of 85, his Score would still be considered 6.

Modifiers can come from many sources: the environment, the character's condition, or specific rules (such as gaining a bonus to strike an enemy after Charging). All modifiers are cumulative.

A task modifier is a specific, GM-imposed modifier that represents the inherent ease or difficulty of the task itself. GMs should use task modifiers sparingly; most situations that would be affected by modifiers are already covered by existing rules.

Task modifiers should never duplicate or overlap with another modifier that's already representing the same condition. For example, when a character swings at an opponent on the ground and gains the +20 bonus for attacking a Prone target, the defender should also not suffer a negative task modifier to their defense roll simply for being in a bad position--the disadvantage of being Prone is already fully accounted for.

Task modifiers should generally not be applied to opposed rolls. Opposed rolls set their own difficulty through the opponent's result.

Task Modifier Table

Difficulty	Modifier	Example
Simple	+20	Intimidate a coward
Easy	+10	Use Commerce to evaluate a handful of foreign coins
Medium	+0	Make an attack in combat
Challenging	-10	Ride an unbroken stallion
Hard	-20	Recall Ancient Lore about a long-forgotten kingdom
Severe	-30	Use Athletics to climb a smooth wall in a rainstorm

success levels

When you roll your skill value or under, you succeed, and the number showing on the tens die is the number of Success Levels (SLs). The Success Level represents the quality of success and, when relevant to the outcome, can have various effects based on the particular skill.

On any successful skill roll, a 0 on the tens die counts as 1 SL.

Simon makes a Track roll to hunt down the deer he's stalking. His skill in Track is 65, and he rolls a 52. This is a success with 5 SLs. If he rolled a 06, it would be a success with 1 SL, not zero.

A roll of 99-00 is always a failure (and if over your skill, a critical failure), regardless of skill value.

In the rare case you have a skill value of 99 or 100, rolling your skill value exactly is still a failure, not a critical success.

Always calculate the critical chance based on the modified skill value.

If your character's skill is 58, but they have a -20 modifier, their modified skill is 38. Rolling 11, 22, 33, or 38 is a critical success. Rolling 44, 55, 66, 77, 88, 99, or 00 is a critical failure.

critical results

A critical success is an extraordinary skill roll result, and is achieved when you roll doubles under your skill, or when you roll your skill value exactly. A critical success adds +3 Success Levels to your roll. In combat it can have additional benefits.

A critical failure, on the other hand, can carry extra consequences. Rolling doubles over your skill value is a critical failure. In combat, a critically failed defense will give a bonus SL to your opponent, for instance. Outside of combat, a critical failure may have a different meaning, or even none at all--failure in most cases is already bad enough without adding insult to injury.

All else being equal, in opposed rolls, critical results beat non-critical results.

There's Always a Chance for Success... or Failure

A roll of 01-05 is always a success, regardless of skill value. Consequently, if your skill value is ever modified to zero or below, it still succeeds on a roll of 01-04, and critically succeeds on a 05.

Skills of 100 or More

On rare occasions, a skill could have a value of 100 or more. These skills still fail on a roll of 99-00, but can no longer critically fail.

If a skill ever has (or is modified to) a value over 100, roll it normally, but a success will benefit from extra SLs. To determine how many, subtract 100 from the skill value. The skill's resulting tens die value (the Score) acts as extra SLs (with a minimum of 1) on a successful skill roll.

For example, let's say an experienced warrior has raised his Melee: Medium skill to 105. He will still fail on a roll of 99 or 00, but he cannot critically fail. Additionally, every successful roll he makes will get a +1 SL to the outcome (105-100 = 05, tens die of zero, minimum 1): rolling an 83 would produce 9 SLs instead of 8. If he somehow raised his skill to 120, he would get +2 SLs on every successful roll, and so on.

standard and opposed rolls

Standard Rolls

A standard roll is made to determine simple success or failure when rolling your own skill against no active resistance. Rolling any number equal to or under the modified skill value is considered a success.

At the GM's discretion, standard rolls can be modified by a task modifier, but the default should be Medium (+0).

> Simon makes an Easy (+10) Common Lore roll to remember a piece of well-known local information. If even 1 SL is generated, he recalls the fact.

A standard roll requires only 1 SL to succeed. However, additional Success Levels can sometimes produce a better outcome. For example, the rules for using the Heal skill on a wound allow you to reduce its Wound Points by a total of 2 + 1 per 3 SLs.

Unless the rules for that skill or situation say otherwise, additional SLs don't normally matter in a standard roll. The GM may allow high results to grant small situational benefits if it makes sense in the context--perhaps +5 or 10 to the next roll, or some other minor advantage.

> Edbert and Simon are fording a narrow but treacherous stream, swollen from spring run-off. The GM decides they must each succeed on a standard roll of some sort to get across safely.
>
> Edbert's player describes throwing his lasso around a tree across the stream to aid the crossing, suggesting an Athletics roll. The GM agrees. Edbert's skill is 78, and he rolls 42, for 4 SLs. He crosses without trouble. Since he rolled well, the GM allows his success to help Simon: the securely fixed rope grants Simon a +5 bonus to his own crossing attempt.

Opposed Rolls

Sometimes your skill is resisted by an opposing force. That could be a hobgoblin swinging a sword at you, a guard trying to spot you as you sneak through the darkness of a courtyard, a trap springing underneath you, a poison coursing through your blood, or a Spellweaver casting a spell at you to alter your memories.

These are called opposed rolls, in which a character's skill is pitted against an opposing force--often, but not always, another skill. For example, Melee: Medium vs Melee: Light, Deceive vs Insight, or Endurance vs a poison's effects. Resisting an opposed roll with your own skill does not count as an action (see Chapter 10: Combat).

Both sides roll their skills and whoever earns more SLs is the winner. It's possible to win an opposed roll with 0 SLs (see Degree of Success).

Resolving an Opposed Roll

If...	Then...
Only one side succeeds	The succeeding side wins
Both sides succeed	The side with the most SLs wins
Both succeed, SLs tied	The higher die roll wins (with 0 SLs)
Both succeed, SLs tied, die rolls tied	The higher modified skill value wins
Both succeed, SLs tied, one is a critical success	The critical success wins (with 0 SLs)
Both rolls fail	Neither wins. If a winner is required--such as a failed Stealth opposed by a failed Perception--the higher modified skill value wins.
Both rolls fail, one is a critical failure	Neither wins. If a winner is required, the normal failure beats the critical failure.

Arn is sneaking past a bandit guard. This will be an opposed roll of Arn's Stealth vs the bandit's Perception.

Arn rolls 25 on his Stealth of 54: a success with 2 SLs. The bandit rolls 27 on his Perception of 40: also a success with 2 SLs.

They tie on SLs, so the higher die roll wins. The bandit's 27 is higher than Arn's 25, so the bandit wins the contest--Arn is spotted! The guard shouts an alarm and rushes toward him.

Opposing a Fixed Number

Sometimes the opposing force isn't a skill at all, but a Fixed Number--either a single value like 3, or a dice expression like 1d4+1 that the GM rolls. This could represent any non-skill-based value, and is common in modeling forces like environmental damage or the effects of poisons.

This works exactly as though the opposing force had succeeded at its "skill" and generated a number of SLs. The PC makes an opposed roll against them as normal, though the precise effects will vary with the context.

On a tie between a skill roll and a fixed number, the rolled skill wins.

Degree of Success

In an opposed roll, sometimes we need to know not only which side won, but by how much. This is common in combat, where the difference in SLs determines damage.

In such cases, the winner's SLs are reduced by the loser's SLs (if any). The result is the winner's final SLs, or Degree of Success (DoS).

Arn is now in combat with the bandit who spotted him. On Arn's turn, he attacks with his broadsword, using his Melee: Medium skill of 70. He rolls 52, succeeding with 5 SLs.

The bandit tries to parry with his handaxe and rolls his Melee: Light skill of 65. He rolls 23, a success with 2 SLs.

Since DoS matters in combat rolls, the defender's SLs reduce the attacker's. Arn wins with a DoS of 3 SLs (5-2=3). This will determine the damage of Arn's attack.

If Arn instead rolled 62 to attack and the bandit rolled 33 to defend, the bandit's roll would have been a critical success, adding 3 SLs to tie with Arn's 6 SLs. Arn had the higher die roll (62 to 33), but because criticals always beat ties, the defending bandit would win the opposed roll and block the attack entirely.

When the Degree of Success Matters

In an opposed roll, whether DoS applies will either be obvious from the context (such as most combat rolls) or will be explicitly marked "DoS" (such as with certain traps or natural hazards). The GM judges any unclear case.

Examples: DoS Applies

Fire Hazard: Dodge DoS vs 10: You take 10 damage, reduced by your Dodge SLs. Rolling 4 Dodge SLs means you take 6 damage.

Examples continue on next page...

Continued from previous page...

Sleep Gas : Endurance DoS vs 1d4 minutes: You are unconscious for 1d4 minutes, reduced by your Endurance SLs. If the GM rolled 3 for the number of minutes, and you rolled 1 SL on your Endurance , you would fall unconscious for 2 minutes. If you rolled 3 SLs, you would resist entirely.

Examples: DoSDoesn't Apply

Earthquake : Athletics vs 2: Generate at least 2 SLs or be knocked Prone. Rolling 1 SL doesn't help you.

Frightening Presence : Willpower vs 4: Generate at least 4 SLs to resist the Fear effect. Rolling 3 or fewer SLs means you suffer the full Fear effect; rolling 4 or more resists it entirely.

If you need to assign an opposing force a skill value or Fixed Number, choose or roll on the Opposing Difficulty Table:

Opposing Difficulty Table

d100	Opposing Difficulty	Opposing Skill Value	Fixed Number
01-05	Simple	20	1
06-15	Easy	35	1
16-55	Medium	50	2
56-85	Challenging	65	4
86-95	Hard	80	6
96-99	Severe	95	8
00	Extreme	100+	10+

extended rolls

Some tasks require more than one roll to resolve. In these cases, the players make a series of standard rolls over time, accumulating SLs. This is called an extended roll .

The GM sets how many SLs are required to complete the task, and the time frame in which each roll occurs (the interval). A character may make one roll during each interval, using an appropriate skill.

Result of Each Skill Roll

- A Success or Critical Success : Add the SLs from each successful roll to the total.
- A Failure : A failed roll adds no SLs.
- A Critical Failure : If any roll is a critical failure, after resolving that interval's result, immediately halve the total accumulated SLs (round up), as work is lost or setbacks occur.

Elements of Extended Rolls

When creating an extended roll, the GM sets:

- A SLs required : the number of SLs required to complete the task.
- A Interval : the time frame in which each roll occurs (a round, a day, a week, etc.)
- A Limit (optional) : the maximum number of intervals available before the opportunity is lost; if the required SLs are not reached within that time, the attempt fails.
- A Minimum duration (optional) : the least amount of time the task can take, regardless of how quickly the SLs are accumulated; used when the nature of the task makes quick completion unrealistic.

Climbing a 1000' cliff might require 9 SLs using Athletics, with each interval representing 1 hour of effort, and with a minimum duration of 4 hours. Even if the character earned 9 SLs in one or two rolls, the climb still takes at least 4 hours.

As a rule of thumb:

- 3 SLs is easy
- 6 SLs is standard
- 9 SLs is difficult
- 12+ SLs is a major undertaking

Extended Roll Examples

Example	SLs Required	Interval
Track a deer through fresh snow	3	1 hour
Canvas the Thieves' Quarter for secret information	6	1 day
Scaling a high cliff	9	1 hour
Forge a Medium weapon	12	1 day
Research an ancient magic ritual in an arcane library	15	1 week
Construct a tower	18	1 month

Stratton the duelist is forging a rapier blade as a gift for a High Lord of Keighton. The GM rules that it requires 12 SLs, with each interval representing 1 day of work, and with a minimum duration of 3 days. The High Lord is expecting the blade within 7 days, which sets the limit to 7: Stratton can make 7 attempts before he runs out of time. He rolls Craft: Practical each day, adding his SLs toward the total. If he reaches 12 SLs before the eighth attempt, the blade is complete and on time.

He finishes the sword in 6 days, earning a total of 13 SLs (if he had miraculously finished in 2 days, he would still be subject to the minimum 3 days of forging time). As he is a Master Craftsman (see the Master Craftsman Talent), he uses the remaining time to try to improve the weapon further--but further rolls are risky, as a critical failure would halve his current total.

Multiple Participants

When multiple characters choose to participate in an extended roll, each makes an appropriate skill roll during the interval. Only the highest SL result is added to the total; however, up to 2 other successful rolls each add +1 SL. If any participating roll in an interval is a critical failure, first add any SLs earned for that interval, then halve the accumulated total, rounding up.

All skills used must be appropriate to the situation. If the party is trying to stop a stampeding herd of animals from overrunning their camp, they might use Might, Intimidate, Nature Lore, Command--or some other skill, if a player is creative enough and the GM approves. The GM may require each PC to use a different skill to prevent overlapping efforts.

Four characters are researching an ancient historical mystery in a vast library. The GM rules that it requires 12 SLs to uncover the truth. Each interval represents 1 day of work, and the characters must soon return to their liege lord with the information; they have a limit of 3 days in which to complete their research.

Two PCs want to use Ancient Lore, but the GM rules that each character must use a different skill to prevent them from interfering with each other's work.

On the first day, all four characters choose to participate. They roll Common Lore, Ancient Lore, Perception, and History-wise. The highest roll is 5 SLs, with only one other character succeeding: the SL total is therefore 6.

On the second day, all four again decide to participate, but this time only one PC succeeds, with 2 SLs--and one of the PCs critically fails. This would bring their total to 8 SLs, but the critical failure halves it to 4.

If they reach 12 SLs by the end of the third day, they uncover the truth. If not, they run out of time.

Not every task can benefit from multiple participants. The GM should determine how many characters can reasonably contribute based on the situation.

The characters uncover a damaged ancient manuscript describing a forgotten rite. The GM rules that it requires 9 SLs to decipher, with each interval representing 1 hour of careful study. Only one character can work through the fragile text at a time, as the script is dense, partially destroyed, and must be interpreted line by line.

The party's Loremaster begins the attempt, rolling Ancient Lore and adding SLs toward the total. The other characters assist by organizing notes, cross-referencing related texts, or maintaining the workspace, but do not make their own rolls. One of them, however, can support the Loremaster with her own Ancient Lore skill Score (see Chapter 3 - Skills: Supporting Skills & Help).

Each of the Loremaster's rolls takes 1 hour. When he accumulates 9 SLs, the text is fully deciphered. If interrupted or forced to stop, the work remains incomplete. A critical failure halves the total accumulated SLs, as earlier conclusions are revealed to be flawed and must be reworked.

Gradual Outcomes

At the GM's discretion, an extended roll may produce results incrementally rather than all at once.

For example, searching a murder scene might have an interval of 15 minutes, where every 3 SLs reveals a specific clue, up to a maximum of 12 SLs, at which point all clues will have been discovered.

Magic In Extended Rolls

Magic skills can be used in extended rolls by abstracting the spellcasting procedure. Spend 1 Resolve and roll the Bind skill to generate SLs. If successful, spend an additional 1d4 Resolve. If any portion of the 1d4 exceeds your available Resolve, immediately suffer a Weave Reaction with a modifier equal to the remainder (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic). On a critical failure, roll an unmodified Weave Reaction.

extended rolls: the timer die

An alternative way for the GM to introduce a dynamic time limit on an extended roll is to use the Timer Die (typically d10). Roll the Timer Die after each interval. If the result is equal to or less than the number of intervals passed so far, a random complication arises, or the conflict or situation comes to a premature end. The GM should decide which it will be before any skills are rolled.

Timer Dice range from d6 - d20, though the standard is a d10. The smaller the Timer Die type, the more potential for pitfalls; a d10 Timer Die is less likely to generate complications or force an end than a d6.

Extended rolls and Timer dice can be used for all kinds of scenarios: investigations, chases, social events, and more (see Chapter 13 - Intrigue).

Timer as a Complication

A random complication must be interpreted based on the current context: Roll twice on the Event Randomizers Tables (see Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying: Random Events) and construe in whatever order makes sense. The resulting complication should always create a new obstacle for someone involved in the extended roll. It could, for example, make the next roll harder, or introduce a new element to the situation that must be dealt with.

Using the previous example of Stratton forging the blade, imagine he has to roll a Timer Die after every interval (each day). On the fourth day, he rolls a 2: a complication has arisen. The GM rolls on the Event Randomizers Tables and gets "Enemy Equipment". He decides that on the fourth day, Stratton hears that a rival swordsmith is forging a blade for the High Lord too, and this new competitor is racing to present it before Stratton finishes his. Things just got interesting!

The GM assigns the rival a Craft skill of 75 and starts rolling every day, tracking his SLs alongside Stratton's. Whoever gets to 12 first without running out of time completes their blade first, and no doubt gains the favor of the High Lord.

Timer as Premature End

Instead of a complication, you can have the Timer Die indicate a premature end to the situation. This is especially useful in a contest between competing parties. In its simplest form, when the timer expires, some event has occurred to interrupt the extended roll, and the party with the most SLs wins (a tie of SLs indicates a draw; if a winner is required, the most recent highest roll wins). If the conflict is not between parties, the sole participant is forced to end the task with only the SLs they have already accumulated.

A guard is chasing a thief through a town's empty streets; both pursuer and prey are rolling Athletics as an extended roll. Each interval represents a round of activity from each side. The GM decides the chase will end when either the guard or the thief reaches 6 SLs. The Timer is set to a d10 and is rolled after both parties have made their skill rolls in the first round.

If the GM is using the Timer Die as a complication, rolling the current round number or less will introduce a random complication that may affect the pursuer, the prey, or both. A bad storm suddenly breaks, for example, giving the thief a bonus as the heavy rain obscures vision.

Conversely, if the Timer Die represents a premature end, then the die showing the current round's number or less means some event has occurred to cut the chase short: a drunken crowd stumbles out of a tavern, for example, tying up the guard or thief. However it happens, the chase ends, and whoever has the most SLs wins. If the guard has more, he catches the thief; if the thief gets more, she gets away.

favor

There are times when the warp and weft of reality's tapestry combine in such a way as to grant good fortune. This is called Favor, and manifests in the game as a circumstantial bonus to improve a skill value, giving a better chance of rolling more SLs. Favor can be gained on your own rolls by spending Resolve (see below), or it can be created through various other means, often for use as a pool of points to be shared amongst the party (see Chapter 13 - Intrigue: Leverage).

For each point of Favor used per roll, you get +10 to the skill value. You can only use up to 3 Favor on any one roll, from any source. Favor must be spent before the roll.

Tracker Dials are useful for tracking Favor, SLs, combat rounds, and time-bound factors for extended rolls.

resolve

Everyone is connected to the Weave of reality, and Resolve is a subtle and unconscious way of reworking it around you. Resolve can help a character push past their own boundaries to exert their will, effort, and drive upon the Weave. Spellweavers use Resolve in a special way to control their spells (see Chapter 14 - Weaving Magic).

A You can spend Resolve as Favor (+10 per Resolve to a skill roll). As stated above, up to 3 Favor may be used on any one skill roll from any source, including Resolve.

A You can spend as much Resolve as you wish to increase your rolled Initiative result each round, 1 for 1.

A You can spend 3 Resolve to:

- » Avoid dropping in Shock.
- » Avoid the fatal result of a single failed Wound Die roll.
- » Avoid instant death and become Dying instead when exceeding your Death Threshold (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils).

A Certain talents require the expenditure of Resolve.

Resolve may be spent only on your own rolls. You may spend as much Resolve as you can afford in any manner described above.

Arn's party is traveling through the woods on a Journey. He is in charge of keeping the party fed and rested, a function of Arn's Survival skill, which is 50. He doesn't want to fail his roll, so his player spends 2 Resolve to add +20 to the skill. His skill is now 70 for the next roll. His player gets a 63, for 6 SLs. In this case, he succeeds (and with great effect!), but only because he spent the Resolve. If he had rolled a 13, he still would have succeeded, but with only 1 SL--which he could have done anyway with his skill of 50. Such is the will of the dice!

melee:medium
melee: heavy
might
missile
thrown

locks & traps
perception
ride
sail/boat
sleight of hand
stealth
survival
willpower

inspire
intimidate
perform
persuade
protocol
seduce
wit

commerce
common lore
craft: pract.
craft: art
divinity
heal
naturewise
streetwise
-wise

control
destroy
witness
language
-w
-w

Indicate spent Resolve with a single slash in the boxes on your character sheet. Resolve track , from left to right. Once the track is filled up to your Max Resolve, there is no more Resolve available to you.

track

resolve & fatigue

Fatigue from travel can limit your maximum available Resolve. For every Fatigue you take, mark one "X" in a Resolve box on the track, from right to left. If your Resolve track becomes filled with spent Resolve or Fatigue (or some combination of the two), taking additional Fatigue will cause Fatigue-based wounds, special wounds associated with the source of the Fatigue.

Spellweavers rely on Resolve when casting magic. If a Spellweaver is at zero Resolve, they cannot cast any spell . They alone can spend more than 3 Resolve at a time, but only when mitigating the Weave after the spell is cast (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic).

Resolve and Fatigue recover with a full night's rest, at a rate based on the quality of the area of rest (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Resolve & Fatigue Recovery).

"Important" NPCs (that is, NPCs who are relevant to the characters' goals) will often have a pool of Resolve that can be used in the same way as the characters. Most other enemies will not have Resolve.

Resolve Limit In Extended Rolls

If the interval on an extended roll is one hour or more, Resolve cannot be spent on the roll. There may be exceptions to this rule based on the context.

Finally, Resolve is not a meta-currency. It is an internal measure of a character's own sense of grit, not a collection of "plot" or "story" points. A character is simply aware of how exhausted they are becoming as they put more and more extraordinary effort into a task; how much more they "have in the tank" before they'll have to resort to simple luck. At no time do Resolve points give a player any narrative control, "scene editing" powers, or any other creative authority normally reserved for the GM.

attributes

max resolve initiative init penalty total toughness death threshold lethality level

wounds

total lethal wp base recov

talents

BODY 1-5

imp
armor t? ap sund bulk
wp nl? wounds inf rb

head 0

imp
armor ap
wp nl? wounds

right arm 6

imp
armor t? ap sund bulk
wp nl? wounds inf rb

left arm 7

imp
armor t? ap
wp nl? wounds

armor penalties

athletics
rise from prone
stealth
dodge
perception

right leg 8

imp
armor ap sund bulk
wp nl? wounds inf rb

left leg 9

imp
armor ap
wp nl? wounds

shield

split
size:
ap shb enc

weapons

name/type	att	pry	rch	dmg	cl	cs	dis	t	enc	rng

cHAPTER 3:

skills

How a character performs a task in the world of the Broken Empires is governed by their Skills. Whether it's swinging a sword, sneaking past an Orc, treating a wound, casting a spell, petitioning a deity for a miracle, or doing anything else, a skill roll is made to accomplish it. Since TBEhas no classes or levels, skills are the primary measure of a character's capabilities and improvements (alongside Talents, which are covered in the next chapter).

Keywords In This Chapter

Adventuring Skill
Bind
Combat Skill
Crafting Time
Group Roll
Lore Skill
Piety
Savvy Skill
Skill Competency
Social Skill
Strand
Support

Not every action requires a roll. If there's no real chance of failure(like walking across flat ground in combat) or no meaningful consequence for failing(like practicing a Sleight of Hand trick when no one's watching), then no roll is needed. In such cases, assume success and move on.

skill categories

Skills are separated into five categories:

- A Combat skills are used in melee or ranged conflict.
- A Adventuring skills are practical skills used in a variety of situations.
- A Social skills are used to achieve a desired objective with an NPC.
- A Lore skills cover knowledge and practical application of various specialized fields.
- A Magic skills are used in Weave magic (the Binds and Strands) and Divine magic (Piety) (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic and Chapter 15 - Divine Magic):

ability score descriptors personality traits

name race sex age

culture previous career size xp

combat	%	ex	adventuring	%	ex	social	%	ex	lore	%	ex	binds	%	ex	strands	lvl
dodge			athletics			deceive			ancient lore			change			air	
melee: light			endurance			insight			arcana			conjure			beast	
melee:medium			locks & traps			inspire			commerce			control			body	
melee: heavy			perception			intimidate			common lore			destroy			earth	
might			ride			perform			craft: pract.			witness			fire	
missile			sail/boat			persuade			craft: art			language	%	ex	plant	
thrown			sleight of hand			protocol			divinity						spheres	
			stealth			seduce			heal						spirit	
			survival			wit			naturewise						thought	
			track						streetwise			-wise			water	
			willpower						-wise			-wise			starting piety	

resolve & fatigue

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attributes wounds

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skill descriptions

Combat Skills

dodge - Ducking, weaving, and generally getting out of the way of incoming damage. Opposing certain magical effects. You must have reasonably unrestricted movement to Dodge.

melee: light - Light, fast one-handed weapons.

melee: medium- Standard weapons like broadswords, maces, or axes.

melee: heavy - Two-handed weapons that often have the Reach quality.

might - Fists, kicks, grappling, and performing general feats of strength. Might attacks and defenses are at -20 against an armed foe. They do non-lethal damage. Might rolls used in a grapple give a bonus to the larger participant of +20 per larger Size category.

missile- Bows, crossbows, slings.

thrown - Spears, knives, bottles, or anything hurled by hand.

Adventuring Skills

athletics - Feats of physical dexterity such as climbing, swimming, and jumping. It can also be used to Rise from Prone.

endurance - The ability to withstand pain and suffering. How hale and hearty a character is, and the base Recovery for wounds. Feats of physical stamina. Going the extra mile. Second wind and fortitude. Opposing certain magical effects.

locks & traps - Picking locks, disarming, designing, and building traps and mechanisms. Noticing the trap requires Perception; disarming it uses this skill.

perception - Being aware of changing physical circumstances around you, such as noticing a thief sneaking through the shadowed alley, or sensing an ambush the moment before it launches. Also used by the Scout role on Journeys.

ride - The skillful riding of a horse or other mount. Can be used in place of Dodgeagainst ranged weapons if mounted. Used in Mounted Combat rolls to avoid falling off your mount when taking damage. Caps ranged attacks while mounted.

sail/boat - Navigating waterways in dangerous or uncertain conditions, captaining larger vessels.

sleight of hand - Feats of legerdemain such as picking pockets, palming small or tiny items to resist a search, using a lasso or rope to secure an object, or cheating at cards and dice.

stealth - Moving quietly and remaining unseen, blending into a crowd. Requires areas to hide behind or shadows to obscure your movement. Cannot be done under direct observation. Cannot move more than 1 zone per round while sneaking. Stealth is opposed by Perception only when the perceiver is actively aware; otherwise, it is a standard roll.

survival - Finding food, water, and shelter in the wilderness. Avoiding poisonous creatures and hazardous animals. Also used by the Quartermaster role on Journeys.

track - Following trails in the wilderness, navigating by landmarks or the stars. If the tracks are easier or harder to read due to local conditions, apply a task modifier. Often made as an extended roll to track a quarry over longer periods of time, or opposed by Stealth. Also used by the Guide role on Journeys.

willpower - Mental and spiritual fortitude, the will to keep going despite pain and adversity. Opposing certain magical effects.

Social Skills

deceive - Lying and cheating, disguising yourself as someone else, general guile.

insight - Flashes of understanding, getting a sense of someone's true intentions, seeing through someone else's opposed Deceiveskill.

inspire* - Rousing speeches, moving someone to tears, emotional empathy, riling up a crowd, commanding loyal troops.

intimidate - Threatening posture and speech, venomous invective, assuming authority and giving orders, shaming someone, subtle pushiness and "peer pressure".

perform - Singing, dancing, acting, storytelling, reciting poetry, playing an instrument, accurately delivering news from abroad.

chapter 3: skills

persuade* - Using logic and reason to convince someone of the rightness of your position, bargaining, stating the plain obvious truth, taking a friendly approach.

protocol* - Knowledge and understanding of rank, status, and standing. Courtesy, polite conversation, diplomacy, knowledge of correct etiquette in social situations.

seduce - Using flirting and innuendo to get what you want from someone who would have reason to have sexual interest in you, understanding sexual cues and relationships, romantic speech (often supported with Craft: Artistic as poetry).

wit* - Knowing just the right clever thing to say at exactly the right time. Charm, flattery, rapier-like repartee, penetrating or astute observation, humor.

*Capped by any non-native Language used

Lore Skills

ancient lore - History, old legends, forgotten myths and stories, academic knowledge, scholarship.

arcana - Knowledge of the Weave of Reality and associated theories, esoteric knowledge, astrology, making effective summoning circles, identifying another Spellweaver's spell.

commerce - Understanding the ways of trade, using markets to create profit, knowing how to make your wealth go further, haggling for better prices, gambling.

common lore - General knowledge of the geography, cultural customs, flora, fauna, and people of geographical areas.

craft: artistic - Creating works of art, like prose or poetry, carvings, sculpture, paintings, drawings, or physical disguises. Normally performed as an extended roll (see Crafting Time Examples). Appropriate - wises can support the creation of specific items (for example, Stone-wise to help craft a sculpture).

craft: practical - Creating or fixing mundane items. Swordsmithing, building a wall, carpentry, repairing armor, making a lute, etc. Normally performed as an extended roll (see Crafting Time Examples). Appropriate - wises can support the creation of specific items (for example, Swordsmith-wise to help craft a sword). As a general rule, the cost in materials to create an item is one-fifth of its listed price. Critically failing any Craft: Practical roll during item creation cuts current SLs in half and requires the material cost to be paid again.

divinity - Knowledge of the various gods and religions of the Broken Empires, church doctrine, and history. Can be used to oppose Divine Miracle effects.

heal - Used in stabilizing Wounds, recovering Impaired limbs, reducing Wound Points, treating poison, and dealing with infection. Each roll requires a roll of the Medical Supply Die. Heal uses its own SL formula (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils).

Crafting Time Examples

Example	Skill	SLs Required	Interval
Forging a Light weapon	Craft: Practical	9	1 day
Forging a Medium weapon	Craft: Practical	12	1 day
Forging a Heavy weapon	Craft: Practical	15	1 day
Forging a piece of plate armor	Craft: Practical	18	1 day, minimum 3
Forging a piece of mail armor	Craft: Practical	12	1 day, minimum 3
Creating a piece of leather armor	Craft: Practical	6	1 day
Creating a piece of padding or quilt armor	Craft: Practical	3	1 day
Making a pair of comfortable boots	Craft: Practical	6	1 hour, minimum 3
Creating a stone sculpture	Craft: Artistic	12	1 day
Writing an epic poem	Craft: Artistic	9	1 hour, minimum 3

naturewise - General lore of the natural world, finding ingredients for natural healing potions, animal handling, predicting the weather, knowledge of wilderness environments.

streetwise - Street savvy, knowledge of local criminal and underworld contacts in population centers, knowing where to find suppliers in urban environments. Streetwisecannot be used as a Social skill, but it can support appropriate Social skill rolls.

-WISE - Any kind of lore on a specific subject (Animal-wise, Ocean-wise, Poison-wise, Alchemy-wise, Old Vestria-wise,etc.). In general, the narrower the scope of the -wise skill, the deeper the knowledge.

language - The ability to speak a language. This does not include literacy; reading and writing require the Literate Talent (most people in the Broken Empires are illiterate). There is no "common tongue " in the Broken Empires, but due to the reach of the old Imperica Vestria, most people know a bit of Low Vestrian. Each region has its own language; related barbarian tongues within its borders may be spoken or understood with a -20 penalty. Every character starts with 70 in their native language and 20 in Low Vestrian. Inspire, Persuade, Protocol, and Wit are capped at the skill value of the language used (not including the native tongue).

Languages

Language	Native To	Language	Native To
Low Vestrian	Old Vestria	Slahvac	Vieksgrad
High Vestrian	Old Vestria; used principally in academic texts	Pirate's Cant	The Serpent's Teeth
Angevarran	Angevarre	Meersreich	Hohenvall
High Angevarran	Angevarran noble courts	Khannish	Drangia, Sattagoya
Dondalese	Tical Dondala	Kharzhad	Dwarves
Westronne	The Westlands	Fionnan (Low Court)	Bolg Fiir
Thessian	Thessia	Tusker	Ogres
Ellaric (also called Anshari)	Ansharir	Orcish	Orcs
Sandspeech	The Red Wastes	Fionnan (High Court)	Duanan Seethe
Gael	Dunblaine		
Iron Tongue/ Vikstongue	The Iron Lands/ Haedravik	Demonic	Demons, devils

Magic Skills

binds, strands, and piety - A Bind is a magical skill that allows a Spellweaver to enact their will upon the tapestry of reality in a particular way, and is rolled like a normal skill. A Strand represents that part of reality which is acted upon, and is not rolled like a normal skill, but rather has a single number that helps cover the cost of spell casting. Piety represents the current divine favor a Godbound enjoys from their deity; it is the only skill that goes up and down with use, and it can never be more than 90 without modifiers (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic and Chapter 15 - Divine Magic).

skill competency

What does it mean for a character to have a skill value of 30? Are they any good at it? If they're trying to remember a piece of history, do they need to make an Ancient Lore roll, or do they have a high enough skill to just know it?

Skill Competency

Skill Value	Ability Level	Description
1-19	Green	Still learning the ropes
20-39	Novice	A basic understanding of the skill
40-59	Proficient	Can succeed in most non-strenuous cases
60-79	Reliable	A professional level of skill
80-99	Expert	One of the best and most noteworthy practitioners
100+	Master	A true paragon of skill; world class

Succeeding Without a Roll

Sometimes a character's skill is high enough that rolling is unnecessary. If the outcome of an action is binary--succeed or fail, yes or no--and the character's skill meets or exceeds a certain value, the GM may declare success without a roll. In such cases, the character is treated as if they had achieved the minimum result possible, gaining the equivalent of 1 Success Level (SL). This is a useful way to speed up play and is always applied at the GM's discretion.

This rule does not apply in combat or other opposed situations, but it is common in Lore-based tasks (e.g., "Do I know what this symbol means?"), Perception rolls, and routine social interactions.

The GM decides that anyone with Perception 50+ automatically spots the hidden door in the study. Characters with lower Perception must roll.

Alternative skills may have different thresholds based on their relevance to the situation.

Bribing the guard might require Persuade 60+ or Deceive 40+, as long as the player roleplays a convincing attempt.

The GM might rule that Perception 70+ or Craft: Artistic 60+ allows the party to notice a hidden passage, and that an Architecture-wise of 50+ will warn the PCs about its unstable ceiling.

Choosing to Roll Anyway

Even if the character has the minimum skill needed to succeed without a roll, their player may still choose to make a standard roll in hopes of gaining additional SLs and unlocking more benefits, but like any roll, there should be a cost to failure.

Arn has an Athletics skill of 72 and wants to climb a rocky cliff with a somewhat dangerous slope. The GM decides that anyone with an Athletics of 60+ may climb it without a roll. Arn could just take the 1 SL and be done with it, or his player could choose to make a standard Athletics roll for more SLs, in hopes that the GM will give him a bonus to his next relevant roll (see Chapter 2 - Core Mechanics: Standard Rolls). Failure would have a cost, however--maybe the climb takes twice as long, or Arn suffers a 1-pt Wound.

Edbert's Athletics is only 54, so his player must roll to ascend the cliff, with similar consequences for failure.

Expertise does count when factoring success without a roll (see Chapter 4 - Talents for more on Expertise).

In the above example, if Arn had Athletics Ex3, he could climb the cliff without a roll and still get 3 SLs, for which the GM may reward him. Perhaps Arn's player chooses to help Edbert up the slope by giving him a +5 bonus (see Chapter 2 - Core Mechanics: Standard Rolls).

Making Multiple Attempts

There will be times when a player fails a roll and immediately wants to try again. In many cases, if they've failed once already, they don't roll again for the same thing until the circumstances have fundamentally changed; what that means is up to the GM to decide. This doesn't apply to actions taken in combat: the circumstances in a combat change from round to round anyway, so if their character failed to hit their opponent with a sword this round, there is no issue with trying again next round.

The classic example is the locked treasure chest. If a PC fails a Locks & Traps roll to open the chest, the player can't just keep rolling until he succeeds. The situation will have to fundamentally change before he'll be able to try again: he gets new lock picks, he increases his Locks & Traps skill, etc.

Success With a Cost

Failing a roll does not necessarily mean that the character does not achieve their objective. At the GM's discretion, it might be that they succeed at a cost. For example, they actually are successful, but there is a new complication revealed; or the roll succeeds, but a piece of the character's gear is used up or broken in the process.

finding information

When using Perception or a Lore skill to find information, every 3 SLs can provide one additional piece of useful information regarding the topic at hand, if it is available (see Chapter 2: Core Mechanics: Gradual Outcomes).

Taking the 1 SL from a success without a roll (if the GM deems that applicable to the current circumstance) will yield only the most basic information. Like any skill, a character who meets the minimum requirements may still choose to roll a Lore skill (or Perception, if applicable) to gain more information, at a cost for failure.

Simon is trying to remember some lore regarding the recent history of the mountain valley he's in. The GM decides that the most basic part of that information can be remembered without a roll if his Common Lore skill value is 50 or more. As Simon has a 53 in Common Lore, his player doesn't need to roll--Simon just remembers. If he wants additional details, his player must roll; for every 3 SLs, he would get a new piece of information. However, failing the skill roll might consume time or have some other cost, depending on the context.

If he was trying to remember something in the more shrouded distant past--something for which the GM is allowing a minimum Common Lore skill of 60 to succeed without a roll--Simon's player would either a) roll on his 53 and hope for a success, or b) hope someone else in the party has a 60 or more in Common Lore to succeed without a roll. (That person could also choose to roll and hope for more information, but failure would have a cost.)

The GM might also allow an Ancient Lore of 40+, or an Arcana of 70+, to reveal the same information without the need to roll. Or a Naturewise skill of 60+ might reveal things that no other skill could--perhaps details on the local dangerous fauna, for example.

supporting skills & help

You can support, or "help", a skill roll with a portion of a second skill's value, if it makes sense in the context. This is when skill in one area logically complements another.

Take the tens die value (the Score) of the supporting skill and double it. Apply that as a bonus to the primary skill.

Simon is trying to persuade a priest of Morrudann to loan him some lesser clerics as assistants for a holy mission. He knows that drawing upon his knowledge of Morrudann's tenets might show the priest that Simon's task serves the church's aims. Simon has a Persuade skill of 56, but the GM allows Simon's Divinity skill (43) to support it. Simon doubles the Divinity Score of 4 to get 8, which is added to his Persuade skill of 56, for a total modified Persuade skill of 64.

If the Score of a support skill is a zero (i.e., if the modified supporting skill is under ten), it can add no bonus to the primary skill.

Only one skill may support a given roll. The supporting skill may belong to the acting character or another assisting them. If another character provides the support, they may use the same skill as the acting character.

If the roll fails, any supporting character shares in the consequences.

Arn and Stratton are both working to heal Edbert's wounds. Arn is the primary healer, as he has the better Heal skill (67). Stratton helps with his own Heal skill (32), giving Arn a bonus of +6 and raising Arn's Heal skill to 73 for this roll. No other skill from any source can support this roll.

Supporting a skill in combat requires the helper to Perform a Minor Action. Skills in the Combat and Magic categories cannot provide or receive support (except for Might, and only when used for feats of raw strength).

Option: Group Rolls

When multiple characters are trying to do the same thing, the GM can call for a Group roll instead of everyone rolling separately.

In a Group roll, the whole group shares the result--success or failure affects everyone. The GM decides whether to roll using the highest or lowest relevant skill in the group, depending on the situation.

For example, if several party members are using Stealth to sneak by enemies, only the party member with the lowest skill makes a roll--you're only as quiet as the loudest person. This would oppose the highest Perception skill of the enemy party; if the most alert among them hears, then they all benefit.

If the GM allows it, one character can get help from another in a Group roll using supporting skills. If the group is searching for a secret door, for example, the character with the highest Perception could receive help from one other character's Perception, Architecture-wise, or other relevant skill. Or, if sneaking past an enemy outpost, the PC with the lowest Stealth skill would make the roll, but could be supported by the PC with the highest Stealth skill.

Group rolls are used to resolve a single, immediate outcome where all participants succeed or fail together. They are not used for extended rolls, which track progress over time.

Savvy Skills

A character can have one or more skills with the Savvy Talent (see Chapter 4 - Talents), marked with an "S" beside the skill on your character sheet. These skills improve more rapidly than other skills (see Chapter 8 - Experience & Advancement).

stealth	(s)	65
survival		50
track	(s)	65
willpower		55

cHAPTER 4:

talents

Special abilities--dare I say "feats"--that give characters an advantage under specific conditions are called Talents. Most Talents are associated with a particular skill, but others benefit Attributes or some other aspect of the character. A special type of Talent (Expertise) that ensures minimum SLs is discussed at the end of the chapter.

Keywords In This Chapter
Expertise (Ex)
Masterwork
Overrun
Secondary Attack
Talent
True Name

Talents are powerful and allow for greater customization in a Player Character's development. Some Talents may be selected during character creation based on the player character's race or Previous Career. But most Talents will be accessible only after a character has accumulated some hard-earned experience using their skills in pursuit of their goals.

After character creation, Talents may be purchased using XP granted to the player by the GM. Unless specified in its description, a Talent costs 5 XP to buy.

Simon's Forceful Shot and Press the Point Talents grant him advantages when using his crossbow or when defending himself in noble courts.

talents
Forceful Shot
Press the Point

talent categories

Talents are separated into 8 categories:

- A Combat Talents are used in melee, mounted, or ranged conflict and offer specialization in armor, might, speed, and weapon handling.
- A Combat Maneuver Talents grant advantages for compelling surrender, circumventing defenses, disarming, and driving your enemies back with words or weapons.
- A Adventuring Talents increase your chances of success and survival in the wilderness and on the road.
- A Social Talents are used to exert your will and influence with words, wit, and inspiration.
- A Lore Talents augment knowledge gained across many disciplines, including nature, healing, languages, crafting, and the will of your god.
- A Magic Talents are used by Spellweavers and Godbound to harness their magical or divine abilities and to focus their power.
- A Miscellaneous Talents have a variety of uses, like boosting your ability to carry more items, increasing your strength or Resolve, and improving your healing rate.
- A Non-Human Talents bring out keen advantages granted by your non-human lineage.

Talents marked with the? symbol indicate an Advanced version of the Talent.

talent descriptions

Combat Talents

ARMOR PIERCER - Pick one specific weapon type (shortsword, mace, 2H sword, etc.). Gain +1 Piercing when attacking with a weapon of this type. Can be purchased once per weapon type.

FINDTHE GAP - You have a knack for finding the weak point in an opponent's armor. Successful attacks with your Armor Piercer weapon always cause a minimum of a 1-pt wound, regardless of the target's armor or shield.Requires Armor Piercer and a corresponding weapon skill of 80.

ARMOR TRAINING (I-IV) - Wearing heavier armor (Reinforced Leather, Mail, Scale, and Plate) on the Body or Arms prevents an untrained combatant from being able to use Combat Maneuvers in a combat round. Armor Training allows regular use of Combat Maneuvers, but each new level must be acquired in order from lightest armor to heaviest:

- armor training i allows Combat Maneuvers while wearing Body or Arm armor as heavy as Reinforced Leather.
- armor training ii allows Combat Maneuvers while wearing Body or Arm armor as heavy as Mail.
- armor training iii allows Combat Maneuvers while wearing Body or Arm armor as heavy as Scale.

Edbert's Previous Career was a Warrior, and so he starts with Armor Training III: he may wear Reinforced Leather, Mail, or Scale armor on his Body or Arms location without affecting his Combat Maneuvers. If he wanted to wear Plate Body or Arm armor and still be able to use Combat Maneuvers, he would have to acquire this Talent again (Armor Training IV). Arn, on the other hand, has taken this Talent only once (Armor Training I) and is therefore trained in Reinforced Leather only: if he wears Mail, Scale, or Plate in the Body or Arms, he will not be able to perform any Combat Maneuvers.

Talents that say "Once per scene" last for the current situation, as decided by the GM. "Once per session" means once during the current play session. Combat talents that say "As your action this round" cannot combine their effects with each other or with other actions, such as Charging with a Sweeping Attack. The GM rules on edge cases.

"Once per combat" refers to the current initiative sequence. Combat ends when the characters leave the initiative sequence, such as when all enemies are defeated or the party flees.

» armor training iv allows Combat Maneuvers while wearing Body or Arm armor as heavy as Plate.

An Ogre can take this Talent only once, gaining training in Bone armor only.

ASSASSIN - Gain +1 SL when attacking with surprise. Can be purchased up to three times.

CATCH AND RELEASE - If attacked with a thrown weapon and not surprised, you can attempt to catch it and immediately hurl it back at the attacker. You must have one free hand, or you may freely drop a held item (including a shield) to free one. As a defense, make an opposed Thrown roll against the attack. If you win, your DoS counts as a successful attack against the original attacker, using your roll to determine hit location. They may defend as normal. You may use this Talent only once per round.

CLOAK AND BLADE - Elical Dondallan duelists often use a cloak and blade in combat. When fighting with either a Light or Medium weapon while using a cloak instead of a shield, and wearing only Padding, Quilted, or Leather armor pieces, gain the following: +20 to parries, -1 SL to Disarm. Additionally, once per combat, at any point during your turn, you may Taunt Foe as a free action, using Perform instead of Intimidate or Wit.

? DANCE OF BLADES - Once per combat, as an action, make a Perform roll to make a disorienting, dancing blur of cloak movements. Any SLs generated can be used as Favor for the duration of this combat. Requires Cloak and Blade

CLOSE THE DISTANCE - Any bonus from Reach weapons used against you is reduced by 10. They may still choose to use the Set for Charge action against you.

COMBAT AWARENESS - Add +1 to your Initiative modifier. Can be purchased up to five times.

DEFENDER - Pick one specific melee weapon type (shortsword, mace, 2H sword, fists, etc.). Gain +10 when parrying with that weapon.

? IMPROVED DEFENDER - As above, but gain +20 instead. Requires and replaces Defender

DROP ATTACK - Once a round in melee combat, if you kill, knock Prone, or send your opponent into Shock, you may immediately make one free attack at -20 on an adjacent foe currently Engaged with you. The free attack cannot use any "as your action " type of Talent.

? CLEAVE - As above, but without the -20 penalty. Requires Drop Attack

EAGLE EYE - Add one zone when determining effective range when using one specific ranged weapon type (longbow, sling, etc.).

ENHANCED DEFENSE - When defending with a specific Combat skill while outnumbered in melee, your opponents only get a +10 Outnumbering bonus. This Talent can be purchased once for each Combat skill.

? GREAT DEFENSE - As above, but one primary opponent (you choose each round) gets no outnumbering bonus; the rest get +10. Requires Enhanced Defense

FAST RUNNER - As your action, you may Run 2 zones instead of 1.

FAST SKIRMISHER - If you get 20 or more on your Initiative result, you get two turns in the round: one on your Initiative result, and the next at your Initiative result -20 (for example, rolling "21 " allows you to act on "21" and again on "1 "). You may act and move (if possible) on each turn within the round. Only one of your turns can be used for casting a spell or asking for a miracle. Cannot be used while mounted.

chapter 4: talents

FEINT - As part of your melee attack action, you may make a Hard (-20) Deceive roll. If you succeed, you mislead your opponent, and he defends at -10. If you fail, your opponent sees your ruse and defends with +10 instead. Either way, he'll see it coming next time: Feint can never be used twice in a row on the same opponent.

? IMPROVED FEINT - As above, but with your successful Deceive, your opponent defends at -20. Requires and replaces Feint

FORCEFUL SHOT - For 4 SLs, you may use the Drive Back Maneuver with a Missile weapon. This can knock a combatant out of an Engaged melee and into a neighboring zone.

FULL QUIVER - Once per combat, you may re-roll an Ammo Supply Die.

HARD-HEADED - You do not become stunned from Head Impairment.

HOLD THE LINE - When you take the Stand Your Ground action, add +1 to your Toughness.

HORSE ARCHER - Your ranged attacks on horseback are not capped by your Ride skill.

IMPAIRED FIGHTER, ARM - If your Arm is rendered useless from impairment, and you are not in Shock, you can still use that arm to make Combat rolls at a -20 penalty.

IMPAIRED FIGHTER, LEG - If a Leg is impaired, and you are not in Shock, you may still take the Run action (but not the Charge action).

INTIMIDATING CHARGE - A successful Charge attack frightens your foe. If the target fails a Willpower or Might roll (defender's choice) opposed to your original attack roll, they must choose the Flee action on their next turn. Creatures larger than you get +20 per size category. You may only attempt this once per opponent per combat, and it must be declared before the Charge. Will not affect Mindless or Undead creatures, or any creature with Ferocity 5+.

KNOCK-OUT STRIKE - When damaging a target's Head from behind and with surprise, they are rendered Unconscious and in Shock on any failed Wound Die result.

LARGE SHIELD TRAINING - Allows you to equip a Large shield (using 3 Weapon ENC).

MOUNTED CHARGE - When charging on horseback (or other applicable beast), gain +1 SL to any successful Charge attack.

? OVERRUN - If your Mounted Charge attack is successful, you have access to the Overrun special Combat Maneuver. Requires Mounted Charge

» Overrun - 3 SLs. After a mounted charge, leave the Engagement and move back out to Close range, on the opposite side of the zone from where you came. You do not provoke any free attacks by doing so. You may not become Engaged with any new foes while moving.

ON YOUR FEET - Reduce any Rise from Prone penalties from Body armor by 10.

? JUMP UP - Reduce any Rise from Prone penalties from Body armor by 20. Requires and replaces On Your Feet.

POWERFUL BLOW - Pick one specific weapon type (shortsword, mace, 2H sword, longbow, fists, etc.). Do +1 base damage when using a weapon of this type. Can be purchased once per weapon type.

PUGILIST - When making a Might attack or defense roll versus an armed opponent, the penalty is reduced to -10

? ADVANCED PUGILIST - When making a Might attack or defense roll versus an armed opponent, there is no penalty. Requires and replaces Pugilist.

QUICKDRAW - Choose one Combat skill. Drawing an "at hand" weapon (i.e., a weapon using up Weapon ENC) that uses this skill does not require an action. You may draw and attack without penalty. Can be purchased once per Combat skill.

RAPID FIRE - You can make a Ranged attack with a longbow, short bow, or throwing knives at two separate targets with the same ranged attack roll, made at -20. They must be within the same zone as one another, and they each defend separately against your roll. The general locations hit are the same on both targets by default. Any resulting Combat Maneuvers can be applied to one target only. Two Ammo Supply Die rolls must be made.

RIPOSTE - If you parry a successful melee attack and win the opposed roll with 3+ DoS, your melee attack against that opponent on your next turn, made with the weapon you parried with, is at +20.

RISE A FIGHTER - You can Rise from Prone by rolling Endurance, Might, or Willpower (choose one when purchasing this Talent) instead of Athletics.

RUN FOR YOUR LIFE! - When fleeing melee, gain +20 to your Athletics roll.

SHIELD WALL - When two or more possessors of this Talent remain shoulder-to-shoulder with Medium or Large shields in the same zone, it costs +2 SL to use Circumvent Shield, Drive Back, or Trip Combat Maneuvers against them. If moving, they must move together on the same Initiative (likely using the Delay action) to maintain the wall. The wall also counts as cover to allies directly behind it.

SPEED-LOADER - You may reload your crossbow as part of your action, provided you don't move on your turn.

SWEEPING ATTACK - As your action this round, make a single melee attack with a Heavy weapon at -20 against two or more Engaged melee opponents. Roll once and apply to all foes, who may defend as normal. The locations hit are the same on all targets by default. Any resulting Combat Maneuvers are applied to one target only.

TACTICAL ADVANCE - When advancing on someone who has made a Fighting Withdrawal, gain +20 on your defense against their attack.

TACTICAL RETREAT - When making a Fighting Withdrawal, you may make a single attack on one additional opponent who engages you. Can be purchased up to three times (to a maximum of four attacks on four different opponents).

TACTICIAN - When Preparing the Battlefield, gain +2 SL to a successful roll.

? MASTER TACTICIAN - When Preparing the Battlefield, gain +20 on your skill roll. Requires Tactician

TWO-WEAPON FIGHTER - If you are armed with a Light or Medium weapon in the primary hand, and a Light weapon in the secondary hand, you have access to a special Combat Maneuver when you attack with the weapon in your primary hand:

» Secondary Attack - 3 SLs. Make an immediate -20 unopposed attack with your secondary weapon against any Engaged opponent.

The secondary weapon adds +1 AP to all locations (and can be bypassed with Circumvent Shield), but does not count as a shield against ranged attacks. You do not suffer an additional -20 penalty for fighting with the off-hand.

? TWO-WEAPON MASTER - Reduce the Secondary Attack modifier to -10. Requires Two-Weapon Fighter

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Combat Maneuver Talents

BULLRUSH - Drive Back costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with one chosen melee Combat skill.

DISARMING HIT - Disarm costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with one chosen Combat skill. Can be purchased once per Combat skill.

DROP. YOUR. SWORD. - Compel Surrender costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with one chosen Combat skill. Can be purchased once per Combat skill.

LEG SWEEPER - Trip costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with one chosen Combat skill. Can be purchased once per Combat skill.

PRECISE STRIKE - Choose Location costs one less SL when attacking with one chosen Combat skill. Can be purchased once per Combat skill.

SHIELD BEAT - Shield Bash costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with one chosen size of shield (Small, Medium, or Large). Can be purchased once per shield size.

SHIELD BREAKER - When using the Cleave Shield Maneuver of a 2H weapon, add +2 to the d20 roll. Can be purchased up to three times per 2H weapon.

SHIELD MANEUVER - Circumvent Shield costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with one chosen Combat skill. Can be purchased once per Combat skill.

SUBJUGATING WORDS - Use Intimidate as a Combat skill to force your enemy to give up. As your action, roll Intimidate vs your foe's Combat skill. If you win with 3+ SL, you can Compel Surrender, subject to all the normal rules regarding Compel Surrender (target must be disadvantaged, etc). If you win with only 1 or 2 SLs, you Unbalance your foe with your intimidating approach.

WRESTLER - Grapple costs 1 less SL to perform when attacking with Might. Can be purchased once.

Each of the following can be purchased up to 3 times:

SHIELD ARM - Any Circumvent Shield attempts made against you cost +1 SL.

SLIPPERY - Any Grapple attempts made against you cost +1 SL.

STABLE STANCE - Any Trip or Shield Bash attempts made against you cost +1 SL.

STAY PUT - Any Drive Back attempts made against you cost +1 SL.

STAY UP - Any Unbalance attempts made against you cost +1 SL.

STRONG GRIP - Any Disarm attempts made against you cost +1 SL.

Adventuring Talents

ANTI-VENOM BLOOD – Gain +20 on Endurance rolls against poison.

"...BUT IT IS NOTTHIS DAY!" – Once per session, you can make an Inspire roll to recover spent Resolve equal to 1+ (1 per 2 SLs). This Resolve may be split among the party, including yourself. This does not remove Fatigue. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

CAREFUL RATIONING – Once per session, if you're the Quartermaster, you can ignore up to 3 points of penalties from any source when rolling on the Fatigue table. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

EASE OF PASSAGE – Once per session, this character can allow each PC in the party to suffer one less Fatigue at the end of a Journey's leg, after the Fatigue roll is made (or after a day's travel on a HexMarch). A party cannot benefit from more than one character with this Talent. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

ENDURING WATCH – If you kept watch during a rest, recover Fatigue as if you had not kept watch.

FEARLESS – Gain +20 on Willpower rolls against fear.

METTLE – Gain +20 on Endurance rolls to resist Body Impairment from the Wound Die.

ON THROUGH THE NIGHT – Once per session, if you're the Guide, you can do a forced march and not suffer the -5 to the next Fatigue roll. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

QUICK AND QUIET – You can use the Run action even while using Stealth.

RIDE LIKE THE WIND – While mounted, make a Ride roll at -20 as part of your movement to move one extra zone in a round (3 zones instead of 2).

SHIP'S GUNNER – In Naval Combat, you can support your ship's Weapon skill with your Sail/Boat skill (add double your Sail/Boat Score). If you are also the ship's captain, you cannot use this Talent in the same round as using your Sail/Boat skill to support the ship's Maneuvering skill.

SPYGLASS – Once per session, if you're the Scout, you may try to avoid the Event even if your Perceptionroll failed. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

USEFUL GEAR – When taking Fatigue on a Journey, you may take 1 less by rolling the Gear Supply Die. This is in addition to any Fatigue reduced from use of the Rations Die.

WATCHMASTER – If you are the only one keeping watch while in camp, your Perceptionpenalty is -10 instead of -30.

chapter 4: talents

Social Talents

ALLOW ME TO INTRODUCE... Adds +1 to Tolerance for all Social Encounters, so long as you are the primary voice for the group. You must be the first to speak and introduce the rest of your party in whichever manner you think best. The roll does count against Tolerance, but also contributes to the total SLs for the Social Encounter. In a Competitive Social Encounter, your first Social skill roll instead gets a +20 bonus.

BARBED TONGUE This Talent is similar to the Taunt combat action, but is used in a Competitive Social Encounter. You land a verbal jab to demoralize an opponent within earshot. Pick one target on the opposing side. As your action this round, make an opposed Intimidate or Wit roll against the target's Willpower. If you win (and if they can understand you), they or their side suffers -20 to their next Social roll. For every 3 DoS, increase the penalty by an additional -10. Each subsequent use of Barbed Tongue against the same target in the same encounter suffers a cumulative -20 to your Intimidate or Wit roll.

BLATHER Spew a string of gobbledegook to confuse one target, in combat or otherwise. The target must be able to hear and understand you. As an action, make a Wit roll opposed to the target's Insight. If you win, they suffer a -20 to their next roll. If you win by 5+ DoS, the target is flabbergasted by your blather, loses their next action, and may only defend. Each subsequent use of Blather against the same target in the same encounter suffers a cumulative -20 to your Wit roll.

ENTERTAINING Your first use of Perform or Wit in a Static Social Encounter does not count against Tolerance. In a Competitive Social Encounter, the first use instead gives a +20 skill bonus.

EXPRESSIVE Your Social skills are not capped by the language you are speaking.

FIERY WORDS Your first use of Inspire or Intimidate in a Static Social Encounter does not count against Tolerance. In a Competitive Social Encounter, the first use instead gives a +20 skill bonus.

HONEYED WORDS Your first use of Persuade or Seduce in a Static Social Encounter does not count against Tolerance. In a Competitive Social Encounter, the first use instead gives a +20 skill bonus.

INSPIRATIONAL When using the Inspire Ally action in combat, a success grants either one ally +20 to their next roll (instead of +10), or two allies +10 each. For every 3 SLs, you gain another +10 that may be given to any eligible ally.

I SEE YOUR MIND If someone in your party gains leverage through an Insight roll during a Social Encounter, you may immediately spend 1 leverage to learn one of the NPC's Special Reactions (GM's choice). You can learn only one Special Reaction this way per encounter. You may also spend 3 leverage to reveal the NPC's Tolerance.

NATURAL POLITICIAN - Your first use of Deceive or Protocol in a Static Social Encounter does not count against Tolerance. In a Competitive Social Encounter, the first use instead gives a +20 skill bonus.

PRESS THE POINT - Once per Social Encounter, you can use a skill for a third time in a row, or you can use a Social skill with an NPC even if that same skill just failed.

RALLY THE TROOPS - When in Mass Combat, make any Rally actions with a +20 bonus. When not in Mass Combat, if forces under your control and within the sound of your voice fail a morale or fear (Willpower) roll for any reason, as an action, make an Intimidate or Inspire roll. For every 2 SLs, one friendly unit recovers from their failed morale and rejoins the battle.

STORM THE DECKS - When leading a crew in a Naval Combat boarding action, you can support their Crew value with double your Inspire Score each round of hand-to-hand combat. You must participate in the boarding action and get into combat yourself to use this Talent.

UNIVERSAL TAUNT - When Taunting a Foe in combat, roll any appropriate Social skill (not limited to Intimidate and Wit).

Lore Talents

ALCHEMIST - When successfully creating alchemical potions, make 1d4 doses + 1 dose per 2 SLs (instead of 1d3 + 1 per 3 SLs).

BARTERER - Use Commerce to make one attempt to adjust the value of a bought or sold item by +10% per DoS (instead of per 2 DoS) up to a maximum of 50% (see Chapter 9 - Equipment: Coins & Haggling).

BATTLEFIELD TACTICS - Once per battle (see Appendix A: Mass Combat), a Commander can roll Battle-wise to increase the Initiative values of friendly units. Each SL can increase one unit's Initiative value by 1. This effect lasts throughout the battle. Requires Battle-wise Lore skill.

BEAST TAMER - Use Naturewise to tame a mundane wild animal as an extended roll, with each roll taking one day. Most normal animals require 6 SLs to tame; more aggressive animals require 9 to 15 SLs, and will attack on any critically failed extended roll. Offers of food may provide a bonus to one or more of the rolls (GM discretion). A tamed animal is considered friendly towards the Beast Tamer and anyone he designates as friends. The tamed animal will follow the Beast Tamer's simple commands on a successful Naturewise roll. It is not a pet, however, and will still behave according to its nature where appropriate. It can be commanded to fight, but it will not generally fight to the death.

chapter 4: talents

At any one time, a Beast Tamer can have tamed a maximum number of animals based on their Size and on the Beast Tamer's Naturewise Score:

- A Naturewise Score is 1-4: up to 3 Small animals
- A Naturewise Score is 5-7: as above, plus up to 2 Medium animals
- A Naturewise Score is 8+: as above, plus up to 1 Large animal

Taming an additional animal of a particular size category requires first releasing one of the currently tamed animals.

? BEAST SPEAKER - Choose up to three of your tamed animals. Through body language, vocalizations, or other nonverbal cues, the tamed animals can communicate simple ideas to you, but nothing more complicated than what would be expressed in short, simple sentences. Requires Beast Tamer.

BEDSIDE MANNER - Add 3× your Heal Score when tending to a character's Recovery rolls.

EXTRA BANDAGES - Once per game session, you may re-roll a failed Medical Supply roll. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

IT'S ALL IN THE MOLD - Gain +20 on Heal rolls to purge infected wounds.

KINGSFOIL - Once per game session, at any point while on a Journey, you may attempt to purge an infection without having to change to Daily Time. Requires a Medical Supply roll. Can be purchased up to 3 times, each giving an additional attempt per session.

LECTURER - Pick one of your custom -wise skills. You may use this skill in a Social Encounter.

LITERATE - You can read and write any language you can speak.

MASTER CRAFTSMAN - When crafting a new item with Craft: Practical/Artistic , for every 3 SLs you earn over the required SLs, you may improve it in one of the ways below to make it a masterwork item. Each option may be selected only once, and each selection increases the crafting cost by an amount in sp equal to the item's listed price:

- A +5% to a skill applicable to the item's use
- A +1 damage to a weapon
- A -1 to the cost of one weapon Combat Maneuver (Choose Location, Disarm, etc.), to a minimum Maneuver cost of 1
- A +1 AP to a piece of armor
- A -1 to the ENC or Bulk, to a minimum ENC or Bulk of 1

A critical failure while trying to gain extra SLs over the required SLs ruins the item, and the material costs from trying to improve the item (as described above) are wasted.

? LEGENDARY CRAFTSMAN - As above, but each improvement can be chosen twice (for example, the skill bonus could be +10%, or armor Bulk could be reduced by 2, to a minimum of 1 Bulk). Requires Master Craftsman.

NATURAL REMEDIES - Gain +10 on any Naturewise or Survival attempts to find ingredients for a natural healing potion, and +10 on Craft: Practical attempts to brew it.

SURGEON - Gain +20 on Heal rolls to perform an amputation.

TRAVEL PLANNER - If you participate in the Travel Lore roll and gain any number of SLs, the party earns 2 additional points of Favor.

WEAPON OF FAITH - Once per combat, as an action, pray to your god, spend 1 Resolve, and make a Divinity roll. Any SLs generated can be used as Favor to your actions for the duration of this combat. Requires a Divinity skill of 70 and to be a faithful adherent of a god (you do not require the Godbound Talent).

? ARMOR OF FAITH - Your faith protects you from harm. Once per combat, as an action, pray to your god, spend 3 Resolve, and make a Divinity roll. Add 1 (+ 1 per 3 SLs) of AP to all locations for the duration of the combat. Requires Weapon of Faith.

Magic Talents

ARMORED CASTER - You are trained to weave magic through the hindrance of armor. Reduce the Total Cost increase from your armor's Initiative penalty by 3. Can be purchased up to three times.

DIVINE CONDUIT - You can try to channel your god's wisdom by allowing the deity to speak through you at (in)opportune times. There is a chance that what is spoken is helpful. Spend 1 Resolve and roll Piety; every 3 SLs generated produces one useful piece of information. The information should be presented in some combination of metaphor, symbolism, and poetry (the gods rarely give a straight answer). Failing the roll, or using this Talent twice in the same day, causes the deity to provide unhelpful or obstructive information. Using this Talent doesn't cost any Piety, only the 1 Resolve.

ENCHANTER - When making Enchanted items, roll Arcana. Reduce the accrued Fraying points by 1 per 3 SLs (to a minimum of 1 Fraying point).

ENDURING CASTER (BIND) - Spend 1 less Resolve when choosing to Mitigate after the casting roll with a specific Bind skill. Can be purchased up to three times in total (not per Bind).

FADED PATTERN - Allows a non-Spellweaver to cast magic within certain limitations; these folk are known as Fades. A Fade wasn't born to the power, and they will never be as accomplished as a true Spellweaver; their magical presence imprints a more unstable outline on the Pattern of the Weave. The following rules apply to a Fade:

- A You may spend XP (or "rounding out" skill points in character creation) on Bind and Strand skills.
- A You may never have a value of more than 70 in any Bind skill.
- A Start with a total of 5 levels among any Strands of your choice. A Fade may never have more than 7 in any Strand. Fades are not limited by Thin Strands.
- A You may not choose Bind skills as Savvy skills.

- A As a Fade, you are even more susceptible to the Weave's lashings: any casting roll that critically fails immediately accumulates 1 Fraying point, in addition to any other critical failure effects.
- A Upon becoming a Fade, the Weave imprints you with a True Name, as a Spellweaver.

Special Restriction: Unlike other Talents, Faded Pattern requires 2 Talent selections if chosen during character creation. These must come from your starting allotment of Talents, including those granted by Previous Careers. If purchased later in play, this Talent costs 10 XP instead of 5.

FAST SUMMONER - Drawing your summoning circle only takes 15 minutes.

FORCEFUL STRAND (STRAND) - Pick one Strand. For any spell you cast using this Strand, the target resists at -10. Can be purchased up to three times per Strand.

GODBOUND - This Talent allows the character to select a chosen patron deity and acquire the Piety skill at a starting value of 30 (or to add 30 during character creation). The Piety value can never be more than 90 (although it can be temporarily raised through modifiers). At character creation, only Previous Career: Godbound may select this Talent. Purchasing this Talent after character creation costs 10 XP.

PATTERNED IN THE WEAVE - This Talent can only be chosen if your Previous Career is Spellweaver. True Spellweavers are born to the Pattern. One must possess this Talent to be a fully-fledged Spellweaver. Choose a True Name imprinted upon you by the Weave: this name must be in the language of your people, and can be used to magically target you using the Arcane Tether Range (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic). Gain +5 to Max Resolve.

RITUAL CASTER - All your ritual spell rolls gain a +10 bonus. Can be purchased up to three times.

STRAND SECRET (STRAND) - Gain a new Strand of your choice at a value of 1 (a Thin Strand costs 10 XP).

TRUE FAITH - Once per session, increase the quality of a granted divine miracle by one step (Lesser to Middle or Middle to Greater). Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

UNERRING BOLT (STRAND) - Pick one Strand. Your attack spells with that Strand do +1 damage. Can be purchased up to three times per Strand.

WEAVE RESISTANT (CHOOSE) - Pick one skill. Gain +20 when using that skill to oppose magic. Can be purchased once per skill.

WEAVE SHADOW - Make all rolls on the Weave Reaction Table at -1. Can be purchased up to five times, for up to -5 on the table.

WORDS ALONE - Casting a spell normally requires at least one free hand. With this Talent, the caster can still attempt the spell if both hands are occupied (such as wielding a weapon and shield) or otherwise prevented from making gestures (such as having both arms Impaired), but at -20 to the Bind roll.

Miscellaneous Talents

CAT'S FALL - When falling, roll Athletics. Reduce falling damage by the SLs. If it reduces the damage to zero, you do not go Prone.

FAST HEALER - Remove 1 extra Wound Point on a successful Recovery roll. This Talent can only be purchased once.

GRIT (LOCATION) - In the specified hit location(s), you do not automatically drop in Shock until you suffer a third Impairment there. Each time this Talent is taken, choose one from: the Body, the Head, both Arms, or both Legs.

I HAVE JUST THE THING - Once per game session, you may re-roll a failed Gear Supply Die. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

INNER STRENGTH - Increase your Max Resolve by 1. Can be purchased multiple times to a maximum Resolve of 30.

NOT TODAY, DEATH - Increase your Death Threshold by 2; recalculate Lethality Level. Can be purchased up to five times.

SAVVY - Pick one skill and mark an "S " next to it. When improving this skill with XP , increase the result by +1 (see Chapter 8 - Experience & Advancement). You may not buy Savvy twice for the same skill.

STEELY THEWS - Once per game session, you may re-roll the Wound Die, keeping the more favorable result. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

STRONG BACK - Increase your number of Inventory slots by 2. Can be purchased up to three times.

STRONG IMMUNE SYSTEM - Once per game session, you may re-roll the Infection Die, keeping the more favorable result. Can be purchased up to three times, each giving an additional use per session.

SWIFT RIDER - While traveling alone on horseback during a Journey, you suffer only a -2 Fatigue penalty for a Forced March instead of -5.

? SWIFT COMPANY - The benefit extends to your whole party. Requires Swift Rider and Ride 80+.

TOUGH - Increase your Toughness by 1. Can be purchased up to three times.

UNKILLABLE - Increase your Lethality Level by 1. You may improve your Lethality Level this way a maximum of three times.

WEAPON BELT - Increase your Max Weapon ENC by 1. Can be purchased up to three times.

chapter 4: talents

Non-Human Talents

BLOOD-FURY – Half-Orc only. Any time your total Wound points exceed half your Death Threshold, you may choose to spend 3 Resolve to enter a Blood-fury state. For a number of rounds equal to half your Endurance Score (round up), gain +20 to any melee attack roll and +1 damage on successful attacks. However, you suffer -20 to all other skills during this time--including all defense rolls--and cannot retreat or disengage unless you succeed on a Willpower roll.

DWARVEN SWORDSINGER – Dwarf only. You are a Dwarven smith whose song can enchant a weapon that you forge (Master Craftsman improvements may be added during forging if desired). Once per turn of the moon (one month), you can make a Perform roll, taking 1 hour. You may instead Perform the song in 1 round, but at a -20 penalty. For every Perform SL, the weapon counts as magical for 1 day (as per the 1 SL Enhance Weapon Effect; see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic).

DEVOURING MAW – Ogre only. Your bite may be used as a Natural Weapon attack (2 dmg, Piercing 1). Once per scene, if you deal at least 1 Wound with this attack, you may consume the flesh to regain 1d3 Resolve (if the target is living) or 1 Resolve (if recently dead).

WHISPERED INHERITANCE – Bolg Fiir only. Once per session, you may roll Willpower to attune yourself to the buried resonance of your people's lost magic. If successful, you receive a fleeting insight or impression relevant to your current situation. The quality of the outcome is based on your SL. Choose one of these effects:

- 1+ SLs: You receive a useful emotional imprint (for example, "This place was a battleground, " or "Someone is lying to you. ")
- 4+ SLs: A forgotten word, rune, or phrase surfaces in your mind. It grants +30 to your next Ancient Lore, Arcana, or Insight roll.
- 6+ SLs : A half-memory of a Seethie magical technique flickers through you, granting a one-time +3 SL bonus to the outcome of the next successful Bind roll you make.
- 8+ SLs: The Seethie thought coalesces briefly into lucidity. You may ask the GM a single specific question related to your current environment or decision and receive a symbolic but useful answer.

HUNTED BY THE QUEEN - Replaced only, mandatory at character creation. You were abducted and enslaved by the minions of the Dark Fae lords. You spent countless years trapped in their dreamy nightmare realm, a mortal plaything of strange elder beings. Finally, you found a way to escape through the Thorns, the supernatural boundary between worlds. Though free, you now carry a fragment of the Glamour: a lingering sliver of the power they used on you. But the Fae Queen never gives up her toys. The Queen's Hunt is always on your trail, appearing in many forms, at the worst possible times.

- A Glamour - By spending 3 Resolve and making a successful Willpower roll, you can make yourself look like anyone a single target would consider friendly or desirable. This lasts for a few hours, or until you do something they would consider suspicious, at which point they get an Insight roll to see through the effect. Further suspicious actions grant a cumulative +20 to the Insight roll. Most individuals are not pleased once they realize they've been deceived by the Glamour.
- A Seduction of the Fae : Resolve spent on Perform (only with song or instrument), Seduce or Wit rolls against a single target adds +20 per Resolve instead of +10. Failing such a Fae-enhanced roll immediately ends a Social Encounter, or otherwise ends badly, as the NPC sees through the Glamour. This may have violent consequences.
- A Cast Out of the Weave : A Replaced may never learn Weave magic, and suffers a -10 on any opposed roll made against it.
- A Legacy of Servitude : A Replaced suffers a 1-pt Wound from any simple contact with cold iron. Such weapons also do +1 damage against them.
- A Hunted : You were one of the Fae Queen's playthings, and she wants her slaves back. The Queen's Hunt is ever at your heels. If you stay in one place for more than a few days, the GM rolls a d20 Timer Die: if the roll is equal to or less than the number of days you have remained in one place, the Hunt has found you. They come in many forms, but their goal is always the same: to drag you back through the Thorns into the "loving" arms of your Fae master.

THORNMARK - Replaced only. Once per scene, you may roll Insight to sense whether a Fae creature or agent of the Queen's Hunt is within 300 feet. On a success with 1-4 SLs, you detect a direction and distance--but not identity. This may give you a chance to flee, prepare an ambush, or otherwise act before they arrive. With 5+ SLs, you also recover a blurred memory of your captivity, which grants +10 to any skill roll made in defiance of the Hunt for the first three rounds of the encounter.

expertise

Expertise is a special type of Talent that affects skill use. It ensures that a successful skill roll generates a minimum number of SLs.

Simon has an Expertise level of 2 in his Survival skill of 65. If his player rolled 16 on a Survival roll, instead of 1 SL, he would get his minimum 2 SLs from the Expertise.

- Failed rolls gain no benefit from Expertise.
- Each individual skill has its own Expertise level.
- In DoS rolls, Expertise SLs may still be reduced by the opponent's SLs as normal.
- Strands and Piety can never have Expertise.

Each time a character gains a level of Expertise in a skill, that skill's minimum SL on a successful roll increases as follows:

- The first time Expertise is gained, the minimum SL becomes 2 (notated as Ex2).
- The second time, the minimum SL becomes 3 (Ex3).
- The third time, the minimum SL becomes 4 (Ex4).
- A character may never have more than Ex4 in any skill. Additionally, a skill cannot have Expertise higher than half the value of its tens digit, rounded down.

A skill of 55 has a tens digit of 5. Half of 5 is 2.5, rounded down to 2, so the maximum possible Expertise is Ex2.

A skill of 69 has a tens digit of 6, half of which is 3, so the maximum possible Expertise is Ex3.

Skill Expertise Limits

Skill Value	Maximum Expertise
20-39	N/A
40-59	2
60-79	3
80+	4

When acquiring Expertise, mark the new value (2, 3, or 4) in the "Ex" column beside the skill value on your character sheet. For NPCs, a GM can put the Expertise after the skill value ("Track 76 Ex2" would mean a Track skill of 76 with an Expertise of 2).

Simon has acquired 2 Expertise in the Endurance skill. In the "Ex" column beside his skill of 67, his player marks "2".

athletics	55	
endurance	67	2
locks & traps	25	
perception	60	
ride	55	

cHAPTER 5:

people of the broken empires

In The Broken Empires RPG, Player Characters are highly capable in their chosen skills and professions, but they remain--despite their particular genetic make-up--ordinary people facing extraordinary circumstances. Whether Human, Dwarf, Half-Orc, Ogre, Bolg Fiir, or one of the enigmatic Replaced, all are bound by their own frailties, ambitions, and moral dilemmas.

A character's Race (or ancestry, or kin, or whatever term you prefer) may give certain bonuses or penalties to various skills and Attributes, but that does not exempt them from the hard decisions and dangerous consequences that define life in the Broken Empires. Here, survival and meaning are achieved not by racial traits and characteristics, but by the choices each individual makes--and the price they are willing to pay for them.

kin, house, tribe, clan

The people of the Broken Empires rise and fall into the following 6 categories:

- A Humans
- A Dwarves
- A Half-Orcs (Uthrak)
- A Ogres
- A Bolg Fiir
- A The Replaced

chapter 5: people of the broken empires

humans

THE VAST MAJORITY OF THE BROKEN EMPIRES' POPULATION IS HUMAN (referenced by Loremasters as "the race of Men"). This was not always so; when Humans emerged many millennia ago, they gradually appropriated the lands from the Elves--the Duanan Seethe (Do-AHN-nan SEETHE)--who diminished and eventually left the world. Humans have been dominant ever since.

Humans come in all shapes and sizes, with the average male standing between 5'8" and 6', females from about 5'6" to 5'10". Their individual hair, eye, and skin color varies greatly, but is largely dependent on the region they hail from. Generally speaking, Human folk from the north tend to be fair-skinned, blue- or green-eyed, and light-haired, whereas those from the south and the deserts of the southeast are darker of complexion, eye, and hair.

There are many cultures of Men in the Broken Empires. Each has its own habits, traditions, and language, and although there is no "common tongue", most folk speak a bit of Low Vestrian.

angevarre ansharir the baronies drangia dunblaine

haedravik hohenvall old vestria sattagoya serpent's teeth isles

keighton thessia tical dondala vieksgrad

THE STEADFAST PROGRESS OF MEN HAS ALWAYS BEEN DRIVEN BY A SENSE OF ADVENTURE AND UNCONVENTIONAL THINKING. FOR MEN FEAR NOT GROWING SLOWLY; THEY FEAR ONLY STANDING STILL.
-- Caedric Fallstan, Loremaester, Thessian Sage's Guild

chapter 5: people of the broken empires

dwarves

STOUT, DOUR, AND OF FEW WORDS, THE DWARVES OF THE BROKEN EMPIRES were not always the lost, wandering race they have become. Before the Flight of the Duanan Seethe, the Dwarves had built a sprawling empire, running under the spine of the mountains from the capital of Mountainholme in the north, all the way to the Sunless Sea in the south. They were renowned as craftsmen, diplomats, and scholars... until the Cataclysm struck, forcing the Dwarves to flee their ancestral homes from disasters both mundane and sorcerous.

Today, the 13 Tribes of the Dwarves are a scattered people always on the move, many living aloft on their ancient flying Stoneships, artifacts of ingenious craftsmanship from a bygone age. The origins of these magnificent lumbering vessels are lost to the mists of time, and certainly no Dwarf now remembers the secrets of their construction. Indeed, a kind of religious cult has sprung up around the maintenance and operation of these colossal machines. Grim Dwarven Sky-Priests ritually intone now-meaningless phrases, anointing the vessel's gears and pulleys with holy oils and exotic unguents. The mechanism by which these habitual rites keep the Stoneships aloft has long been forgotten, devolving into the stuff of religious dogma. What is certain is that without the solemn rituals, the airships would certainly cease operating and crash to earth, scattering the Dwarven nations once more...

Stoneship-dwelling Dwarves have the Wanderer culture, but Player Character Dwarves are assumed to have left their sky-ships (some may have never grown up on them at all) and can come from any culture.

WE DO NOT QUESTION THE STONESHIPS. WE ANOINT, WE CHANT, WE TEND THE GREAT GEARS, AND THE STONE REMEMBERS TO FLY.

THE WIND IS OUR ROAD NOW, BUT ONE DAY, THE STONES WILL SETTLE AGAIN UPON PEAKS NOT YET CLAIMED, AND IN HALLS NOT YET CARVED.

-- Thrain Coppervein, Keeper of the Wind-Chain

chapter 5: people of the broken empires

half-orcs (uthrak)

THE ORCS OF THE BROKEN EMPIRES ARE EXCLUSIVELY MALE, and, with rare exception, savage, ferocious marauders, driven by a collective hatred of virtually every other race. No one knows what fuels this constant, burning rage, but no peace between orc and Human--or any other group--seems possible. Occasionally, an individual orc may display a faint sense of what might be called honor--but this is rare and fleeting. They are known to turn on each other at the slightest provocation and delight in mayhem, chaos, and carnage. Consequently, orcs are feared and fought wherever they appear, and with good reason.

But none of this correctly describes the Half-Orc. Contrary to popular belief, a Half-Orc is not in fact the offspring of Human and orc; such a product is impossible, as the two races are too biologically distinct to interbreed. No, a Half-Orc is an orc who has somehow transcended its race's most violent instincts and has developed something of a conscience--if not a proper moral center, at least a vague sense of right and wrong. In fact, the term Half-Orc is used (in Orcish) by true orcs as a vicious slur to describe their "fallen and weakling" brethren. No one knows what causes this rare transformation from orc to Half-Orc--Loremasters suspect something fundamental changes in the orc's brain, like a biological lever being pulled--but a Half-Orc does not last long among its purer cousins, being either driven out or killed.

Those Half-Orcs (or Uthrak, as they call themselves) that are lucky enough to have been accepted by Humans are encouraged to temper the savage side of their nature, to ensure they are never confused with the more monstrous members of their race. Half-Orcs retain the brute physical qualities of their Orcish lineage, including the smoky, ashen skin and slightly pointed ears, but there are some that can even pass as Human, with some creative use of wardrobe and favorable shadows. The real test is, of course, engaging in conversation with an Uthrak, as a true orc would never waste breath talking to its next victim.

THE RAGE IN MY BLOOD SLEEPS... BUT NOT DEAD. NEVER DEAD. HOW LONG UNTIL IT WAKES, AND KILLS THE THING I HAVE BECOME? AND WHO ELSE WILL DIE WITH IT?

-- Varnek Draal, Exile of Red Pass

chapter 5: people of the broken empires

ogres

LARGE, LUMBERING, AND SEEMINGLY BRUTISH, THE OGRES OF THE BROKEN Empires have a reputation for being unpredictable savages, on par with the orcs. That reputation is (largely) hyperbolic. The reality is that the stories of their vicious monstrousness are mostly embellished by the Ogres themselves, to ensure potential enemies keep their distance.

What is true is their enormous--and sometimes uncontrollable--appetites, be it for food, wine, laughter, or music. This appetite is undoubtedly the cause of their dangerous reputation: Ogres struggle with a condition known as "the Breaking", which is brought on by humiliation and failure, and causes the Ogre to have an uncontrollable urge to consume any living creature within reach, friend or foe. The Breaking can strike at the worst possible moment, as was the case during the Carnage of Din Dyrthas, where a docile-seeming Ogre retainer who was entrusted with watching the lord's young children suddenly experienced the Breaking and consumed each child whole, one by one.

Most of the Ogres that make their way down from the mountains and hills are eager to leave this particular notoriety behind them. Some of them even try to pass themselves off as Men, hacking off their lower tusks or curving horns and dressing as country nobles, but there is no hiding the coarse hair, the mighty jaw, or the powerful upper body that could crush a man into paste.

The average Ogre stands 6'5" or taller. They are thick around the midsection and weigh 400 pounds or more, making them Large-sized creatures. They tend to have long, stringy hair, bulbous noses, and slightly slanted, almond-shaped eyes. Ogres judge one another by the striations on their horns; more elaborate swirling patterns are associated with higher status and sophistication.

AH, THE BREAKING--NASTY BUSINESS, THAT. BEST WAY TO AVOID IT IS TO KEEP AN OGRE HAPPY: FEED US, TOAST WITH US, PLAY A TUNE OR TWO. WE'RE MUCH LESS LIKELY TO EAT YOU WHILE WE'RE SINGING... THOUGH I CAN'T PROMISE ANYTHING IF THE PIE RUNS OUT!

-- Olga "Two-Keg" Grumblegut, Traveling Cook and Sometime Bodyguard

chapter 5: people of the broken empires

bolg fiir

RELATED BY BLOOD AND FAE MAGIC TO THE DUANAN SEETHE OF OLD AND also sharing a lineage to the ancient race of Giants, the Bolg Fiir (Bohlg FEER) were ever in competition with their estranged Elven cousins for dominion over the lands that would become the Broken Empires. After a devastating war that left both sides much diminished, an uneasy but necessary truce allowed each race to meet the rising threat of the newly appearing orcs and Humans. Both sides put their grievances aside long enough to jointly construct a host of marvels (often with the help of the Dwarves) that gave them a significant advantage over the invaders. But just when the Bolg Fiir were starting to feel truly allied with their ancient cousins, the Duanan Seethe suddenly abandoned the Bolg Fiir. They disappeared into the mists of the Otherworld--the strange and ever-hidden realms of the Fae, known as Tirn Nanaille (TEERN nah-NIGH)--leaving the Bolg Fiir behind to deal with the threats of the Broken Empires alone. The Bolg Fiir have never forgiven their absent kin, and now wander the Empires in small numbers, making what homes they can in the wild distant places of the world.

Physically, the Bolg Fiir resemble the race of Men, but with both Giant and Seethie features being apparent. They stand taller than the average Human of the Empires, averaging 6'3" and possessing a slightly huskier look. The males grow thick, soft beards, braided in the old style, but from under their fair hair poke the pointed ears of the Elves. The females are usually beautiful, in an almost harsh way: their features are rugged but Elfin, with high, thin cheekbones framing stern, cold faces. With some effort, a Bolg Fiir can hide their features and pass as Human; although most Bolg Fiir would consider such a notion insulting at best. Most Humans will be wary of a Bolg Fiir if they suspect their heritage, so they must be careful when interacting with Human cultures.

The legendary magic of the Elves is largely absent in the Bolg Fiir. Very few of them have any connection with the powers of the Otherworld. However, the occasional loremaster or mystic among them can still commune somewhat with the Ancestors, the ancient memory stones of the Duanan Seethe. Mastering the Weave is not beyond them, and it is said there is an "Awakening" coming for the Bolg Fiir; a time when the Duanan Seethe will return to the world and restore the gifts of Seethie magic to their cousins. Time will tell whether this is a foolish prophecy or a canny inevitability.

THEY WHISPER OF AN AWAKENING, A DAY WHEN OUR LOST KIN WILL STEP FROM THE MISTS AND PLACE THE OLD MAGIC IN OUR HANDS AGAIN. I DO NOT WAIT FOR IT. IF IT COMES, LET IT FIND US STANDING, NOT KNEELING. LET THEM SEE WE ENDURED WITHOUT THEIR GIFTS--AND THAT WE NO LONGER NEED THEM.

-- Vaelric, Walker of the Ways

chapter 5: people of the broken empires

the replaced

A REPLACED IS A HUMAN WHO WAS FORCIBLY ABDUCTED AND MADE TO serve in the realm of the Dark Fae, found a way to escape, and is now hunted by the Fae Queen. When they return, they realize their life has been stolen from them, and often a faerie changeling has taken their place.

The Fae realm is a beautifully nightmarish place only faintly remembered by mortals who venture there. It is thought to be related or connected to the Otherworld, where the Duanan Seethe are said to have gone. Indeed, most folk assume the Seethie are Fae themselves.

The Fae consider mortals to be their playthings, and while they dress them in beautiful clothing and give them delectable faerie foods to eat, the mortal is still never anything more than a slave, bound to the will of their Fae Lord or Lady, for eternity. By some miracle, certain slaves manage to find a way beyond the Thorns, the supernatural boundary between the Dark Fae realm and the Broken Empires. The first thing most Replaced do is find a way to eliminate any changeling imposter that may exist, in a desperate attempt to take their life back.

A Replaced is always on the run from the ever-pursuing members of the Queen's Hunt, monstrous faerie creatures that will stop at nothing to retrieve their Queen's escaped prize. While the Replaced enjoy certain vestigial powers from their time as captives in the Fae realm, most wish it had never happened to them, for the price of such powers is far too high.

I CAME HOME TO FIND MY BED WARM, MY CHILDREN LAUGHING... AND NONE OF THEM KNEW MY FACE. SHE WORE MY VOICE, MY SMILE, MY MEMORIES. I KILLED HER, AND STILL THEY LOOKED AT ME LIKE I WAS THE IMPOSTER. NOW I RUN, BUT THE HUNT NEVER STOPS. ONE OF THESE NIGHTS, THEY'LL FIND ME--I KNOW IT. BUT I WILL DIE BEFORE I LET THEM TAKE ME BACK HERE.

-- Moirla Teornach, Former Lady of Faolann

cHAPTER 6:

goals

The true driving force of your Player Character is their Goals, and as such, they are necessary to discuss before we get into character creation proper. They represent your character's ambitions, drives, and desires. Characters with strong, specific goals fuel great, dynamic games. A character without goals leads to a game without conflict; and without conflict, there is no game.

Keywords In This Chapter

Goals
Individual Goals
Shared Goals

Goals are the primary way your character earns Experience Points (XP) with which to improve skills and abilities (see Chapter 8 - Experience & Advancement). There are specific criteria required for this: you have to roll dice to overcome meaningful obstacles in pursuit of the character's goals.

"Rolling dice" normally means skill use, but could also refer to a Wound Die roll or similar. You only roll dice if there is something at stake for the character; if there is something to gain or lose by rolling.

The obstacles in your path must be of significance; otherwise, they do not count for XP. What is "significant" or "meaningful" will be up to the individual table to decide, but writing easy-to-overcome goals merely to farm XP is against the spirit of the game.

coming up with goals

You can derive character goals from anywhere. It can be useful to look back at your Life Events for inspiration, and also at any shared histories you might have discovered with other PCs. You could decide that a goal is based on a particular Personality Trait or passion that the character has (see Chapter 7 - Character Creation for more on Life Events and Personality Traits). There are no wrong answers, but some methods are more effective than others in describing a goal, as we will see.

Some goals can be fulfilled within a session or two:

- "I want to find Balgar the Gem Merchant at his shop here in town and extract the location of the treasure stash from him."
- "I want to forge the Skystone longsword by the end of the week."
- "I will convince the clergy of Morrudann to lend me one of their priests for my expedition into the undead temple."

Other goals require a bigger investment of time and effort:

- "I will track down and kill the slaver who abducted my lover."
- "I need to restore the Dwarven Sky-priests' faith in my ability to serve."
- "I will prove that I can become an influential member of the League of Free Lords."

chapter 6: goals

Individual and Shared Goals

You will likely have several active goals at once. Some of them will be individual goals (objectives specific to the character), and some of them will be shared goals (objectives that the whole party has a common interest in pursuing). Creating shared goals helps explain why the party is adventuring together. Goals arising from shared histories (see Chapter 7 - Character Creation) create an organic reason for them to be a party--if you can weave in any Shared History events you have with another character to formulate shared goals, so much the better. Discuss your goals with the other players as you make your characters.

Shared Goal Examples

- "Together, my friends and I will bring the criminal Talon to justice for the suffering he has inflicted on our respective families."
- "We will acquire enough funds to purchase a warship."
- "My friend Edbert and I will find a way to free him of the ghost who haunts him."

Regardless of whether they are individual or shared, try to maintain three to five active goals at any one time.

Three-Goal Target

There will be times when you have more or fewer than the suggested three to five goals. That's fine, but try to ensure your character has at least three total goals most of the time; without goals, there is no way to progress. Conversely, having too many goals can quickly become overwhelming and distracting, as your character's attention is pulled in too many directions at once (and you can only gain a maximum of 3 XP per session for pursuing goals, no matter how many you worked towards). As a norm, if you maintain a three-goal limit, it will focus your efforts on completing the goals you already have. You don't want to feel like you're drowning in objectives!

Goals Take Time

A goal should be substantial enough that it takes at least one full session to complete. A goal that can be completed by one simple skill roll is rarely meaningful or significant, and is usually too trivial to be worth XP.

Goals Should Relate to Your Party's Goals

It is useful to have your individual goals at least related to what the other party members are trying to achieve. This helps ensure that the party isn't splitting up all the time to pursue their own individual goals at the expense of the party's shared goals. If most of the party's individual goals have some element in common--an idea, a person, a place, a thing--it is more incentive for the group to stay together while pursuing their respective goals.

This doesn't always work out, and sometimes the group must focus on one particular member's goal that is significant only to them. This is a feature, not a bug, as it creates dynamic sessions that shift the spotlight between Player Characters. However, it helps if each party member has some function to serve in helping that character pursue the personal goal, to keep the whole group engaged most of the time.

Again, it's not always possible, but game sessions tend to work better if all players are part of what's currently going on, at least the majority of the time.

Goals Should Be Compatible... Unless They're Not

Try to make your character's goals at least compatible with the other Player Characters' goals. They don't have to be perfectly aligned with each other, but they at least shouldn't be diametrically opposed. If another character's goal is, "I will protect the life of the Bishop at all costs", having the goal of "I will kill the Bishop and laugh while I do it" isn't going to end well for your group.

This isn't a hard and fast rule--some groups thrive on intra-party conflict, and some truly incredible situations can arise from characters at odds with one another--but it has been my experience that most players prefer to keep the conflict

focused on forces outside their party. It requires a certain maturity for players to be able to satisfyingly enact competing goals, and only you know if your group has it. Tension for your players is a good thing; tension among them rarely is. But, every table is different, so make your own judgement call.

Goals Change

Your goals will evolve and shift through play. If you find that a goal has changed due to developing circumstances, or has become untenable or unsatisfying, you are free to adjust it as you will at the end of a session. This is best done in consultation with your GM.

Failing a goal has no system consequences (except for possible XP--see Chapter: Experience & Advancement), although it could have profound narrative consequences for the character who did not achieve the goal.

Goals are About Gain, Loss, and Change

It helps to think of goals as, "What is the conflict I'm trying to overcome?" Word them starting with "I want...", "I need...", "I will...", or "I must..." Make them about specific things you want the character to accomplish in the future. Ask yourself one of these two important questions when coming up with a goal:

- What do you stand to gain by completing the goal?
- What do you stand to lose by not completing it?

Whether a goal is successful or not, the pursuit of it should have changed something important to the character. Actions--and failing to act--have consequences.

Specific, Proactive, Completable

Goals should be specific, proactive, and completable.

Specific: Goals that are too vague and broad cannot be effectively envisioned, so make sure you narrow down the details of each one and focus on a single specific outcome. Don't make it "I want to get rich"; instead, make it "I want to overthrow the bandit leader known as The Raven, and claim his all-gotten treasure for myself". The more specific the goal, the easier it is to know how to pursue and complete it.

Proactive: Goals should also require the player to take action. Don't make a goal that relies on someone else doing something. The goal should only be achievable by the PC using skills to overcome obstacles by rolling dice.

Completable: And finally, know the endpoint of the goal. Under what circumstances can the goal be considered completed? Open-ended goals that cannot be completed will never give you XP for finishing them.

"I want the lord to put an end to the suffering of the peasants" is...

- Vague instead of specific: Which peasants? Where are they? What are they suffering from?
- Passive instead of active: You want the lord to do something? No, no--what will you do to make that happen?
- Open-ended instead of completable: How can indistinct suffering ever be ended? What exact circumstances will end their suffering from their specific affliction?

Do not confuse goals with personality types, or a character's habits or tendencies. "I feel sorry for wounded animals" is a general character disposition, not a goal. "I will always try to save wounded animals" is better, and it's proactive, but it cannot be completed, as there will always be another wounded animal to save. "I seek to heal the wounded Thessian bear we found to earn his trust" is specific, proactive, and completable.

chapter 6: goals

One Goal, or Many?

A goal may take time, span multiple scenes, and generate XP through continued pursuit, but it should still revolve around a single accomplishment. If overcoming part of a goal would introduce a new and distinct problem to solve, that next step is often best treated as a new goal. This helps track your overall progression, but also allows you to benefit more often from completing smaller, more focused goals.

Consider the goal: "I will steal the wizard Havarian's Krythus Orb and sell it to the highest bidder."

Although written as a single sentence, this actually describes two different goals.

Stealing the Orb requires overcoming Havarian's defenses--his tower, wards, guards, or secrecy. Selling the Orb introduces a new challenge entirely: finding a buyer, navigating dangerous negotiations, and avoiding betrayal or exposure.

For XP purposes, these are best treated as two separate goals, pursued in sequence:

- A "I will steal the wizard Havarian's Krythus Orb from his tower."
- A "I will sell the Krythus Orb to the highest bidder without being cheated or killed."

Completing a goal furthers your character's objectives and earns them XP , so separating a larger goal into two smaller ones can help you advance. Just be sure that each goal is a distinct accomplishment, stays true to the larger goal's original intent, and requires rolling dice to overcome meaningful obstacles.

Goals Should Not Overlap

Each goal should represent a distinct, specific outcome. If two goals are ultimately trying to achieve the same thing, they should not be treated as separate goals.

When deciding whether goals overlap, ask yourself: Would completing one of these goals also mean the other is effectively complete? If the answer is yes, they should be combined into a single goal.

Be on the lookout for this when writing goals. If a new goal shares a similar outcome with an existing goal--whether individual or shared--change it to something more distinct.

For example, if the group's shared goal is "Explore the ruined city," and as one of your individual goals you write, "I will make it to the ruined city," then these goals overlap--they are pursuing an outcome so similar, they might as well be the same. In this example, you should change the individual goal to something more distinct, such as "I will uncover who built the ruined city," "I will map the safe routes through the ruined city," or whatever else sounds appealing to you.

Goals Should Be Varied in Focus

Set goals that can be accomplished via multiple methods. Don't make everything about combat; have goals that can be resolved through other means, like social challenges or exploration. Instead of "I will kill the Knight of Brastonbury Tor for what he did to my family", it could be "I will convince the folk of Brastonbury Tor to rise up against their lord", or "I will prove to the Keighton Council that the Knight of Brastonbury Tor is a murderer". Instead of "I will slay the Giant of Gildaine", it might be "I will travel to Gildaine to discover the truth about the Giant". Variety in your goals creates opportunities for many different types of adventures, which then builds a satisfying dynamic range in your campaign.

Effectively describing interesting and active goals is the responsibility of the player. They're your goals, after all--make them exciting to you! Only through the pursuit of your goals will your character earn XP, and therefore advance their skills and earn new talents.

Goal or Backstory?

Goals aren't backstory. They can arise from backstory, but what is past is nowhere near as important as what is present and future. Avoid goals that make predictions about your character. If your goal is based on a backstory that assumes you're prophesied to

save the Barony of Thorngate by overthrowing its wicked ruler, you are just setting yourself up for disappointment when you get slain by a bandit's arrow during a random encounter on the road. Pro tip: No prophecy survives contact with the dice.

The real purpose of backstory for an RPG character is to provide a reason for future action. It is there only to 1) give your character a grounded reason why he or she must take action now, and 2) provide fodder for the GM to throw related obstacles in your way so you can overcome them and achieve your goals.

chapter 6: goals

A Quick Method for Turning Ideas into Goals

Even with the tools provided in character creation, some players may struggle to come up with clear, actionable goals. When in doubt, use this simple four-step method:

1. Start with something your character wants.
2. Identify an obstacle standing in the way.
3. Decide what you will do about it.
4. Combine the above into a goal.

1. "What do I want?"

This can be a person, an item, a truth, a position, a fear you want to resolve -- anything that matters to the character.

- A " I want to chart the safest route through the Draithwood."
- A "I want to avenge my brother's death."
- A "I want a seat on the Merchant Council."

2. "What's stopping me?"

A goal only matters when something opposes it. Ask: What makes this difficult? Tie your obstacles directly to the desire you named above.

- A "The forest is unmapped, haunted, and filled with dangers no one understands."
- A "The bandit chief who killed my brother is protected by a fortified hideout and dozens of loyal followers."
- A "The Council believes I lack influence and backing."

3. "What will I do about it?"

This is the action clause: the part that requires using skills, facing danger, and rolling dice. Keep it tied to the same desire and obstacle.

- A "I will use my Track skill to identify possible paths through the forest, and use various other skills to learn what haunts it."
- A "I will weaken the bandit chief's forces by picking off his scouts and lieutenants."
- A "I will secure the endorsement of three prominent guildmasters."

4. Combine all three into a goal.

A reliable goal structure is:

" I will [take action] to overcome [obstacle] so that I can [desire]."

Using the linked examples above, this produces:

- A "I will use my skills to identify paths and uncover the dangers of the Draithwood, so that I can chart its safest route."
- A " I must eliminate the bandit chief's scouts and lieutenants to break his defenses, so I can finally reach him and avenge my brother."
- A "I need to win support from three influential guildmasters to overcome the Council's doubts and claim a seat among them."

Each of these is specific, proactive, and completable--precisely the kind of goal that generates meaningful obstacles, requires dice rolls, and therefore earns XP.

cHAPTER 7:

character creation

A character is the player's way of interacting with the game world, and TBE allows a player to design a character from the ground up. In character creation, the player chooses the character's race, skill values, culture, career, and more. It is best if the players make their characters together to help create a cohesive party that has one or more shared goals. Life Events (see later) will help facilitate that.

Because TBEs character creation is a cumulative process, it helps to understand the steps before diving in. You'll be assigning numbers that build on one another, not rolling randomly; once points are spent, retracing them can quickly tangle the math.

Keywords In This Chapter

Ability Score
Adversary
Attribute
Convocation
Cultural Background
Death Threshold (DT)
Experience Points (XP)
Expertise (Ex)
Friend
Initiative
Lethality Level (LL)
Life Event
Max Resolve
Patron
Personality Trait
Previous Career
Relationship NPC
Resolve Track
Revelation
Rival
Rounding Out
Savvy Skill
Status
Shared History
Thin Strand
Toughness

the path to building a character

A Player Character is created by following these steps:

1. Envision Concept & Assign Starting Skills
2. Choose a Race
3. Choose 2 "Ability Scores"
4. Determine Attributes
5. Pick a Cultural Background
6. Roll for Life Events
7. Select a Previous Career
8. Rounding Out
9. Equip Your Character
10. Assign Personality Traits
11. Create Character Goals
12. Status (Optional)

By the end of character creation, you should have at least a few skills at 70. Otherwise, you might be a little too spread out and generalized. You should ensure you have a variety of usable Social skills, too. Not all conflicts are violent, and relying only on a single well-developed Social skill will hamstring you in social encounters.

Throughout this section, we will follow Brian, our example player, as he creates his character by following the steps detailed here.

1) envision concept & assign starting skills

Establish a Rough Concept

Before you begin, take a moment to picture the kind of character you want to play. Come up with a single sentence or short phrase that captures the idea in your head -- "wandering sellsword haunted by his last command," "young scholar chasing forbidden truths," "runaway noble turned smuggler."

This isn't binding. You might change it as the dice, cultural background, and Life Events take shape. Think of it as your compass: a rough heading that helps you make decisions when the path branches.

Assign Starting Skill Values

Starting skill values are assigned to the Combat, Adventuring, Social, and Lore skill categories. (Magic skills have their own starting values as detailed later; they all start at zero, and unless you are a Spellweaver, Fade, or Godbound, they are likely to remain at zero.)

These are the base values that every character starts with before any later adjustments. Every subsequent step--Race, Ability Scores, Culture, Life Events, Career, and Rounding Out--adds bonuses on top of these numbers or modifies them in some way.

- First, choose one skill from each category except Magic and assign it a value of 30.
- Then, assign a value of 20 to all other Combat, Adventuring, Social, and Lore skills (except custom -wises and Languages under Lore; these may receive values in later steps, but leave them at zero for now).

During character creation, no skill can be increased beyond 70 for any reason, and Strands cannot be increased beyond 5.

Brian envisions playing a Human Spellweaver character, possibly a druid from the fading southern lands of Old Vestria.

For his starting skills, he assigns a value of 30 to the Combat skill Dodge; to the Adventuring skill Willpower; to the Social skill Protocol; and to the Lore skill Arcana.

He then assigns a value of 20 to all other Combat, Adventuring, Social, and Lore skills. He ignores the -wise, Language, and Magic skills for now.

2) choose a race

Choose or roll a race for your character. Each race has one or more Traits, listed below, that provide special features and modify certain skills. These are most often skill increases, but certain non-humans can suffer skill decreases, too.

If a racial modifier decreases a skill value to zero or below, set it to zero, remembering that a) later bonuses from Culture, Life Events, and Previous Career will be added to skill values, and b) that every skill roll succeeds on a 01-05 regardless of value.

In addition to Traits, every race speaks its own language, as well as a limited amount of Low Vestrian. There is no "Common tongue" in the Broken Empires, but due to the enormous reach of the ancient Imperica Vestria, a few words of Low Vestrian are known to almost everyone.

Further, each non-human character has access to an exclusive Talent (this includes Replaced characters, who aren't really considered "human" anymore). Whenever a non-human character has the opportunity to take a Talent in character creation, they may instead take their exclusive Non-Human Talent. Otherwise, these Talents may be purchased later with XP in the usual way. (see Chapter 4 - Talents: Non-Human Talents)

In several steps, you will pick Talents (see Chapter 4 - Talents). Your Status (an optional system that tracks reputation and social standing; see Status, later) starts at zero.

If at any time during character creation you would be assigned a Talent that you already have, you can take 100 sp (or +1 Status if using the optional Status rules).

The playable races, along with a d100 range for random determination, are:

d100	Race
01-70	Human
71-80	Half-Orc (Uthrak)
81-90	Dwarf
91-95	Ogre
96-99	Bolg Fiir
00	The Replaced

HUMAN SPEAKER
CIVILIZED, URBAN
CITY STATE OF ANSHARIR
LANGUAGE: ELLARIC

Human traits: All Humans may take one bonus Savvy skill of their choice. They may also take one additional level of Expertise in any skill of their choice, and one additional Talent for which they meet the requirements.

languages: The cultural Language of the region at 70 and Low Vestrian at 20. Old Vestrian characters instead assign Low Vestrian 70 and High Vestrian 20.

The major Human cultures, along with a d100 range for random determination, are:

d100	Human Culture	Language
01-12	The free and wild Westlands, guided by the memory of a long-lost king.	Westronne
13-24	The old feudal empire of Angevarre, the breadbasket of the Western Empires.	Angevarran or High Angevarran
25-30	The rural folk of icy Thessia, unwitting keepers of a forgotten history.	Thessian
31-35	The fierce sea raiders of Haedravik, whose past is stained with human sacrifice.	Vikstongue
36	The grim exiled Ironlanders from beyond the Iron Veil, whose shimmering curtain bedazzles the night skies of the far north.	Iron Tongue
37-42	The Serpent's Teeth Islanders, sailors, and upjumped pirates whose leaders dare to call themselves the League of Free Lords.	Pirate's Cant
43-50	The naval empire of Tical Dondala, whose treasure fleets plunder every isle and fledgling nation they can lay their golden hands on.	Dondalese
51-58	The lands of Dunblaine, a mad, foggy, distant kingdom, long thought dominated by the dark Fae themselves.	Gael
59-64	The Old Vestrians, clinging to a glorious past, while ignoring the rot that corrupts the heart of their ancient realm.	Low Vestrian or High Vestrian
65-69	The Hohenvallers, seafaring isolationist merchant princes with unnatural control of the water.	Meersreich
70-77	The Vieksgradians, a robust and dour group of warrior clans, preserving old memories of the World That Was.	Slahvac
78-81	The Red Waste Tribals, scratching a living from the desert sands.	Sandspeech
82-90	The City-State of Ansharir, growing ever richer from the desert caravans who pass through its jeweled gates, but blind to the ancient evils that lie buried in the sand just beyond its walls.	Ellaric (Anshari)
91-95	The warlike barbarians of Drangia, ever hateful towards Spellweavers and their meddlesome ways.	Khannish
96-00	The horse lords of the Sattagoya Steppes, a mighty but squabbling warrior nation, ever unable to unite under the Khanate's banner.	Khannish

Brian decides on a Human from the Old Vestrian culture, and names his character "Hadrion". He chooses Arcana as Hadrion's Savvy skill. As a Human, he can take one additional level of Expertise in any skill of his choice, and one additional Talent that he meets the requirements for. Brian decides to wait until after the character is finished to add the Expertise and Talent. As an Old Vestrian character, Brian assigns a value of 70 to Hadrion's Language: Low Vestrian, and 20 to Language: High Vestrian (an academic language used almost exclusively in written form).

Dwarf

traits: Dwarves have a knack for mechanisms: Locks & Traps is a bonus Savvy skill. They are also gifted at creating things: reduce the required SLs of any extended Craft: Practical or Craft: Artistic roll by 2. Dwarves are hardy folk, gaining +10 to Endurance, and +1 to their Lethality Level. Their dour nature, however, gives them a -10 to Inspire. They alone can acquire the Dwarven Swordsinger Talent.

languages: Kharzhad 70, Low Vestrian 20

Half-Orc (Uthrak)

traits: Few if any Half-Orcs will be from the Civilized: Urban background. They start with Toughness 1, and get Endurance as a bonus Savvy skill, but they suffer a -10 to Willpower. Most folk who encounter a Half-Orc (who is always male) will assume he is a monster that needs killing unless he can prove himself civilized. This makes a Half-Orc's initial social encounters uneasy affairs at best. They alone can acquire the Blood-Fury Talent.

languages: Orcish 70, Low Vestrian 20

BOLG FIIR LOREMASTER
CIVILIZED, RURAL
CARN TAERMANN, DUNBLAINE
LANGUAGE: FIONNAN

Ogre

traits: Ogres may not take any Civilized background. They start with Toughness 1 and a Death Threshold of 22. Due to their Large size, they get +10 to Might (and get the additional +20 per Size difference when Grappling), but must reduce their Stealth and Athletics by 20. They have 8 general Inventory ENC instead of 6.

Ogres suffer -20 to their Melee: Light skill, as those weapons are too small for the Ogre's great hands. They can only use Medium or Large shields. They do not wear the reinforced leather, mail, scale, or plate armor of Men, as they believe the metal brings on the Breaking. If an Ogre wears such armor, they do so untrained and suffer -20 to all Willpower rolls. To mitigate this weakness, some make their own armor from the bones of various creatures, protecting as well as mail, but with more bulk. Ogres may never become any type of Spellweaver or Fade, but some have turned to serving the gods of Men.

If an Ogre critically fails a skill roll for which they used any amount of Resolve, they experience the Breaking: on their next turn, they will attack (with +10) the closest living thing, friend or foe alike, seeking to consume them. This continues every round until they are either knocked Unconscious, killed, successful at a Willpower roll, or are talked out of their carnivorous spree. This can only be done by one they trust, who succeeds at an Inspire or Persuade roll opposed by the Ogre's Intimidate. One such attempt may be made per round.

They alone can acquire the Devouring Maw Talent.

languages: Tusker 70, Low Vestrian 20

Bolg Fiir

traits: No Bolg Fiir may take the Civilized: Urban background. Although the Bolg Fiir have lost their attunement to Seethie magic, they do have an aptitude for harnessing the Weave: if they have the Patterned in the Weave Talent, a Bolg Fiir gets +10 to one Bind skill of their choice. If not, they instead get a +10 bonus to all opposed rolls against Weave Magic.

Due to their natural presence and aloofness, their Stealth and Insight are reduced by 10. Though their Giant blood makes them slightly taller than an average Human, their Duanan Seethe heritage makes them somewhat fragile: no Bolg Fiir can ever have a Toughness of more than 2.

They can take Melee: Light, Missile, Ancient Lore, Arcana or Naturewise as a bonus Savvy skill. They alone can acquire the Whispered Inheritance Talent.

Ancestor Communion: A Bolg Fiir may lay hands on an Elven memory stone and make a Hard (-20) Willpower roll. If successful, they may access the memories of that stone. The quality, usefulness, and danger of those memories will vary greatly, but the more SLs achieved, the more positive the results.

languages: Fionnan (Low Court) at 70, Low Vestrian 20

The Replaced

traits: Despite their captivity, the nature of the realm of the Dark Fae ensures that most details quickly fade from the minds of those who escape. At best, a Replaced has disjointed snatches of memory about the realm of their servitude, sometimes intensifying when coming into contact with other escapees. They start with a score of 20 in a specialty Lore skill, Dark Fae-wise This skill can only be improved after a session in which the character has been in the physical presence of a fellow Replaced, as the shared memories of captivity flood each other's minds, unbidden.

Replaced can never be Spellweavers or Fades: the Fae know better than to abduct one who could wield the powers of reality against them, and a Replaced's time as captive in the Dark Fae realm burns away any connection to the Weave that would allow them to become a Fade in the future.

Replaced get all the Traits of a Human, but they must also take the Hunted by the Queen Talent (they get this for free). This gives them the powers of Glamour but puts a supernatural bounty on their head. They also have exclusive access to the Thornmark Talent.

languages: The Language of their cultural region at 70, Low Vestrian 20

A Warning

While it may seem cool on the surface, playing a Replaced can be a grueling experience. You never get any true rest and are always on the run, can never make lasting connections with regular folk, and are a perpetual outsider in your own world. You're the victim of the ultimate identity theft, and even those who knew you in your previous life probably think you're crazy.

Playing a Replaced can create extra complications for the GM and the other players in trying to accommodate your situation. Think carefully before choosing this!

HUMAN RANGER
WANDERER
HASAIHAN, SATTAGOYA
LANGUAGE: KHANNISH

3) choose ability scores

Using Ability Scores to represent a character's physical, mental, and social capabilities is a time-honored tradition in many RPGs. In TBE, Ability Scores (Strength, Constitution, etc.) are not a defining feature of the system; instead, our characters are represented by their skills, Talents, and goals. However, for those of you who really like to use the Big Six to better envision your character, and as an honored nod to the Old Ways, we use Ability Scores as an early step to help start defining your character.

Ability Scores represent innate aptitude rather than learned experience. They define what your character was naturally good at before culture or circumstance shaped them. The +5 skill bonuses granted here will continue to accumulate with later improvements.

Choose (or roll 1d6 twice to randomly determine) two Ability Scores in which your character is exceptionally gifted. For each stat:

- Add +5 to each listed skill.
- Add 1 level of Expertise to one of the listed skills.
- Choose one of the three listed Talents.
- Select one of the descriptors listed (or come up with your own). These descriptors function like Personality Traits and can provide the same kind of bonuses (See Personality Traits in step 10).

Brian picks Intelligence and Charisma as Hadrion's Ability Scores, and increases the listed skills by +5 each. His current totals become: Locks & Traps 25, Protocol 35, Wit 25, Ancient Lore 25, Arcana 35, Commerce 25, Common Lore 25, Deceive 25, Inspire 25, Perform 25, Persuade 25, Seduce 25, and Streetwise 25. He takes Ex2 in Ancient Lore and Persuade, and the Talents of Inner Strength (which will increase his Max Resolve by 1), and Press the Point.

For Hadrion's descriptors, he chooses "Well-read" and "Affable".

1. Strength
   Skills: Melee: Medium; Melee: Heavy; Thrown; Athletics; Sail/Boat; Intimidate
   Talents: Powerful Blow (Combat); Sweeping Attack (Combat); Strong Back (Misc)
   Descriptors: Strong, Big, Brutish, Powerful, Muscled
2. Dexterity
   Skills: Dodge; Melee: Light; Missile; Ride; Sleight of Hand; Stealth
   Talents: Combat Awareness (Combat); Quick and Quiet (Adventuring); Quickdraw (Combat)
   Descriptors: Fast, Nimble, Quick, Dexterous, Agile
3. Constitution
   Skills: Might; Endurance; Survival; Track; Craft: Practical
   Talents: Enduring Watch (Adventuring); Not Today, Death (Misc); Mettle (Adventuring)
   Descriptors: Tough, Hardy, Enduring, Weathered, Rugged
4. Intelligence
   Skills: Locks & Traps; Protocol; Wit; Ancient Lore; Arcana; Commerce; Common Lore
   Talents: Tactician (Combat); Travel Planner (Lore); Inner Strength (Misc)
   Descriptors: Smart, Studied, Intelligent, Astute, Cunning
5. Wisdom
   Skills: Perception; Willpower; Insight; Craft: Artistic; Divinity; Heal; Naturewise
   Talents: Combat Awareness (Combat); Fearless (Adventuring); I See Your Mind (Social)
   Descriptors: Wise, Perceptive, Discerning, Prudent, Sage
6. Charisma
   Skills: Deceive; Inspire; Perform; Persuade; Seduce; Streetwise
   Talents: Feint (Combat); Press the Point (Social); Allow Me To Introduce... (Social)
   Descriptors: Charismatic, Magnetic, Alluring, Affable, Natural Leader

4) determine attributes

Characters have five Attributes : Max Resolve, Initiative, Toughness, Death Threshold, and Lethality Level. Together, they define how forcefully a character can impose their will upon the world before faltering, how quickly they can react when danger strikes, and how close they stand to death when wounded.

At character creation, allocate 5 Attribute points among the first four Attributes to set their starting values. (Lethality Level is a derived value from Death Threshold, and is not purchased with Attribute Points at character creation.) Each Attribute can be increased later during play by spending Experience Points (XP).

Max Resolve

Max Resolve is the total amount of Resolve points that represent your inner strength, conviction, and connection to the Weave. It is a crucial attribute for Spellweavers. Resolve is tracked on the character sheet using a row of boxes called the Resolve Track .

- A Every Player Character starts with 10 Max Resolve represented as the first 10 empty boxes on the Resolve Track from left to right.
- A Increase Max Resolve by 2 boxes per Attribute point spent.

Once your Max Resolve is set, draw a vertical line to the right of your Max Resolve box on the Resolve track. Any Resolve past this line is unavailable unless purchased with XP earned through play.

Initiative

Initiative is your potential to react quickly in a combat situation. At the start of each combat round, you roll a d10 and add your Initiative modifier to determine when you act in the initiative order. This modifier is reduced by wearing armor. Each roll can be increased by spending Resolve.

- A Starting Initiative modifier is +10.
- A Increase Initiative by 1 per Attribute point spent.

Option:Randomized Initiative

For those of you wanting to leave your character's raw combat speed up to the whims of the dice, start with an Initiative modifier of 6 + 1d6 instead of 10, then spend any Attribute points as normal.

Toughness

Toughness helps prevent you from falling in Shock, or succumbing to lethal wounds. It's a combination of stamina, grit, and raw stubbornness. Its value acts as a positive modifier to a Wound Die roll.

- A Starting Toughness is zero.
- A Increase Toughness by 1 per 2 Attribute points spent.

Death Threshold

Death Threshold (DT) is the maximum number of total lethal Wound Points you can suffer in all combined hit locations before you are killed.

- A Starting Death Threshold is 20.
- A Increase the Death Threshold by 2 per Attribute point spent.

Option: Randomized Death Threshold

If you want to give a bit more physical variation to your character, consider making their starting Death Threshold 15 + 2d4 instead of 20. This costs no Attribute points, but you may not spend additional Attribute Points to increase it further.

Lethality Level

Lethality Level (LL) determines the point at which you start dying when you've fallen in Shock.

- A character's Lethality Level is equal to 1/3 of their Death Threshold, rounded up.
- If they drop in Shock and their total lethal Wound Points exceed their Lethality Level, they are now Dying.
- You cannot spend Attribute points on LL, but it can be increased separately later through Talents, if desired.

If making a Spellweaver, you'll want to make sure that their Max Resolve is high. Toughness is vital for characters who expect to take a beating. A higher Death Threshold ensures a character can take many wounds before becoming victim to "death by a thousand cuts"; and Initiative is important for a character who wants to act before their enemies do.

Brian will assign two Attribute points to Hadrion's Max Resolve, making it 14. He adds the +1 from his Inner Strength Talent to make it 15. He will spend two Attribute points to make his Toughness +1. Finally, he spends his fifth Attribute point on his Initiative modifier, making it +11. His Death Threshold was unimproved, so it starts at 20, making his Lethality Level 7.

HUMAN GODBOUND
CIVILIZED, RURAL
MARKRONIA, OLD VESTRIA
LANGUAGE: LOW VESTRIAN

5) pick a cultural background

Every character grows up in a particular type of culture and learns skills common to that culture. Each culture grants the character skill bonuses, Expertise, and some starting silver pieces. Cultural backgrounds are open to interpretation--a barbarian culture in Drangia might mean a warrior tribe, whereas a barbarian culture in Angevarre could be a group of outlaws living in the hills.

Cultural bonuses stack on top of everything chosen so far. Keep in mind that you'll gain more bonuses later from Life Events, Previous Career, and Rounding Out.

If you see "Add 1 level of Expertise" to a selected skill, and that skill has no current Expertise, give it Ex2; otherwise, increase it one level, to either Ex3 or Ex4. You can buy multiple levels of Expertise in the same skill, if appropriate. For example, a character from a Civilized: Rural background starts with one level of Expertise (Ex2) in Naturewise. They could then choose to put their additional Lore Expertise in Naturewise again, increasing it one level to Ex3.

Pick one cultural background (or roll 1d10):

d10	Cultural Background
1-3	Civilized, Urban
4-6	Civilized, Rural
7-8	Barbarian
9-0	Wanderer

Civilized, Urban

You were raised in a town or city, among crowded streets and specialized trades. Life was shaped by craft, commerce, and laws, even if not all abided by them.

Add +20 to	1 Social skill Common Lore
Add +10 to	2 Combat skills Perception 4 additional Social skills Arcana or Divinity Commerce Craft: Practical or Craft: Artistic Heal Streetwise
Expertise	Add 1 level of Expertise to 1 Adventuring skill and 1 Lore skill
Starting Coin	1d6 × 10 sp

Civilized, Rural

You were raised on a farm, in a marcher lord's fief, in a crafter's household, or a similar setting within reach of a larger population center in a recognized political realm. Life was defined by steady labor and its ties to the wider order.

Add +20 to	Common Lore Craft: Practical
Add +10 to	2 Combat skills Athletics Endurance Perception Ride or Sail/Boat Survival 2 Social skills Arcana or Divinity Heal Naturewise
Expertise	Add 1 level of Expertise to Naturewise, and to either 1 Adventuring or 1 Lore skill
Starting Coin	1d4× 10 sp

Wanderer

You were raised without a homeland or tribal bonds. Your people lived by constant movement, carrying their culture with them but never settling long enough to claim any land as their own.

Add +20 to	Ride or Sail/Boat Naturewise
Add +10 to	2 Combat skills Athletics Endurance Perception Survival Track 1 Social skill Common Lore Craft: Practical Divinity Heal Take an additional Language at 40
Expertise	Add 1 level of Expertise to Common Lore, and to either 1 Adventuring or 1 Lore skill
Starting Coin	1d6× 5 sp

Barbarian

You were raised among tribes that lived beyond kingdoms and towns. They lived by herding, hunting, raiding, and trade, bound to land and kin rather than laws or borders.

Add +20 to	Common Lore Survival
Add +10 to	2 Combat skills Athletics Endurance Perception Ride or Sail/Boat Stealth Track 1 Social skill Divinity Heal Naturewise
Expertise	Add 1 level of Expertise to Survival, and to either 1 Adventuring or 1 Lore skill
Starting Coin	1d4× 5 sp

Brian decides that Hadrion comes from a Civilized, Urban culture. He adds 20 to his Common Lore, making it 45, and to the Social skill Protocol, making it 55.

After adding +10 to the other skills listed under Civilized, Urban, his new values are: Missile 30, Dodge 40, Perception 30, Deceive 35, Insight 30, Intimidate 30, Wit 35, Arcana 45, Commerce 35, Craft: Artistic 30, Heal 30, and Streetwise 35.

He takes Ex2 in Perception and Arcana, and rolls 30 sp.

6) roll for life events

Random events from a character's life help spur adventure ideas, inspire character goals, or even provide the seeds for an entire campaign. In TBE, Life Event tables help flesh out the PC's years before they embarked upon the path of adventure.

Roll once on the Life Event: Origin Table, once on the Life Event: Youth Table, and once on the Life Event: Recent Table.

Each event offers an option to add to an existing skill value. Pick one, and increase that skill by the listed amount immediately. It is possible to increase a skill multiple times this way by rolling on all three Life Event Tables.

If you gain a new Customs or Language skill, assume a starting value of 20 (or add 10 if you already have it). Some events offer you a Status or Strand increase instead (Strands are only applicable if you intend to be a Spellweaver or Fade).

On the Life Event: Origin Table, Hadrion rolls "Heretic's Offspring", and increases his Willpower to 40. He rolls the "Strange Flora" result on the Life Event: Youth Table, giving him a +2 in the Plants Strand, available once he assigns his Magic skills. Finally, he rolls on the Life Event: Recent Table, and gets "Fortune Dealer", allowing him to increase his Arcana to 55.

Shared History

After all players have rolled their Life Events, two players may agree that one character's Life Event provides an explanation for how their characters first knew each other, or why their paths crossed before the start of play. This is called a shared history. It is not a new Life Event of its own, but a way of reinterpreting an existing Life Event so that it also involves the other character.

Both characters choose a skill connected to the chosen Life Event and increase it by +5. The chosen skills do not need to be the same, but each must make narrative sense within the context of the shared history.

- A character can form up to two shared histories in this way.
- Each shared history must involve a different character.
- A character cannot raise the same skill twice through shared histories.
- If the +5 is applied to a Customs or Language skill that does not yet have a value, that skill begins at 20, then receives the +5 (for a total of 25).

Brian and a fellow player decide that due to Hadrion's "Heretic's Offspring" Life Event, their two characters grew up together and learned something about the true history of the gods: Hadrion adds +5 to his Divinity (making it 25), while the fellow player decides to add +5 to their character's Ancient Lore skill.

Relationship NPCs

For each of the three Life Events, a player has the option of gaining a Relationship NPC: either a Friend, a Patron, a Rival, or an Adversary. These are NPCs that can appear in your character's adventures to help or hinder you, and act as excellent opportunities for the GM to use the character's history as active elements of the ongoing campaign. Roll 1d4:

1	Friend
2	Patron
3	Rival
4	Adversary

Some Life Events might suggest NPCs appropriate to that Life Event. In that case, simply pick one of the above rather than rolling.

The player and GM should create the NPC based on the details of the Life Event, and the na-

ture of the relationship should arise logically from it. The NPC's details can be derived from the NPC Trait Subtable in Chapter 18 - Bestiary and the Name Tables in the Appendix.

- A Friend is someone who may not always be available to you, but generally has your best interests at heart and will go out of their way to help you in most cases. The depth of the friendship will be based on the context of the Life Event that birthed it.
- A Patron is someone of higher standing or influence who has taken an interest in you. They may provide information, opportunities, employment, resources, or protection, but it often comes with expectations of loyalty, service, or repayment, and they will not risk their position or fortune for you without good reason.
- A Rival is someone who was, or is, in competition with you in a certain field. They are not exactly your enemy, but they will take advantage of an opportunity to supplant you if they can. They may even be friendly towards you--but their intentions are always to get an advantage over you, or to otherwise hinder you.
- An Adversary is someone who is out to get you. There could be many reasons for them to wish you harm, but they feel that you wronged them in some way and are seeking revenge or justice. The nature and intensity of the enmity will be dependent on the content of the relationship, but make no mistake: they are your enemy.

Brian takes a Relationship NPC based on Hadrion's "Strange Flora" Life Event. He rolls a d4 and gets a 3, a Rival. Brian and the GM create an NPC called Vesuvian, a fellow Spellweaver student of alchemy who was always in competition with Hadrion, and who, to this day, seeks to prove his superior knowledge and magical skill by discrediting anything Hadrian achieves or pursues.

These relationships can change over time. It is possible that if a player handles things in a smart and creative way, an Adversary or Patron could become a Rival--or even a Friend. Conversely, a Friend whose goodwill is abused or neglected may evolve into a Rival or Adversary. The GM will decide based on the player's choices and on the logical outcomes of their actions.

With parties of 3 or more PCs, it's a good idea to limit the number of Relationship NPCs to one per PC. Otherwise, it can become overwhelming for GMs to try and keep track of and meaningfully incorporate all of these NPCs in upcoming adventures.

Personalizing the Details

It's always up to the player's creativity (working closely with the GM) to tie Life Events into their own history and culture. If you come from a Barbarian background, but an Origin event indicates you grew up in a castle, feel free to change it to a chieftain's yurt or something appropriate. If you're non-human, adjust the details of the Life Event to something appropriate to your race.

The Life Event descriptions aren't holy writ. Twist them, dissect them, rework them; use some, most, all, or none of their details. The entries are provided as an inspirational launching point to breathe some life into your PC's history, and the questions asked in each Life Event are designed to get you thinking about how it might provide fodder for a future character goal.

Option

To help shape the details of your Life Events, roll on the two Event Randomizers Tables (see Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying in the Broken Empires) and apply your interpretation of those two words to the Life Event you've rolled. There is no wrong answer here; just go with your first instinct on how those random words could shape and personalize the details of the Life Event. If nothing comes to you, either re-roll the two words or carry on with the Life Event as written.

Life Event: Origin

d100	Life Event
01-02	Child of Revolt. You were the child of a noble family against whom the common folk revolted. How did you escape the ensuing violence? What did this teach you about the politics of your people? Add +10 to Protocol or Common Lore
03-04	Legacy of Invention. Your family were inventors. What was the nature of their work? How did their creations get them into trouble? And what unfinished task did your dying parent beg you to complete? Add +10 to Craft: Practical or Commerce
05-06	Tower of Secrets. Your father was made petty nobility and granted a small keep. Why did your father never speak of why he was made a noble? What was the thing he was hiding in the highest tower of the keep? And why did the other lords always avoid your family at court? Add +10 to Perception, or gain Noble-wise, or take +1 Status.
07-08	Faithful Companion. You come from a line of animal breeders or handlers (horses, hunting dogs, etc.). To whom did your family sell your most beloved four-legged friend? Did you let it go, or did you do something to get it back? Add +10 to Ride or Track.
09-10	Servant to Nobility. You grew up as a servant to a noble house. How did you befriend one of their children? Why were you released from service? What favor did your noble friend promise to do for you if ever you returned? Add +10 to Inspire or Protocol.
11-12	Outside the Law. You were raised in a bandit camp, where you were forced to prove your worth on a daily basis. What physical feat demonstrated your value? And the one you humiliated in front of the leader--where are they now? Add +10 to Athletics or Intimidate.
13-14	Smuggler's Start. Your family were smugglers. What kind of contraband did they move? What stolen valuable finally got them caught? And why is the person to whom it belonged still hunting you? Add +10 to Sleight of Hand or Stealth.
15-16	Tied to the Streets. You spent years as an orphan on the streets of a large city. What individual, organization, or group took you in and trained you? What secret were they hiding? And how has that secret returned to plague you? Add +10 to Streetwise or Deceive.
17-18	Marked by the Weave. You were born with a strange mark somewhere on your body. What magical rune does the mark resemble? Who revealed to you its possible significance? And how does it change under certain astrological conditions? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to a Bind skill of your choice; if not, add +10 to Arcana or Divinity.
19-20	River Rat. Your family scratched out a living plying the riverways of the Broken Empires, selling whatever goods they could manage to trade. Why was your family wanted by the authorities? Where did one of your parents stash the "most valuable prize in the world"? And why were you the only one she trusted with the map to its location? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Persuade.
21-22	Fated From Birth. Your family line is cursed: upon reaching age 30, the firstborn child starts to sleep longer and longer, until one day they simply don't wake up. You are the firstborn. How long until you turn 30? What have you learned about the possible origins of this curse? And who taught you how to stave off the coming dreamless sleep? Add +10 to Ancient Lore or Willpower.
23-24	Far Trader. Your family was part of a wealthy caravan or trading fleet. As a child, you traveled far from your homeland. What wonder from a foreign land still lingers in your memory? What trinket or skill did you bring back with you? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Commerce.
25-26	Raised by a Sect. You were given to a secluded religious order to be raised in faith and discipline. What sacred artifact or practice were you entrusted to guard? Were you cast out, or did you leave of your own free will? Add +10 to Divinity or Ancient Lore
27-28	Cursed Inheritance. An ancestor passed down a priceless heirloom--ancient weapon, amulet, or tapestry--with a troubling history. What is said to happen to those who own it? Who tried to steal it from you as a child, and what did you do? Why do you still carry it, despite the rumors? Add +10 to Willpower or Arcana; or take +1 Status.
29-30	Imprisoned. Due to ill fortune or parental negligence, you spent your early years in captivity. Why were you imprisoned? Where were you held, and for how long? What friend or enemy did you make there, and where are they now? Add +10 to Locks & Traps or Intimidate.
31-32	Bastard of High Blood. You are the illegitimate child of a noble or influential figure. How did you discover the truth of your parentage? Who raised you in secret, and what did they teach you? Which sibling or rival hates you most for existing? Add +10 to Protocol, or gain Noble-wise, or take +1 Status.

Life Event: Origin

d100	Life Event
33-34	Raised in the Wild. You grew up on the edge of civilization, either in the wilderness or among nomads. What animal or spirit do you believe watches over you? What hidden glade, ruin, or cave did you discover as a child? How did you prove yourself to your wild kin or guardians? Add +10 to Naturewise or Survival.
35-36	Witness. When you were young, you saw a man in the town square claiming the gods didn't exist. As he spoke against Devona the Sea-Bitch, he suddenly drowned before your very eyes. What did this teach you about the world and your place in it? Why did no one in town speak of that event ever again? And who were the shadowy figures who came for his corpse in the night? Add +10 to Divinity or Insight.
37-38	Orphan of War. You were lost or abandoned during a military conflict. Who trained you to survive, and what--besides your family--did you lose in the chaos? Add +10 to Endurance or Heal.
39-40	Apprentice of the Esoteric. You were raised by a reclusive alchemist, court magician, or inventor. What odd habit or quirk of theirs did you pick up? What dangerous experiment or forbidden knowledge did you glimpse while working with them? What is the current state of your relationship? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to a Bind skill of your choice; if not, add +10 to Arcana or Craft: Practical.
41-42	Far Traveler. Your family was forced to flee their homeland due to war, famine, or other disaster. How far did you travel? What memory of that journey lingers in your mind? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Survival.
43-44	Heretic's Offspring. Your mother believed she was the chosen of a god, but the church considered her a heretic. What finally happened to her? What made you doubt her story? And what did it look like when the god finally spoke to you in a dream? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety; otherwise, add +10 to Divinity or Willpower.
45-46	Shipwrecked. You were the sole survivor of a shipwreck that claimed your family. Upon what strange isle or hidden cove did you wash ashore? What token of that place do you carry with you still? Add +10 to Survival or Sail/Boat.
47-48	Apprenticed. An artisan took you in as an apprentice. What was so odd about them? With what aspect of the trade did you assist? Why did you leave before your training was complete? Add +10 to Craft: Practical or Craft: Artistic.
49-50	Haunted Home. Your family residence was plagued by unexplained phenomena--whispers, apparitions, or moving objects. What did you see during your childhood that no one else would believe? What aspect of that experience haunts you, even now? Add +10 to Insight or Perception.
51-52	Diplomatic Upbringing. Your family served as envoys or mediators between warring factions. What treaty or alliance fell apart back then because of betrayal or sabotage? What document or map remains with you from that time? Add +10 to Protocol or Insight.
53-54	Child of the Sands. Your father made a bargain with a desert Djinn to save your life from the illness you were suffering. You survived, but your father disappeared. What clues have you found of his fate? What were the permanent side effects of your illness? And what words did the Djinn whisper to you on the wind as you made your recovery? Add +10 to Survival, or gain Desert-wise.
55-56	Raised by a Sage. You were brought up by someone who sought to decipher the world's secrets. Were they your birth parent or adoptive parent? What unfortunate truth did you learn from them by accident? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to a Bind skill of your choice; otherwise, add +10 to Common Lore or Ancient Lore.
57-58	Tavern Kid. Your family ran a popular tavern. What sort of clientele did the place serve? What did you learn about the world from trying to manage drunken brawls and rowdy guests? Add +10 to Persuade or Wit.
59-60	Beast-Marked. As a child, you survived a dangerous encounter with a wild animal or monster. What scar or injury remains from the attack? Why do you believe the creature left you alive? Add +10 to Dodge or Naturewise.
61-62	Crowd Pleaser. You were taught to work the crowd at markets, festivals, and fairs. Were you the pupil of a lone expert, or a young member of a storied company? What forced you to leave that life behind? Add +10 to Perform or Sleight of Hand
63-64	Rising Star. At a young age, you were lauded as a prodigy in a specific field. Who tried to exploit or sabotage your talent? What caused your rise to fame to falter? Add +10 to any Combat skill, Craft: Practical, or Craft: Artistic.
65-66	Revenge Sworn. Someone wronged your parents, leaving your family destitute or disgraced. Who do you blame? How have you sought revenge or justice? What token of that vendetta do you still carry? Add +10 to Track or Perception

Life Event: Origin

d100	Life Event
67-68	Secret Heritage. One or both of your parents were of noble birth, but hid it from everyone. Why did they turn their backs on their old life? How did you discover their secret? And what did they threaten you with if you ever told anyone? Add +10 to Protocol, or gain Noble-wise, or take +1 Status.
69-70	Secret Sanctuary. As a child, you sought refuge in an ancient ruin, hidden cave, or other private hideaway. What was so special about that place? What memory or token of its existence continues to haunt or inspire you? Add +10 to Stealth or Naturewise.
71-72	Little Thief. You were caught stealing as a child, either out of necessity or mischief. What did you try to steal? Who caught you, and how did they punish or forgive you? Add +10 to Sleight of Hand or Stealth.
73-74	Found Family. You were raised by a band of outcasts, on the city streets or in the wilds. How did you come into their company? What did they teach you about the rules of society? Why did you eventually leave them behind? Add +10 to Streetwise or Naturewise.
75-76	Scion of Glory. One of your parents was a celebrated hero, famed for a great deed or tragic sacrifice. What did they do? What burden or expectations has their legacy placed on you? Add +10 to Inspire or Athletics; or take +1 Status.
77-78	Blightmarked. Your family were outcasts, due to having unintentionally spread a terrible contagion among your people. What was the nature of that disease? Why did your sibling always believe your family was unjustly blamed? And why have you always been immune to the effects of the sickness? Add +10 to Heal or Insight.
79-80	Soldier's Child. One or both of your parents were enlisted in an armed force of some kind. In what battle or war did they distinguish or shame themselves? What crippling or fatal injury did they suffer? Add +10 to any Combat skill or Ride.
81-82	Last Words. The oldest surviving member of your family swore to reveal to you the incredible secret of your family, once you come of age. What happened to them before they could share the knowledge? Where was the shallow grave in which they were hastily buried? And what was the eerie rhyme in the song that served as your relative's last words to you? Add +10 to Perform or Ancient Lore
83-84	Merchant's Life. Your family were traveling peddlers or traders. What sorts of things did they buy and sell? What prized item of those days do you still carry with you? Add +10 to Persuade or Commerce
85-86	Village Protector. You helped defend your community from a minor threat in your youth. How did the villagers reward you, and who still sees you as a hero? Add +10 to Missile or Insight; or take +1 Status.
87-88	Fateful Rescue. You saved a noble or other refined personage from certain injury or death. What reward, resentment, or burden did this act produce? Do you regret it? Add +10 to Athletics or Protocol; or take +1 Status.
89-90	Wild Child. You were raised in the wilderness by your stern and secretive aunt. What did she tell you happened to your parents? What kind of wilderness was it? And what did you see when you secretly followed your aunt out into a storm one night? Add +10 to Survival or Perception
91-92	Student. At a young age, you began your studies under a scholar or sage. What did your teacher appreciate or dislike about you? Did your family value the acquisition of knowledge? How did it eventually prove useful? Add +10 to Ancient Lore or Common Lore
93-94	Child of Privilege. You were the child of the ruling class among your people. Unfortunately the leader of your faction became corrupt, and the common people revolted. How did you, a child, escape the violence that ensued? How did the leader get mysteriously reinstated? And what did this teach you about the politics of your people? Add +10 to Protocol or Common Lore
95-96	Storykeeper. You were raised by a group of traveling minstrels, storytellers, or other performers. Were they your blood relatives, or found family? For what tale or song were they most renowned? Add +10 to Perform or Wit.
97-98	Home of Ill Repute. You older sibling raised you in the red light district of a large city. To make ends meet, they plied their trade sometimes as an artist, sometimes as a courtesan. What was the one talent your sibling insisted would one day allow you to escape this life? What token did they give you and implore you to never, ever lose? And what bone-chilling thing did you hear the night your sibling was "entertaining" a strange visitor from a foreign land? Add +10 to Craft: Artistic or Seduce
99-00	Oathsworn. A parent or ancestor made a vital promise, the burden of which has been passed on to you. What was the nature of the oath they swore? Has it been broken already--saddling you with stigma--or does it remain intact? Add +10 to Willpower or Inspire.

chapter 7: character creation

Life Event: Youth

d100	Life Event
01-02	Miraculous Recovery. You died and somehow came back to life. How did you die? Was it mundane? Who or what was responsible for bringing you back? What was the cost of your being brought back? Add +10 to Arcana or Heal.
03-04	Itinerant Actor. You performed in a wandering theatrical troupe. What secrets of theirs did you discover? Why were you forced to flee? Did you leave anything behind? Add +10 to Perform or Streetwise.
05-06	Dogsbody. You served onboard a vessel of one of the Free Lords of the Serpent's Teeth Isles. The captain trusted you with the location of a valuable secret. Why you? And why did the crew blame you for his death? Add +10 to Sail/Boat, or gain Navigation-wise.
07-08	Nightmare Fuel. Your village was overrun by a terrible undead creature. Why did it leave you alive? Why did it abduct certain members of the village to its hidden lair? And why have you been recently plagued with vivid nightmares about it? Add +10 to Arcana, or gain Undead-wise.
09-10	Unexpected Stand-In. You spent some years in service to a troupe of far-wandering minstrels. You were never allowed on stage, until one night a mistake was made. How did you wind up performing for an influential lord and his retinue? Who was the minstrel whose place you took? And why did they curse your name and vow revenge? Add +10 to Perform or Wit.
11-12	Ever a Squire. You squired to a knight in wartime. Why didn't he make you a knight? What item of his do you still possess? And what forbidden treasure did you see him hiding? Add +10 to one Combat skill or Ride.
13-14	Tough Character. In the community where you spent your youth, you became known for your physical presence. Did you use that advantage for good or ill? Who was your greatest rival, and what happened to them? Add +10 to Athletics or Intimidate.
15-16	Grifter. You learned early on how to identify and take advantage of the ignorant and gullible. What was your main means of extracting wealth? Whom do you most regret ripping off? Did they ever find out the truth? Add +10 to Sleight of Hand or Insight.
17-18	Hunted. You discovered a beloved sibling or friend was part of a secret society. When you confronted them, they grew angry with you, and you left. The society has been after you ever since, believing you to be a threat. What of theirs do you carry with you? Why did you leave your sibling/friend behind, and do they still belong to that group? Add +10 to Stealth or Persuade.
19-20	Shady Trade. For some time you dealt in contraband, and had to learn quickly how to evade the authorities. What illicit product did you buy and sell? Why did you leave that line of work behind, or are you still in it? Who is the useful ally or dangerous rival you made along the way? Add +10 to Streetwise or Commerce.
21-22	Artist. You were an artist with a wealthy patron. What type of art did you produce? Why were you forced to leave it all behind? And why did this make an enemy out of your patron? Add +10 to Craft: Artistic or Protocol.
23-24	Sanguine Secret. You apprenticed with a well-known armorer. Who was the mysterious figure that paid him to secretly infuse custom armor with something that looked a lot like blood? How did you wind up with a single piece of that armor? And how has the armor's owner been constantly tracking you? Add +10 to Craft: Practical or Insight.
25-26	Gaoler. For a while you worked as a guard in a prison or dungeon. What was the worst part of the job? Who was the worst person you had to deal with while you were there? And why do you still think about them, even now? Add +10 to Locks & Traps or Intimidate.
27-28	River Run. One day the lights went out--all of them. Who did you help escape? How did you convince them to join with you in using the river as a means of escape? Why did no one believe your warnings of impending disaster? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Persuade.
29-30	By Wits Alone. Somehow you ended up as a jester, clown, or adviser to someone of means. Who were they, and how did they treat you? What forced you to eventually abandon that job? Add +10 to Perform or Wit.
31-32	Terrible Vision. You were given a vision from what you believed to be the gods. Why did it terrify you? What divine truth did it reveal? And in what undiscovered location did it tell you to seek that truth? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety. Otherwise, add +10 to Divinity or Inspire.
33-34	Weavebound. You studied the ways of the Weave from a young age. Who was your teacher? Under what circumstances did they disappear? And who are the people seeking the ancient artifact your teacher left you? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to a Strand of your choice; otherwise, add +10 to Arcana or Ancient Lore.

Life Event: Youth

d100	Life Event
35-36	Rebel Arisen. A revolt or uprising swept through your community, leaving it broken or embattled. Who did you lose in the chaos? Who stayed with you through thick and thin? And who planted in you the bitter seed of revenge? Add +10 to Endurance or Stealth.
37-38	Young Recruit. You were conscripted at a young age into a local militia. What lord or cause did your company serve? What fellow conscript or officer became a friend or enemy for life? And what event brought your company's service to an end? Add +10 to any Combat skill or Ride.
39-40	Champion. You competed in a contest at a provincial fair or noble court--and won. What feat did you accomplish, and how did it color your reputation for years afterward? What was the prize? Does your closest competitor still hold a grudge, or have you become fast friends? Add +10 to Athletics or Wit; or take +1 Status.
41-42	Labyrinth-Lost. You became lost for weeks in a tangled forest, ancient ruin, or endless catacomb. What wisdom or trauma do you carry with you as a result? What did you encounter there that fosters your wish to one day return? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to Strand: Earth; if not, add +10 to Willpower or Ancient Lore
43-44	Healer's Apprentice. You assisted a healer of renown during a great number of years, your greatest trial manifesting in the outbreak of a deadly disease that decimated the community. How many were lost, and how did their deaths affect you? What important figure was saved by your ministrations? And what happened to your master? Add +10 to Inspire or Heal.
45-46	Thrilling Pursuit. For several years, you hunted for living, at one point joining in the pursuit of a prized quarry--a swift stag, dangerous predator, or legendary beast. The chase tested both your marksmanship and your ability to traverse treacherous terrain. Did you take the killing shot, or did someone else claim the glory? What trophy or lesson did you take from the experience? Add +10 to Missile or Survival.
47-48	Saboteur's Sidekick. You were taken under the wing of a skilled saboteur who taught you to spot weak points and create or disable traps. For whom did your master work? What dangerous operation did you assist with that tested your skills and nerves? What key insight or clever trick saved you from disaster? Add +10 to Locks & Traps or Perception.
49-50	Harsh Migration. Your family or community was forced to flee through harsh wilderness due to war, famine, or disaster. You played a key role in tracking safe paths, foraging for food, and avoiding dangers. What toll did the journey take on you? Who do you remember most from those desperate days? Where did your people finally find refuge? Add +10 to Survival or Track.
51-52	Forbidden Lesson. You studied the ways of the Weave under the tutelage of a reclusive mentor. One day, you were left alone to observe a summoned entity. The strain tested your mental fortitude as the being attempted to break free. What was the nature of the entity? Did you succeed in holding it at bay, or did it escape? What mark did the encounter leave on you? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to Bind: Control; if not, add +10 to Willpower or Arcana.
53-54	Dealmaker. You became known in your community for negotiating agreements and resolving disputes in the local marketplace. Your ability to recall useful facts about merchants, their wares, and their customs gave you an edge. What was the largest deal you brokered, and who still owes you a debt--or holds a grudge? Add +10 to Common Lore or Commerce; or take +1 Status.
55-56	Courtly Spy. You were taken in as a servant or page in a noble house, but your true role was to gather information for a rival faction. Using your understanding of etiquette, you blended in seamlessly while uncovering secrets. What critical piece of information did you uncover? Did you get away clean, or were you exposed as a traitor? Add +10 to Deceive or Protocol.
57-58	Honey-Trap Hustler. Among the shadier activities of your youth, you engaged in cons designed to exploit greed, vanity, and desire. What was your most successful--or disastrous--scheme? Who has never forgiven you for it? Add +10 to Streetwise or Seduce
59-60	Amorous Adventure. During a period of artistic exploration, you created a song, poem, or other work of art that enchanted your audience, and one admirer in particular. What was the nature of your creation? How did it spark the romance that still burns--or haunts you--to this day? Add +10 to Seduce or Craft: Artistic.
61-62	Sacred Grove. You were tasked with tending a grove or forest shrine dedicated to a deity. What omens or divine signs did you witness there, and how did they influence your faith? What taboo did you accidentally break, and how did you make amends? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety; otherwise, add +10 to Naturewise or Divinity.
63-64	Tricky Tinker. At some point you became adept at crafting small mechanical devices or tools. What was the most ingenious (or underhanded) thing you invented? Who has been seeking you out to replicate it, and to what end? Add +10 to Sleight of Hand or Craft: Practical.
65-66	Land of Legend. You grew up near a forest or wildland that figured prominently in local folklore. What story or belief about the land's history shaped your understanding of it? How did your knowledge of old stories and natural signs help you uncover a hidden truth about the place? Add +10 to Ancient Lore or Naturewise.

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Life Event: Youth

d100	Life Event
67-68	Rite of Passage. In your community or culture, everyone had to complete a rite of passage. What was the nature of yours? How did you prove yourself, and at what cost? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to a Strand of your choice; otherwise, add +10 to Athletics or Insight.
69-70	Trial of Strength. Your community held a ceremonial ritual that required participants to survive a series of punishing physical or combat-related challenges. Did you succeed by dint of raw endurance or a skill with a particular weapon? What did completing--or failing--the trial teach you? What scar or ceremonial tattoo marks you as a result? Add +10 to Melee (Light, Medium, or Heavy) or Endurance.
71-72	Eagle Eye. You earned respect in your community for spotting distant threats or game before anyone else could. Your sharp eyes and steady aim became invaluable. What challenge tested both your perception and marksmanship? How did your success or failure alter your reputation in the eyes of your people? Add +10 to Missile or Perception.
73-74	Narrow Escape. You were either involved in a risky theft, or just in the wrong place at the wrong time. Your ability to evade guards and disappear into the environment was the only thing that saved you. What was the object of the theft? If it was successfully stolen, who has it now? Who else was involved, and what happened to them? Add +10 to Dodge or Stealth.
75-76	Range Rider. You spent time roaming the wide open country, as a loner, hunter, or warden. At one point you had to track down an outlaw, fugitive, or missing person. Who was it? What happened when you found them? And how did the experience test your bond with your mount? Add +10 to Ride or Track.
77-78	Vigilant Ally. Stranded in a remote landscape, you had to keep yourself and a gravely injured companion alive. Gathering scarce resources while tending to their wounds pushed you to your limits. Who were they? Did they survive? And what did you lose in the process? Add +10 to Survival or Heal.
79-80	Spiritual Path. You joined a group of religious pilgrims on a sacred journey. Along the way, your words or hymns uplifted the weary travelers, bolstering their faith. What was the destination of the pilgrimage? What hardship did the group overcome? How did your voice or prayers play a pivotal role? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety; otherwise, add +10 to Divinity or Inspire.
81-82	Duel of Words. You were drawn into a heated argument or debate with someone far more powerful than you--perhaps a noble, scholar, or elder. Using sharp wit and sheer determination, you held your ground and earned their respect (or wrath). What was the subject of the debate? How did the confrontation end? What ally or enemy did you make as a result? Add +10 to Willpower or Wit.
83-84	Master's Plan. You apprenticed under a renowned artisan who specialized in tools or mechanical devices. One day, they left you in charge of finishing a critical project. Did you complete it flawlessly or add your own modifications? How did your master react to your completed work? Add +10 to Locks & Traps or Craft: Practical; or take +1 Status.
85-86	Merchant Mariner. You worked as a crew member aboard a trading vessel, learning the ropes of both sailing and negotiation. What critical deal or trade did you help secure? How did your quick thinking save--or risk--the valuable cargo? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Commerce.
87-88	Magician. For some time, you earned a living as an entertainer, dazzling onlookers with illusions and mundane trickery. Or was it? What feat was the crowd-pleaser? How did it go wrong that one time, and what were the consequences? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to Bind: Change; otherwise, add +10 to Sleight of Hand or Perform.
89-90	Counterfeiter. You were commissioned--or coerced--into creating a forgery of a valuable artwork, document, or currency. Your skill as an artist and talent for deception allowed you to pass it off as the real thing. Who discovered the ruse? What consequences have followed you since? Add +10 to Deceive or Craft: Artistic.
91-92	Enforcer. For a while you worked for a gang or criminal organization, using your knowledge of the streets and your menacing demeanor to collect debts or settle disputes. What line did you cross--or refuse to cross--while carrying out your duties? How did that decision change your life? Add +10 to Streetwise or Intimidate.
93-94	Firebrand. You rallied your community during a time of crisis, drawing on local traditions and historical examples to inspire unity. What was the threat faced by your people? How did your words of encouragement turn the tide? And who still looks up to you because of it? Add +10 to Inspire or Common Lore.
95-96	Courtly Affair. You became involved in a romantic entanglement at court, navigating the delicate roles of decorum while advancing your ambitions. Who was your partner in this intrigue? How did the affair bolster or harm your standing? Add +10 to Protocol or Seduce.
97-98	Strange Flora. You experimented with an unusual plant thought to have mystical properties. While its use saved a life or cured a disease, it also carried unforeseen consequences. What did you learn about the plant's hidden nature? What lasting impact has it had on your life? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to Strand : Plants; otherwise, add +10 to Heal or Nature wise.
99-00	Glimpse Beyond. During a moment of meditation or turmoil, you connected to something greater--a fleeting vision, cryptic message, or profound realization. What did it show you about the past, present, or future? How has your interpretation of the signs altered the course of your life? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to Bind: Witness; otherwise, add +10 to Perception or Insight.

Life Event: Recent

d100	Life Event
01-02	Desperate Rescue. You saved a mysterious woman's life from bandits in the woods, beating them in a moment of desperation with your bare hands. What were the bandits trying to get from her? What did she reward you with? Why did you choose to leave it behind? Add +10 to Perceptionor Might.
03-04	Bitter Victory. You talked your way into a lord's archery contest to impress his young heir, and won. What was the prize? Why did they accuse you of cheating? Where did you escape to with the lord's heir, and what happened to them? Add +10 to Seduceor Missile.
05-06	Arena Contender. You participated in a brutal public contest--perhaps a gladiatorial bout, a test of strength, or an endurance challenge. Your physical prowess and intimidating presence cowed your opponents. What was the prize? What scar now marks your body as a result? And who still holds a grudge against you? Add +10 to Athletics or Intimidate; or take +1 Status.
07-08	Gambler's Touch. You caught someone cheating at a game of chance, or used your own tricks to outplay them. Your sharp observation and quick fingers turned the game to your advantage. What was at stake? Who took notice of your skills? And what opportunity or threat did they then present? Add +10 to Sleight of Handor Insight.
09-10	Back From the Dead. You saw your best friend die. Then last year in a crowded town square, you saw him again. His eyes met yours--and he fled. How did he "die"? What did you see him carrying as he ran away? To where were you able to track him to before you lost his trail? Add +10 to Trackor Heal.
11-12	Survivor. You were trapped in a mountain crevasse for days. Only by stumbling across a grappling hook and rope did you manage to escape. What happened to the rest of your expedition? What else did you take from the bottom of the crevasse? And what strange symbol did you discover down there? Add +10 to Thrown Weaponsor Survival.
13-14	Revenue Run-In. You worked as a tax collector--or evader--which brought with it the need to avoid physical confrontations with angry debtors or enforcers. What clever deal or bribe helped you escape a particularly heated moment? Who's after you now, for your enforcement or defiance of the law? Add +10 to Dodgeor Commerce.
15-16	Jailbreak. You orchestrated--or were forced to participate in--a daring escape from a guarded facility. The success of this undertaking relied upon your threatening demeanor or ability to disable security measures. Who escaped with you? Who did you have to leave behind? What do you need to do now, to stay one step ahead of the authorities? Add +10 to Locks & Trapsor Intimidate.
17-18	Healer's Friend. During a military campaign you befriended a skilled healer. What rare disease did they teach you to recognize? Which influential figure did you use this treatment on, securing their favor? What medical experiment is the healer still working on? Add +10 to Heal or Protocol.
19-20	Pirate's Gambit. You were captured by a notorious crew of cutthroats and talked your way into a position aboard their ship. What bold claim or skill convinced them to spare you? How did you quickly earn--or lose--their trust? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Persuade.
21-22	Forced Labor. You were conscripted into a work crew for the ambitious construction project of a powerful figure. The experience nearly broke you, but you bonded with your workmates and were able to eventually find freedom. What were you building? How did you and your comrades finally get out from under the yoke? And who among them travels with you now? Add +10 to Endurance, or gain Architecture-wise.
23-24	Broken Promise. You broke your oath. To whom or what was that oath? What did the oath require of you? And what forced you to break it when you didn't want to? Add +10 to Willpoweror Deceive.
25-26	Cavalry Charge. You joined a mounted skirmish or battle, riding at the forefront of a daring charge. Your skill with weapon or steed turned the tide. What unexpected obstacle forced you to adapt mid-combat? Who was your most formidable opponent? What happened to your mount? Add +10 to Melee(Light, Medium, or Heavy) or Ride.
27-28	Whisper Campaign. You secretly spread messages of hope or rebellion within a heavily guarded area, rallying others to the cause without being detected. Who betrayed--or protected--you during the effort? What insurgent action did your efforts spark? Who suffered, and who emerged as a villain or savior? Add +10 to Stealth or Inspire.
29-30	Evangelist. You helped to spread the teachings of your faith as part of a pilgrimage or religious mission. What song, dance, or tale recently captured the hearts of your audience? Who opposes your message, and why? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety; otherwise, add +10 to Performor Divinity.
31-32	Clever Ingenuity. During a recent siege, you drew upon historical techniques to construct or repair a critical piece of equipment--a battering ram, catapult, barricade, or the like. What flaw in the design almost jeopardized the effort? How did your quick thinking save the day? How did the siege finally come to an end, and what did it cost you? Add +10 to Craft: Practical or Common Lore

Life Event: Recent

d100	Life Event
33-34	Artist of the Wild. You created a striking memorial, shrine, or work of art using materials gathered from the wilderness, blending natural elements into your design. What inspired this creation? Who now seeks to claim or destroy it? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to Strand : Earth; otherwise, add +10 to Craft: Artistic or Naturewise.
35-36	Wayward Familiar. You tracked down a rogue magical entity running loose in the city, using every resource at your disposal to subdue it. Who hired you for this task? How were you rewarded for your success? And what did you lose in the process? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to Bind: Control; otherwise, add +10 to Streetwise or Persuade.
37-38	Storm-Runner. While investigating a legend about a flying beast or airborne vessel, you found yourself caught in a dangerous chase under stormy skies. You surely would have perished, were it not for your physical agility and knowledge of the weather. What became of your quarry? And what tantalizing truth did your encounter reveal? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to Strand : Air; otherwise, add +10 to Dodge or Survival.
39-40	Stalwart Defender. In a fight against overwhelming odds, you held your ground while others faltered. Your determination and skill inspired those around you to rally. Who or what were you fighting, and why? With what scar--physical or emotional--did the battle leave you? Add +10 to Melee (Light, Medium, or Heavy) or Willpower.
41-42	Stalker. You spent days tracking an elusive target through harsh terrain, waiting for the perfect moment to strike. Who or what were you tracking? What tested your patience during the pursuit? And what unexpected complication arose after you took the shot? Add +10 to Missile or Track.
43-44	Ancient Mystery. While exploring a ruin or enigmatic site, you discovered lines of weathered glyphs etched in stone. A consultation with a local loremaster revealed their meaning, unlocking a piece of forgotten history--or a dangerous secret. What does the ancient writing suggest or foretell? What other party has taken an interest in your find? Add +10 to Perception or Ancient Lore
45-46	Informant. Through personal connections or clever conversation, you obtained a valuable piece of intel regarding the local criminal underworld. What's the nature of this information? To whom is it most valuable? And who wants you to keep quiet? Add +10 to Streetwise or Wit.
47-48	Infiltrator. You slipped into a guarded event or restricted area under the guise of someone else. You went largely unnoticed--until someone started asking questions. Whom did you impersonate? What did you uncover? And how did you escape? Add +10 to Stealth or Deceive.
49-50	Fortune Dealer. In a bustling marketplace, you set up a stand offering astrological readings to attract wealthy patrons. One influential client took your augury to heart, for good or ill. Who was it? What did you tell them about their future? And in what way have they decided to reward you--or make you pay for your insolence? Add +10 to Arcana or Commerce.
51-52	Challenging Climb. You scaled a treacherous ridge in search of a mountain pass, rare flora, or reclusive hermit. Your physical strength and understanding of the wilderness were tested by the journey. What did you find at the summit? What challenge did you face on the way down? Add +10 to Athletics or Naturewise.
53-54	Sacred Vigil. You participated in a ritual that required you to stay awake and focused for days in prayer or meditation. What vision came to you at the height of your altered state? How has it shaped your beliefs? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety; otherwise, add +10 to Endurance or Divinity.
55-56	Lover's Lock. You charmed, distracted, or gained the trust of someone in the possession of a valuable item, long enough to lay your hands on it without their notice. What was the item? How did you get away? And what strong emotion do you still feel for the person you deceived? Add +10 to Locks & Traps or Seduce.
57-58	Memorial Tribute. You chose or were commissioned to craft a tribute to a fallen hero or other important figure. During its presentation, the crowd was deeply moved by your words or the beauty of the work itself. Who was the fallen figure, and what was your personal relationship to them? What controversial rumor arose around that relationship or the tribute itself? Add +10 to Inspire or Craft: Artistic.
59-60	Battered Vessel. You were part of a desperate repair effort to keep a storm-damaged ship afloat. Your practical skills and knowledge played a key role in the outcome. What crew or cargo was lost to the tempest? Where did the ship go down, or finally limp into harbor? Who remains grateful--or holds you responsible--for her fate? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Craft: Practical.
61-62	Courier. You delivered a vital message to a local authority, noble court, or military official. What unexpected challenge did you overcome in the course of your journey? What was the nature of the message? And who among the recipients now trusts and respects you? Add +10 to Ride or Protocol.
63-64	Smuggled Goods. You helped transport contraband through a heavily patrolled district or settlement, using your dexterity and street savvy to outwit the authorities. What were you smuggling? What unexpected complication arose? How did you turn the situation to your advantage? Add +10 to Sleight of Hand or Streetwise.
65-66	Campfire Tales. While facing bleak conditions over the course of a long journey, you used storytelling or song to distract yourself and others from the harsh reality. Who were your comrades, and where were you going? What was the lowest point, and what story or song got everyone through it? Who or what was lost along the way? Add +10 to Survival or Perform.

Life Event: Recent

d100	Life Event
67-68	Secret History. Curiosity and intuition led you to piece together clues about a community's past, leading to the revelation of a hidden truth. What secret did you uncover, and what did you do with this knowledge? How has your position with the community been permanently altered by it? Add +10 to Insight or Common Lore
69-70	Battlefield Medic. In the chaos of battle, you endured terror and exhaustion in order to provide aid to wounded comrades. What forces or factions were at war? Among those you helped, whose life did you save, or fail to save? In what way has that stayed with you? Add +10 to Willpower or Heal.
71-72	Deal of a Lifetime. You convinced a skeptical merchant or other buyer to agree to a deal that others thought impossible. What was on the table? What terms did you negotiate? And what valuable item or service changed hands? Add +10 to Persuade or Commerce.
73-74	Improvised Repair. Your weapon broke in the heat of battle, and you had to fix it on the fly. Whom or what were you fighting? What material or clever fix saved the day? What fresh scar do you carry as a result? Add +10 to Melee (Light, Medium, or Heavy) or Craft: Practical.
75-76	Heroic Rescue. You performed a feat of physical prowess to save someone in danger, inspiring those who witnessed your bravery. What danger did you face, and whom did you rescue? How has this selfless act impacted your reputation? Add +10 to Athletics or Inspire; or take +1 Status.
77-78	Holy Revision. While listening to someone recount a sacred parable, or reading it for yourself, you discerned a different lesson or deeper meaning than the one commonly accepted. What divine truth--or paradigm-altering tenet--did you perceive between the lines? How has it reshaped your faith? And who disagrees vehemently with your interpretation? If you plan to choose the Godbound career, add +10 to Piety; otherwise, add +10 to Perception or Divinity.
79-80	Masked Entertainer. You performed anonymously at some event, concealing your identity while delighting onlookers--or disturbing them with an unwelcome truth. What display or story left a lasting impression? Who now is bent on uncovering your true identity? Add +10 to Stealth or Perform.
81-82	Path to Ruin. While traveling in the country, you came across an overgrown trail that led to a long-abandoned structure. What was its original function? What signs told the tale of its downfall? And what clue to an object of great value did you discover there? Add +10 to Track or Ancient Lore
83-84	Close Bond. In the course of taming an unruly horse or other mount, you became bonded to the animal and learned to see the world from their perspective. What is the mount's name? Is it yours, or were you taming it in service to someone else? What did the experience teach you about yourself? Add +10 to Ride or Insight.
85-86	Trial of the Wild. During a time of scarcity--due to isolation, war, famine, or seasonal extremes--you had to forage and search for resources in the wild. What plant, animal, or water source did you locate? How did it save you, your expedition, or your community? Add +10 to Survival or Nature wise.
87-88	Agent of Diplomacy. Unexpectedly or by design, you served as envoy aboard a ship on an important diplomatic mission. Your understanding of maritime customs and social etiquette ensured the mission's success--or barely salvaged it. What was the mission? What critical role did you play in the negotiations? And who now respects or distrusts you for your efforts? Add +10 to Sail/Boat or Protocol.
89-90	Clever Theft. Through some combination of witty banter and technical skill, you gained access to a locked room or container, in the presence of its guardian. What treasure or secret did you claim within? Who was the guardian? And who is now after you because of your actions? Add +10 to Locks & Traps or Wit.
91-92	Reluctant Revelation. By charm, lies, or magical means, you managed to extract valuable information from someone who did not want to give it up. Who were they, and what dangerous truth did they yield? How has your relationship been complicated (or destroyed) as a result? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to Strand : Thought; otherwise, add +10 to Deceive or Seduce
93-94	Waycutter. You mustered physical force or destructive magic to clear a path through an obstacle or opposing force. What was so important that such measures were demanded? What price did you pay for this dangerous feat? And what was won or lost, in the end? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to Bind: Destroy; otherwise, add +10 to Might or Endurance.
95-96	Summoner's Call. You or someone else conjured a powerful entity, risking otherworldly attention in order to gain the upper hand in some negotiation or conflict. What bargain or threat held the entity in check? What lasting impression did the display leave? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +2 to Strand : Spheres; otherwise, add +10 to Intimidate or Arcana.
97-98	Forbidden Knowledge. You came across an ancient tome or scroll that contained astonishing and disturbing insights. What revelation did your study of the text uncover? And what danger do you now face for possessing--or destroying--it? If you plan to choose the Spellweaver career, add +10 to a Bind skill of your choice; otherwise, add +10 to Arcana or Ancient Lore
99	Haunted. The restless spirit of a dead soul haunts your waking moments and invades your dreams. You rarely sleep anymore, but the constant wailing of the dead soul has given you some insight into the spirit world. Who was the spirit in life, and how did they die? Are you the cause of their torment? If not, why does this ghost haunt you, and what can you do to free yourself from it? Add +10 to Arcana and give yourself the Undead-wise skill.
100	Forgotten Past. You have woken up with no memories other than your other 2 life events, and this: standing on a dock, preparing to fight your pursuers. Where was the dock? Who were the pursuers? And why do you have the feeling this has all happened before? Add +10 to a skill of your choice.

7) select a previous career

A Previous Career represents the training and vocation your character had before they began their adventuring life. A Previous Career is not a "Class"; nor does it dictate the life path your character must take. Moreover, after character creation, you are free to develop your character however you see fit, either by deepening their earlier training or by pursuing an entirely different path altogether. In short, a character starts as the product of their cultural background, Life Events, and pre-adventuring career, but their future development belongs to them.

A Previous Career provides you with a pool of points to spend on skills in each skill category (each point spent raises a skill by one point). No skill can be raised higher than 70 during character creation. Skill points cannot be transferred between categories.

Each Previous Career also provides your character with Talents and some silver pieces (sp). You may swap out one of your Previous Career Talents for +2 Status.

Each Previous Career grants one or more custom - wise or Language skills. For each, choose whether to create a new - wise or Language using the listed starting value, or apply that value as a bonus to an existing one.

There are ten Previous Careers. If you wish to determine yours randomly, roll 1d10:

d10	Previous Career
1	Warrior
2	Rogue
3	Ranger
4	Speaker
5	Bard
6	Civilian
7	Loremaster
8	Merchant
9	Godbound
10	Spellweaver

HALF-ORC WARRIOR
BARBARIAN
KEZDES ORINI, DRANGIA
LANGUAGE: KHANNISH

Warrior

Mercenaries, knights, archers, pirates, bandits, and anyone who lives by the sword.

- A One Custom -wise or Language at 20
- A Combat 80; Adventuring 50; Social 40; Lore 30; Magic 0
- A Talents: Armor Training III, and one Combat Talent
- A 1d6 × 5 sp

Rogue

Thieves, assassins, ruffians, burglars, swashbucklers, pirates, and all those who make a living outside the law.

- A One Custom -wise or Language at 20
- A Combat 50; Adventuring 70; Social 50; Lore 30; Magic 0
- A Talents: Pick a total of two Talents from the Combat, Adventuring, or Social categories
- A 1d6 × 5 sp

Ranger

Warriors of the wilderness, rangers often act as guides for those brave or foolish enough to leave their homes and traverse the uncivilized and wild places of the Broken Empires.

- A One Custom -wise or Language at 20
- A Combat 50; Adventuring 80; Social 30; Lore 40; Magic 0
- A Talents: On Through the Night or Armor Training I, and any one Combat or Adventuring Talent
- A 1d6 × 5 sp

Speaker

Diplomats, envoys, raconteurs, or anyone who can sway individuals or groups with soaring rhetoric, inspirational speech, razor-sharp wit, or a host of other social tactics.

- A One Custom -wise or Language at 30
- A Combat 20; Adventuring 40; Social 80; Lore 60; Magic 0
- A Talents: Two Social talents
- A 2d4 × 10 sp

Bard

A wandering minstrel, skald, singer, or performer, known for their knowledge of old stories and songs, and for their Social skills. They tend to be highly valued in noble halls throughout the Broken Empires as a source of information about far-away events. "News travels slowly, save from the lips of a skald", as they say in the North.

- A Two Custom -wisesor Languagesat 20 each
- A Combat 30; Adventuring 50; Social 70; Lore 50; Magic 0
- A Talents: Entertaining, and one Social Talent
- A 1d6 × 5 sp

Civilian

A townsman, guildsman, crafter, farmer, or any other vital role in a pseudo-medieval society not covered by other Previous Careers.

- A One Custom -wise or Languageat 20
- A Combat 50; Adventuring 50; Social 50; Lore 50; Magic 0
- A Talents: Experienced (during Rounding Out, get an extra 30 points on Adventuring, Social, or Lore skills), and any one Adventuring, Social, or Lore Talent.
- A 2d6 × 10 sp.

Loremaster

A scholar, expert, or wise one well versed in knowledge both esoteric and mundane.

- A Three Custom -wisesor Languagesat 30 each
- A Combat 20; Adventuring 50; Social 50; Lore 80; Magic 0
- A Talents: Literate and either Lecturer or Travel Planner
- A 2d4 × 10 sp

DWARVEN MERCHANT
CIVILIZED, URBAN
KEIGHTON, THE WESTLANDS
LANGUAGE: WESTRONNE

Merchant

Masters of commerce, merchants travel the world (or set up shop) trading wares or services for profit.

- A One Custom -wise or Language at 30
- A Combat 20; Adventuring 60; Social 60; Lore 60; Magic 0
- A Talents: Literate, and either Barterer or I See Your Mind
- A 3d6 × 10 sp

Godbound

A mortal servant chosen by a deity and granted the right to call upon divine aid, provided their Piety is maintained through deeds in the god's name. Godbound are not defined by church rank (though priests and clerics may be among them); rather, the title marks those who truly hold the god's favor.

- A Custom -wise (your chosen deity) at 30
- A Combat 30; Adventuring 40; Social 50; Lore 60; Magic (Piety) 20
- A Talents: Godbound, and either Literate or any one Lore Talent
- A 1d6 × 10 sp

Spellweaver

Wizards, sorcerers, warlocks; call them what you will, a Spellweaver pulls at the threads of reality to work their own will upon it.

- A Select 2 Binds , 4 Strands , and 2 Thin Strands to define your magical focus.
  - » Thin Strands are harder for you to learn. They cannot be developed at character creation and are double the normal cost to learn later.
  - » If you designate a Strand gained during Life Events as one of your Thin Strands, keep whatever value you gained, but you cannot develop it further in character creation.
- A Add +10 to each of your two chosen Bind skills.
- A One Custom -wise or Language at 20
- A Combat 20; Adventuring 20; Social 20; Lore 40; Magic 100
  - » Spend the 100 Magic skill points among any of the five Binds. No Bind may be developed past 70.
- A A Strand's starting value is added in levels. No Strand can be developed past level 5 during character creation.
  - » Add 10 levels of Strands among any of your chosen 4 Strands.
  - » Add three additional levels of Strands to any Strands except Thin Strands.
  - » All other Strands start at zero .

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Continued from previous page...

- Take one level of Expertise in one Bind skill.
- Talents: Patterned in the Weave, Literate
- Choose a d8 Thread Die of a Bind or Strand of your choice (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Threads).
- 1d6 × 5 sp

Hadrion's Previous Career will be a Spellweaver of the Druid Convocation. His Change and Control Binds each become 10.

He takes the custom -wise of Ritual-wise at 20, and now spends his skill category points. The 20 points in Combat skills are used to make his Dodge 50 and Missile 40. His 20 points of Adventuring skills adjust his Endurance to 25, Perception to 40, and Willpower to 45. He uses his Social category bonuses to bump his Insight 20 points to 50, and he spends his 40 points of Lore skills to make his Ancient Lore 35, his Arcana 70 (the maximum it can be at character creation), and his Craft: Artistic 45.

He divides his 100 Magic category points among the five Bind skills (and adding to his previously chosen Binds of Change 10 and Control 10). He increases them to Change 40, Control 50, Destroy 20, and Witness 10.

He then takes 10 levels among his Druidic Convocation Strands: Beasts 4, Earth 1, Plants 5 (including the +2 he received from his Life Event), and Water 2. He takes an additional 3 levels in any Strand he wants (except his Thin Strands of Spheres and Spirit), making his Body 2 and Thought 1.

He takes Ex2 in Bind: Control. He takes the Talents Literate and Patterned in the Weave (which increases his Max Resolve by 5 and requires him to choose a True Name, in Low or High Vestrian. He goes with "Varimaxx Cusoris"). He takes a d8 Beast Thread, and rolls 25 sp.

HUMAN SPELLWEAVER
WANDERER
THALVORN, HOHENVALL
LANGUAGE: MEERSREICH

Option: Magic Convocations

If you want a template for building your Spellweaver, you may select one of the established Convocations . Each provides a typical combination of Binds, Strands, and Thin Strands used by mages of a particular magical style.

Aeromancer
Binds: Conjure, Control
Strands: Air, Earth, Spirit, Thought
Thin Strands: Beasts, Spheres

Battlemage
Binds: Conjure, Destroy
Strands: Beasts, Body, Earth, Fire
Thin Strands: Spirit, Thought

Druid
Binds: Change, Control
Strands: Beasts, Earth, Plants, Water
Thin Strands: Spheres, Spirit

Earthbinder
Binds: Change, Control
Strands: Beasts, Air, Earth, Plants
Thin Strands: Spirit, Thought

Elementalist
Binds: Conjure, Control
Strands: Air, Earth, Fire, Water
Thin Strands: Body, Thought

Firemancer
Binds: Conjure, Control
Strands: Air, Fire, Plants, Thought
Thin Strands: Water, Body

Healer
Binds: Conjure, Witness
Strands: Beasts, Body, Thought, Water
Thin Strands: Spheres, Spirit

Inquisitor of the Order of the Purifying Flame
Binds: Destroy, Witness
Strands: Body, Fire, Spheres, Spirit
Thin Strands: Earth, Water

Seer
Binds: Control, Witness
Strands: Body, Air, Spheres, Thought
Thin Strands: Beasts, Earth

Sorcerer
Binds: Control, Destroy
Strands: Body, Fire, Spheres, Thought
Thin Strands: Beasts, Spirit

Spiritbinder
Binds: Change, Control
Strands: Body, Spheres, Spirit, Thought
Thin Strands: Plants, Fire

Wavemaster
Binds: Change, Control
Strands: Air, Beasts, Body, Water
Thin Strands: Fire, Spirit

8) rounding out

Rounding Out is the final step in defining your character's skills. It reflects everything they've learned or gained since their Previous Career, up to the present day.

1. Bonus Talent/Status/Money - Take any one Talent for which you meet the requirements or take +1 Status or take +100 sp.
2. Age-Based Bonuses - Determine your relative age: Young, Adult, or Old.
   - » Young characters get: +20 Endurance; +1 Death Threshold; 70 bonus skill points to spend among any skills from any category as you choose.
   - » Adult characters get: 100 bonus skill points to spend among any skills from any category as you choose.
   - » Old characters get: +1 level of Expertise to any applicable skill; -20 Endurance; -2 Death Threshold; 30 bonus skill points to any skills in the Lore category; 100 bonus skill points to spend among any skills from any category as you choose.
3. Bonus Savvy Skills - Pick any three skills from any category and mark them as Savvy. Mark an "S" next to each one. When you spend Experience Points on improving a Savvy skill, it will advance as though it benefits from the Savvy Talent: after improving this skill with XP, add +1 to the skill's new total.
   - » Piety and Strand skills cannot be chosen as Savvy skills.

Reminders

- A You cannot exceed the 70 maximum skill value for starting characters.
- A New-wise or Language skills must be purchased at 20 (for 20 skill points) and may be improved further with any remaining bonus skill points.
- A Only a Godbound can put bonus skill points into Piety, up to a maximum starting value of 70.
- A Only a Spellweaver or Fade may put bonus skill points into Binds. A Spellweaver's starting maximum is 70. A Fade may never increase a Bind skill past 70.
  - » Allowed Strands may be improved for five bonus skill points per level, to a maximum of level 5 at character creation. Improving Strands after character creation is subject to the rules for spending XP (see Chapter 8 - Experience & Advancement: Spending XP).
- A If you are a Human, don't forget to take your additional Savvy skill, Expertise level, and Talent.

Normally, a skill's Expertise cannot exceed half of its tens digit (rounded down). However, if a factor in character creation such as Cultural Background or Rounding Out grants a higher Expertise than this limit would allow, that factor takes precedence.

As part of Rounding Out, Hadrion takes the Forceful Strand: Plants Talent.

Brian determines Hadrion will be of Adult age, giving him 100 points to spend on whatever skills he chooses. He makes his Missile 60, Endurance 45, Willpower 60, Protocol 65, Ritual-wise 25, Change 50, Witness 15, and Beasts 5.

He chooses Perception, Insight, and Bind: Change as his Savvy skills.

He now chooses the one additional level of Expertise and one Talent he received from being a Human. He gives himself Ex3 in Bind: Control, and takes the Steely Thews Talent.

9) equip your character

Starting adventurers enter the world with a few bare essentials to help them survive:

1. Starting Weapon - Every character starts with a dagger.
2. Starting Armor - Characters start with 1d3+1 pieces of armor, as long as they have whatever training the armor requires (if any).
3. Starting Coin - Add 2d4×50 sp and make any purchases you can afford.

   » Instead of starting with the armor and coin above, if you have high Status (see Step 12: Status later in this chapter), the GM may allow you to start with more expensive equipment.

4. Weapon/Armor Stats - Write in armor and weapon details, including ENC/Bulk in their appropriate areas on the character sheet.
5. Calculate your Initiative penalty (see Chapter 9 - Equipment: Armor).
6. Supply Dice - Start with a d12 in all of your Supply dice boxes (Gear, Ammo, Rations, Medical).

Hadrion takes a dagger. He'll want to buy a longbow later, as his Missile skill is pretty decent. He rolls two starting pieces of armor, and since he has no training, he chooses a Leather helmet and vest, giving 3 AP to the Head and Body locations.

He rolls an additional 300 sp, giving him 355 sp to spend on starting equipment. He spends 80 sp to buy Quilt armor (2 AP) for both his legs, and another 40 sp to get Padding (1 AP) for both his arms, leaving him with 235 sp. His Initiative penalty from the armor bulk is -3 (making his final Initiative modifier +8). He takes note of his ENC limitations and weapon details, and gives himself a d12 in all his Supply dice.

10) assign personality traits

Personality Traits act as a snapshot of the character's overall demeanor. They help you get a handle on how a character might behave in a given situation. They are evolutionary, not static: feel free to change them in response to campaign events as they unfold.

In extreme circumstances where a character's Personality Trait really informs the moment, the player may suggest a circumstantial bonus or penalty of up to +/-20 to an appropriate skill roll. This may only be used in dramatic or intense moments relating to a character's goal, and is always at the GM's discretion.

A bonus is its own reward, but if the player voluntarily takes a skill penalty from a Personality Trait, they get +1 XP at the end of the session.

Ability Score descriptors (see Step 3: Choose Ability Scores earlier in this chapter) also act as a kind of Personality Trait: while there isn't typically a way to accept a penalty from an Ability Score descriptor (as they are generally beneficial), a bonus can be gained in exactly the same way as invoking a Personality Trait.

Choose two or three Personality Traits from the following list (or create your own) that best describe your character.

A more mechanically-involved optional Personality Trait system is included in Appendix C.

Brian decides Hadrion will have the Personality Traits "Obsessive" and "Trusting", in addition to his Stat Descriptors of "Well-read" and "Affable".

Personality Traits

Trait	Description
Altruistic	Places the needs of others before personal gain
Callous	Emotionally cold, harsh, or lacking compassion
Calm	Controlled, measured, and slow to anger
Cautious	Careful, deliberate, and wary of risk
Compliant	Inclined to obey rules, laws, or authority
Deceitful	Habitually dishonest or manipulative
Defiant	Resistant to authority, expectation, or control
Fearless	Bold, reckless, or seemingly without fear
Forgiving	Willing to let go of grudges or offenses
Friendly	Open, approachable, and warm toward others
Honest	Truthful and sincere in word and deed
Hopeful	Inclined toward optimism and positive expectation
Humble	Modest, unassuming, or free of arrogance
Loyal	Devoted to people, causes, or ideals
Passionate	Driven by strong emotions and intense convictions
Pessimistic	Inclined toward cynicism or expecting poor outcomes
Proud	Strongly aware of personal worth, status, or accomplishment
Self-serving	Primarily concerned with personal benefit or advancement
Suspicious	Distrustful, skeptical, or expecting hidden motives
Trusting	Inclined to believe in the good intentions of others
Unprincipled	Guided more by self-interest than ethics or duty
Vengeful	Inclined to hold grudges and seek retribution

11) create character goals

Now that the characters are made, look at their Life Events, shared histories, Personality Traits, or anything else that might inspire their Goals. Do this together if possible--creating goals as a party creates an immediate group cohesion (no need to "meet in the tavern").

It's a good idea to start with at least one individual goal and one shared goal (see Chapter 6 - Goals). Regardless of type, try to maintain three to five active goals at any one time.

Discovering Goals in Play

It's okay to leave goals entirely blank and discover them in play. A lot of players only discover what motivates their character once they are actually playing them. Goals can be declared at any time; let some goals emerge naturally from interaction with the conflicts in the world.

And as an option to quickly kick things off, the GM can offer a shared goal to focus the party on an immediate task ("You've all been hired by a grey-bearded wizard to retrieve a stolen treasure from a nearby troll lair...").

Hadrion's starting goals are derived from his and the other PCs' background Life Events:

"I will prevent the Lady Jane of Keighton from building a hunting lodge near the sacred Druidic standing stones," and "I will help my friend Ramirez find the bounty hunter who killed his sister."

Example Goals

- I will find my old friend Alric, who recently vanished from the town of Tun-on-Traeth.
- I must reclaim Retribution, the sword of my father, from the black knight who stole it.
- I want to win the bardic competition in Balbom to increase my standing there.
- I will find and convince an arcane mentor to teach me one of my Thin Strands.
- We must broker a peace between the pirates of Dengmarsh and the native Lizardmen.
- I will help my friend Simon clear his name from the false murder charges brought against him.
- We will discover the secret that lies at the heart of the Shroud.
- I will find the pieces of my grandfather's spear and reforge it.
- I will find out how I wound up on this beach with no memory of how I got here.
- We want to convince the Voiyod of Vieksgrad that the gods are nothing more than ascended Spellweavers.
- We will track down the Lich Mot-Zaroth and put him back in his tomb.
- We will solve the mystery of who has been killing the beggars in Keighton.

chapter 7: character creation

Hadrion (name) | Human (Old Vestrian) (race) | M (sex) | Adult (age)
Civilized Urban (culture) | Spellweaver (Druid) (previous career) | Med. (size) | xp

ability score descriptors: Int: Well-read; Cha: Affable
personality traits: Obsessive; Trusting

combat	%	ex
dodge	50	
melee: light	20	
melee:medium	20	
melee: heavy	20	
might	20	
missile	60	
thrown	20	

adventuring	%	ex
athletics	20	
endurance	45	
locks & traps	25	
perception S	40	2
ride	20	
sail/boat	20	
sleight of hand	20	
stealth	20	
survival	20	
track	20	
willpower	60	

social	%	ex
deceive	35	
insight S	50	
inspire	25	
intimidate	30	
perform	25	
persuade	25	2
protocol	65	
seduce	25	
wit	35	

lore	%	ex
ancient lore	35	2
arcana S	70	2
commerce	35	
common lore	45	
craft: pract.	20	
craft: art	45	
divinity	25	
heal	30	
naturewise	20	
streetwise	35	
Ritual -wise	25	

binds	%	ex
change S	50	
conjure		
control	50	3
destroy	20	
witness	10	
language	%	ex
Low Vestrian	70	
High Vestrian	20	
-wise		
-wise		

strands	lvl
air	
beast	5
body	2
earth	1
fire	
plant	5
spheres	
spirit	
thought	1
water	2
starting piety	

resolve & fatigue

attributes

max resolve	initiative	init penalty	total	toughness	death threshold	lethality level
20	+11	-3	+8	+1	20	7

wounds

total lethal wp	base recovery	shock?	rounds dying

talents

Inner Strength
Press the Point
Literate
Patterned in the Weave
Forceful Strand: Plants
Steely Thews

armor penalties

athletics
rise from prone
stealth
dodge
perception

shield

size:
split
ap shb enc

BODY 1-5

armor: Leather | t? | ap: 3 | sund bulk: 2 | imp
wp nl? | wounds | inf rb

right arm 6

armor: Padding | t? | ap: 1 | sund bulk: 0.5 | imp
wp nl? | wounds | inf rb

right leg 8

armor: Quilt | ap: 2 | sund bulk: 1 | imp
wp nl? | wounds | inf rb

head 0

armor: Leather | ap: 3 | sund bulk: 2 | imp
wp nl? | wounds | inf rb

left arm 7

armor: Padding | t? | ap: 1 | sund bulk: 0.5 | imp
wp nl? | wounds | inf rb

left leg 9

armor: Quilt | ap: 2 | sund bulk: 1 | imp
wp nl? | wounds | inf rb

detailed locations

body
1-5 . . . . chest
6-8 . . . . stomach
9-0 . . . . groin

head
1-2 . . . . skull
3 . . . . . left eye
4 . . . . . right eye
5-6 . . . . face
7 . . . . . nose
8 . . . . . right ear
9 . . . . . left ear
0 . . . . . neck

arms
1-2 . . . . shoulder
3-4 . . . . bicep
5 . . . . . elbow
6-8 . . . . forearm
9-0 . . . . hand

legs
1-2 . . . . hip
3-6 . . . . thigh
7 . . . . . knee
8-9 . . . . shin
0 . . . . . foot

weapons

name/type	att	pry	rch	dmg	cl	cs	dis	t	enc	rng	notes
Dagger	20	20	0	1	2	2	5	6	0/1	0	Piercing 5 on Prone/Grappled
Longbow	60	-	-	3	6	5	5	5	3	4	2H

Hadrion (Brian)
name

goals

shared

I will prevent the Lady Jane of Keighton from building a hunting lodge near the sacred Druidic standing stones.

shared

I will help Ramirez find the bounty hunter who killed his sister.

??

life events: origin

Heretic's Offspring
+10 Willpower

My mother was contacted by "god", although I never believed her.

(Shared History with Ian's PC - grew up together and learned about the gods: +5 Divinity)

life events: youth

Strange Flora
+2 Strand: Plants

Discovering the magical properties of the Bloodthorn plant, I realized I had the potential to become a true Spellweaver.

Rival: Vesuvian

life events: recent

Fortune Dealer
+10 Arcana

After reading the fortune of a noblewoman, I discovered her intent to desecrate the sacred standing stones south of Keighton.

RESOURCES

supply dice

gear d12
ammo d12
rations d12
medical d12

silver pieces
235

status

relationship npcs

Vesuvian, Rival - Alchemist trying to discredit anything I achieve

inventory

max enc:
enc

threads

Beast thread (bear claw): d8

notes

True Name: Varimaxx Cusoris

fraying

points:

12) status (optional)

The role of the adventurer is rarely a profitable or respected one. They often risk their lives for a mere handful of coins, only to blow through it all on replacement gear, new armor, or just a clean, safe place to sleep. And no matter how much ill-gotten silver they spend, it never gains them the legitimacy or respect afforded to other, more accomplished members of society. Luckily, there are other ways to get ahead in the world. Characters who are less interested in scraping together a few silver coins for their next meal and more interested in gaining real wealth and influence can try to increase their Status .

A Status level confers many social benefits, including recognition, privilege, access, and authority within a community or area. It also assumes that financial needs commensurate to that level will be taken care of; once elevated to a high enough rung on the social ladder, daily irritants like food and lodging generally get taken care of for you by others.

The gaining and losing of Status is based on whatever actions the characters take as they pursue their goals. Since the specifics of such outcomes are idiosyncratic, it is difficult to provide universal rules to reflect changes in social standing within a given community. What follows instead is a set of general guidelines and considerations on how to use Status in your campaign.

Status has three key features:

- A Status is measured between 0-10.
- A Status is neither a skill nor an Attribute; it does not increase with XP .
- A Status goes up and down according to its own guidelines, detailed here.

Status as Wealth and Social Standing

A key question answered by Status is, "What can I afford without having to worry about the number of coins I'm carrying?" Status is not about the coins in your purse (silver coins are separate and distinct from Status, and have consistent value no matter where in the Broken Empires you go). Very often, those with elevated status do not have to worry about the many small expenditures of daily life, as either their standing within the community will afford them whatever they require, or their good reputation, credit, or investment income will cover the cost.

But Status is about more than just money: it represents social standing, equity, reputation, and income, which allows the character to participate at a whole other level within a society. It allows access to people and places that would be denied to those of lesser standing, gives characters the right to get past certain social rules, mores, or even laws, and generally confers other intangible benefits, which will be discussed in more detail below.

Establishing Your Credentials

Status is integrally linked to civilization, and you can therefore only benefit from Status in civilized places where you have established yourself. When you are out in the wilds or when you are in a place where you are an unknown quantity to the local community, your effective Status is 0, regardless of your actual Status value (you don't have different Status numbers in different areas or groups; once you establish yourself with a group, your Status level applies with them as well).

If you want to benefit from your Status, you must establish your credentials with the pillars of the local community. They don't have to like you, but they do have to know who you are, or see the benefit of interacting with you (or the peril of ignoring you). The process of establishing your credentials will be different for each character in each community, and must account for factors like local customs, history, social structures, trust, and connections. This process may itself become the subject of one or more adventures, and will almost certainly involve the pursuit of relevant character goals.

It's important to keep track of the communities and/or areas where you've already established yourself.

It's possible that your character has already established their credentials with multiple communities prior to the start of the campaign based on their history and/or the random events rolled during character creation. Being from a noble background, for example, automatically establishes credentials in most civilized areas. Confirm such details with your GM.

Using Status

Status is used to make single expenditures your Status level allows you to afford, and to gain social benefits among the community or area in which you enjoy the Status.

Once you've established yourself in a community, you can draw upon your assets and social credit to make expenditures within your Affordable Limit, as outlined on the Status table below. Note that the limits listed on the table are approximate and that pushing too often against the limits of your Status may result in a loss of Status.

Using Status is separate from spending coins or trading individual items. Your current Status tells you whether you can afford something without dipping into your cash on hand. It doesn't provide a discount on purchases.

You either use Status or you spend cash; you cannot use both on a single transaction.

Stratton has a Status of 2, and he wants to get an excellent private room at the inn. This is usually about 20 sp and is therefore affordable for him. He gets the room without having to spend any coins.

While he's in town, Stratton wants to purchase a horse. At 300 sp, a horse is worth much more than his Affordable Limit will allow--he'll need to come up with the cash or make other arrangements.

The Affordable Limit is the amount in sp a character at this Status level can comfortably afford in a single transaction before his assets need to regenerate, or before he wears out his welcome. How often or at what interval this expenditure can be made will be a matter of table discussion and common sense.

Intangible Benefits are various types of social rewards conferred at each Status level. Several examples of each type are provided; they are just examples and are not representative of all possibilities.

- A Recognition is both the strength of a character's reputation, and how quickly they are physically recognized within the community. This could be good or bad, depending on whether or not the character wants to remain incognito.
- A Privilege means perks the character can expect to enjoy in the area or from the community under normal circumstances.
- A Access represents how easily the character can get an audience or meeting with more powerful or influential NPCs who recognize his or her Status, or gain access to restricted areas or information.
- A Authority is the kind of political or social power the character can be expected to wield. A character at this Status level can reasonably expect to receive obedience from those of lesser Status in the community or area.

Many sessions later, Stratton has advanced to Status 4, and he has come by information that he thinks would be valuable to the landed knight who serves as the local lord. Stratton has established himself in this region already, so his Status applies. The GM determines that his Status of 4 is enough to grant him an audience with the lord, although he still has to present his information as trustworthy.

Status

Status Score	Affordable Limit (sp)	Intangible Benefits	Example or Title
0 - Destitute	0	None	Itinerant wanderers, beggars, press-ganged sailors, adventurers.
1 - Struggling	10	Recognition : Known for doing odd jobs; recognized by regular members of the relevant community. Privilege : None. Access : None. Authority : Sought for advice by fellow workers; counsel valued by colleagues.	Town citizens, apprentice craftsmen, peasant farmers, unskilled workers, or mercenaries.
2 - Modest	50	Recognition : Respected as skilled; acknowledged by the relevant community for reliability. Privilege : Gets slightly better wages for being dependable; forgiven for minor debts by lenient lenders; free to use shared workshop facilities. Access : Invited to local guild meetings. Authority : Oversees apprentices in their trade.	Journeyman craftsmen, small -scale farmers, merchants with single -market stalls, low-ranking soldiers, sailors or town guards.
3 - Comfortable	100	Recognition : Acknowledged as a successful and influential member of the community. Privilege : Permitted to store goods in communal spaces; occasional free use of, and special treatment at, stables and inns. Access : Granted access to low-level noble households or government functionaries. Authority : Can arbitrate disputes among neighbors; negotiate contracts with merchants; has voting power in the local guild. Can expect lodging and provisions from peasants or villagers during travel.	Well-established craftsmen, prosperous small farmers, minor government or guild officials, minor landowners, wandering landless knights, ship's mate.
4 - Prosperous	250	Recognition : Celebrated as a benefactor to the community; sought after for partnerships or advice. Privilege : Exempt from small tolls; invited to local feasts hosted by officials; free use of town stables, inns, and facilities. Access : Invitations to private guild functions; opinions are considered more worthy than idle gossip in noble courts. Authority : Can advise the mayor or lord on trade policies; controls local guild chapters.	Successful tradespeople, mid-level merchants with trade routes, minor landowners, household knights (knights bachelor serving in a lord's retinue), respected key advisors, ship's navigator or physician.
5 - Established	500	Recognition : Widely known across neighboring towns; name is synonymous with quality and success. Privilege : Exclusive seating at festivals and official events; personal guards allowed within city limits. Access : Regular guest in the homes of minor nobility; special access to restricted trade routes. Authority : Holds influence over town appointments; directs regional trade agreements; commands small bodies of troops.	Large-scale merchants, senior guild members, landed knights, market lords, captains of ships, owners of multiple farms, workshops, or ships.

Status

Status Score	Affordable Limit (sp)	Intangible Benefits	Example or Title
6- Affluent	1,000	Recognition : Known as a prominent figure in the region; referenced in local Common Lore and tales. Privilege : May bypass certain tax and legal processes. Access : Invited to noble courts for counsel; access to guarded archives or libraries. Authority : Appoints local leaders; can mobilize local militias for protection; enforces minor justice (fines, imprisonment) within their domain.	Guildmasters, captains of merchant fleets, lesser noble families managing small estates, barons.
7- Elite	2,000	Recognition : Known across a region; name associated with noteworthy deeds. Privilege : Provided escorts for travel; bypasses town curfews or laws when convenient. Access : Direct access to ruling councils; visits royal courts without prior summons. Authority : Appoints guildmasters or regional leaders; sets trade tariffs or tolls; sponsors major infrastructure projects; musters knights and barons for military expeditions.	Regional guildmasters, landowning nobles with lucrative holdings, high-ranking noble or governmental officials or in trade centers, viscounts.
8- Renowned	4,000	Recognition : Known across regions. Privilege : Immune to most local laws. Access : Unrestricted movement through national borders; permitted exclusive audience with kings or queens. Authority : Controls regional economies; shapes the political landscape through wealth.	Owners of a fleet that controls a key sea lane, patrons of large mercenary companies, financiers with stakes in multiple cities' economies, earls.
9- Eminent	8,000	Recognition : Universally known and respected; their name carries weight in every court or city. Privilege : Treated as an equal by high-ranking nobility if not already noble themselves; granted honorary ranks or ceremonial privileges. Access : Unfettered access to royal and arcane secrets; owns or governs key trade hubs. Authority : Influences dynastic successions; commands armies or fleets.	Heads of trade consortiums, leaders of banking houses that fund kingdoms, merchants who monopolize exotic goods like spices or silk, generals, dukes/duchess, second sons of kings.
10- Supreme	15,000	Recognition : Their name is synonymous with power itself; invoked in every hall of governance, temple, and guild across the known world. Privilege : Commands sovereign rights over territory; considered untouchable by law. Their presence alone can make or break alliances. Access : Free passage and dominion anywhere; receives tributes from nations, has the ear of kings and emperors, and is privy to all state, arcane, and divine secrets. Authority : Determines the fate of nations; establishes or abolishes laws; commands absolute loyalty from vassals, armies, and economies alike.	Merchant princes, royalty, and kings.

chapter 7: character creation

Increasing Status

Your Status value can be increased in a few ways:

- Social Standing - Receiving a new title, marrying into a prominent family, or being recognized by the community for your deeds.
- Equity - Acquiring land, buildings, ships, or other highly valuable assets.
- Income - Gaining interest in a caravan or sea route, ownership of a business, control of a bridge or toll road, the right to levy taxes, or other ongoing revenue generators.

All of these kinds of events should be the result of the character pursuing relevant goals and handled through the normal rules of the game.

Whenever one of the above events takes place, the GM considers its scope and impact. If he determines it to be a significant milestone along the character's road to greater Status, the character may raise their Status level by 1.

Decreasing Status

There are three primary ways your Status might decrease:

- Liquidating assets
- Pushing your limits
- Other events

Liquidating

You can turn some of your social capital and equity into hard coin, but it will have a cost. If you want to generate some liquid assets (typically coins, but may also include trade goods, gems, jewelry and/or letters of credit), decide how much cash you need, up to the Affordable Limit of your current Status. Note that the GM may impose a limit on how much currency the local community can supply. Such a "withdrawal of funds" more than once in a short time will reduce the Status level by 1 (what "a short time" is will be based on the context).

Pushing your limits

Pushing the limits of your Status includes:

- A purchase slightly above the Affordable Limit shown on the Status table.
- A few consecutive purchases at or near the affordable limit.
- Many consecutive purchases each over half the affordable limit.

Any time the GM rules that your spending habits are pushing the limits of your Status, they may reduce your Status by 1.

Other Events

One danger of being a person of Status is that the sources of your Status can come under threat by any number of events, whether malicious or random. Homes can burn down, reputations can be tarnished, lands can be confiscated, businesses can be driven under by rivals, and so on. When such an event occurs, and if the character is not able to prevent it, the GM may reduce the Status by 1.

Important Considerations

Time

All trade and enterprise take time to arrange--whether establishing your credentials, selling dungeon loot, or commissioning armor. The length depends on circumstances, and the GM decides what makes sense for the situation.

Availability

Being able to pay doesn't mean something is at hand. Smaller markets have fewer options, especially for rare or costly goods. A Thessian woodcarver might have several staves for sale, but the lone weaponsmith (if one exists) may only have a single broadsword--and finding a second would be nearly impossible.

Intent

As with any abstract system, the Status rules depend on players engaging with them in good faith. Though loopholes can always be found, the GM and group share responsibility for keeping play within the spirit intended.

cHAPTER 8:

experience & advancement

Advancement in The Broken Empires RPG, as in real life, is hard-earned and requires a sincere investment of time and effort from the players. As stated in the Introduction, this is a game of slow, incremental improvements. But when players make a good-faith effort at the table to pursue their character's goals, they will earn Experience Points (XP), which they can spend to improve their character's Skills and abilities.

Goal pursuit is the foundation of XP. Even if you don't finish a goal, you should usually walk away with at least 3 XP just for pressing forward. Pursuing goals is vital for your character to advance, but there are other ways to earn Experience Points. Each will be discussed in this chapter, as well as the many ways to spend that precious XP.

Keywords In This Chapter

Experience Points (XP)
Personality Trait Skill Penalty
Revelation

earning xp

In order to earn Experience Points, you have to roll dice to overcome meaningful obstacles in pursuit of one or more of your character's goals (and each table's interpretation of meaningful will, of course, be different). During a session, Experience Points are earned in the following ways:

- A Pursuing and Completing Goals
- A Failing and Abandoning Goals
- A Having a Revelation
- A Voluntarily Taking a Personality Trait Skill Penalty

Pursuing and Completing Goals

Progress toward any of a character's goals earns the player 3 Experience Points (see Chapter 6 - Goals). Completing an individual goal earns 1 XP; completing a shared goal earns 2 XP . It is up to the GM and players to ensure that any goal is meaningful and worthy of generating XP .

Failing and Abandoning Goals

If the character failed at a significant goal, or had to abandon one in a dramatic way, they get 1 XP . This award should be reserved only for a truly dramatic turn of events, where the loss or abandonment of a goal has meaningful consequences for the character. What that means is up to each individual table to decide.

Having a Revelation

A revelation is a moment in the game, not necessarily tied to a specific goal, in which a roleplaying moment or character discovery within the scene causes a change in the character's outlook, or otherwise shifts expectations. This is obviously a very broad category, and includes any memorable roleplaying moments in the game that seem worthy of being rewarded. The players should discuss the events of the session among themselves, and if they and the GM feel one or more moments were particularly cool, exciting, or profound (and not already rewarded under a different XP category), the characters involved get 1 XP.

Taking a Personality Trait Skill Penalty

If the player accepts a skill penalty from a Personality Trait at least once in the session, they get 1 XP. This can only be earned once per session, regardless of the number of times Personality Traits penalize rolls. This award should only be granted if the Personality Trait penalty mattered in the moment: if it advanced or complicated one of the character's goals, or otherwise meaningfully contributed to a dramatic or important moment.

Edbert has the Personality Trait "Bloodthirsty". When speaking to the assassin Veil, who has captured and imprisoned him within the hold of her ship, Edbert decides to take a -20 to his Persuade roll, knowing that his violent, threatening personality will make it harder for him to "play nice". Since he voluntarily accepted the skill penalty, he gains 1 XP at the end of the session.

Gaining XP

Goals-Related Activity	XP Earned
Did you pursue one or more goals by rolling dice against meaningful obstacles?	3 XP
Did you complete an individual goal?	1 XP per goal
Did you complete a shared group goal?	2 XP for each party member who shared the goal
Did you fail or abandon one or more significant goals in a dramatic or meaningful way?	1 XP
Did you experience one or more revelations?	1 XP
Did you accept a skill penalty due to a Personality Trait at least once?	1 XP

Simon overcame obstacles this session toward at least one of his goals (3 XP). The group also completed a shared goal (2 XP). He didn't fail at any goals in a dramatic way, nor did he take a penalty due to Personality Traits, but he experienced a revelation (1 XP), for a total of 6 XP.

spending xp

With XP, you can improve skills and buy Talents. This can be done either at the end of a session or at the beginning, but not during.

Improving Skills

As in real life, skill mastery requires patience: the better you already are at something, the harder it is to improve. You may spend XP to increase any skill you have.

- For each XP spent on improving a skill, roll 1d100. If the result is over the current skill value, increase it by 1d4+1 points. If the roll is equal to or under the current skill value, increase it by 1 point.
- For a skill marked with the Savvy Talent, add 1 to either result.
- Critical results on experience rolls have no additional effect.

Buying a New -Wise or Language Skill

You can purchase a new -wise or Language skill for 3 XP, which starts it at 20. You may increase it normally from there.

Talents

Most Talents cost 5 XP to purchase. More expensive Talents are noted in their descriptions. You must meet any requirements the Talent has before purchase, as listed in its description.

Expertise

A maximum of 3 levels of Expertise can be bought for each skill (up to Ex4). Skill Expertise has a fixed cost by level: Ex2 costs 4 XP, Ex3 costs 6 XP, and Ex4 costs 8 XP. Each level must be bought separately, in ascending order (for example, you can't buy Ex3 until you first have Ex2).

Expertise is also limited by the skill's value: a skill cannot have Expertise higher than half the value of its tens digit, rounded down (see Chapter 4 - Talents: Expertise). Strands and Piety cannot have Expertise.

Personality Changes

At the end of a session, you can choose to change, add, or remove any Personality Trait as long as you feel it is warranted by the session's events. This has no XP cost.

Magic Skills Advancement

Unless you started out with the training, it's much harder to learn magic. If you didn't acquire the Patterned in the Weave or the Faded Pattern Talent during character creation, and you later wish to learn magic, you must first purchase the Faded Pattern Talent. This gives you no actual starting value in any Magic skill; it merely allows you to become a Fade, and spend additional XP to open up Magic skills.

Bind Improvement

Bind skills improve like any other skill. If a Spellweaver or Fade doesn't yet have skill in a particular Bind, they may spend 5 XP to acquire it at a starting value of 10. A Fade can never develop any Bind skill past 70.

Strand Improvement

The Strand Magic skills have a range of 1-10 (and beyond, but see below). To increase a Strand, spend XP equal to the next highest value. For example, going from Air 3 to 4 would cost 4 XP; increasing the Spheres Strand from 6 to 7 would cost 7 XP, etc. Improvements must be sequential (improving from 3 to 5 would cost a total of 9 XP: you must first spend 4 XP to go from 3 to 4, then another 5 XP to go from 4 to 5).

A true Spellweaver can improve Strands beyond 10 using the same XP progression--spend-

ing XP equal to the new value each time. However, for each point a Strand is raised above 10, the Spellweaver gains 1 Fraying. Improving a Strand to 11 gives 1 point of Fraying; raising it to 12 gives another, and so on.

Spellweavers can learn a new Strand only if they are trained by someone who already knows that Strand, or they discover and study a magical tome or other valid source during play. This process of study usually takes at least a week, though the GM may shorten it depending on the circumstances.

Once a new Strand becomes available to the character, they may spend 5 XP to acquire the Strand Secret Talent, granting the Strand a starting value of 1. If the Strand is a Thin Strand, the cost is instead 10 XP .

Further Strand improvement requires spending additional XP as detailed above.

Fade Strand Improvement

When a Fade wishes to buy a new Strand, they must acquire access to it just as a Spellweaver does. They can then purchase a Strand Secret Talent to give them a value of 1 in the new Strand, improving it further as explained above--but a Fade's Strands can never be developed past 7. Fades are not limited by Thin Strands.

Piety and XP

The Piety skill cannot be increased by spending XP. Only through acts of service to the deity can a Godbound's Piety increase, thereby allowing them a greater chance of benefiting from a miracle. Piety can never exceed 90, except by temporary modifiers (see Chapter 15 - Divine Magic: Piety).

cHAPTER 9:

equipment

What would a fantasy adventuring game be without the characters hauling in their ill-gotten loot to sell in exchange for better gear? To facilitate this ancient trope, we need a basic system for trade, exchange, and--of course!--encumbrance.

This chapter details some standard items one might buy or sell in one of the many marketplaces of the Broken Empires, including their relevant statistics, monetary value, and encumbrance. These are by no means complete lists, but the GM can use them as a guide for pricing other items as needed.

Keywords In This Chapter

Armor Points (AP)
Armor Skill Penalties
Bulk
Encumbrance (ENC)
Initiative Penalty
Inventory ENC
Repairing Armor
Silver Pieces (sp)
Split the Shield
Sunder the Armor
Supply Dice
Weapons at Hand

coins & haggling

There are many currencies in use throughout the Broken Empires--a different one for every kingdom, realm, or territory--but for simplicity's sake, we record them all equally as standard silver pieces (sp). Every 500 silver pieces takes up 1 Inventory ENC (see Encumbrance).

In most cultures of the Broken Empires, haggling over price is normal. In others, however, the notion of haggling over an item is deeply insulting. If the PCs are in a haggling-friendly environment and are negotiating over price when buying or selling, use the following guidelines.

Both buying and selling represent several minutes of back-and-forth bartering. By engaging in haggling, both parties agree to abide by the outcome.

Buying

Buying an item costs the listed price in sp as shown in the tables. To bargain for a better price, a Player Character and the seller make opposed Commerce rolls. For every 2 DoS the PC achieves, reduce the cost by 10%, up to a maximum of 50%.

Selling

When selling an item, a PC can make an opposed Commerce roll against the buyer:

- A If the PC wins, every 2 DoS increases the base price by 10%, up to a maximum of +50%.
- A If the buyer wins, every 2 DoS decreases the base price by 10%, up to a maximum of -50%.

When selling weapons, armor, or mundane items, the base price is half the listed price. That amount can be haggled over from there using the rules above.

Simon wants to sell a gem worth 100 sp to a jewel merchant:

- If Simon wins the roll with 2 DoS, the merchant pays 110 sp (a 10% increase).
- If the merchant wins with 4 DoS, she only pays 80 sp (a 20% decrease).

Trading Limits

There are limits on the amount of hard coin one can get from selling items. In a small village, there may be only a few score silver coins in the entire settlement; when selling valuables there, you're far more likely to receive goods or services than currency (and that's only if the locals consider what you're selling valuable at all; in many places at the edge of civilization, if you can't eat it, use it, or fight with it, it's pretty much worthless). In a large city, however, trading for coinage isn't normally going to be a problem unless they are suffering scarcity for some reason (war, famine, etc.).

The availability of an item in any particular market is also a consideration (see Chapter 7 - Character Creation - Status).

supply dice

Supply Dice are a quick way to determine whether or not you're running out of useful items, and are designed to abstract away the minutiae of tracking such things.

Gear, Ammo, Medical, and Rations are all supply categories abstracted with a Supply Die, each ranging in value from d12 down to d6 (d12-d10-d8-d6).

After every time you use Supply, roll its corresponding die type; if it comes up 1-2, decrease the value of the die to the next lower type (d8 to d6, for example). Once you deplete a d6 Supply Die, the supply has run out and is unavailable until replenished.

Simon's Ammo Supply Die is at d10. After he fires his crossbow, he must roll his Ammo Die (a d10). He rolls a 2, which means that after his shot, he must reduce his Ammo Die to a d8.

Supply Dice can be traded among characters, one-for-one, obeying the maximum of d12 and the minimum of d6.

roll 1 or 2

roll 1 or 2

roll 1 or 2

Gear

Gear includes torches, lantern oil, rope, and other useful equipment that your character could expect to have under normal circumstances. (It doesn't include weapons or armor, or anything covered by a different Supply Die.)

If it's reasonable that your particular character would have a particular item, then they have it. Produce the single item from your pack, then roll the Gear Supply Die to check for depletion. Think of Gear as expendable supplies: lantern oil gets used up, rope is cut and abandoned, crowbars break, etc. Unique non-consumable items aren't considered part of Gear, and are instead added to the Inventory. If it is unclear whether or not an item is part of Gear, the GM decides.

> In the wilderness, Edbert produces a rope from his pack, and then his player rolls the Gear Supply Die. It is unlikely that he would be able to produce a quill and parchment from his Gear, as this warrior from Dunblaine isn't even literate.

Ammo

Ammo is tracked if you have missile weapons of any kind (the Ammo Die represents all your ammo, regardless of type), and is rolled after every turn in which at least one shot is taken.

Replenishing Ammunition

If you are unable to buy more ammunition, but have access to appropriate resources, arrows and bolts can be replenished with a Craft: Practical roll. Each roll takes a few hours and produces a number of Ammo Die steps equal to 1 + 1 per 3 SLs.

> Simon has fired many crossbow bolts, and his Ammo Die has been reduced to a d6. The GM rules that, as he is in the forest, he may fashion new bolts from plentiful wood. Simon takes a few hours and gets 3 SLs on his Craft: Practical roll. He may increase his Ammo Die by 2 steps (1 + 1 per 3 SLs), bringing it up to d10.

Medical

Medical supplies are used with the Heal skill, and the Medical Supply Die is rolled after every attempt (successful or not) of that skill. Supplies include bandages soaked in thyme oil, basic surgical tools, silk sutures for mending wounds, smelling salts, etc. A low Medical Supply Die (d6) could represent running out of basic needs and having to tear up clothing for bandages, etc.

Rations

Rations represent food and water and must be tracked while in Daily Time (see Chapter 12 - Travel). Running out of Rations can cause Fatigue and ultimately Deprived wounds.

Option: De-abstracting Supply

More simulationist-minded players may prefer a more concrete method of tracking Supply. If so, it's easy enough to assign ENC values to everyday items--5 torches per ENC point, for example, or a 50' rope taking up 2 Inventory ENC slots--but you'll have to work those out for your own table. If you go this route instead of using the Gear Die, I would recommend increasing each character's Max Inventory ENC by 4 or more.

You can even give each resource normally absorbed into Gear its own die, if you want: a character might have a d8 Torches die, a d10 Rope die, a d4 Caltrop die... you get the idea. If you go this route, you can give each separate resource die half an ENC point, or something like that.

encumbrance

A character can only carry so many items. This limitation is represented by encumbrance (ENC). ENC doesn't reflect weight; it reflects the reality of having only so much space on the body to put things, and the overall discomfort and burden accrued by carrying and wearing cumbersome items over time.

Each item has an ENC value. The higher the ENC value, the more cumbersome an item is to carry.

Every character has carrying limits for different categories of gear: Weapons at Hand, Worn Armor, Supply Dice, and general Inventory. Each ENC category is dedicated: it can only be used for one type of item.

Weapons at Hand

You can carry up to 6 ENC worth of weapons or shields where they're easily reachable--strapped to your back, hip, or shoulder. These are considered At Hand and can be drawn as a single action.

Weapon Readiness

Weapons can be in one of three states:

- Held and Ready: Already in your hand, no action needed
- At Hand: Drawn by Performing a Minor Action (must fit within your 6 ENC of Weapons At Hand)
- Stored: In Inventory, takes 2 full actions to retrieve.
  - » Dropping a weapon is a free action.
  - » Drawing, sheathing, or picking a weapon up off the ground is an action (Perform a Minor Action).

Worn Armor

Armor's ENC is called bulk, which is used to calculate your armor's Initiative penalty. Each hit location (Head, Body, each Arm, each Leg) can hold 1 piece of armor, regardless of its bulk. If you carry armor instead of wearing it, each piece (regardless of type) takes up 1 ENC of Inventory space (see Inventory).

Supply Dice

You may carry 1 of each type of Supply Die (Ammo, Rations, Medical, and Gear) without using up Inventory ENC. Any extra Supply Dice must be stored in Inventory, and each has ENC 2, regardless of die size.

Simon has a d12 Rations Die, which takes up no ENC. However, he wishes to carry extra food for the road. He buys an extra d10 Rations Die, which will have to be stored in his Inventory, taking up 2 ENC.

Inventory

You have an Inventory Max ENC of 6. This is general Inventory space--items stored in packs, satchels, pouches, etc. Anything that isn't worn or at hand goes here: backup weapons, extra Supply Dice, etc. Procuring an item from your Inventory takes 2 actions.

A broadsword (a weapon) has ENC 2, taking up 2 of the 6 available Weapon ENC. The same broadsword stored in a pack would take up 2 Inventory ENC instead, and would not be considered at hand. A small but heavy chest with an ENC of 3 takes up 3 of the 6 available Inventory ENC.

Inventory ENC Sizes

Items acquired from your Gear Supply do not count against your Inventory ENC. Their ENC is already abstracted into the Gear Die.

Items other than Supply-based items, Weapons at Hand, or Worn Armor may take up Inventory ENC. Weapons carried in Inventory take up their listed ENC.

Item Size	Examples	Enc
Tiny	Jewelry, rings, scrolls, or anything that wouldn't take up any meaningful space on one's person	0
Small	Bucklers, small shields, stacks of 500 coins or less, or up to 3 potions or similar items	1
Medium	Extra Supply Dice of any type or die value, or Medium shields	2
Large	Large shields or cumbersome treasure items	3
Very Large	Bulky items	4

Six Inventory ENC may not seem like much, but remember that the majority of an adventurer's equipment is taken up by the abstracted Gear Supply Die, which already covers the encumbrance of its own items. You can increase Inventory ENC with the Strong Back Talent.

Inventory ENC Overflow

You may carry more ENC than your Max Inventory ENC of 6, but doing so applies a penalty to all skill rolls involving physical activity (Athletics, Combat skills, etc). No one can carry 10 or more ENC over their limit.

Enc Overflow	Skill Roll Penalty
1-3 over Max	-10
4-6 over Max	-20
7-9 over Max	-30

weapons, armor, & shields

Weapons, shields, and armor are the tools of the adventurer. Used properly and skillfully, they can be the difference between surviving a lethal confrontation, or becoming the victim of it. However, weapons and shields take up valuable and limited encumbrance space, while armor can slow you down in combat.

> Just as I make no attempt to simulate a realistic economy in this fantasy world, neither do I make any attempt to simulate "realistic" weapons or armor. This is still a fantasy game, and that means embracing fantasy concepts of how armor actually works. The old tropes win out over HEMA-approved historicity here, my hardcore simulationist friends!

Weapons

Weapons cause damage when they hit, either lethal (swords, claws) or non-lethal (fists, staves). This damage translates into Wounds .

Lethal weapons can be used to cause non-lethal wounds instead, but at -10 to the attack (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Situational Rules).

Weapons do a static amount of base damage. The DoS from an attack roll translates to extra damage, which is added to the base damage. See the Weapon Tables .

Weapons have different minimum required SLs to fuel Combat Maneuvers (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Combat Maneuvers).

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Might Weapons

	SP	Rch	Dmg	Cl	Cs	Dis	T	Enc	Rng	Notes
Fists/Kicks	-	0	0 NL	1	3	2	4	-	-	Unarmed attacks; -20 vs armed foes
Brass Knuckles	20	0	0	1	3	3	4	0	-	Turns unarmed Might attacks into Lethal damage; -20 vs armed foes

Light Weapons

	SP	Rch	Dmg	Cl	Cs	Dis	T	Enc	Rng	Notes
Dagger	20	0	1	2	2	5	6	0/1*	0	Thrown; Piercing 5 on Prone/Grappled opponent *A single dagger may always be "at hand" with no ENC cost.
Parrying Dagger	25	0	1	2	2	5	6	1	-	Defensive; +2 AP when used in the secondary hand with Two Weapon Fighter Talent; no penalty for off-hand use
Shortsword / Cutlass	60	0	2	2	2	5	6	1	-	
Hand Axe	30	0	2	3	2	5	6	1	0	Thrown
Cudgel	10	0	2 NL	2	2	5	6	1	-	
Rapier	100	0	2	2	2	4	7	1	-	Defensive; cannot be used in the secondary hand with Two Weapon FighterTalent
Javelin	70	0	2	2	2	5	6	2	2	Piercing 1; Thrown
Blackjack	15	0	1 NL	2	2	5	6	1	-	If struck in the Head with surprise, a humanoid rolls the Wound die at -3
Whip	25	1	1	2	5	2	3	1	-	Cannot be used to parry or Set for Charge
Torch	-	0	1	2	2	5	7	-	-	Does fire damage causing Burn wounds. After attacking, roll a d6: on a 1-2, the torch goes out.

Brass Knuckles

Dagger

Parrying Dagger

Shortsword

Cutlass

Hand Axe

Cudgel

Rapier

Javelin

Blackjack

Whip

Torch

Weapon Table Terminology

SP .....Cost in silver pieces

RCH ..... Reach weapons have a value from 0-2. The weapon with the greater Reach gains a +10 bonus to attack and defense rolls per point of difference from the opponent's Reach. Weapons with greater Reach also allow a Set For Charge attack against charging opponents with lesser Reach

DMG.....Base damage of the weapon

CL.....Choose Location requirement in SLs

CS.....Circumvent Shield requirement in SLs

DIS .....Disarm requirement in SLs

T .....Trip requirement in SLs

ENC.....Weapon encumbrance

RNG ..... Maximum effective attack range for a missile or thrown weapon. You can shoot at a target at 1 range beyond this at -20

Ranges

0 .....Close, in the same zone, within about 30'

1.....Short, in an adjacent zone, from 30-60' (spear)

2 ..... Medium, 2 zones away, from 60-100' (sling, light crossbow)

3 .....Long, 3 zones away, 100-200' (shortbow, crossbow)

4 .....Very Long, 4+ zones, 200-300' (longbow)

5.....Sight, 5+ zones, 300+

Notes

2H ..... Requires both hands to wield, and you may not equip a shield

ClSh..... Weapon may attempt the Cleave Shield Maneuver

NL ..... Non-lethal. Wound points marked NL do not count against the Death Threshold or Lethality Level

Piercing ..... Weapon bypasses this number of Armor Points from worn Armor. It does not reduce a shield's AP

Reload .....Number of actions to reload the weapon

Thrown ..... Weapon can be used with the Thrown Combat skill. Use the stats from the Thrown Weapons table if thrown

Defensive ..... When parrying with this weapon, gain a +10 bonus to the defense roll

Unwieldy ..... When parrying with this weapon, suffer a -20 penalty to the defense roll

Overbearing .....Drive Back Combat Maneuver costs 1 fewer SL

Medium Weapons

	SP	Rch	Dmg	Cl	Cs	Dis	T	Enc	Rng	Notes
Broadsword / Mace / Scimitar / Flail	100	0	4	3	3	4	5	2	-	
Bearded Axe	120	0	4	3	2	3	5	2	-	Unwieldy
Warhammer	110	0	4	4	3	4	5	2	-	Piercing 1
Club	30	0	4 NL	3	3	4	5	2	-	
Staff	50	1	4 NL	3	3	4	4	2	-	2H; Defensive
Spear	60	1	3	3	3	5	5	2	1	Piercing 1; Unwieldy; Thrown

Improvised Weapons

Items you can pick up and wield as weapons do damage according to their relative size, and the skill used corresponds to that size. An improvised item that is small enough to be used by the Melee: Light skill does 1 damage; if large enough to be used by Melee: Medium , 2 damage; and if Melee: Heavy , 3 damage.

What constitutes the size category of an improvised item is up to the GM.

The item can also be used to reduce damage as a shield if appropriate: small item, 1 AP, medium 2 AP, and large 3 AP.

Improvised weapons are one-time use items; they are destroyed the first time they either cause or reduce any damage.

Broadsword

Mace

Scimitar

Flail

Bearded Axe

Warhammer

Club

Staff

Spear

Weapon Table Terminology

SP .....Cost in silver pieces

RCH ..... Reach weapons have a value from 0-2. The weapon with the greater Reach gains a +10 bonus to attack and defense rolls per point of difference from the opponent's Reach. Weapons with greater Reach also allow a Set For Charge attack against charging opponents with lesser Reach

DMG.....Base damage of the weapon

CL.....Choose Location requirement in SLs

CS.....Circumvent Shield requirement in SLs

DIS .....Disarm requirement in SLs

T .....Trip requirement in SLs

ENC.....Weapon encumbrance

RNG ..... Maximum effective attack range for a missile or thrown weapon. You can shoot at a target at 1 range beyond this at -20

Ranges

0 .....Close, in the same zone, within about 30'

1.....Short, in an adjacent zone, from 30-60' (spear)

2 ..... Medium, 2 zones away, from 60-100' (sling, light crossbow)

3 .....Long, 3 zones away, 100-200' (shortbow, crossbow)

4 .....Very Long, 4+ zones, 200-300' (longbow)

5.....Sight, 5+ zones, 300+

Notes

2H ..... Requires both hands to wield, and you may not equip a shield

ClSh..... Weapon may attempt the Cleave Shield Maneuver

NL ..... Non-lethal. Wound points marked NL do not count against the Death Threshold or Lethality Level

Piercing ..... Weapon bypasses this number of Armor Points from worn Armor. It does not reduce a shield's AP

Reload .....Number of actions to reload the weapon

Thrown ..... Weapon can be used with the Thrown Combat skill. Use the stats from the Thrown Weapons table if thrown

Defensive ..... When parrying with this weapon, gain a +10 bonus to the defense roll

Unwieldy ..... When parrying with this weapon, suffer a -20 penalty to the defense roll

Overbearing .....Drive Back Combat Maneuver costs 1 fewer SL

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Heavy Weapons

	SP	Rch	Dmg	Cl	Cs	Dis	T	Enc	Rng	Notes
Battle-Axe	150	0	6	5	5	3	2	3	-	2H; ClSh; Unwieldy; Overbearing
Longsword used 1H	200	0	4	4	4	3	3	3	-	1H
Longsword used 2H	200	0	5	5	5	3	2	3	-	2H
Two-Handed Sword	180	1	6	5	5	3	2	4	-	2H; ClSh; Unwieldy; Overbearing
Longspear / Pike	100	2	5	5	5	3	2	4	-	2H; Piercing 1; Unwieldy; DMG 10 versus Lance Charge
Halberd / Bill Hook	200	1	6	5	5	3	2	4	-	2H; +10 vs Mounted; Unwieldy; Overbearing
Heavy Flail	150	0	6	5	4	3	2	3	-	2H; Unwieldy; Overbearing
War Staff	80	1	5 NL	5	5	3	2	3	-	2H; Defensive
Maul	175	0	6	5	5	3	2	4	-	2H; Piercing 1; ClSh; Unwieldy; Overbearing
Lance	160	2	10	5	5	3	2	2/4*	-	Unwieldy; Overbearing; Mounted Charge only; may break on hit. *2 ENC while on horseback only

Battle-Axe

Longsword

Two-handed sword

Longspear

Halberd

Heavy Flail

War Staff

Maul

Lance

Images not to scale.

Weapon Table Terminology

SP .....Cost in silver pieces

RCH ..... Reach weapons have a value from 0-2. The weapon with the greater Reach gains a +10 bonus to attack and defense rolls per point of difference from the opponent's Reach. Weapons with greater Reach also allow a Set For Charge attack against charging opponents with lesser Reach

DMG.....Base damage of the weapon

CL.....Choose Location requirement in SLs

CS.....Circumvent Shield requirement in SLs

DIS .....Disarm requirement in SLs

T .....Trip requirement in SLs

ENC.....Weapon encumbrance

RNG ..... Maximum effective attack range for a missile or thrown weapon. You can shoot at a target at 1 range beyond this at -20

Ranges

0 .....Close, in the same zone, within about 30'

1.....Short, in an adjacent zone, from 30-60' (spear)

2 ..... Medium, 2 zones away, from 60-100' (sling, light crossbow)

3 .....Long, 3 zones away, 100-200' (shortbow, crossbow)

4 .....Very Long, 4+ zones, 200-300' (longbow)

5.....Sight, 5+ zones, 300+

Notes

2H ..... Requires both hands to wield, and you may not equip a shield

ClSh..... Weapon may attempt the Cleave Shield Maneuver

NL ..... Non-lethal. Wound points marked NL do not count against the Death Threshold or Lethality Level

Piercing ..... Weapon bypasses this number of Armor Points from worn Armor. It does not reduce a shield's AP

Reload .....Number of actions to reload the weapon

Thrown ..... Weapon can be used with the Thrown Combat skill. Use the stats from the Thrown Weapons table if thrown

Defensive ..... When parrying with this weapon, gain a +10 bonus to the defense roll

Unwieldy ..... When parrying with this weapon, suffer a -20 penalty to the defense roll

Overbearing .....Drive Back Combat Maneuver costs 1 fewer SL

chapter 9: equipment

Missile Weapons

	SP	Rch	Dmg	Cl	Cs	Dis	T	Enc	Rng	Notes
Sling	10	-	1	6	5	5	5	1	2	
Light Crossbow	100	-	3	6	5	5	5	3	2	2H; Piercing 1; Reload 1
Shortbow	50	-	2	6	5	5	5	2	3	2H
Longbow	120	-	3	6	5	5	5	3	4	2H
Heavy Crossbow	200	-	3	6	5	5	5	4	3	2H; Piercing 3; Reload 1

Thrown Weapons

	SP	Rch	Dmg	Cl	Cs	Dis	T	Enc	Rng	Notes
Throwing Knives	30	-	1	3	5	5	5	Ammo Die	0	Draw and throw without penalty
Dagger	20	-	1	5	5	5	6	0/1*	0	Thrown; Piercing 5 on Prone/Grappled opponent *A single dagger may always be "at hand" with no ENC cost.
Hand Axe	30	-	2	5	5	5	5	1	0	
Spear	60	-	3	5	5	5	5	2	1	Piercing 1
Javelin	70	-	2	5	5	5	5	2	2	Piercing 1

Sling

Light Crossbow

Shortbow

Longbow

Heavy Crossbow

Throwing Knives

Dagger

Hand Axe

Spear

Javelin

Weapon Table Terminology

SP .....Cost in silver pieces

RCH ..... Reach weapons have a value from 0-2. The weapon with the greater Reach gains a +10 bonus to attack and defense rolls per point of difference from the opponent's Reach. Weapons with greater Reach also allow a Set For Charge attack against charging opponents with lesser Reach

DMG.....Base damage of the weapon

CL.....Choose Location requirement in SLs

CS.....Circumvent Shield requirement in SLs

DIS .....Disarm requirement in SLs

T .....Trip requirement in SLs

ENC.....Weapon encumbrance

RNG ..... Maximum effective attack range for a missile or thrown weapon. You can shoot at a target at 1 range beyond this at -20

Ranges

0 .....Close, in the same zone, within about 30'

1.....Short, in an adjacent zone, from 30-60' (spear)

2 ..... Medium, 2 zones away, from 60-100' (sling, light crossbow)

3 .....Long, 3 zones away, 100-200' (shortbow, crossbow)

4 .....Very Long, 4+ zones, 200-300' (longbow)

5.....Sight, 5+ zones, 300+

Notes

2H ..... Requires both hands to wield, and you may not equip a shield

ClSh..... Weapon may attempt the Cleave Shield Maneuver

NL ..... Non-lethal. Wound points marked NL do not count against the Death Threshold or Lethality Level

Piercing ..... Weapon bypasses this number of Armor Points from worn Armor. It does not reduce a shield's AP

Reload .....Number of actions to reload the weapon

Thrown ..... Weapon can be used with the Thrown Combat skill. Use the stats from the Thrown Weapons table if thrown

Defensive ..... When parrying with this weapon, gain a +10 bonus to the defense roll

Unwieldy ..... When parrying with this weapon, suffer a -20 penalty to the defense roll

Overbearing .....Drive Back Combat Maneuver costs 1 fewer SL

Shields

A shield acts as passive defense. If the user is aware of the attack, a shield's Armor Points will add to any struck location's Armor Points.

Against a Ranged attack, if you don't have a shield, the only defense possible is Dodge.

Shields use up Weapon ENC. Only someone with the Large Shield Training Talent can equip a Large Shield.

No two-handed melee weapon can be wielded while using any shield. A bow or crossbow can be used while using a buckler.

If equipped with a shield of Small size or larger, the attacker may choose the Shield Bash (ShB) Combat Maneuver (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Combat Maneuvers).

Shields

Type	SP	Ap	ShB	Enc	Examples
Buckler	25	+1	-	1	Small blocker strapped to forearm; can use bow
Small Shield	50	+3	7	1	Target shield
Medium Shield	75	+4	6	2	Round or Heater shield
Large Shield	100	+5; requires Talent	5	3	Kite or Wall shield

ShB - SL cost to perform a Shield Bash Maneuver

Buckler

Small Shield

Medium Shield

Large Shield

Splitting the Shield

When about to suffer damage that would cause you a Wound, you can choose to Split the Shield: you take no Wound, but the shield is broken in the process. This can be done even if the attacker used Circumvent Shield (such is the incredible advantage of a shield!). A broken shield cannot be repaired. You cannot Split the Shield with a parrying dagger or buckler.

Armor

Armor protects individual hit locations. Every type of Armor has an Armor Point rating (AP) per hit location it protects, and a Bulk, which can slow you down in combat.

Armor may not be layered; each location can have only one type of armor protecting it.

When striking a target, if you cause damage greater than the target's total Armor and Shield AP, you cause a Wound. The Wound Point value is the amount of damage in excess of the AP.

Armor

Type	SP	Ap	Bulk	T?	Sund	Penalties	Examples
Padding	20	1	0.5	-	-	None	Thick, protective clothing or furs
Quilt	40	2	1	-	-	None	Layers of quilted fabric like linen or wool, stuffed with horse hair or cloth scraps
Leather	60	3	2	-	Y	None	Hardened but flexible animal hides
Reinforced Leather	100	4	3	Y	Y	Body: Stealth, Dodge-5 At least one Leg: Athletics-5	Flexible, hardened animal hides with metal rings or strips sewn in
Mail	200	5	4	Y	Y	Body: Stealth, Dodge, Rise from Prone -10 At least one Leg: Athletics-10	Metal rings sewn in a flexible mesh
Bone	125	5	5	Y	Y	Head: Perception-10 Body: Stealth, Dodge-15, Rise from Prone -20 At least one Leg: Athletics-15	Bone plates of various creatures linked by leather straps; used by Ogres
Scale	250	6	5	Y	Y	Head: Perception-10 Body: Stealth, Dodge-15, Rise from Prone -20 At least one Leg: Athletics-15	Overlapping metal scales sewn over leather
Plate	500	7	6	Y	Y	Head: Perception-20 Body: Stealth, Dodge-20, Rise from Prone -30 At least one Leg: Athletics-20	Steel plates linked by rivets or internal leathers

SP - Cost per piece AP - Armor Points per hit location BULK - Use to calculate Initiative penalty
T? - Requires armor training to perform Combat Maneuvers SUND - Armor may be sundered

Armor Drawbacks

While it is often necessary to survive, there are 3 drawbacks to armor:

- Each piece of armor has Bulk, which can slow you down in combat by imposing an Initiative penalty.
- Certain armor also causes different kinds of skill penalties per hit location.
- Without the Armor Training Talent, wearing certain pieces of armor prevents you from being able to make any Combat Maneuvers in a round.

Bulk & Initiative Penalty

Add up the Bulk from each piece of worn armor and divide by 3, rounding up. The result is the Initiative penalty your armor causes you. This is only for worn armor; armor carried in Inventory causes no penalty but takes up 1 Inventory ENC per piece, regardless of type.

Armor Skill Penalties

Heavier armor types (Reinforced Leather, Mail, Bone, Scale, and Plate) impose armor skill penalties: Body armor affects Stealth and Dodge, Leg armor affects Athletics, and Head armor affects Perception. Body armor of Mail, Bone, Scale, or Plate also penalizes the Rise from Prone action in combat. Record any penalties in the Armor Penalties section of your character sheet, and be sure to adjust any affected skills when rolling.

The penalties assume Leg armor is worn as a pair. Wearing armor on only one of your legs imposes the Athletics penalty, but don't double it for wearing the armor on both legs. If each leg is clad in a different armor type, only suffer the penalties of the heavier type.

Wearing any piece of Reinforced Leather, Mail, Bone, Scale, or Plate armor on any of the Body, Arm, or Leg locations while swimming adds -30 to any existing Athletics penalties.

Carlos the pirate is wearing mail leggings (-10 Athletics). If he falls in the water, his Athletics-based swim rolls will be at -40.

Use of Armor Without Training

If you wear Body or Arm armor of Reinforced Leather, Mail, Bone, Scale, or Plate without possessing the relevant Armor Training talent, you will not be able to perform Combat Maneuvers of any kind in a combat round.

Fane Rezada the Spellweaver, with no Armor Training, decides to don a mail vest, leather bracers on both arms, and quilt on both legs (total Bulk of 14, divided by 3 for an Initiative penalty of -5). This also increases the Total Cost of any spell he casts by +5 (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic).

He will not be able to perform any Combat Maneuvers while he remains untrained in the mail Body armor, and he will suffer -10 to Stealth, Dodge, and Rise From Prone attempts.

The Bounty Hunter Arn has acquired Armor Training II (Mail) and is wearing a hodgepodge of protection: mail sleeves on both Arms, mail leggings on the Right Leg, plate greaves on the Left leg, a plate helm on his Head, and a mail vest on his Body.

His Stealth, Dodge and Rise From Prone attempts will be at -10 from the mail Body armor. His Perception will be at -10 from the plate helm. His Athletics will be at -20 from the one plate greave on his left leg (the mail leggings impose penalties too, but he only suffers the penalties of the heavier type of leg armor). He will be able to perform Combat Maneuvers as normal, as he is trained in the Mail he wears on his Body and Arms. His Initiative penalty from the armor is -10 (28 total Bulk/3).

If he swapped out his mail sleeves for plate vambraces, he would no longer be able to perform Combat Maneuvers, as he is untrained in plate.

Plate Helm
(AP 7, Bulk 6)

Plate Vambrace
(AP 7, Bulk 6)

Reinforced Leather Greaves
(AP 4, Bulk 3)

Scale Hauberk
(AP 6, Bulk 5)

Armor Piece	Bulk
Plate Helm	6
Plate Vambrace	6
Reinforced Leather Greaves	3
Scale Hauberk	5
Quilt Leggings (x2)	2
Total Bulk	22
Initiative Penalty (Bulk/3, round up)	-8

Quilt Leggings
(AP 2, Bulk 1)

Reinforced Leather Cuirass
(AP 4, Bulk 3)

Padding for Arms & Legs
(AP 1, Bulk 0.5)

Armor Piece	Bulk
Reinforced Leather Cuirass	3
Padded Leggings (x2)	1
Padded Sleeves (x2)	1
Total Bulk	5
Initiative Penalty (Bulk/3, round up)	-2

Sundering the Armor

If you are wearing Leather, Reinforced Leather, Mail, Bone, Scale, or Plate armor in a location that's about to suffer a Wound, you can choose to Sunder the Armor : you take no Wound, but instead mark an "X" in the armor's Sundered box of the struck location. Sundered armor has an AP of zero, but still takes up armor ENC. You cannot both Sunder Armor and Split the Shield for the same wound.

Repairing Damaged Armor

A piece of sundered armor can be repaired by extended Craft: Practical rolls with a required SL based on type. Success allows removal of the "X" and full restoration of the armor's AP . Each roll requires one full day's work and an armor repair kit or other appropriate tools. To repair:

- A Leather : Required SLs 3
- A Reinforced Leather or Mail : Required SLs 6
- A Bone , Scale , or Plate : Required SLs 9

Option: All-or-Nothing Armor

With this option, do not reduce damage by AP when hit. Instead, when struck, first roll a d10 for your shield (if any). If the result is equal to or less than the shield's AP, the blow is deflected. If it fails--or if the attack Circumvents the Shield--roll a d10 for your armor in the struck location. If that roll is equal to or less than its AP, no damage is taken; otherwise, the blow finds a gap and deals full damage.

Circumvent Shield, Sunder the Armor, and Split the Shield work exactly the same way. Be warned that with this optional rule, fights will take longer and wounds will be far more serious.

Miscellaneous Items

Here are some examples of items that may not be procurable by a given character's Gear Supply Die. Any carried item that is not part of Gear Supply must have its ENC accounted for separately in the character's Inventory.

Miscellaneous Items

Item	SP	Enc	Notes
Medical Supply Die, per step	3	-	
Rations Supply Die, per step	5	-	Each extra Supply type takes 2 Inventory ENC regardless of die step
Ammo Supply Die, per step	5	-	
Gear Supply Die, per step	10	-	
Upgrade Rations Die to Superior Rations	20	-	Allows one Rations Die re-roll per session
A mug of ale at the tavern	1	-	-
A simple meal	3	-	Covers Daily Rations Die roll
A fancy meal	5	-	Covers Daily Rations Die roll
Night in a common room	2	-	-10 Recovery Bonus
Private room at an inn	10	-	+0 Recovery Bonus
Excellent private room at an inn	20	-	+10 Recovery Bonus
The finest medical care for a night	50	-	+20 Recovery Bonus
One day's transport by coach	5	-	Does not include rations or accommodation
Armor repair kit	20	1	Covers 5 Craft: Practical attempts to fix armor
Use of a forge or workshop to make items with Craft skills	5 per day	-	-
d12 Ritual Grimoire for 1 Bind and 1 Strand	500	-	-
Cabin	800	-	-
Farm (1 acre)	1,500	-	-
Inn and stables	2,000 - 5,000	-	Based on overall quality
Riding horse	300	-	Holds 12 Inventory slots; Ride roll to move into melee
Warhorse	1,200	-	Holds 12 Inventory slots
Wagon	100	-	Holds 20 Inventory slots. Pulled by a mule
Mule	150	-	Holds 15 Inventory slots
Rations Supply Die for animals, per step	10	2	2 Inventory slots regardless of die step
Horse barding (Head and Body only)	as armor ×2	Bulk	Body barding causes Athletics penalties as Leg armor of its type (-5 Reinforced Leather, -10 Mail, -15 Scale, -20 Plate)

cHAPTER 10:

combat

Most violent conflicts in The Broken Empires RPG are decided after only a few brief exchanges. Combat is not to be taken lightly: there is real risk of lasting injury, infected wounds, or ignominious death. When you fight, you wager your life on your skill and, as always, the roll of the dice.

Combat in The Broken Empires RPG is all about visualizing the visceral details of every swing of a sword. The system is designed to provide gritty detail of outcome while preserving a reasonable speed of resolution; every dice roll gives a wealth of information that helps the GM and players see the fight in their minds, but does so without bogging down the pace of the game.

Keywords In This Chapter

Action
Combat Maneuver
Engaged
Free Action
Hit Location
Initiative
Move
Round
Surprise
Turn
Zone Hazards
Zones

combat round sequence

1. Combatants roll initiative .
2. Each combatant takes a turn in initiative order , performing a move and/or an action.
3. An attacker makes an opposed roll vs the defender.
4. If the attacker wins, choose and apply a qualifying Combat Maneuver .
5. Determine the DoS . Subtract the defender's SLs, if any, from the attacker's.
6. Calculate Total Damage . Add the DoS to the weapon's base damage.
7. Determine the General Hit Location . Use the attacker's "ones" die to find which body part is struck.
8. Determine the Detailed Hit Location . Use the defender's "ones" die to determine the precise point of impact.
9. Apply Protection . Subtract AP from Armor covering that location and/or Shield.
10. Inflict Wound . Any remaining damage becomes a Wound of equal value.
11. Roll Wound Die . The target rolls a Wound Die + Toughness, immediately applying the result (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Peril).

the combat round

A violent conflict is structured in combat rounds, which typically last only a few moments each (about 6 seconds, for 10 rounds per minute).

- During a combat round, each participant gets a turn.
- On their turn, a character can perform one action and one move (usually one zone), in whichever order they choose.

Initiative

To determine the sequence of turns, each round begins with all participants rolling for initiative. To determine initiative, roll a d10 and add your Initiative value. The highest total acts first and then turns proceed in order from highest to lowest.

- Enemies typically do not roll; they have a static Initiative value, which determines their place in the turn order each round. Ties go to the PC.
- Two or more enemies acting on the same initiative take their turns one at a time, in an order chosen by the GM.
- A character can increase their initiative total for a round by spending Resolve on a one-for-one basis. If an NPC has Resolve, they may spend it to increase their static Initiative for the round, but they must do so before the players roll their initiative.
- Wearing armor imposes an Initiative penalty (See Chapter 9 - Equipment: Armor). If a roll takes a character's initiative below 0, the character acts on the negative value.

Hit Location Table

Attacker's Ones Die	General Hit Location	Defender's Ones Die	Detailed Hit Location
1-5	Body	1-5	Chest
		6-8	Stomach
		9-0	Groin
6-7*	Arm	1-2	Shoulder
		3-4	Bicep
		5	Elbow
		6-8	Forearm
		9-0	Hand
8-9*	Leg	1-2	Hip
		3-6	Thigh
		7	Knee
		8-9	Shin
		0	Foot
0	Head	1-2	Skull
		3-4	Eye*
		5-6	Face
		7	Nose
		8-9	Ear*
		0	Neck

*Even = Right, Odd = Left

Simon (Initiative +7, after armor penalties) is fighting a troll (Initiative 12). At the start of the round, his player rolls a 3, +7 is 10. Simon will act after the Troll, unless his player spends 2 Resolve to match the Troll's Initiative of 12 and go first (as PCs win ties).

Important: Initiative is re-rolled every round.

A useful Initiative Round Tracker chart is available for download to help keep each combat round organized. Simply place each PC or NPC in their respective initiative order slots. Repeat each round until combat is over.

Surprise

If one side is unaware of the other, it may be caught by surprise. The aware party makes a Stealth roll opposed by the unaware party's Perception. If successful, the aware party gains one free round to act before regular combat begins, during which the unaware party cannot act or defend.

If the Stealth roll fails--or if neither side is aware of the other until they meet--no surprise occurs, and combat begins with initiative as normal.

When attacking with surprise:

- A Make the attack roll with +20.
- A All Combat Maneuvers cost 1 SL less than normal.
- A The surprised opponent gets neither a defense roll nor any shield AP.

If one group is trying to surprise another, use a Group roll: the lowest Stealth skill opposes the highest Perception.

After the surprise round is resolved, start a new round with all combatants determining initiative.

To Your Next Roll

If a combat condition described in this section would make you suffer a bonus or penalty to your next roll, it will apply to your very next skill roll (like an attack, defense, rising from Prone, etc.), but not to any other roll, like an initiative roll. It also doesn't usually apply to resistance-type rolls, like making an opposed roll versus a spell or resisting a poison; use your judgement.

chapter 10: combat

taking a turn: movement

Zones

An encounter will occur at a certain range measured in zones, abstracted distances that delineate different areas and show the relative position between combatants.

The size and nature of zones can vary based on the area they represent. Zones in a building could be broken up by rooms and hallways, or even sections within a large room, whereas zones in an open field will likely be larger, or divided by terrain features or other qualities.

Different elevations can be modeled as different zones (the top of a hill can be a separate zone than its base, for example). Sometimes an action of some sort is required to change elevation, like needing to use Athleticsto climb a wall (although using ladders and the like usually does not require a roll).

While a zone can be shaped to represent any kind ofbattlefield, in general, the more dynamic the zone--the more features, elevations, obstacles, and details--the more interesting and memorable the battle.

Zones can be roughly sketched out on a piece of paper to give the players and GM a rough idea of where everyone is standing (or you can use a dry-erase board, a hex-grid "battle-mat", terrain and minis, or the official TBE terrain battlemaps--whatever you prefer).

Range Table

Range	Distance
Engaged	Already in melee in the same zone
Close	In the same zone, but not in melee; within about 30'
Short	1 zone away, from about 30-60'
Medium	2 zones away, from about 60-100'
Long	3 zones away, about 100'-200'
Very Long	4 zones away, about 200-300'
Sight	5 or more zones away, about 300'+

Move

On your turn, you get to perform an action and/or move 1 zone. Moving from Close to Engaged (or moving to a spot within the same zone) also counts as moving 1 zone. A Prone character can only crawl 1 zone, and must use both their move and their action to do so.

Engaged

If you are within melee weapon reach of one or more foes, you are Engaged and may make a melee attack against one of them.

- A If you become Engaged over the course of your movement, you must immediately stop.
- A In order to move out of Engaged range, you must either take a Fighting Withdrawal or Flee action (or be the target of a Drive Back Maneuver).

- A Prone, Restrained, or Paralyzed enemy does not count as Engaged for movement purposes; you may freely move away from such a foe.

Some conditions can negatively affect a character's ability to move or act, including:

- » Immobilized: The character cannot move but can still perform an action.
- » Restrained: The character can neither move nor act, but can defend.
- » Paralyzed: The character can neither move, nor act, nor defend.

Zone Hazards

Zone features that can cause restrictions or dangers when encountered are known as Zone Hazards:

- A Confined
- A Rough
- A Obscured
- A Blocked
- A Damaging
- A Other

It is always the GM who decides what hazard, if any, is applied to a zone, based on the needs of the encounter. Hazards are useful tools to keep zones dynamic and interesting, but don't overuse them--context is always king here, but in general, it's best to keep it down to one or two per battlefield. Otherwise, you risk a complicated mess of a combat area.

CONFINED - A Confined zone is cramped or restrictive, and forces a -20 penalty to all Dodge and Melee Heavy skill rolls.

A low tunnel through a cave or a narrow corridor through a castle would be Confined.

ROUGH - A Rough zone has precarious footing that affects Athletics rolls.

- A Making a Charge into a Rough zone requires an Athletics roll. Failure means you make the charge, but without the +20 bonus.
- A Starting in or entering a Rough zone while taking the Run action requires an Athletics roll. Failure means you fall Prone.
- A Using the Drive Back Maneuver to move an opponent into a Rough zone (or a Rough part of the current zone) forces them to make an Athletics roll opposed to the attack roll or else fall Prone in the new zone.

A mountainous zone filled with jagged or loose rocks, a beach zone at high tide, or a swamp zone filled with sucking mud are examples of Rough zones.

OBSCURED - Obscured zones interfere with vision due to fog, smoke, ash, foliage, darkness, or similar effects.

When a target cannot be clearly seen through an Obscured zone, ranged attacks against that target suffer -20.

In especially dense conditions, the GM may rule that an Obscured zone blocks line of sight entirely, preventing ranged attacks into, out of, or through the zone.

A densely wooded area or a city street drowning in soupy fog would each be considered an Obscured zone.

BLOCKED - A Blocked zone is difficult to enter or leave. A standard Endurance roll (or whatever's appropriate) is required to enter or leave the zone. Failure means either you cannot move into or out of the zone this round, or it takes up your whole turn to do so (depending on the nature of the Block). Some Blocked zones are also impassable, which prevents anyone from entering the zone at all.

A zone choked with thick brambles might be Blocked, requiring an Athletics or Dodge roll to enter or leave it. A waterfall at the base of a cliff might be considered simply impassable, or the GM might decide that it takes an entire round and a successful Endurance roll to get past it into the cave beyond.

DAMAGING - A Damaging zone inflicts damage upon anyone who starts in or enters the zone. This is context-dependent; standing still in a zone of razor-sharp thorns may not cause damage, but moving through such a zone will. Remaining in a Damaging zone usually inflicts the same damage again each round a character remains exposed.

- Every damaging hazard has a fixed damage it causes--typically between 1-30, though catastrophic events may exceed this. (See the Hazard Lethality Guidance Table.)
- A DoS opposed roll is made against the zone's damage to resist. The skill used is context dependent: running through a burning corridor might call for Dodge or Athletics, while enduring poisonous vapors could require Endurance.
  - » On a failure, the character takes the zone's full listed damage.
  - » On a success, reduce the damage by the character's SLs.
- Damage is applied to one or more hit locations appropriate to the hazard. If nothing specific applies, roll a random hit location. The GM may instead choose based on context (for example, a low, acidic fog might affect the legs, while falling debris might strike the head or arms).
  - » If the damage is external--such as fire or falling stones--Armor Points and shields normally apply after the opposed roll is resolved.
  - » If the damage is internal--such as choking gas or poison--Armor Points do not apply.

Burning underbrush in a forest zone is a Damaging hazard that causes external fire damage. In this case, based on the guidance of the table below, the GM decides that the hazard's damage is 12. When a character starts in or enters the burning zone, they must roll Dodge to keep away from the flames. Every SL on the Dodge roll reduces the fire's damage of 12.

Simon enters the zone and rolls 4 SLs on his Dodge. This reduces the incoming fire damage to 8. As the fire is mostly burning bushes, the GM decides the damage will be to his two Leg locations. Simon has leather armor on each leg (3 AP), and the GM allows him his small shield AP of 3. Simon takes a 2-point Burn wound to each leg.

OTHER - An Other hazard is a catch-all category that describes a zone with some specific effect not detailed by any of the above hazards, like qualities that can knock someone Prone or render them immobile, for example. Starting in, or entering, such a zone requires a context-based roll to avoid the zone's effects.

A zone can have more than one hazard. A zone could be Obscured with an Other hazard of poison fog that requires Endurance rolls to avoid unconsciousness, for example.

Particularly dangerous hazards can impose modifiers to rolls, at the GM's discretion.

Hazard Lethality Guidance Table

Damage	Examples	Lethality Guidance
1-3	Nettles, hot coals, light smoke	Nuisance; attrition only
4-6	Thorn patch, burning floor, choking dust	Dangerous over time
7-10	Falling masonry, strong acid splash, toxic gas pocket	Serious threat in a few rounds
11-15	Burning building, flood surge, lava splash/edge, cave-in	Potentially lethal in 1-2 rounds
16-20	Raging wildfire front, collapsing tower zone, lava stream	Likely lethal in 1 round for many
21-29	Avalanche core, firestorm, lava fall/pool, hurricane eye wall	Catastrophic; kills most characters outright
30+	Tsunami break, volcanic vent, magical apocalypse zone	Nearly unsurvivable

Claiming the Zone

Sometimes a zone contains tactical chokepoints that, if defended, prevent enemies from getting through. These spots can also act as "funnels" to allow you to deal with one foe at a time, to avoid getting surrounded or out-flanked. In such a zone, you can "claim the zone" by performing the Stand Your Ground action. Despite what the zone might physically look like on the map, if you have claimed a zone that the GM has approved as a chokepoint, the enemy will not be able to freely move around you; they will have to deal with you before getting through. Enemies cannot be Driven Back past someone claiming a zone.

taking a turn: actions

Any proactive task performed by a Player Character or NPC on their turn is an action. Actions may be performed either before or after movement. Failing an action still counts as having taken your action for the round.

Action bonuses and penalties are cumulative with any other relevant bonus or penalty. Aiming a bow (+20) at a target in melee (-20) who is also in an Obscured zone (-20) while you have been Unbalanced from a previous hit (-20) is a total of -40.

Free actions are activities that do not use up an action, but must still be done on your turn. These are activities that require some proactive intent, but aren't substantial enough to take up an entire turn's action. For example: using a quick Perception, shouting a few words, dropping Prone, dropping a weapon or shield on the ground, or similar. As always, the GM is the final judge.

Defending with an opposed roll--like when resisting a spell or defending against an attack--is not proactive, and therefore not an action. A defender can make as many defense rolls in one round as they need to, but may only attempt one defense per attack.

Actions that can be performed in a combat are:

- A Aim
- A Attack in Melee
- A Attack at Range
- A Cast Spell
- A Charge
- A Delay
- A Draw Weapon and Attack
- A Environmental Maneuver
- A Fighting Withdrawal
- A Flee
- A Hold to Interrupt
- A Inspire Ally
- A Perform Minor Action
- A Rise from Prone
- A Run
- A Set for Charge
- A Stand Your Ground
- A Taunt Foe

Aim

Hold your aim with a Missile or Thrown weapon on a visible target. If you do not move or perform a defense before your next turn, you can make a ranged attack on that target on your next turn with +20 and -2 to the Choose Location cost. You can only benefit from one turn of aiming.

Attack in Melee

Attack a single Engaged target by making a DoS Melee: Light, Medium, or Heavy roll with an equipped weapon. If the roll fails, the attack misses. If the roll succeeds, the target may attempt to defend by either making a Dodge roll, or by parrying with the Melee skill of an equipped weapon.

- If the defender wins, they avoid the attack entirely.
- If the attacker wins, they may perform a Combat Maneuver (see Combat Maneuvers) and then add their DoS to the weapon's base damage.
- The attacker's ones die determines the General Hit Location, and the defender's ones die determines the Detailed Hit Location.
- Critical successes add +3 SL, and may have added benefits (see Critical Attacks and Defenses in Combat).

Attack at Range

Attack a target you can see with a missile or thrown weapon. As Attack in Melee, above, but:

- You cannot make a ranged attack if you are Engaged.
- A target can defend against any ranged attacks that they can see coming, but only with Dodge, or if using a shield with any Melee skill of their choice.
- If defending against two or more ranged attacks from any source in the same round, any defense after the first suffers a -20.

Attack in Melee

Edbert is in melee with a Tical Dondallan soldier. Edbert uses his broadsword (Melee: Medium 73, Dmg 4), and the soldier uses a battle-axe (Melee: Heavy 60, Dmg 6).

Edbert's Initiative is 1d10+4; the soldier acts on 10. Edbert's player rolls a 9, +4 is 13, so he goes first this round. Edbert's player rolls a 72 to attack, the GM for the soldier rolls a 16 defense. Edbert wins the contest with a DoS of 6 SLs. He hits in the Body ("ones" die of 2), chooses the Unbalance Combat Maneuver (1 SL), and causes 10 damage (Broadsword 4 dmg + 6 DoS). The soldier has Mail armor in the Body (5 AP). The soldier's defense roll's "ones" die (6) determines the detailed hit location, causing a 5 pt wound in the Stomach (10 dmg - 5 AP).

The GM for the soldier rolls the d10 Wound die, rolls a 2, and adds +1 for his Toughness. The result is 3, which is less than the 5 total Wound Points he has in that location. The soldier then fails his Endurance roll from the Impaired Body, and drops in Shock for 2 minutes (the number rolled on the Wound Die). If he hadn't dropped, his next roll would have been at -20 from the Unbalance Maneuver.

Attack at Range

Simon has aimed the previous turn and now shoots at an Orc at Short range, gaining +20 from Aiming.

Simon's player rolls 11--a critical success! This grants +3 SLs (for a total of 4 SLs) when determining possible Combat Maneuvers (of which he'll get two, because of the critical).

The Orc rolls 47 on his Dodge 60, succeeding with 4 SLs. Because their SLs are tied, the higher number would win--but criticals beat ties, so Simon wins the contest with 0 DoS.

Examples continue on next page...

Continued from previous page...

Simon hits the Orc in the Body (attacker's "ones" die of 1), Stomach (defender's "ones" die of 7), and inflicts only his weapon's base damage (since his DoS = 0).

If the GM had rolled 57 instead (for 5 SLs), the Orc would have Dodged the hit entirely.

Charge

Edbert, with his broadsword (no Reach), is charging a pirate armed with a Longspear (Reach 2). Edbert charges in from Close (in the same zone) to Engaged. The pirate has Reach on Edbert, and as he has not yet acted in the round, he can choose the Set for Charge action and attack first, with the +20 Reach bonus (this will count as his action for the round). He rolls 2 SLs, but Edbert is able to parry the strike completely (he does not get the +20 charge bonus to his parry, only his attack).

Having survived the spear attack, Edbert now Engages the pirate, and attacks with the +20 Charge bonus. (If the pirate's Set for Charge attack had struck Edbert and caused him any Wound Points, Edbert would have lost the bonus). The pirate's parry is at +0, because of the Unwieldy (-20 to defense) spear penalty combined with the +20 Reach bonus.

If Edbert was using a two-handed sword instead (a Reach 1 weapon), the pirate would only get a +10 Reach bonus (Reach 2 vs 1), but he would still get the opportunity to Set for Charge, as the spear has greater Reach than the sword. Presuming Edbert did not get injured on the charge, he would still get the +20 charge bonus (to his attack only), and the pirate's parry would be at -10 (Unwieldy -20 + Reach 2 vs 1 +10 = -10).

Environmental Maneuver

Veil is confronted by two guards in a crowded tavern who are trying to arrest her. She is standing at the bar, which the GM has described as being choked with bottles. The guards win the initiative, Draw their Weapons and Attack (-20) with an Outnumbering bonus of +20. Veil is able to Dodge each of them. She then declares an Environmental Maneuver Action using Athletics.

She says that as she is standing next to the crowded bar, she uses her forearm to sweep a group of bottles into the face of the nearest guard and push him into a group of drunks. Her player rolls a success with 2 SLs; the targeted guard fails his Dodge. She uses her SLs to Unbalance him. As he stumbles into the surprised drunks, the bottles crash into his face, causing no damage, but giving him a -20 disadvantage to his next roll.

Meanwhile, at the other end of the bar, Simon is being threatened by the guard Captain, who has drawn his sword and is menacing Simon with it. The Captain has the initiative on Simon, so he acts first. He stabs and rolls 3 SLs, but Simon Dodges with 4 SLs, evading the attack. Simon pulls the old, "Look! Behind you!" move to throw the captain off. This is an Environmental Maneuver Action using the tavern's "crowded" description and the Deceive skill: he points behind the Captain, feigning shock and horror. He rolls 4 SLs, and the Captain defends with Insight, scoring 1 SL. Simon wins and points at a large, burly man right behind the Captain, whose proximity momentarily distracts the captain's attention. Simon takes the opportunity to Disarm the guard Captain while he's looking away (which his DoS of 3 allows him to do), knocking the blade out of his hand and onto the floor.

- Shooting a ranged weapon that uses ammunition requires the roll of an Ammo Supply Die after your action. If the die shows 1-2, reduce it one step.
- Ranged attacks firing into melee shoot at -20.
- If a target has cover, a ranged attacker fires at -20 (see Situational Rules: Cover).
- You can shoot a target at 1 zone beyond the weapon's range at -20.
- Critically failing a ranged attack instead strikes an unintended target that could reasonably be hit; otherwise, it reduces your Ammo Supply by 1 step.

Cast a Spell/Ask for a Miracle

Compose the spell and make the Casting Roll (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic), or pray to the deity for a Miracle (see Chapter 15 - Divine Magic).

- Casting a spell requires at least one free hand to make the required arcane gestures.
- Any Weave Reactions occur at the end of each Spellweaver's action and take effect immediately.
- Unwilling targets always get an opposed roll against a spell or miracle, using a skill that makes sense in the context. Winning the opposed roll entirely negates the spell's effect.
- AP only applies to External spell damage (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic).
- A Spellweaver may defend against an incoming spell with a Counterspell.
- If you are Engaged with one or more foes, and you wish to cast a spell not targeted at yourself or your Engaged foe(s), do so at -20.
- Dropping a spell's ongoing effects can be done at any time by the caster as a free action.

Charge

A Charge is a single melee attack made with a +20 bonus. To charge:

- You must not be Engaged at the start.
- You must first move at least one zone's worth of distance directly toward your target.
- If this movement brings you to Close range, you may then spend your action to close to Engaged range and make the attack.
  - » Mounted attackers may charge from Short range instead.
- If you charge a foe who Sets for Charge, they can attack you first. You may defend as normal (do not add the +20 charge bonus to the defense roll).
  - » If you suffer any Wound Points from the Set For Charge attack, you lose your +20 Charge bonus.
  - » If you are unable to complete the charge (knocked Prone, disarmed, etc.), your turn ends.
- If making a charge in a Rough zone, you must make an Athletics (or Ride if mounted) roll. Failure means you make the charge, but without the +20 bonus. On a critical failure, you drop Prone in the Rough zone.
- You cannot charge uphill.

Delay

Wait until any point later in the round to take your turn. This cannot interrupt an enemy's turn (use Hold to Interrupt for that).

Draw a Weapon and Attack

Draw one at-hand weapon and attack in the same action, but suffer a -20 penalty to the attack roll. Sheathed throwing knives are exempt from this penalty. Picking up a weapon from the ground is Performing a Minor Action.

Environmental Maneuver

A character may attempt to use the environment itself to gain an advantage over a foe--swinging on a chain, kicking debris, toppling a brazier, pulling down a hanging tarp, shoving a table, throwing sand, etc.

The character makes an opposed roll with an appropriate non-Combat skill (such as Athletics, Deceive, Insight, or Endurance) against the target's Dodge, parry, Endurance, Willpower, Insight, or whatever fits the context. The environment itself must logically support the action; the GM adjudicates what is or isn't possible.

If the roll succeeds, the attacker may apply one of the following effects (identical to Combat Maneuvers), provided their DoS meets the effect's requirement:

- Unbalance (1 DoS)
- Drive Back (2 DoS)
- Disarm (3 DoS)
- Trip (4 DoS)

The attack does no damage and affects whichever hit location makes sense. A critical success allows the choice of two Maneuvers.

Fighting Withdrawal

You may safely disengage from melee by moving from Engaged to Close range. Afterward, you may use your normal movement to reach Short range (or Medium if mounted).

- You must not Engage any foes at any point during this movement.
- You must withdraw only into zones already behind you, never into zones beside or beyond your enemy.
- After performing a Fighting Withdrawal, you may make a single attack against the first opponent who engages you before your next turn, and before they make their attack. They may defend as normal, and may continue their attack if able.
- This attack does not remove a charging foe's +20 bonus unless it knocks them Prone or otherwise prevents their attack.

Flee

If you are currently Engaged and wish to run away, roll a standard Athletics (or Ride if mounted) at -10 for each Engaged foe past the first.

- If you succeed, move 3 zones, from Engaged to Medium range (Long if mounted). Your move rate returns to normal in subsequent rounds.
- If you fail, any current melee opponents may make an immediate unopposed free attack against you before you move (even if they've already acted this round).
  - » Either way, fleeing takes up your entire turn, including your move.
- While fleeing, you may not make any defense rolls, nor can you benefit from any use of a shield.
- You must not engage any opponents at any point while fleeing, and you must move as far as possible from any visible enemy by the most direct route.
- If in any round after fleeing you wish to do anything other than continue to flee, you must make a -20 Willpower roll. Success allows you to stop fleeing and rejoin the combat or take some other action.

Hold to Interrupt

Hold your entire turn until later in the round to interrupt an enemy's turn. This interruption can happen at any point during the enemy's turn. You must specify the action or enemy you are Holding to Interrupt. This is an "if-then" statement (If an enemy appears from behind those rocks, then I'll shoot them; if that enemy casts a spell, then I'll attempt to counter it). If the specified criteria do not occur, then you waste your turn this round.

Inspire Ally

Bolster an ally with words or presence by rolling Inspire. On a success, one ally within hearing distance who can understand you gains +10 to their next roll. For every 3 SLs, you may either grant an additional +10 to that ally or apply +10 to another eligible ally within range.

Perform a Minor Action

Perform any reasonable activity not otherwise covered by any other action. Some examples are drawing or sheathing an "at hand" weapon; drinking a held potion; reloading a crossbow; performing a skill; supporting a nearby ally with a support skill; or picking up an item from the ground.

- You may draw up to two weapons with this action, as long as both are "at hand." This includes shields. To draw a new weapon, any held weapon must first be dropped (free action) or sheathed (separate action).
- Retrieving an item or weapon from your Inventory (e.g., backpack or pouch) takes 2 actions, including when procuring an item with your Gear Die. You may use the item on your third action.
- Picking up a weapon from the ground while Engaged requires a standard Athletics roll, with a -10 for each additional Engaged foe beyond the first.
  - » On a success, you recover the weapon.
  - » On a success with 5 or more SLs, you recover the weapon and may still take your action as normal.
  - » On a failure, you do not recover the weapon.

Fighting Withdrawal

Arn is in a losing battle with two viking warriors. He notices that 2 zones away (at Medium range behind him), there is a burned-out cottage that might give him some advantage--it is a Rough zone, and the GM declares that fighting within its ruined doorways and structures will give anyone fighting in the zone +10 to all defense rolls.

Arn wins the initiative, and on his turn, takes the Fighting Withdrawal action. He moves from Engaged to Close, and then uses his move to get to Short range, keeping his extended sword pointed toward the vikings. He is now only 1 zone away from the more defensible position.

On the vikings' turn, they both move from Short to Close, and then Charge! Arn gets a free attack on the first one from his Fighting Withdrawal action, an attack the viking fails to defend against. Arn impairs the viking's leg, but does not knock him Prone; the viking is able to continue the charge (although he loses the +20 Charge bonus as he was wounded by Arn's attack). The two vikings each attack (only the unwounded one receiving the +20 charge bonus), and Arn tries to defend. He takes only minor wounds from both attacks.

Next round, he wins the initiative again and once more makes a Fighting Withdrawal. He goes from Engaged to Close and is then able to move 1 zone into the ruined cottage zone. Only the unimpaired viking can Charge now, and when he does, Arn again gets his free attack on him. Arn drops the raider before he can strike! The other viking with the Impaired leg moves into Arn's zone at Close range, but can't Run to Engage him (or Charge and attack).

Rise from Prone

Get up from a Prone position. If you are Engaged, make a standard Athletics roll, with a -10 penalty for each additional Engaged foe beyond the first.

- A On a success, you are no longer Prone.
- A On a success with 5 or more SLs, you rise without spending your action.
- A On a failure, you remain Prone.

If you are not Engaged and wish to move after rising, make a standard Athletics roll.

- A On a success, you may rise and take your movement as normal.
- A On a failure, you may rise, but cannot move this turn.

Wearing heavy Body armor (Mail, Bone, Scale, or Plate) imposes penalties to this action (see Chapter 9 - Equipment).

Run

If you are not Engaged, move 1 zone as your action. If you combine this with your regular movement, you may move a total of 2 zones on your turn.

- A You may Run to move into Engaged range with an opponent, but you cannot attack as part of this action. This is useful for engaging foes with Reach weapons without triggering a Set for Charge attack.
- A If you become Engaged at any point during your movement, you must stop immediately.
- A If mounted, this action allows you to move 2 zones instead of 1.
- A You cannot take the Run action while using Stealth.
- A If you start in or enter a Rough zone while Running on foot, you must make an Athletics roll. On a failure, you fall Prone.

Set for Charge

If you are armed with a Reach weapon, on foot, and not currently Engaged, you may prepare for a charging opponent. If an enemy with shorter Reach charges you, you may make a single attack against them before their attack is resolved. If your attack inflicts any Wound Points, the enemy loses the +20 bonus normally granted by Charge.

- A You may declare a Set for Charge in response to an enemy charging you, even before your turn. If you do, it uses up your action for the round--you may not take any other action or move on your turn.
- A You may not make a Set for Charge attack if you have already taken any other action this round.

Stand Your Ground

Plant your feet and make a stalwart defense, either on your turn, or the first time you make a defense roll in a round. You may not attack or choose to move this round for any reason. While Standing Your Ground:

- A All your defensive rolls until the start of your next turn gain +20, including the first one that triggers this stance.
- A Enemies do not gain Outnumbering bonuses against you.
- A Any Trip or Drive Back Maneuver used against you costs +2 SLs (this stacks with bonuses from the Stable Stance and Stay Put Talents).

You cannot choose this option if you have already taken your turn this round. Use this action to Claim the Zone.

Taunt Foe

Rattle an enemy with words or presence. Choose one foe within hearing distance who can understand you, and roll Intimidate or Wit opposed by their Willpower. If you succeed, that foe suffers -10 to their next roll. For every 3 DoS, apply an additional -10 to that roll.

critical attacks and defenses in combat

As a Reminder:

A critical success is rolling doubles under the skill value, or rolling the exact skill value itself.

A critical failure is rolling doubles over the skill value. Any roll of 99-00 is a failure regardless of skill.

Critical Success when Attacking

- Gain +3 SLs as normal.
- Perform up to two qualifying Combat Maneuvers .
- A critical success beats ties.

Critical Success when Defending

- Add +3 SLs to the result.

Critical Failure when Attacking

- Anyone Engaged with the attacker may immediately leave melee, moving to Close range, even if they have already moved or acted this round; OR
- One Engaged defender may immediately perform the Drive Back Maneuver on the attacker and follow them into the new zone.
- A critically failed ranged attack strikes an unintended target that could reasonably be hit; otherwise, it reduces the attacker's ammo die by one step.

Critical Failure when Defending

- Add +1 SL to the opponent's result.

combat maneuvers

Combat isn't just about causing damage to your opponent. It is as much about exploiting momentary weaknesses in their defense to seize a tactical advantage. That could mean forcing them into an adjacent zone with precarious footing; shifting them off balance to set up the next attack; knocking them into a dangerous prone position; or finding other opportunities.

Combat Maneuvers reward players who pay attention to their environment and use its features to their advantage. They keep combat unpredictable, exciting, and dynamic, and empower creative players to make bold, tactical choices in a fight wherein the battlefield matters as much as the character's skill.

Combat Maneuver Requirements

You don't declare what you're specifically trying to do to your opponent beforehand; Combat Maneuvers are determined after the roll. Winning the clash of arms gives you an opportunity to take advantage of your opponent's momentary failure.

After winning an opposed roll in a melee or ranged attack, the attacker may select a Combat Maneuver and apply its effects immediately before determining the DoS and calculating damage.

The attacker's rolled SLs must meet or exceed the Maneuver's SL requirement. The defender's SLs do not reduce the attacker's for this purpose. Rolled SLs include minimum SLs from Expertise and critical successes.

For determining damage, the defender's SLs still reduce the attacker's to produce the DoS, which then adds to the weapon's base damage (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, and Perils).

Some Combat Maneuvers have additional conditions--for example, Trip requires striking one of the target's Leg locations.

Note that you don't "spend" SLs on a Combat Maneuver. You merely have to roll well enough to meet its SL requirement.

Critical Benefits

If the attack was a critical success, add +3 SLs to the rolled number, and the attacker may perform 2 Combat Maneuvers, provided the roll meets the SL requirement for each. Each Maneuver is resolved in the order in which it is declared.

Simon rolls a 02 on his Melee: Medium attack. He has Ex3 in that skill, which improves his roll to 3 SLs. His opponent rolls a defense of 28 and succeeds with 2 SLs; Simon wins the exchange with 1 DoS. For the purposes of damage, he adds 1 to his weapon's base damage. However, because Combat Maneuvers are based on his rolled SLs, he can choose any Combat Maneuver requiring 3 SLs or less.

If this had been a critical success with a roll of, say, 33, Simon would add +3 to his rolled SLs (for 6 total, winning the exchange by 4 DoS) and could select 2 Combat Maneuvers, provided each one required 6 or fewer SLs.

Maneuvers Based on DoS

Some Combat Maneuvers--Cleave Shield and Compel Surrender--require the attacker to forgo all damage from the attack, and use the attacker's DoS rather than rolled SLs. This ensures that the defender's skill meaningfully resists attempts to destroy a shield or force a surrender.

If a critical success allows 2 Combat Maneuvers and one uses the DoS while the other does not, resolve each using its respective SL type.

For example, if Simon got 6 SLs from a critical, but his DoS was 4 (the enemy rolled 2 SLs), he could choose 2 Maneuvers; one might be based on his rolled SLs of 6, and the other (such as Cleave Shield) on his DoS of 4.

the combat maneuvers

Unbalance (UnB)

Requirements : 1 SL

Catch your opponent off guard. Cause a -20 disadvantage to the opponent's next skill roll (not including an Endurance roll to resist falling in Shock) by using the zone's features against them, or whatever narrative description makes sense within the context. Multiple instances of Unbalance on the same opponent don't stack.

Drive Back (DB)

Requirements : 3 SLs, Melee attack

Force your foe to yield ground. The attacker immediately moves a single Engaged enemy and themselves into an adjacent zone in any direction, or into a different part of the current zone. The attacker remains Engaged with that foe. If the defender is driven into a Rough zone (or a Rough part of the current zone), they must immediately make an Athletics roll opposed to the attacker's roll or fall Prone in the new zone. Can be performed after a Charge. Can be performed while Engaged with multiple enemies, who remain behind. For 4 SLs, the attacker may instead push the opponent out of the zone without following.

Lock (Lc)

Requirements : 3 SLs, Melee attack

Prevent an opponent from tactically retreating. On the target's next turn, they cannot perform a Fighting Withdrawal. If they wish to leave Engagement, they must instead use the Flee action. The effect ends if the attacker becomes Prone, Stunned, or moves out of Engagement. Targets more than two Sizes larger than the attacker cannot be Locked.

Pierce Armor (PA)

Requirements: 4 SLs, opponent in Reinforced Leather armor or better

Exploit a flaw or weak point in your opponent's rigid armor. The attack gains Piercing 3 on the struck location. This has no effect if that location has 3 AP or less (Leather, Quilt, or Padding). Any other Piercing the attack already has applies normally.

Choose Location (CL)

Requirements : Weapon Choose Location requirement in SLs

Strike a different location than the one rolled. Any of the target's other hit locations can be selected.

Circumvent Shield (CS)

Requirements : Weapon Circumvent Shield requirement in SLs

Slip your weapon or shot past the defender's shield. Bypass and ignore any shield AP .

Disarm (Dis)

Requirements : Weapon Disarm requirement in SLs, must strike an Arm location.

Knock a foe's weapon out of their hand onto the ground in front of them. Requires +1 SL to have the weapon land in a random adjacent zone; +2 SLs to disarm a two-handed weapon; +3 SLs to disarm a shield. Creatures with Natural Weapons cannot be Disarmed.

Trip (T)

Requirements : Weapon Trip requirement in SLs, must strike a Leg location.

Knock a foe Prone. Requires +3 SLs on a creature with four or more legs.

Shield Bash (ShB)

Requirements : Shield-user only, Small shield 7 SLs, Medium shield 6 SLs, Large shield 5 SLs.

Use a shield to knock an opponent down. The attacker knocks their opponent Prone, regardless of the struck hit location. This Combat Maneuver only works on creatures the same Size or smaller than the attacker. Requires +3 SLs on a creature with four or more legs.

Cleave Shield (ClSh)

Requirements : DoS, Melee attack, ClSh trait

Use a 2H weapon with the ClSh trait to destroy a shield in one hit. The attacker causes no damage to their foe with this attack, instead rolling a d20 and adding their DoS from the attack roll: on a result of 10+,

the weapon destroys a buckler or parrying dagger; on a 12+ a Small shield; on a 15+ a Medium shield; and on a 18+ a Large shield. This can be chosen regardless of struck hit location.

Compel Surrender (Com)

Requirements : 3 SLs, opponent disadvantaged
Force a disadvantaged enemy to surrender. The attacker causes no damage to their foe with this attack; hit location is irrelevant. The opponent must already be significantly disadvantaged (they have one or more 3+ point Wounds, are Prone, Disarmed, outnumbered, or are under any other disadvantaged condition that the GM decides). They must make a standard Willpower roll, with a -10 penalty for every 3 DoS the attacker earned on their attack roll (3-5 DoS: Willpower -10; 6-8 DoS: Willpower -20, 9+ DoS: Willpower -30). If they fail, they immediately surrender. PCs, animals, undead, non-sentient beings, and beings with Ferocity 5+ (GM's option) cannot be compelled to surrender this way. Using this Combat Maneuver with a ranged weapon might mean making a threatening shot near the foe's head or something similar.

Grapple (Gr)

Requirements : 3 SLs, Might attacks only, both hands must be free
Seize and restrain a foe in close combat. A successful Grapple inflicts unarmed NL damage and restrains the target.

- A All Might rolls against armed opponents suffer -20.
- A Costs +2 SL per Size category difference. Foes more than two Sizes larger or smaller cannot be Grappled. The larger combatant gains +20 per Size category difference on all Might rolls while grappling.
- A If initiated during a Charge, both combatants become Prone and drop all held items (including shields).

On their turn, a character engaged in a Grapple must drop everything except a dagger (free action) and choose one of the following:

- A Maintain Hold : Keep grip; no roll required.
- A Move : If not Prone, roll opposed Might or Athletics (attacker's choice) vs foe's Might or Athletics (their choice) to move both combatants one zone in a direction of the attacker's choosing.
- A Break Free : Opposed Might or Athletics vs. foe's Might. If unopposed, the Grapple ends.
- A Non-lethal Strike : Might attack (opposed by Might) to deal non-lethal damage (armor applies).
- A Draw Dagger : Might or Athletics roll to draw a dagger (Quickdraw does not apply).
- A Dagger Attack : Melee: Light (opposed by foe's Might, or Melee: Light if they also hold a dagger). Daggers gain Piercing 5 when used in a grapple.
- A Natural Weapons : May attack with Natural Weapons (opposed by foe's Might).
- A Cast Spell : A grappler is at -20 to cast a spell.

Grapple Limits:

- A Only the following Combat Maneuvers are allowed: Grapple, Choose Location, Unbalance, Disarm, Trip, Compel Surrender. If Trip is used, both grapplers become Prone.
- A No more than two participants can be involved in a single Grapple.
- A A grappling character cannot defend against attacks from outside the Grapple.
- A Attacks from outside suffer -20; a critical failure strikes the other grappler instead.

chapter 10: combat

situational rules

Attacking a Prone Opponent

You gain +20 to melee attack and defense rolls against a Prone opponent, but suffer -20 to ranged attack rolls against them. You may freely move away from a Prone opponent, even if Engaged. Attacks made with a dagger against a Prone target gain Piercing 5.

Being Prone

If you are Prone, you may attack and defend, but all Engaged enemies will get a +20 bonus against you. You may not move away, as you are still Engaged (but your enemies may freely move away from you). You may Rise from Prone as described earlier. You may drop Prone for free during your action. A Prone character who wishes to move may (if not Engaged) crawl 1 zone, using both their move and their action to do so.

Bigger Enemies & Combat Maneuver Costs

You cannot use Drive Back, Trip, Disarm, or Grapple against a creature three or more Sizes larger than you. Size refers to monster categories (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary).

Cover

Cover represents solid terrain that shields a character from ranged attacks, such as battlements, trees, carts, rubble, or thick stone. Ranged attacks made against a character who is behind cover suffer -20. Penalties from cover and Obscured Zones stack.

If solid terrain completely blocks an attacker's shot, the character cannot be targeted at all. If a character makes a ranged attack from such a position, they may be targeted normally until the start of their next turn, though the terrain may still impose -20 if it continues to shield them.

Cover does not affect hit location; a successful hit represents the moment the target exposes themselves or is struck at an angle.

Damaging Objects

To damage an object, make an attack roll and apply weapon damage as normal.

- A Stationary objects: Roll unopposed. On a failed roll, deal only base weapon damage.
- A Moving objects: Roll unopposed. On a failed roll, you miss.
- A Held objects: Roll opposed by the holder's relevant defense. Use Choose Location to target the object for normal damage. On a failed roll, no damage is dealt.
- A Combat Maneuvers cannot be used against objects.

Each object has a Destruction Threshold (DT), ranging from <=5 for a fragile item, to 40+ for a very strong item like a section of stone wall (see Item Destruction Threshold Table). A single hit that exceeds the DT destroys the object; otherwise, track cumulative damage until it exceeds the DT. Using the proper tool may add +1-6 damage depending on its suitability (a crowbar for a lock, a sledgehammer for stone, etc.).

Environmental Effects

Rain, heat, distractions, etc. These kinds of things can penalize a skill by -10 to -30, at the GM's discretion.

Item Destruction Threshold Table

Category	DT Range	Examples	Example Tool Effectiveness
Fragile	2-5	Glass, pottery, bows, small wooden items	+1: Rock, boot heel, dagger pommel
Wood	10-25	Furniture, doors, barrels, wooden shields, leather armor	+2: Hatchet, small hammer +3: Crowbar, handaxe
Metal	20-40	Swords, axes, locks, chainmail, steel shields	+4: Heavy hammer, prybar +5: Sledgehammer, pickaxe
Stone / Reinforced	40+	Strongboxes, plate armor, stone or brick walls	+6: Maul, mining pick

Shields and armor are given DT here as examples, but they're not really intended to be destroyed this way in a combat situation (seeChapter 9 - Equipment: Sundering Armor and Splitting the Shield).

Fighting from a Higher Elevation

Gain +10 to melee combat skill rolls versus an opponent at a lower elevation (fighting a foot soldier from horseback, occupying the high ground of a hill or an embankment, etc.).

Fighting with Might versus an Armed Opponent

Using Might to make an unarmed attack or defense against an armed foe, or Grappling them, is at -20. Creatures with Natural Weapons are considered armed. Might attacks do non-lethal damage.

Fighting with the Off-hand

Weapons used in the non-primary hand suffer a penalty of -20 (Parrying Daggers do not suffer this penalty).

Morale & Ferocity

Enemies have a Ferocity level (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary), which is the strength of their morale. It dictates the circumstances under which the enemy will flee or surrender. This is separate from but related to the Compel Surrender Maneuver, which lets skilled combatants force the decision early.

Mounted Combat

Movement & Control

Horses move 2 zones instead of 1 and can carry +12 Inventory ENC (in addition to the rider).

To spur a non-warhorse into combat, roll Ride as part of your move. On a failure, the horse refuses to move toward danger this round.

Combat Modifications

- Being Engaged with a target on foot grants +10 to Melee skills for higher elevation.
- When defending against ranged attacks while mounted, you may roll Ride instead of Dodge.
- When making ranged attacks from horseback, your attack skill is capped by your Ride.
- A 2H melee weapon cannot be used while on horseback.

Continues on next page...

Charging

A mounted Charge can move you from Short range to Engaged and grants +20 to the attack. If charging with a lance, and the attack inflicts any Wound Points, the lance may shatter depending on the roll:

- If the attack roll is even, the lance splinters on impact and cannot be used again.
- If the attack roll is odd, the lance holds and may be used for another charge.

Setting for Charge (Long Spear vs Lance)

When using a long spear or pike to Set for Charge against a Charging lancer, the spear attacks first.

- If the spearman hits, resolve the long spear at base damage 10 (instead of 6). If this inflicts any Wound Points, the charger, if able, still completes the attack but loses the +20 charge bonus (and, as per Wounds While Mounted, must make the Ride roll).

Wounds While Mounted

If you take a Wound while on horseback, make an immediate Ride roll. On a failure, you fall Prone to the ground.

Outnumbering

If, at the moment of a melee attack, Engaged individuals outnumber their foe, they each get a +20 to their attacks against the outnumbered foe. Outnumbering does not apply to ranged attacks. However, defending against a second or subsequent ranged attack in the same round gives a non-cumulative -20 penalty to each additional defense.

Edbert is Engaged with the pirate Corbin. Another pirate, Sully, is in the next zone, armed with a bill hook. Sully charges in, swinging his bill hook. At the moment of his Charge attack, Sully and Corbin will be Outnumbering Edbert. Sully will get +20 from the Charge, +20 from Outnumbering, and an additional +10 for his long Reach.

Slow Borgar and Pete the Tooth, pirate archers, appear at Short range and fire at Edbert. Borgar shoots first, and will not benefit from Outnumbering as he is a ranged attacker, but he will suffer a -20 penalty for firing into melee. Edbert defends against Borgar's shot normally, but when Pete fires, Edbert defends at -20.

Preparing the Battlefield

If the party has adequate time to prepare the area in which they expect to fight--setting up an ambush, fortifying a camp, studying the enemy's tactics, or otherwise gaining advantage--they may attempt to Prepare the Battlefield in a specific zone.

Anyone involved may make one appropriate skill roll. This could be a Lore or Adventuring skill, or any other reasonable choice based on the preparation described. The GM has final say, but creative use of skills should be encouraged. Magic skills cannot be used this way (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Zone Condition).

On a successful roll, the character creates a pool of Favor equal to 1 + 1 per 2 SLs earned. This Favor can be used by anyone in the zone, as long as the bonus is narratively justified.

Favor from preparation follows the normal rules for Favor: each point spent adds +10 to a skill value, up to a maximum of 3 per roll. Once the pool is spent, it is gone.

If Preparing the Battlefield to fortify a camp, resolve rest as normal, then gain 1 Fatigue (see Chapter 12 - Travel).

The party is defending their position at a ruined tower. They know a band of murderous brigands will arrive within the next few hours, so each member Prepares the Battlefield in a different zone.

Simon's player describes setting snares and camouflaged traps around the tower entrance. He rolls Survival and gets 3 SLs, granting a pool of 2 Favor for use in that zone. Any party member fighting there may draw from that pool for any roll, as long as they describe how it incorporates Simon's traps.

Meanwhile, Arn's player describes dragging the remains of old ale barrels from the tower's cellar and stacking them across the boulder-strewn path leading up to the entrance, creating an improvised barricade. He rolls Craft: Practical and scores 4 SLs, generating 3 Favor for that zone. Anyone fighting there can spend these Favor points to represent the barrels slowing or hindering enemies, gaining +10 per Favor used.

Reach Weapons

Gain +10 to combat skill rolls per point of Reach difference you have over your opponent. Weapons with a greater Reach can be Set for Charge against a Charging attacker.

Using a Lethal Weapon to Deal Non-lethal Damage

Take -10 to the attack roll, but mark any Wounds caused as "NL".

Option: Quick Combat Resolution

There might be times when the details of the enemies' wounds or the specifics of the tactics don't matter as much as the pace of the encounter. If so, consider Quick Resolution, where one successful PC roll resolves the conflict.

Describe what you want your character to achieve. Roll opposed skills. If you win the contest, you take your target out or achieve your stated intention. If they win, they damage you as per normal combat (or they achieve their intention, if it wasn't to damage you).

Think of this as "low level resolution": we are zooming out from the gory details in favor of a quick outcome. We can always zoom back into "high-res" and add in all the juicy, wound-y bits to savor the evisceration of our enemies. It's all about the pace you want to set.

On a dark winter's night in a high mountain chateau, Simon is making his escape. Running into a chamber, he is confronted by two mercenaries blocking a doorway that leads to an icy, snow-covered balcony. Here's the Quick Resolution version:

Simon declares he wants to overrun the two mercs, and they declare they are trying to wound him. Simon's player rolls an Athletics skill against the mercenaries' Melee skills. If Simon wins against both of them, he moves past them into a neighboring zone. If one or both of them win against his roll, they will do damage to him based on their rolled hit location, DoS, and weapon damage, likely stopping him from moving past them. Note that in that case, any SLs he generates on his Athletics skill will reduce their SLs for damage purposes, as this is considered a combat opposed roll.

cHAPTER 11:

wounds, healing,

Many things can hurt or kill you in the Broken Empires. In Chapter 10 - Combat, we learned how to land a hit; now we'll examine the consequences of that hit. In this chapter, we'll look at Wounds and their effects, how to tend and recover from such injuries, and the septic consequences of ignoring them.

Of course, wounds come from many more sources than just the weapons of your enemies. The Other Perils section covers the many additional ways in which a character can suffer damage, from falling to fire to fatigue.

Keywords In This Chapter

Cleanliness Modifier
Dying
External Damage
Impaired
Infection
Infection Check
Internal Damage
Lethal
Non-Lethal
Recovery Bonus (RB)
Resolve & Fatigue Recovery
Sepsis Check
Set a Recovery Bonus
Shock
Stabilize
Treatment
Wound Die
Wound Points (WP)

, & perils

wounds

Wounds can be lethal (from weapons, claws, etc.) or non-lethal (from fists, kicks, etc.). When a character takes physical damage, it is recorded as an individual wound, which is an injury to a specific part of the body. Each wound has its own Wound Points (WP), heals at its own rate, and is subject to infection. Individual wounds have immediate consequences, and there are only so many one can take before they cross the Death Threshold and die.

Types of Damage

There are two categories of damage: external and internal.

If the damage is external --such as a spear thrust or falling stones--Armor Points normally apply after any opposed roll is resolved. Shield AP may or may not apply, at the GM's discretion.

If the damage is internal --such as choking gas, poison, or falling--Armor Points do not apply.

And sometimes, a situation can bypass the idea of "damage" altogether and just cause a wound of some point value directly to a location.

Marking a Wound

A successful attack adds the attacker's DoS to the weapon's base damage. Unless the attacker performed the Choose Location maneuver, the attacker's ones die determines the General Hit Location of the strike (Body, Right Leg, etc.). The defender's ones die determines the Detailed Hit Location, specifying exactly where the wound is suffered. If the defender did not roll (due to being surprised, for example), the attacker rolls a d10 and consults the "Detailed" column on the Hit Location Table.

Subtract the location's Armor + any Shield AP from the incoming damage. The remaining amount is the WP of the wound. For example, an 8 damage hit against a total AP of 6 inflicts a wound of 2 WP (or "a 2-point wound").

- In the struck location's "Wounds" section, record:
  - The WP of the wound
  - The type of injury (slash, stab, bash, burn, etc.)
  - The Detailed Hit Location
- Mark a non-lethal wound as NL.
- Update the current total lethal WP from all locations.

A PC has suffered two wounds: the first in the Right Leg location (3 WP crushed Knee), and the second in the Body location (4 WP slashed Groin). The total lethal Wound Points are recorded as 7.

Hit Location Table

Ones Die	General Hit Location	Detailed d10 Roll	Detailed Hit Location
1-5	Body	1-5	Chest
		6-8	Stomach
		9-0	Groin
6-7*	Arm	1-2	Shoulder
		3-4	Bicep
		5	Elbow
		6-8	Forearm
		9-0	Hand
8-9*	Leg	1-2	Hip
		3-6	Thigh
		7	Knee
		8-9	Shin
		0	Foot
0	Head	1-2	Skull
		3-4	Eye*
		5-6	Face
		7	Nose
		8-9	Ear*
		0	Neck

*Even = Right, Odd = Left

The detailed location and "type of injury" in a wound description are mostly for narrative flavor. There is no mechanical difference between a stab, slash, burn, crush, or any other type of damage; nor is there a mechanical difference between a wounded Hand or a wounded Elbow, as they are both functionally just separate Arm wounds.

Although wounds are recorded in detail, they can be interpreted somewhat abstractly, too. For example, a 6-point non-lethal bash to the leg that impairs you might be recorded as a "shattered leg". It has no additional mechanical effects, but it helps picture and portray the injury in play.

The Wound Die

Although TBE's combat system doesn't result in a "death spiral" (where damage causes mounting skill penalties), every new wound does have the potential to impair the struck location, which can have immediate tactical effects.

When suffering a wound, immediately roll the Wound Die (a red d10) and add the character's Toughness. If the result is equal to or less than the new total Wound Points in the wounded location (from all wounds there), mark the location as Impaired.

If the roll is a natural 10 ("0") on the Wound Die, the location automatically avoids impairment, regardless of the location's Wound Point total.

Shock

Being in Shock means you drop Prone, still somewhat aware of your surroundings but unable to do much more than moan in pain. While in Shock, you are entirely at your opponent's mercy.

If any of a character's hit locations are Impaired a second time, they immediately drop in Shock (and also unconscious if from a Head impairment) for a number of minutes equal to the number showing on the failed Wound Die. A second Body impairment causes the character to immediately drop in Shock; there is no Endurance roll to avoid it. Once no longer in Shock, the character can act normally.

A PC can spend 3 Resolve to avoid dropping in Shock.

Option: Shorter Shock Time

If you want to lessen the fight-ending nature of Shock, make dropping in Shock last a number of rounds equal to the failed Wound Die face rather than minutes. This will likely draw out combats, however, as enemies can recover much more quickly and get back in the fight.

Or, if you want to be really generous, only apply this rule to the Player Characters.

Impaired

Impaired (IMP) refers to a part of the body that is no longer functioning optimally. The first time a location is Impaired, the character suffers the following effects:

First-Time Impairment Effects By Location

Body Succeed in an Endurance roll or drop in Shock for a number of minutes equal to the number showing on the Wound Die

	If the failed Wound Die number is...	
	Odd	Even
Arm	Drop any held item in that arm's hand (including a shield or a 2H weapon)	Drop any held item, and the arm is also rendered useless until the impairment is removed: weapons or shields cannot be held, and skill rolls dependent on that arm are impossible
Leg	Fall Prone	Remain standing, but Run or Charge actions cannot be taken under any circumstances until the impairment is removed
Head	Momentarily stunned; lose next action (can still defend and move, if possible)	Drop unconscious and in Shock for a number of minutes equal to the number showing on the Wound Die

Lethality Level

Your Lethality Level is how many total lethal Wound Points you can take before you are in danger of bleeding out while in Shock.

When a PC has dropped in Shock and their total lethal Wound Points across all hit locations are over their Lethality Level, they are Dying.

Dying

When a character is Dying, start tracking rounds. At the end of each round, the character must roll the Wound Die + Toughness. If the total is equal to or less than the number of rounds that have elapsed since they dropped in Shock (including the round in which they did so), the character dies.

A natural 10 ("0") on the Wound Die immediately Stabilizes the character: they are no longer Dying, regardless of WP (although they remain in Shock).

A PC can spend 3 Resolve to avoid the fatal result of a single failed Wound Die roll.

If the Heal skill is used to Stabilize the character (or their WP are otherwise reduced), and their total WP are reduced to their Lethality Level or below, the character is no longer Dying (although they remain in Shock).

You can be in Shock while not Dying, but you can't be Dying unless you're also in Shock.

Dying is a condition primarily concerning PCs or "important" NPCs (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary for more), as it gives a chance for friendly healers to save the Dying character's life.

Option: Instant Death

For those who really like to live on the edge, try the Instant Death rule: if the new wound would cause the total WP to exceed the character's Lethality Level, and the Wound Die rolls a natural "1", the character is instantly killed. Toughness has no effect on the natural "1". This only applies upon taking the new wound.

At the GM's option, the fatal result of a failed Wound Die roll can be nullified by spending 3 Resolve.

Rolling a "1" on the Wound Die when the Lethality Level is not exceeded may incur Impairment, but does not cause Dying and/or instant death.

Death Threshold

A character's Death Threshold is the amount of total lethal WP they can take; exceeding the Death Threshold means the character is immediately killed. This includes WP from all lethal wounds in all locations.

After buying the "Not Today, Death" Talent, Egbert's new Death Threshold is 23. If he ever takes a total of 24 lethal WP in any combination of locations, he dies.

Every time a character takes a new lethal wound, add its value to the Total Lethal WP taken.

Non-lethal Wounds

For a wound caused by non-lethal damage, mark the "NL" column next to that wound on the character sheet. Some weapons do non-lethal damage, as indicated in their description (see Chapter 9 - Equipment). Non-lethal wounds can cause a Wound Die roll for Impairment, but do not count against the Lethality Level, do not contribute to the Death Threshold, and cannot become infected (see Infection).

Thragg takes a 5-point NL wound from a quarterstaff to the Left Arm. He is already suffering a 4-point lethal slash in that arm. He must roll the Wound Die (against 9), but if he drops in Shock, the Dying condition would not apply, as his new NL wound does not count toward exceeding his Lethality Level of 8.

Dead Man Walking

If you want to model lethal injuries that take a while to finally kill you, consider this option. When you would have otherwise died by any means short of total disintegration or similar, and you are not Engaged in melee, you may survive just long enough to do something interesting, important, or cool. This could be stumbling away to warn your comrades in a nearby location; crawling to a desk to scrawl the name of your killer; or giving one last emotional and oh-so-inspiring speech in your dying moments.

Option: Critical Injury

Instead of dying from a bad Wound Die roll or from exceeding their Death Threshold, this option gives the character one more chance to survive, but with a critical injury.

Have the character roll their Endurance. If they fail, they die. If the character succeeds, instead pick the character's worst specific wound. That Wound's corresponding hit location is now permanently maimed, cut off, or rendered nearly useless. Suffer permanent penalties according to the chart below. Multiple effects are cumulative. The penalties may stack with any Amputation effects (see Amputation), depending on the type of critical injury. Furthermore, the affected skill or attribute can never be improved again. Depending on the location, death might be preferable...

Location	Critical Injury Effects
Body	-20 Endurance, -3 Initiative
Arm	-20 All Weapon skills
Leg	-20 Athletics and Dodge
Head	-20 Perception, -3 Initiative

Arn has 14 points of wounds: a 9-point Thigh wound in his left Leg, a 2-point Face wound on his Head, and a 3-point Hand wound on his right Arm. He has been Dying and in Shock for three rounds. At the end of the round, he rolls a 1 on the Wound Die, adds his Toughness of 2, for a result of 3: the same as the number of rounds that have elapsed. He would normally die here, but the GM is feeling generous and allows the player an Endurance roll. He succeeds and receives a critical injury instead. The worst specific wound Arn has is his Thigh wound; therefore, the GM decides his left Leg becomes maimed. Arn survives, but now walks with a pronounced limp; he takes a permanent -20 to all Athletics and Dodge rolls, and those skills can never be improved again.

healing wounds

The following rules apply to all uses of the Heal skill:

Reducing WP and Removing Wounds

- If a wound's Wound Points (WP) are reduced to zero by any method--Stabilizing, Treatment, Recovery, or magic--remove that wound from the character sheet.
- If a location has no remaining wounds, remove any Impairment affecting that location.
- Reducing lethal WP in any location also reduces the character's Total Lethal WP .

Medical Supply Use

After any Heal roll, whether successful or not, you must roll your Medical Supply Die:

- On a roll of 1-2, reduce the die one step (e.g., d8 to d6).
- A critical failure on the Heal roll automatically degrades the die one step.

Heal Limitations

- You may not Stabilize yourself, as you'd be in Shock. Otherwise, you may use Heal on yourself with no penalty.
- Only one healer may treat a patient at a time, though they can be assisted as per the Support rules.
- No Heal roll may be attempted if the healer is Engaged in melee.

the many uses of the heal skill

Stabilize the Dying

When a PC drops in Shock and their lethal Wound Points exceed their Lethality Level, they are Dying and have very little time left to live. A Heal roll can be made to Stabilize a Dying character.

- Stabilize can only be used on a Dying character.
- A successful Heal roll targets one specific wound.
- The roll takes one round's action and reduces that wound's WP by 1 per 2 SLs. The wound is not considered Treated (see below).
- As soon as a character's total lethal WP are reduced to the character's Lethality Level or below, the character is no longer Dying. Further wound reduction must be done through Treatment.
- If the healer fails a roll to Stabilize, they can try again next round, but if their Medical Supply runs out, no more Heal attempts can be made.

A character in Shock remains in Shock until a separate Heal roll is made to Remove Impairment, (see Remove Impairment & Shock).

Thragg takes a 5 WP crush to the knee in his left Leg and fails the Wound Die roll, leaving him with an Impaired leg. The next round, he takes a 5-point puncture in the left foot, and rolls a "1" on the Wound Die against the new left Leg WP total of 10. This second impairment drops him in Shock, and as his Total lethal WP are over his LL of 8, he is now Dying. He must roll the Wound Die + his Toughness at the end of the round, hoping not to roll a 1 (the elapsed round number). Thankfully, he has a Toughness of +2, so he'll be fine this round.

On her turn in the next round, Veil uses Heal on Thragg's 5-point knee crush to Stabilize him... and fails! She rolls the Medical Supply Die and gets a 5, so no loss there. At the end of the round, Thragg rolls the Wound Die + his Toughness against 2, as this is the second round since he dropped in Shock. His Toughness of +2 ensures that he'll succeed in this second elapsed round (as his minimum result would be a 3), but next round, things could get dicey.

Next round, Veil tries again on the knee wound. This time she rolls 6 SLs. That's a total of 4 WP that can be immediately eliminated from that wound, reducing it to 1 point. His new Total WP across all his hit locations is 6--below his Lethality Level of 8. He is no longer Dying, but still in Shock with an Impaired leg. Veil rolls a 2 on the Medical Supply roll from the Heal attempt, and must reduce her die type one step, to d10.

No more stabilization can be made to any other wounds on Thragg; he will have to wait for proper treatment to heal any more. Veil succeeds on two more Heal rolls to Remove Impairment on the Impaired leg, and to bring him out of Shock. Her Medical Die is rolled twice more, the last coming up 1, reducing it to a d8.

Remove Impairment & Shock

An Impaired location can have its functionality fully restored with a successful Heal roll.

- This takes an action and does not reduce any WP.
- On a success, uncheck the Impaired location's "Impaired" box, and no longer suffer any Impaired effects for that location.

A separate Heal roll must be made to bring a character out of Shock and/or unconsciousness.

- A character who comes out of Shock may rejoin a combat in the following round, rolling Initiative as usual.
- If a character is both Dying and in Shock, they must first be Stabilized before Shock can be treated.

Wound Treatment

Stabilizing is useful for the dying, but tending wounds after the emergency is over requires more time. Heal is used outside of combat as Treatment to reduce Wound Points and a wound's Recovery Bonus (RB).

Reduce WP

- Treatment cannot be used on a character who is Dying--they must be Stabilized first.
- Each Treatment roll targets one specific wound and takes 15 minutes.
- On a success, reduce the wound's WP by 1 + 1 per 3 SLs.

Set Recovery Bonus (RB)

The same Heal roll result used for Treatment sets the wound's RB, which affects future Recovery rolls (see Wound Recovery):

- Success: RB is +0, and +10 for every 3 SLs
- Failure: RB is -10
- Critical failure: RB is -30
- If untreated, the wound sets on its own after 1 hour with an RB of -20

Once a wound's RB has been set--whether by Treatment or time--it cannot be treated again. Further healing must occur through daily Recovery rolls or magic.

Continuing from the previous example, Veil now decides to treat Thragg's wounds in his left leg. He has a 1-point knee wound and a 5-point foot wound. She fails the Heal roll on the knee, which doesn't reduce the wound, but sets its Recovery Bonus to -10. After rolling her Medical Die, she tries to treat his punctured foot. She succeeds with 3 SLs, allowing her to remove 2 WP from it and set its RB to +10. She loses one step from her Medical Supply, reducing it to a d6. Thragg now has a treated 1-point wound and a treated 3-point wound. Time will have to take care of the rest, through successful Recovery rolls.

Treat Poison & Disease

If a victim is suffering non-wounding effects (like paralysis or nausea) from a poison or disease, a healer can make a Challenging (-10) Heal roll to reduce its remaining duration by half.

This roll may be attempted only once per instance of poison or disease. At the GM's discretion, some poisons may have effects that cannot be treated this way (see Other Perils: Poison for more details).

Treat Infection

The Heal skill can be used to eliminate infection from wounds (see Infection: Purging Infection).

infection

Infection is a real danger in the world of the Broken Empires. If a wound becomes infected, it could turn septic and prove deadly. Even the most experienced character can be brought down by a minor wound if it goes untended long enough for infection to set in.

The infection rules work slightly differently depending on when they apply (see Chapter 12 - Travel for full explanations of Journeys, HexMarches, Daily Time, and Events), but they are compiled here for your reference.

Option: No Infection

If you want to make your PCs a little less susceptible to a demeaning, lingering death choking on their own pus and sputum, ignore the infection rules. This will, however, have some ripple effects throughout the rest of the system... so be warned.

Marking Infection

When a wound becomes infected, mark the (INF) box beside its description.

Non-lethal (NL) and Fatigue-based wounds cannot become infected.

When to Check for Infection

There are four possible ways a wound can become infected:

- Having any lethal Wound Points while on a Journey
- Critically failing a Recovery roll during Daily Time
- Encountering an infection Event while traveling
- Suffering certain attacks

Infection on a Journey

After the party arrives at the destination hex of each leg of the Journey, any character with one or more lethal wounds must make an Infection check.

- Roll 1d20 (Infection Die) + Toughness.
- Compare the total to the character's total lethal Wound Points.
- If the result is equal to or less than this number, the uninfected lethal wound with the highest wound point value becomes infected. If two or more are tied, choose one.

Any character who has one or more infected lethal wounds after this check--including any wound that became infected because of it--must then make a Sepsis check (see Consequences of Infected Wounds).

Infection in Daily Time

A critical failure on a Recovery roll causes that wound to become infected.

Infection from an Event

While traveling, infection can strike suddenly as an Infection Event. When an Infection Event occurs:

- Anyone with one or more currently uninfected wounds must roll a d20 Infection Die + Toughness against:
  - The highest uninfected wound value + any Opposing Difficulty (if tied, pick one)
- If the result is equal to or under this number, that wound becomes infected.

Infection from an Attack

Certain creatures cause Infectious Wounds. Upon taking a new wound from a creature that causes infectious wounds:

- The target must roll a d20 Infection die + Toughness. If the result is equal to or less than the new wound's value, the wound becomes infected.

Purging Infection

Once a wound becomes infected, it must be purged or else the victim will eventually die (see Consequences of Infected Wounds). Each infected wound must be treated separately using a Heal roll. This process takes about an hour, as it requires gathering leeches, poultices, fresh water, and so on.

- If successful, the infection is purged. Remove the (INF) mark. The wound may recover normally.
- This Heal roll does not restore any Wound Points.

However, these purge attempts have limitations:

- On a Journey: Infection cannot be purged (unless through a special travel Event, or by shifting into Daily Time).
- During Daily Time: only one purge attempt may be made per infected wound per day.

Magical Purging

Magic (Weave or Divine) that restores Wound Points may also purge infection, depending on the nature of the spell (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic and Chapter 15 - Divine Magic). During Daily Time, magical healing may be attempted multiple times--but magic has its own risks. Spells that purge infection faster than natural healing require a higher Magnitude.

Consequences of Infected Wounds

An infected wound cannot heal naturally and makes no Recovery rolls until the infection is purged. But the true threat is that with each passing day, the infection grows more likely to fatally spread.

Checking for Sepsis

At the end of each day (or upon arrival in each leg's destination hex while on a Journey), a Player Character with any infected wounds makes a Sepsis check:

Roll a d20 Infection Die + Toughness against the Wound Points of all infected wounds. Only one roll is made per character, regardless of how many infected wounds they have.

- If the result is higher than the total infected WP, the infection holds steady for now; nothing worsens.
- If the result is equal to or less than the total infected WP, the infection has worsened and spread deeper into the body. The infected wound with the highest Wound Point value becomes septic, and the victim will die within 48 hours unless it is treated or amputated. During this time, they suffer a -30 penalty to all skills.

Practically speaking, having infected wounds of a total WP value equal to or less than your Toughness is merely an inconvenience that prevents wound recovery, rather than a danger that risks sepsis. If, for example, you have Toughness +3, with one infected 3-point wound, even rolling a 1 on the Infection Die gives a result over the current total infected WP, preventing sepsis.

Septic Wound Treatment

Once a wound has become septic, any Heal attempt on it (or suitable spell roll) is made at -10. Because the sepsis isn't fatal for 48 hours, the Heal skill can be attempted twice (once per day).

- If successful, the character survives, and that wound's infection is purged. Remove the (INF) mark. However, the character's Lethality Level is permanently reduced by 1.
- If both Heal rolls fail, a new emergency Heal roll may be made at -20 to save the character's life through amputation (see below). Otherwise, the character dies of sepsis.

Reminder: Only one Heal attempt may be made per infected wound per day. Second attempts by a different healer are not allowed. If a Heal roll fails on an infected wound, and that wound later becomes septic on the same day, it cannot be treated again until the next day.

Amputation

To try and save a character about to die of sepsis, an emergency -20 Heal roll can be made to amputate the septic location, removing everything from the specific location downward, as suggested by the hit location chart (i.e., an infected Elbow amputation would remove the Elbow, Forearm, and Hand; Body location infections can be carved out of the torso). This will save the patient's life, but will permanently affect their skills (see Amputation Effects). Only the Eye, Nose, Ear, and Face can be amputated from the Head; all other septic Head wounds are fatal. If the Heal roll fails, the patient dies.

Amputation Effects

After amputation, any affected skills or attributes can never be improved again.

If a hit location is entirely removed due to amputation, consider any hits to that location as a Body hit instead.

Amputation Effects Table

Part Removed	Cumulative Effects
Body (any)	Endurance -20; reduce Death Threshold by 3
Hand, either	Both Sleight of Hand and Locks & Traps -20
Hand, weapon arm	Can't use Weapon skills except Might (can add a hook for +1 lethal damage).
Forearm to Shoulder, shield arm	Can't use a shield
Forearm to Shoulder, weapon arm	Can't use weapons except in the off-hand (-20)
Foot, either	Athletics -20
Shin or above	Require crutch or prosthetic leg; can't Run or Charge; Ride -20
Eye or ear, either	Perception -20
Nose	Perception -10, Seduce -20
Face (Yikes..!)	Seduce -30, Intimidate +10

chapter 11: wounds, healing, &perils

rest & recovery

Rest is required for any kind of recovery, including healing individual wounds, regaining Resolve, and removing Fatigue. "Rest" means staying in one spot and getting at least several hours of solid sleep. The following section interacts heavily with the Travel rules, which are explored in the next chapter.

Wound Recovery

Wounds heal over time by making Recovery rolls , which may only be made while in Daily Time, or as the result of a specific Event while on a Journey (see Chapter 12 - Travel).

After a night's rest (or equivalent period of downtime), a wounded character may make one Recovery roll per uninfected wound (infected wounds do not make Recovery rolls; see Infection).

- A Use the wounded character's Endurance skill as the base chance.
- A Apply the wound's Recovery Bonus (RB), and any cleanliness modifiers (+20 to -20).
- A Resolve may be spent on Recovery rolls as usual.
- A Recovery rolls cannot be supported by another skill, except if being tended to by a healer.

Attending healers can make a difference to a recovering character. If tended by a healer, add double the healer's Heal Score to each of the wounded character's Recovery rolls.

- A The maximum number of characters a healer can tend to at any one time is equal to half the Heal Score (rounded down).
- A The healer must roll the Medical Supply Die once per character tended.
- A A character may benefit from only one healer in this way.

A healer who tends characters in this manner recovers less Fatigue during rest.

Recovery Roll Results

- A On a successful Recovery roll, reduce the wound's WP by 1 + 1 per 3 SLs . (Any extra points are wasted.)
- A On a critical failure, if the WP are lethal, the wound becomes infected (INF) .

Cleanliness Modifiers

Modify each Recovery roll further based on the cleanliness modifier of the place in which you're convalescing (ranging between +20 and -20, with +0 being average). A clean inn's private room might add +10 to all Recovery rolls, whereas a typical wilderness camp might cause a -10 penalty. A filthy troll-hole or your average "dungeon" might cause a -20, but a temple of Ilosia would give +20.

Resolve & Fatigue Recovery

While in Daily Time , both Resolve and Fatigue recover from rest. The rate depends on the danger level of the hex you are in (see Chapter 12 - Travel):

Area Type	Resolve Recovered	Fatigue Removed
Safe	All spent Resolve	Remove 3 Fatigue
Neutral	Up to 3 spent Resolve	Remove 2 Fatigue
Precarious	Up to 2 spent Resolve	Remove 1 Fatigue
Dangerous	Up to 1 spent Resolve	No Fatigue removed

- Removing any Fatigue through rest also allows you to remove the same number of WP from a Weary wound (see Other Perils: Fatigue-based Wounds).
- Rest also completely removes a Sleepless wound.
- Characters suffering from Fatigue due to lack of Rations cannot benefit from rest until they are able to make a Rations Supply roll or otherwise eat a reasonable amount. Doing so also removes a Deprived wound.

If you kept watch, fortified the camp, or tended the wounded with Heal (see Chapter 12 - Travel), benefit from rest as normal, then gain 1 Fatigue.

Simon keeps watch in a Neutral hex:

If he begins the rest period with 0, 1, or 2 Fatigue, rest would normally leave him at 0, but keeping watch causes him to awaken with 1 Fatigue.

If he begins with 5 Fatigue, rest removes 2 Fatigue as normal, reducing him to 3. Having kept watch then adds 1 Fatigue, so he awakens with 4 Fatigue.

In either case, he also recovers up to 3 spent Resolve.

Resolve and Fatigue can only be restored through rest (although some Divine magic can eliminate Fatigue).

If the party is resting in a safe place, have access to ample supplies, and are in no real hurry to leave, the GM may simply declare that enough time passes for all wounds, Resolve, etc., to simply heal completely with no Recovery rolls necessary.

magical healing

Weave-based Healing

- The standard Bind + Strand combination to heal is Conjure Body (Instant Duration).
- A Weave-magic-based healing spell must target a specific wound.
- Wounds healed with Weave magic are considered permanently healed, as if by natural Recovery rolls.
- Magical healing does not reset a wound's existing Recovery Bonus.
- If used on a fresh wound (with no RB) and the spell doesn't fully heal it, the wound gains an RB based on the caster's Magic skill roll SLs, just like with Treatment.

Edbert has taken a Chest Stab 4 with an existing RB of +10. A friendly Spellweaver heals 3 points to his Chest wound, reducing it to 1. That was an old wound that was already treated, so he keeps the currently set RB.

If he took the chest wound within the last hour--before it has set on its own--and the Spellweaver heals 3 out of 4 WP, there is still a 1-point wound. The RB is set based on the caster's Bind roll; if he rolled 2 SLs, it would be set to +0.

Weave Magic can also remove any infections in the wound if accounted for by the spell's cost (see Infection, and also Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Heal Damage Effect).

Weave magic cannot be used to restore spent Resolve points, nor to remove Fatigue.

Divine-based Healing

Unlike Weave magic, Divine magic applies healing to any combination of wounds or Wound Points. Divine magic can remove Fatigue, but can never restore spent Resolve.

A priestess of Ilosia prays for healing and gets 5 SLs on the Piety roll. As per the Healing domain Middle miracle (see Chapter 15 - Divine Magic), she removes 5 WP in any combination from any of Edbert's wounds, and each wound receives +10 RB if it didn't already have a Recovery Bonus.

Natural Healing Potions

Craft: Practical can be used to concoct herbal potions to reduce WP . This requires gathering ingredients in the wilds, then brewing the potion.

Gathering the Ingredients

- A It takes half a day's searching in the wild to make a gathering roll by making either a Naturewiseor a Challenging (-10) Survival roll.
- A Apply modifiers for the terrain being searched and the current season.
- A The gathering roll determines the quality of ingredients found (see Found Ingredient Quality chart).
- A Repeated foraging in the same map hex within a single season imposes a -20 cumulative penalty per additional attempt.

Brewing the Potion

- A It takes another half a day and a Craft: Practical roll to brew the potion. Critical failure wastes the ingredients.
- A The SLs generated, plus the brewing bonus of the ingredients, equal the total number of WP the potion can heal.

Using the Potion

- A Healing from a natural potion is applied within one minute of consumption.
- A The potion remains usable until its full WP potential is expended.
- A Each potion's healing may be divided among any number of wounds, but no single wound can benefit from more than one dose of natural healing potion per day, regardless of variant (see Variant: Recovery Roll Potion).
- A Potions do not set or alter a wound's Recovery Bonus (RB), and they do not count as medical treatment.
- A Potions provide no benefit to infected wounds.
- A Potions have no effect on a Dying character until they have first been Stabilized.
- A Natural healing potions affect only physical wounds eligible for Recovery rolls, not Weary, Deprived, or Sleepless wounds.

Variant: Recovery Roll Potion
An easier-to-make variant of this potion (+20 to Craft: Practical to brew) allows additional Recovery rolls to be made by the user instead:

- A Instead of directly healing WP , it grants Recovery rolls equal to the Craft: Practical SLs + brewing bonus.
- A For each dose consumed, the user may make one immediate Recovery roll per treated wound. Only a single dose is effective per wound per day.

Anti-infection Poultice
A single-use anti-infection poultice can be made from natural ingredients. Gather ingredients and make a Craft: Practical roll to brew, as above.

- A If the user has any wounds, the poultice grants a bonus of 1 + 1 per 3 SLs from the Craft roll to the user's next Infection Die roll , after which the poultice loses its effectiveness.
- A Ingredient rarity has no effect.

Healing Potion Gathering and Brewing

Terrain Modifiers (Gathering Roll Difficulty)

Terrain	Modifier
Forests, Riverbanks	+20
Marshes, Coasts	+10
Plains, Hills	0
Mountains	-10
Barren Wastes, Deserts	-20
Blighted Land (eg., Grey Wailing)	-30

Seasonal Modifiers (Gathering Roll Difficulty)

Season	Modifier
Spring	+20
Summer	+10
Autumn	0
Winter	-20

Found Ingredient Quality

Gathering Roll SLs	Ingredient Rarity	Brewing Bonus
1-2	Common	+0
3-4	Uncommon	+1
5-6	Rare	+3
7+	Very Rare	+6*

*or special properties, GM's discretion

Healing Herb Examples and Gathering Modifier by Terrain Type

Forests / Riverbanks (+20)

Ashroot, Common: A gnarled root with ashen-grey skin and fibrous veins.

Sunberry, Uncommon: Small golden berries in tight clusters, glossy and bright.

Rivermint, Rare: Sharp-scented green leaves with jagged edges.

Willowbind , Very Rare: Long, ribbon-like strands hanging from low branches, slick with clear sap.

Marshes (+10)

Bloodfern, Common: Crimson fronds with serrated leaves that bead with red sap when cut.

Bog Sage, Uncommon: Grey-green stalks topped with fuzzy, downy leaves.

Adder's Tongue, Rare: Thin, forked fronds shaped like a serpent's tongue, pale green.

Rotbulb , Very Rare: A swollen, half-submerged bulb with mottled skin, pulsing faintly beneath the water.

Plains / Hills (+0)

Ironleaf, Common: Stiff, dark green leaves veined with a metallic sheen.

Saffronweed, Uncommon: Slender stems with bright yellow, star-shaped flowers.

Stoneblossom, Rare: Small white flowers blooming low to the ground amid rocky soil.

Windreeds , Very Rare: Tall, hollow stalks that whistle softly in the wind, pale gold in color.

Mountains (-10)

Frostmoss, Common: Pale, crystalline moss that sparkles faintly in the cold.

Silverthorn , Uncommon: Thorny shrub with silvery leaves that shimmer faintly in light.

Goat's Rue, Rare: Hardy green herb with small purple blossoms and a bitter scent.

Cliffwool , Very Rare: Dense, wool-like growths clinging to sheer rock faces, off-white and tightly bound.

Barren Wastes / Deserts (-20)

Gravetongue, Common: Withered, tongue-shaped leaves, grey and leathery.

Ash Bloom, Uncommon: Ash-grey flowers with curling petals, dusted with fine powder.

Dune Thistle, Rare: Thick, spiny succulent with pale yellow blooms.

Glasswort , Very Rare: Translucent, brittle stems growing in jagged clusters, glinting like glass.

Blighted Land (-30)

Nightblossom, Common: Black-petaled flower that unfurls only under low light.

Ghostcap, Uncommon: A pale white mushroom with a powdery surface.

Witch's Teeth, Rare: A blackened stalk with thorny ridges and twisted growths.

Veinrot Creeper , Very Rare: A black, vein-like vine that spreads across the ground, faintly twitching.

other perils

Acid

Normal acid damage ranges from 1-10. Anything beyond that represents supernaturally caustic acid.

Acid used as a weapon (typically in a thrown vial) can eat away armor and flesh. If the defender fails to Dodge the ranged acid attack, they suffer the acid's damage. Do not add the attacker's SLs to the acid damage, though the attacker may Choose Location for 5 SLs.

If the attacker critically fails their thrown attack, they take the acid damage instead, to a location indicated by the ones die of their failed attack.

Acid first does its damage directly to the Armor Points (if any) of the struck location. This may include the shield if the defender chooses, in which case the shield takes the damage first, with any remaining damage spilling over onto the armor. This damage reduces the AP of the shield and/or armor. A piece of armor that has its AP reduced to zero is useless until repaired; a shield so reduced is destroyed. Any damage exceeding AP does an Acid wound to the target. Shields cannot be Split nor armor Sundered as a response to an acid attack.

Acid as Zone Hazard

Anyone starting in, entering, or moving through an acid-based Damaging zone (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Zone Hazards) must make an immediate opposed Athletics roll against the acid's damage; each SL reduces the damage by one. Acid damage is based on its type and concentration (and on how cruel the GM is feeling).

Most "environmental" effects like acid, lightning, or fire do external damage, meaning AP from armor (and sometimes shield, if appropriate) protects, after any resistance roll is made to reduce.

Blinded/Deafened

Becoming blinded causes all skills requiring sight to roll at -50. Ranged attacks are impossible while blind. Becoming deafened does the same with all skills requiring hearing and speaking, including casting any Weave spells or asking your god for a miracle.

Cold & Freezing

Very cold temperatures from mundane sources like the weather cause 1 Fatigue for every day of exposure.

Extreme, bitterly cold temperatures instead cause a 1d3 point wound to a random location every hour of exposure. Mark the wound as Frostbite. Armor does not protect, but if the character has appropriate winter gear, they can make a Gear roll to avoid the damage for one day.

Ice as Zone Hazard

Anyone starting or moving into the zone must make an immediate Athletics roll to avoid slipping and falling Prone. Very icy conditions can increase the difficulty.

Drowning & Suffocation

Submersion in liquid or certain gaseous particles can cause you to drown or asphyxiate. By default, you can hold your breath for a number of rounds equal to your Endurance skill Score.

After this period, make an Endurance roll. Each subsequent round, take a cumulative -10 to the roll (-10 on the second roll, -20 on the third, -30 on the fourth, etc.). After the first failure, you fall unconscious. After the second, you die. This can apply to water, severe smoke, or other inhalants.

Water as Zone Hazard
Anyone starting in or moving into the zone cannot Run or Charge. If the water fills the zone, they may need to resist drowning, as above. To move out of a water-filled zone takes an entire turn of swimming and requires an Athletics roll.

Gas as Zone Hazard
There are various effects a gas Hazard can have. Anyone starting in or moving into the zone must make an immediate Endurance roll or suffer the specific gas's effects.

Falling Damage

Falling or similar environmental concussive effects cause internal damage to a random location and render you Prone.

Falling Between...	Causes
5-10'	1d6-point wound (non-lethal)
11-20'	2d6-point wound (lethal)
21-40'	3d10-point wound (lethal)
40-60'	4d10-point wound (lethal)
60-80'	6d10-point wound (lethal)
81'+	Death

Fatigue

Fatigue limits the maximum Resolve available. It is gained under several circumstances, mostly when traveling.

Fatigue is marked on the Resolve track, from right to left, with an "X" for every Fatigue taken. Fatigue can only be removed by taking the time to rest or finding Event opportunities.

Fatigue-based Wounds

Taking additional Fatigue when your Resolve track is already filled causes Fatigue-based wounds. These kinds of wounds:

- are lethal, counting toward both Death Threshold and Infection checks;
- never become infected themselves;
- never cause more than a single instance of their type (you can never have more than one Weary wound, for example);
- do not require a Wound Die roll when first taking them or when increasing them;
- increase by 1 point whenever you would take any amount of Fatigue you cannot mark because your Resolve track is already filled;
- cannot be treated with Heal, or make Recovery rolls.

Weary

Fatigue is commonly suffered when traveling. If your entire unspent Resolve is filled with Fatigue, and you suffer any amount of additional Fatigue, instead mark a 1-point Weary wound to the Body location. This wound can only be reduced by resting. If you remove any amount of Fatigue by resting, remove an equivalent amount of WP from a opposed Weary wound.

> Simon's Resolve track is full, and over the course of this Journey, he has accrued a 2-point Weary wound. The next Fatigue Table roll of "Arduous" instructs him to take 3 Fatigue. Since he cannot take any more Fatigue, he increases his Weary wound by 1 point, to 3 WP.
>
> Later, a night's rest in a Neutral area (see Resolve and Fatigue Recovery) allows him to remove 2 Fatigue "X"s from his Resolve Track. He may also reduce the Weary wound by the same amount, to 1 Wound Point (3-2=1).

Deprived

Food and water deprivation while on a Journey is handled solely by taking Fatigue.

However, going a full day without rations (as in Daily Time) causes 1 Fatigue, and that person cannot benefit from resting at all until after they eat and drink.

If your entire unspent Resolve is filled with Fatigue, and you suffer any amount of additional Fatigue from lack of rations, instead mark a 1-point Deprived wound to the Body location. This wound is only removed when the character can make a Rations Die roll or is otherwise provided with food and drink.

Sleepless

Going a 24-hour period without sleep, and every eight hours of sleeplessness after that, causes 1 Fatigue.

If your entire unspent Resolve is filled with Fatigue, and you suffer any amount of additional Fatigue from lack of sleep, instead mark a 1-point Sleepless wound to the Head location. This wound is only removed when the character can get eight hours of uninterrupted sleep.

Fear

When confronting a frightening creature, make an opposed Willpower roll against the creature's Fear Rating (a fixed number). If you succeed, you are unaffected for the duration of the conflict.

If you fail, you have a choice: Fight, Flee, or Fall. Roll again at the start of each of your turns while you are still in the creature's vicinity. If you win, you have mastered your fear: you can act normally and do not need to make further Willpower rolls against that creature's Fear Rating for the rest of the encounter.

If Fight is chosen, the character must do nothing but attack the source of fear with wild, crazed desperation until it is destroyed or otherwise no longer an influence: all rolls (except further Willpower rolls to beat the fear) are at -20. In addition, no Combat Maneuvers may be performed. The character may spend Resolve only on actions that directly harm or affect the source of the fear; Re-

solve may not be spent on Willpower rolls to break free of the fear.

If Flee is chosen, the character moves immediately and with all haste as far away from the source of fear as possible. No other actions may be performed. This effect lasts until either the character can no longer perceive the source of fear with any of his senses, or they succeed at a Willpower roll while fleeing; success immediately ends the fear, even if the source is still perceived. If the fear ends because the character can no longer perceive the source, and the character later comes back into contact with it during the same encounter, a new opposed Willpower roll must be made.

If Fall is chosen, the character drops Prone, huddled in a cowering ball of ignominy. They cannot perform any action except to defend themselves, although most enemies will ignore a cowering character. The Fallen character will remain in this state until they can no longer perceive the source of fear with any of their senses; the opposed Willpower roll succeeds; or when someone else takes an action to make a successful Inspire roll versus the Fear Rating.

Magic that causes fear has a Duration. An individual stops suffering from magical fear effects once the spell's Duration comes to an end.

Some circumstances make one resistant or immune to Fear. These are usually magic-related, or situational (a mother defending her children might not be subject to fear; these situations are always up to the GM to adjudicate).

Fire

Fire damage causes a Burn wound to the affected location(s). Fire does external damage based on its size, as shown here:

Damage	Size of Fire
1	Small open flames
10	Bonfire
15	Burning building
30+	Conflagration; a portal to Hell

Fire as Zone Hazard

Anyone starting in or entering a burning Damaging zone must make a single opposed Athletics or Dodge roll vs the zone's fixed damage to reduce. Any unreduced damage is applied to each of one or more appropriate hit locations. Smaller fires like campfires can be Damaging zones unto themselves.

Catching Fire

Flammable objects or clothing may ignite and continue inflicting damage, although at a lower intensity (GM discretion).

Fire Spreading in a Zone

Fire tends to spread. Every round, for each burning zone, roll 1d20. If you roll the burning zone's damage value or less, and if neighboring zones are combustible, it spreads to one adjacent combustible zone. If neighboring zones aren't combustible, the burning zone's damage increases by 2 instead. A fire started by magic will continue to burn after its duration expires, as long as there is fuel in the zone.

Lightning and Electricity

Mundane lightning and electricity (rare though it is) typically do 10 damage to the Body location, which can be reduced by an opposed Endurance roll. Mark the wound Electricity. Only Padded, Quilt, or Leather armor offers protection against electricity. Shields offer no protection.

Electricity as Zone Hazard

Anyone starting in or entering the zone must make an opposed Endurance roll against the electrical damage to reduce (armor protects as above).

Poison & Disease

Poisons and diseases use this standard presentation for their stats:

Skill vs X (DoS if applicable) | Effect | Delivery | Onset

- A vs X: The character must meet or beat X SLs or suffer the full effect.
- A DoS: The character's SLs reduce X, and the remainder becomes the severity or duration.
- A Effect: The result if not resisted.
- A Delivery: How it enters the body.
- A Onset: How long before the effects take hold.

Some diseases include an Initial Resistance, a standard roll made before the main effect. If the initial roll succeeds, the character avoids the disease entirely. If it fails, apply the rest of the effect line.

Poison

Poison can be delivered by ingestion as food or drink, injection by fang or coated weapon, inhalation as a gas, or (extremely rarely) upon skin contact. It can cause wounds, paralysis for a round/minute/hour/day duration, deep sleep for the duration, or many other effects.

A wound caused specifically by poison is marked as Poison to the location that received it. If the poison was ingested or inhaled, the wound is to the Body.

Some ongoing, non-wounding effects of poison can have their current durations halved by a healer (see Treat Poison).

Specific poison sources can be searched for and harvested using Poison-wise (or Naturewise at -20). Harvested materials can be turned into a usable poison using Craft: Practical. Use the rules under Natural Healing Potions as a guide. The Craft: Practical roll produces a number of doses of the specific poison equal to 1 + 1 per 3 SLs.

Poison applied to a weapon is used up the first time a wound is caused, regardless of whether the target resists the poison's effects.

Example Poisons

Shadowshade

Endurance DoS vs 6 | Suffer up to 6 internal damage, reduced by SLs | Weapon coat | Instant

A powerful venom derived from a rare plant found only on the eastern slopes of the Grande Eastern Mountains.

Iceblood

Endurance DoS vs 2d4 | Paralysis for (result × 10 minutes) | Ingestion | 1 minute

An odorless, tasteless liquid that locks the body stiff when swallowed.

Slumberpede Extract

Endurance vs 1 | Fall into deep sleep for 1 hour on failure | Ingestion | 1 minute

Distilled from the gas glands of subterranean slumberpedes; failure means sudden collapse into a death-like sleep. An ally can attempt a standard Heal roll at -20 every 10 minutes to rouse the sleeper.

Diseases

Diseases follow the same stat-line format as poisons, but may include an Initial Resistance roll before infection takes hold. If successful, the disease does not take hold.

Example Diseases

Black Spores

Endurance vs 2 | On failure, 1d4 uninfected wounds become Infected | Inhalation | Within 1 day

Released by the Nightsbane swamp plant, Black Spores take root in open wounds.

Blood Cough

Initial Resistance: Endurance. Upon Infection: Endurance DoS vs 10 days | -30 to Athletics, Endurance, and Perception for (10 days minus DoS) | Proximity | 6 hours.

A wasting fever that leaves the victim weak, trembling, and coughing blood.

Death's Door

Initial Resistance: Endurance (Hard -20). Upon Infection: Endurance DoS vs 10 | Reduce Death Threshold by (10 minus DoS) for 2d6 days | Proximity | 1 day

A dreadful communicable disease that causes the victim to become sallow and gaunt, bringing them closer to death. If an already-wounded victim has their DT reduced below the total value of their current lethal Wound Points, they die.

Traps

Traps are a common peril in old ruins, enemy camps, etc., but what is really important is that traps feel like obstacles and not penalties. As a player, there's nothing less fun than getting hit with a trap that the party had absolutely no chance of discovering before it went off. To this end, a good trap--from a player's perspective--should offer at least some degree of foreshadowing: a sign of its presence and a chance, however small, for the PCs to detect it before it goes boom. On the other hand, adventurers who carelessly blunder through ancient dungeons get exactly what they deserve...

Each trap is listed with both Perception modifiers for spotting it and Locks & Traps modifiers for disarming it. A trap can normally be spotted by a reflexive Perception check before the trap triggers. If a player specifically states that their character is looking for traps in the area and describes how they are doing it, at your discretion, give them a +10 or 20 to the roll (or if their described search would obviously reveal the trap, allow them to discover it without a roll; again, at your discretion). Failing a disarming attempt usually sets the trap off. Most traps are one-use, but some more advanced traps reset themselves after activation.

Traps will either do internal damage (no AP applies) or external damage (AP applies; each trap will indicate if shield AP also applies).

Traps use the following standard presentation for their stats:

Perception Mod | Locks & Traps Mod Resistance Skill | Effect | Trigger

Example Traps

Slippery Floor

Perception Simple +20 | Locks & Traps N/A | Athletics | Prone | Walking over area

The floor is covered with a thin layer of oil, wax, or wet slime. Anyone walking over it must succeed on a standard Athletics roll or slip and fall prone. Nearby ambushers could take advantage of the

Prone individuals when launching an attack. Removing the substance will take time and Gear Dice rolls, which will slow the party down and may make them targets for ambushers or wandering enemies.

Pit Trap, Shallow

Perception Easy +10 | Locks & Traps N/A | Athletics (+10) | Internal falling damage (1d2) | Walking over area

A shallow pit (3-4 feet deep) is covered with loose debris or a thin layer of dirt. Anyone stepping on it and failing an Easy (+10) Athletics roll falls in, receiving 1d2 internal damage to a random leg. Once discovered, the covered pit takes only a few minutes to clear.

Swinging Net

Perception Medium +0 | Locks & Traps Medium +0 | Might DoS vs 3 | Immobilized | Trip wire or pressure plate

A large, camouflaged net swings down from above when triggered, attempting to entangle 1d4 characters in the zone. Affected PCs must make a Might DoS roll vs 3 or be Immobilized for the difference in rounds.

Poisoned Dart Trap

Perception Challenging -10 | Locks & Traps Medium +0 | Dodge; then Endurance DoS vs 4 | -20 Combat skills 1 hr per difference | Pressure plate

A hidden mechanism fires darts coated with poison, striking 1d4 characters if triggered. Victims may roll a standard Dodge to avoid the hit. On a hit, the target takes no damage but must roll Endurance DoS vs 4 or be poisoned, suffering -20 to Combat skills for 1 hour per difference. The trap holds enough darts for 10 activations.

Poisoned Needle Chest Trap

Perception Challenging -10 | Locks & Traps Medium +0 | Endurance DoS vs 4 | 1 Poison WP per difference | Tampering

A poisoned needle pierces the hand (and armor) of anyone tampering with the lock. The victim must roll Endurance DoS vs 4. On failure, take a 1-point Poison wound per difference in the hand.

Collapsing Ceiling

Perception Hard -20 | Locks & Traps Challenging -10 | Dodge | 1d6+1 damage | Pressure plate

A section of the ceiling is rigged to collapse when triggered. Anyone underneath must make a standard Dodge roll to avoid being crushed. Failure results in 1d6+1 external damage to a random location and being pinned under debris for a round.

Acid Trap

Perception Challenging -10 | Locks & Traps Challenging -10 | Dodge | 1d6 acid damage | Tripwire or pressure plate

A hidden flask or vial of acidic material explodes when triggered, dealing 1d6 acid damage to a random location to everyone in the zone. Each target may roll a standard Dodge to avoid. Armor and Shield AP protects, but lose 1 AP per point of acid damage stopped (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Acid).

Forgetfulness Gas Trap

Perception Hard -20 | Locks & Traps Challenging -10 | Willpower | Amnesia for 15 minutes | Pressure plate

A blast of gas fills the zone, forcing everyone in it to make a standard Willpowerroll or forget everything that has happened in the last 15 minutes. This is a clever trap that prevents tomb robbers from getting through secret doors, as they immediately forget where they are.

Flame Jet Trap

Perception Challenging -10 | Locks & Traps Hard -20 | Dodge DoS vs 1d6+2 external damage | Pressure plate

A concealed mechanism releases a burst of fire from hidden vents, catching those in a narrow hallway or room (the zone). The fire does 1d6+2 external damage vs Dodge DoS to a random location. Armor AP protects, but Shields do not.

Pit Trap, Deep

Perception Hard -20 | Locks & Traps N/A | Athletics | 2d6 falling damage | Concealed pit

A deep pit (10-20 feet) is concealed under a false cover. Anyone triggering it must roll a standard Athletics. Failure results in falling, taking 2d6 internal damage to a random location, and possibly ending up in a dangerous position at the bottom.

Hallucinatory Gas

Resets, Perception Hard -20 | Locks & Traps Hard -20 | Endurance DoS vs 4 | -30 all skills, 1 round per difference | Pressure plate

A hidden valve releases hallucinatory gas. All in the zone must roll Endurance DoS vs 4. Victims suffer vivid illusions for 1 round per difference, taking -30 on all skills.

Gargoyle Statues

Resets, Perception Medium +0 | Locks & Traps Severe -30 | Dodge vs attack | 5 + DoS damage | Close proximity or opening a door

Five stone gargoyles are set into the walls. Triggering the trap causes their ancient curse to take effect, as they animate and unleash a flurry of attacks. Each PC in the zone suffers one Monstrous claw attack (75/5, no maneuvers). Victims may only roll Dodge to defend. The statues reset after striking. Each gargoyle has DT 30; damaging them without disarming the trap causes reactivation.

Arcane Rune Trap

Perception Medium +0 | Locks & Traps N/A, but can be disarmed with a Hard -20 Arcana | Willpower DoS vs 12 | 1 external damage per difference | Close proximity

A faintly glowing rune on the ground explodes with magical energy. Everyone in the zone must roll Willpower DoS vs 12 external damage. On failure, suffer 1 damage per difference to one random location. Armor protects; Shields do not.

Cursed Mirror Trap

Resets, Perception Severe -30 | Locks & Traps Severe -30 | Willpower vs 4 | -20 Willpower rolls for 1 day; 1d4 damage to head and paralyzed on critical fail | Glancing at mirror

A large ornate mirror mounted on the wall curses anyone who gazes into it. The magic within the mirror ensures it cannot simply be smashed. Victims must roll Willpower vs 4. On failure, suffer -20 to all standard and opposed Willpower rolls for 1 day. On a critical failure, also take 1d4 psychic internal damage to the Head and fall paralyzed with fear for 1 minute (Inspire cannot break the effect).

Zone Hazards

Zone features that can cause restrictions or dangers when encountered are known as Zone Hazards: Confined, Rough, Obscured, Blocked, Damaging, or Other (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Zone Hazards for full rules).

cHAPTER 12:

tra vel

Travel can be one of the most satisfying and exhilarating aspects of the fantasy roleplaying game experience. It is also, tragically, one of the most underused and underappreciated, despite being a staple of so many flavors of fantasy.

What would The Lord of the Ringshave been if Tolkien had just skipped past "all that travel stuff "? A book about ten pages long, is what; a thin and stretched experience, like butter scraped over too much bread. Instead, we get one of the richest and most epic fantasy experiences of the modern age. Elric of Melnibone's entire saga takes place while wandering the Young Kingdoms; his story would be so much less interesting if he had never left the Dragon Isle. The epic journeys in A Song of Ice and Firereveal a robust, breathing world spread across a vast and meticulously detailed landscape, bringing us deeper into the story with every step. So it can be in an RPG. Travel is the very stuff of which adventure is made.

Keywords In This Chapter

Daily Time
Daily Time Rolls
Events
Fatigue
Forced March
Guide
Hex
Hex Danger Level
HexMarch
Infection Check
Journey
Leg
Quartermaster
Scout
Sepsis Check
Travel Lore

two separate systems

There are two different methods by which to travel the Broken Empires. They share similar procedures, but have different focuses:

The Journey system abstracts many elements to portray a long trek toward a predetermined destination (typically at least 100 miles through the wilderness). Characters take on specialized travel duties and carefully manage their various resources to reach their destination with as little Fatigue as possible. Journeys hold many risks; while traveling, wounds do not heal, and infections may grow worse. However, there will generally also be fewer Events to deal with. A Journey is for when the focus is distance, not daily detail.

The HexMarch, on the other hand, provides a more granular experience intended for shorter excursions or for intentionally exploring the wilderness. It is focused on the daily rigors of travel: trudging along hex-by-hex; keeping watch at camp; enduring changing weather; making Ration, Wound Recovery, and Hostile Encounter rolls; dealing with more frequent Events; and others. A HexMarch is for when the party wants to experience the wilderness step by step, rather than focus on a distant destination.

But whether you're running a full Journey or covering a short stretch on a HexMarch, treat each moment of travel as a chance to bring the world to life. The Travel rules exist to keep the game dynamic and immersive, not to bog the game down in tedious dice rolls or bookkeeping. They're opportunities to make the Broken Empires, its people, and its dangers feel real as the party experiences them.

chapter 12: travel

travel basics

Each hex on the overland map represents 10 miles and shows a terrain type, which influences the party's Fatigue.

The party chooses a destination and charts a course to it, planning a route, hex by hex. Different paths may offer different risks, terrain, or strategic advantages (such as access to Safe areas to rest).

Before setting out, the party assigns travel duties, one character per duty:

- A Guide: Uses Track to determine movement
- A Quartermaster: Uses Survival to manage supplies and Fatigue
- A Scout: Uses Perception to prepare for unexpected encounters

Multiple Duties & Helping

A single character may take on multiple duties, but each additional duty imposes a -20 to each duty's skill.

Each duty may be supported by one helper using an appropriate skill (e.g., someone using Perform to assist the Quartermaster by boosting morale). Helpers cannot assist with more than one duty or perform a duty themselves.

Keeping Time

The standard movement rate on foot or by boat is 2 hexes per day, 3 if mounted. A standard travel day assumes about 12 hours of movement, including time to eat, scout, and find camp.

When traveling (either by Journey or on a HexMarch), it can be important to keep track of days passed. This can have narrative repercussions if the party is under a time limit, but also helps to portray the scope and hardship of the road.

the journey

In the Broken Empires, getting there is literally half the fun. The destination is vital, but the road there is its own adventure. Journeys are a chance for players to feel the true breadth of the world--to imagine that they've walked its roads and weathered its wilds.

A Journey is tiring and can sap a party's Resolve, while besetting them with all manner of Events--encounters both hostile and benign. It is a procedure that assumes the party has picked a destination hex and is making their way through the world to get there. It abstracts away many of the details we would otherwise have to account for while traveling through the wilds: finding a good campsite, rationing food and water stores, setting a watch, and all the kinds of details that a HexMarch covers.

The 8 Steps of a Journey Leg

Traveling any amount of hexes is known as a leg, and there are typically several legs to a Journey. While on a Journey, the passage of time gets compressed into 8 steps, repeated in the same order for each leg. No step can be skipped unless specifically indicated:

1. Plan the Route
2. Make Travel Lore rolls
3. Guide's Track Roll and Movement on the map
4. Quartermaster's Survival Roll
5. Check for Infection
6. Describe the Leg
7. Scout's Perception Roll & Event
8. Change to Daily Time OR Begin a New Leg

1) plan the route

The players begin by consulting the overland hex map to choose their specific destination. From there, they decide which exact path to take, plotting the route hex by hex. By measuring distance and considering the terrain, they can estimate how many days the Journey might take and how exhausting it could be.

At the table, consider placing a printed map inside a plastic sheet protector and having players draw their intended route directly onto it using a water-soluble marker. On a Virtual Tabletop (such as Foundry or Roll20), the same effect can be achieved by using drawing tools. This will indicate what specific types of terrain the party's route takes them through, as well as the color-coded Danger Levels in each hex (if known; see Hex Danger Levels), both of which are very important when executing a Journey.

Edbert, Arn, and Simon must travel on foot over the mountains separating Angevarre from the Westlands, from the town of Bosiville to the Westlander settlement of Marford. They don't want to waste any time, so they won't enter Daily Time if they can avoid it.

Step 1: Plan the Route

Simon is the Guide (Track 70 Ex2), Arn the Quartermaster (Survival 65), and Edbert the Scout (Perception 58). They plan a route that will take them 34 hexes (340 miles) up over the mountain passes, down into the valleys beyond, and into the town of Marford. They know that orc tribes have been raiding this pass recently, so many hexes will likely be Precarious or even Dangerous areas, although only the GM knows which ones for certain. They plan their route to try to avoid as much difficult terrain as they can, though that will be difficult while going through the mountains.

2) travel lore

Travel Lore is a temporary pool of Favor points that can be spent to augment certain rolls on the next leg of the Journey. It represents recalled memories of the local landscape, the studying of maps, talking to the locals, remembering old traveler's tales of the area, etc.

Earning Travel Lore

Before each new leg of the Journey begins, characters may attempt Travel Lore rolls if the current hex offers a reasonable opportunity to learn about the road ahead.

Each character may attempt one skill roll that must be relevant to the nature of the departure hex. If the GM rules that no skill fits the current hex, no Travel Lore roll is possible. The time required to gather Travel Lore depends on the method used and the situation, as determined by the GM.

Some examples:

- A Common Lore in civilized or well-mapped areas (this is the default Travel Lore skill)
- A Naturewise if departing from a remote forest hex in which you have had contact with a friendly fur trapper
- A Social skills when engaging with NPCs for gossip or stories
- A Commerce if the route is often traveled by merchants
- A Ancient Lore if leaving from the ruins of an ancient library high in the mountains
- A A successfully-cast spell's Bind SLs can be used towards Travel Lore, if the context allows it.

Once all participating characters have rolled, only the single highest successful roll among all attempts contributes to the Travel Lore pool: 1 Travel Lore, plus 1 more for every 2 SLs earned .

If a character critically succeeds on a Travel Lore roll, the GM may grant previously hidden information about the Journey ahead, such as known landmarks, safe rest spots, or even the Danger Level of one or more hexes (see Events) along or near the party's route.

If any character critically fails their Travel Lore roll, the party receives bad, misleading, or mistaken information: the Guide suffers a -20 penalty to their next Track roll.

Using Travel Lore

Travel Lore is a pool of Favor that can be spent during the next leg of the Journey exclusively by the Guide, Quartermaster, or Scout on their official travel duty rolls (Track, Survival, and Perception, respectively).

Additionally, the party may spend up to 3 points of Travel Lore to modify the Fatigue Table roll for the upcoming leg, at +1 per point. This must be declared before the Fatigue roll is made (see The Quartermaster).

Travel Lore is usable on the upcoming leg only. It is lost after the party deals with the Event in the arrival hex.

> For travel to involve meaningful choice, the players must have information. Before the party sets out, the GM should volunteer enough broad, practical detail about each available route to convey the kinds of dangers or hardships involved.
>
> If the northern woods are known to be infested with murderous orcs, that information should be given freely, without requiring a Travel Lore roll. If an alternate mountain route is generally safer but extremely exhausting, that tradeoff should be made clear as well. If a monastery known to be friendly to travelers lies along a well-trodden path, the party should be told about it.
>
> Specific details--such as exact Danger Levels of individual hexes, or the locations of ancient ruins and hidden sites--should remain hidden behind strong or critical Travel Lore results, but remember that finding out about interesting hidden places is a good

thing: it gives the party an opportunity to choose whether or not to adjust their course and explore.

As a general rule, lean toward giving too much information rather than too little. Players should always be given enough up front to decide which risks they are willing to accept before the Journey begins.

Step 2: Travel Lore

Before leaving the village of Bosiville, the party members each make Common Lore rolls to get Travel Lore. The highest result is Simon's: he rolls a critical 22 on his Common Lore, gaining 5 Travel Lore. The GM describes how, over the course of a full day, they contemplate their own memories of traveling this way, question the residents about the road ahead, and spend some time listening to old stories of these parts from the wizened codgers drinking in the tavern. Because Simon rolled a critical success, one of the villagers tells Simon about a secluded glade beside a lake along the way about 100 miles on, and recommends that their route pass through that hex where they will be able to safely rest (a Safe area). Simon adjusts their route to include it.

3) the guide

The Guide's job is to lead the party as efficiently as possible, minimizing the number of Track rolls needed to reach their destination. The more ground the party can cover before the Quartermaster must roll on the Fatigue Table, the less chance of becoming prematurely exhausted or running into a dangerous encounter.

On foot or by boat, a party can travel 2 hexes per day; if mounted, 3 hexes per day. Terrain does not slow movement, but it affects Fatigue during that leg of the Journey.

Forced March

A forced march allows the party to cover 3 hexes on foot or 5 if mounted, but imposes a -5 penalty on the next Fatigue roll. Forced marching must be declared before the Guide rolls Track. A forced march cannot be made while traveling by water.

Making the Track Roll

The Guide makes a Track roll to determine how many 10-mile hexes the party can travel before triggering a Fatigue roll and a Journey Event. If traveling by boat on a river, the Guide rolls Sail/Boat instead of Track.

- On a success, the party moves a maximum number of hexes equal to half the Guide's Track Score (rounded up), plus 1 hex per SL.
- On a failure, the path is inefficient. The party moves, at maximum, half the Guide's Track Score, rounded up. The next Fatigue roll is made at -1.
- On a critical failure, the route is exhausting or misjudged. Move the party as with a failed roll, but apply -3 to the next Fatigue roll.

If the party changes methods of travel at any point during a leg (for example, leaving a boat to continue on foot), their movement ends at that point. Proceed to the next step of the Journey sequence as normal.

The party is currently traveling by boat. Their chosen route will take them 3 hexes upriver to a waterfall, where they must disembark and go 6 hexes overland into a forest to their destination. The Guide's roll moves them 7 hexes. Once they move 3 hexes upriver, they must end the leg's movement there (the extra 4 hexes from the Guide's roll are wasted). After the GM describes the voyage, they proceed with the Check for Infection step.

Tracking Days

After determining how many hexes the party moved, retroactively calculate the number of days passed based on their movement rate. Always round up when recording days spent traveling.

Arrival Hex Danger Level

The GM will determine the relative safety of the arrival hex: either Safe, Neutral, Precarious, or Dangerous. The Danger Level determines what kind of Event befalls the characters, ease of rest, and other factors. See Events for more.

Step 3: The Guide

In the morning, it is time to leave. It is a bright summer's day, with clear blue skies and a slight breeze carrying the delicate scent of lavender flowers across the river. The party gathers their supplies and sets off northward. They know that the first 4 hexes of their chosen route will be in open ground, before bringing them through sharp foothills toward the black mountains beyond.

Simon rolls his Track skill of 75 and gets a 46 (4 SLs). That will take them 8 hexes, over 4 days (half Track Score of 7 is 4, + 4 hexes from 4 SLs = 8 hexes total, at 2 hexes per day, equals 4 days) before an Event occurs. The first 4 hexes take them along the flatlands, with the last 4 going north across the rising landscape of the foothills, arriving into a Precarious hex.

Option: Terrain-based Movement Rates

To simplify things, I have made terrain affect the Fatigue taken from crossing it, not the rate at which it is crossed. However, if you want to take terrain into account for movement rates, here is an option.

Daily travel rate is based on the majority type of terrain the party moved through during the leg, and whether they are on foot or mounted. In order for the party to use the mounted travel rate, the entire party must be mounted. River and ocean travel is also included.

If the party was traveling through:	On Foot	Mounted
Majority Open terrain (plains, fields, or meadows)	3 hexes per day	5 hexes per day
Majority Difficult terrain (desert, forests, hills)	2 hexes per day	3 hexes per day
Majority Very Difficult terrain (mountains, swamps)	1 hex per day	2 hexes per day
Traveling by boat, going downriver	2 hexes per day	
Traveling by boat, going upriver	1 hex per day	
Traveling by ship	5 hexes per day	

A forced march adds +1 hex per day to the daily travel rate over land. However, the next time the Quartermaster rolls on the Fatigue Table, he does so at a further -5.

The PCs are in the city of Ansharir at the edge of the Red Wastes. They wish to travel to a strange ruin in the desert, 20 hexes (200 miles) away. On foot in Difficult terrain like this, they can go 2 hexes per day. The party's Guide (Track of 65) rolls 4 SLs as they set out, which moves them 7 hexes (half 6, + 4), traveling for three-and-a-half days before the first Fatigue roll and Event. The GM decides the Event occurs at noon, halfway through the fourth day.

But say they are in a hurry: they need to recover an artifact from the ruin and return it to the city to stop a foul necromantic ritual in time. In this case, the Guide wants to do a forced march: now they'll be moving at three hexes per day. The Guide again rolls 4 SLs, for seven hexes. Seven hexes at three hexes per day takes them just over two days before an Event. They've covered the same distance as above in a much shorter time, but when the Quartermaster rolls on the Fatigue Table, it will now be at -5 for the forced march (in addition to the -1 for Difficult terrain). The GM determines that the Event happens in the morning of the third day (as they traveled two-and-a-third days).

Now let's say that after two hexes, they instead switched to traveling by boat upriver. The majority of the seven hexes traveled this leg would be at the upriver rate of 1 hex per day, and it would take them seven days to go the same distance, before the Event.

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4) the quartermaster

Traveling the Broken Empires is tiring. Taking Fatigue represents the arduousness of the Journey, the lack of sleep from poor campsites, the dwindling of food supplies, etc. It's a combination of physical and spiritual exhaustion, part weariness and part morale.

Rolling for Fatigue

The Quartermaster's job is to minimize Fatigue taken. Their duty of finding nightly camps, managing ration stores, making good use of travel gear, hunting and foraging, etc. is abstracted into a single Survival roll.

Any SLs from that roll are combined with any other relevant modifiers as indicated on the Fatigue Modifiers Table. Once all modifiers are tallied, roll 1d10 + modifiers on the Fatigue Table to determine how tiring that leg of the Journey was. (A HexMarch uses a d20 instead.) All Fatigue is marked before any Event takes place.

Fatigue Modifiers Table

Travel Lore	
Per spent Travel Lore, max 3. Must be declared before the roll. (N/A on HexMarch.)	+1
Guide and Quartermaster Rolls	
If the Guide failed the Trackroll (Journey only)	-1
If the Guide critically failed the Trackroll (Journey only)	-3
If the Guide critically succeeded on the Trackroll (HexMarch only)	+2
Quartermaster's Survival roll	+SLs
If the Quartermaster critically failed the Survival roll	-3
Season :	
If traveling in Autumn	-1
If traveling in Winter	-2
If traveling in good weather (HexMarch only)	+1
If traveling in bad weather (HexMarch only)	-1
Terrain (choose one)	
If the leg briefly crossed difficult terrain	-1
If the leg was largely desert, forest, or hill terrain	-2
If the leg was largely badlands or swamp terrain	-3
If the leg was largely mountainous terrain	-4
Other :	
For each major river, waterfall, ravine, canyon, cliff, or other major obstacle crossed on this leg	-1
If the party made a forced marched this leg	-5
For each person in the party who has a completely depleted Ration Supply Die	-1
If the majority of the leg followed a road	+2
If the entire party is mounted	+2
If traveling in a boat by river	+1
If the arrival hex contains a settlement	+3
If traveling alone (for solo players)	+5

Fatigue Table
d10 Journey | d20 HexMarch

Roll + mods	Result
<=1	Exhausting - Every member of the party takes 4 Fatigue
2-6	Arduous - Everyone takes 3 Fatigue
7-10	Wearisome - Everyone takes 2 Fatigue
11-13	Tiring - Everyone takes 1 Fatigue
14-17	Taxing - One PC takes 1 Fatigue (party chooses)
18+	Mild - No one takes Fatigue

There are certain cases where a later leg of a journey may be just a couple of hexes--or even a single hex--yet the party still winds up taking significant Fatigue. For example, they have traveled 2 legs, ending up only 1 hex away from their final destination--but upon reaching the last hex during the third leg, an unlucky Fatigue roll inflicts 4 Fatigue on everyone.

There are many ways to explain this retroactively; one of my favorites is to suggest that a bad storm struck without warning along the way. Of course, there are other explanations as well, but in any case, a creative GM should have little trouble assigning narrative reasons for why the Fatigue penalty was so severe over such a short stretch.

Weary Wounds
If your entire unspent Resolve is filled with Fatigue, and you suffer any amount of additional Fatigue, instead mark a lethal 1-point Weary wound to the Body location (see Chapter 11: Wounds, Healing, Perils: Fatigue-based Wounds).

Using Rations While on a Journey
When you're on a Journey, you don't have to roll the Rations Supply Die every day as you do on a HexMarch, as the rationing of stores is abstracted into the Quartermaster's duties.

However, if you take Fatigue while on a Journey, you may reduce that amount by 1 by reducing your Ration Supply Die by 1 step (no roll). However, if anyone depletes their Rations completely, it will penalize Fatigue Table rolls and make things riskier for everybody.

Step 4: The Quartermaster
Now, Arn the Quartermaster makes his Survival roll. He rolls 50 (5 SLs, which will count for +5 on the Fatigue Table). This leg largely took them through rough hills, so that will be a -2 terrain penalty. He spends 1 of the Travel Lore points for +1, for a grand total of +4. He rolls 6 on the d10, plus 4 is 10: Wearisome, meaning everyone takes 2 Fatigue. Simon decides to reduce his Ration Supply die by 1 step, from d12 to d10, to reduce the Fatigue he takes by 1.

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What About Getting Lost?

Getting lost in the wilderness is a time-honored tradition in fantasy RPGs, going all the way back to the early days of the hobby. But in my many years of gaming, I've never found it worth the trouble. Making secret navigation rolls, tracking where the party actually is versus where they think they are, then wasting precious gaming time backtracking? Unless their getting lost causes an interesting discovery, it always ends the same: a few grumbles, one or two lost travel days, and some trivial resource expenditures before they're right back on track.

In The Broken Empires RPG , I skip the tedium. We assume the group will wind up off-course at some point--arguing over a fork in the trail, following goat tracks that look promising, realizing too late that the river's supposed to be behind them. All of that's baked right into the Guide and Quartermaster steps, and rolled into the Fatigue outcomes: fail a Track or Survival roll, and the odds of a longer, more exhausting trip go up. Plus, "Lost" is a specific result on the Event Tables anyway--so the PCs may still have to deal with temporarily losing their way.

Getting lost means the characters suffer for it--but the players are spared the hassle.

5) check for infection

A Journey is a grubby, tiring affair that prevents wounds from healing and places them at continual risk of infection.

Upon coming to that leg's arrival hex, any wounded character must determine whether those wounds have become infected along the way, and whether any existing infections have worsened.

Infection and Sepsis checks use the Infection Die (d20).

A) Infection Check

Any character who arrives with any current lethal Wound Points--whether those wounds are currently infected or not--must attempt an Infection check:

- Roll the d20 Infection Die + Toughness.
- Compare the total to the character's total lethal WP (both infected and uninfected).

If the result is equal to or less than that number, the wound with the highest lethal WP value that is not already infected becomes infected. If multiple uninfected wounds are tied for the highest value, choose one.

B) Sepsis Check

After resolving the Infection check, any character with one or more infected wounds must make a Sepsis check:

- Roll the d20 Infection Die + Toughness.
- Compare the total to the combined Wound Points of all infected wounds.

If the result is equal to or less than that number, the infected wound with the highest Wound Point value becomes septic (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Consequences of Untreated Wounds).

Step 5: Check for Infection

Edbert has a 3-point infected Leg wound and a 5-point uninfected Head wound, both of which are lethal WP.

Upon arrival in the leg's final hex, he must make an Infection check.

His total lethal Wound Points are 8. He rolls the Infection Die and gets a 3. Adding his Toughness of 1 results in a total of 4.

Because 4 is equal to or less than his total lethal WP of 8, his highest-value uninfected lethal wound (in this case, the 5-point Head wound) has become infected at some point over the course of the Journey.

Edbert now has two infected wounds with a combined infected WP total of 8.

Now he must make a Sepsis check. He rolls a 12 and again adds Toughness 1 for a total of 13.

Since 13 is over the total infected WP of 8, none of his wounds turn septic.

(If he had rolled a result equal to or less than the total infected WP of 8, the most serious infected wound--the newly infected 5-point head wound--would become septic.)

If he still has these two infected wounds (or any new wounds) by the time they get to Step 5 of the next leg, he will repeat both the Infection and Sepsis checks then.

Treating Infection

Infection cannot be treated while the party remains in the Journey sequence. To attempt treatment, the party first deal with the Event (Step 7), then exit the Journey and enter Daily Time (Step 8).

6) describe the leg

The party has moved a few hexes on the world map, possibly taken Fatigue, and risked infection in open wounds. Stop and take stock: what different terrain types have they crossed? What has the weather been like? Were there landmarks, oddities, or notable sights? How did any of these details affect the party's Fatigue? If someone's wound became infected, was it exacerbated by poor travel conditions, difficult terrain, or bad weather?

Now put that all together and describe it to your players. Immerse them! Bring them into the game world. Make them feel like they've actually been there in their minds. This is probably the single most important step in the whole Journey sequence.

First, you have to see it in your mind. Think of it like a travel montage in a fantasy movie. How would you describe the Fellowship leaving Rivendell and traveling south for several days along the western slopes of the Misty Mountains? Really put yourself in the characters' shoes. Use more than one sense in your description. Not everything is about what they see; there are sounds, smells, physical sensations, feelings. Think of the rich, earthy scent of the forest, the feel of mist from a nearby waterfall, the cries of eagles over snow-covered peaks...

...but don't write a novel. Keep it short, a few evocative sentences at most. You're a Gamemaster, not an author, but words are still your best tools to share the vistas of the Broken Empires with your players.

Step 6: Describe the Leg

The GM describes how, for the first couple of days, the high golden grasses of the Angevarran fields sway in the pleasant summer wind, the land sloping ever-upward. Eventually, the rolling fields give way to thickets of willow, birch, and poplar trees. On the morning of the third day, they turn north across the hills towards the looming mountains in the distance. As the day passes, the land grows progressively rockier, with their footing becoming more and more unsure with each passing mile. The weariness of the Journey begins to wear on each of them, and shortly after entering the hills, Edbert begins to notice a foul smell coming from his head bandages--his infection has spread...

7) the scout

An Event is a situation that the PCs must deal with, and the Scout's job is to spot it before the party is surprised by it. The GM first decides what the Event will be using the tools in the Events section, and then the Scout rolls Perception to try and gain an advantage.

Making the Perception Roll

The Scout rolls Perception before the Event:

- On a success, the party is not surprised by any enemies, and the Scout chooses one of two benefits.

  Either:

  - The Scout's Perception roll grants a special bonus of +10 per 3 SLs to each of the party members' first skill rolls to avoid or otherwise deal with the Event, if it makes sense within the context,

  Or:

  - If the Event involves combat, the Scout's SLs may instead act as a bonus to each party member's Initiative roll for the first round only.

- On a failure, the party cannot avoid the Event, and must deal with it.
- On a critical failure, the party cannot avoid the Event, and:
  - If the Event involves combat, the party is surprised by the enemies (see Chapter 10 - Combat, Surprise).
  - If the Event is dangerous for some other reason, each party member suffers -20 to their first roll.

Veil is the Scout for her party. She rolls 3 SLs on her Perception. The Event involves a group of hobgoblins in the crags ahead. Veil has spotted them first, and now she can give a +10 to each party member's first skill roll--if they choose to try and sneak away with Stealth, for example. Or, if they enter combat (either through failing to sneak away or by choosing to attack), every member of Veil's party will get +3 to their first Initiative roll--as long as they didn't already use the bonus for their Stealth attempts to slip away.

Use the Scout's Perception roll to set the timing of the Event: an even roll means it occurs during the day; an odd roll means it occurs at night (often while the party is camped or asleep).

Optionally, you may determine the Event's time of day based on the Guide's Track roll, counting partial days if necessary. For example, if the party traveled 10 hexes on horseback at a rate of 3 hexes per day, the Journey Event would occur in the morning--or roughly the first third--of the fourth day.

Rules for generating an Event are in the Events section at the end of this chapter.

Step 7: The Scout

Unfortunately, before the PCs can consider what to do about Edbert's spreading infection, they will have to first deal with the Event. (The Event and how it is created are detailed in an example at the end of the Events section.)

Edbert is the Scout. He rolls his Perception and gets 81, a failure; the party must face the Event, and there are no extra bonuses for them to do so.

8) change to daily time or begin a new leg

After resolving the Event, the party may continue with the Journey's next leg, starting from Step 1: Planning the Route Otherwise, they have the option to drop out of the Journey sequence and Change to Daily Time , the default "adventuring time" in which day-to-day conditions are tracked. Changing to Daily Time allows the characters to either try to make camp and rest in the current hex, or to explore it.

Resting

Resting can remove Fatigue, recover Resolve, allow Recovery rolls and Heal rolls to purge infection, but it will also put the PCs at risk of expending daily rations, making additional infection rolls, and having Hostile Encounters.

If resting in a hex covered by any kind of settlement, the party will have to find an inn, barn, or other place of refuge, lest the local authorities harass them for their vagrancy. Depending on the settlement, this could mean anything from forcible relocation to arrest and imprisonment; in any case, the party will get no rest this night.

"In camp" scenes can be great opportunities for character interactions. Let the players roleplay as they see fit. Don't let the sequence become a sterile dice-rolling exercise.

Exploring

Exploring allows the characters to search the hex while remaining in Daily Time. This could result in making new discoveries, uncovering hidden locations, or having any other kind of encounter as decided by the GM (see Exploring the Hex and Searching for a Hidden Site).

Daily Time Rolls

Whenever the PCs are in Daily Time (regardless of what time of day they enter it), they must follow the Daily Time sequence at the end of each day. Steps that don't apply to the current situation can be skipped:

A. Ration Die rolls
B. Infection Die rolls for any infected wounds
C. Queen's Hunt rolls (for Replaced characters only)
D. Hostile Encounter roll
E. Rest and Recover Resolve and/or Fatigue
F. Wound Recovery rolls
G. Add 1 Day to the Journey Total

"At the end of the day" simply means the point before the characters try to get some significant rest. If they are traveling through the night for some reason, the "end of the day" would be whenever they stop to rest, likely just before dawn.

A) Ration Die Rolls

At the end of each day while in Daily Time, each character must roll their Rations Die. These Ration Supply rolls are generally not required while in settlements or in any hexes they encompass; in those cases, needs are assumed to be met through coin or Status.

Animals such as horses or pack beasts don't need to roll their own Rations Die unless they're in an area where there's nothing to graze. If needed, separate animal rations can be purchased (see Chapter 9 - Equipment).

If a character runs out of Ration Supply, they are considered to lack adequate food and water, and must mark a Deprived wound (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Fatigue-based Wounds)

Replenishing Rations

Instead of exploring the wilderness hex, a character may spend a full day trying to hunt, fish, or gather by making a Survival or Track roll. Success will increase a Ration Supply Die by 1 step, +1 per 3 SLs .

Ration Supply Modifiers (Cumulative)

Hex	Survival or Track Roll Modifier
Desert	-20
Mountain/Swamp	-10
Plains/Open	+0
Forest	+5
Jungle	+10
Coastal	+15
Hex contains a river	+10
Season: Autumn	+10
Season: Winter	-30

B) Infection Die Rolls

If a character has one or more infected wounds that haven't yet received a Purge Infection attempt during the current day (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Purging Infection), a healer may now attempt to remove the infection.

If any wound remains infected after this attempt, the character must now make a single Sepsis check. If a wound becomes septic, it will likely not be able to be treated until the next day (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Septic Wound Treatment).

C) Queen's Hunt Rolls (Replaced only)

If any Replaced characters are in the group, roll a d20 at the end of each day. If the result is equal to or less than the number of days the party has spent in the current hex, it means the Queen's Hunt has located the Replaced. A pack of 1d6+1 Dark Fae Huntsmen is dispatched to reclaim them (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary).

D) Hostile Encounter Roll

A Hostile Encounter is brought on by staying in the wilderness for too long. It specifically represents a dangerous threat drawn to the party while they rest; benign nighttime encounters fall outside this roll and occur only at the GM's discretion. Hostile Encounter rolls are not typically required in settlements, unless the settlement itself is of questionable safety.

Keeping Watch

Keeping watch during the night can prevent surprise by hostiles, but reduces the benefits of rest. A character on watch will recover less Fatigue from rest. Resolve recovery is unchanged.

The night is split into two halves, or "shifts". If a hostile encounter occurs, the Hostile Encounter roll determines which shift it falls into--an even result means the first shift, an odd result means the second.

A character keeping watch may attempt a Perception roll to detect intruders. If stealth is a factor, this is an opposed roll against the trespasser's Stealth. Success means the watchman can alert the party; failure means the group is surprised.

More than one character may keep watch during a shift. Each gets a separate Perceptionroll, but will also recover less Fatigue from rest. Resolve recovery is unchanged.

If only one person keeps watch across both shifts, that character suffers a -30 penalty to their Perceptionroll and gains 2 Fatigue instead of 1 (see Step E).

Tending the Wounded

If a healer spends the night tending the wounded (see Wound Recovery Rolls), the healer will also recover less Fatigue from rest. Resolve recovery is unchanged. A healer who tends the wounded overnight cannot also serve as a watchman.

Fortifying Camp

If a character is willing to accept reduced rest, they may spend time fortifying the camp by Preparing the Battlefield (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Preparing the Battlefield). When done at the end of a travel day, the character will also recover less Fatigue from rest. Resolve recovery is unchanged. Someone who Prepares the Battlefield cannot serve as watchman or healer.

However, if the party remains in a hex where they have already made camp, and the character spends an entire day fortifying the site, they recover Fatigue from resting as normal.

Making the Hostile Encounter Roll

After the PCs have decided who, if anyone, is going to keep watch, make a 1d100 Hostile Encounter roll. The base chance depends on the hex's Danger Level (see Events):

- Safe (Green): 0%
- Neutral : 15%
- Precarious (Yellow): 25%
- Dangerous (Red): 35%

Each day past the first that the party remains in this hex adds +5% (cumulative). Resting in adjacent or nearby hexes simply to avoid this increase still counts as consecutive nights in the same hex.

Roll 1d100. If the result is equal to or less than the current Hostile Encounter chance, a Hostile Encounter occurs.

If the roll is even, the Hostile Encounter happens in the first watch; if it's odd, during the second.

Roll on theAmbush Event from theEvent Type by Hex Danger Tables to discover the Hostile Encounter's type, tactics, and motivation. Alternatively, roll on theEnvironmental Hazard Event Table for a non-combat encounter; or, come up with your own encounter.

Ambush Event

d100	Type	Tactics	Motivation
01-10	Assassins/Bounty hunters targeting party member	Attack from above	Capture for ransom or information
11-20	Bandits or brigands	Attack, then feign retreat	Escalating hostility after misunderstanding
21-30	Cultists or religious zealots	Camouflage	Random violence or sadistic entertainment
31-40	Hostile wildlife	Coordinated charge	Recruitment or coercion
41-50	Local militia, territorial guards, or barbarians	Forced bottleneck	Revenge for perceived slight or trespass
51-60	Mercenaries	Intimidation	Ritualistic purpose
61-70	Opportunistic scavengers	Lure with decoy or bait	Robbery
71-80	Predatory monsters	Missile barrage	Seeking food or supplies
81-90	Rival party or faction	Surround and attack from all sides	Strategic elimination of a perceived threat
91-100	Roll on Enemy Subtable	Traps set ahead of time	Territorial defense

Environmental Hazard Event

d100	Type	Cause	Possible Consequence
01-10	Dangerous wildlife (stampede, predator, etc.)	Ancient effort or artifice	Altered terrain
11-20	Extreme weather (hurricane, blizzard, etc.)	Inexplicable	Delayed progress
21-30	Falling debris (rockfall, avalanche, etc.)	Intelligent influence or interference	Injury, infection or death
31-40	Fire (wildfire, lightning strike, etc.)	Magical, divine, or supernatural	Local creatures become agitated or displaced
41-50	Flooding (flash flood, rising tide, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Loss of resources or supplies
51-60	Impeding terrain (quicksand, bog, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Necessity for time-sensitive escape
61-70	Magical or supernatural anomaly	Natural occurrence	New environmental hazards are created
71-80	Sudden collapse (cave-in, sinkhole, etc.)	Recent event or disaster	Opportunity for discovery
81-90	Thorny or toxic vegetation	Seasonal effect	Potential for recurrence or expansion
91-100	Volcanic activity (tremors, fumes, etc.)	Wildlife activity	Separation or isolation of party members

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E) Rest: Resolve & Fatigue Recovery

To benefit from rest, a character must remain in one place and sleep for several uninterrupted hours.

Recovery normally takes place even if the night is disturbed by a Hostile Encounter, unless the GM judges the interruption to be extremely severe or prolonged.

The quality of recovery is based on the Hex Danger Level of the current area (see Events):

Area Type	Resolve Recovered	Fatigue Removed
Safe	All spent Resolve	Remove 3 Fatigue
Neutral	Up to 3 spent Resolve	Remove 2 Fatigue
Precarious	Up to 2 spent Resolve	Remove 1 Fatigue
Dangerous	Up to 1 spent Resolve	No Fatigue removed

There can be areas of varying danger within a hex, and this can affect the quality of rest the PCs can get and the likelihood of a Hostile Encounter. Some examples:

A Dangerous old ruin within a Precarious hex: resting within the ruin itself recovers 1 Resolve and no Fatigue, but resting some distance outside the ruin recovers 2 Resolve and 1 Fatigue. There is also a higher chance of a Hostile Encounter in the Dangerous ruin than outside it.

A besieged fortress might be a Precarious area within a Dangerous hex. Rest will be improved within the fortress, but there is still the chance of a besieger getting through in the night.

A village in a Dangerous mountain hex might be magically protected from the valley's wandering undead and therefore considered Safe: not only do you recover all Resolve and 3 Fatigue by staying within the village, but the odds of a Hostile Encounter are very low despite the dangers just outside.

If you kept watch, fortified the camp, or tended the wounded with Heal, benefit from rest as normal, then gain 1 Fatigue.

Resting also affects Fatigue-based wounds (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils).

F) Wound Recovery Rolls

After the night's rest, characters may attempt wound Recovery rolls. Each is an Endurance roll modified by the specific wound's Recovery Bonus, along with any cleanliness modifiers (+20 to -20; see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Rest & Recovery). Infected wounds may not make Recovery rolls.

If a healer tended to the character overnight, add double the healer's Heal Score to the character's Recovery rolls (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Wound Recovery).

- On a successful Recovery roll, reduce the wound's WPs by 1 + 1 per 3 SLs. (Any extra points are wasted.)
- On a critical failure, if the WPs are lethal, the wound becomes infected (INF). Treating a new infection can begin immediately, but only one Heal attempt may be made per infected wound per day, and each attempt requires an hour of dedicated effort.

G) Add One Day to the Journey

After resting the night, add one day to the Journey and to anything else being tracked day-by-day. If the party continues their Journey, a new leg starts with Step 1 of the Journey Procedure.

Exploring the Hex

If the party chooses to spend a day exploring the hex they're camped in, remain in Daily Time and describe what they find over the course of the day. If unsure, use the Event Type by Hex Danger Table.

Step 8: Change to Daily Time

Unfortunately, the Event the party just experienced resulted in Arn receiving a 2-point wound to his leg, and as Edbert's previous wounds have already become infected, the party decides to enter Daily Time to try and deal with it.

The GM describes the area in which they make their camp, and then has each of them roll their Rations die. None degrade, thankfully.

Simon now tries to Purge Infection on Edbert's infected leg and head wounds. He succeeds on the 3 point leg wound, but fails on the 5 point head wound. As at least one of Edbert's wounds remains infected, he must now roll the green d20 Infection Die + his Toughness against 5, the total infected WP of all his wounds. He rolls 17, so sepsis doesn't set in...yet.

Arn and Simon decide to Keep Watch. As he is keeping watch, Simon will not be able to also tend to the wounded. The GM has determined that their current map hex is yellow, or Precarious; there is a 25% chance for a Hostile Encounter, but with a roll of 41, no encounter occurs.

Upon waking, they can all recover Resolve and Fatigue. Edbert slept through the night, so he gets back 2 Resolve and removes 1 Fatigue (as they are in a Precarious area). Simon and Arn each recover 2 Resolve and 1 Fatigue, but as they kept watch, they each also take 1 Fatigue.

Arn can also now make a Recovery roll on his 2-point Leg wound. Arn's Endurance is 64. He had no help from a healer tending to his wounds, so he only adds his wound's Recovery Bonus of +10; however, he takes a -10 penalty due to the (un)cleanliness of the camp. He rolls 27, so he can remove a single Wound Point (the roll reduces 1 WP + 1 per 3 SL), bringing the leg wound down to 1 point.

Edbert's head wound is infected, so he makes no Recovery roll for that one, and fails on his Recovery roll for his leg wound. One Heal attempt per day can be made on an infected wound, so Simon tries again on the head wound. His roll fails, leaving Edbert's head wound still infected. Simon won't be able to try again until the next morning.

They mark an extra day on their Journey, and must now decide whether to carry on despite Edbert's infected wound. Against the protestations of his fellows, Edbert insists that he'll be fine. Reluctantly, the party re-enters the Journey procedure, hoping that the Infection Die doesn't cause Edbert to go into sepsis in the new arrival hex.

The new leg of the Journey begins. They decide to keep to the same route, as Simon knows from the critical Travel Lore roll that the Safe area the villager told him about is only 2 hexes away. The GM rules that Travel Lore rolls made from their current hex aren't allowed, as there is no feasible source of information about the road ahead. The Journey continues...

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the hexmarch

When the party is wanting to travel hex-by-hex or explore unfamiliar territory, they can opt to perform a HexMarch and travel in Daily Time . Unlike Journeys, a HexMarch zooms in on the details of each day along the way, which means more frequent resource use, infection checks, and exposure to hazards and encounters.

A HexMarch follows 7 steps each day:

1. Weather
2. Plan Route
3. Check for Mishap
4. Travel
5. Event
6. Fatigue Roll
7. Daily Time Rolls

If charting unexplored hexes on an overland map, the details of each hex on the map are revealed only as the party explores it (this is particularly effective if using an online VTT's "fog of war" feature).

1) weather

Weather can affect Fatigue rolls. At the start of the day, roll on the Daily Weather Table :

Daily Weather Table

d10	Weather
1-3	Bad weather for the season and region
4-7	Average weather for the season and region
8+	Good weather for the season and region

Roll -2 in winter, -1 in autumn, +1 in summer

2) plan route

The party must plan their route and commit to a course for the day's travel. Once chosen, the route cannot be changed mid-day. Travel Lore isn't used in a HexMarch.

3) check for mishap

A Guide does not affect how many hexes are moved while on a HexMarch. Instead, before the party moves out that day, the Guide must make a Track roll to avoid a mishap. Apply the results of the mishap before the party travels, although narratively these mishaps don't occur until after the party has departed.

- On a success, the party suffers no mishaps.
- On a critical success, the Guide's well-chosen route adds +2 to the Fatigue Table roll.
- On a failure, the party suffers a random mishap (roll d6 on the Mishap Table).
- On a critical failure, roll twice on the Mishap Table and apply both results.

Mishap Table

d6	Mishap	Result
1	Lost Time	The route is inefficient or misjudged. The party travels only 1 hex this day.
2	Wasted Rations	Food, water, or provisions are mishandled or spoiled. One PC reduces their Ration Supply Die by 1 step.
3	Broken Gear	Poor planning, confusion, or bad conditions undermine supply management. One PC reduces their Gear Supply Die by 1 step.
4	Ominous Route	The Guide leads the party through signs of danger or exposure. An Event happens this day on a roll of 01-50.
5	Scout Disrupted	The route leaves the party exposed, distracted, or poorly positioned. The Scout suffers -20 to their Perception roll.
6	Rough Going	The terrain proves more taxing than expected. Apply -2 to the day's Fatigue roll.

4) travel

Once any mishaps have been applied, the party may follow their route on the map.

- They may travel up to 2 hexes per day on foot or in a boat, or 3 if mounted.
- A forced march moves them 3 hexes on foot, 5 if mounted, but they must commit to a forced march at the start of the day. Forced marches cannot be made when traveling by boat.

The GM should describe the landscape the PCs pass through, just as in a Journey.

5) event

On a HexMarch, if there is an Event, it will occur before the day's Fatigue roll.

Each day of travel, regardless of how many hexes the party crosses, check once to see if an Event occurs.

Roll 1d100:

- 25 or below: An Event occurs. Roll on the Event Type by Hex Danger Table and run the Event.
- 26+: No Event; proceed to Step 6.

If an Event occurs, the GM may choose which hex along the day's route it happens in, or use the ones digit of the same d100 roll:

Ones Digit of d100 Event Roll	Time of Event
1-3	The Event happens early in the day (in the first hex traveled).
4-7	The Event happens in the middle of the day (in a middle hex, or GM's choice).
8-0	The Event happens late in the day (in the last hex traveled).

If the hex's Danger Level is unknown, roll 1d10 on the Hex Danger Level Table :

Hex Danger Level Table

d10	Danger Level
1-2	Dangerous (Red)*
3-5	Precarious (Yellow)
6-9	Neutral
0	Safe (Green)

* If adjacent to a known Safe hex, treat as Precarious (Yellow)

The Scout may attempt a Perception roll. This works exactly the same as in the Journey rules (see Making the Perception Roll).

Searching for a Hidden Site

If the party knows that a particular site lies somewhere within a hex but does not know its exact position, they must search for it. The method depends on the nature of the search and the GM's preference; this could involve one or more standard rolls, an extended roll, or simply descriptive exploration and problem-solving.

This search is distinct from any Event the party might experience during their normal day of travel. An Event is something that happens while on the move; searching for a hidden site requires a deliberate effort to comb the terrain, investigate signs, or piece together clues to its whereabouts.

Triggered HexMarch Events

Just as in Journeys, the GM can forgo the day's Event roll and run a premade, custom encounter of their own instead, which can occur day or night at their discretion.

6) fatigue roll

When the party makes camp in their final hex at the end of the day's travel, they must make a Fatigue Table roll. This works exactly as in Step 4 of the Journey, except you roll 1d20 on the Fatigue Table with all applicable modifiers instead of 1d10.

7) daily time rolls

If the party's final hex is different from the one in which the Event occurred, roll again on the Hex Danger Level Table ; the new result determines that hex's rest quality and recovery rates. The party can't search the rest of the hex for a safer spot to camp; wherever they end up determines the Danger Level they face that night.

Once any Fatigue is incurred, Daily Time rolls are made (identical to the Daily Time rolls in the Journey section):

A. Ration Die
B. Infection Die
C. Queen's Hunt (Replaced characters only)
D. Hostile Encounter
E. Rest and Recover Resolve and/or Fatigue
F. Wound Recovery
G. Add 1 to the total days traveled

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events

The Event is an encounter that the GM improvises to test the character's skills, goals, or anything else. It is randomly assembled from rolling two descriptor words, drawing inspiration from various aspects of the party's current situation, or consulting one or more of the included random tables (or all of these together!).

Events, no matter the focus, are the backbone of a Journey. They make the world feel dynamic and alive. Even a simple social interaction with a passing NPC may present the characters with new information or new choices about the road ahead.

> This section is a toolkit that will help you create an infinite number of Events. These Events encourage a creative GM to improvise in the moment around the prompts. This doesn't come easy to everyone, so while you are getting used to the system, I recommend using the list of Premade Events in this chapter until you get a feel for how Events are intended to be structured and executed.

The Event can be as simple or as complex as the GM chooses. One Event might have a single character testing a single skill, while another might be a small adventure in its own right. It might be a purely character-interaction Event where no dice are rolled at all, or a simple opportunity to experience some aspect of the Broken Empires' setting. One Event might require a standard roll to avoid some kind of damage, while another might allow an opposed roll to offset that damage.

What the characters stand to gain or lose from the Event is entirely up to the GM. They might be faced with a danger that threatens their lives, their gear, their goals, their progress, or anything else of value to them. Or, they might find a chance to gain useful things like information, healing, treasure, Supply, furtherance of their goals, or anything else they might consider valuable (the Event Difficulty Table might be useful to decide hard numbers). But no matter the details, how they choose to overcome the Event's obstacles is entirely up to them.

If the party has reached their planned final destination hex, or if they've arrived in a settlement, the GM can skip the leg's Event if desired. A settlement is typically a place of civilization or refuge, and is usually considered Safe (see Hex Danger Levels).

Triggered Events

If you have a premade or custom encounter idea that you want to spring on the players, feel free to use a Triggered Event as your vehicle. This is an Event of your devising that happens as the Guide moves the party across a particular hex or region, or after they've been on a Journey for a certain amount of time.

Procedurally it happens before the Infection and Quartermaster steps: after the Triggered Event is resolved, the party may continue moving the rest of the Guide's earned hexes, rolling for Infection and Fatigue in the arrival hex as normal, but skipping the Scout step (the Triggered Event replaces the leg's normal Event).

building the event

When building or describing the Event, the GM should consider one or more of the following:

- The Danger Level of the current hex
- The terrain type of the hex
- The weather, if relevant (see the Daily Weather Table for inspiration)
- Whether it is day or night (choose, or use the Scout's Perception roll: even day, odd night)
- Any character goals that could be challenged by the event

Then:

- Roll two prompts from the Initial Prompt Table to inspire the Event.
- If needed, consult the Event Type by Hex Danger Table to determine the kind of Event (Ambush, Wary NPC, Environmental Hazard, etc.).
- Roll or choose further details using the tables provided in this section to flesh out the Event.
- Decide who the Event affects:
  - The entire party?
  - One character?
  - A few of them?
  - Why, and how?
- If needed, decide on a specific difficulty and consequence.
- Finally, play out the Event using whatever rules are applicable. The party can use bonuses from the Scout (if earned) as they respond.

Hex Danger Levels

Each hex on the map has a relative Danger Level, which determines the threat level of the Event. However, a hex is 10 miles across; the Danger Level more specifically reflects the actual area within that hex where the PCs happen to be.

A Danger Level has a descriptive label and an associated color: Safe (green), Neutral (no color), Precarious (yellow), and Dangerous (red). Each GM decides which Danger Levels exist in each hex in their version of the Broken Empires, although official supplements and adventures may pre-assign these levels for convenience. The GM can mark the Danger Level directly on the map using the Danger Level's color, a letter ("S," "N," "P," or "D"), or any other notation they prefer.

They may also choose not to mark Danger Levels at all, and instead determine them randomly (see Randomized Danger Levels).

Danger Levels are usually known only to the GM, unless a PC takes steps to learn such things (as may happen with a successful Travel Lore roll, for example).

- A Safe (green) hexes are more likely to provide opportunities than dangers. An Event here leans toward something positive for the party. Settlements and their surrounding hexes tend to be Safe.
- A Neutral (no color) hexes have no additional effects. An Event is mostly random.
- A Precarious (yellow) hexes are places of elevated risk that increase the chances of encountering a danger. An Event leans toward being costly or troublesome but not necessarily lethal.
- A Dangerous (red) hexes are very risky areas. An Event here is often a lethal threat.

Danger Levels are useful for determining the severity of Events, but don't feel restricted by them. Anything can happen anywhere. If you roll two descriptors that suggest an interesting healing opportunity in a Dangerous hex, go with it. If you roll something that inspires an Infection die roll in a Safe hex, do it. Also, finding an opportunity to rest in a non-Safe hex does not turn it into a Safe hex; a random beneficial Event is a one-time benefit regardless of the hex's Danger Level.

Due to the hex's large area, a new Event in a previously visited hex will likely have no bearing or similarity to any previous Event experienced there.

Randomized Danger Levels

A GM can randomize the hex's Danger Level. This can also be done to hexes that are already familiar to the players; there's no guarantee that an area hasn't become more dangerous over time (maybe a fierce monster has taken over what was previously a dependable sanctuary, for example).

After the Guide moves the party into the new hex, roll a d10 and consult the table below to determine the Danger Level of the specific area they're in:

Hex Danger Level Table

d10	Danger Level
1-2	Dangerous (Red)*
3-5	Precarious (Yellow)
6-9	Neutral (no color)
0	Safe (Green)

* If adjacent to a known Safe hex, treat as Precarious (Yellow).

Difficulty & Consequence

Events that aren't pure roleplaying opportunities usually have a Difficulty (how hard an obstacle the Event is), and a Consequence (what is at stake to gain or lose).

Event Difficulty

If desired, the GM can use the Event Difficulty Table as a rough guide for an Event's numerical difficulty.

There's no exact formula for determining the "correct" numbers involved in an Event. As always, the system expects a GM to rely on their judgement, their knowledge of the game's systems, and the context of the situation to provide appropriate numbers.

- A If the Event requires a character to make one or more standard rolls, the difficulty might apply a Skill Modifier.
- A If the Event involves one or more NPCs making opposed skill rolls, use the Opposing Skill Value column to determine the NPC skill value. This includes an enemy's combat skills (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary).
- A If the Event is an environmental hazard or other challenge that causes damage or some other effect, use the Opposing Fixed Number column. This could be an all-or-nothing opposed roll, or a DoS roll, depending on the circumstances.
- A If the Event involves a group roll where the PCs all contribute to the success of an endeavor, resolve it with an extended roll using the Extended Roll SLs column.

Event Difficulty Table

d100	Difficulty Description	Standard Roll Modifier	Opposing Skill Value	Opposed Fixed Number	Extended Roll SLs
01-05	Simple	+20	20	1	3
06-15	Easy	+10	35	1	6
16-55	Medium	+0	50	2	9
56-85	Challenging	-10	65	4	12
86-95	Hard	-20	80	6	15
96-99	Severe	-30	95	8	18
00	Extreme	-30	100+	10+	21

Veil's party is traveling the Red Wastes when they must deal with an Event. The GM has rolled on the Event tables and determined that an "edible fruit" will provide "efficient travel". He rolls on the Event Difficulty Table and gets a result of "Hard". What does that all mean?

The GM describes a small desert oasis. A tall palm tree has a single spiky fruit hanging from the upper fronds. He knows that the fruit has restorative properties, but he doesn't yet know the details; he'll discover those when he considers the Event Consequences.

The party decides to climb the tree to get at the fruit. The GM decides that it will require a single PC to make a standard Athletics roll. Since difficulty is Hard, the Athletics roll will be made at -20.

Alternatively, he could have declared that climbing the tree requires an opposed Athletics roll vs a Fixed Number of 6 (because of the Hard difficulty).

If he thinks that sounds unreasonably difficult for one PC to accomplish, he could instead model the challenge as an extended roll, where each PC can attempt a single appropriate skill of their choice, pooling their SLs. One PC might climb up to the fruit, another might throw a spear to dislodge it, while another might use Might to shake the tree. If all of these efforts add up to 15 SLs (the Hard result on the Extended Roll SLs column), the party successfully retrieves the fruit.

Event Consequence

An Event may have definite, measurable consequences that interact with a game system in some way. If so, choose the appropriate numbers based on the context.

The consequences of an Event might cause damage, increase or decrease Supply Dice, affect a Fatigue Table roll, give a bonus or penalty to a skill, force a Wound Die roll, increase or decrease Tolerance, or affect any other aspect of the game's systems. If so, you'll have to judge for yourself what a reasonable penalty or reward is.

Sometimes the consequence will be easily derived from the Event's difficulty. For example, if the Event is a Hard flame trap that requires a PC to make a Dodge DoS roll vs 6, the consequence is any damage the PC fails to mitigate.

Because Events can be literally anything a GM might imagine, it's impossible to provide a universal table of applicable numbers. That said, using the Fixed Number column of the Event Difficulty Table can provide a rough guide. Here are some examples of numerical consequences:

- A Challenging forest fire might deal 4 WP to each person who fails to deal with it.
- A Medium healing opportunity might allow 2 Heal rolls to purge infection, or permit a couple of Recovery rolls for wounded characters.
- A Hard swamp miasma that causes infection might require an immediate Infection Die roll from any wounded characters, adding the Event Difficulty's Fixed Number (6) to the roll.
- When the party discovers a cache of supplies in a bandit's hideout, the GM ignores the Fixed Number, and simply declares that the PCs can take as many extra Supply Dice they can carry--as long as they account for the 2 Inventory ENC of each extra Supply Die taken.

The GM may wish to decide an Event's consequences at the same time as its difficulty, and even communicate one or both to the players.

Veil's party has succeeded in retrieving the fruit. Now the GM must decide what the consequences are. He might base it on the Hard difficulty's Fixed Number of 6, and award 6 Rations Die steps to the group to split however they choose.

In the first example of the single PC climbing the tree with a -20 standard Athletics roll, success might indicate reaching the fruit and gaining all 6 Ration Die steps.

Or, if the player was rolling Athletics DoS vs the Fixed Number of 6, and the Athletics roll only produced 2 SL, the GM might reduce the fruit's 6 Ration Die steps to 4, the difference between the roll and the Fixed Number. Maybe the GM describes how at the last minute the player accidentally squeezes the fruit too hard while picking it, damaging its flesh and reducing its quality.

If the party instead performed the extended roll, the GM might give them all 6 uses. Or 4. Or 1. Or whatever seems right. Maybe he awards them an additional use over the initial 6 for every 3 SLs over the required SLs.

Or the GM might ignore the Fixed Number and the idea of Ration Dice altogether, and just say that the fruit gives a +2 on the party's next Fatigue Table roll.

Whatever the decision, the GM should make it a fair outcome for the players, commensurate to their skill use, effort, and luck. If they earned it, they should get it.

As a GM, always let your own imagination and interpretation guide anything that comes up as a result of these procedures. This structure is here to help you improvise something interesting for your players. Let it inspire you, not confine you.

Turning Events into Social Encounters

If you as GM feel that an Event suggests a full Social Encounter, simply apply the Social Encounter rules (see Chapter 13 - Intrigue). Consider the Event's descriptors or inspiration to decide what's at stake, pick a Tolerance for the encounter, assign any Special Reactions for the NPC, and follow the procedures listed under the Social Encounter section.

A Social Encounter doesn't have to be a conflict, however. Sometimes the party will encounter people who are interested in swapping stories of the road, or wish to trade, or who just want to hear news from abroad. These are purely roleplaying opportunities, but there may be benefits available for the characters, depending on how they handle it.

Combat Events

Some Events result in combat. Many example foes can be found in Chapter 18 - Bestiary, but some of them will be products of your own improvisation, based on the table results. In those cases, use existing Bestiary entries as templates, and use the Event's Difficulty as a guide to determine the foes' skill levels and capabilities (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary for more guidance on creating opponents).

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the event tables

Initial Prompt Table

Roll one Action and Subject on the Initial Prompt Table , and consider the combination in context. If it prompts an idea, run with that. If not, roll on the Event Type by Hex Danger Table .

d100	action	subject	d100	action	subject	d100	action	subject	d100	action	subject
01	Adapt	Ally	26	Defy	Emissary	51	Ignore	Lie	76	Reassure	Ruin
02	Alter	Ancestor	27	Demand	Elements	52	Implore	Lock	77	Recover	Sanctuary
03	Antagonize	Army	28	Destroy	Enemy	53	Impress	Loyalty	78	Remember	Secret
04	Attack	Artifact	29	Devour	Faction	54	Inspire	Magic	79	Repel	Shadow
05	Avoid	Beast	30	Discover	Failure	55	Instigate	Map	80	Rescue	Shield
06	Awaken	Betrayal	31	Disguise	Fauna	56	Interpret	Message	81	Retreat	Ship
07	Bargain	Bond	32	Dominate	Festival	57	Intimidate	Mistake	82	Reveal	Sibling
08	Barter	Bounty	33	Eavesdrop	Flora	58	Investigate	Monster	83	Sabotage	Stone
09	Believe	Caravan	34	Embolden	Freedom	59	Invoke	Monument	84	Sacrifice	Storm
10	Breach	Challenge	35	Encircle	Friend	60	Isolate	Mystery	85	Scatter	Stranger
11	Build	Chaos	36	Encourage	Gamble	61	Lure	Nightmare	86	Search	Stronghold
12	Capture	Choice	37	Enlist	Gate	62	Mark	Offering	87	Seek	Supplies
13	Challenge	Cold	38	Enrage	Goal	63	Negotiate	Omen	88	Shield	Task
14	Chase	Conflict	39	Entangle	Heat	64	Offer	Pact	89	Steal	Temple
15	Climb	Connection	40	Entertain	Heirloom	65	Overhear	Passage	90	Strengthen	Time
16	Comfort	Contraband	41	Escape	Heritage	66	Perceive	Plague	91	Study	Tomb
17	Conceal	Contract	42	Evade	Illusion	67	Plan	Pride	92	Subdue	Tower
18	Confront	Creature	43	Execute	Influence	68	Preach	Prisoner	93	Subvert	Trap
19	Connect	Curiosity	44	Expand	Justice	69	Protect	Prophecy	94	Summon	Treasure
20	Contain	Curse	45	Explore	Key	70	Provoke	Rebellion	95	Survive	Vengeance
21	Coordinate	Debt	46	Flee	Knowledge	71	Punish	Reflection	96	Translate	Vision
22	Counter	Disaster	47	Forgive	Labyrinth	72	Pursue	Refuge	97	Warn	Water
23	Cripple	Disguise	48	Fortify	Landmark	73	Quell	Relationship	98	Watch	Weapon
24	Deface	Dream	49	Guard	Leader	74	Rally	Rift	99	Withdraw	Weather
25	Defend	Duel	50	Hide	Legend	75	Reassess	Rival	100	Withhold	Wound

Event Type by Hex Danger

Roll on the table corresponding to the Danger Level of the current hex, then on the indicated set of subtables.

d100	Safe	Neutral	Precarious	Dangerous
01-05	Ambush	Catastrophic Event	Catastrophic Event	Catastrophic Event
06-10	Environmental Hazard	Major Threat	Major Threat	Major Threat
11-15	Minor Threat	Ambush	Major Threat	Major Threat
16-20	Accident	Trap	Ambush	Major Threat
21-25	Wary NPC	Environmental Hazard	Ambush	Ambush
26-30	Strange Phenomenon	Minor Threat	Trap	Ambush
31-35	Curious Wildlife	Lost	Environmental Hazard	Trap
36-40	Mysterious Clue	Accident	Environmental Hazard	Environmental Hazard
41-45	Scenic Moment	Wary NPC	Minor Threat	Environmental Hazard
46-50	Scenic Moment	Strange Phenomenon	Minor Threat	Minor Threat
51-55	Social Interaction	Curious Wildlife	Lost	Minor Threat
56-60	Social Interaction	Mysterious Clue	Accident	Lost
61-65	Trade Opportunity	Scenic Moment	Wary NPC	Accident
66-70	Trade Opportunity	Social Interaction	Strange Phenomenon	Wary NPC
71-75	Resource Opportunity	Trade Opportunity	Curious Wildlife	Strange Phenomenon
76-80	Environmental Boon	Resource Opportunity	Mysterious Clue	Mysterious Clue
81-85	Helpful NPC	Environmental Boon	Scenic Moment	Scenic Moment
86-90	Helpful NPC	Helpful NPC	Resource Opportunity	Resource Opportunity
91-95	Discovery	Discovery	Discovery	Discovery
96-100	Site	Site	Site	Site

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Accident

A minor injury or mishap occurs within the party (e.g., a twisted ankle, dropped item, etc.).

d100	Type	Cause	Possible Consequence
01-10	Burnout or exhaustion	Anxiety, fear, or panic	Damage to critical equipment
11-20	Conflict between party members	Carelessness or distraction	Delay in progress
21-30	Equipment failure (broken, torn, etc.)	Conflict with a mount or pack animal	Loss of morale
31-40	Lost item (dropped, misplaced, etc.)	Fatigue or exhaustion	Minor injury or infection
41-50	Minor injury (sprain, cut, bruise, etc.)	Faulty or poorly maintained equipment	Noise or sign that alerts hostiles
51-60	Miscommunication	Ignorance or lack of knowledge	Opportunity to recover or adapt
61-70	Misfire or mishandling of volatile item	Magical or supernatural interference	Resource loss
71-80	Poison or illness	Overconfidence	Risk of further injury or threat
81-90	Slip or fall (down slope, into water, etc.)	Unexpected environmental factor	Social tension within the party
91-100	Unintended noise	Unseen hazard (loose rock, etc.)	Temporary incapacitation

Ambush

Hostile forces attack suddenly, with the intent of capture or inflicting harm.

d100	Type	Tactics	Motivation
01-10	Assassins/Bounty hunters targeting party member	Attack from above	Capture for ransom or information
11-20	Bandits or brigands	Attack, then feign retreat	Escalating hostility after misunderstanding
21-30	Cultists or religious zealots	Camouflage	Random violence or sadistic entertainment
31-40	Hostile wildlife	Coordinated charge	Recruitment or coercion
41-50	Local militia, territorial guards, or barbarians	Forced bottleneck	Revenge for perceived slight or trespass
51-60	Mercenaries	Intimidation	Ritualistic purpose
61-70	Opportunistic scavengers	Lure with decoy or bait	Robbery
71-80	Predatory monsters	Missile barrage	Seeking food or supplies
81-90	Rival party or faction	Surround and attack from all sides	Strategic elimination of a perceived threat
91-100	Roll on Enemy Subtable	Traps set ahead of time	Territorial defense

Catastrophic Event

A major disaster or overwhelming threat occurs, requiring immediate action to survive (e.g., an earthquake, a magical anomaly, invasion).

d100	Type	Cause	Possible Consequence
01-10	Earthquake (tremor, fissure, etc.)	Ancient mechanism	Altered terrain
11-20	Flood (sudden torrent, flash flood, etc.)	Collapse of long-decayed infra-structure	Delayed progress
21-30	Landslide or avalanche	Conflict or war	Injury, infection or death
31-40	Magical or supernatural calamity	Divine wrath or celestial event	Local creatures become agitated or displaced
41-50	Meteor strike or celestial event	Experimentation gone wrong	Loss of resources or supplies
51-60	Plague or contamination	Invasion or incursion	Necessity for time-sensitive escape
61-70	Structural collapse (cave-in, etc.)	Magical or supernatural interference	New environmental hazards are created
71-80	Violent storm (hurricane, sandstorm, etc.)	Natural (weather, geological activity, etc.)	Opportunity for discovery
81-90	Volcanic activity (eruption, ashfall, etc.)	Predatory creature or force	Potential for recurrence or expansion
91-100	Wildfire	Reckless behavior of faction	Separation or isolation of party members

Curious Wildlife

Local animals approach the party, with harmless or mildly disruptive results.

d100	Type	Behavior	Possible Consequence
01-10	Fantastical beast (gryphon, etc.)	Aggressive, perceives party as threat or prey	Delayed progress
11-20	Flying creature (hawk, owl, etc.)	Approaching cautiously, curious but wary	Gain a useful resource
21-30	Insect swarm (bees, ants, beetles, etc.)	Defensive posture, ready to attack if provoked	Long-term threat
31-40	Large herbivore (deer, elk, etc.)	Herd migration, nearby or coming head-on	Magical or symbolic effect
41-50	Magical creature (glowmoths, elemental, etc.)	Mischievous	Minor loss of resources or supplies
51-60	Pack animals (wolves, feral dogs, etc.)	Observing from a distance	Neutral parting
61-70	Predator (mountain lion, giant spider, etc.)	Scavenging through camp or supplies	Physical injury
71-80	Sentient wildlife (talking crow, etc.)	Territorial display (stomping, hissing, etc.)	Potential ally
81-90	Small scavenger (raccoon, fox, giant rat, etc.)	Unusual or magical behavior	Revelation or clue
91-100	Water-dwelling creature (crocodile, fish, etc.)	Vocalizing (Growling, chirping, etc.)	Spooked NPCs, mounts, or pack animals

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Discovery

The party finds something potentially useful, such as a hidden cache, path, or clue.

d100	Type	Origin	Possible Consequence
01-10	Clue or message	Adventurers or explorers	Indication of opportunity
11-20	Environmental feature (ore deposit, etc.)	Ancient civilization	Confusion or debate within the party
21-30	Forgotten structure (ruins, hut, etc.). Roll on Site Subtables	Magical or supernatural event	Cursed or dangerous
31-40	Hidden cache (supplies, treasure, etc.)	Mysterious origin	Delayed progress
41-50	Magical anomaly (strange lights, etc.)	Natural phenomenon (erosion, etc.)	Environmental change
51-60	Natural wonder (hot spring, crystal cave, etc.)	Recently abandoned	Gain resources or supplies
61-70	Path or trail	Religious or ceremonial (offering, etc.)	Magical or supernatural boon
71-80	Relic or artifact	Trap or deception (lure, bait, etc.)	New threat introduced
81-90	Remains (wildlife, travelers, etc.)	War or conflict (battle or duel site, etc.)	Personal connection to party member or goal
91-100	Trap or mechanism	Wildlife activity (den, burrow, hoard, etc.)	Rivalry or claim

Environmental Boon

A natural feature provides an opportunity for safety, rest, resources, or other benefit.

d100	Type	Source	Benefit
01-10	Abundant game or fish	Ancient effort or artifice	Beneficial or cooperative wildlife
11-20	Edible plants or fruits	Inexplicable	Efficient travel
21-30	Ideal weather	Intelligent influence or interference	New opportunity
31-40	Defensive feature (high ground, thicket, etc.)	Magical, divine, or supernatural	Restoration or healing
41-50	Rare resource (herbs, ore vein, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Revelation or insight
51-60	Safe path (shortcut, hidden path, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Safety
61-70	Scenic beauty (inspires, boosts morale, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Temporary aid
71-80	Shelter (cave, overhang, etc.)	Recent event	Tenuous advantage (comes at a risk)
81-90	Source of potable water	Seasonal effect	Unintended disturbance
91-100	Unusual feature (hot spring, healing mud, etc.)	Wildlife activity	Warning

Environmental Hazard

A natural event or hazard poses significant danger, such as an avalanche, flood, or quicksand.

d100	Type	Cause	Possible Consequence
01-10	Dangerous wildlife (stampede, predator, etc.)	Ancient effort or artifice	Altered terrain
11-20	Extreme weather (hurricane, blizzard, etc.)	Inexplicable	Delayed progress
21-30	Falling debris (rockfall, avalanche, etc.)	Intelligent influence or interference	Injury, infection or death
31-40	Fire (wildfire, lightning strike, etc.)	Magical, divine, or supernatural	Local creatures become agitated or displaced
41-50	Flooding (flash flood, rising tide, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Loss of resources or supplies
51-60	Impeding terrain (quicksand, bog, etc.)	Natural occurrence	Necessity for time-sensitive escape
61-70	Magical or supernatural anomaly	Natural occurrence	New environmental hazards are created
71-80	Sudden collapse (cave-in, sinkhole, etc.)	Recent event or disaster	Opportunity for discovery
81-90	Thorny or toxic vegetation	Seasonal effect	Potential for recurrence or expansion
91-100	Volcanic activity (tremors, fumes, etc.)	Wildlife activity	Separation or isolation of party members

Helpful NPC*

A local individual or group offers assistance, guidance, or resources.

d100	Type	Motivation	Possible Benefit
01-10	Commoner (farmer, laborer, etc.)	Altruism	Companionship
11-20	Guide (hunter, ranger, tracker, etc.)	Cultural obligation	Connection or influence
21-30	Healer (herbalist, medic, etc.)	Curiosity	Healing or restoration
31-40	Merchant or trader	Desire for protection	Information, advice, or insight
41-50	Religious figure (priest, shaman, etc.)	Duty, oath, or debt	Mediation or negotiation
51-60	Scholar or sage (historian, wizard, etc.)	Mutual enemy	Opportunity or job
61-70	Scout or messenger	Opportunism	Safety, shelter, or protection
71-80	Soldier or guard	Religious or moral principle	Special skill or item
81-90	Tradesperson (smith, carpenter, etc.)	Shared goal	Supplies or equipment
91-100	Wanderer (drifter, nomad, etc.)	Trade or barter	Transportation

*Roll on the NPC Trait Subtable in Chapter 18 - Bestiary, as needed.

Lost

The party's sense of direction is disrupted, leading to delays or wrong turns.

d100	Cause	Possible Consequence	Remedy
01-10	Distraction	Conflicting choices (multiple trails, etc.)	Choose wisely (forking paths, etc.)
11-20	Environmental change (sudden fog, etc.)	Delayed progress	Discover hidden or forgotten route
21-30	Forced detour (landslide, fallen trees, etc.)	Exposure (vulnerability to the elements)	Discover sign of travelers (campfire smoke, etc.)
31-40	Magical or supernatural interference	Heightened peril (Hex Danger Level increased by 1)	Find local guide
41-50	Miscalculation (misreading of map, etc.)	Increased tension among party members	Follow echo or sounds (flowing water, etc.)
51-60	Misleading clues (left by others)	Isolation (someone gets separated)	Follow tracks or animal trail
61-70	Overconfidence	New area or Site discovered	Interpret signs (weather, sun, stars, etc.)
71-80	Route obscured (overgrowth, flooding, etc.)	Physical fatigue (exhaustion, minor injury, etc.)	Locate known landmark
81-90	Sabotage or deceit	Resource or supply depletion	Notice animal behavior
91-100	Separation	Unexpected encounter (hostile creature, etc.)	Trust magic or divine power (spell, prayer, etc.)

Major Threat

A significant enemy or group that poses a serious threat.

d100	Type	Behavior	Possible Consequence
01-10	Alpha predator (dragon, etc.)	Attempts to separate weaker foes	Attraction of additional threats
11-20	Corrupted or cursed wildlife	Charges aggressively	Capture of a party member or NPC
21-30	Hostile humanoid group*	Considers lesser foes not worth the trouble	Discovery of lair or cache of treasure
31-40	Large predatory creature (bear, roc, etc.)	Defends lair or territory	Environmental change (fire, destruction, etc.)
41-50	Large swarm (ravens, giant rats, etc.	Directs subordinates or minions	Escalation into prolonged battle or chase
51-60	Major undead (death knight, etc.)	Displays power before striking	Forced retreat causes disorientation
61-70	Organized bandit gang	Retreats to regroup or call reinforcements	Long-term condition (infection, curse, poison, disease, etc.)
71-80	Powerful magical beast (Void demon, werewolf, etc.)	Sets up trap, ambush, or bottleneck	Loss of valuable resources or equipment
81-90	Rogue mage or priest	Stalks, waiting for opening to strike	Reward for victory (bounty, fame, etc.)
91-100	Roll on Enemy Subtable	Uses environmental features to its advantage	Serious injury to one or more party members

*Humanoid Subtable

01-10..Bolg Fiir	21-25..Half-giants	46-60..Ogres	100..Replaced
11-20..Dwarves	26-45..Hobgoblins	61-99..Orcs	

Minor Threat

A run-in with NPCs, aggressive wildlife, or territorial locals, which may escalate.

d100	Type	Behavior	Possible Consequence
01-10	Lone bandit or thief	Alerts allies	Clue to presence of another threat or discovery
11-20	Minor magical creature (sprite, etc.)	Attacks if approached	Discovery of a nearby camp, den, or nest
21-30	Minor predator (wolf, giant spider, etc.)	Charges recklessly	Escalation into a major threat
31-40	Minor undead (zombie, skeleton, etc.)	Defends nearby camp, den, or nest	Fight or chase in difficult terrain
41-50	Opportunistic scavenger (vulture, etc.)	Feigns retreat to lure into a trap	Lost supplies or mount
51-60	Trap or snare	Flees when confronted	Minor injury or infection to party member or mount
61-70	Swarm (bats, bees, locusts, etc.)	Observes from a distance	Noise alerts other creatures nearby
71-80	Territorial local (villager, hermit, barbarian, etc.)	Responds fiercely to perceived aggression	Opportunity to harvest resources
81-90	Territorial wildlife (boar, snake, etc.)	Scavenges or steals supplies or mounts	Temporary delay
91-100	Roll on Enemy Subtable	Stalks, waiting for opening to strike	Threat flees, leaving behind useful clue or item

Mysterious Clue

The party stumbles across something intriguing but potentially ominous.

d100	Type	Origin	Possible Consequence
01-10	Abandoned campsite or post	Connected to nearby creature, hiding or dead	Alters understanding of existing factor
11-20	Broken item (weapon, armor, tool, etc.)	Decoy or bait	Attracts unwanted attention
21-30	Fragment of text or symbols (parchment, etc.)	Deliberate message	Connects to a backstory or personal goal
31-40	Liquid spill (blood, oil, etc.)	Evidence of dramatic event (battle, etc.)	Delays progress by creating distraction
41-50	Map with cryptic markings or annotations	Left by recent travelers	Offers new objective
51-60	Odd wildlife behavior (silent, repetitive, etc.)	Remains of failed endeavor	Points to something hidden (path, loot, etc.)
61-70	Strange scent (incense, flowers, rot, etc.)	Remnant of traveling merchant or caravan	Provides relevant and useful information
71-80	Strange symbol (carved, painted, etc.)	Residue of magical or supernatural force	Temporary boon
81-90	Tracks toward or away from unknown location	Sign of long-lost settlement or civilization	Triggers a trap or other hazard
91-100	Unexpected sound (bell, whispers, etc.)	Sign of ritual or ceremony	Unanswered questions provoke debate

Resource Opportunity

A chance to gather food, supplies, or treasure.

d100	Type	Detail	Possible Benefit or Complication
01-10	Animal byproducts (pelts, bones, etc.)	Abandoned settlement or campsite nearby	Attracts unwanted attention
11-20	Cache of supplies or gear	Affected by recent event (flood, storm, etc.)	Creates future opportunity (for trade, etc.)
21-30	Edible flora (berries, nuts, mushrooms, etc.)	Ancient site nearby (ruin, vault, etc.)	Depletes quickly
31-40	Fuel source (dry wood, peat, coal, etc.)	Destination (for hunters, gatherers, etc.)	Gathering or extraction causes delay
41-50	Hunting or fishing opportunity	Guarded by local wildlife	Leads to additional discovery
51-60	Magical resource (crystals, reagents, etc.)	Hidden (in a cave, thicket, etc.)	Potentially dangerous (poisonous, etc.)
61-70	Source of fresh water (stream, spring, etc.)	Ignored or discarded (by locals, travelers, etc.)	Provides short-term boost (to strength, etc.)
71-80	Valuable flora (medicinal herbs, spices, etc.)	Naturally occurring	Provokes debate or conflict
81-90	Valuable minerals or ores (iron, gold, etc.)	Religious or magical significance	Requires specialized tools or knowledge
91-100	Wood or stone	Revealed recently (by earthquake, erosion, etc.)	Restorative (wounds, Resolve, morale, etc.)

Scenic Moment

A peaceful or awe-inspiring scene, providing respite or inspiration.

d100	Type	Detail	Possible Effect
01-10	Ancient artifice (standing stones, etc.)	Clarity (crisp air, clear vision, etc.)	Inspires an idea or solution
11-20	Breathtaking (distant mountains, lake, etc.)	Landmark (rock formation, distinct tree, etc.)	Instills awe or humility
21-30	Celestial (aurora, meteor shower, etc.)	Light (rainbow, shimmering, glittering, etc.)	Momentarily distracting
31-40	Dramatic (waterfall, precipitous cliffs, etc.)	Notable smells (flowers, animals in rut, etc.)	Offers a safe place to rest
41-50	Hopeful (shafts of light, open horizon, etc.)	Notable sounds (birdsong, flowing water, etc.)	Opportunity for introspection
51-60	Lush flora (wildflowers, jungle, etc.)	Overgrowth (vines, flowers, etc.)	Provides an advantage
61-70	Otherworldly (strange geology, glowing, etc.)	Sign of the past (carving, inscription, etc.)	Restores morale or Resolve
71-80	Serene (misty valley, quiet river, etc.)	Silence	Reveals a relevant clue or detail
81-90	Vibrant colors (sunrise, sunset, foliage, etc.)	Subdued (shadowy, dewy, misty, etc.)	Sparks conversation or memory
91-100	Wildlife (vast herd or flock, etc.)	Weather (warm breeze, sprinkling of rain, etc.)	Strangely foreboding

Social Interaction*

A neutral or positive conversation with a traveler or local.

d100	Type	Demeanor	Possible Consequence
01-10	Awkward run-in	Aloof or indifferent	Accidental offense
11-20	Chance meeting	Cautious or mistrustful	Aroused suspicion
21-30	Confrontation or fight	Distracted or preoccupied	Curiosity (about a new goal, location, etc.)
31-40	Cryptic message	Earnest and sincere	Delayed progress
41-50	Debate or argument	Enthusiastic and excitable	News (local gossip, rumor, etc.)
51-60	Invitation to food or drink	Friendly and welcoming	Nothing of note
61-70	Negotiation	Nervous or secretive	Potential ally
71-80	Opportunity to share knowledge	Overly inquisitive	Resources or equipment
81-90	Passing conversation	Sly or manipulative	Valuable information
91-100	Request for aid	Stern or authoritative	Warning or insight (potential threat, etc.)

*Roll on the NPC Trait Subtable in Chapter 18 - Bestiary, as needed.

Strange Phenomenon

The environment behaves oddly, potentially posing a minor challenge or confusion.

d100	Type	Source	Possible Effect
01-10	Altered flora or fauna (glowing, decaying, etc.)	Ancient or unstable magic	Alters equipment or resources
11-20	Energetic shift (tingling air, magnetic pull, etc.)	Connection to religious figure or force	Attracts unwanted attention
21-30	Ethereal presence (being watched, etc.)	Influence of a powerful artifact	Clue or vision (prophecy, opportunity, etc.)
31-40	Inexplicable sensation (calm, dread, vertigo, etc.)	Influence of creature or entity	Escalates, leading to larger encounter or threat
41-50	Odd sounds (whispering, drumming, etc.)	Lingering effects of battle or spell	Fades, leaving mysterious object or evidence
51-60	Spatial distortion (looping paths, etc.)	Natural but rare environmental factors	Imbues strange feeling (being watched, etc.)
61-70	Temporal distortion (slowing, etc.)	Presence of a supernatural rift or portal	Minor boon (inspiration, etc.)
71-80	Unnatural movement (shifting objects, etc.)	Ritual or summoning	Minor affliction (curse, nausea, bad luck, etc.)
81-90	Unusual weather (sudden storm, dense fog, etc.)	Trickster or illusionist	Sense of wonder or unease
91-100	Visual anomaly (lights, mirage, etc.)	Warning or precursor to a larger event	Temporary disorientation

Trade Opportunity*

A chance to gather food, supplies, or treasure.

d100	Type	Additional Goods	Possible Outcome
01-10	Collector (seeking specific or unique items)	Rations (food, water, etc.)	Barter for favor instead of goods
11-20	Exotic trader (from afar, unusual items, etc.)	Curiosities (oddities, magical trinkets, etc.)	Discovered connection
21-30	Local tradesperson (blacksmith, tailor, etc.)	Documents (maps, charts, plans, etc.)	Exceeded expectations
31-40	Nomadic trader (part of a group or clan)	Medical supplies (herbs, bandages, etc.)	Fair deal
41-50	Peddler (trinkets, tools, small items, etc.)	Livestock or mounts	Faulty goods
51-60	Religious figure (blessings, charms, relics, etc.)	Luxury or exotic items (spices, fabrics, etc.)	Hidden agenda (spying, scamming, etc.)
61-70	Reluctant villager (trading out of necessity)	Rare materials (alchemical supplies, etc.)	Lead on future opportunity
71-80	Resource gatherer (hunter, miner, etc.)	Gear (rope, lockpicks, etc.)	Overcharged
81-90	Retired adventurer (old gear, rare items, etc.)	Useful information (news, knowledge, etc.)	Undercharged
91-100	Traveling merchant or caravan	Weapons or armor (refurbished, etc.)	Unintended conflict

*Roll on the NPC Trait Subtable in Chapter 18 - Bestiary, as needed.

Trap

The party triggers or encounters a physical danger, such as a pitfall or collapsing structure.

d100	Type	Origin	Possible Consequence
01-10	Alarm (loud noise, silent signal, etc.)	Ancient civilization	Attracts unwanted attention
11-20	Environmental hazard (quicksand, etc.)	Bandits or thieves	Clue revealed
21-30	Explosive (alchemical or magical device)	Creatures or monsters	Damage to route (bridge, path, etc.)
31-40	Falling object (rocks, logs, cage, etc.)	Hunters	Disarmed without incident
41-50	Illusory (lure, bait, disguise, etc.)	Locals (villagers, hermit, etc.)	Environmental change (flooding, fire, etc.)
51-60	Magical (ward, blinding glyph, etc.)	Magical or supernatural entity	Physical injury or infection
61-70	Mechanical (spring-loaded, bear trap, etc.)	Mercenaries or bounty hunters	Resource loss (damaged equipment, etc.)
71-80	Pitfall (covered hole, steep drop, etc.)	Military force	Separation or isolation
81-90	Poisoned (darts, needles, gas, etc.)	Natural	Status effect (infection, poison, blindness, paralysis, etc.)
91-100	Snare (rope, vine, net, etc.)	Rivals	Unexpected benefit

Wary NPC*

A person or group with unclear intent observes or interacts with the party.

d100	Type	Reason	Consequence
01-10	Fugitive (fleeing, hiding from pursuers)	Fear of authority (soldiers, tax collectors, etc.)	Alerts others
11-20	Local commoner (villager, farmer, etc.)	Guarding something valuable	Becomes hostile
21-30	Militia or guard (suspicious of outsiders, etc.)	Personal trauma	Demands favor or bribe
31-40	Outcast or hermit	Recent attacks (bandits, etc.)	Establishes a connection
41-50	Reluctant informant	Recent interaction went wrong	Flees the scene
51-60	Scout or ranger	Reluctance to get involved	Gains trust and offers minor help
61-70	Superstitious local	Rumors (tales of monsters, thieves, etc.)	Refuses to help
71-80	Traitor or spy	Signs of threat (weapons, injuries, etc.)	Requests or demands departure
81-90	Traveling merchant	Superstition	Reveals useful information
91-100	Weary traveler	Unfamiliar appearance	Spreads rumors

*Roll on the NPC Trait Subtable in Chapter 18 - Bestiary, as needed.

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the site subtables

A location with a type, condition, original function and occupants with roles, dispositions, resources, and other features. Use as many or as few of these tables as needed to develop the Site.

Site Subtable A: Site Type

d100	Type
01-02	Amphitheater/arena
03-04	Barrow/mound
05-06	Battlefield
07-08	Beacon/lighthouse
09-10	Bridge
11-12	Campsite
13-14	Cave
15-16	Cemetery
17-18	Cove/grotto
19-20	Crossroads/trading post
21-22	Den/hideout
23-24	Dock
25-26	Fae circle
27-28	Farmstead
29-30	Forge
31-32	Fortress/citadel
33-34	Glade/clearing
35-36	Grove/copse
37-38	Guardhouse/tollhouse
39-40	Hamlet/village
41-42	Hut/hovel
43-44	Inn/roadhouse
45-46	Island
47-48	Keep/castle
49-50	Labyrinth
51-52	Library/archive
53-54	Lodge/manor
55-56	Mausoleum
57-58	Mill/Granary
59-60	Mine
61-62	Monastery/Abbey
63-64	Oracle
65-66	Orchard/Vineyard
67-68	Outpost/Watchtower
69-70	Pass/Ravine
71-72	Pit/Excavation
73-74	Prison
75-76	Ruin
77-78	Sanctuary
79-80	School/Academy
81-82	Shrine/Chapel
83-84	Spring/Well
85-86	Standing Stones
87-88	Temple/Church
89-90	Tomb/Crypt
91-92	Tower
93-94	Vault
95-96	Village
97-98	Waterfall
99-100	Waystation/Tollhouse

Site Subtable B: Condition

d100	Condition
01-05	Active (in use)
06-10	Overgrown
11-15	In dispute
16-20	Abandoned
21-25	Recently disturbed
26-30	Partially ruined
31-35	Completely ruined
36-40	Restored/rebuilt
41-45	Flooded/sunken
46-50	Haunted
51-55	Deserted
56-60	Desecrated
61-65	Infested (creatures/vermin)
66-70	Fortified
71-75	Cursed/forsaken
76-80	Weathered (eroded/aged)
81-85	Reclaimed (by nature/ original inhabitants)
86-90	Occupied (by outsiders/ non-original inhabitants)
91-95	Sealed
96-100	Enchanted

Site Subtable C:
Original Function, if Unclear

d100	Function
01-05	Bulwark/fortification
06-10	Burial/interment
11-15	Defense/protection
16-20	Ceremony/ritual
21-25	Communication
26-30	Crafting/smithing
31-35	Education
36-40	Feasting/celebration
41-45	Gathering/meeting
46-50	Healing/medicine
51-55	Law/judgement
56-60	Memorial/remembrance
61-65	Record-keeping
66-70	Research/study
71-75	Seclusion/contemplation
76-80	Shelter
81-85	Storage
86-90	Trade/commerce
91-95	Training
96-100	Worship

Site Subtable D: Occupant Role
*or roll on Enemy Subtable

d100	Role
01-10	Bandits (using site as hideout)
11-15	Cultists (serving dark purpose)
16-20	Exiles/outcasts (fleeing or hiding)
21-30	Explorers (investigating)
31-35	Guardians (protecting something valuable), or Original Inhabitants
36-40	Healers (tending sick/wounded)
41-45	Nomads (temporary residents)
46-50	Researchers (studying site's secrets)
51-60	Scavengers (searching for resources)
61-95	Wild (using site as den/shelter)
96-100	Monsters (using site as lair)

Site Subtable E: Occupant Disposition

d100	Disposition
01-05	Cursed (trapped/bound to the site)
06-10	Fanatical (unyielding in their faith/mission)
11-15	Helpful (willing to aid others)
16-35	Hostile (aggressive/malevolent)
36-40	Mystic (engaged in meditative/ mystical practices)
41-50	Neutral (not actively interacting but aware)
51-65	Opportunistic (looking to barter/trade)
66-75	Peaceful (seeking knowledge/harmony)
76-90	Suspicious (wary of newcomers)
91-100	Vigilant (on guard against threats)

Site Subtable F: Occupant Resources

d100	Resources
01-05	Arcane tools (in possession of magical artifacts)
06-20	Defensive measures (traps, fortifications, etc.)
21-25	Heavily armored (battle-ready)
26-40	Lightly armed (simple tools/weapons)
41-50	Religious supplies (items of worship/devotion)
51-55	Ritual supplies (preparing for mystical or dark rituals)
56-70	Scavenged equipment (used, old, or mismatched gear)
71-85	Survival gear (equipped for harsh conditions)
86-90	Treasure hoard (protecting wealth or valuables)
91-100	Well-provisioned (ready for travel or long stay)

Site Subtable G: Occupant Other Feature

d100	Feature
01-07	Blessed/anointed/ordained
08-15	Clan/tribe/cult/faction affiliation
16-22	Clever/stealthy/deceptive
23-30	Cursed/corrupted/condemned
31-37	Feral/wild
38-45	Hierarchical/organized
46-52	Magical/enchanted
53-60	Mercenary/freelance
61-67	Mutated/altered
68-75	Oathbound/honorable
76-82	Possessed/controlled
83-90	Rebel/insurgent
91-100	Well-adapted/symbiotic/parasitic

Enemy Subtable

Use this table as inspiration to create your own unique and interesting foes.

d100	Enemy 1st part	Enemy 2nd part
01-02	Ancient	Abominations
03-04	Arcane	Acolytes
05-06	Barbaric	Archers
07-08	Berserk	Assassins
09-10	Blessed	Bandits
11-12	Bloodthirsty	Barbarians
13-14	Chaotic	Beasts
15-16	Corrupted	Bounty Hunters
17-18	Cursed	Brigands
19-20	Decrepit	Cultists
21-22	Desperate	Dark Fae
23-24	Devout	Demons
25-26	Duplicitous	Fades
27-28	Enchanted	Followers
29-30	Feral	Ghosts
31-32	Forsaken	Giants
33-34	Frenzied	Godbound
35-36	Haunted	Guards
37-38	Heretical	Humanoids*
39-40	Hidden	Hunters
41-42	Incorporeal	Insects
43-44	Illusory	Invaders
45-46	Infected	Knights
47-48	Infernal	Marauders
49-50	Insane	Mercenaries
51-52	Itinerant	Nomads
53-54	Malevolent	Outcasts
55-56	Mercenary	Outlaws
57-58	Mundane	Predators
59-60	Mysterious	Raiders
61-62	Parasitic	Reptiles
63-64	Poisonous	Rogues
65-66	Reclusive	Scavengers
67-68	Relentless	Seekers
69-70	Ruthless	Sentinels
71-72	Sacred	Shadows
73-74	Savage	Shamans
75-76	Scarred	Shapeshifters
77-78	Shadowy	Skirmishers
79-80	Starving	Soldiers
81-82	Tainted	Spellweavers
83-84	Terrifying	Spies
85-86	Traitorous	Swarms
87-88	Twisted	Thieves
89-90	Unholy	Trackers
91-92	Vengeful	Traitors
93-94	Vigilant	Undead
95-96	Violent	Vermin
97-98	Wandering	Warriors
99-100	Watchful	Zealots

*Humanoid Subtable

01-10	Bolg Fiir
11-20	Dwarves
21-25	Half-giants
26-45	Hobgoblins
46-60	Ogres
61-99	Orcs
100	Replaced

Event Creation Example

Picking up on the Arn, Simon, and Edbert travel example from earlier, this is how the GM might create the Event. The GM rolls "Provoke" and "Stone" on the Initial Prompt Table. Because this is a yellow hex, he rolls on the Event Type by Hex Danger Table for more inspiration and gets "Environmental Hazard". Further rolls on that subtable produce "Sudden collapse", "Natural occurrence", and "Injury, infection or death". He rolls for Difficulty and gets "Challenging". Knowing the terrain is rocky, the GM uses these rolls to inform the Event.

Edbert the Scout fails his Perception roll with an 81. If the GM did not already know what the Event was, he might have used the odd roll to set it at night, but the Event works better by day.

The GM describes the group climbing the rocky foothills beneath the late afternoon summer sun when loose scree suddenly gives way beneath them. They risk losing their footing and tumbling down the slope. Because Edbert failed his Perception roll, they have no chance to prepare and gain no bonuses.

Simon and Edbert try to catch themselves with Athletics rolls, while Arn grabs exposed roots and tries to hold on as the scree cascades around him (Endurance). Simon succeeds with 3 SLs and asks if his extra SLs can help Edbert (see Chapter 2 - Core Mechanics: Standard Rolls), who is tumbling nearby. The GM agrees, granting Edbert +5 on his next roll. Edbert succeeds, but Arn fails. The GM assigns 4 points of internal bashing damage from the Challenging Difficulty to a random location: Arn is struck in the right thigh by a falling boulder. He succeeds at the Wound Die roll, so the leg is not impaired.

Once safe, Simon treats Arn's wound, reducing it by 2 points and setting it with a Recovery Bonus of +10. It will not heal while they're still on a Journey, and because Edbert's earlier wounds have already become infected, the party decides to enter Daily Time, despite their urgency.

Additional Event Examples

Casilda, Athelgar, and Rothan encounter a morose, suspicious old healer in the woods. The GM decides this will be a full Social Encounter. He assigns her a Tolerance of 4 with no Special Reactions (see Chapter 13 - Intrigue).

Rothan tries to convince the old woman to help them (Persuade), while Athelgar Performs an old Dunblainish ballad to lift her spirits. Casilda offers to gather healing herbs with a Naturewise roll. Together they achieve 16 SLs, a great outcome. The GM decides she rewards them with a natural healing potion worth 10 WP of healing, and also grants them 3 Travel Lore by sharing local information.

Elsewhere in the Broken Empires, another party has entered a Precarious hex in the Red Wastes. The Scout succeeds on her Perception roll with 3 SLs. Whatever comes next, the party may either gain +10 on their first roll or +3 to their Initiative roll if combat occurs.

Because the hex is Precarious, the GM decides a dangerous but non-lethal challenge lies ahead. Rolling the descriptors "Adapt Storm," he decides on a Hard Event that inflicts 6 Fatigue on each party member, reducible through DoS.

Drawing on the desert setting, he describes the party fleeing a gathering sandstorm threatening to engulf them. Each character has one chance to act. The players describe how they avoid, escape, or endure the storm, rolling appropriate skills and applying the Scout's +10 bonus if they can justify it. Those who succeed reduce the incoming Fatigue by their SLs.

chapter 12: travel

premade events

The sample Events below are presented in the following format:

Event Name

Hex Danger Level in which the Event should occur | Randomizer words used to generate the Event Difficulty

Event details and description, including any numbers derived from or inspired by the Event Difficulty Table .

The Dead Marsh

Dangerous | "Sacrifice Wound" | Challenging

After traveling through a swamp (or similar terrain) for the better part of a day, the party begins to smell a bad odor coming from under the bandages of anyone with wounds. The foul air has gotten inside the wounds, and risks infecting them. Anyone who has any currently uninfected wounds must roll the Infection Die + Toughness against [points of their highest value uninfected wound + 4]. Rolling equal to or under this number causes that wound to become infected.

Raging Bear

Dangerous | "Survive Beast" | Hard

The party comes across a bear wounded by hunters (use the stats for a Thessian Bear in Chapter 18 - Bestiary). In its rage, it will attack anything it sees. Unless avoided, the bear attacks (with surprise if the Scout critically failed their Perceptionroll).

Tomb Excavation

Precarious | "Discover Tomb" | Medium

A group of orcs (as many as the party, +1 leader) are being driven by their whip-cracking leader to dig away the side of a hill, apparently trying to uncover what looks to be the entrance to an old tomb. They have established a camp with enough supplies to suggest they've been here for at least a few days. Among their belongings is evidence that they have been working in service of another. Who is it, and why? Whose tomb is this, and what lies inside? If the Scout succeeds, and the party tries to avoid the encounter, have the PC with the lowest Stealth skill roll to sneak away. Otherwise, the orcs spot the party and attack (with surprise if the Scout critically failed).

A Bloated Corpse

Precarious | "Awaken Plague" | Medium

The group stumbles across a bloated, putrescent corpse in the middle of the road. The PC with the lowest Athletics skill inadvertently stumbles and puts a foot into the chest cavity, releasing a cloud of green spores that immediately envelops the group. Anyone who has any currently uninfected wounds must roll the Infection Die + Toughness against [points of their highest value uninfected wound + 3]. Rolling equal to or under this number causes that wound to become infected.

Nest of Serpents

Precarious | "Entangle Creature" | Challenging

A single PC stumbles into a camouflaged nest of snakes. If they fail a Perception, Athletics, or Naturewise roll, they suffer several small bites. Luckily, the poison is non-lethal, but causes extreme drowsiness (4 Fatigue).

A Place of Respite

Precarious | "Negotiate Sanctuary" | Medium

The party spots a safe-looking campsite on an oxbow island in a swift river cutting through a deep gorge (or other difficult to attain place based on the current terrain). If they can find a safe way down without falling, get across the river without being swept away, and make a protected camp on the island, they can take advantage of it to recover and heal. Some ideas: Athletics to climb down safely;

Track to follow an animal pathway down the gorge; Craft: Practical and/or Sail/Boat to fashion a raft to navigate the dangerous river; Survival to make a protected camp on the island. Those who make it and rest there overnight can drop into Daily Time and make up to 5 Recovery rolls (in addition to the usual benefits from rest in this zone).

Flash Flood

Precarious | "Embolden Water" | Hard

As the PCs are filling their waterskins by a river, there is a booming sound: a deluge of river water suddenly rushes their way, the oncoming swell of the river quickly flooding its banks. The party must make appropriate skill rolls at -20 (Athletics to leap up a nearby tree, Endurance to resist the oncoming current, etc.). Whoever fails will suffer 4 points of Fatigue from being tossed around in the water as they get swept away by the current, getting washed ashore some several hundred yards downstream.

Cabin in the Woods

Precarious | "Build Mystery" | Medium

The party stumbles across an eerie-looking cabin/hut/refuge in the wilderness. It is in a very safe place and looks like they could use it to hole up for a while. Have someone with the highest Arcana skill make a roll: they get a feeling that something is watching them from inside. Lying on the ground outside the entrance is a crude club; Naturewise or Heal can reveal the dried brown smudges on it as human blood. Investigating the rooms within reveals the remains of what appears to be a human male, his skeleton collapsed beside a table as though he died in the middle of a meal. Examining the ancient remains of the meal with Naturewise reveals that the food was poisoned. Poison-wise, Streetwise or Heal can show that the poison was "Heartsbane", made from heartberries (a Naturewise or Common Lore reveals they grow wild in this area), used in food and drink to kill slowly over hours. Searching the place (Perception) reveals a bedroom closet with rugged, battered leather armor and expensive, but moldering clothing appropriate for a noble-born woman.

A locked chest can be discovered hidden away under the bed; it can be opened with Locks & Traps or smashed open with Might. Inside is an old diary written in High Angevarran; figuring it out requires an Insight or a High Angevarran Language roll.

A In a woman's handwriting, it tells of a girl and her courtier lover fleeing her arranged marriage for a new life in a better place.

A As the days turn into weeks, she realizes her lover has no intention of taking her anywhere and intends to keep her here for his own pleasure.

A She has made a foolish mistake and, in desperation, plans to poison him, but he has caught her collecting heartberries from outside and is suspicious.

A The last entry describes how he has threatened to lock her up in the pantry.

Track outside reveals an old path winding away from the cabin, leading to a shallow firepit surrounded by heartberry bushes. Heal will determine that the remains inside the firepit are of a human female, who looks to have been clubbed to death before being carelessly tossed here.

If the party gives her body simple last rites (Divinity, or Common Lore at -10), the restless spirit of the girl appears to them, tells them her story as described in the diary, smiles, and departs; Daily Time rest here reduces a PC's Fatigue by 6. If they tarry at the fire pit site, or try to rest here without solving the mystery, the spirit begins to moan and cry from everywhere at once, chilling their blood; no Daily Time rest here is possible.

The Wealth of the North

Neutral/Precarious | "Perceive Treasure" | Easy

The party's Scout finds what looks to be a buried mound/secret door/covered hidey-hole. Inside, they find a few tarnished ancient Thessian coins buried in the dirt. Commerce rolls can evaluate them as being worth a fair price to a collector, maybe 10 sp each. Those searching can make an Easy (+10) Perception roll. Success unearths more (5 coins +

5 per SL). If anyone rolls a critical success, they also find an old, sturdy small shield with Ironlander runes inscribed on it: its superior quality provides 4 AP instead of 3.

The Permeated Ground

Neutral | "Challenge Passage"| Medium

The ground underfoot is pockmarked with scores of small, ankle-sized holes, made by local critters. The holes are concealed by grasses/soil/rocks, and easily stepped in. If the PCs fail an Athletics or Endurance roll, they each take a 3-point wound to the Foot location as they twist their ankle.

Falling for Your Stories Again

Neutral | "Cripple Trap"| Easy

One of the characters (preferably the one with the highest Perform skill) is happily distracting the others with a song or story, when they blunder across a covered pit (a natural sinkhole, or perhaps laid as a trap). Have the character make a Perception roll. If they fail, they take a 2-point wound to a random location as they tumble into the pit.

A Nasty Rash

Neutral | "Adapt Flora"| Hard

The PCs have developed an itchy red rash, likely from walking through a poison ivy patch or something similar. It's easily treated, but it may take up valuable Medical supplies. Each character must make a Heal or Naturewise DoS roll vs 6, losing Medical Supply Dice equal to the difference.

The Poacher

Neutral, Social | "Implore Friend"| Challenging

A commoner is being harassed and threatened with arrest by three rangers who bear the livery of a local lord. They claim the man has been caught poaching on their lord's grounds. A dead deer lies nearby with an arrow in its side. The PC Quartermaster realizes this is the deer they themselves took a shot at a few hours before while hunting. The poacher claims innocence. The rangers can be talked into letting the man go if the party succeeds at a Social Encounter (Tolerance 3). A Success with a Cost results in the rangers setting the man free, but only after they extract a fine from him (half of his secret stash). A failure sees the rangers arrest the man and take him away. If it comes to violence, the rangers have average combat skills of 50 and are armed with broadswords and longbows, wearing a combination of leather and quilted armor. If the poacher is freed, he will reward each character with 4 Supply Dice of their choice from his nearby hidden stash, or local information worth 4 Travel Lore for their next leg if the party's supply is already full.

Thick Fog

Neutral | "Subvert Time"| Medium

A deep fog or mist descends on the area. The party gets turned around and might lose time finding each other. Those who fail a Track/Naturewise/Insight roll will take 3 Fatigue, as they waste time getting back on track.

The Ogre and the Bridge

Neutral | "Challenge Duel"| Hard

The road ahead is blocked by a swift stream. A makeshift bridge made from logs spans the stream. Blocking the way across the bridge stands a mighty ogre, bearing a war staff. He introduces himself as Big Jim, and tells the party he is under a magical command to not let anyone across the bridge unless a challenger can best him in non-lethal single combat. He will not speak of the details, but he will tell them that anyone who defeats him may take as a prize his magical silver-capped war staff. The PCs are free to go around and find another way across, but this will force them to go miles out of their way; the Guide's next roll will be at -20.

Any PC accepting Big Jim's challenge fights at -20 due to the unstable footing of the log bridge. The ogre will make use of the war staff's reduced Disarm and Choose Location cost (see below). His Melee: Heavy skill is 80 Ex4, and he wears leather armor on his body and arms. Any Disarm maneu-

vers made against him require +3 SLs. The ogre does not suffer Impairment, and cannot be knocked Prone or have his surrender compelled. As soon as he is disarmed or takes a total of 12 WP , Big Jim drops to one knee, thanking the victor effusively for breaking the curse. He hands over his staff, a superior quality silver-capped war staff (+10 Melee: Heavy, CL 4, Dis2, counts as a magical weapon when targeting supernatural creatures, 300 sp). If the players decide to instead pull a murder-hobo and kill him, the war staff (which is also the source of his curse) reverts to a plain wooden stick.

The Old Songs

Neutral | "Inspire Bond"| Medium

While the party has stopped for a rest, a patch of sunlight/moonlight briefly lights up the remains of a broken statue half covered by weeds/soil/sand/rock. The statue is of an inspirational ruler/sage/hero from ancient times, and reminds one of the characters of an old song. Ask the players what the topic of the song is, and to provide a bit of detail about its story. Every character may then make a Perform roll to recount a part of the song (players actually singing it is optional...). Those who succeed recover points of spent Resolve equal to 2 + 1 per 3 SLs. Those who fail find the words of the song are just on the tips of their tongues, but they can't remember enough of it to benefit from the nostalgia.

The Greedy Thorns

Neutral/Safe | "Defy Supplies"| Easy

The party traverses row after row of thorny hedges that tear into their packs. Those that fail a Perception to notice, or a Survival to know how to avoid it, or a Craft: Practical to be able to reinforce their packs, will lose 2 steps of Gear Supply Dice.

Good Hunting Grounds

Neutral/Safe | "Lure Refuge"| Medium

The party comes across a glade in the forest/oasis/watering hole where game and resources are plentiful. Have them describe if and how they use this resource to replenish their supplies. Ideas might be Missile attacks to bring down a deer; Survival to set a trap for smaller game or to forage for berries and to find fresh water; Craft: Practical to turn hides into clothing or to make arrows from raw materials available; or Heal to turn sinews and gut into Medical supplies. Each successful character replenishes their choice of Supply Die steps equal to 1 + 2 SLs.

The Wandering Oracle

Neutral/Safe | "Eavesdrop Omen"| Medium

The party comes across a covered wagon of loud color and garish decoration, pulled by a couple of flea-bitten mares. If they stop and speak with the occupant, they are offered to have their fortunes told by "Bogdan the Far-Seeing", a wandering Vieksgradian oracle and mystic.

He will offer to tell each character their fortune. But Bogdan doesn't take money; in exchange for their fortunes, Bogdan requires each character to "share something of their truest souls". For each PC who satisfies him, he will reward the group with 1 Travel Lore, as Bogdan's soothsaying proves accurate. To those who fail to impress, Bogdan says that their future is too shrouded in mystery.

Common Lore rolls may reveal that Bogdan is known for being reputable; Insight may reveal that Bogdan absolutely believes in his own oracular power, and is proud of it; Heal may reveal that the bones Bogdan is throwing to divine his prophecies are made of actual human knuckles, and an Arcana roll may reveal that such prophecies are indeed possible and that using real human knucklebones tends to magnify the power. The reason for Bogdan's desire for their "truest souls" is up to you, but he does not have ill intent. Or does he...?

cHAPTER 13:

intrigue

There are many types of conflicts in the world of the Broken Empires, and violent combat is but one way to produce exciting encounters. When the characters are in desperate need to procure the help of an NPC in order to pursue their dearly held goals; seek to influence someone important to change their way of thinking about a situation related to the PCs; or otherwise attempt anything that advances the characters' objectives, raises the stakes in a non-violent manner, and carries consequences for failure, we can break out the Social Encounter system.

Keywords In This Chapter

Chases
Competitive Encounter
Investigations
Investigation Timer Die
Leverage
Social Encounter
Special Reactions
Static Encounter
Tolerance
Victory Condition

The following rules give guidance for all kinds of non-combat situations, including Social Encounters, Investigations, and Chases. You will also find several extended examples of each, intended to provide inspiration for how these systems might be used at your own table.

social encounters

When to Use This System

Not every interaction is a formalized Social Encounter. This system shouldn't be used for every conversation with every single NPC; if you want to bribe the guard to let you past the gate, simply offer the money, roll the Persuade skill, and abide by the outcome. If you suspect a thief is lying to you, there's no need for a detailed round-by-round formal social conflict when an Insight versus Deceive will do. If you are introducing yourself to an important lord, there may not be a need for anything other than a simple roleplayed dialogue.

No, you don't break out the Social Encounter system until you need something specific and important from an NPC--hopefully something connected to your goals--and there is a real and interesting consequence of failure. The system is designed to turn important conversations and audiences with influential NPCs into tense situations that highlight what's at stake for the characters. The players are given the opportunity to make meaningful, tactical choices in how they approach each moment in the conversation, in hopes of getting exactly what they want from that particular NPC.

A Social Encounter doesn't have to be governed by these rules, or by any rules at all--there are times when you may choose to simply let the roleplaying itself determine the outcome. Each group and situation is different, and these rules are not trying to force you into roleplaying the "correct" way. Introduce these rules only when you feel they'll add to the fun. They're here to simply add more meat to your roleplaying feast.

And as always in all aspects of running TBE, context is king. If the GM decides the player characters have absolutely no chance of influencing a particular NPC, then no amount of dice rolling is going to change that. However, allowing socially oriented characters the chance to change the outcome of what was assumed to be a foregone conclusion is part of what gives social skillsets their usefulness and can produce surprisingly tense and satisfying non-violent encounters.

Social Skills versus Other Players

In general, Social skills are intended to influence NPCs--not other PCs. Skill use by one player shouldn't force another player to have their character behave in a way that they disagree with. If one PC wants to try to Persuade or Intimidate another, both parties should agree to it; otherwise, it is up to the affected player whether or not to be bound by the roll's results. In the end, fostering "PvP"-style conflicts is not what these rules are intended for.

Understanding Success & Failure

The players should understand exactly what their characters hope to achieve in a social encounter. The more specific their objectives, the better. And whenever possible, clearly define the consequences of success, and have at least some idea of what failure will bring. Characters who have nothing at stake (and players who are uninvested in the outcome) make for dull, anticlimactic social encounters that can prove frustrating and, ultimately, a waste of time.

> Sometimes it's hard to reveal the consequences without ripping your players out of their immersion. If, for example, the party is surprised by an angry mob and a Social Encounter is about to begin, the players may not have any idea what failure might mean, as they have no clue why the mob is after them in that moment. You don't want to just stop everything and say, "Okay guys, now there's going to be a Social conflict. Define your objectives, and here's exactly what will happen if you succeed or if you fail!" They don't want to just know that beforehand; they want to play it out and discover the consequences. In this case, let the roleplaying and the dice dictate the course of events. Perhaps in the ensuing shouting match, the characters discover the source of the mob's fury, in which case they now have some idea of what might happen if they fail to calm them. Or perhaps the PCs will decide to foolishly attack the mob (see Escalation, below), or try to escape and make a break for it--either way, the Social Encounter is now over and moves to another type of conflict.

Accommodate, not Replace

What is crucial to understand about this system is that Social skills are designed to accommodate and enhance the roleplaying experience, not replace it. You don't roll a Social skill to get out of having to roleplay your character; you roll a certain skill directly because of how you just roleplayed the character.

Roleplaying Triggers the Skill

The general structure of Social Encounters is this: Players roleplay or otherwise detail what their characters say, and the GM--often with input from the whole table--decides on the appropriate Social skill for them to roll based on their wording. The roleplaying triggers the skill .

The player's objective is to carefully choose their words to best reflect the skill they intend the character to use. The player roleplays the statements, angling for a particular approach, but it is the character's in-game skill that determines success or failure, not the player's inherent charisma (or lack thereof). This prevents naturally persuasive players who have chosen to play lower-status characters from inexplicably dominating every social interaction; it conversely allows less naturally aggressive players to effectively portray assertive and confident characters.

Naturally, this system relies on fair, honest, and accommodating judgement from the GM in quickly interpreting the player's roleplayed statements and deciding which skill to roll. However, in many cases, the whole table often becomes actively involved in carefully listening to and judging which skill they think the player should roll, based on how he or she just played that moment in the conversation. Provided the players are approaching it honestly, a good GM takes their input into account when making a decision.

"I look the thief in the eye, crack my knuckles, and say (the player puts on the character's deep voice) 'Watch what you say, friend. I've broken men's legs before for lying to me'" would be the first-person version of "My character tells the thief that if he lies, he'll be walking away from this meeting on two broken legs. My warrior leans in and cracks his knuckles, showing he means business". The first is the "acted", in-character way of stating the intention, and the second is more of the descriptive third-person perspective--but both versions communicate the clear intention to Intimidate, which is the skill that would be triggered and rolled.

Obviously, understanding the differences between social skills is going to be crucial. However, different people will interpret the meaning of Social skill applications in different ways. One GM might suggest that telling the simple truth to a general about the impending threat to his army is a Persuade, while another GM might consider that a Protocol roll. Such is the spice of variety in gamemastering! What counts is that the GM remains internally consistent on their rulings. If you as GM believe that impersonating a foreign envoy is a Perform roll instead of a Deceive, make sure you don't turn around and demand a Deceive roll when that character later tries to pass themselves off as someone else. Players require consistent judgement from their GMs in order to make meaningful choices.

Clearly Communicate the Character's Intention

Note that none of this requires "acting", or putting on a funny voice or accent, or even speaking in the first person. It merely requires an honest attempt by the player to speak the words the character would say in that moment, based on what they are trying to achieve socially. Your job as a player is to clearly communicate what your character intends to achieve in that moment . The perspective can be from the first person or the third, "acted" or described, but you must clearly indicate your character's intentions.

Remember too that this system does not necessarily mean "one statement equals one skill roll". There's nothing stopping a GM from allowing the players, as a group, to have a back-and-forth banter with a particular NPC, and only stopping them when he decides that it is time to make an appropriate skill roll (just don't forget about the concept of Tolerance, detailed below).

chapter 13: intrigue

static &competitive encounters

The Social Encounter system is a type of extended roll that uses Social skills, and falls under one of two variations: the Static encounter and the Competitive encounter. Both use a series of standard rolls, and both are about accumulating as many Success Levels as possible before time runs out.

Rolling a critical success on a Social roll gives +3 SLs to the outcome, as usual. However, as it is an extended roll, rolling any critical failure will cut the current amount of earned SLs in half (round up).

static encounters

A Static Social Encounter is when the PCs are trying to influence one or more NPCs without any other party actively interfering in their attempts. This could be asking the Baron for permission to cross his lands, pleading with the Council of Lords to release a political prisoner, or convincing a well-regarded courtesan to reveal details of some of her noble clients.

There is no Initiative roll required: the encounter starts the moment a Player Character opens their mouth and triggers a Social skill.

Tolerance

The players' goal is to gain as many SLs as they can without exceeding the Tolerance, which is the number of skill attempts--successful or not--that can be made with this NPC. Think of Tolerance as a kind of built-in encounter timer.

Exceeding the Tolerance means the NPC immediately ends the audience. Whether the skill rolls are successful or not is irrelevant as far as the Tolerance is concerned; if the Tolerance is 4, then on the fifth roll, success or failure, the NPC ends the encounter. The Tolerance is hidden from the players, so they will never know for sure how many opportunities they have left.

It is important for the GM to indicate to the players through NPC portrayal that they may be drawing closer to the Tolerance, though subtle shifts of attitude or body posture signaling growing discomfort, boredom, or agitation (or whatever is appropriate to that NPC).

The standard Tolerance is 5. It can be affected by the NPC's relationship to the party: a great relationship might set the Tolerance to 7, where a hostile one might reduce it to 2 or 1.

Tolerance is established during encounter set-up. Certain factors may modify this initial Tolerance, but once the first Social roll is made, Tolerance cannot be changed.

Tolerance can also be randomly determined by rolling 2d10:

Tolerance Table

2d10	Tolerance
2	2
3-4	3
5-8	4
9-13	5
14-17	6
18-19	7
20	8

These rules are designed for a party of characters. If you are playing solo, consider increasing the Tolerance of the NPC by 2.

The more SLs the players earn, the better the outcome. By default, the players do not know the current number of SLs they have earned, unless they are tracking it themselves.

Critically failing a skill immediately cuts the current accumulated SLs in half (round up).

The PCs are free to voluntarily end the encounter at any time; if they do, compare their total SLs to the Static Social Encounter Outcome Table below to determine the outcome.

Otherwise, as soon as they make a roll that exceeds the Tolerance (ending the encounter), they still count any SLs of that roll, but must then reduce their total SLs by 1d10 before comparing it to the table.

Static Social Encounter Outcome

SLs	Result
0-5	Failure. You don't get what you want, or get a bad outcome.
6-10	Success with a cost, complication, or compromise. A marginal outcome that costs something.
11-15	Success. A good outcome.
16+	Success with benefits. A great outcome.

If the players are not sure what the exact consequences are for success or failure--if the motives of their target are hidden from them for some reason--they can still judge the outcome by the number of SLs they achieve, as indicated on the table.

Option: Static Social Timer Die

If the target's attention is unpredictable, or you want to be as surprised as the players are when they deal with the NPC (or if you're playing solo), you can replace the static Tolerance value with a d10 Timer Die.

Halve the NPC's listed Tolerance (round up). After every skill roll is made, mark a "round", then roll the Timer Die and add the Tolerance (not unlike adding Toughness to a Wound Die). If the result is equal to the current round or less, the encounter is over; reduce the total SLs by 1d10 before consulting the Static Social Encounter Outcome Table.

Veil, an agent of the Order of the Purifying Flame, knows that there are valuable artifacts inside the Vizier of Ansharir's palace that might help her track down the lich she's hunting. She has recently made a good impression on General Bengarrah, a close adviser to the Vizier. She is trying to convince him to help her get inside the palace.

Unbeknownst to her, his Tolerance is 5. She formally introduces herself, using the language of the high court. The GM tells her player to make a Protocol roll, and she succeeds with 4 SLs. He responds to her with equally officious language and seems to be cautiously curious about her. Trying to hide the truth from him, she spins a lie about her motivations, and the GM tells her player to roll a Deceive. She succeeds with 3 SLs. She's now up to 7 SLs, and she's only made two rolls; she knows she's doing well. Her player knows that if she can get at least 11 SLs total, that will give her an outcome of Success--but with the Tolerance hidden from her, she can't know how many more times she can try without the General dismissing her, or worse.

After a few more exchanges, she's now rolled a total of 5 times, and is sitting at 12 SLs. She could decide enough's enough and end the encounter with a "good" outcome. Or she could push her luck and hope to gain extra benefits, but by doing so, she risks losing much: as soon as she makes a sixth roll, though she still benefits from any SLs it generates, her total SLs would be immediately reduced by 1d10, possibly reducing her Success to a Success with a cost, or even a Failure.

If the optional Timer Die rule is being used, the GM might instead convert the General's Tolerance to 3 (5/2 rounded up). Now, after each time Veil rolls a skill, the GM rolls a d10 Timer Die and adds 3. If the result is equal to the current round or less, the meeting is over, and she would reduce her accumulated SLs by 1d10.

chapter 13: intrigue

competitive encounters

A Competitive Social encounter is when two or more sides are vying with each other to influence a third party. This could be defending yourself in a trial against a crown prosecutor for a murder you didn't commit, competing with members of the Vizier's court to be granted a private audience with him, or swaying the vote at a barbarian village council to elect a new chief.

Victory Condition

In a Competitive encounter, instead of Tolerance, there is a Victory Condition: the number of SLs one side must attain before the other side can.

The standard Victory Condition is 15 SLs, but can be higher or lower depending on how long the GM thinks the encounter should take. If the third party has a bias toward one side over the other, the favored side might start with 1-4 SLs already "in the bank", as a kind of head start to the Victory Condition.

When one side speaks, the encounter begins; after that side rolls the triggered skill, the other side responds. This can be formal, like in a debate, or informal like when trying to convince an angry mob to disregard a hostile agitator. While the natural flow of the roleplaying may involve going back and forth in conversation, you cannot trigger another skill roll until after your opponent has had a chance to respond with a skill roll of their own, and vice versa.

Rolled SLs can either increase your own SL count, or reduce your opponent's. This can model arguments made to either support your side, or erode support from the other's. If a side critically fails a skill roll, their total accumulated SLs are immediately halved (round up, minimum zero). This never increases the opponent's total.

The first side to earn enough SLs to reach the Victory Condition immediately wins, with no chance of rebuttal. Subtract the loser's total SLs from the winner's to determine the winner's DoS. Compare the winner's DoS to the Competitive Social Encounter Outcome Table to find the quality of the victory.

If one side willfully abandons the contest early for whatever reason, the opposing party automatically achieves "success with extra benefits". See also Escalation, later.

Competitive Social Encounter Outcome

Winner's DoS Result

1-5	Success with a cost, complication, or compromise.
6-9	Success but with nothing extra.
10+	Success with one or more extra benefits.

Option: Competitive Social Timer Die

The d10 Timer Die can be introduced in Competitive encounters, too. This works very much like it does in Static encounters: if the GM wants to simulate a limited amount of time for the contenders to make their case (maybe the third party is particularly impatient), he can keep track of "rounds". One round is enough time for one participant on each side to make one skill attempt.

At the end of each round, the Timer Die is rolled. If it comes up equal to or less than the current round, the third party ends the debate immediately and selects a winner based on which side currently has the most points toward victory. Unlike in Static encounters, do not reduce any side's SLs by 1d10, but do subtract the loser's SLs from the winner's before consulting the table.

In the case of a tie, each side gets one more chance to make a roll to convince the third party and gain enough SLs to pull ahead. If that still results in a tie, the GM decides who won (or each side rolls a d10, and whoever gets higher wins).

Similar to Static encounters, the GM can choose to give a third party a Tolerance value of between 1-3, which is added to the result of every Timer die roll, ensuring that the encounter will not end for at least as many rounds as the Tolerance.

succeeding in a social encounter

At the conclusion of the Social Encounter, compare your total net SLs to the appropriate table (Static or Competitive) to see how well you did:

- A Failure gains you nothing, and may even reduce your standing with the NPC for the future (reflected in a -1 Tolerance the next time you interact in a Social Encounter). Failing will have repercussions based on the context: failing to convince a magistrate of your innocence at court might mean a harsh prison sentence, whereas failing to get the local church to lend you priests to cleanse the nearby undead temple simply means they dismiss you from their presence.
- A Success with a cost, complication, or compromise gets you what you want but at a price: some unexpected complication arises that has to be dealt with first: the NPC demands something from you in return, or you must temper your demands and settle for a less-than-ideal outcome.
- A Success but with nothing extra gets you what you wanted from the NPC, nothing more, nothing less.
- A Successwith one or more extra benefits gets you what you want and then some, which will of course be based on the context of the encounter.

In Veil's encounter with the General, she needs to convince him to help her get inside the palace undetected. If she succeeds with a cost, he may demand something from her in exchange for his help ("Very well, my lady, I will help you get inside--but only if you promise to pilfer a particular diamond necklace from the Vizier's inner chambers."). If she succeeds with a benefit, not only will he help her get into the palace, but he offers additional information too ("I will help you, my lady--and you should know that if you are discovered, there is a secret escape route to the alley through the cellar."). If she fails, she not only doesn't get his help, but he may also seriously complicate her situation ("I don't know who you are, but you are clearly lying, and, I suspect, a threat to this city. You and I are going to see the Vizier--now. Guards!").

It can often be useful to create your own custom table of outcomes for a specific NPC. This will help tailor the results to the player characters' current goals. (See the Lord the Half-Orc example later in this section.)

Choice of Skill and Approach

When rolling a Social skill:

- If you fail that skill roll, a different skill must be chosen for the next roll against this target, whether by you or someone else. (In other words, try a different approach: that one's clearly not working right now.)
- The same skill cannot be used more than twice in a row against this target, whether by you or someone else. (People grow resistant to a predictable approach.)

If the next player speaks words that the GM interprets to be a use of the skill that just failed or has just been used twice in a row, the GM should either:

- Give the player another chance to word their sentence differently to accommodate a different skill (the more generous approach), or
- Immediately register a failed roll against the Tolerance (best for players already familiar with the system).

This means that if a group of PCs is in a Social Encounter and one of them fails a Persuade roll, the next PC to speak cannot use Persuade. Also, they can only successfully use Persuade twice in a row before having to change approaches. If they try a third time (or try again immediately after a failed roll), the skill will automatically fail and still count against the Tolerance (or if in a Competitive encounter, count as no SLs and pass the turn back to the opponents).

In rare cases, non-Social skills can be used to achieve social goals (Ride to impress a Horse-lord, for example, Arcane Lore to convince a Spell-weaver). The GM decides.

Awarding Roleplaying Modifiers

If the player makes a particularly impressive roleplaying display, or their approach and/or argument is deemed to be particularly appropriate, the GM may choose to award up to a +20 modifier to whatever skill that particular roleplaying has just triggered. This should, however, be reserved for truly noteworthy moments. The final judgement here is the GM's.

Helping

Characters cannot directly help one another with support skills during a Social Encounter, although PC's can support their own Social skill with another skill if it seems relevant.

A fellow PC can, however, make a single Insight roll to provide bonus Leverage points for their friends.

Leverage

Leverage is having some kind of advantage over a person. This does not have to be adversarial: leverage could mean that you are blackmailing them, but it could also mean that you simply have benign information that they would find valuable.

Leverage is a pool of Favor that anyone in your party can draw upon in a Social Encounter to help skills influence a particular NPC (Static encounter) or third party (Competitive encounter). It typically totals from 1 to 5 points, where up to 3 points can be spent as per the usual Favor rules (gaining a +10 bonus per Favor to a skill roll).

The use of leverage should be tied to the context in which it was gained. As long as the leverage is relevant to the player's chosen tactic, and is justified in the roleplaying, the points can be spent on any Social skill roll that makes sense. Be lenient with leverage use; those points are there to help the players achieve their goal in an interesting and creative way. Ingenuity of leverage use should be rewarded and encouraged.

> Through various investigation methods and Stealth rolls, Veil has discovered the General coming out of a brothel, throwing into doubt his cherished reputation as a loyal husband. The GM awards her 3 points of leverage for this discovery. If she wants to use it to aid a skill roll, she will have to incorporate his awkward predicament into her approach.

How Do You Get Leverage?

There are 3 main ways to acquire leverage for use in a Social Encounter:

- Even if you prefer to let the rest of the party do most of the talking, you can still contribute to the Social Encounter by succeeding at an Insight roll once during the encounter. Each SL counts as a point of leverage that can be used by anyone who consults you during the encounter (including yourself). This attempt does count against Tolerance.
- If confronting a stranger, most of the time you won't have any leverage. But if you've discovered something about a person or have a past history with them, you might have between 1-5 points of starting leverage, as determined by the GM.
- Taking the time and effort to investigate an NPC beforehand for useful information about their character or circumstances will require its own set of rolls--typically some combination of Perception, Insight, or relevant Lore rolls-- and could even be the justification of an adventure in its own right. This kind of "research" acts similarly to Travel Lore: each participant rolls a relevant skill, and the highest successful roll counts as leverage equal to 1, plus 1 per 2 SLs.

Special Reactions

Every NPC is different and may react strongly to certain things the players say. Some respond well to the formality of Protocol rolls, others to direct, plainspoken Persuade rolls. Some warm to the humor of Wit; others despise it. One might love to gossip about the nobles at court; another might be prejudiced against (or admiring of) Ogres. A beautiful woman or handsome man might resent anyone's use of Seduce--or be particularly susceptible to it.

These particular preferences or aversions are known as Special Reactions, and they help make the NPC feel real and believable. Not every NPC will have Special Reactions, but in general, it helps bring the NPC to life.

Using a Special Reaction

A Special Reaction is triggered through roleplaying, either by bringing a particular topic into conversation, using a specific skill, or even having a member of a particular race or profession speak. Each Special Reaction has a specific effect which applies only when the players meaningfully incorporate

the relevant detail into their words or actions. The players will not be explicitly told about this effect, though they may infer it from the GM's roleplaying.

Obviously, whether a player is using a particular skill in a way that applies to the Special Reaction or not is up to the GM to interpret. Make sure to be consistent with the guidelines established at the beginning of this chapter.

The following list of example Special Reactions is non-exhaustive; Special Reactions can be whatever the GM can imagine. The NPC Traits Table (see Chapter 18: Bestiary) provides random Special Reaction triggers for NPCs.

Typical Special Reaction examples:

- Increase / Decrease initial Tolerance based on a particular bias.
- A skill that automatically fails when used.
- Up to +/- 2 SLs to the party's SL total when attempting a particular skill.
- Up to +/- 2 SLs to the party's SL total when incorporating a particular topic into the skill roll.
- Up to +/- 2 SLs to the party's SL total if the skill is attempted by a character of a particular race/profession/cultural group.

Special Reaction SL adjustments modify the side's accumulated SL total. Positive SL modifiers apply only on a successful roll. Negative SL modifiers apply whether the roll succeeds or fails (but the party's accumulated SL total can never drop below 0; ignore any excess penalties).

Multiple Special Reactions may apply to the same roll, and their effects stack unless the NPC's profile states otherwise.

Apply any Special Reaction SL adjustments to the party's total before any halving effects (such as critical failures or exceeding Tolerance) are applied.

An NPC could be a lover of ballads: anyone incorporating music into their successful Perform skill gains +1 SL. Maybe the NPC has an affinity for the folk of the Westlands, and therefore any Westlander character gets +1 SL from any successful use of Inspire, Persuade, or Protocol (or maybe any skill they use!). Or maybe the NPC hates talking about the Angevarran civil war: any skill triggered by words incorporating that topic reduces the total SLs by 2, regardless of the skill's success or failure.

As another example, a party is trying to convince Mord the Half-Orc, a dangerous warrior, to help them in an upcoming battle. Their outcome will be determined by the results of his customized reaction table.

Mord has several Special Reactions. He despises Dwarves, and their presence in the party will reduce his initial Tolerance by 1. Despite his savage nature, Mord likes formality; the first successful Protocol roll in the encounter gives +1 SL. He's not a fan of clever words, so any use of the Wit skill reduces the party's total by 2 SLs. He reacts very poorly to strong-arming attempts: any Intimidate rolls automatically fail and count against his Tolerance.

Tolerance	4 (3 if there are any Dwarves in the party)
Special	+1 SL to first Protocol roll; -2 SLs from any use of Wit; Intimidate rolls automatically fail

SLs	Result
0-5	Mord tires of your blathering and attacks you.
6-10	He agrees to back you up in the fight, but only if you swear to later help him slay a dangerous beast that's been plaguing his tribe.
11-15	He agrees to fight with you during your next battle, but won't take unnecessary risks.
16+	He agrees to fight with you until he gets seriously injured, or is betrayed.

Escalation

It is possible that in the middle of an otherwise peaceful Social Encounter, a character may leap to violence or use magic to get what they want. While this does go against the purpose of the Social Encounter (i.e., to resolve a conflict without violence), players are as players do.

If they turn a conversation into a combat, that's on them; obviously, the Social Encounter ends immediately, and all gained success levels are lost. But remember that in a social conflict, the stakes and possible outcomes should be known to all before any dice start rolling; if everyone has agreed to what they are trying to achieve socially, it is very bad form to suddenly draw steel. That should be the choice of absolutely last resort. Context matters, as always, but if you have the type of players that insist on jumping to a violent "solution", then let them reap the full consequences of violence. "He who lives by the sword", and all that...

Magical Manipulation in Social Encounters

It may be tempting for a Spellweaver to simply cast Control Thought or some such "charm" magic directly against a target in a Social Encounter and just get everything they want. This is possible--a caster can circumvent the entire Social Encounter process if they choose. But there is always a price to pay for such shortcuts.

All Thought-based magic leaves the victim aware of being magically manipulated when a) they successfully resist the magic, or b) if they succeed on an Insight roll when the duration of the spell expires. Also, being magically coerced to act against one's own interests very often allows the victim of a Thought-based spell to make another immediate opposed roll, regardless of the spell's duration.

Thus, casting a spell and failing usually causes the party to immediately fail the encounter and may have other consequences too--up to and including violence, depending on the context. But casting and succeeding can have equally bad consequences, as even if the caster gets what they want from the Social target, that spell will eventually expire according to its duration, and the victim's Insight roll may reveal the manipulation. There are few who will happily let such a mental invasion go unanswered.

So casting a Command spell on the local lord to hand over his family's symbol of rulership may indeed "win" you the Social Encounter in one roll... unless the lord resists the spell (in which case get ready for a long stay in his castle's dungeons). And even if he doesn't, imagine the shock of the lord's courtiers as he suddenly and inexplicably hands over such a valuable item to a bunch of grubby strangers. Any good chamberlain is likely to intercede on his lord's behalf, with the household guard loosening the blades in their scabbards... And even if the PCs get out of that sticky situation, the spell will eventually wear off--so prepare to be hunted down by the lord's guards as he likely realizes he's been magically forced to act against his will.

Sometimes it's wiser to rely on words rather than wizardry.

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extended static encounter example

The party has uncovered hints of a heretical cult and believes the truth may lie within the restricted archives of the Royal Vaults in Dineol. Before petitioning the archivist, Vellastine of the Ninefold Quill, they spend time researching her reputation, using Insight , Common Lor e, and Academic-wise skills. Their investigations garner 3 SLs, revealing that Vellastine is famously impatient with visitors, but also that she prizes order, academic knowledge, and scholarly duty above all. They earn 3 points of leverage from their rolls that can be used on any skill roll that plays to that research.

Vellastine's Tolerance is only 3 (due to their research, the players suspect her Tolerance is low, but have no way of knowing the exact number). She also has several Special Reactions:

- A If there are any Loremasters in the group, increase Tolerance by 1.
- A She warms to precise academic citation, granting +1 SL to the first successful roll that references a specific academic work.
- A She despises careless handling of books (which would immediately end the encounter).
- A She dislikes cleverness during formal petitions (any use of Wit automatically fails and counts against Tolerance).
- A Vellastine abhors dishonesty. If a Deceive roll fails, reduce the party's accumulated total by 2 SLs.

Casilda the Loremaster is in the party, so the Tolerance increases to 4 before the encounter begins.

The audience begins with Casilda formally introducing the group and requesting access to the archives "in the interest of correcting several historical errors in the Index." The GM calls for a Protocol roll. Because her argument meaningfully invokes scholarly duty, her player is allowed to spend 2 leverage for +20 to the roll before rolling. Casilda succeeds with 5 SLs, and her citation of the Index also triggers Vellastine's positive Special Reaction for +1 SL.

This brings the party's accumulated total to 6 SLs after only a single attempt. They have also used 1 of Vellastine's 4 Tolerance.

Athelgar the Spellweaver follows with a calm, deliberate argument about preservation rituals. He rolls Persuade , supported by Lore: Bureaucracy-wise , showing he understands Vellastine's priorities on an institutional level. He spends the group's final point of leverage for +10 to the roll, and succeeds with 3 SLs. Those bring the party's accumulated total to 9 SLs. No Special Reaction triggers this time, but Vellastine appears genuinely impressed. Two rolls remain within Tolerance, and the party already has a strong foundation for success.

Rothan, a charming rogue, then attempts a reasoned appeal, using Persuade to frame their request as a way to prevent misunderstandings that could lead to bloodshed. He succeeds with 4 SLs, bringing the total to 13 SLs. This crosses the threshold for a standard Success result. The players are not sure about how close they are to exceeding Vellastine's patience after 3 rolls, but they want more.

Athelgar speaks again, using words and mannerisms the GM interprets as Persuade ; the GM reminds him that the same skill can't be used three times in a row. Athelgar's player rephrases his statement as a light-hearted joke, and the GM calls for Wit --which automatically fails because of one of Vellastine's Special Reactions. The joke dies on Athelgar's lips as Vellastine's expression

hardens. The party gains no SLs from the roll, but it still counts against Tolerance. The GM knows this uses up Vellastine's final point of Tolerance: she has now endured 4 rolls.

Despite the not-so-witty setback, the players decide to push one more time in hopes of reaching the Success with extra benefits tier.

With the group still sitting at 13 SLs, Rothan decides to shift tactics and tries Deceive , attempting to shade the truth about their motives in a way he hopes Vellastine won't notice. Unfortunately, this is exactly the wrong approach with her. He fails the roll, generating 0 SLs--but because a failed Deceive triggers one of her Special Reactions, the party's accumulated total is reduced by 2 SLs, dropping them from 13 to 11 SLs.

This is also the fifth roll, which exceeds her Tolerance of 4. They keep their adjusted total of 11 SLs from the encounter, but now the 1d10 penalty for exceeding Tolerance applies. The die comes up 5, reducing their 11 SLs to 6: Success with a cost, on the Static Social Encounter Outcome Table .

Vellastine grants them access to the restricted manuscripts--but only for one hour, under her direct supervision, and with the added requirement that they prepare a written summary for the archives afterward.

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formal competitive social encounters

Competitive Social Encounters can get more complex and formalized when applied to a larger group or situation. They follow the same basic rules, but sometimes add in additional factors to better represent the situation. In this section I will present some ideas on how to create formalized variants of Competitive Social Encounters, which you can use as a guide for your own ideas: the Debate , the Trial , and the Council .

Variant: The Debate

Let's start with a fairly common formal Competitive Social Encounter: the Debate . It is very much like a regular Competitive Encounter, but has a few extra formalities, like agendas and the introduction .

- A The GM sets the Victory Condition. The standard is 15.
- A Each side's SL score contributes to its agenda : a statement of your side's position or intention.
- A The GM determines if the third party has a bias toward one over the other. If so, the favorable side might have 1-4 starting SLs in their agenda.
- A If it's a formal affair, each side makes an introduction ; one party will be selected to speak first. This is an opening statement of some sort that begins the proceedings, and could be a literal introduction if the speaker(s) is unknown to the assembly. Any SLs generated must contribute to your own side's agenda. This is an "opening salvo" to score some early points.
- A Otherwise, whoever opens their mouth first starts the debate!
- A The first contender speaks their argument. The GM determines the skill to be tested based on the roleplaying.
- A The player rolls the character's skill. If the character's intention is to support a side's agenda, any SLs are added to that agenda's value. If it's to detract from it, the SLs will reduce the agenda's value. You cannot reduce an agenda to less than zero.
- A Then an opponent speaks, following the same procedure as above.
- A The GM keeps track of "rounds". One round is enough time for each side in the debate to make oneskill attempt. If there are multiple participants on a side, only one may roll that round.
- A Continue until either a) one agenda ends a round with 15 or more SLs, at which point the debate is immediately over, or b) the (optional) Timer Die ends the debate first.
- A In a tie, each side gets onemore chance to make a roll to convince the third party. If that still results in a tie, the GM decides who won.

- The winner subtracts the loser's SLs and consults the Competitive Social Encounter Outcome table.
- OPTION: If the GM wants to simulate a limited amount of time for the contenders to make their case, he can use a Timer Die:
  - At the end of each round, the Timer Die is rolled. If it comes up equal to or less than the current round, the third party ends the debate and selects a winner based on which agenda currently has the most points toward victory. The higher agenda subtracts the lower and compares it to the Competitive Social Encounter Outcome table.
  - The GM can also choose to set a third-party Tolerance of 1-3, to add to the Timer Die result. This is identical to the Timer Die in a normal Competitive Social Encounter.

The pirate Captain Leudo DiFrantis is before the assembled League of Free Lords, debating Captain Elsbeth the Raven about whether to send League ships into the Dead Man's Reef to seek a powerful artifact. Captain DiFrantis wants to send the ships, but Elsbeth is opposed to the idea; she has information that Tical Dondala may be sending a battle fleet to assault the League's base.

Captain DiFrantis' agenda is "Send an expeditionary force to the Reef immediately", while Captain Elsbeth's is "Keep the fleet together to defend against Tical Dondala". The Victory Condition is the standard 15. Neither side has an advantage in opening value; both agendas start at zero. The League wants a decision soon, so the GM decides to use the optional Timer Die, assigning a Tolerance of 2 to the League of Free Lords.

The GM has the players forgo the introductions, as both captains are influential pirates with considerable sway over the League's decisions. DiFrantis speaks first, making an impassioned speech about the need to find powerful assets that may be hiding in the Reef. The GM tells him to roll Inspire, and he succeeds with 5 SLs! His agenda goes from zero to 5. The GM describes how the lords of the League all mutter to each other, seemingly swayed by DiFrantis' argument.

Then the Raven speaks of the size and fury of the Tical Dondallan force: her own spies have confirmed that "they bear down on our positions even now, their ships bristling with cannon set to blow the League from these waters for good!" She is allowed to roll Intimidate and gets 2 SLs, which she uses to reduce DiFrantis' agenda down to 3. The Lords now all begin to question DiFrantis' haste in the face of this threat...

The first round is over, as both sides have had an opportunity to roll. The GM marks the round and rolls the Timer Die, which comes up 3. As the Tolerance is 2, the result is 5, nowhere near the current round number of 1. Which captain will sway the council before they run out of patience?

At the end of the fifth round, neither has yet reached 15 SLs. DiFrantis currently has 7 SLs and Elsbeth 9. The Timer Die result is a 4: the council has heard enough. Elsbeth has the higher SLs in her agenda, but she must subtract DiFrantis' 7, for a total of 2. Checking the tables, this gives her a Success with a cost, complication, or compromise.

The council decides to heed the Raven by keeping the fleet together, but they give DiFrantis command. Another triumph of compromise: no one walks away happy.

If they had tied with equal SLs when the Timer Die forced an end, each one would get one final opportunity to plead their case.

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Variant: The Trial

Another example of a formal Competitive Social Encounter is the trial of Simon at the end of Season 1 of Me, Myself & Die. There, I was using a variant for use with the Savage Worlds RPG system, but under these rules, it would look something like the following. Note the variant at the very end that introduces a random d10 roll to increase each side's final agenda score.

Consider using this structure whenever the PCs are formally judged or must argue before an authority.

The contenders are Simon of Argoston, on trial for murder, against the members of the court prosecution. The third party is the council of High Lords of Keighton, who are judging the case. This trial will play out according to a formal structure where each side gives opening statements, presents arguments and witnesses, makes closing statements, and rests their case. There is no Timer Die involved, nor will this Competitive encounter automatically end when someone reaches 15 SLs: each side must continue until all phases of the trial have been completed.

Simon's agenda starts at zero, but the prosecution's agenda starts at 2 (the court is biased against Simon).

Each side makes its introduction, or opening statement, which in this case is represented by a Protocol roll. Any SLs are added to their own respective agendas.

As it is a formal affair, the laws of Keighton dictate that the prosecution present its arguments first. The prosecution has their witnesses each address the court and make appropriate Social skill rolls. Any successes are added to their agenda or used to reduce Simon's agenda (he scored 4SL on his opening statement, a ripe target for the prosecution's witnesses to go after).

Then the defense calls its own witnesses, each either supporting Simon's position or attacking the prosecution's. Then Simon himself can take the stand and use any SLs he gains to either add to his own total or reduce his accuser's.

Throughout all of this, both sides' agendas are being constantly moved up and down as evidence is presented, testimonies heard, and arguments are both attacked and supported.

Arriving now at the end of the trial process, the High Lords of Keighton ask for closing statements, giving both Simon and the prosecution one last round to try to influence the agendas.

The final SLs on each agenda are registered. As an additional randomizing variant, to represent the deliberations of the jury, the prosecution and the defense each make a d10 roll and add it to their agenda's current SLs. The higher subtracts the lower's, and the winning agenda's score is compared to the Competitive Social Encounter Outcome Table to determine the quality of victory.

Gaining Leverage in Formal Encounters

In formal Competitive Encounters such as Debates or Trials, a character may still attempt to gain leverage by testing Insight , Common Lore , Law-wise , or another appropriate skill.

Doing so counts as that side's action for the round or phase--it replaces a normal argument or witness roll.

Afterward, play proceeds to the opposing side as usual.

Variant: The Council

The rules of the Competitive Social Encounter can be modified in many ways to represent different social situations and to play up different kinds of tension. Let's now look at a very formalized version: the Council Vote .

In this variant, the five PCs (Simon, Arn, Edbert, Veil, and Stratton) are addressing a formal village assembly poised to vote for their next War Elder, who will command the village in times of strife. Note the many modifications throughout, including the absence of Tolerance and the optional Timer Die; the GM simply determines that the Victory Condition is whichever agenda has the highest total at the end of the proceedings.

A Each candidate has their own agenda, tracked independently as accumulated support (represented by SLs).

A Introduction . If the PC is known to the assembly he's addressing, he may automatically participate in the conversation to come. If he doesn't know the group whom he's addressing, or they don't know him, he must make an introduction. This can be done with any appropriate Social skill, but the default is Protocol. If he fails the introduction, he may only participate in the Informal phase of the council.

A The PCs choose whether to participate in the Formal or Informal phase of the coming conversation. They can do both, but if they participated in the Formal conversation, anything they roll in the Informal conversation will suffer a -20 penalty.

A Formal Conversation . Any Formal conversation will play out here. This is dialogue, debate, or anything else said in full view and knowledge of the council participants. Each person (PC or NPC) may contribute once per round (one round being enough time for each par-

ticipant to make one skill attempt, the skill of which will be determined by the GM based on the roleplay). They may target whatever agenda they wish, tailoring their words and roleplaying to reflect. After the roll, they may apply their SLs to either increase or decrease the targeted Agenda. This continues for as many rounds as the GM feels appropriate (usually 2-4), or until discussion naturally concludes.

A Informal Conversation . Next, any Informal conversation will come into play. This could be scenes involving post-council persuasion, back-room dealings, spreading gossip, digging up dirt on your opponents, etc. Each participant may make only a singleskill roll, as always based on the roleplaying and the GM's decision. Any SLs can be used to affect the target Agenda.

A Resolution and tallying of the results. Optionally, each side rolls a d10 and adds it to their agenda's current SLs, to represent the unpredictability of the final vote. The highest number wins, and that agenda is enacted.

In this council, four candidates are standing for the position of War Elder. The PCs are supporting one particular candidate and are trying to influence the vote in her favor. The candidates are:

5 Uldred, a powerful warrior with sometimes questionable ethics;

5 Cavinn, a wealthy merchant originally from a rival village;

5 Muudrick, the incompetent but popular son of the previous leader, and

5 Leodia, a reluctant but highly intelligent ranger. This is the PCs' preferred candidate.

Each candidate's goal is to accumulate as much support (measured in SLs accumulated) for their agenda as they can before the final vote. Each agenda starts with a predetermined opening value of support:

Agenda Support Value (SLs)

Uldred	Cavinn	Muudrick	Leodia
5	6	8	4

Each PC can either address the assembly as part of the Formal conversation, or stay quiet and try to influence events after the debate during the Informal conversation.

Simon, Stratton, and Arn are all known to the village, but Edbert and Veil are strangers. Edbert tries to formally introduce himself with a Protocol roll, but fails--he has not made a good impression with these people, and must wait for the Informal phase of the council to contribute. Veil decides to stay quiet and participate only in the Informal conversation.

As there are no more Formal introductions, each candidate now speaks. The GM roleplays or describes how the NPC tries to make their basic case for why they should be elected. After they say their (short) piece, the NPC rolls their own appropriate skill (each NPC speaks in a manner consistent with that skill). Any SLs they generate are added to their own agenda. (If a PC was a candidate, they too would make their roll now.)

Uldred Intimidates the crowd with 1 SL; Cavinn uses 3 SLs from Insight to point out the dangerous nature of Uldred's potential leadership; Muudrick tries to Perform by telling hilarious stories of his drunken escapades, but fails; and Leodia shyly Persuades the crowd with 1 SL that she will always put the village's interests before her own.

After the rolls, the new agenda totals look like this:

Agenda Support Value (SLs)

Uldred	Cavinn	Muudrick	Leodia
6	9	8	5

The PCs chosen candidate is not doing so well, and they can hear the guarded mutterings of the villagers about how Cavinn is probably the best choice for War Elder...

Now, any PC who is allowed to participate in the Formal phase of the council can address the assembly, one at a time. They can speak either in support of Leodia, or against another candidate. The player roleplays what the character says; the GM decides on the skill based on the words chosen; that skill is rolled. If the speech was designed to help Leodia, her support value is increased by the amount of SLs the player generated. If it was against another candidate, reduce that candidate's total support by the generated SLs.

Simon is the first to speak, using his Inspire skill in a rousing speech to increase Leodia's support by 3 SLs; Arn tries to talk sense to the crowd with a Persuade roll, but fails; and Stratton spends his 4 SLs from a successful mocking Wit roll to reduce Uldred and Cavinn's totals by 2 SLs each.

The new support totals look like this:

Agenda Support Value (SLs)

Uldred	Cavinn	Muudrick	Leodia
4	7	8	8

Once each PC addressing the assembly has had a chance to speak, the round is over. A new round begins, and all participants say their piece. The support totals ebb and flow, but by the end of the second round, they wind up the same. The GM could allow further rounds of debate, but in this case decides that the moot retires to consider before the vote.

Now comes the "behind the scenes" Informal conversation. Edbert and Veil did not participate in the Formal conversation, so they each now have a single opportunity to try to sway the vote. (The others could too, but they would do so at -20 for having already participated in the Formal conversation. They choose not to.)

Edbert decides to try to Intimidate some of the villagers into voting for Leodia. He fails, and the support totals do not change.

Veil now tries to slyly convince some of the voters that Muudrick is actually conspiring with Cavinn to pilfer the village's treasury. She rolls Deceive and scores 3 SLs. She decreases Cavinn and Muudrick's support to 6 each.

Agenda Support Value (SLs)

Uldred	Cavinn	Muudrick	Leodia
3	6	6	8

Looks like Leodia is in the lead... but now the villagers vote. The GM describes how the villagers return to the moot circle, and are called upon to choose in a voice-vote.

The GM will roll a single d10 for each candidate and add the result to their respective support values to see who has the most votes. The GM rolls each d10 in front of the players to maximize tension.

"All for Uldred the warrior?" Uldred rolls a 4, for a total of 7. Not good for him.

"Who speaks for Cavinn the merchant?" The d10 comes up 7, for a total of 13. The crowd is clearly in support of Cavinn.

"And shall Muudrick, son of Alrick, be our War Elder then?" The die rolls a 6, for a total of 12. Despite his inexperience, the crowd is still fairly supportive of the old Elder's son.

"All in favor of electing Leodia the Ranger, say 'Aye'!" The GM has a player roll a d10 and add it to Leodia's support value (8). The player rolls a 6, for a total of 14. Leodia is elected Elder!

(Later, Uldred will go on to plot the murder of both Leodia and the PCs, as clearly they "conspired to steal my rightful place!" And such is how future adventures in intrigue are birthed.)

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investigations and mysteries

An investigation can be run any time the PCs are looking for an answer: they're trying to discover unknown information, solve a mystery, or even go undercover to unveil hidden secrets. If you as the GM know the details of what the characters are trying to learn, you can choose how best to dole out that information. If you want to formalize that process--or if you yourself don't know the answers they seek and want to discover them right along with the party--consider the following process.

Treat the investigation as an extended roll with a Gradual Outcome, where every 3 SLs uncovers one clue relevant to the skill used to reveal it. A CommonLoreskill might reveal some bit of history relevant to their investigation; a Social skill might cause an NPC to reveal a detail; a Craft roll might reveal some relevant detail pertaining to an item being examined. Whatever it is, the clue should be specific enough to be meaningful, but vague enough to allow for interpretation (and not giving away too much information at once).

Use the extended roll's SL requirements as a guide: if, in their investigations, they accumulate a set number of SLs before the Timer Die introduces a complication (see The Investigation Timer Die), they discover the answer they were looking for. What that answer is, of course, depends on what the question was. Context, as always, is king.

If you already knew the details of the mystery beforehand--if you are running a prepared adventure, for example--then the clues they discover will have been predetermined, along with the answers or solutions.

If you don't know the significance of the answers they find, you'll have to make it up on the fly. (This is the default position of the solo player, who is only discovering things at the same time as their character does!) Interpret the revealed clues in context to the question and allow those clues to shape the answer. Using the Event Randomizers Tables in Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying in the Broken Empirescan be a big help with improvising a meaning to the revealed information. As long as the connections you draw are believable, this form of retconning can produce a really satisfying outcome.

> GMs, if you're really stuck, allow the players to piece together the clues and theory-craft about what they think is going on. It's a good bet that among their pontifications, they'll come up with some really cool explanation or idea that you didn't think of. Go ahead and make that the answer. Your players will feel like geniuses, and you can take all the credit for thinking up such a brilliant plot! (Just be very careful about how often you use this neat little technique. The players will eventually see through it, and might feel pandered to. You never want your players to feel like they didn't earn their victories fairly.)

The Investigation Timer Die

Keep track of the number of investigation skill rolls the players make, whether Social, Adventuring, or Lore rolls. After every skill roll, roll a d10 Timer Die. If you roll equal to or less than the total number of skill rolls they've made so far, a new obstacle or complication appears to interfere with their investigation somehow.

It can be anything: the party is suddenly attacked by armed assassins, a strange twist upends their assumptions, an unexpected clue reveals itself, a new NPC appears to help or hinder them... whatever seems interesting in the moment. Just make sure that whatever it is, it has something to do with their investigation. It could relate to the particular details of the case, or even to the party's investigative approach (maybe they've angered the local authorities by Intimidating the Captain of the Guard, and now he's come to make them pay...). If nothing immediately comes to you, use the Event Randomizers Tables to randomly determine the obstacle.

Phases of Investigation

An investigation can unfold across several phases, to accommodate different types of scenes, threats, or opportunities. The total SLs and Timer Die count continue between phases--do not reset them.

In Season 4 of "Me, Myself and Die: Legacy", a disguised Veil infiltrates the Vizier's ball in order to discover if he's an ally of the Lich she's hunting. The first phase is the "Mingling" phase, which is a Social opportunity for Veil to discreetly canvas the nobles and guests to see if any of them are hiding anything. The second phase is the "Fireworks" phase, where the Vizier brings the assembled guests out into the courtyard to witness the pyrotechnics display of the Firetamer's Guild; this affords an opportunity for Veil to sneak away into the palace's lower levels, to investigate anything being hidden down there. Finally, there is the "Ball" phase, where the courtiers return to the interior of the palace shortly after midnight to begin the dance. This offers Veil another opportunity to observe the Vizier among his guests and maybe discover something more.

In the palace, Veil was in disguise, and the stakes were high, so I wanted to ramp up the tension: any roll she failed during her investigation would raise the suspicions of any observers. To that end, I called the Timer Die the "Suspicion Die", but also added a kind of Tolerance: I would only start rolling the Timer once Veil failed three rolls. However, if the Suspicion Die rolled the current number of skill rolls she had made up to that point or less, it wouldn't just signal a complication--it would mean her cover was blown!

Variant: Suspicion Die

In high-stakes or undercover investigations, the Timer Die can represent suspicion or exposure rather than time pressure.

You may delay rolling it until a certain threshold (for example, after three failed rolls; this is a kind of Tolerance).

If it ever rolls equal to or less than the total number of investigation rolls made so far, the character's cover is blown or the investigation unravels.

Using Magic in an Investigation

Magic can be the bane of mystery--especially magic that allows a caster to peer into the most secret thoughts of a subject. But keep the following in mind when dealing with compulsion-based spells or other Thought or Witness-based approaches. Reading someone's mind doesn't automatically allow you to understand what you see. At best, you'll get a bonus to an Insight roll to interpret the images, which would contribute to the investigation's SL count as normal.

And magically spying on somebody using Witness spells doesn't necessarily give you any automatically usable information: it may still require you to make a Perception or Insight roll to decipher any possible clues. Interpreting those clues to find The Answer is still up to the player.

Most of all, never forget that any intrusive Thought-based magic may leave the victim with the certainty that they have been mentally violated. Nothing can blow your cover faster than a Charm victim resisting the spell earlier than expected and calling for the guards.

chapter 13: intrigue

chases

Chases bring speed, danger, and immediacy to the game. Whether sprinting through narrow city streets, racing across rooftops, or pursuing a fugitive through wilderness trails, a chase is a contest of skill, nerve, and endurance.

This section provides simple rules for resolving both quick pursuits and prolonged hunts, letting you decide how much detail and tension the scene deserves.

Quick Chases

When one character tries to catch another over a short distance, make opposed Athletics rolls. The winner catches the loser and Engages them. Context could suggest modifiers: give the prey a +20 if they have a significant head start, for example.

Prolonged Chases

A prolonged chase functions as an extended roll contest between pursuer and prey. Both sides attempt to accumulate a target number of SLs before the other does. The more SLs required, the longer the chase; most chases require between 5 and 15 SLs to conclude. Each roll can represent different time intervals, from a minute per round in a frenetic foot chase through a city, to a day per round in an extended hunt through a mountain range with one party doggedly tracking the other.

Each round:

- Both sides make a skill roll.
- Add any SLs earned to their running totals.
- If one side reaches the target SLs, the chase ends immediately--they escape or make the catch.
- If both reach the target SLs in the same round, play one more round to break the tie.

Critically failing one of the rolls cuts the current amount of successes in half (round up), as setbacks occur, obstacles appear, etc.

If a group of Player Characters are involved in a chase, only one of them makes a roll each round. Ideally, PCs would alternate with each new chase round, so that they all can contribute.

Skill Use

During prolonged chases, Endurance, Streetwise, Naturewise, Perception, Stealth, and possibly other skills can all be used, depending on the situation. Allow players to use skills in creative ways; a chase is more fun if they get to come up with some cool way to use a skill based on the details of their evolving situation.

Choices, choices...

Always provide players with meaningful choices. Use the random tables in this book to create two or more interesting options for the characters to choose between when leaving an area: do they go left into the busy market, or right toward the docks? Think about how the new situation might influence certain skill rolls. If the pursued character turns a corner and runs into a group of priests proselytizing to a large group of bystanders in the middle of a street, how might that affect skill use? Would it cause a penalty to Athletics, as the mob of people is too thick to push through? What about using Intimidate to bellow at the crowd to get out of the way? Can the pursued character use Divinity to take advantage of the priests' sermonizing and cause a distraction? Does doing so here receive a bonus, or penalty? Offer clues in your descriptions about these opportunities, but remember to let the players decide what skill they want to try, and how.

Chases with the Timer Die

To heighten the tension, introduce the Timer Die. Roll a d10 (or other die type, based on the difficulty or inherent chaos of the situation) at the end of every round. If the die rolls the current round number or

less, either a complication is introduced--determine one using the random tables in this book, then determine whether it affects the pursuer, the prey, or both--or the chase comes to a premature end (GM's choice).

A complication should be a bonus or penalty to one or more of the next rolls. Whatever it is, it should arise naturally out of the current situation, and should be tied to the details of the immediate surroundings.

If the chase does come to a premature end, the party with the most SLs at that moment wins (a tie of SLs indicates a draw; if a winner is required, the most recent highest roll wins).

Three palace guards are chasing Veil through the busy streets of Ansharir. Each roll represents a couple of minutes, and in each round, a different skill can be used, based on the changing context. This chase will end when either the guards or Veil reaches 6 SLs.

The GM describes a long, empty avenue in front of them. Veil's player describes how she launches into a flat-out sprint. In the first round, both pursuer and prey are rolling Athletics as they bolt along the straight street. Veil gets 2 SLs, the guards get 1. (Even though there are three of them, the NPC guards are acting as a single character here.)

The Timer is chosen to be a d10, and is rolled after the first round. If the Timer Die rolls a 1, a random complication is introduced, which may affect the pursuer, the prey, or both. It comes up 6.

Up ahead, the avenue comes to a dead end. Quickly rolling on the random tables, the GM determines two areas of egress: to Veil's right, a funeral procession is winding its way down a narrow street, flanked by long columns of black-clad mourners. To her left is a busy market square filled with shouting merchants plying their trade, slow-moving camels carrying gargantuan water barrels, and citizens milling about looking for bargains. Veil briefly considers going for the funeral procession, hoping her Divinity skill will allow her enough knowledge about local funeral customs to blend in with the mourners; the GM also suggests that she could use Common Lore for the same effect, but at -20.

Veil instead chooses to dart into the market, hoping to use Streetwise to disappear into the crowd. The GM allows it. The guards will roll Perception to see if they spot her. Veil critically fails her roll, which reduces her total by half; luckily, she only had 2 SLs, so her new total is 1. The guards roll 2 SLs, and now have 3 SLs to Veil's 1. Veil tries to get lost amongst the crowd, but one of the eagle-eyed guards spots her and points her out to his searching fellows.

The Timer Die is again rolled, this time coming up a 2 on round 2--a complication! The GM discovers, using a random table, that a camel handler has lost control of one of the angry beasts. He randomly determines that the focus of the complication is the guards. As they push their way through the crowd, they run smack dab into the angry camel, and the crowd surrounding it. They will get -20 to their next roll.

Next round, Veil runs out of the market to see a guard post on her left, and a shadowy stairwell in a building to her right. She goes right and rolls Athletics to speedily climb up the darkened stairs to the roof, where she hopes to lose her pursuers. The guards, meanwhile, make Might rolls to force themselves past the enraged camel and through the jostling crowd. Veil spends Resolve and rolls 5 SLs; with their -20, the guards fail their roll. Both sides have had a chance to roll this round, but Veil has hit the 6 SL threshold; she escapes across the rooftops of Ansharir.

cHAPTER 14:

wea ve magic

Magic is inherently complex and unpredictable. Spellweavers literally pull at the threads of the Weave that holds reality together. They pluck at the strands of the cosmic tapestry and re-pattern them into a form that favors their current circumstances.

A Spellweaver doesn't have to memorize or preselect individual spells. Instead, they build magical effects in the moment based on what they're trying to accomplish.

They do this by pulling at a metaphysical Strand (an aspect of reality) and Binding it with techniques of imposing the caster's will on the Weave, often with the expenditure of Resolve. Each Spellweaver is trained in a number of Binds and Strands. They use the Bind skill to cast the spell, and the Strand's value to control it.

The Binds and Strands can be thought of as approaches to altering the Tapestry of reality. The magical skills you choose will inform how much the Weave reacts to the spell's incursion on reality (its Magnitude). You will also determine the Shaping costs of that spell--the Target, Range, Duration, and Effect --to tailor it to your intention. Worn armor is

Keywords in this Chapter

Arcane Tether
Binds
Bounded Laws of Magic
Duration
Effect
Essential Pattern
Fraying
Magnitude
Mastery
Mitigate the Weave
Range
Requisite
Resist
Rituals
Shaping
Strands
Target
Threads
Total Cost (TC)
True Name
Weave Reaction

intrinsically distracting to Spellweavers and makes spells harder to control, so its Initiative penalty adds to the Shaping cost. Controlling the spell requires Mastery .

But beware: to cast far beyond your control is to court Fraying . Each point brings you closer to the Weave's inevitable reclamation of your Pattern, until you are expelled forever from the Tapestry...

The rules of Weave magic are complex, but no more so than swordplay or intrigue. Once you learn their structure, you'll find that every spell follows a clear sequence: state what you want to do, determine how plausible it is, decide its details, and bind your will upon the Weave to make it so. The result is a system that rewards creativity and precision alike--but with near-infinite possibilities for how magic can be shaped, it also requires common sense, cooperation between player and GM, and the spirit of fair play.

spellcasting at a glance

1. State the intent.
2. Assign a Magnitude.
3. Choose a Bind and Strand.
4. Shape the spell with Target, Range, Duration, and Effect. Add Magnitude and Initiative penalty (as a positive modifier) to find the spell's Total Cost (TC).
5. Roll the Bind skill. Success sets resistance.
6. Control the spell with Mastery: the Bind roll's ones die, the Strand value, Threads, and Resolve. Uncontrolled success provokes a Weave Reaction.
7. Targets resist with an opposed roll against the Bind result.

chapter 14: weave magic

foundations of magic

The Binds and Strands

Binds

The Bind skill is the manner in which the Spellweaver harnesses the power of the Weave. Think of it as the verb of the spell.

Bind: Change

To alter, to change the basic properties of.

An individual--either living being or object--may be made of component parts, but its Essential Pattern is its truest use or most honest expression. A sword has a metal blade (Earth), wooden handle (Plant), and leather wrappings (Beast), but in the end, its true function is about the blade--so its Essential Pattern is Earth. Therefore, casting a spell that Changes a sword would require the Earth Strand.

Bind: Conjure

To bring forth into being, to create matter from nothing.

Individual beings, living or otherwise, cannot be Conjured into existence, but such beings may be healed by this Bind; extra-planar beings may be Summoned. Conjureditems last only as long as the spell's Duration, but their effects may last beyond that.

Bind: Control

To manipulate or protect, to take active control.

Once a thing is under your control, it remains so until the Duration ends (or until the circumstances change to grant it a new opposed roll). Generally, it takes an action to actively control something or to issue a specific command.

Bind: Destroy

To cause harm, to bring an end to.

Things destroyed by magic stay destroyed after the spell's Duration ends; hence, most Destroyspells that do direct or permanent damage have a Duration of Instant, but also have a higher Magnitude to reflect the spell's destabilizing nature.

Bind: Witness

To perceive, to know, to divine, to detect, to scry.

Witnessspells are often based on what Senses they employ.

Strands

The Strand is that aspect of reality that the caster is interacting with. Their Strand value determines how effectively they can control the spell. Think of it as the noun of the spell.

Strand: Air

Sound, electricity, cold, and light that does not produce heat. Includes invisibility.

Strand: Beast

Properties of all creatures, animals, and monsters native to the Broken Empires, and their products (hides, scales, teeth, etc.). Extra-planar creatures like demons fall under Spheres.

Strand: Body

Life, healing, properties of the humanoid physical form. Wounds healed by magic remain healed after the Duration expires.

Strand: Earth

Terrestrial materials, minerals, soil, metal, rock, the bones of the earth. Includes gravity.

Strand: Fire

Light that produces heat, that which burns. Fire created by magic is normal fire, and burns until it runs out of fuel, the Duration ends, it is put out, or the spell is countered.

Strand: Plant

All living plants and materials derived from them.

Strand: Spheres

The planes of existence, summoning and binding otherworldly creatures, divining through the constellations, magical transport, the minutiae and esoterica of magic itself.

Strand: Spirit

Ghosts and the undead, but also the immortal soul, and spiritual conviction and resistance.

Strand: Thought

Minds, dreams, imagination, illusion, knowledge, reason, emotions. When Thought magic's Duration expires, or if successfully resisted, the target may become aware of the magical manipulation.

Strand: Water

Includes precipitation, snow, ice, oceans, rivers, and non-biological liquid.

chapter 14: weave magic

A Spell's Intention

There are many possible approaches to achieving a result through magic. A player should be very specific about their intent behind the magical effect, and how they imagine that spell unfolding. As a caster, I must think: "What's my intent? And which Bind and Strand combination will I use to achieve that intention?" These answers will shape the spell's Magnitude, Effect, and cost.

If I want to make myself invisible, is it because I'm trying to sneak past a few guards? That comes down to an opposed roll between my Stealth and their Perception. Am I effectively trying to give myself a Stealth bonus? That seems to be the true purpose of going invisible in this situation. If so, one option is to Change or Destroy Air around me, altering the light and giving me a positive modifier to my Stealth with a Skill Effect (in this case, the bigger the modifier, the harder I am to see); that Magnitude might be considered Offensive. Another approach might be Control Thought in the onlooking sentries to give them a penalty to their Perception. This might instead have a Subtle Magnitude. Or I might try to really push the boundaries of reality and cast The Unseen Light spell (see the sample Change spells at the end of this chapter), which bends the light around me to literally make me invisible. This seems clearly Vulgar--but it's all based on the particular circumstances and the judgement of the GM.

What about cost? As you will see, casting a spell on yourself is always less risky than casting it on another target. In the Change Air option above, the cost for Target and Range are both zero. That is a much more controllable spell than the Control Thought option, in which I must account for each individual Target that might see me, and reach the targets by paying for sufficient Range.

So why would I choose the second option? For one thing, maybe I don't have any training in the Air Strand. Or maybe I have a magic Thread that gives me a special bonus to Thought magic. Also note that the second option was judged to be Subtle Magnitude instead of Offensive, and the third was Vulgar: that alone represents a substantial cost difference.

Spell crafting is all context-dependent. Magic is limited only by your imagination, but you'll have to think flexibly to produce your intended Effect.

The Bounded Laws of Magic

To better understand how magic works in the Broken Empires, consider the "Bounded Laws": the strictures and underlying philosophies of magic.

The Law of Limitation

"The Tapestry has edges."

There are things forever beyond the bounds of Weave magic:

- A No spell can affect time or reverse the effects of aging.
- A No spell can affect the sun or moon, nor any of the heavenly bodies.
- A Weave magic cannot restore spent (or change Maximum) Resolve, nor reduce Fatigue.
- A No creature may cast more than one spell in a single turn.
- A No magic--not even the power of the gods--can restore life to the dead (the powers of Necromancy merely create twisted mockeries of the living).
- A The Weave cannot create life, nor can it Conjure beings into existence.
- A Any spell that affects Wound Points directly must have an Instant Duration.
- A When Thought magic's Duration expires, or if successfully resisted, the target may become aware of having been manipulated.
- A A Controlled individual uses either its own relevant skill, or half the caster's, whichever is greater.

This law can also cover anything else the GM deems impossible; hence, it could also be called the "Law of GM Fiat", the "Law of No You Can't Jump To The Moon", or the "Law of Because I Think It's Stupid And Will Break This Game, That's Why". It basically allows the GM to be the final arbiter

of what is and what is not an appropriate or reasonable magical effect in his or her campaign. Just make sure your Spellweaver players have this knowledge so they can make informed decisions. Like any other aspect of magic in this game, imagination, common sense, and shared reasonableness are essential.

The Law of Logic

"One thing must lead to another along a path of simple logic."

This is essentially the law of common sense. When crafting a magical effect, you must follow a logical course of actions. This may necessitate the casting of multiple spells to achieve your goal, especially when crafting a spell that encompasses multiple effects.

For example, creating a skeleton warrior to fight for you would follow something similar to this process: first, you'd cast Conjure Body spell to create the skeleton out of nothing. Okay, so there's a pile of lifeless bones on the ground; now you must animate it with Control Body. Great, you've got a skeleton that can move by your command. Any attack it makes will be with bony little fists. You may need to Conjure Earth to create a sword for it. What weapon skill does it use? According to the Law of Limitation, because it is controlled by you, it uses half your weapon skill. And so forth.

This Law also considers the logical results of a spell's effects. The consequences of a spell may logically outlast the spell's Duration: Wound Points healed by magic stay healed after the spell's Duration ends, a forest burnt down by Conjure Fire remains ashes after the spell expires, bread conjured into existence still satiates you after the spell's Duration expires, etc.

Always consider the spell's primary purpose or Spell Effect when determining its cost. If a secondary outcome would logically follow from that primary Effect, it is generally included for free. If the secondary outcome would not occur without ongoing magical intervention, it must be paid for as a separate Effect or extended Duration.

> Casting a Change Earth spell to bring a zone's ceiling down on multiple enemies specifically to cause them damage is an Attack spell. However, the Law of Logic (and the GM) dictates that after the roof collapses, the zone also acquires a Blocked hazard--even though the caster didn't explicitly pay for that effect. The Block lasts indefinitely, not subject to the spell's Duration.

Requisites

This law also deals with requisites. Sometimes magical skills can overlap, and on the surface seem governed by more than one Bind or Strand ("I'm trying to turn that bandit into a frog. That's definitely the Bind Change, but is the governing Strand Beast or Body?"). These cases implement a requisite: having to use the lower value of the applicable Bind or Strand ("To turn him into a frog, combine Change with the lower of your Beast or Body values").

Or consider a spell that changes a wolf into a human. That would be Change Beast, with a Body requisite. But would that only change the physical form of the wolf, and not the mind? Would it think as a wolf, or as a man? If you wanted the wolf to have the reasoning power of a human, you might have to add the Thought requisite. This spell now requires mastery of at least 3 Strands, and could very easily be a Vulgar spell. Or maybe not: maybe you've decided that the Essential Pattern of the human also includes the mind, so turning Beast into a human Body also includes the mind as part of the transformation.

In any case, you must have a value of at least 1 in all requisite Strands in order to cast the spell in question.

Learning to adjudicate the "correct" combinations of Binds and Strands or requisites is, like every other part of the magic system, more art than science. Each GM will have to come to their own decisions about how magic is going to work in each particular situation--just be consistent once you do.

The Law of Resistance

"The Weave is not all-powerful, and is unpredictable even in the hands of a master."

An unwilling target always gets a chance to resist spell effects. A spell is resisted by making an opposed roll against the spell's Bind roll.

The caster's Bind roll includes the extra 3 SLs from a critical success. The caster's Bind Expertise, if any, can apply as a minimum SL.

If the spell wins, its effects manifest as the caster intended. If the target wins, the entire spell effect is negated. DoS is not a factor. Resisting a spell effect does not count as an action.

Any skill can be used to oppose magic, but it is always dependent on the form and context of the spell's effects. The opposing skill should be agreed upon by the player and GM before the casting roll. By default, use Dodge, Endurance, or Willpower, but the GM makes the final decision.

If you are the direct target of a spell, you will always get a resistance: if a caster hurls a spear of fire at you as an attack spell, a successful resistance nullifies that damage, as you are the direct target. But if the caster hits you with a magically flaming sword that does +3 fire damage, you are not the direct target of the spell--the sword is (the fire becomes part of the sword's Essential Pattern). Therefore, you don't get to oppose the effects of the fire damage.

- Willing targets may choose to forfeit resistance.
- Inanimate objects, areas, or zones can't oppose, but more resistant objects might trigger higher Magnitude.
  - Objects held, carried, or worn by a creature oppose the spell using the creature's Dodge, Endurance, or Willpower.
- If you failed an opposed roll against a spell with a Duration of a minute or less, you are able to make a new opposed roll against the original Bind roll at the end of your next turn.
- If you failed an opposed roll against a spell with a Duration of longer than a minute, you are able to make a new opposed roll against the original Bind roll only if one of the following occurs:
  - You would have reason and opportunity to use an action to make a significant change to the circumstances. The action taken can be used as the opposing skill if it makes sense, but it will consume your round's action.
  - An external force changes the circumstances.
  - If a magical compulsion would cause you to do something obviously against your own interests.
- Once you've opposed a particular spell, you are immune to its ongoing effects, if any. A new casting of the same spell will require a new opposed roll.
- Magical effects that cause extra damage placed on weapons become part of that weapon's Essential Pattern for the Duration, and as such cannot be opposed beyond the expected methods of opposing the attack itself, through a parry or Dodge.

The Law of Reaction

"The Weave punishes those who cannot control it."

Magic is a literal tearing apart of the fabric of reality. This causes chaos and instability. The more ostentatious and contrary to the laws of reality the spell is, the more the Weave will unpredictably lash out against it, and alter it in some way. This is called a Weave Reaction, and its severity is influenced by its Magnitude: Discreet, Subtle, Offensive, or Vulgar. The Magnitude translates directly to a higher TC (Total Cost) for the spell.

The GM decides the Magnitude of the proposed spell based on the player's description of it. The more the spell obviously transgresses the laws of reality, the higher the Magnitude. Start with the question: "Do the overall effects of the spell align with the internal logic of the setting?" The more the spell strays from the internal logic of the world, the greater its Magnitude.

For example, a spell that harnesses a nearby bonfire to damage an enemy would use the Bind Control and the Strand Fire. If the spell causes a sudden swell of heat to damage an enemy adjacent to the bonfire, that could be a Discreet spell. If the spell causes the fire to actually flare outwards at the nearby enemy, the GM might decide this is a somewhat unusual magical effect that gets the Weave's attention, and assign it a Magnitude of Subtle. If the caster instead causes a ball of flame to erupt from and fly out of the bonfire at a more distant target, that might be an Offensive Magnitude. If the flaming attack instead took the form of a screeching dragon (which might also have the incidental non-magical side effect of terrifying other enemies), that might be Vulgar.

If a spell is cast surreptitiously, or is masked by another mundane activity, the Magnitude should be lower. If I cast a healing spell after performing a Heal roll, the likely Magnitude will be Discreet; but if I instead wave my hands and heal the wound in a flash of improbability, the Magnitude will likely be Offensive or even Vulgar.

As a rule of thumb, if a spell's effects can easily be explained away, the Weave will not react as badly. The Magnitude should be appropriate to the spell effect. As with most other aspects of magic, Magnitude designations will be up to each individual GM.

The Magnitude is added to a spell's TC:

Magnitude	TC	Amount
Discreet	+0	Almost indistinguishable from happenstance/ Beneath notice
Subtle	+2	Unusual but easily explained/Believable through natural means
Offensive	+5	Highly unusual but could be explained/Extremely unlikely in nature, but still possible/Strains credulity/ Suspiciously unusual/One in a million
Vulgar	+10	Obviously impossible in nature/Clearly supernatural/Ostentatious or especially flashy magic

As a general rule, whenever possible, Weave Reactions will manifest contrary to the caster's intentions, and beyond his control. However, not all Weave Reactions are negative. Sometimes a Spellweaver gets lucky and produces either a harmless incidental cosmetic effect, or actually brings into being a Thread attuned to the Bind or Strand used in the spell. Casters should think carefully when mitigating the Weave: sometimes it pays to save the Resolve and risk a roll on the Weave Reaction Table instead. Such is the gamble that is magic!

chapter 14: weave magic

The Law of Mystery

"Not all can be explained."

Magic is mysterious. Not everything a magic user encounters will fit within his understanding of the Weave. Despite their best efforts to categorize magic into a set of formulae that can be organized, studied, and reproduced, Spellweavers must accept that there are some magical effects and items in the world that defy any explanation; their very existence reveals just how limited a Spellweaver's understanding of the magical realm truly is. Some magical effects will simply not make sense to the assumptions of the Spellweaver, and yet exist nonetheless.

The rules presented in this chapter represent an approximation of how the Weave may best be understood and harnessed by mortals, but in the end, the Weave is not bound by any strictures that a wizard would foist upon it. Binds and Strands are the best way Spellweavers know to affect the Tapestry, but they are not the only way. The Tapestry ultimately plays by its own rules, the full secrets of which are forever beyond the grasp of any Spellweaver.

This Law also encompasses all non-Weave magic: the powers of demons, fairies, the Dark Fae, and all other forms of magic that do not draw directly upon the Weave in the same way. (Divine magic is still largely bound by the Weave and these Laws, but there are exceptions.) This allows the freedom to create magic items and powers that defy Weave magic, and is the exclusive territory of the GM. How and why these otherworldly powers work is up to each individual GM.

Binding the Strand

Casting a spell is also known as Binding a Strand. To do so, the caster must have at least 1 available Resolve . Otherwise, a spell cannot be attempted.

There can be many ways to achieve a result through magic, but choosing the right Bind and Strand combination is only the first step. Just as important is using your immediate circumstances to best support the effects of your spell, to ensure the least risk of Weave Reactions. Maximizing the potential of your environment and given circumstances can be just as crucial to a controlled casting as using the right Binds and Strands.

- A To use a Bind and Strand combination, you must have a value in each. Binds or Strands with a value of zero cannot be used in spellcasting.
- A Casting a spell cannot be combined with, or performed at the same time as, any other skill or action.
- A A Spellweaver must both make the correct gestures with at least one hand and speak the required magical words to cast any spell.

Shaping the Spell: Total Cost & Mastery

Before it can be cast, a spell must be shaped by the following elements, each one contributing to its Total Cost (TC).

- A Magnitude is how offensive to the Weave the spell is.
- A Target determines whom or what the spell affects. Targets are either Individuals or Zones.
- A Range is how distant the spell's target or effect is from the caster.
- A Duration is how long the spell's effects will last.
- A Effect provides the actual results of the successfully-cast spell.
- A Initiative penalty of worn armor acts as a positive modifier to every spell's TC. (An armor Initiative penalty of -5 would add 5 to the TC of any spell cast.).

Once shaped, a spell must be successfully cast with a Bind roll, which determines how hard it is to resist in an opposed roll.

After a successful Bind roll, the caster must control the spell, or else suffer a Weave Reaction. To control the spell, the caster's Mastery value must equal or exceed the spell's TC. Mastery is derived from:

- A the ones die from a Bind roll *
- A the value of the involved Strand ,
- A any Threads used, and
- A any Resolve used to mitigate the spell.

* Remember a "0" on the ones die counts as 10

Shaping Costs

Magnitude	TC
Discreet	+0
Subtle	+2
Offensive	+5
Vulgar	+10

Target	TC
Self	free
1 individual (Ind.) +2 TC per additional individual +2 TC to Choose Location on an individual, or to target a specific part of an object	2
1 zone	3
2 zones	5
3 zones	7
Structure (Ritual only)	9
Bounded Area (Ritual only, +1d6 Fraying)	10

Range	TC
Self	free
Touch/Engaged	1
Close/Short	2
Medium/Long	3
Very Long	4
Sight	5
Arcane Tether	6

Duration	TC
Instant	free
One Round (6 seconds)	1
Concentration	2
1 Minute (10 rounds)	3
1 Hour	4
Sun (to the next Sunup/Sundown)	5
Week (Ritual only)	6
Fortnight (Ritual only)	7
Month (Ritual only)	8
Year (Ritual only, +1d4 Fraying)	9
Permanent (Ritual only, +2d6 Fraying)	10
Triggered Effect	+1-9

Effect	TC
Various Costs	X

Initiative Penalty from Worn Armor	TC
Use as a positive modifier to the TC	+X

Casting Time

The time it takes to cast a spell is determined by its Duration.

- A A spell with a Duration of 1 minute or less has a casting time of 1 action.
- A A spell with a Duration of 1 hour or Sun has a casting time of 1 minute.
- A A spell with a longer Duration must be cast as a Ritual (see below), with a casting time of 1 hour for each of the spell's required TC.

In practice, this means in combat you can't reasonably cast a spell with a Duration of longer than 1 minute.

You can only cast a spell on your own turn, unless casting a counterspell specifically against incoming magic (see Counterspells).

making the casting roll

1. Describe intention. The player states exactly what the spell is intended to do.
2. Determine Magnitude . The GM assigns a Magnitude: Discreet (+0 TC), Subtle (+2 TC), Offensive (+5 TC), Vulgar (+10 TC)
3. Pick the Bind and Strand . The GM approves which Bind and Strand apply, and decides whether any Requisites are required.
4. Shape the spell . The player picks the spell's elements (Target, Range, Duration, Effect). Together with the Magnitude and Initiative penalty from worn armor, these produce the spell's Total Cost (TC).
5. Make the casting roll. Roll the relevant Bind skill. Up to 3 Resolve can be spent as usual to increase the Bind chance.
6. Mitigation (optional).The caster may spend as much Resolve as they can afford to reduce the Weave Reaction Modifier. (This is the only case where more than 3 Resolve may be spent on one roll.) Each additional Resolve spent reduces the modifier by 1. Reducing the modifier to zero cancels the Weave Reaction. Otherwise, roll 1d20 + the Weave Reaction Modifier on the Weave Reaction Table .
7. Target rolls resistance; apply results . If the spell succeeded, targets resist with an opposed roll against the Bind result. Apply spell effects and any Weave Reactions simultaneously. Any physical Arcane Tethers used are consumed.

Bind Roll Results

Roll	Outcome
Success	The spell is cast. The Bind roll's SLs set the resistance. Add together the Bind roll's ones die, the relevant Strand value, and any Thread result to find the caster's Mastery . If this total is equal to or greater thanthe spell's TC, the spell is controlled (no Weave Reaction).
Success, but Mastery is less than the spell's TC	The spell is cast as above, but is uncontrolled. The difference between the Mastery and the TC is called the Weave Reaction Modifier . A Weave Reaction occurs unless mitigated (see step 6).
Critical Success	The spell is cast. Add +3 SLs.
Failure	The spell is not cast. Spend 1 Resolve with no further effect.
Critical Failure	The spell is not cast. Spend 1 Resolve and immediately roll on the Weave Reaction Table , adding the spell's Magnitude cost to the result. Fades also gain 1 Fraying.

Commitment and Risk

A spell's scale and intended effects are declared in advance. After a successful Bind roll is made, the caster must immediately decide whether to mitigate the Weave, without knowing whether the spell will be resisted.The spell will either take hold or it will not--there is no opportunity to revise or withdraw the casting.

This means that even a spell with a low Bind roll demands a choice: commit resources to stabilize a spell that may be easily resisted, or accept the risk of a Weave Reaction. A strong Bind roll, or a high Bind Expertise that raises the spell's minimum SL, makes resistance far less likely and turns that same decision into a safer bet.

shaping element guidelines

Target

The target of a spell can be an Individual in a zone, the Zone itself, a Structure, or a Bounded Area. The caster must be able to see or otherwise perceive their target (see also Range: Arcane Tethers).

A An Individual target (2 TC, +2 TC per additional) is an object or being independent of the space it's in. An object can be considered one "thing" even if it is made up of component parts, as long as those parts are all part of a contiguous whole governed by the Strand, or part of that thing's Essential Pattern.

- » The Self is an individual target with no cost.
- » Multiple targets of the same spell must be contiguous with each other, or in the same zone.
- » When targeting an individual to cause damage, the random struck hit location (if needed) is the ones die of the casting roll.
- » Choosing Location on an individual target is +2 TC per target, and can be chosen after the roll.

A A Zone (3 TC for one; 5 TC for two; 7 TC for three) is a location or area, or a part of a location or area.

- » Targeting the zone affects the zone itself, in whole or in part, not the individuals in that zone.
- » Individuals in a targeted zone can be exempted from a spell's Effect for +2 TC per individual exempted.

A A Structure (9 TC; Ritual only) is any contained building or similar with any number of zones. You may either:

- » affect all zones within the structure; or
- » affect all specified targets within the structure. Each one gets a resistance roll.

A A Bounded Area (10 TC, +1d6 Fraying; Ritual only) refers to any large area with contiguous boundaries (a village, a forest, a knight's fiefdom). This target requires the Arcane Tether Range. You may either:

- » affect all zones within the bounded area; or
- » affect all specified targets within it. Each one gets a resistance roll.

Targets of Control Spells

Affected Individual targets within your perception can be controlled by you throughout the Duration of the spell. If a controlled target leaves your perceptual range, you cannot issue commands to it, although it remains under your control (this could award it a new opposed roll against your control, however). Issuing commands to a controlled target outside your perceptual range requires a Witness spell with an Arcane Tether to the target, a Duration of at least 1 round, and a Sense Effect of at least Hearing.

It costs 1 action to deliver a specific command and does not break concentration. The command can apply to up to your Strand value in individuals currently under your control. The command must be short and executable ("Carry this object over there"), or a simple if/then conditional command ("If anyone approaches this door, attack them"). Controlled individuals act on their own Initiative. For spells of Duration longer than 1 round, the target will continue acting upon the last given command until the Duration expires, they complete the action, they are able to successfully resist, or the caster gives them a new command.

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Example

If you cast multiple Control spells affecting two humans via Control Thought, three animals via Control Beast, and one dancing sword via Control Earth, you can control all of them for as long as each spell's Duration is in effect. If you issued a command to attack a particular enemy, the humans, animals, and sword would all do so, unless you specifically excluded one or more of them from that command.

Range

Where the effect happens; the distance between the source of the spell and its Target or its effect at the time casting is complete. If you can't see or otherwise perceive your target, you need to have an Arcane Tether to the target, and must choose the Arcane Tether range for 6 TC.

- A Self (0 TC) means your person.
- A Touch (1 TC) and Engaged (1 TC) is anything within arm's length that you can actually lay hands on.
- A Close/Short (2 TC), Medium/Long (3 TC), and Very Long (4 TC) refer to zones of distance.
- A Sight (5 TC) is anything you can see with the unaided eye.
- A Arcane Tether (6 TC) means the physical distance to the target is not a factor.

Arcane Tethers

An Arcane Tether is a mystical connection to the target. Possessing one allows you to affect the target irrespective of distance.

- A If the target is a being, a valid Tether must embody a significant personal connection. It must be one of the following:
  - » A valued possession genuinely important to the target which the caster physically possesses, such as a weapon they forged, a diary, or a wedding ring -- not a random trinket or borrowed tool.
  - » A specific and meaningful part of their person, such as a lock of hair, three drops of their saliva, seven nail clippings, or similar. These fragments must be taken directly from the individual.
  - » An artistic representation such as a painting, drawing, sculpture, or the like;
  - » Their True Name, the ultimate Arcane Tether to any Spellweaver or powerful other-worldly individual. See the True Names section later in this chapter for rules on their use.
- A If the target is an object or non-being, some significant piece or artistic representation of that object will suffice (a steel shaving from a targeted sword blade, an accurate drawing of a targeted stone wall, etc.).
- A Artistic representations used as Arcane Tethers must be created with an extended SL 15 Craft: Artistic roll, 1 day/roll. Such representations are only useful as Tethers for 1 full turn of the moon (1 month) from the time of completion.
- A A physical Arcane Tether is consumed upon the successful completion of the spell.

- A spellweaver may only ever possess a total number of physical Arcane Tethers (not including True Names) equal to their Arcana Score. If a Spellweaver ever intentionally possesses more Tethers than their Arcana Score allows, the Weave rebels: they must immediately make a Weave Reaction roll of 1d20 +10 on the Weave Reaction Table. Tethers in a caster's possession can be physically carried or contained within a dedicated vessel (scroll, reliquary, etc.). Lost or stolen Tethers still count against the limit until destroyed or consumed.
- Arcane Tethers can be sensed and identified by Spellweavers using Arcana or a Witness Spheres spell (see Tears in the Tapestry, below). True Names cannot be identified this way.
- When dealing with very powerful forces, an individual person or object who has been in the force's presence may even act as an Arcane Tether. Such a person is not consumed by the spell. This kind of tether is one-use only--the strain on the individual destroys their link to it afterward.

Duration

How long the spell effects last, starting the moment the spell casting is complete. The results of a spell are often permanent; for example, if a spell destroys an item, that item remains destroyed after the spell's Duration expires, etc.

In general, natural changes and effects last even after the spell's Duration expires, but unnatural effects do expire (Wound Point damage caused by a spell lasts after the spell has expired, but a wolf transformed into a bird would revert back to its Essential Pattern). The Duration of some spell effects will also be obvious: flinging sand into a foe's face with Control Earth to temporarily blind him might be Instant Duration, but the effect will last until the foe takes an action to wipe the sand away. Adjudication will be necessary.

Fire and Duration

Fire conjured by magic is normal fire, and spreads according to the rules in Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Other Perils. But if a magically created fire with sufficient fuel will burn long past its Duration, why would a caster ever cast a spell with anything other than Instant Duration?

Because Duration determines how long the fire is magically sustained before natural factors take over.

Instant Duration: The spell produces fire only for a moment. It will linger naturally only if it immediately ignites real fuel. If no fuel catches, the flame vanishes as quickly as it appeared.

Sustained Duration: The spell forces fire to exist even without fuel or favorable conditions. When the Duration ends, the fire continues only if it has spread to something that can burn.

Note that any spell (Fire Strand or otherwise) that directly inflicts Wound Points is an Attack Spell, and must always be Instant Duration. Duration may be used to maintain hazards (such as burning zones, walls of fire, or other environmental effects), but not to prolong direct damage.

A spell's Duration determines how long it takes to cast (see Casting Time).

- Instant (0 TC) spells occur immediately. The effect starts and ends with the caster's action.
- One Round (1 TC). If targeting an individual being, the spell's effect lasts until after the target's next turn; otherwise, it lasts until the start of your next turn.
- Concentration (2 TC) spells last only as long as the caster focuses on the spell, taking no action other than movement or speaking a few words.
  - » If the spell allows them to perform an action as part of the spell, this does not break concentration.

- » If the caster is interrupted, has any location Impaired, or performs any other action or defense outside of what the spell allows, the Concentration spell immediately ends.
- » Resisting a spell effect does not break concentration.
- » Concentration spells endure regardless of the caster's current range to the target.
- » A caster may only concentrate on one spell at a time.

A One Minute (3 TC) lasts 10 combat rounds.

A One Hour (4 TC) is 60 minutes.

A Sun (5 TC) means the spell lasts until the next time the sun's light either touches the sky (sunup) or leaves it (sundown).

A A Week (6 TC) , Fortnight (2 weeks, 7 TC) , Month (8 TC) , Year (9 TC, +1d4 Fraying) , or Permanent (10 TC, +2d6 Fraying) Duration is only possible through ritual magic. Year and Permanent Durations also accrue Fraying points.

A Spells of certain Durations (including Permanent) may allow a new opposed roll to resist if circumstances permit; see The Law of Resistance

A A caster can delay the start of the Effect until some specific caster-described condition sets off the spell by adding a trigger (see Triggered Spells).

Effect

Effect answers the question, "What is the spell intended to actually do?", and it represents how the spell interacts with the game's mechanics, like skills, Wound Points, Toughness modifiers, and more.

Calculating Effect can be tricky, but always goes back to the spell's governing Bind and Strand, and its intent. What are you trying to achieve, and how are you trying to achieve it? These questions will help adjudicate any edge cases you encounter.

The Effect affects all of the spell's targets equally.

At the GM's discretion, a spell can have more than 1 Effect, as long as it is covered by the Bind and Strand of the spell (otherwise, a requisite must be introduced). Any allowed additional Effects add their TC to the spell's total. Resisting such a spell resists all of its effects. If there is a choice of resistance skills, the target chooses.

These are the most common effects Weave magic can produce:

- A Spells that add Actions
- A Spells that affect Armor Points
- A Spells used to Attack
- A Spells that affect Attributes
- A Spells that Enhance weapons
- A Spells that Heal
- A Spells that affect Mental or Emotional states
- A Spells that affect Senses and produce Illusions
- A Spells that affect Size and Transformation
- A Spells that affect Speed or Movement
- A Spells that Conjure Substances into being
- A Spells that Summon
- A Spells that affect Skill values
- A Spells that affect Zones
- A Spells that do anything not specifically listed here

Add Actions

A spell can grant the target additional actions for the current round. Extra actions occur at the end of the round, after all other participants have acted. The spell's Duration must be One Round. Extra actions cannot be used to cast additional spells, to Hold to Interrupt (counterspell), or to take the Delay action. The caster suffers 1 Fraying when using the two-action variant.

TC	Additional Actions Granted
5	+1 Action
10	+2 Actions, +1 Fraying

Armor Points

Provides Armor Points of protection appropriate to the Bind and Strand used. These APs give protection equal to worn armor.

If the target is Self or an Individual being, AP affects all hit locations (if any of the target's hit locations already have armor, use whichever AP value is higher).

If enhancing an individual object (like a piece of worn armor), add the magical armor points to the existing armor points.

This Effect can enhance a weapon, giving it the Piercing trait to ignore Armor Points of locations struck.

This effect can also nullify armor points.

TC	Armor Point Modifier
1	+1 AP
2	+2 AP
4	+3 AP
6	+4 AP
8	+5 AP
10	+6 AP

Attack Spells (External or Internal)

If the primary purpose of a spell is to cause direct damage to an Individual target, it is an Attack Spell. An attack spell can take many forms but is always based on the Bind and Strand used. Whether it's blasting an enemy with a fireball or lashing their mind with whips of psychic pain, if the spell would cause direct damage, it's an attack spell.

There are two varieties of attack spell, based on the spell's Bind and Strand: External (damage originating from outside the target, like a firebolt) and Internal (damage originating from inside the target, like a heart attack).

- The damage caused by an External spell allows the target the benefit of armor and/or shield AP. An External attack spell is almost always resisted by Dodge.
  - For 1 TC, an External attack spell's damage is equal to its Strand score. Additional damage costs +1 TC per extra point of damage.
  - External damage affecting an inanimate object does double the final damage (see Chapter 10 - Combat: Damaging Objects).
- The damage caused by an Internal spell completely ignores the target's AP from armor or shield. It is resisted by either Willpower or Endurance, depending on the description of the spell.
  - For 1 TC, an Internal attack spell's damage is equal to its Strand score. You cannot increase the damage of an Internal attack spell past your Strand score.

An attack spell, like any other spell, allows the target to make an opposed roll against the spell's Bind roll. Success nullifies all damage from the spell; opposing SLs do not reduce the spell's damage.

It doesn't matter whether an attack spell's damage source comes from the caster himself, or as indirect damage from a proxy object: the damage the spell does is derived from the spell, not the proxy object.

If Fionnah the Sorceress causes a boulder to fall on a bandit with Control Earth, and her intention is to use an attack spell to damage him, the boulder does whatever damage she pays for, not damage derived from the size of the boulder itself. Magnitude is a definite factor, though; because of its size, the boulder attack spell might be a Subtle or even Discreet Magnitude. If she tried to attack him for the same damage with a pebble, that would definitely be a Vulgar effect.

- All attack spells must have a Duration of Instant.
- Attack spells do not cover enhancing weapons or affect any other method of causing damage.
- Attack spells do not suffer the -20 penalty for targets in cover.
- If the spell's Strand accommodates, the caster can choose to make the Wound Points non-lethal.
- The target's struck hit location is the ones die of the spell roll (which is also applied toward Mastery). A different hit location can be chosen after the roll for an additional cost of +2 TC per target. Some spells will require a specific location to be struck based on their description.
- After the roll, shield AP can be bypassed. For +2 TC per target, ignore shield AP.
- After the roll, armor AP can be bypassed. Per target, for every +1 TC, ignore up to 3 armor AP in the struck location.
- Elemental damage (fire, cold, electricity, etc.) may have additional effects (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Other Perils).

Fionnah casts magical blue bolts (Conjure Spheres 5) at a raider in her zone. This is an External Attack spell. The Magnitude is Vulgar (10), the Duration is Instant (0 TC), the Range is Close (2 TC), the Target is One Individual (2 TC), the Damage is 7 (3 TC), for a total cost of 17 TC.

The spell roll succeeds with a 42 (4 SLs). The raider tries to resist with his Dodge of 50, and rolls a 35 (3 SLs). His opposed roll failed, so he takes the full 7 damage to the Body (the spell roll's ones die was a "2"). He happens to be wearing Leather (3 AP) on the Body and is carrying a small shield (3 AP). She decides to spend +1 TC after the roll to ignore the 3 AP in the Body, reducing his total AP to just 3, from the shield. He takes a 4-point wound to the Body. In total, the spell now costs 18 TC. After factoring in her Strand score of 5, any Thread dice she might use (she has none here), and the 2 she rolled on her Bind roll, Fionnah will be 11 TC short of the spell's requirement--she'll have to spend Resolve to control the spell or else suffer a Weave Reaction.

Later, Fionnah uses a spell to increase her Toughness by 3 for 6 TC, lasting for the spell's Duration.

Attributes

Alters a creature's inherent traits such as Toughness, Death Threshold, Lethality Level, Initiative, or Max ENC.

TC	Attribute Modifier*
2	+/- 1
4	+/- 2
6	+/- 3
8	+/- 4
10	+/- 5

Initiative or Max ENC

1	+/- 1 per TC

*Resolve, Max Resolve, and Fatigue can never be affected by Weave magic.

Enhance Weapon

Adds magical Strand-based damage to a weapon's base damage:

TC	Damage Bonus
1	To "make magical" gives no damage bonus, but makes the weapon count as magical for the purposes of damaging spirits and unearthly creatures who can only be affected by magic. This also applies to all levels of the Enhanced Weapon Effect.
2	+1 damage
4	+2 damage
5	Suppress a creature's immunity to non-magical weapons (targeting the Individual creature, not a weapon)
6	+3 damage
8	+4 damage
10	+5 damage

Heal Damage

Magical healing (Conjure Body) is applied to a specific wound and must have a Duration of Instant. You do not have to pay extra to Choose Location.

The closer a healing spell's description is to a standard Heal attempt (the manner in which it's cast, the time it takes, etc.), the lower the Magnitude of the spell.

TC	Magical Damage and Healing
1	Per 1 Wound Point healed
+3	Add to remove infection from a specific wound
5	Nullify a poison or remove a disease

Mental or Emotional Effect

These spells affect mental states and emotional conditions. They are almost always resisted by Willpowerand are Thought-based if used on humanoids. All Thought-based magic will cause the victim to be aware of being manipulated if they succeed on the opposed roll, or if they succeed on a standard Insightroll immediately after the spell expires.

1 TC

- A Detect Emotional State to provide a general feel of the target's emotional state.

2 TC

- A Base emotion : Anger, jealousy, desire, despair, disgust, anxiety.
  - » Affecting a target's base emotions may give +/- 10 on various skills based on the situation (inflicting despair may give +10 on Intimidate or Persuade attempts, for example).

3 TC

- A Fear causes Fear effects (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Other Perils). The Fear Rating is the spell's Bind SLs.
- A Charm spells make the caster seem friendly to the target until something happens to change that perception, or the Duration expires. Add +30 to any Social rolls except Intimidate made by the caster against the Charmed target. The target gets a new opposed Willpowerroll if they are compelled to act against their own interests.
- A Sleep : Targets failing an opposed Willpower roll fall into a magical sleep. They fall Prone and cannot take any actions at all. Taking damage will immediately wake them. A sleeping target can be awakened by someone else using an action to rouse them, but not by simple loud noises.
  - » For Durations of a week or longer, the sleeper is preserved in magical stasis. Until the spell ends, they may only awaken if roused by an outside force and succeed at a Willpowerroll opposed to the Bind roll. For Durations of over a week, one such attempt may be made per week.

4 TC

- A Higher Emotion : Love, compassion, loyalty, joy, gratitude, guilt.
  - » Affecting a target's higher emotions may give +/- 20 on various skills based on the situation (affecting Loyalty might give +20 to any Inspireor Persuadeattempts on the affected target, for example).
- A Bond : This is a special condition that can be imposed upon an animal with a Control Beast spell. If successful, the Bonded being becomes a loyal servant to the caster for the Duration. The target gets a new opposed Willpower roll if they are compelled to act catastrophically against their own interests. Upon the Bond's expiration, a creature will attack the caster or flee, according to its inherent aggression.
  - » A Mindless undead can be Bonded with Control Spirit.
  - » An otherworldly creature can be Bonded with Control Spheres, but it must be summoned into a circle first.
  - » Humanoids cannot be Bonded.

5 TC

- Confuse spells make the target act in hesitant, random ways. Each time they would take an action, roll a d10:

d10	Effect
1-4	They stand confused, take no action, and can only defend themselves.
5-7	They take a beneficial action toward an antagonist. If no antagonist is within range, treat as 1-4.
8-10	They take an aggressive action against an ally. If no ally is within range, treat as 1-4.

6 TC

- Memory can affect what and how the target remembers an event. Duration is how long the memory effect lasts. Like all Thought magic, the victim may be aware of being manipulated after the spell expires.
  - » Destroy magic erases memories for the Duration.
  - » Change magic alters the memories for the Duration.
  - » Conjure magic implants new memories for the Duration.
  - » Control magic can force the target to reveal their thoughts and memories.
  - » Witness magic reads the target's surface thoughts for the Duration.

8 TC

- Dominate type spells can make the target act even against their own interests, but cannot have a Duration of more than 1 minute, unless cast as a ritual with a ritual Duration of up to a month. If a command would cause the target to do something suicidal or similarly catastrophic, they immediately get a new opposed Willpower roll against the original spell.

Sense & Illusion

Often used in Witness spells and in various illusions, this Effect determines how many senses the spell engages or affects. With Witness spells, the chosen sense(s) provides the medium through which the caster perceives.

TC	Senses Affected
1	1 of Taste, Touch/Feel, or Scent
2	Sound. Spells affecting speech are included with Sound.
3	Any 3 of the above
4	Sight
5	Any 3 of the above
8	All senses

Our sorceress Fionnah is scrying on an enemy to whom she has an Arcane Tether with a Witness Body spell. She wants to both see and hear him, so it costs 5 TC to get any 3: Sight, Hearing, and Smell.

This Effect can also be used to blunt a target's specific senses (affecting a target's overall senses could instead use the Skill Effect Perception). Spells that inflict blindness or deafness on a target follow the Blinded/Deafened rules for the Duration.

She decides to blind her enemy from afar, which she can attempt thanks to her Arcane Tether. With Destroy Body, it will cost 4 TC to target his Sight (with an Offensive Magnitude, Duration of Sun, Range of Arcane Tether, Target of Individual, and Sense of Sight, this is a 22 TC spell). If his opposed roll fails, he will be struck blind (-50 on all tasks requiring sight) for the spell's Duration.

Illusions

An illusion fools anyone who perceives it into experiencing something that is not really there. An illusion can produce anything the caster can imagine, but it must use only the senses paid for, work within the limitations of Range, Target, and Duration, and cannot replicate or be combined with any other magical effect described in this section. Illusions always use the Thought Strand and are created with the Conjure Bind.

Targeting

An illusion can be cast either on an individual being or object, or a zone.

- Illusions that target a zone cannot leave the zone's boundaries. A zone-target illusion may be cast on empty space, allowing the caster to conjure something seemingly "out of thin air," such as a ghost, wall, or fire.
- Illusions that target an individual object are not bound by location, but each time someone interacts with such an illusion, it increases the chance they will disbelieve it.

Behavior

When first created, an illusion must be set to behave according to simple, appropriate patterns defined by the spellweaver. An illusory group of hobgoblins, for example, could be made to snarl threateningly, but they would not change their behavior if attacked. For an illusion to respond to outside stimuli or change its behavior dynamically, the caster must be within perceptual range of the illusion and must also maintain a separate Control Thoughts spell with a Duration of Concentration.

Limits

Illusions can disguise or mask existing things by overlaying them with another appearance, but they cannot erase those things or make them invisible. Spells that render a being or object unseen require another appropriate Bind and Strand.

Illusions cannot cause actual harm. They may only create the appearance of things, with their strength determined by the senses they affect and the believability of the illusion; however, creatures who mistake an illusion for reality may still suffer indirect consequences from their own reactions (such as fleeing off a ledge or into danger).

Fionnah wants to scare an enemy with an illusion of a ghost. She casts a Conjure Thought spell, and creates a false banshee using Sight, Sound, and Feel (5 TC). As the banshee is just an illusion, it won't cause fear like a real ghost (or like the Mental Effect of Fear), but she could "program" it to float into view, scream horrifically, and broadcast icy coldness--certainly giving the enemy a reason to flee the area!

Resistance and Disbelief

Zones and objects never resist illusions. Only individual beings may resist them, and this occurs in three ways:

- If the illusion is cast directly upon a being, that target immediately resists with a Willpower roll opposed to the caster's Bind.
- When someone first perceives an illusion--whether by seeing, hearing,

touching, or otherwise sensing it--the GM secretly rolls their Insight opposed to the spell's Bind roll. On a success, they see through it. On a failure, the perceiver continues to experience the illusion as real until they have a legitimate reason to disbelieve it.

A Only if a perceiver later has a legitimate reason to suspect the illusion may they declare an attempt to actively disbelieve. Doing so requires spending an action to make a Willpower roll opposed to the spell's original Bind roll. The GM may grant bonuses if repeated interactions or mounting evidence strongly suggest the illusion is false.

An illusion, for all intents and purposes, is real as long as those perceiving it believe it to be genuine. One cannot simply walk past a troll if one thinks it is standing in front of them, nor can one move through an illusion of a Blocked zone if one believes it to be Blocked. While the illusory troll cannot hurt him, to the victim of an illusion, it is real--and he must behave appropriately.

Illusion Magnitude

The Effect cost of an illusion is based on the number of senses it affects, but its Magnitude is determined by its believability and complexity. Creating an illusion of a burning barn is Discreet. Having the barn burning in the middle of a thunderstorm is Subtle, since it remains possible. Having the barn burn with ghostly blue-green fire is Offensive. Having the barn burn while a demonic figure emerges holding a flaming sword is Vulgar.

Size & Transformation

These tend to be Vulgar Magnitude spells, and often utilize the Change Bind. Changing a being will affect some of its Attributes and specific combat abilities (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary: Size). Changing an object will have all manner of consequences as dictated by the situation (for example, increasing the size of a two-handed sword will just make it too big for a human to wield--not make it do more damage).

TC	Change in Size
3	+/- 1 Size category change
5	+/- 2 Size category change
7	+/- 3 Size category change
10	+/- 4 Size category change
15	+/- 5 Size category change (Ritual only)

Magical Size Changes

Adjust the following stats for each step a creature is magically Changed above or below their starting Size:

Each Size Above	Each Size Below
+1 Toughness	-1 Toughness (min 0)
+2 base damage	-2 base damage (min 0)
+5 Death Threshold	-5 Death Threshold (min 1)
-1 Initiative	+1 Initiative

Size Categories

Minute - Diminutive - Tiny - Little - Small - Medium - Large - Huge - Massive - Gargantuan - Colossal

Combat Effects by Size Difference

When 2 or More Sizes Apart

- Reach: A creature gains +1 Reach for every 2 Sizes it is larger than its opponent.
- Grappling: You can only Grapple creatures up to 2 Sizes larger or smaller than you.
- Might Bonus: In a Grapple, the larger creature gains +20 Might per Size category of difference.

When 3 or More Sizes Apart

- Maneuver Limits: You cannot use Drive Back, Trip, or Disarm against a creature 3 or more Sizes larger than you.
- Monstrous Attacks: A creature 3 or more Sizes larger makes melee attacks that cannot be parried, only Dodged.
- Easier to Hit: All Combat skills used against a creature 3 or more Sizes larger are at +20.

Fionnah casts a Change Beast spell with a Size Effect cost of 3 TC to reduce a troll's size 1 step from Large to Medium (1 Size category difference). The troll will lose 1 Toughness, 2 base damage, and 5 Death Threshold for as long as it's the smaller Size. It will gain +1 Initiative.

Speed or Movement

Spells targeting movement or speed affect how many zones a target can move in one round, impede general movement, apply Combat Maneuvers, or bind and restrain creatures through magical or physical means.

- +Zone movement allows a target to use its move in a round to move an additional number of zones. This spell does not allow the recipient to move farther with a Run action.

TC	Additional Zones
2	+1 zone
5	+2 zones
7	+3 zones
10	+4 zones

To restrict a target's movement:

TC	Effect on Movement
4	Immobilized: They cannot move, but can still act.
6	Restrained: They can neither move nor act, but can defend.
8	Paralyzed: They cannot move, act, or defend.

3 TC

- Perform a Combat Maneuver: Inflict Unbalance (oppose with Athletics), Drive Back (oppose with Endurance), Disarm (oppose with the appropriate Melee skill), or Trip (oppose with Athletics). Correct hit locations must be targeted for Disarm and Trip (+2 TC to Choose Location). The spell Effect is not subject to the target's Combat Maneuver talents. Spell Duration must be Instant.

5 TC

A Puppet : Controlling someone's movement like a puppet. This cannot be used to make them harm themselves.

6 TC

A Perform a Vulgar movement Effect : Causes motion that could not occur under natural physical laws, whether of a being, object, or the terrain itself. Includes levitating, flying, gliding without propulsion, moving through solid matter, the smooth vertical ascent of stone, or any other movement that visibly defies gravity or inertia. The spell's Magnitude is usually Vulgar (+10 TC). (At the GM's discretion, brief or minor defiance of gravity--such as a momentary hover or slowed fall--may use a lower Magnitude if it remains within plausible natural limits.) The +6 TC Effect cost is applied in addition to any other spell Effect cost.

Substance

A The Conjure Bind can bring substance into existence. Conjured substances are physical manifestations of Weave-stuff, based on the Strand used, that do not otherwise currently exist in the world (you cannot Conjurea specific already-existing item or substance; this isn't teleportation). Conjured substances vanish into nothingness after the Duration expires.

A Beings, living or otherwise, cannot be Conjured into existence.

A The Strand dictates the nature of the substance, and a caster can only create so much of it.

Conjured Substance TC by trade value

TC	Value
1	Items or goods up to 5 sp in value
2	Items or goods up to 50 sp in value
3	Items or goods up to 100 sp in value
4	Items or goods up to 200 sp in value
5	Items or goods up to 500 sp in value
6	Items or goods up to 1,000 sp in value
7	Items or goods up to 2,000 sp in value
8	Items or goods up to 5,000 sp in value
9	Items or goods up to 10,000 sp in value
10	Items or goods up to 20,000 sp in value

Conjured Substance TC by size or volume

TC	Amount
1	a pocketful
2	sword-sized
3	a backpack's worth
5	a Man-sized amount
7	a Wagon-load full
10	to fill an Inn's common room (ritual only)

Conjured currency or items that vanish cannot be used to permanently settle debts, for obvious reasons.

Summoning

Spells that summon otherworldly beings or departed spirits must use a summoning circle (see Summoning Procedure), and have an Effect cost of 6 TC. The Magnitude for any summoning spell is always Vulgar (+10 TC).

Skill Effects

Spells can raise or lower a creature's skill value, whether through boosting Melee for an attack, Protocol for diplomacy, or Willpower to resist hostile magic. These can represent blessings, curses, heightened reflexes, sharpened awareness, or magical resistance. Choose one skill to magically modify; all targets of the spell are affected in the same way.

TC	Skill Modifier
1	+/- 10
3	+/- 20
5	+/- 30
7	+/- 40
10	+/- 50

- To modify more than one skill on a target, include multiple instances of this Effect in the spell and pay the cost for each, keeping each within the bounds of the Bind and Strand.
- If a target successfully resists the spell, none of the skill effects in that casting apply to them.
- You cannot assign different skills to different targets within the same casting.

Fionnah casts a spell using a 5 TC Skill Effect to add +30 to an ally's Melee: Medium skill.

Later, she casts Control Body on a bandit, paying 2 TC for two separate -10 Effects (Melee: Heavy + Dodge). If the bandit resists, neither applies.

In another fight, she casts Conjure Spirit to create a kind of magical ward on three allies at once, increasing their ability to resist magic. Since all targets are affected in the same way, they each gain +20 to Willpower, at a cost of 3 TC for the +20 Effect plus 6 TC for three targets.

Zone Condition

A Zone Condition spell changes the nature of the zone in some way. Zone Condition spells target the zone directly, not any individuals within it (although individuals may have to separately deal with the repercussions).

- Favored Zone (2 TC): Alter the zone to provide a pool of Favor equal to half the Strand value (rounded up), identical to the Prepare the Battlefield special action. Unused Favor disappears when the Duration expires.
- Hazard--Confined, Obscured, or Rough (3 TC): Individuals in the zone cannot resist these Zone Conditions.
- Barrier (4 TC): A physical or energetic obstacle that provides cover against ranged attacks and may block line of sight at the GM's discretion. The exact form of the barrier (earth wall, thorns, ice sheet, shimmering force, etc.) depends on the Strand used. A Barrier grants cover but does not restrict movement through the zone.
- Hazard--Blocked or Other) (5 TC): An individual can avoid or otherwise resist a Blocked or Other Zone Condition by making an opposed roll against the original Bind roll.
  - » A Blocked zone may also provide cover if the obstruction offers physical shelter (boulders, dense thicket), but not if it merely impedes movement (mud, ice).
  - » If an Other zone hazard reproduces another Spell Effect already detailed elsewhere, use the more expensive of the Effect costs.
- Hazard--Damaging (Variable TC): A damaging hazard creates ongoing damage to any individual in that zone.
  - » Damaging hazards create Damaging zones exactly as described in Combat: Zone Hazards.

- A Damaging Zone Condition that causes external damage (fire, acid, debris) costs 1 TC per damage caused, up to 3x the caster's Strand value.
- A Damaging Zone Condition that causes internal damage (poison, gas, psychic force) costs 1 TC per damage caused, up to 2x the caster's Strand value.
- Individuals in the zone make an opposed DoS roll against the zone's damage to reduce (not against the spell's Bind roll to avoid). The skill roll used to resist is context-dependent.

A If the spell has a Duration of longer than Instant, the caster can exclude individuals in the zone (including the caster) from the spell's hazards for +2 TC per individual.

A A spell can have more than one Zone Condition, but the cost for each must be added to the spell cost.

An earthquake spell (Control Earth) targets a Zone (3 TC) at Short range (2 TC) for 1 minute (3 TC), and creates a Zone Condition: Other Effect (5 TC: anyone starting in or entering the zone must make an Athletics roll or fall Prone). The caster also specifically wants vision in the zone to be blocked by thick dust spewing up from the ground, so she adds the Obscured Zone Condition for another 3 TC.

Spells That Do Anything Else

If the spell cannot be represented by any Effect listed above, use your own judgement and assign an appropriate Effect cost of between 1-10 TC.

An Example of Spellbinding

Fane Rezada the Earthbinder casts a spell targeting a zone with a group of 4 orcs in it. The spell is intended to cause the ground in that zone to transform into sucking mud, actively preventing them from being able to move out of it (a Blocked Hazard Zone effect).

The GM decides this is a Change Earth spell with a Control requisite, so Fane will use the lower of his Change or Control Bind (Change, in his case). It's been raining, so the GM calls it a Discreet Magnitude (+0). Fane is still wearing heavy armor with an Initiative penalty of -5, so he will add 5 to the TC of the spell. The spell looks like this:

Bind & Strand Change Earth, req Control	Range Short (2)
Magnitude Discreet (0)	Duration Concentration (2)
Target 1 zone (3)	Effect Blocked Zone Hazard (5)

Fane's Initiative penalty (5) increases the spell cost to 17 TC.

His Change Bind roll of 37 succeeds with 3 SLs, which will set the resistance to the spell. Now to control the spell: his Bind roll's ones die was 7; his Earth Strand is 5; and he uses 3 from a consumable Earth Thread (see Threads, later in the chapter). This gives him a Mastery of 15, putting him 2 short of the spell's TC of 17. He spends 2 Resolve to make sure he doesn't produce a Weave Reaction.

Anyone trying to enter or leave the zone while Fane is concentrating will have to resist his Bind roll of 37 with an opposed Endurance roll. If they succeed, they can move and take their action as normal; but if they fail, the mud hampers and ends their movement (an orc in the zone could not move out of it, and anyone trying to enter it would be stopped just outside of it).

As an example of a similar spell, let's assume Fane instead used the mud to target all four orcs individually with an Immobilizing Effect. All else being equal, that spell might look like this:

Bind & Strand Change Earth, req Control	Range Short (2)
Magnitude Discreet (0)	Duration Concentration (2)
Target 4 Ind (8)	Effect Immobilizing Movement (4)

Fane's Initiative penalty (5) increases the spell cost to 21 TC.

If he rolled 48, he would succeed. The 8 from the Bind's ones die along with his Earth Strand of 5 and Thread of 3 would leave his Mastery 5 points short of the spell's TC. Let's assume he only spends 2 Resolve, leaving him with a Weave Reaction Modifier of 3; he must now roll 1d20 + 3 on the Weave Reaction Table. He rolls 5, + 3 is 8: he loses 1d4 + 1 steps of Supply.

Each orc would now get an immediate Endurance resistance roll to Fane's successful Bind roll of 48. If they succeeded, they would be unaffected. If they failed, they would be Immobilized in the mud (unable to move but able to act). Since the Duration is less than 1 minute (Fane is Concentrating), at the end of their next turn, they would get another opposed roll against the spell roll's original result of 48.

the weave reaction table

An uncontrolled spell must roll d20 + the Weave Reaction Modifier and consult the Weave Reaction Table.

Some Weave Reactions require the caster to take Fatigue. If his Resolve Track has no more open boxes to mark Fatigue, for every point of Fatigue he cannot take, he instead takes a "Weave" Wound of that value to a random location.

Fane Rezada comes up 6 TC short on a spell. Trying to conserve his resources, he spends only 2 Resolve, making his new Weave Reaction Modifier 4. He rolls 1d20+4 on the Weave Reaction Table and hopes for the best.

Weave Reaction Table

d20 + modifier	Weave Reaction	d20 + modifier	Weave Reaction
<=1	2 pt Thread created	16	Echo: 1d4+1 targets
2	Unexpected Detail	17	1d4+1 point wound
3	1 Fatigue	18	Restrained for 1d4 rounds
4	Cut Off for next round	19	Cut Off until sunrise/set
5	1-point wound	20	1d3 Fraying
6	Echo: 1 unintended target	21	Marked: Minor deformity
7	d6 Thread Die created	22	Reality Snag
8	1d4+1 steps of Supply consumed	23	Cut Off for 1d4 days
9	Cut Off for 1d6 rounds	24	Weave Scar: -1d6+2 to Bind skill, permanently
10	Immobilized for 1d4 rounds	25	Marked: Major deformity
11	Hallucinations	26+	Catastrophic Fray
12	1d4 Fatigue	30+ (Vulgar Only)	Void Incursion
13	Additional spells cost +2d6 TC until sunrise/set	31-35 (Ritual only)	Fraygeist
14	Weave Scar: -20 to Bind skill until sunrise/set	36-40 (Ritual only)	Pattern Collapse
15	Hazard created in zone	41+ (Ritual only)	The Grey Wailing

thread created - A Thread is spontaneously created and appears in the area. It is attuned to the higher value of the Bind or Strand used in the casting roll.

unexpected detail - Some strange minor cosmetic adjustment of the spell's effects, that does not negate the intent of the spell. It leaves a strange smell behind, changes a color, everyone in the vicinity gets a strange taste in their mouth, makes a strange noise, etc.

supply dice consumed - One or more of the caster's Supply dice are consumed by the Weave and reduced by 1 die type, distributed amongst them. Suffer 1 Fatigue for each step of die type unable to be reduced.

cut off - The Spellweaver is cut off from the Tapestry and can't cast another spell for the listed Duration. Ongoing spells continue; Concentration is allowed.

hallucinations - The Weave produces strange visions which distract the caster, preventing them from taking any actions until they use an action to make a successful Willpowerroll against 3 or the spell's Bind roll (whichever is higher).

fatigued - The spell tires the caster. If the new Fatigue is unable to be marked, a Weary wound is caused (see Chapter 11- Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Fatigue-based Wounds).

echo - The spell affects an additional unintended target in a manner that, if possible, is contrary to the caster's intentions and beyond his control; or its effects occur elsewhere within Range. Unintended targets get opposed rolls as per the intended effect, if appropriate. Echo does not nullify the caster's intentions, only complicates them; however, if there are no other suitable targets, an Echo will affect the caster himself if the effect is to his detriment.

wound - Caster suffers a separate Wound to a random location. Armor Points do not protect.

immobilized/restrained - The energies from the Bind and Strand lock the caster in place, unable to do anything other than defend for the listed time. The caster can use their action to make a new opposed Willpowerroll against 3 or the spell's Bind roll (whichever is higher) every round to break free.

hazard created in zone - The details will reflect the Bind and Strand used. Any resistance is an opposed roll vs 3 or the spell's Bind roll, whichever is higher. Hazards affect anyone in the zone, including the caster, and last for an hour. Roll 1d6 for type:

d6	Hazard Type
1-2	Obscured (frenetic shadows)
3-4	Rough (based on the Strand)
5	Blocked (based on the Strand)
6	Damaging (Strand value in damage)

marked - Caster is permanently marked by the Weave with a minor or major deformity to a random detailed hit location. This may have social ramifications, and major deformities can affect appropriate skills by -20. These should be different from blood magic marks (see Rituals: Blood Magic, below).

weave scar - The Tapestry reweaves your own Pattern within it; reduce the Bind skill value used in the casting by the listed amount.

fraying - Add Fraying points as indicated.

reality snag - The Weave twists its energy around the caster and refuses to release. Until the next sunrise or sunset:

- The caster's spells suffer +5 to future Weave Reaction rolls. This can still be reduced through normal mitigation.
- Each time the caster attempts another spell before the effect ends, reality buckles around them. Roll 1d6:

d6	Effect
1-3	Spatial distortion: Objects and space twist near the caster; all ranged attacks into or out of the zone the caster is in are at -20 for one minute.
4-5	Backlash strain: The Weave tugs at the caster's body; they suffer 1 Fatigue.
6	Severe backlash: The caster suffers 1d4 Fatigue and must roll Willpower vs 3 or become Cut Off for 1d6 rounds.

catastrophic fray - Gain +1 Fraying per point over 25, and a spontaneous magical anomaly manifests (GM choice: storm, rift, bleeding light, mass hallucination, etc.).

void incursion (Vulgar spells only; otherwise treat as Catastrophic Fray) - A breach in reality tears open, and a Void Demon emerges in or near the caster's zone (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary: Void Demon). On its turn, it will immediately try to possess the closest living humanoid, forcing an opposed Willpower roll against its Willpower of 75 to resist. Each individual may only be targeted once. If no suitable host is available--or if all resist--the demon manifests on its own and attacks instead.

- A Spellweaver may attempt to seal the breach. This attempt can only be made once per caster per incursion, and requires an immediate Bind: Destroy roll opposed by the demon's Willpower of 75.
  - » On a success, the demon is dragged back into the Void, and the caster suffers 1d6 Fraying.
  - On a failure, the demon must be dealt with.
  - Ritual version: If the spell was a Ritual, the demon is Greater-tier. Good luck.

fraygeist (ritual only) - An exact duplicate of the caster, a Tapestry-born reflection called a Fraygeist, manifests near the casting site within 1d6 days, believing itself to be the true original. It retains the caster's knowledge, power, and skills. It possesses duplicates of all the caster's items, weapons, and Threads, and will seek to hunt down and destroy the original caster.

pattern collapse (ritual only) - The Weave seizes part of the caster's essence. Lose 3d10 points each from 3 random skills. All owned Threads unravel and are consumed. Each participant gains +1d3 Fraying. The caster is scarred; any future spells using the same Bind and Strand combination as the ritual suffer +2 to Weave Reaction rolls.

the grey wailing (ritual only) - The Weave ruptures, birthing a spreading corruption of dust, ash, and wailing sound. Towering black spires tear from the ground, and life within one mile begins to twist and die. The ritual's zone and 1d6 surrounding zones are permanently transformed into a corrupted wasteland; fires die, light dims, and all who linger risk mutation or madness. Only a Destroy Spheres ritual of TC 40+ performed at the heart of the corruption can halt its spread. Left unchecked, it expands by 1d6 feet each dawn.

Catastrophic Frays

A Catastrophic Fray means the caster has torn a hole in the Tapestry wide enough for the world to notice. Use it to make the players feel that reality just broke, without turning it into an instant TPK (Total Party Kill).

Guidelines

- Keep it local and survivable: The event should be contained to a few zones or minutes--large enough to be noticed, small enough to not be annihilated.
- Reflect the Bind and Strand: The anomaly should express the kind of magic that caused it. AFire Strand spell might ignite a sustained heat storm; aThought Strand spell could cause everyone in the area to hear each other's memories.
- Persistent or temporary: The anomaly might fade after hours or days, or linger as a new blight that future travelers can still find.
- Always leaves a scar: Every Catastrophic Fray should change something permanently or leave evidence of its presence--scorched terrain, spots of inverted gravity, haunted echoes of That Which Comes From The Other Side, dead zones in the Weave where magic just doesn't work.

Example Manifestations

Bind/Strand	Manifestation
Conjure Fire	A sheet of white flame sweeps outward for 1d10 zones, turning sand to glass.
Control Spirit	Bound souls tear free; for 1 hour, the dead whisper from every reflective surface.
Change Spheres	A small rift to another plane opens; gravity and light distort until sealed.
Witness Thought	Everyone within sight experiences shared hallucinations of alternate presents.
Change Body	Living tissue nearby mutates unpredictably, gaining new limbs or fusing together.

threads

Magic users often carry physically manifested Threads of the Weave. These items help control a spell by contributing to the caster's Mastery. Threads are vital for more demanding magic that would otherwise drain Resolve, and are some of the most valuable items a spell caster can possess.

Threads are physicalized, raw magic that are attuned to specific Binds and Strands. They can only be used in casting magic that utilizes the Bind or Strand associated with them. A Control Thread can only be used in spells that use the Control Bind; a Spirit Thread can only be used with a spell using the Spirit Strand.

Threads are pieces of the Weave given form. They can look like anything imaginable, but their physical form will be somehow related to the Bind or Strand they are a product of.

> A thread of the Destroy Bind might be a sharp dagger; a Beast thread might be an animal feather or a tooth. Perhaps a Conjure thread might take the form of a piece of chalk for the drawing of magic circles; a thread of the Body Strand might be an undecaying human eyeball.

There are two categories of Threads applicable to Weave magic: consumable Threads and those that use a Thread Die.

A consumable Thread allows a preset pool of Mastery to be used in whatever amount or combination the caster decides before the item is gone. A consumable Thread might be a wolf's tooth that contributes a total of 5 points of Mastery to any combination of Beast Strand magic; this Mastery pool can be divided up among casting rolls however the user wants before the Thread is rendered forever inert. You might find a tree branch from an enchanted wood that gives up to 4 Mastery for spells using the Plant Strand, or a magic-infused piece of flint that gives up to 3 Mastery for Fire Strand spells before it is consumed.

A Thread with more versatility utilizes a Thread Die. They provide bonus Mastery to spells using a specific Bind or Strand, and they come in die types (d6-d12). When using the Thread Die, roll it after a successful Bind roll, and gain whatever amount you roll as Mastery. If you roll a 1 or a 2, take that number as bonus Mastery, but reduce the Thread Die to the next lower die type. If a d6 Thread rolls a 1 or a 2, it is fully expended and crumbles to dust.

The properties of a Thread can be recognized and identified with an Arcana roll.

You must be in physical contact with a Thread of any variety in order to be able to access its powers. Threads are typically considered Tiny for ENC purposes.

You may use up to one Bind Thread and one Strand Thread in a single casting. Additional Threads of the same type never stack--choose which one applies.

Threads are used only after a successful Bind roll (never on a failure).

Threads come in a wide variety, limited only by your imagination: a magical Thread Die shackle that provides d8 Mastery for all castings involving the Control Bind; powdered Crimson Lotus flower ingested as a drug, each dose granting a consumable +3 Mastery to Witness bindings; a golden ring serving as a d10 Body Thread Die that works by applying a drop of the target's blood to a groove in the ring; a crystal ball that adds a d6 Thread Die to Spheres-based scrying spells; a doll of a specific target (created with a Craft: Artistic roll) that acts as a d12 Witness Thread Die for spells relating to that target.

Location-based Threads

Threads are often found as part of a location. These kinds of Threads tend to be more powerful than the more portable variety. Location-based Threads often give a set number of Mastery points to spells using the Binds or Strands attuned to them, and can be called upon an unlimited number of times per day. You might find a magical pool at the base of an ancient tower that gives 3 bonus Mastery to all Plant and Beast magic, for example. Such sites are of inestimable value to Spellweavers, who often build towers or fortresses (or even dungeons...) around them to keep them secret.

Other Magic Items

Remember the Law of Mystery: not all can be explained. Not all magic items in the world operate by these rules. They are magic after all, and just because someone is a practitioner of magic does not mean they know all the secrets of the magical world. Some magic items and threads follow their own rules, with no explanation.

For example, in Season 4 of "Me, Myself and Die!", the Spirit Mantle that Veil carried granted 1d6 bonus Mastery per day to all Spirit magic (it was neither a consumable nor a Thread Die), and it also had the very specific purpose of binding the lich Mot Zaroth back into slumber. How did that work according to these magic rules? It didn't, that's how. It was a magical item made for a specific purpose and required no further explanation past "the mystery of the Weave at work". This allows the GM to introduce all manner of magic items or unique artifacts without having to provide an explanation for their existence, powers, or rules for replicating them. (See also Enchantments, in this chapter).

fraying

Having the power to manipulate reality as you see fit exacts a steep and inevitable price. A magic-user's days in the Broken Empires are numbered: eventually, the strains on the Tapestry from your magical meddling will cause the very thread of your essence that ties you to the Pattern to come undone--to Fray.

Fraying is an accumulation of points that, over the Spellweaver's career, eventually causes the Weave to forcibly expel the caster out of the Pattern. It's a kind of magical forced retirement, whereby you lose the very fabric of your own individual identity by being rewoven out of the Tapestry of the universe.

It's Magical Endgame; a thing to be avoided. There is no way to hide from the Fraying; once the Weave has noticed you, it will inevitably turn reality against you and claim you. No matter the particular form of the Spellweaver's decline, the results are always the same: the caster is removed from the physical universe and never seen again.

Rituals often bring Fraying. It can also occur as a Weave Reaction. Those with a Faded Pattern accumulate Fraying at an even faster rate: every time they roll a critical failure on a casting roll, they accumulate 1 Fraying point, in addition to the other effects of the critical fail.

Anytime a Spellweaver gains a point of Fraying, if their new total Fraying points is more than their Max Resolve, they must immediately make a Fraying Roll:

A Roll 1d100. If the result is less than or equal to (Total Fraying - Max Resolve) × 2, the Spellweaver is forcibly purged from the Tapestry of reality.

Fionnah has a Max Resolve of 23. She gains a new Fraying point, putting her at 24 Fraying. Because her Fraying has just crossed her limit, she is now within Fraying Roll territory. The difference is 1 (24 - 23 = 1). Multiplying that by 2 gives only a 2% chance of being purged from reality. The risk is small, but it has begun.

Later in her career, Fionnah's Max Resolve remains at 23, but she has accumulated 30 Fraying points. Because this is well above her limit, every new gain requires a Fraying Roll. When she rolls poorly on the Weave Reaction Table and accumulates an additional 6 Fraying, her total rises to 36.

The difference between her new Fraying point total and Max Resolve is 13 (36 - 23 = 13). Multiply that by 2, giving a 26% chance of being purged from reality. Fionnah rolls 1d100: on 26 or lower, she is erased from the Pattern; otherwise, she survives--for now.

Optionally, the Fraying total is kept hidden, but it is generally better to let the player know what their character's running total is. Losing a character all of a sudden to Fraying shouldn't ever come as a complete surprise. The required roll of the dice will create enough tension as it is without also being in the dark about your chances.

There is no way of reducing Fraying points, although many Spellweavers have dedicated their lives to finding a reprieve from their inevitable fate. None have thus far been successful. Rumors persist that the condition of lichdom--wherein a spellweaver escapes death by becoming an undead being--is the result of the caster making a final bargain with the Weave itself to avoid Fraying, trading one doom for another. This theory has never been proven.

Such fates are beyond the desires of most sane Spellweavers. Those who carefully husband their power and keep their spells as subtle as possible can outlast the Weave's call. Consequently, the eldest of mages have learned to never call upon powerful magic unless absolutely necessary.

Fraying Symptoms

A Spellweaver's Fraying point total marks how much the Weave has begun to reject them. The more Fraying a spellweaver accumulates, the more reality starts to shift around them in unsettling ways.

The Fraying Symptoms presented below are examples of narrative flair to be imposed by the GM at opportune moments, or roleplayed by the Spellweaver player themselves; in fact, Fraying can be used as a Personality Trait (see below).

Each set of symptoms is tied to your Max Resolve, as indicated. When your Fraying first reaches or exceeds the threshold, one or more of those symptoms begin and remain permanently, even if your Max Resolve later increases.

10 Fraying points (regardless of Max Resolve)
Subtle, deniable disturbances that might be passed off as fatigue or coincidence.

- A Your shadow lags behind or tilts slightly wrong.
- A Strangers forget your name moments after hearing it.
- A Your reflections ripple or appear subtly distorted.
- A Your footprints fade away almost as soon as they're made.

Fraying points >= Max Resolve -5
The wrongness can no longer be ignored by those nearby.

- A Animals shy away, bark, or bolt from your presence.
- A Written words about you blur or fade from pages.
- A Colors look washed out when you enter a space.
- A Companions swear you weren't there until you spoke.

Fraying points >= Max Resolve
Reality struggles to hold you in place; the unraveling is undeniable.

- A Doubles of you are glimpsed in the corner of the eye.
- A Dreams depict you as faceless or as a stranger.
- A Patterns misalign: bricks, tiles, rugs subtly warp around you.
- A Objects near you refuse to line up -- shelves sag slightly, stacked items tilt the wrong way, dice refuse to land square, ink lines on a page refuse to stay straight.

Fraying >= Max Resolve +5
The Weave is actively tugging your thread loose.

- A Your eyes look hollow or distant.
- A Whole conversations with you vanish from memory after they end.
- A Places you linger warp: candles drip upward, mirrors crack, walls bend, plants wither.
- A You feel a constant physical snag in your chest, like a thread being pulled away.

Fraying as a Personality Trait

Once a Spellweaver accumulates 10+ Fraying points and begins to show the first symptoms, they may choose to take the "Frayed" Personality Trait.

This acts in every way as a regular Personality Trait: the caster can advocate for a +20 bonus to a roll, or gain XP from it if it causes complications in a session. However, it also assumes the player is roleplaying the kinds of narrative effects described in the Fraying Symptoms section.

Once chosen, this Trait may not be removed. The Weave does not forget, and the scars of Fraying remain.

The Final Act

When a Spellweaver is finally claimed by Fraying, the Weave does not erase them instantly. Instead, they are given a single, unavoidable moment of final power: their Final Act .

When a Spellweaver is about to be purged from the Tapestry, they may immediately attempt one last working of magic before they unravel. This act of magic is always successful: even if the Spellweaver is bound, silenced, or unconscious, the Weave itself forces the act through them. The scope of the magic may exceed what the Spellweaver would normally dare to attempt, and is almost always of Vulgar Magnitude.

A The player describes what they intend their Final Act to be based on one of their possible Bind and Strand combinations.

A The GM adjudicates how reality resists or reshapes that attempt, as with any other spell, but should err on the side of making the moment legendary. This should feel like a culmination of the Spellweaver's career: either an ultimate triumph, a devastating failure, or a tragic mix of both.

A For the purposes of resistance, assume the caster rolled their skill exactly, resulting in a critical success. Even if the target of a Final Act spell resists, the Act should leave a scar on the world (for example, an eternal echo of the Spellweaver's voice in the area, a storm that rages for a decade, the withering of all plant life in a one-mile ring around the spell effect, or a lingering curse on local inhabitants).

A Regardless of outcome--whether the magic reshapes the battlefield, saves the party, or consumes everything around them -- once the Act is resolved, the Spellweaver is immediately unmade, vanishing from the Tapestry.

A The GM is encouraged to let the Weave itself "decide" the exact effect. Sometimes the Weave twists the caster's intent, sometimes it fulfills it perfectly--but it always leaves behind a mark that endures, ensuring the Spellweaver's end is remembered.

advanced magic

Tears in the Tapestry

Ongoing magical effects are like rippling tears in the Tapestry. These ripples are a Spellweaver's signature, and each caster's magic leaves a unique fingerprint behind. Such fingerprints are impossible for a caster to mask or change.

Any Spellweaver with line of sight to a spell or spell effect can use mystical clues from a successful Arcana roll (this is a free action, but not automatic; the player must specify they're doing this) to see and recognize not only the spell's Bind and Strand, but also the signature and identity of the Spellweaver who cast it. If the observing Spellweaver does not know the caster in person, they will recognize any future magic that the caster performs. The mystical clues from the Arcana roll can be visual, auditory, olfactory, or even tactile. If 3+ SLs are generated by the Arcana roll, the Spellweaver also learns all the details of the spell (Range, Duration, etc.).

Fades cannot recognize magic this way, but a simple Witness Sphere spell will also reveal all the information above (with a Subtle Magnitude, Individual Target, Variable Range, Instant Duration, and Sense Effect 3).

Counterspells

A Spellweaver can cast a counterspell to cancel an incoming opposing spell. This is a special kind of magical invocation that functions as an opposed Bind skill roll, and must be done by taking the Hold to Interrupt action.

The Bind skill used to counter must be either Destroy, or the Bind of the opposing spell. As in Tears in the Tapestry above, a free Arcana roll can determine the Bind and Strand of the incoming spell. The counterspell's caster must be aware of the incoming spell.

Countering a spell is an opposed roll. Compare the incoming spell's Bind roll to the countering Bind roll, as normal.

If the countering Bind skill wins, the incoming spell is countered and has no effect. The incoming spell's caster spends a single Resolve as if the spell failed, and there is no Weave Reaction.

If the countering Spellweaver loses, the incoming spell resolves normally. There is no partial success or reduction of effect--countering a spell is all-or-nothing.

You may counter any spell declared within your line of sight while you are Holding to Interrupt; if its casting time is an action, you may interrupt it at the moment it is declared.

Resolve Cost of Counterspells

Attempting a counterspell costs Resolve equal to the original caster's SLs, reduced by the countering Spellweaver's Strand value in the countered spell.

This Resolve cost is based solely on the original spell's Bind roll and is not affected by the DoS of the countering Spellweaver's roll.

Countering Resolve cost = original caster's SLs - countering caster's Strand value in the countered spell.

If the original caster generates 7 SLs casting Conjure Fire, a Spellweaver with Fire 3 would spend 4 Resolve to counter it. If the countering Spellweaver had no score in Fire, it would cost the full 7 Resolve.

The Resolve must be expended whether the counterspell succeeds or fails. A countering Spellweaver who succeeds but cannot afford the full Resolve cost marks all remaining Resolve, but the counterspell fails.

Critically failing a counterspell causes the countering Spellweaver to suffer a Weave Reaction (roll 1d20), in addition to losing the Resolve.

Dispelling Ongoing Magic

A Spellweaver who detects a tear in the tapestry (an ongoing spell effect) can use the same process to attempt to restore the Weave's integrity by dispelling the ongoing spell. An opposed magic skill roll is made versus the original spell as described above. If the dispelling spell wins, the ongoing effect is neutralized. If the original spell's Bind roll is not known, set an appropriate fixed number instead.

The time required to dispel an ongoing magical effect is the same as the time taken by the originator to cast it, or half that time if the dispelling roll is made at -30.

Success means the original spell's effects end immediately. A failure means the Spellweaver may not make further dispel attempts against that spell effect until they increase their Bind skill, or some other GM-approved circumstance is sufficient to warrant a new attempt.

Anchoring a Spell

A Spellweaver who wants to protect their spell from dispelling attempts after it has been successfully cast may anchor it in the Weave by choosing to take one Fraying point upon casting. An anchored spell is no longer visible as a tear in the tapestry and cannot be dispelled. Anchoring does not protect a spell from being countered during its initial casting; it only prevents dispelling attempts after the spell has successfully taken effect.

Any spell that already had Fraying points accrued from shaping the spell's elements (Duration, Range, etc.) may anchor the spell by taking an additional Fraying point. Fraying points gained from Weave Reactions do not count towards anchoring.

True Names

Nature and Bearers

Having a radiant pattern in the Weave of reality singles one out for special attention by the Tapestry. Anyone with the Patterned in the Weave or Faded Pattern Talent has been thusly marked, and is imprinted with a True Name.

True Names are the ultimate connection to the Weave, and can be used as an Arcane Tether (see Range) to magically target any being who possesses one. Such beings include all Spellweavers and Fades, and also certain powerful other-worldly individuals not native to the Broken Empires, be they demon, angel, or other extra-dimensional trespasser. As their True Name can be used against them, those possessing one guard it jealously. It is an act of the utmost trust and vulnerability to volunteer one's True Name to another.

Ordinary mortals do not have True Names, and thus cannot be magically targeted through them.

> No being keeps their own True Name on their surface thoughts. Trying to read their mind with Witness Thought to discover their True Name is a Vulgar magnitude spell, and is considered an act of war among practitioners of magic.

Language and Invocation

A Spellweaver's True Name is given at birth, and must be in the language of their race or culture. To use a being's True Name, it must be spoken aloud in the language of that name (in Dondalese for a Tical Dondallan sorcerer, in Demonic for a hellish entity, etc.)--requiring a successful Languageroll--or else the spell using it will automatically fail.

On a critically failed Language roll, the caster also suffers an immediate Weave Reaction (roll 1d20 +10).

Speaking a True Name always alerts the target that it was invoked; they may not know where or why, but they feel the tug.

Magical Use and Risks

Using a being's True Name allows the spell to target that being with a Range of Arcane Tether.
As a True Name is not a physical Arcane Tether, it is not consumed with the casting, and knowing another's True Name does not count towards the caster's Arcane Tether limit.

However, each time you invoke a True Name in a spell, roll 1d10; on a 1, gain 1 Fraying.

If used as part of a summoning spell, a True Name imposes a -20 penalty on the target's Willpower roll to resist the summoning, and on any attempts to break free from the circle (see Summoning). True Names must be used when summoning powerful extra-dimensional beings.

Triggered Spells

Any spell may be cast with a trigger, delaying its effect until a specific, caster-defined condition is met. The trigger must be very specific and clearly observable (e.g., "when a creature steps within 10 feet" or "when the door is opened").

When casting a triggered spell:

- Choose a creature, object, or location to act as the origin. This is where the spell will come from when it goes off, and is used to determine its range-to-target.
- You can choose the spell's target as the origin if you wish.
- You must be within Short range of the origin when casting the spell. Even if the spell has a Range of Arcane Tether, the caster must still be within Short range of the origin at the time of casting.

For triggered spells, Range refers to the distance between the spell's origin and the eventual target when the trigger activates. The caster only needs to be within Short range of the origin when first casting the spell. You do not calculate or pay Range for the distance between the caster and the origin.

- Define the criteria that will trigger the spell.
- Assign an additional cost-- a trigger duration --using the normal Duration Shaping Cost Table. This represents how long the trigger remains active before fading. A trigger can have a Duration of up to a month without needing to cast it as a ritual (see Rituals). A permanent trigger lasts until the spell activates.
- Make the casting roll to determine Resolve spent, the Bind result, and any immediate Weave Reactions suffered, but the final effect of the spell is not applied until the trigger criteria is met.

A being, object, or zone can be the origin of only one triggered spell at a time. If another triggered spell is placed on it, by any caster, it replaces the first.

A Spellweaver or Fade can only detect a triggered spell with a Witness Spheres spell:

Bind & Strand Witness Spheres	**Range** Variable
Magnitude Subtle (2)	**Duration** Instant (0)
Target Ind (2) or Zone (3)	**Effect** Sense (3)

This spell also reveals the triggered spell's details, including the triggered spell caster's signature and identity (See Tears in the Tapestry).

You want to create an electricity ward on a door that lasts for the next two weeks, and will damage the next person who comes within Close range of it. That spell might look like this:

Lightning Ward
TC 17

Triggered. When any bipedal living being comes within Close range of the origin (the door), a blast of electricity damages them. Dodge opposes.

Bind & Strand Conjure Air	Range Close (2)
Magnitude Offensive (5)	Duration Instant (0); Trigger: Fortnight (7)
Target Ind (2)	Effect AirStrand in damage (1)

The origin of the ward is the door, but the Target is whomever comes within Close range of it.

Or, let's say you want to create a contingency that, for the next year, magically teleports you away as soon as you take a wound of 3 points or more. This would have to be cast as a ritual:

Expeditious Withdrawal (R)
TC 31

Triggered. When the caster takes a wound of 5 points or more, they are immediately teleported to a predetermined place to which they have an Arcane Tether.

Bind & Strand Control Spheres	Range Arc (6)
Magnitude Vulgar (10)	Duration Instant (0); Trigger: Year (9), +1d4 Fraying
Target Self (0)	Effect Vulgar Movement (6)

In this case, the caster is both the origin and the Target (Self).

Magic Circles

Spell costs can be lessened by casting them in permanent magical circles inscribed with expensive materials. These are always stationary, and usually located in a Spellweaver's domicile, where castings can be protected from outside interruption. Fades cannot use magic circles.

Select a zone. Inscribing a magic circle costs 1,000 sp in materials, and takes a full 8 hours. There can only be one magic circle inscribed in a zone. Once inscribed, the Spellweaver must make an Arcana roll. Every 2 SLs on the Arcana roll will allow the circle to reduce the cost of any spell or ritual cast entirely within its bounds by 1 TC. Resolve may not be used on the Arcana roll.

Every additional 500 sp worth of materials consumed while inscribing the circle adds +10 to the Arcana roll, up to +30 for 1500 sp. The materials are used up regardless of the success of the Arcana roll.

A circle lasts indefinitely unless physically defaced, magically dispelled, or the structure containing it is destroyed. Once completed, it is only as effective as your Arcana roll's results. If you are unsatisfied with it and wish to try again, you must create a different circle from scratch in a different zone.

These are different circles than Summoning Circles and are created separately; their powers and benefits cannot overlap (see Summoning).

chapter 14: weave magic

rituals

Rituals are powerful magics that take hours or even days to perform. It is widely believed that uncontrolled ritual magic caused the Grey Wailing, and consequently the fall of the Vestrian Empire. It is for this reason that ritual magic is, in many areas, considered too dangerous to tolerate.

Ritual-only spells are indicated on the Shaping Cost Tables . Both Spellweavers and Fades can cast ritual spells.

- A Determine the Magnitude and TC of the ritual just as you would a normal spell.
- A The Range of any ritual must be Arcane Tether. Any physical Tether must be present in order to cast the ritual, and is consumed in a successful casting.
- A All ritual castings automatically suffer +5 to any Weave Reaction roll, should one be required.
- A Critically failing a ritual causes a Fraying point in addition to other costs.
- A Rituals, like other spells, require Mastery to prevent Weave Reactions.

Ritual Cost

There are various ways to help lessen or reduce the possibility of a Weave Reaction in a ritual: procuring valuable components, getting assistance from other casters who have knowledge of the Strand used, using Blood Magic, or consulting Grimoires.

Procuring Components

Rituals benefit from components specific to that ritual. Having the right components can provide between 1-8 Mastery toward the ritual's cost (GM's discretion). In the Forever Sleep ritual, for example, having a feather from every pillow in the building will gain 5 Mastery (see Ritual Examples later in this chapter). A GM should feel free to get creative with ritual components; procuring them can be the focus of whole separate adventures. Otherwise, assume the ritual will require components worth 100 sp × the ritual's Total Cost.

Assistance from Others

Multiple casters can pool their power to pay for a ritual. This requires every additional participant to have some score in the Strand used in the casting. Every such participant can add half their Strand value (rounded up) as Mastery toward the ritual.

The maximum number of additional participants is equal to half the original caster's value (rounded up) of the Strand used in the ritual.

All participants may benefit from the ritual's effects if it makes sense within the context, but all will suffer any negative Weave Reactions, Fraying points, or other consequences.

Blood Magic

Rituals can be assisted with forbidden Blood Magic practices.

Over the course of the ritual's casting, for every lethal Wound Point inflicted on a thinking, reasoning being (the "victim"), the caster gains 1 Mastery, up to a maximum of 20. The caster can take the role of victim, and wound himself if desired.

Further, if the victim is killed immediately prior to the ritual's completion, the casting roll is made with a +20.

However, the Weave abhors blood magic, and will possibly mark its users, including the caster and all assistants. For each Wound Point inflicted upon the sacrificial victim, there is a 5% chance the caster and all assistants become marked in an appropriate hit location with a signifier that the user is a blood magician. If the victim is killed, that chance rises to 100%. Such marks could be (d10):

d10	Mark
1	A patch of skin permanently blackened, as if charred
2	Veins that show through the skin in dark crimson or black
3	Eyes that glint faintly red in firelight
4	A faint sigil burned into the palm or forehead
5	Skin that appears stained with blood in streaks or blotches
6	Fingernails turned permanently black
7	A brandlike scar in the shape of twisting lines or runes
8	The mouth bleeds slightly when speaking the truth
9	An aura of faint cold
10	Teeth or tongue faintly discolored as if with dried blood

Blood Magic is outlawed in civilized lands, and those who are known to utilize it are hunted as witches.

Grimoires

Grimoires are ancient tomes filled with esoteric knowledge. They act as Threads for use in ritual castings only, using their own unique rules.

Each grimoire contains knowledge on up to 3 Binds or Strands, and may be used only for rituals using the Binds or Strands the book is associated with: a grimoire on Control, Body, and Spirit can only be used in rituals using one or more of those magic skills, for example.

A grimoire has a Thread value of d4 to d12, and may be used once per ritual. At the end of the ritual casting, roll the grimoire's Thread Die and gain that amount of Mastery. If you roll the maximum amount on the die, benefit from that amount of Mastery, but the grimoire is consumed by the ritual and destroyed. A grimoire can be combined with other Threads appropriate to the ritual. Grimoires that are associated with more than one applicable Bind or Strand may provide separate Thread Die rolls for each.

Casting a Control Earth ritual using a d8 grimoire that deals in both Control and Earth magic allows you to roll two separate d8 rolls for bonus Mastery. If either Thread Die roll comes up 8, you will gain 8 Mastery, but the grimoire will crumble into dust or be otherwise consumed.

Casting Time and Concentration

A ritual requires one hour of casting time per TC (but it can be rushed --see below).

Rituals demand unbroken concentration. The principal caster and all assistants take 1 Fatigue for every eight hours (or portion thereof) of casting time. In addition, the principal caster must make a standard Willpower roll every eight hours (or portion thereof) to maintain focus.

- A Success: The ritual continues normally.
- A Failure: Any Weave Reaction roll made at the ritual's completion is at an additional +3. This modifier stacks with each failed concentration roll.
- A Critical Failure: Concentration collapses entirely--the ritual fails, all components are consumed, and the process must begin anew.

The Ritual Casting Roll

The caster cannot spend Resolve on the Ritual casting roll, either to increase the Bind skill, or to mitigate the Weave after the roll. However, rituals still require each participant to have at least one available Resolve.

Any Fraying points during the ritual gained from Target or Duration costs, or from any other source or effect, are inflicted on both the caster and all assistants.

At the end of the casting time, the caster makes the Bind roll for the ritual, and consults the Ritual Casting Results Table .

Ritual Casting Results

Roll	Outcome
Success	The ritual is cast as intended. All participants take 1 Fatigue. The Bind roll's SLs sets the ritual spell's resistance. Add the ones die from the Bind roll, the caster's Strand value, Thread use, and bonuses from components, assistance, grimoires, and/or blood magic (the Mastery). If the Mastery is equal to or greater than the ritual's TC, there is no Weave Reaction.
Success,but Mastery is less than the spell's TC	The ritual is cast, but not fully controlled: roll on the Weave Reaction Table with a modifier equal to the difference between the Mastery and the TC, plus any accumulated modifiers from failed concentration rolls, and +5 for the ritual itself. All participants take 3 Fatigue and are each affected by the Weave Reaction, ignoring any beneficial results.
Critical Success	The ritual is cast as intended and there is no Weave Reaction roll.
Failure	The ritual fails. All participants take 3 Fatigue. Components can be reused.
Critical Failure	The ritual fails. All participants take 6 Fatigue and 1 Fraying. All components are used up. Roll immediately on the Weave Reaction Table with the ritual's TC as a modifier, ignoring any beneficial results.

Rushing the Ritual

If the caster wants to cut the spell's casting time in half (hours equal to half the final TC, rounded up), any Weave Reaction roll will be made at +10. This does not reduce the Total Cost itself.

Resisting a Ritual

Resisting a ritual's effects is exactly the same as resisting a regular spell: all targets make an opposed roll against the ritual's Bind roll to neutralize the spell effect.

Rituals for Non-Casters: Pacts

There are ways to perform a ritual even without any skill in magic: a petitioner can make a Pact with a Pact Patron, an extra-planar force such as a demon or spirit, to benefit from a magical ritual's effect for a Price.

A Pact's Price can range from a temporary penalty to skills, to the unnatural maiming of one of the petitioner's limbs; from the sacrifice of a valuable item, to the seizing of a piece of the petitioner's soul by the Patron. While these outcomes may seem extreme, desperate times may call for desperate measures...

Not every Patron demands such costly Prices, however. A good rule of thumb is, the less intrusive or damaging a ritual, and the more lenient the Patron, the gentler the Price paid. A ritual that creates a protective amulet granting 6 armor points whose power lasts a year shouldn't cost the petitioner's soul when the timer runs out; perhaps the Price here is that for a month the petitioner himself becomes vulnerable to weapons (takes 3 extra damage from each hit or something like that).

Pacts often have the "monkey's paw" effect: the Price is somewhat ironic and connected to the ritual's effect, perhaps in an inversely proportional way, as in the example above.

Prices each have a d10 Timer Die associated with them, with roll intervals ranging from one day to one year. At the completion of the ritual, the petitioner sets the Price total at 1 and must start tracking intervals. At the end of each interval, the petitioner rolls the Timer Die. If the result is the current Price total or less, the Price is immediately paid. If not, the petitioner adds 1 to the Price total.

> In a desperate situation, Edbert cries out to the goddess Devona for help. Amazingly, she answers and provides a miracle--but at the cost of a portion of his memories, which she covets as nourishment. The roll interval is one month, and after Devona has performed the miracle, the Price total is set to 1. In exactly one month, Edbert must roll a d10: if he gets a 1, he'll immediately pay the price and abandon his memories to Devona. If he rolls a 2-0, there is no effect... but the Price total is set to 2. In another month, if Edbert rolls 1-2, he pays the price; otherwise the new Price is set to 3, and so on.

It is up to the petitioner's player to record the details of each Price they have waiting to be paid. Multiple Prices from multiple pacts track separately.

Example Ritual Prices

- 5 A piece of the petitioner's lifespan, or reduction of Toughness/Death Threshold/ location Lethality Level.
- 5 Loss of a cherished memory.
- 5 The petitioner or someone they care for suffers a wound or infection.
- 5 The petitioner's voice becomes increasingly muffled or distant, imposing Social skill penalties.
- 5 Reduction of a petitioner's skill value by 5d6.
- 5 A requirement to revisit a specific location every week/month/year and perform a costly sacrifice.
- 5 Loss of Status due to moral or spiritual corruption.

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5 Someone the petitioner loves spurns and abandons him.

5 Gradual loss of distinction between dreams and reality.

5 A new, horrific scar appears in a prominent place on the petitioner's body.

5 A relentless hunger that no food or drink can satisfy.

5 The petitioner's reflection disappears, leaving her unable to see herself ever again.

5 At inopportune moments, the petitioner speaks the words and thoughts of the patron instead of his own.

5 One of the petitioner's loved ones becomes possessed by an agent of the patron, causing them to commit acts favorable to the patron.

5 One of the petitioner's arm locations slowly starts to turn into a translucent tentacle, scaled claw, or other such mutation.

5 The petitioner feels the suffering of others in her proximity as if it were her own.

5 The petitioner feels invisible eyes watching him constantly, trapping him in a perpetual state of paranoia.

Casting the Pact Ritual

Neither petitioner nor Patron has to roll for the pact ritual--just assume the ritual's effects take effect as agreed upon.

Finding a Patron

Finding a Patron could be the stuff of whole adventures unto itself. The means of contacting Patron demons can be discovered in infernal scrolls; ancient arcane rituals can be unearthed in forgotten libraries; the intercession of ancient gods can be invoked by adherents; the esoteric favors of the Dark Fae can be bargained for at lonely crossroads or in shadowed forests. The possibilities are endless.

Summoning

Unbeknownst to the wider world, the Broken Empires is but one of many unique realms of existence, each more unfathomable than the last. Some Spellweavers have harnessed the power to plunge a hand into those alien realms and draw forth bizarre and sometimes demonic creatures to command or interrogate.

Summoning magic allows a spellweaver to bring a being from one of the other myriad planes of existence into our world, using Conjure Spheres. Native beings of the Broken Empires cannot be summoned this way, except for the spirits of the dead; since death removes the substance of the departed from the realm of the Broken Empires, those spirits who were once native to this plane can be summoned with the Spirit Strand instead.

The summoned being appears within a prepared magic circle (see below). As long as the summoned being stays in the circle, as an action the caster has the option of sending it back from whence it came. If it breaks free, or if the caster releases it, it stays in the world of the Broken Empires.

Summoning spells always require an Arcane Tether. If bringing forth a being without a True Name, a standard Tether will suffice: the essence of a lesser Void demon, an accurately-carved representation of a known extra-dimensional creature, a mourner's tears from a ghost's funeral, etc. A physical Arcane Tether is consumed in a successful casting.

If summoning a being with a True Name, it must be known, and uttered in the language appropriate to the being. Certain well-guarded eldritch tomes contain the True Names of various extra-planar creatures, and whole expeditions can be embarked upon to procure them.

Though a spellweaver has a True Name, they cannot be Summoned as they are native to the Broken Empires.

There are many other realms of existence, but there is only one universe. Each individual is unique throughout all of reality; there is no "multiverse" in which a person could meet a different version of themselves. The Spheres represent the various dimensions and planes, but no one place is a direct reproduction of another. A given plane might resemble another, at least superficially--but all of its inhabitants would be unique to that realm.

Summoning Procedure

The Magnitude of any summoning spell is always Vulgar (+10 TC).

First, a unique summoning circle is drawn on the ground by the caster (a process that takes an hour and requires 1,000 sp worth of materials; a circle can only be used for one successful casting). Investing 2,000 sp in materials gives a +10 to the Arcana roll (see below); investing 5,000 sp gives a +20.

The Conjure spell is then cast with a Duration of Instant, a Range of Arcane Tether, a Target of Individual, and a Summoning Effect (6 TC). The being to be summoned gets an opposed Willpower roll. Using a creature's True Name, if it has one, imposes a -20 penalty on its Willpowerroll. If it fails, the creature appears within the circle.

Once the summoning succeeds, the quality of the cage is tested. The caster makes an Arcana roll (including any modifiers for higher-quality materials, as described above), and the creature makes a new Willpowerroll to oppose it. The creature suffers a -20 penalty if its True Name was used or inscribed within the circle. If the caster wins, the creature is bound within the circle for a number of days equal to the caster's Arcana Score. If the creature wins, it breaks free and may act as it wishes--typically to flee or attack the summoner.

A bound creature remains trapped in the circle until the caster either banishes it back from whence it came or allows it to leave the circle, the circle decays (see below), or the circle is intentionally broken by a third party. (For this reason, many summoners take the time and effort to scratch the circle into stone instead of using a ring of salt, for example). A contained creature can see and hear its new surroundings, and may communicate freely with anyone outside the circle, but it cannot cross the boundary or exert any physical or magical influence beyond it.

Circle Decay and Renewal

A summoning circle remains stable for a number of days equal to the caster's Arcana Score. After this time, the circle's integrity decays, and the containment fails--the creature is immediately freed and may act as it wishes.

To prevent this, the caster may attempt to renew the circle before it expires. This requires one hour of uninterrupted work and a new Arcana roll (any existing material modifiers still apply). If the roll succeeds, the circle endures for another period equal to the caster's Arcana Score in days. When the renewal is complete, the creature--fully aware of the attempt--rolls Willpower (at -20 if its True Name was used or inscribed) opposed by the caster's new Arcana result. If the creature succeeds, it breaks free; if it fails, the renewed circle holds it once more for the same duration.

Controlling the Summoned Creature

Controlling the creature requires a separate spell or method. If the summoned creature is able to leave the circle without first being controlled, it will either flee by the most direct route or attempt to harm the summoner.

If the caster does gain control of the creature, it may be ordered to leave the circle, perform a task, and return--but the control must endure for the full span of that task. Control gained through a spell ends when its Duration expires, while other methods may have their own limits. If the creature returns to the circle while still under control, it is re-imprisoned there, provided the circle's power remains intact.

A summoned creature that leaves the circle without being under control--whether because it was never bound, the circle decays, or because its control expired before returning--remains in the world of the Broken Empires until it is either destroyed, banished by another force, or able to find its own way back to its home realm.

Enchantments

The art of Enchantment is that of permanently imbuing a mundane item with the ability to reproduce a spell effect. In essence, the object itself becomes the caster of a specific spell every time it is used.

Enchanted items work either with a Die Type, or they have finite charges. The Die Type option represents a permanent enchantment that risks going temporarily inert, while Charged items have a fixed reservoir of guaranteed uses.

Die Type Enchantments - Some enchanted items have a Die Type: every time the item's spell effect is used (as an action), the Die is rolled. If it comes up 1 or 2, the item becomes inert and can't be used again for 1-6 days. Other than that limitation, Die Type enchanted items are effectively permanent magical items, and continue to work until destroyed.

Charged Enchantments - When creating the item, the caster may instead choose a fixed number of charges. Each charge powers one use of the effect; when the final charge is expended, the item becomes non-magical.

Preparing the Item

An item must be made specifically for enchantment: it must be a masterwork item crafted using Craft: Artistic or Craft: Practical. Any magical enchantment will override and remove any other bonuses or qualities the masterwork item may have had from its craftsmanship.

Once the masterwork item is crafted, it must be prepared for enchantment by shaping it to receive magic and attuning it to the caster's Pattern. This preparation requires one full day of work.

Enchantment Costs

Enchanting an item causes the enchanter to accrue Fraying points, based on the chart below:

Enchantment Use Die or Charges	Fraying Cost
Single-use (1 charge)	0
Die type d6 or 3 charges	1
Die type d8 or 10 charges	2
Die type d10 or 15 charges	3
Die type d12 or 30 charges	4
Anyone can use it	+1

By default, only those who can manipulate the Weave (a Spellweaver or Fade) can use the enchanted item. They can recognize and use the item after a successful Arcana roll.

An item can be made usable by anyone, but this costs +1 Fraying point. If the caster wishes this, they must imprint an activation word into the item--either spoken aloud or inscribed upon it and activated by touch (caster's choice). Anyone who speaks the word or touches the inscription may use the item.

No enchanted item may exceed d12 or 30 charges. An item cannot possess both a Use Die and a Charge pool; choose one when it is created.

Imbuing the Spell

Once the item is prepared, the enchanter determines the cost of the spell they intend to embed. The item will replicate that spell exactly as cast--its Duration, Target, Range, and Effect are fixed at the time of creation.

An enchantment spell can never include anything exclusive to rituals, such as ritual-only Durations, Targets, or extended Effects.

Once the spell is successfully cast, the Bind roll becomes the item's fixed value for purposes of resistance. Anyone resisting the item's magic must meet or beat that roll to negate its effect.

When the spell is bound into the item, the item itself becomes the caster. Because of this, any spell with a Range or Target of Self normally affects only the item, not the person holding or wearing it.

A cloak enchanted with Self: Invisibility would make the cloak vanish, while its wearer remains plainly visible. For the cloak to make its wearer invisible, the spell's Target must be Individual.

A sword enchanted with Self: Fire Aura would wreathe the blade in flame, not the wielder's body.

However, if the item's purpose naturally extends its effect to its user, the spell can still benefit them indirectly.

A broom enchanted to fly carries its rider because its movement includes whoever sits upon it.

A lantern enchanted with Self: Light illuminates the area for anyone holding it, since the lantern itself is the source of the glow.

An enchanted item can only reproduce its own stored spells; it cannot be used to counterspell or otherwise react to external magic.

Finalizing the Enchantment

After one full day of preparation, the Spellweaver casts the chosen spell into the item. Resolve and Thread use is allowed as normal.

If the spell succeeds, the item becomes permanently enchanted and the caster accrues the appropriate Fraying points as listed under Enchantment Costs.

Any Weave Reactions occur as normally. If a Weave Reaction occurs during enchantment, regardless of type, the resulting flaw becomes part of the item's Pattern. Such items are considered unstable enchantments (see below).

If the enchanter's spell roll fails, the item is not enchanted and is no longer suitable; a new one must be crafted to try again. If the spell roll critically fails, the item is no longer suitable, and any Fraying is also accrued.

Single-Use Enchantments

An item can be enchanted as a single-use item. If so, it has only one charge, and the base Fraying Point cost is 0.

Once the single-use enchantment is expended, the masterwork item that contained it can never again serve as a vessel for magic. An enchanter who performs a 0-Fraying enchantment must still make a full casting roll and risk Weave Reactions as normal.

Multiple Spells

A caster can imbue as many different spells into an item as desired, but each one incurs its own Fraying cost separately. Failure on any of the enchanting spell rolls renders the item unsuitable for enchantment, and all previous enchantments are removed.

If an item bears multiple enchantments, and one of them is single-use, expending that single-use effect does not destroy the other enchantments unless the single-use effect's description explicitly states that it consumes the item. However, if the item was only intended as a single-use vessel, it becomes inert as normal.

If multiple spells are embedded, record each Bind roll's result as a separate fixed resistance value

Unstable Enchantments

If a Weave Reaction occurs during the casting of a spell intended to enchant an item, the item becomes an unstable enchantment. The effect of that depends on what kind of item was enchanted:

- After an unstable Die Type item is used, roll its usage Die as normal--but it becomes inert on a roll of 1-4 instead of 1-2.
- After an unstable charged item is used, roll a d10. On a result of 1-2, the enchantment burns out, immediately losing 1d4 additional charges. If this reduces the remaining charges to 0, the enchantment collapses and the item becomes non-magical.

A Before an unstable single-use enchanted item is used, roll a d10. On a 1-2, the stored magic unravels harmlessly and the enchantment does not take effect. The item cannot be used again.

Using Weave Reagents

For every point of Fraying the enchantment would normally cost, the caster may instead consume one Weave Reagent of the same Strand. This substitution is declared before rolling the spell, not after.

Weave Reagents are naturally occurring materials similar to Threads that hold a trace of resonance from one of the ten Strands of the Weave. They are used as the active ingredient in alchemy and as a material substitute for Fraying in enchantment.

A reagent can be almost any rare or unusual physical substance: glass dust collected from lightning-struck sand, clay gathered from the base of a hanging man's gallows, chalk from a circle that once held a summoned thing, or dew gathered from spider webs before sunrise. What matters is that the substance still carries the Weave's signature.

Reagents are found only in places where the Weave is active or disturbed. They cannot be found in ordinary farmland, villages, or settled ground.

A reagent may be located by making an Arcana roll when the GM deems the location suitable--typically while traveling through a remote wilderness hex, searching a magical or ruined site, or examining the remains of a magical creature or event. This takes half a day.

Success indicates the discovery of one usable reagent aligned with the dominant Strand of that area or creature (or a random Strand, if the GM is unsure), + 1 additional reagent per 3 SLs.

A reagent can only be used to power effects related to that Strand. Reagents lose their potency after several weeks if not properly stored.

chapter 14: weave magic

Alchemy

Alchemy is a simplified form of enchantment, performed on liquids to create spell effects in potion form. Like enchantment, it binds a spell into a physical vessel so that the substance itself becomes the caster when consumed. Unlike permanent enchantments, however, alchemy always creates single-use effects and does not accumulate Fraying.

Masterwork items are not required to make potions. Obviously, certain spell effects will not make sense as a potion; use your judgement here.

Alchemical potions are distinct from natural healing potions and other non-magical brews (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Natural Healing Potions).

Only spells with a Range and Target of Self can be successfully brewed into potions.

An alchemical potion can never include anything exclusive to rituals, such as ritual-only Durations or extended Effects.

Potion Requirements

The creation process requires a laboratory or suitable workspace. A better lab, detailed formulae, or careful patience provides bonuses; see Alchemical Aids.

Alchemy also requires Weave Reagents (see Enchantments) appropriate to both the potion's Strand and the specific spell's TC:

Potion's Spell TC Range	Reagent Cost (per batch)
1-15 TC	1 reagent
16+ TC	2 reagents

If a potion's spell effect involves a requisite Strand, reagents from each Strand must be included in the brewing process.

Each batch uses the same reagents to produce multiple doses (see Potion Yieldbelow). Reagents are consumed in the process.

Brewing the Potion

- A Gather ingredients including the necessary reagents and prepare the brewing apparatus.
- A Cost out the desired spell effect.
- A Spend a full day (eight hours) brewing, then cast the spell intended for use with the potion.
  - » Resolve may not be used on this roll, but Threads may be.
  - » Any Weave Reaction happens as normal, if applicable, and renders the potion unstable .
  - » If the spell roll fails, the potion is not created and all materials are wasted.
  - » On a success, the potion is complete. Roll Craft: Practical for yield.

Potion Yield

A finished potion produces 1d3 doses + 1 dose per 3 SLs on the Craft: Practical roll. This roll can be supported by Arcana. Each dose reproduces the spell's effect exactly, including Duration and Effect, as though the spell had been cast normally.

If the potion's Effect would normally allow a resistance roll (for example, a harmful transformation), the drinker makes it against the caster's original Bind roll.

Unstable Potions

If any Weave Reaction occurs during brewing, the potion is unstable . Each time a dose is consumed, roll 1d10. On a 1-2, the mixture collapses and all remaining doses from that batch--including the dose just taken--are immediately rendered ineffective.

Alchemical Potion Recipe:
Lucinda's Fortified Flesh

Lucinda the Enchantress brews a body-hardening potion (15 TC):

Bind & Strand Change Body	Range Self (0)
Magnitude Offensive (5)	Duration 1 Hour (4)
Target Self (0)	Effect +3 to Toughness (6)

She retrieves the distilled troll ichor she found in an old mine the previous week (1 Weave Reagent, the requirement for a 15 TC potion). After eight hours, she succeeds on her casting Bind roll with no Weave Reaction, then gets 6 SLs on her Craft: Practical roll. Her yield is 1d3 doses + 1 per 3 SLs; rolling a 3 gives 5 total doses.

When a dose is consumed, the liquid binds into the flesh, tightening muscles and hardening skin. For 1 hour, the drinker gains +3 Toughness.

Alchemical Aids

Unless otherwise noted, bonuses from different aids are cumulative.

Alchemical Aid Table

Aid	Description	Effect
Refined Laboratory	A complete, well-tuned set of alchemical apparatus, such as calibrated glassware, temperature-stable crucibles, and precision scales. Establishing such a lab costs roughly 500 sp and requires a permanent workspace.	+10 to the Bind roll.
Master Alchemist's Laboratory	A permanent, rune-inscribed workspace outfitted with containment wards and magically regulated furnaces. The pinnacle of alchemical refinement, capable of producing consistent results with minimal loss. Establishing such a laboratory costs roughly 1,000-1,200 sp and replaces a Refined Laboratory (you can't use both).	+20 to the Bind roll and +10 to the Craft: Practical roll.
Formula Notes	Detailed notes or a perfected recipe for the specific potion, compiled through prior experimentation or copied from a trusted grimoire. They provide exact ratios and timing for stable infusion. These are normally never sold and must be found, bartered for, or stolen.	+10 to the Bind roll.
Tempered Patience	Brewing with Tempered Patience requires two full working days instead of one, testing mixtures and adjusting temperature between infusions. This deliberate pacing improves control and stability.	+10 to the Bind roll; twice as long to brew.

spell examples

The following sample of spells are provided as examples of the costs and effects of magic. These should give you some idea of the kinds of things different spells can achieve, and their suggested Magnitudes. Each spell's individual elements can be adjusted as needed, correspondingly changing the TC. None of these spells' TCs include any Initiative penalty from worn armor.

Change Spells

The Unseen Light

TC 18

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Air	Self (0)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Self (0)	Sense - Sight (4)

Change the light around yourself to make you and everything you wear invisible for one hour. Taking any action that would reveal your location (attacking, moving a large object within view of someone) renders you visible again, until you take an action to reestablish the invisibility. You may do this for as long as the spell lasts. If an enemy has reason and opportunity to detect you and succeeds at a Perceptionroll, they may attack you at -30.

Haste

TC 16

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Body	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	+5 Initiative (5)

Target's combat movement becomes unusually fast: they have a +5 Initiative bonus for 10 rounds.

Enlarge Wolf

TC 20

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Beast	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Size +1 (3)

Enlarge a normal wolf one Size category for 1 minute. Increase its Toughness by 1, base damage by 2, and Death Threshold by 5. Reduce its Initiative by 1.

Spider Climb

TC 18

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Body req Beast	Self (0)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Self (0)	Vulgar Movement (6)

Allow the caster's hands to take on the properties of a spider's ability to move up walls, along ceilings, etc., at normal speed.

Bearer of Burden

TC 13

Bind&Strand: Change Body
Range: Touch (1)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: Sun (5)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: +3 ENC (3)

Allow someone to carry more by adding 3 available Inventory ENC.

Man to Bear

TC 17

Bind&Strand: Change Body
req Beast
Range: Self (0)
Magnitude: Vulgar (10)
Duration: 1 hour (4)
Target: Self (0)
Effect: Size +1 (3)

Transform into a Thessian bear or Size Large equivalent animal (See Bestiary for stats). The caster retains their mental faculties, but is otherwise subject to the physical characteristics and limitations of the bear. None of the caster's worn or held possessions transform with him (they are not part of his Essential Pattern).

Guardian Golem

TC 17

Bind&Strand: Change Earth
Range: Touch (1)
Magnitude: Offensive (5)
Duration: 1 hour (4)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Skill +30 (5)

Enhance one of a controlled golem's combat skills by +30 for 1 hour. The base skill of any animated substance or object is half the caster's skill.

Soil to Mud

TC 16

Bind&Strand: Change Earth
Range: Close/Short (2)
Magnitude: Offensive (5)
Duration: 1 min (3)
Target: Zone (3)
Effect: Rough (3)

Transform an area of dry soil into sucking mud. Creates Rough Terrain in the zone for 10 rounds.

Sharpen Blade

TC 14

Bind&Strand: Change Earth
Range: Touch (1)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: Sun (5)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Enhance Weapon +2 (4)

Add +2 magical damage to a metal weapon until the sun rises or sets.

Flame to Fire

TC 8

Bind&Strand: Change Fire
Range: Engaged (1)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: Inst (0)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Other (3)

Turn a small match-size flame into a roaring campfire.

Carpet of Thorns

TC 15

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Plant	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Blocked (5)

Changes an adjacent forest zone's undergrowth to thorns for 1 minute, Blocking the zone with stinging and hazardous footing.

Thorny Staff

TC 15

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Plant	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Enhance Weapon +2 (4)

A regular staff grows thick thorns, becoming a magical weapon, turning its damage Lethal, and doing +2 damage.

The Shrouded Item

TC 23

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Spheres	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Sun (5); Trigger: Month (8)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	-30 to Arcana rolls made to detect/decipher (5)

Triggered. A triggered spell cast upon an enchanted item that hinders Arcana attempts made by probing spell casters. The spell triggers the first time a Spellweaver uses Arcana to decipher the item, and lasts for Sun Duration. The trigger lasts a month.

Undeath to Death

TC 14

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Spirit	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Enhance Weapon (Suppress) (5)

Allow an undead creature normally unaffected by anything other than magic to be damaged by non-magical attacks for 10 rounds.

Mystic Charisma

TC 11

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Thought	Touch/Engaged (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Charm (3)

Make a target like you for a brief time. Increasing the Duration requires a longer casting time, which may be tricky if you don't want the target to be aware of the casting. Like all Thought-based magic, a Mystic Charisma spell will cause the victim to be aware of being manipulated if they succeed on the opposed roll, or if they succeed at an Insight roll immediately after the spell expires.

Water to Ice

TC 11

Bind&Strand	Range
Change Water	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Discreet (0)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Other (3)

Cause a zone of water to become solid ice. If cast in freezing temperatures, the Magnitude is Discreet.

Conjure Spells

Lightning Bolt
TC 17

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Air	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind ×2 (4)	Attack, Air Strand dmg (external, no metal AP) (1)

Create and hurl a bolt of lightning at 2 targets at Short range. Shield or metal armor offer no protection. Casting in a thunderstorm lessens the Magnitude.

Ward of Frigid Air
TC 16

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Air	Close (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0); Trigger: Week (6)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Attack, Air Strand dmg (external) (1)

Triggered. When any bipedal living being comes within Close range of the origin (a door in this case), a blast of freezing air damages them. Dodge opposes.

Gulping Air
TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Air	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Attack, Air Strand internal dmg, +2 TC to CL Body (1+2)

Fill a nearby enemy's lungs with air to cause lethal Internal damage unless an opposed Endurance roll is successful.

Heal Animal
TC 10

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Beast	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Healing (5)

Remove 5 WP from a specific wound on an animal or other beast.

Feast of Flesh and Sinew
TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Beast	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Substance, 5 SP (1)

Creates 1 Ration Die step of succulent roasted meat. Such food will vanish if unconsumed after the Duration. Casting this spell while cooking reduces the Magnitude to Discreet (0).

Third Arm
TC 19

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Body	Self (0)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Self (0)	Add Action +1 (5)

An extra arm is added to the caster's body for 1 hour. The arm can do anything the caster's regular arms can do, at the same skill, at the caster's direction. It adds an extra attack action per round. (The extra action follows the Add Actions rules and cannot be used to cast a spell.)

Heal Wound

TC 8

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Body	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Healing (3)

Remove 3 WP from a specific wound. If done at more or less the same time as a Heal roll, Magnitude is Discreet (0) instead of Subtle (2).

Iron Bolt

TC 8

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Earth	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Attack, Earth Strand +1 dmg (external) (2)

An attack spell that allows you to produce an iron spear from inside your cloak and fling it at a target within Short range for Earth Strand+1 dmg. Successive castings increase the Magnitude. Use Dodge for an opposed roll.

Raise Earthen Wall

TC 16

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Earth	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Barrier (4)

A wall of packed soil rises to chest height, granting cover to anyone behind it. When the Duration ends, it collapses into loose dirt.

Flaming Sword of Armor Piercing

TC 15

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Fire	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Enhance weapon (fire) +1 dmg (2); Piercing 1 (2)

Wreathe a sword in magical flame, adding +1 fire damage and 1 point of armor piercing for 1 minute. Spreading oil from a Gear Die roll on the blade first makes this spell Subtle (2).

Burning Zone

TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Fire	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Damaging hazard (5), External, Fire

Set a zone ablaze. If there is any combustible material in the zone, and the caster throws a torch into the zone the round of the casting (with a Gear Die use), reduce the Magnitude by one level. The Damaging Hazard may spread (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Other Perils). This particular spell's starting damage is 5 with a Magnitude of Offensive (5), but the thrown torch reduces the Magnitude to Subtle (2).

Toxic Brew

TC 14

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Plant	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Discreet (0)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Paralyze (8)

Create a herbal drink of toxic poison that paralyzes those who drink it for 10 rounds. If not used within 1 minute of creation, the brew evaporates.

Sustenance of the Weave

TC 9

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Plant	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Substance, 5 SP (1)

Creates 1 Ration Die step of vegetarian food and drink. Such food will vanish if unconsumed after the Duration.

Mystic Armor

TC 22

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Spheres	Self (0)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Self (0)	4 AP all locations (8)

Create a shimmering magical nimbus around the caster that protects as reinforced leather for 1 hour.

Create Hell-mouth

TC 24

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Spheres	Arcane Tether-True Name (6)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Summoning (6)

Opens a Summoning portal to a hellish realm and draws forth a Named demon into a premade circle, if it fails an opposed Willpowerroll. See Summoningfor more.

Portal

TC 30

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Spheres	Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Sun (5)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Vulgar movement - Teleport (6)

Create a temporary magical gate in a zone through which beings can move to a place connected to an Arcane Tether.

Magic Missiles

TC 20

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Spheres	Long (3)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind x3 (6)	Attack, Spheres dmg (external) (1)

Three bolts of pure magic hit random locations on 3 different targets at up to Long range, doing Spheres Strand damage unless Dodged.

Summon Lesser Void Demon

TC 24

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Spheres	Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Summoning (6)

Call forth a void demon whose Arcane Tether you possess. If the spell is not resisted by the demon's Willpower, it appears within your summoning circle (see Summoning for more).

Summon Ghost

TC 24

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Spirit	Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Summoning (6)

A Summoning spell that brings forth a ghost or spirit connected to the Arcane Tether. If the spell is not resisted by the ghost's Willpower, it appears within your summoning circle (see Summoningfor more).

False Serpents

TC 18

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Thought	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Illusion: Sight, hearing and feel (5)

Create an illusion of a snake-filled room/area for 1 minute. This kind of spell can be effective in temporarily throwing off pursuers.

False Flaming Death

TC 20

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Thought	Long (3)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Illusion: Sight, hearing and smell (5)

Create an illusion of the caster burning to death on the ground.

Swell the River

TC 16

Bind&Strand	Range
Conjure Water	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Discreet (0)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Zone ×2 (5)	Other (5)

Make a river burst its banks after a heavy rain, causing flooding. This may require skill rolls to escape.

Control Spells

Arrow Shield
TC 14

Bind&Strand: Control Air
Range: Self (0)
Magnitude: Offensive (5)
Duration: 1 min (3)
Target: Self (0)
Effect: 3 AP all locations (6)

The air around the caster swirls invisibly and turns aside incoming missile attacks.

Beast-friend
TC 14

Bind&Strand: Control Beast
Range: Close (2)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: 1 hour (4)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Bond (4)

One normal animal within range becomes a loyal servant to the caster. As with all control spells, issuing a command to the beast takes an action. Used often with the Call Beast spell.

Call Beast
TC 11

Bind&Strand: Control Beast
Range: Short (2)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: 1 hour (4)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Other (1)

A Small or Medium Size animal common to the local environment emerges within Range from a likely place. Its initial attitude is friendly and can be Controlled with a separate spell, or given simple commands with successful Naturewise rolls for the spell's Duration.

Abjure Pain
TC 9

Bind&Strand: Control Body
Range: Self (0)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: 10 rounds (3)
Target: Self (0)
Effect: Attribute +2 (4)

Dulls the pain of wounds for 1 minute by increasing the caster's Toughness by 2.

Animate Golem
TC 21

Bind&Strand: Control Earth
Range: Touch (1)
Magnitude: Vulgar (10)
Duration: Sun (5)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Other (3)

Animate and control a golem made with the Shape Golem ritual until the sun goes down/up. As it is an inanimate object, the golem cannot oppose this spell. It performs skills at half the caster's skill value.

Open Lock
TC 7

Bind&Strand: Control Earth
Range: Engaged (1)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: Inst (0)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Other (2)

Manipulate a lock and make its inner mechanisms malfunction, opening it. If using lock picks, the Magnitude is Discreet (0).

Swell the Aggressive Flame

TC 9

Bind&Strand: Control Fire
Range: Close (2)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: Inst (0)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Attack, Fire Strand +2 damage (external) (3)

Cause an existing fire at Close range to lash out at a single adjacent target as if blown by a wind.

Awaken the Roots

TC 20

Bind&Strand: Control Plant
Range: Close/Short (2)
Magnitude: Vulgar (10)
Duration: Conc (2)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Attack, Plant Strand dmg + 3 (external) (4)

Make a tree's roots and limbs come alive and attack the Target. Base damage is Plant Strand NL.

Expeditious Withdrawal

TC 26

Bind&Strand: Control Spheres
Range: Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude: Vulgar (10)
Duration: Inst (0); Trigger: Hour (4)
Target: Self (0)
Effect: Vulgar movement - Teleport (6)

Triggered. When the caster takes a wound of 3 points or more within the hour this trigger is active, they are immediately teleported to a predetermined place to which they have an Arcane Tether.

Control Demon

TC 17

Bind&Strand: Control Spheres
Range: Close (2)
Magnitude: Offensive (5)
Duration: 1 hour (4)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Bond (4)

A summoned demon becomes a loyal servant to the caster. As with all control spells, issuing a command takes an action. When the spell expires, a demon is likely to attack the caster.

Force the Ghostly Mind

TC 17

Bind&Strand: Control Spirit
Range: Close (2)
Magnitude: Offensive (5)
Duration: Conc (2)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Mental/Memory (6)

Force a ghost (which resists with Willpower) to reveal the purpose of their haunting.

Control Zombie

TC 18

Bind&Strand: Control Spirit
Range: Close (2)
Magnitude: Offensive (5)
Duration: Sun (5)
Target: Ind (2)
Effect: Bond (4)

Put a mindless undead under your control for Duration.

Abjure Ghost

TC 12

Bind&Strand: Control Spirit
Range: Close (2)
Magnitude: Subtle (2)
Duration: 1 min (3)
Target: Self (0)
Effect: +30 Skill (5)

Gives the caster protection from restless undead spirits by giving +30 to fear-based Willpower rolls.

Mind Shield
TC 11

Bind&Strand	Range
Control Thought	Self (0)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Self (0)	+30 Skill (5)

Protection from mind control. Gives the caster +30 to Willpowerrolls for an hour.

Face of a Friend
TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Control Thought	Touch/Engaged (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Charm (3)

Cause Target to think you're a friend for Duration.

The Receding Waves
TC 16

Bind&Strand	Range
Control Water	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Zone ×2 (5)	Other (3)

Cause a flooded riverbank to calm and recede.

Destroy Spells

Suffocate
TC 15

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Air, req Body	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Attack, Air Strand damage (internal) (1)

Steal the air within a victim's body and cause them internal damage.

Darkness
TC 17

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Air	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Sense - Sight (4)

Create a patch of inky darkness by destroying the light in an adjacent zone. Anyone within (or looking into) the zone is effectively blind (-30 for all rolls based on sight).

Turn the Raging Beast

TC 16

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Beast	Medium (3)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	1 min (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Fear (3)

Cause an aggressive animal at Medium range to turn and flee.

Earth to Dust

TC 17

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Earth	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Attack, Earth Strand (8) damage +7 (8)

Cause a section of a sandstone floor to crumble to dust (30 DT). (Attack spells vs objects do double final damage. This spell's particular caster has an Earth Strand of 8.)

Heart Failure

TC 10

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Body	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Attack, Body Strand damage (internal) (1)

Cause a heart attack in an older humanoid target at Short range. The younger and healthier the target, and the less stressful the circumstances, the higher the Magnitude.

Kill the Inferno

TC 20

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Fire	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Zone Condition - Damaging Hazard (10)

Extinguish up to a 10 damage fire in an adjacent burning zone. If the zone is burning from a currently active Fire spell, it must be dispelled instead.

Silence the Speaker

TC 14

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Body	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	10 rounds (3)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Sound (2)

Prevent a person's vocal chords from forming words for the Duration.

Wither the Forest

TC 15

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Plant	Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Zone Hazard - Blocked (Rotted and dead vegetation) (5)

Cause the plants in a forest zone to wither and die, choking it with impassable vegetation. Magnitude is based on the lushness of the zone.

Banish Demon

TC 19

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Spheres	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Other (5)

A targeted demon must make an opposed Willpowerroll or be sent back to its own hellish realm.

Mind Wipe

TC 19

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Thought	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Sun (5)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Mental/Memory (6)

Removes Target's memories of the past Duration, lasts for the next Duration.

Abjure the Wandering Ghost

TC 10

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Spirit	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Attack, Spirit Strand damage (internal) (1)

Cause direct damage to a spirit as if it were mortal.

Evaporate

TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Destroy Water	Touch/Engaged (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Other (3)

Annihilate all the standing or running water in a zone. This has no effect on anything other than the zone itself.

Witness Spells

Weather Sense

TC 8

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Air	Self (0)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Sun (5)
Target	**Effect**
Self (0)	Sense - Smell (1)

Smell the air and tell what the weather will be in your current location until Sunup/down.

Whispers on the Wind

TC 13

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Air	Sight (5)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Hearing (2)

Hear Target's speech within Range for Duration with Hearing sense, as though they are standing next to you.

Talk to Animal

TC 13

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Beast	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Sound/Speech (2)

Send thoughts to and understand a target animal as if it was speaking to you. They may not like your questions.

See Disease

TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Body	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Skill +20 (3)

By touching a target, the caster can see any disease present in the target and know all its qualities, giving the caster a +20 to Heal rolls on that target's infected wounds for the next hour.

Hawk's Sight

TC 14

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Beast	Very Long (4)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Sight (4)

See through the eyes of a bird of prey within Very Long Range for as long as you concentrate. Most unaware animals do not get a chance to oppose.

Sense the Earth's Memories

TC 19

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Earth	Touch (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Inst (0), +2 (within the last day)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	All senses (8)

By touching a section of a zone, the caster can read the images imprinted in the earth to get a vague sense of what transpired here within the last day (2 SLs). See Looking Through Time in this chapter.

Sense Venom

TC 13

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Beast	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Sense - Sight (4)

By looking at a zone, you can tell if there are any venomous creatures within it.

Facts from Ashes

TC 14

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Fire	Touch/Engaged (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Sight (4)

Looking at a fire or ashes, the caster can see exactly what the fuel source was and any pertinent details (the words of a burned up letter, for example).

Find Healing Herbs

TC 8

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Plants	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Discreet (0)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Zone (3)	Sense - Smell (1)

Follow the scent and find plants used for natural healing potions without the need of a Naturewise roll.

Scry

TC 19

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Spheres	Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Off (5)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Sight (4)

See a target you have an Arcane Tether to.

Track Spirit

TC 15

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Spirit	Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	1 hour (4)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Sense - Taste (1)

Know the general location of a ghost for Duration by getting a foul taste; must have an Arcane Tether to the ghost.

Whispers Past the Veil

TC 12

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Spirit, req Body	Touch/Engaged (1)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Offensive (5)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Hearing/Speech (2)

Converse with a recently dead corpse. It might not tell you the truth.

Read Mind

TC 22

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Thought	Close/Short (2)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Vulgar (10)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Mental/Memory (6)

Read the surface thoughts of the target for Duration.

Discern the Keel

TC 14

Bind&Strand	Range
Witness Water	Sight (5)
Magnitude	**Duration**
Subtle (2)	Conc (2)
Target	**Effect**
Ind (2)	Other (3)

Use ocean currents to perceive the details of one vessel (Maneuvering, Crew, Weapon and Hull) within Sight.

chapter 14: weave magic

Looking Through Time

The Law of Limitation states that magic cannot affect time. However, objects and zones retain a Weave resonance --a faint imprint on the Tapestry of what has transpired there--which can be observed through the Witness Bind combined with an applicable Strand and the Sense Effect.

By touching an object, or by standing within a location (a Zone), a caster may perceive--through the eyes of the Weave itself--what occurred around the object or in that location. The spell's Strand is always determined by the material or association of that object or place: Earth for stone, Plant for wood or reeds, Water for a pool or vessel, Spirit for the presence of a ghost, and so on. In effect, the caster is asking the thing or place what it saw .

The GM determines which moment is shown: a single flash of sights, sounds, and sensations that together suggest what occurred. The vision is never perfectly clear; even the most powerful casting shows only a clouded, fragmented impression, though it will always relate to what the caster is seeking (despite its cryptic nature, the GM should make sure the vision is actually useful to the caster). This magic can never alter the past, only observe it.

Limitations

The shaping elements of Looking Through Time are fixed; they cannot be modified beyond what is listed here. The Weave reveals only a single instant before releasing its hold. Each object or zone retains only one clear imprint that can be read per day; repeated castings on the same subject before sunrise or sunset reveal no new information.

Bind&Strand
Witness, Strand (see below)

Range
Touch (1 TC)

Magnitude
Offensive (5 TC)

Duration
Instant (0 TC)

Target
Individual (object) or Zone (location) (2 or 3 TC)

Effect
All Senses (8 TC)

Special
Add the Perception Window cost:

Perception Window	Additional TC Cost
Within the last hour	+1 TC
Within the last day	+2 TC
Within the last week	+4 TC
Within the last month, or unknown	+8 TC
Within the last year (Ritual only)	+10 TC
Within the last century (Ritual only)	+12 TC, +1 Fraying

Choosing a Strand

Looking Through Time uses the Strand tied to the object or location's resonance, not necessarily its material composition:

Object or Location	Likely Strand
Battle-tested weapon or armor	Body or Earth
Sacrificial altar, a murdered man's robe	Spirit
Flooded site or sunken ship	Water
Burned room or ruin	Fire or Earth
Field trampled by beasts	Beast or Plant
Forest grove or clearing	Plant
Tomb or stone chamber	Earth
Scriptorium or Library	Thought
A magical item	Spheres

ritual examples

Bind Familiar (R)

TC 23

Bind&Strand Control Beast
Range Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude Subtle (2)
Duration Year (9) +1d4 Fraying
Target Ind (2)
Effect Bond (4)

Bonds a normal animal to be your faithful servant for a year.

Shape Golem (R)

TC 21

Bind&Strand Change Earth
Range Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude Subtle (2)
Duration Month (8)
Target Ind (2)
Effect Size +1 (3)

Turn a lump of pre-existing Earth-based material into a Large Size humanoid vessel for animation with the Animate Golem(CoEa) spell (golem stats as per Bestiary). A Craft: Artistic roll is required after casting to make the golem have specific cosmetic features: the more SLs, the closer to what the caster envisions. After the month is up, the rock reverts back to its natural form.

Forever Sleep (R)

TC 33

Bind&Strand Control Thought +1 Fraying (anchored)
Range Arcane Tether (6)
Magnitude Off (5)
Duration Permanent (10) + 2d6 Fraying
Target Structure (9)
Effect Sleep (3)

Put everyone in a chosen building into a permanent deep slumber. Having a feather from every pillow in the building will put 5 toward the Total Cost. The effects of this spell cannot be dispelled as it is anchored.

cHAPTER 15:

divine magic

Divine powers work differently from the powers of the Weave. A Godbound (one who serves and is favored by a god, but not necessarily a priest or other titled member of a religious hierarchy) has a skill called Piety. This is different from any other skill, in that it changes with use. Each god governs a number of Domains (those aspects of reality which the god has purview over), and bestows help to their Godbound through spell-like miracles whose effects are thematically linked to a given Domain.

A Godbound prays for assistance--the Piety skill roll--and if the request lies within one of the god's Domains and the roll succeeds, the god performs a miracle from an appropriate Domain. The number of Piety SLs rolled determines the level of miracle (Lesser, Middle, or Greater) that is granted.

Keywords in this Chapter

Atonement
Cast Out
Celestial Servant
Domain
Holy Symbol
Miracle (Lesser, Middle, Greater)
Miracle Resistance
Piety Modifier
Piety Roll
Pious Acts

Each god reveals themselves differently to different races or cultural groups, and is worshipped under different guises and faces. There are six main gods in the Broken Empires pantheon, and a new god (Omnus the One) who claims to transcend the others. A Godbound serves a single deity, although it is expected that they show reverence to all the gods. In addition, each god has angels, saints, or other celestial servants who can be directly appealed to, and who often provide slightly different Domain powers than the god itself.

piety

Anyone can serve a church or religious organization, and even attain a high rank in its worldly hierarchy, but earning a score in the Piety skill requires the possession of the Godbound Talent. This implies that the character has done something in-game to earn the favor of the god itself, not just the church; after character creation, this is always a roleplaying outcome and never merely a mechanical one. When the Godbound Talent is taken, the character is granted a starting Piety of 30.

The Piety skill can never be improved with Experience Points. Only pious acts of service done in the god's name and for the god's benefit will improve the skill.

A PC's actual Piety skill can never be improved past 90, although modifiers can temporarily raise it to 100 or beyond. This is a hard limit that reflects the fickle nature of the gods of the Broken Empires.

Piety can never have Expertise, but a Piety roll can benefit from a holy symbol (see The Holy Symbol).

By default, the Godbound never knows exactly what his current Piety score is: the GM keeps track of it. Whether the Godbound gains Piety from enacting the will of his god, or loses Piety through regular invocations, the amount is ran-

dom, so the player will not know by exactly how much the score has changed. A wise Godbound always strives to further the goals of their deity, and thereby gain favor.

However, if a Godbound's Piety falls to 30 or below, they should receive an appropriate vision from their god by way of warning. This could be a dream, omen, or other sign. Conversely, if their Piety reaches 80, they should receive a positive vision or sign as encouragement.

A Godbound of Morrudann, with a Piety recently reduced to 30, notices while walking through a field at harvest time that sheaves of wheat are dropping dead in his wake.

A Godbound of Latheriel whose Piety has reached 80 dreams of standing before an angry mob, when beautiful harp music begins playing soothing notes that calm them, turning their anger to joy.

Piety can be arbitrarily decreased if the Godbound performs acts that the god finds outrageous or contrary to the strictures of the church. It can also be reduced by any amount if the god feels that the Godbound is continually using her powers for her own benefit instead of for the god's!

Overworked GMs may instead choose to have their Godbound players track their own Piety. However, this will remove some of the urgency for the player to continuously enact the god's will, as the player will know where their character stands in the eyes of that god.

Domains

Each god has several associated Domains, which are those ideas, concepts, people, places, and things that the god represents and holds celestial dominion over. Domains and what they cover can be very broad. No Domain is exclusive to any one god, and gods who share a Domain will bestow powers associated with that Domain in their own individual way.

Each Domain has a range of miracles a deity can give their Godbound to enact the divine will (Lesser, Middle, and Greater). Some of the miracles are very specific, while some are quite vague. This allows the GM to interpret them however they want based on the context of the Godbound's situation. The example miracles are by no means complete lists, but they should give a GM a sense of the type of powers the Domain is capable of providing.

The gods are not bound by the Domain powers listed; the miracles are more guidelines than hard and fast rules. If the Domain doesn't contain a miracle appropriate to the situation, feel free to come up with another way the god can help within the bounds of the Domain. The miracle's effects should be within the bounds of the god's description.

> Ilosia, the goddess of healing, has the Fire Domain, but nothing in her description (the Healer, She Who Mends, Bruxara the Merciful, The Planter, Springdaughter, Valora Garden-keeper) suggests that she would bestow the powers of Fire to cause injury. No matter how hard he prayed, a priest of Ilosia would never be granted the ability to throw a fireball at an enemy!

Asking for a Miracle

A Godbound is just a conduit, a vessel of their god. It is not by the Godbound's will that power manifests, but by the will of their deity. The Godbound does not make demands of their god, but requests--requests that will be answered only as the god sees fit. A Godbound asks their deity to intercede on their behalf in the form of a miracle. The god will try to answer the Godbound's prayers as appropriately as possible, based on:

- the outcome of the Pietyroll
- the kind of help the deity perceives that the Godbound needs at that moment, and
- whichever of the god's Domains that is most appropriate to the situation.

There are some key principles to miracles:

- The gods cannot affect things outside their Domains. If a Godbound asks for a miracle that falls outside their deity's Domains, there will be no result. You cannot ask the goddess of healing to smite down your enemies, for example.
- The gods grant less granular control over the miracle's effects. Unlike a Spellweaver, a Godbound cannot shape the miracle's effect. Instead, they ask for help in a given situation, keeping the requested effect within the bounds of the god's Domain. The level of the miracle--Lesser, Middle, or Greater--will be based on the Pietyroll's outcome, and the specifics will ultimately be dictated by the deity (represented by the GM).

Celestial Servants

A Godbound may request a miracle from a celestial servant to access that servant's Domain. This functions like any other miracle, but due to the indirect nature of the appeal to the god's power, celestial servants cannot grant Greater Miracles under any circumstance.

The Piety Roll

When a Godbound requests something of their god, they roll their current Piety.

- A Godbound can't spend Resolve on Piety rolls. The Godbound's resolve has nothing to do with the outcome; it is entirely a matter of faith and divine favor.
- A Weave Reactions do not manifest from a miracle. The god itself mitigates the Weave, regardless of the miracle's success or failure.
- A Piety SLs can be improved by +2 from a holy symbol's use.

The Holy Symbol

Holy symbols are trinkets that act as a kind of Supply Die: each use of the symbol requires a roll of its current Die Type (starts at d12). The symbol can be rolled after a successful Piety roll to add +2 SLs to the outcome, but the Die Type diminishes one step on a roll of 1-2. The holy symbol does not help a failed Piety roll.

If a Godbound's holy symbol depletes below d6, the symbol must be blessed by another Godbound of the same deity with at least 70 Piety before it will provide further benefit. The blessing itself is considered a Lesser Miracle that must be prayed and rolled for like any other effect, and restores the symbol to d12. A Godbound may only possess one holy symbol at a time.

- A If, in the GM's opinion, the requested miracle genuinely serves or advances the god's aims (not merely the Godbound's desires), the Piety roll gains a +10 or greater bonus.
- A If the request is selfish, frivolous, or runs contrary to the deity's interests or church strictures, apply a -20 or worse penalty.
- A Repeatedly calling on divine power for personal gain may anger the god, resulting in the Godbound being Cast Out (see below).

Piety Modifier Table

Type of Request	Modifier to Piety
Clearly furthers the god's aims or agenda	+10 to +30
Directly aids others faithful to the god	+10
Involves genuine self-sacrifice or personal hardship in the god's name	+10 to +20
A plea made during great danger, showing true faith and humility	+10
Made arrogantly or without reverence	-10 to -20
Motivated by personal gain, comfort, or vanity	-10 or worse
Involves harm to the church's own faithful	-20 or worse
Violates a Core Stricture of the deity	-30

If a Godbound's Piety has been temporarily increased to a score beyond 100 through modifiers, they gain bonus SLs on the roll. This works exactly the same as any skill over 100: subtract 100 from the modified Piety skill value. The tens die amount of this value acts as extra SLs (minimum +1 SL). It also means the miracle roll cannot critically fail.

Varakash the Godbound has served his deity well, and when he beseeches the god for aid in a manner that significantly furthers the god's aims, Varakash gets a whopping +30 to his Piety of 77, allowing him to roll a skill of 107. He will get a bonus of +1 SL (107-100=07, or the 1 SL minimum for skills over 100).

The miracle's effects will have a Duration as long as the god deems it necessary to help their Godbound. This could mean, depending on the power used, 1 action, 1 minute, 1 hour, 1 day, the whole "scene", or some other Duration. Some listed miracles have suggested Durations.

The Range can vary based on the particulars, but usually the miracle affects a target within Close Range.

Asking for a miracle takes one action. However, engaging in persistent prayer for longer periods increases the outcome of a successful Piety roll as follows:

- Praying for a full minute: +1 SL
- Praying for 10 minutes: +2 SLs
- Praying for a full hour or more: +3 SLs

Resistance to a miracle is based on the target's actions or intentions towards the Godbound's deity (see Miracle Resistance).

Asking for a miracle reduces the Godbound's Piety as indicated by the Piety roll.

Piety Roll Results

After all modifiers are accounted for, the Piety skill is rolled:

Piety Roll Result

Success	The request is granted. Reduce the Godbound's Piety by 1d10 + the total SLs generated (including any holy symbol use and/or persistent prayer). 1-4 SLs grants a Lesser Miracle 5-8 SLs grants a Middle Miracle 9+ SLs grants a Greater Miracle
Critical Success	Add 3 SLs to the roll's total. The miracle is granted as above with zero Piety cost.
Failure	The god doesn't grant the miracle; reduce the Godbound Piety by 1d10.
Critical Failure	The god doesn't grant the miracle; reduce the Godbound Piety by 1d10+10.

The Godbound Varakash has 56 Piety. He asks for help and rolls a 46. With the +2 SL from using his Holy Symbol, he gets 6 SLs, enough for a Middle Miracle. He reduces his total Piety by 1d10+6, and rolls his holy symbol die to check for depletion.

If he had rolled 44, that would be a critical success, increasing his SLs to 7, and giving him a Middle Miracle with a cost of zero Piety. If he used his holy symbol, the +2 SLs would bump him up to a Greater Miracle (the Piety cost of the miracle would still be zero, as it was a critical success).

If he had rolled a 79, a failure, he would not be granted a miracle and would lose 1d10 Piety just for asking.

If he had rolled a 77, a critical failure, he would not be granted a miracle and would lose 1d10+10 Piety.

Miracle Resistance

Like Weave magic, targets always get an opposed roll to completely avoid a miracle's adverse effects, using a skill that makes sense considering the specifics of the miracle. Unlike Weave magic, the resistance fixed number is based on the target's actions or intentions towards the Godbound's deity.

Miracle Resistance Table

Target's actions or intentions	Description	Fixed Number	Examples
Uninvolved or ignorant (or unclear)	Performed from instinct, ignorance, or circumstance, or are not opposing the god, the faith, or the Godbound in any meaningful sense	1	A beast defending its young or territory; a thief stealing from a temple without realizing the item is sacred.
Directly threatening the Godbound	Directly threatening the Godbound (this includes typical enemies the Godbound may face: bandits, monsters, or beasts)	2	A monster hunting the Godbound; a jealous noble plotting to ruin the Godbound's reputation.
Blasphemous or offensive to the faith	Knowingly mocking, defiling, or acting disrespectfully toward the deity, the church, or its tenets	3	A thief knowingly stealing relics or holy offerings; a poet spreading irreverent songs about the god's supposed failings.
Active threat to the deity's works	Willfully harming, stealing from, or defiling the faith's property, relics, or servants	4	A warlord looting or burning temples; a corrupt bishop profaning relics for personal gain.
Profane defiance	A direct threat or challenge to the core principles of the church, or to a large group of the deity's worshippers	5	A lord ordering the destruction of holy sites as a "new covenant" replacing the old; a general ordering the slaughter of pilgrims or clergy.

Only living, sentient beings make resistance rolls. Inanimate objects, areas, or zones cannot oppose a miracle, though objects held, carried, or worn by a creature resist using that creature's Dodge, Endurance, or Willpower, as appropriate.

Any character may oppose a miracle with the Divinity skill instead of another appropriate resistance, representing an understanding of the gods' patterns and the limits of their will.

If an ongoing Divine effect lasts for 1 minute or less, the target may attempt an opposed roll every round. If the Divine effect lasts for longer, they may usually only make another opposed roll if the circumstances change (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: The Law of Resistance).

Increasing Piety

The only way for a Godbound to regain lost Piety is by performing acts of service or devotion to the deity or the church (Pious Acts). Since by default a Godbound never knows the exact value of their current Piety, they are incentivized to serve their god's interests as often as possible.

Note that living by the god's Core Strictures (see Chapter 16 - The Gods of the Broken Empires) is required of a Godbound, and does not in itself count as a Pious Act. However, embodying the core strictures (as suggested in each god's description) can be rewarded with a generous amount of Piety.

A Godbound's Piety can never be raised to more than 90 through Pious Acts.

Pious Act Table

Pious Act Example	Piety Increase
One hour of uninterrupted prayer (one attempt per day)	50% chance of 1
Fasting*	1d3 per full day
Confession**	1d3
Helping a member of the Faith	1d4
Conducting a mass	1d4+1
Consecrating holy ground	1d6
Making a sacrifice of an item of deep personal importance	1d8+2
Enduring physical or social harm for the god's sake	1d8+4
Establishing a place of worship	1d12+3
Converting an unbeliever	2d8+4
Destroying a true enemy of the faith	3d6+2
Embodying the Core Strictures***	4d6
Fulfilling a pilgrimage	1d10+8
Completing a holy quest	1d10+10

*Suffer 1 Fatigue per day of fasting due to deprivation (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Fatigue-based Wounds)

**Confession must be heard by a religious superior, and can only be benefited from once per week

***Varies by deity: the act must clearly advance the god's aims, carry real cost or risk, and be performed in the deity's name (see each god's entry for examples).

Cast Out

If a Godbound's Piety ever falls to zero, they are Cast Out. They receive an angry or chastising vision or visitation from the god or one of their emissaries, who communicates the deity's displeasure (they will have already received a warning vision from their god when their Piety reaches 30 or below).

A Godbound can also be Cast Out for repeatedly calling upon the god's power for selfish or self-serving ends, or intentionally ignoring or working against the religion's Core Strictures (detailed under each god's entry). The deity will always first warn the Godbound through dreams, omens, or visions, giving them a chance to amend their behavior. If these warnings are ignored, the god withdraws their favor: the Godbound's Piety falls to zero, and they are Cast Out. Truly egregious abuse of divine power for selfish ends can prompt the deity to sever the bond permanently, casting the Godbound out forever. This should be rare.

> If the Piety score falls to zero due to a miracle roll's Piety cost, the Godbound is Cast Out immediately after the miracle's effects are resolved (if the roll was successful).

Once Cast Out, the deity will no longer respond to the Godbound's requests for miracles, and the Godbound cannot regain lost Piety until they have made an act of atonement.

Atonement

Each religion and god has different guidance on what they expect as an act of atonement. These tend to be difficult quests or missions on behalf of the deity or the church. Completing acts of atonement returns the Godbound into the god's good graces, after which the Godbound may continue earning Piety and asking for miracles.

After Atonement

When a Cast Out Godbound completes their act of atonement and regains divine favor, the bond is not immediately whole. The god has forgiven, but distance remains.

For a short time, the deity's attention is muted: no Greater Miracles may be granted to the Godbound for 1d6 game sessions.

Lesser and Middle Miracles may still occur as normal, though their manifestations may feel restrained or uncertain, reflecting the god's lingering mistrust. Once this period has passed, the god's full favor returns, and Greater Miracles may again be granted.

A Godbound of Devona (Piety 77) is asking the goddess to protect her from a raging forest fire long enough to escape it. The GM decides that this falls under Devona's Water Domain. He also decides that countering fire is agreeable to the Sea Bitch's desires, and gives a +10 bonus to the priestess' roll, for a total modified Piety of 87. She prays for a full minute, giving her a +1 SL to a successful roll. The Godbound rolls 46, to which she adds +2 SLs due to her holy symbol (a roll of 2 on the d12 means it degrades to d10), and +1 from persistent prayer. She has a total of 4+2+1 = 7 SLs, providing a Middle Miracle.

The GM decides that since the priestess asked for protection from the flames, Devona grants her SLs in AP (7) to all locations vs the fire only, for as long as it takes for her to exit the fire zones. The GM describes how a sheen of sweat on the Godbound's body seems to dissipate some of the heat as she runs out of the fire, and lessens any fire damage by 7.

As she was successful in her Miracle roll, she will deduct 1d10 + 7 from her current Piety.

If she had rolled 89, the miracle would fail and not be granted. Her Piety would be reduced by 1d10.

If she had rolled 44, a critical success, the miracle would work with +3 SLs (or 10 in this case, adding in the holy symbol and the persistent prayer, generating a Greater Miracle). She would deduct nothing from her current Piety. The GM might describe how a sudden thunderstorm coalesces and sprinkles rain on the burning forest, dampening the priestess's path just enough to get her out of the area.

If she had rolled 88, a critical failure, the miracle would not be granted, and her Piety would be reduced by 1d10+10 (she rolls an 8, for 18), bringing her current Piety down to 59 (77-18). The gods are vindictive...

If her original Piety had been at, say, 10, and she rolled a successful miracle but lost 10 or more Piety, she would be Cast Out immediately after the effects of the miracle manifest. She would have no further access to her goddess's power, and would have to perform an act of atonement suitable to Devona to regain it--and even afterwards, she wouldn't be granted Greater Miracles for 1d6 sessions.

Answering the Godbound's Prayer

When a Godbound's prayer succeeds, the god acts; how that power manifests is up to the GM. Miracles are responses, not commands. In general, miracles follow the Bounded Laws of Magic, but the GM shouldn't feel straitjacketed by them--these are the gods, after all.

The GM should use these principles to decide what happens when fulfilling a Miracle

Serve the Intention, Not the Words

Answer what the Godbound truly means, not exactly what they say. A plea for "protection" might create shelter, drive off foes, or strengthen resolve; whatever fits the god's interpretation of how best to help their servant.

Stay Within the Domain

Keep every miracle within the god's Domains. If the request doesn't fit, it goes unanswered--or the god twists it to reflect their own nature.

Match Power to Level of Miracle

Lesser Miracles should feel personal, Middle Miracles tactical, and Greater Miracles awe-inspiring. Even a small miracle should have sensory presence--light, scent, warmth, sound, emotion--so that it feels divine.

Show the God's Hand, Not the God

The gods rarely appear directly (despite the events of "Me, Myself and Die!"). Instead, describe signs, coincidences, or symbolic echoes: a chill wind, a sudden silence, a glimmer of light. Their presence should be more felt than seen.

chapter 15: divine magic

domain lists & miracles

Miracles within a Domain are listed according to their power: Lesser, Middle, or Greater. Within each level, there are several different examples of what the miracle might accomplish. The miracle effects are just guidelines, and there is intentionally a lot of room for interpretation; feel free to adjust and invent as necessary. And don't be afraid to go big on Greater Miracles once in a while, if you feel the Godbound has earned it; nothing wrong with a particularly favored Godbound parting seas or calling down plagues of frogs!

By default, miracle effects last "for the Duration of the scene/combat". This just means the effect lasts for the rest of the combat/social exchange/series of rolls, or as long as the GM deems it to be applicable. Suggested exceptions will be noted.

The Range of the miracle effect, as noted earlier, is normally Close, but can vary.

A miracle that does internal damage will ignore AP , but each case is different; as always, the GM must use reason and good judgement to decide.

A Divine effect that adds Armor Points applies them to all of the target's hit locations (if any of the target's hit locations already have armor, use whichever AP value is higher). If a random hit location is affected by a miracle, use the ones die of the Piety roll to determine.

Every Domain allows a Lesser Miracle that restores the power of its god's holy symbol, as detailed under The Holy Symbol above.

Air Domain

Weather, storms, light, sound, silence, the sky

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Perceptionrolls based on hearing or smell.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Stealth rolls based on silence.
- A The Godbound channels the rage of a storm and receives +20 or Ex2 on Intimidate rolls.
- A A soft, divine light, equivalent to a lantern, emanates from the Godbound's holy symbol.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound can fall short distances without taking damage (up to 20').
- A A whirlwind forms around the Godbound, acting as 1d4+1 AP .
- A A gust of air acts as a Might 90 Ex3 NL attack (Dmg 3) against one target of the Godbound's choice.
- A Shimmering air and tricks of light cause the Godbound to be invisible for the Duration of the scene, or until he takes an aggressive action.
- A A controlled cyclone forms around a zone, Blocking it for 1d4+1 rounds.
- A A mighty wind damages smaller structures, or Drives Back (as per the Combat Maneuver) 1d4+1 foes out of the targeted zone.

Greater Miracle

- A Calms a storm in the Godbound's vicinity.
- A A whirlwind forms around the Godbound and 1d4+1 of her nearby allies, acting as 1d4+1 AP for the Duration of the combat.
- A Shimmering air and tricks of light cause the Godbound and his nearby allies to be invisible for 3d6 rounds, or until one of them takes an aggressive action.
- A The Godbound is moved from the area of one storm to the area of any other storm in the Broken Empires.

Battle Domain

Enhancing weapons and armor, combat maneuvers, feats of strength, aggression, war, struggle, honor

Lesser Miracle

- The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to 2 Combat skills.
- The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Endurance rolls.
- The Godbound receives a +20 bonus or Ex2 to Prepare the Battlefield attempts until combat begins.

Middle Miracle

- A divine light forms around the Godbound, acting as 1d4+2 AP .
- The Godbound receives +2 to all Wound Die rolls.
- One of the Godbound's allies receives a +20 blessing to a Combat skill.
- The Godbound's attacks do +2 damage.
- As long as the Godbound performs the Stand Your Ground action, he receives an additional +10 to all defense rolls (for a total of +30) and any Trip attempts against him require +1 SL.

Greater Miracle

- The Godbound's next successful attack ignores all AP .
- The Godbound's next successful attack causes any Wound Die roll to be made at -5.
- For the duration of the combat, the Godbound may make a re-roll of any fatal Wound Die rolls he suffers.
- The Godbound's Lethality Levels increase by 3.
- The Godbound's Death Threshold increases by 5.

Communication Domain

Interactions among thinking beings, social engagements, creativity, camaraderie, the arts, worldly pleasures, law and order, justice, society, poetry, and song

Lesser Miracle

- The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to any two Social skills.
- The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to opposed Willpower rolls against mental manipulation.
- The Godbound can send a short one-sentence message to any fellow adherent of the faith who possesses a holy symbol.

Middle Miracle

- The Godbound receives Ex4 to one Social skill for the next three rolls.
- The Godbound can mentally communicate without words to one target in Short Range.
- The Godbound can speak and understand any one language.
- The Godbound implants one specific memory in the mind of one nearby target.
- The Godbound's voice carries over great distances.
- The Godbound can send a short one-sentence message to anyone in the world, as long as they know the person's current location.

Greater Miracle

- The Godbound receives Ex4 to one Social skill until the scene ends.
- The Godbound may Command a target to make them act even against their own interests exactly as the Weave magic Command Effect. The effect lasts for 1 minute. If resisted, or when the effect ends, the target knows they have been manipulated if they make an Insight or Divinity roll.
- Everyone in the chosen zone can speak and understand any one language.
- Everyone the Godbound targets in a zone can mentally communicate without words to each other.
- The Godbound can send a short message to anyone in the world.

Curse Domain

Hexing an enemy, bringing lingering misfortune

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound chooses two of a target's skills to be at -20.
- A Some cosmetic curse befalls the target: hair falls out, warts, bad smell, etc. Most of these are permanent until the curse is removed.

Middle Miracle

- A One target suffers -3 Initiative.
- A One target suffers -2 Toughness.
- A One target suffers -1 zone movement.
- A One of a target's non-combat skills always fails for the duration of the miracle.
- A The Godbound can remove a curse.

Greater Miracle

- A Any one of a target's skills always fails for the duration of the miracle.
- A One target goes last for the duration of the combat.
- A 1d4+1 targets (within Long Range) suffer up to -2 Toughness.
- A 1d4+1 targets (within Long Range) suffer -1 zone movement.
- A Some awful curse manifests: cannot reproduce for a year, always react to friends with wrath, up to 500 sp worth of materials turn to dust/destitution, etc.

Dream Domain

Memory, visions, prophecy, illusion, restfulness

The Godbound must know at least some pertinent detail about a Dream target.

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Insight rolls.
- A The sleeping Godbound can enter the dream of a sleeping target within 1 mile and change one detail per 2 SLs of a standard Insight roll.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound can cause a target to have nightmares for 1 straight week, causing Sleep Deprivation (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils:Other Perils).
- A The Godbound can enter the dreams of a target within one mile and control them as a sleepwalker for 1 hour. Issuing a command that the target wouldn't normally do requires a successful Insightroll; failure expels the Godbound from the target's dream.
- A The Godbound can manifest an object from a target's dream in the real world. The object lasts for 1 minute.
- A The deity provides the Godbound with an illusion that helps them in this moment. The illusion can deceive all senses, but has no physical presence and cannot directly affect the real world.

Greater Miracle

- A The sleeping Godbound can enter the dream of a sleeping target anywhere in the world and communicate directly with them for 1 minute.
- A The sleeping Godbound can implant, erase, or take one specific memory from the mind of a sleeping target within one mile.
- A The Godbound can manifest a Dream Beast in the real world (as a Summoned Creature in the Bestiary) to serve him for the duration of the scene.

Earth Domain

Crafting, terrestrial materials, metal, stone, gravity

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Craft: Practical or Artistic rolls when using stone.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Endurance rolls.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Might rolls.
- A The Godbound can shape stone or rock into small structures or objects.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound's skin hardens like rock, acting as 1d4+1 AP .
- A The Godbound leaves no trace of his passing over soil or stone for 1 day.
- A The Godbound can sense a quarry through the earth; he receives either +20 to Track, or a Track of 80, whichever is greater, for 1 day.
- A The earth rises and ensnares a single enemy, Restraining them for 1d4+1 rounds.
- A The Godbound can turn an earthen zone into quicksand (Hazard: Rough, Blocked).

Greater Miracle

- A The earth rises and ensnares a single enemy, Paralyzing them for 2d6 rounds.
- A An earthquake shakes 1d4+1 contiguous zones, causing a Hazard: Other (knocked Prone), and Damaging (External Damage 10).
- A The Godbound can shape stone or rock into a 6-10' high defensible wall through 1d4+1 contiguous zones that lasts for 1 day.

Fertility Domain

Fertility, birth, the harvest, life, youth, passion, love, marriage, joy, food, crafting and building, Spring

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Naturewise rolls.
- A The Godbound can re-roll a Rations Die.

Middle Miracle

- A The crops/plants in 1d4+1 zones grow more rapidly, producing a 1d20+20% higher yield when harvest comes.
- A A target becomes reproductively attractive to likely members of the opposite sex, gaining +30 to Seduce for 1d4+1 hours.
- A +20 to a character's next set of Recovery rolls.
- A Provide enough food and water for 1d4 Ration dice.

Greater Miracle

- A The Godbound's touch turns barren ground into rich soil. Affects 1d4+1 zones, lasts the growing season.
- A Purge a single infected wound or other affliction (poison, disease) from the target.
- A Guarantee a child is born healthy, and ensures them great strength and vigor in adulthood

Fire Domain

Heat, light, fire, strong emotions

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Survival rolls.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Intimidate rolls.
- A The Godbound creates a small flame equal to a torch with no need for kindling.
- A The Godbound causes a strong emotion in the target: anger, jealousy, desire, despair, disgust, or anxiety. This may give a contextually-appropriate +/- 20 to various skills used either by the target or against him.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound does not suffer the effects of cold or freezing for 1 day.
- A A jet of flame from an existing fire shoots forth at a target within Close Range, doing 1d8 fire damage opposed by Dodge
- A A zone within Medium range is filled with smoke, causing an Obscured Hazard for 1d4+1 rounds.
- A The Godbound's weapon (or an ally's) is wreathed in flame (+5 Fire Damage).

Greater Miracle

- A The Godbound summons a wall of flame through 1d3 contiguous zones, creating a zone Damaging hazard (Fire Damage 15, external).
- A The weapons of the Godbound and all their allies are wreathed in flame (+5 Fire Damage).
- A The earth erupts into flame, smoke, and lava in a single zone within Long range, creating a Zone Hazard: Damaging (Fire Damage 20, external), Blocked & Obscured.

Healing Domain

Reducing WP, removal of disease, poison, and other afflictions of the body

Lesser Miracle

- A Grants +20 on the next 1d4+1 Heal rolls or until the end of the scene, whichever comes first.
- A Grants +30 to the next Nature-wise roll used to make natural healing potions, or Survival roll to treat poison.
- A Grants +20 to a target character's next set of Recovery rolls.

Middle Miracle

- A Heals total WP equal to the Piety roll's SLs to any combination of wounds on the target. If it doesn't already have an RB, give each wound +10 RB.
- A Purges a single infected wound or other affliction (poison, disease) from the target.

Greater Miracle

- A Heals all of the target's wounds completely and cures all infection.
- A Eliminates all Fatigue and removes infection from 1 infected wound.
- A Resets all current RBs of the Godbound and each of his allies to +30.

Knowledge Domain

Thought, memory, history, reasoning, creativity, truth, foresight, lore, learning, secrets

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Common Lore and Ancient Lore rolls.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Craft Practical or Artistic rolls.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to opposed Willpower rolls against mental manipulation.
- A The Godbound may read any language for the duration of the scene or until the end of the day, whichever comes first.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +30 on the next three rolls they make with any Lore skill.
- A By placing hands on a target's head, the Godbound may pull one memory from the target's mind.
- A The Godbound may speak and read any language for the duration of the scene or until the end of the day, whichever comes first.
- A The Godbound may make a single Masterwork item as though they had the Master Artist/Craftsman Talent.

Greater Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +30 on the next three skill rolls they make with any skill.
- A The Godbound sees in her mind an ethereal library containing every book, scroll, and text from all ages. The Godbound may ask any question, and the answer will be provided as a book or scroll pulled from the library. If it's conceivable that someone would have had cause to write the desired answer down somewhere, then the Godbound can see it.

Luck Domain

Chance, fortune, risk, wagers, reversals of fate

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +2 to Initiative for the rest of this combat.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Locks & Traps and Dodge rolls.
- A Once during the current scene, the Godbound may reroll any single failed test and keep the better result.
- A A coin, card, or dice roll within sight always lands in the Godbound's favor for the next minute.

Middle Miracle

- A For 1 minute, the Godbound and allies within Short range gain +20 to all Dodge and Perception rolls.
- A For the rest of this scene, the Godbound's critical failures are counted as regular failures instead.
- A Roll a d10 immediately after invoking this miracle. On 1-5, any roll the Godbound makes in this scene gains +10; on 6-10, all rolls against him also gain +10. The Godbound may not refuse either result.
- A Choose one ally within Short Range of the Godbound. That ally gains +20 to all rolls for 1d4+1 rounds--but for that same duration, the Godbound suffers -20 to all rolls.

Greater Miracle

- A An event of staggering improbability occurs in the Godbound's favor (the bridge doesn't collapse, the enemy's bowstring snaps, lightning strikes the pursuer).
- A The Godbound may name one person or object within Long range, including themselves. For the next 24 hours, the first great fortune or disaster that would befall them is reversed.
- A For the next hour, the Godbound and all allies remaining within Medium Range ignore the first failed roll they make; treat it as a success with 3 SL. This miracle fades after it benefits each creature once.
- A Once in the next 24 hours, before any roll the Godbound makes, they may declare "The hand is mine", to automatically succeed with SL equal to the Godbound's DivinityScore.

Magic Domain

The planes of existence, fate, Magic itself

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Arcana rolls.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to all opposed rolls against magic.
- A The Godbound detects the presence and type of Threads within the zone for 1 minute.
- A The Godbound may participate in a Ritual spell exactly as an assistant, reducing the ritual's Total Cost by half the Godbound's Divinity Score (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Assistance From Others).
- A For 1 minute, the Godbound may identify, with an Arcana roll, the Binds and Strands of any magic he encounters and the magic signature of the Spellweaver who cast it. Success with 3+ SLs also allows him to know all the details of the spell (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Tears in the Tapestry).

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound may dispel magic exactly as a Spellweaver, using Divinity instead of a Bind skill. This power lasts until the end of the scene. On a tie, compare the Godbound's Divinityto the Spellweaver's Strand.
- A The Godbound channels the deity's power as a magical attack, causing 1d4+2 magical internal damage to a random location on 1 enemy, resisted by Dodge
- A The Godbound points at a Spellweaver and forces them to make a roll on the Weave Reaction Table with a modifier equal to the Piety roll's SLs (re-rolling positive results).

Greater Miracle

- A A Spellweaver ally subtracts 10 from any Weave Reaction Table rolls for the next 5 rounds.
- A Enemy Spellweavers within Medium range of the Godbound suffer a -30 to all Bind rolls for 1d6+2 rounds.
- A The Godbound points at a Spellweaver and forces them to take Fraying points equal to half the Piety roll's SLs (round up).

Movement Domain

Moving faster or slower, restraining, immobilization or paralyzation, independence

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Athletics, Dodge, or other rolls directly related to quick movement.

Middle Miracle

- A Add +1 zone to the Godbound's regular Move for Piety SL rounds.
- A Immobilize 1d4 enemies (within Long range) in their zone for 1d4+1 rounds.
- A The Godbound ignores all worn armor penalties.
- A Increase the Godbound's Inventory ENC by 1d4+1 until the next sunset/rise.

Greater Miracle

- A Add +2 zones to the Godbound's regular move for Piety SL rounds.
- A Restrain 1d4 enemies (within Long range) in their zone for 1d4+1 rounds.
- A Paralyze one enemy (within Long range) for 1d4+2 rounds.

Nature Domain

Animals, wilderness, plants, and the products derived from them, balance, change, the wilderness, Summer

Unless otherwise stated, these prayers can be made at any point on a Journey.

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to Survival, Track, Naturewise, or other appropriate roll currently being used to survive in the wilds.
- A The Godbound creates a small globe of sunlight in his/her hand with light equal to a torch.
- A Allows the Godbound to receive a true answer to a single question posed to the local plants or animals.

Middle Miracle

- A Produce food and drink equal to 1d6 Ration Supply Die steps.
- A Summon a friendly local animal of up to Medium Size that will help as best it can for the scene.
- A Foretell the exact weather conditions for the next 24 hours in the general vicinity.
- A Restore life or fertility to blighted crops or plants in the immediate zone.
- A Restore 1 Fatigue each to 1d4 of the Godbound's allies.

Greater Miracle

- A Restore 1d6+2 Fatigue to the Godbound and each of her allies.
- A Produce food and drink equal to 2d6 Ration Supply Die steps.
- A Summon a friendly local animal of up to Huge Size that will help as best it can for the scene.
- A Change the current weather to something beneficial to the Godbound's situation.
- A Avert a natural disaster, within reason.

Protection Domain

Armor, shields, magic resistance, skill enhancement, sending help, guardianship, virtue

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to all defense rolls.
- A The Godbound receives +20 or Ex2 to all opposed rolls against magic.

Middle Miracle

- A An invisible force protects the Godbound, acting as 1d4+2 AP .
- A The Godbound selects an ally to receive +20 to either Dodge, Endurance, Willpower, Athletics, or Insight for 3 rounds.
- A The Godbound receives +3 on all Wound Die rolls.
- A All physical attacks targeting the Godbound are at -20.
- A A Size Medium or smaller creature arrives to assist the Godbound.

Greater Miracle

- A All physical attacks targeting 1d4+1 of the Godbound's allies are at -20.
- A The Godbound and all allies receive +3 on all Wound Die rolls.
- A The Godbound is made invisible for 1d4+1 rounds (if an enemy has reason and opportunity to detect them and succeeds at a Perception roll, they may attack at -30).
- A A Size Large or bigger creature arrives to assist the Godbound.

Spirit Domain

Ghosts, spirits, decay, stillness, shadows, damage to and protection from undead, death, the afterlife, Winter

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound gains +20 or Ex2 to any two skills used against undead for the Duration of the conflict.
- A The Godbound gains +20 or Ex2 to Stealth for the duration.

Middle Miracle

- A Cause 1d4 undead targets to each suffer a 3-point wound to a random location.
- A One undead target suffers one 1d6+2 wound to a random location.
- A One undead must make a Willpower roll or be forced to flee.
- A A chill wind freezes 1d4 undead in place, Restraining them for 1d4+1 rounds.
- A One undead not currently in combat is forced to answer 1d4 specific questions made by the Godbound.
- A The Godbound gains 1d4+1 AP vs attacks from all undead for the Duration of the current conflict, or bestows this power to one ally.

Greater Miracle

- A Cause 1d4+1 undead targets to suffer a wound of 1d4+2 points to a random location.
- A One undead must make a Willpower roll at -30 or be forced to flee OR 1d4+1 undead targets must make a Willpowerroll or be forced to flee.
- A The Godbound gains 1d6+3 AP vs attacks from all undead for the Duration of the current conflict, or bestows this power to one ally.
- A 1d4 of the Godbound's allies gain 1d4 AP+1 vs attacks from all undead for the Duration of the current conflict.
- A A snowstorm covers the area, protecting the Godbound and his party in some way.

Travel Domain

Making journeys safer and easier, navigation

Unless otherwise stated, these prayers can be made at any point on a Journey.

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound's deity grants +20 or Ex2 to a character making the next Travel Lore, Guide, Quartermaster, or Scout skill roll.
- A The Godbound, or one who receives the Godbound's blessing, gains a one-time +20 bonus to an applicable skill during a Travel Event or encounter.
- A The Godbound's deity allows one target to make a single Recovery roll while on a Journey.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound or an ally receives +3 on the next or current Fatigue Table roll.
- A Produce food and drink equal to 1d4 Ration Supply Die steps.
- A Apply -5 to the next Hostile Encounter roll.

Greater Miracle

- A Restore 1d6+1 depleted Ration Supply dice.
- A If on a Journey, allows the Godbound's party to add 1d4+1 hexes to the next Guide roll.
- A Upon arrival in a new hex, make the area one level safer (Dangerous to Precarious, Precarious to Normal, Normal to Safe), with a -5 to the first Hostile Encounter roll.

Water Domain

Liquids, water, tranquility, mystery, the ocean

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound gains +20 or Ex2 to Sail/Boat rolls, Athletics(swim), or any roll required while on or in the water.

Middle Miracle

- A Use water to do 1d6+2 external damage to a single enemy within Long Range if water is reasonably available.
- A Protect the Godbound from the effects of water or fire (or AP equal to Piety SLs on all locations, versus water/fire only).
- A Get a vision through a body of water's surface and get an important detail of some approaching danger.
- A Extinguish a wagon-sized fire or smaller.

Greater Miracle

- A Use water to do 1d6+2 internal damage to a single enemy within Long range if water is reasonably available.
- A Protect the Godbound and those he blesses from the effects of water or fire (or AP equal to Piety SLs on all locations, versus water/fire only).
- A Guide a ship or boat through troubled waters; lasts until the next sunset/rise.
- A Extinguish a building-sized fire.
- A Turn aside a giant wave.

Wealth Domain

Money, items of value, prosperity, commerce

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound gains +20 or Ex2 to Commerce rolls.
- A The Godbound gains +20 or Ex2 to Common or Ancient Lore rolls regarding wealth or money.

Middle Miracle

- A The Godbound receives the Intangible Benefits (not Affordability Limit) of a Status of 2 higher than their current amount for the Duration of the scene.
- A The Godbound coincidentally discovers [current Piety Score ×50] silver pieces among their possessions. Requesting this kind of help too often will cause an extra loss of Piety.

Greater Miracle

- A The next 3 Resolve the Godbound uses to increase a skill count as +20.
- A The Godbound receives the Intangible Benefits (not Affordability Limit) of a Status of 4 higher than their current amount for the duration of the scene (max Status of 9).

Wrath Domain

Anger, rage, revenge, dealing damage directly to enemies

Lesser Miracle

- A The Godbound receives +20 to a combat skill for the duration of the conflict.
- A One target suffers a 1-point wound to a random location.

Middle Miracle

- A Cause a target to make an immediate Wound Die roll (choose the most wounded location).
- A 1d4 enemy targets suffer a 2-point wound to a random location.
- A One target suffers one 1d6+2 wound to a random location.
- A A target must roll Willpoweras against Fear. On a failure, foe must Fight, Flee, or Faint for the duration of the scene.
- A 1d4+1 foes must make an opposed Enduranceroll or have their weapons fly out of their hands into an adjacent zone.

Greater Miracle

- A Cause a target to make an immediate Wound Die roll at -5 (choose the most wounded location).
- A Cause all of the Godbound's enemies within Medium Range to make Wound Die rolls (choose the most wounded locations).
- A A single target takes a 1d8+1 wound to a random location.
- A A chosen foe must make an opposed Willpowerroll or break and run as though Fleeing.
- A A Thessian Bear (or geographically appropriate animal) appears and attacks the Godbound's enemies with Ferocity 6.
- A 1d4+1 foes must make an opposed Enduranceroll or have their weapons fly out of their hands and start attacking them next round with a combat skill of 70. The weapons have 3 AP, and are defeated when taking 5+ damage on a single hit. No Combat Maneuvers apply against them.

cHAPTER 16:

the gods of the broken empires

The folk of the Broken Empires recognize six primary deities (although there is a nearly-heretical seventh, The Elements, as well as the almost-assuredly heretical cult of Omnus the One). In general, a person will pay obeisance to a god if that god's domain is likely to affect their endeavors. Foolish is the midwife who chooses not to pray to Ilosia for the healthy delivery of the newborn babe, for example, and farmers across the Empires wisely intone hymns and make offerings to Morrudann to ensure a successful harvest each year.

Gods take different names and forms based on the particular aspect they're embodying, and they take on different guises depending on the race worshipping them. Devona is known to mariners of the Serpent's Teeth Isles as the Sea Bitch, Lady of Ice. But she is known to the Lizardfolk there as Derrevass, the Protector. In the south, the Spinners weave the fabric of the Tapestry; past the Iron Veil in the far north, they are all collectively known as Fate.

Keywords in this Chapter

Ascension Heresy
Celestial Servant
Core Stricture
Embodying Acts

In Dunblaine, Morrudann is appealed to by sailors praying for a calm voyage; in the Westlands, he is called "St Martin, He Who Sows"; to the Angevarrans, he is Morghus the Wanderer; and to the folk of the City-State of Ansharir, Morrudann is known as the goddess Mairay, Bountiful Lady of the Flood.

The Ascension Heresy

Within every faith of the Broken Empires, there lingers a forbidden doubt so widespread and unthinkable that none dare speak it aloud.

It is called theAscension Heresy , and it whispers that the gods are not divine at all, but merely mortal Spellweavers who once sought to master the Tapestry utterly. In their hubris, they escaped the Fraying, but in doing so became something more than mortal, yet less than divine. What endures now are only echoes of glorified wizards--fragments of will and memory sustained and swollen by the ignorant prayers of mortals.

Those who fear this to be true believe that all worship is built upon a lie: Priests and Godbound may cry out to their deities, but they are answered only by the fading remnants of those ancient wizards--beings who, beneath all the pomp and ceremony, are not gods at all, but only the lingering ghosts of mortal ambition.

If so, there is no true salvation, no divine ear to hear the pleas of the faithful--only the echo of humanity, vainly calling back to itself.

chapter 16: the gods of the broken empires

Celestial Servants

Each god has a number of celestial servants -- divine beings who may be invoked directly to act on the god's behalf. Each servant embodies a lesser facet of the god and tends to a single Domain that the god has willingly entrusted to the servant's care. They cannot grant Greater Miracles.

Core Strictures and Embodying Acts

Each god has a set of beliefs and behaviors that their Godbound are expected to live by. If these beliefs, called core strictures, are embodied by the Godbound's actions, as in the examples given in each god's description, the Godbound regains 4d6 Piety (see the Pious Act Table in Chapter 15 - Divine Magic). Each embodying act (like any Pious Act) requires some degree of time, effort, and sacrifice on the part of the Godbound, as determined by the GM.

The Major Deities

utris - God of justice, order, oaths, and maintaining social order. People pray to him when they want fairness or protection from corruption. His priests act as judges and soldiers, enforcing laws and punishing the guilty.

ilosia - Goddess of healing, mercy, and care. People turn to her for health, safe births, and comfort in grief. Her priests are healers and helpers who look after the sick and poor.

morrudann - God of the harvest, nature, and travel. Farmers pray to him for good crops, and travelers ask for safe roads. His priests work the land, bless the seasons, and guide people through life's hardships.

devona - Goddess of the sea, storms, and luck. Sailors, gamblers, Spellweavers, and providers of all kinds call on her when survival depends on luck or nerve. Her priests bless voyages, seal oaths, and warn that anyone who bargains with her must always pay what they owe.

latheriel - God of trade, knowledge, and speech. Merchants and messengers pray to him for fair deals and clear words. His priests oversee markets, record contracts, and act as trusted witnesses in business.

the spinners - Gods of death, fate, and endings. People pray to them for peaceful deaths or closure after loss. Their priests bury the dead, end feuds, and help people let go of the past.

the elements (foundation) - The powers of air, earth, fire, and water. People respect them as the forces that make and change the world. Their priests teach balance, endurance, and living in step with nature.

Other Gods

omnus the one - A mysterious new monotheistic faith out of the southern deserts that claims its deity, Omnus the One, is not only the personification of all other gods, but their divine progenitor as well.

the deep cold gods of the dwarves - Ancient, dour dwarven deities whose esoteric worship is confined to those brazen few who cling to the old ways.

local deities - There are also a host of minor local deities and spirits who are worshipped by various out-of-the-way tribes and wanderers throughout the fringes of the Broken Empires. The details of these beings--and the legitimacy of their divinity--are left up to each GM's imagination.

the forbidden andthe fallen - When need turns to desperation, some folk turn away from the civilized gods and toward darker patrons. The Broken Empires are ancient, and in their long shadows linger unspeakable powers eager to play at godhood. Demons of the Void, deathless horrors, and even stranger abominations whisper to the hopeless from hidden corners, incubating secret cults and silent cabals beneath the notice of the world. Some even play the dangerous game of masquerading as other gods, manipulating and misleading the faithful while pursuing their own foul designs.

the seven faiths

Utris

The Elements

Ilosia

The Spinners

Morrudann

Latheriel

Devona

Utris

The Guardian, the Bladefriend, Justiciar of the Heavens, Settler of Disputes, the Proud Victor, the Skyfather, He Who Sees, the Truthspeaker, the Burning Lady, Tydis the Vengeful, Amenemsou the Protector

domains: Battle, Communication, Protection, Wrath

Utris is the god of justice, vengeance, the social order, and final judgement. Although he is the patron of warriors and magistrates, anyone seeking resolution may call on him. Widows demand truth about their husbands' deaths, disgraced knights seek to reclaim honor, and commoners appeal to him when wronged.

His clergy act as mediators of law and enforcers of justice. Their task is to end disputes, expose lies, and hold the guilty to account. Speaking with a servant of Utris ensures your case will be heard, but does not guarantee mercy.

Utris' name is invoked before duels, executions, and binding oaths. Across the Broken Empires, the phrase "Utris sees" serves as both warning and reassurance.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

Sarahh the Judge (Knowledge) — Warden of lawkeepers, archivists, and witnesses

Balarith the Iron Flame (Earth) — Patron of smiths, masons, and builders

The White Eagle (Air) — Patron of watchmen and scouts

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

A Godbound of Utris earns favor through acts of courage, truth, and judgement, which must be done openly, without deceit or cruelty.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Lie not, even by omission.	Speak truth that endangers you.	Confess a painful secret that could cost allies or safety. Refuse to lie to save your own life. Tell a ruler an unwelcome truth.
Never strike from behind.	Face greater odds in an open challenge.	Confront a stronger foe head-on instead of ambushing them. Announce your presence to an enemy camp before battle. Fight an unfair duel openly rather than from the shadows.
Refuse no righteous duel.	Stand against those who dishonor law or oath.	Accept a challenge from an unjust noble, even knowing defeat is likely. Defend someone falsely accused, taking their punishment if you fail. Demand accountability from those above you.
Shield the helpless, even at cost.	Risk your life or standing to protect another.	Interpose yourself between innocents and harm. Take a wound meant for someone else. Shelter the hunted, knowing it will bring danger to your door.
Hold to your oaths, despite the cost.	Keep your word when it ruins you.	Fulfill a promise that costs your fortune, friendship, or freedom. Honor a vow even when the other side breaks theirs.
Do not kill lightly--but when judgement falls, carry it through.	Deliver justice when no one else will.	Execute a murderer when the law refuses. End a feud by slaying the guilty despite your affection for them. Enforce a verdict knowing it will haunt you.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the flame of truth

- Once every seven days, the Godbound lights a sacred fire and publicly confesses any failures. Others are invited to speak their grievances and seek judgement. Keeping silent about a wrong is a serious offense.

the vigil of ending

- Godbound of Utris are often called to the side of the dying, especially soldiers, rulers, and authority figures. They help settle final disputes and hear final confessions. They guide people to death with honesty and dignity.

the bannerweight ritual

- When a tyrant falls, the Godbound visits the place of downfall and drives a ceremonial blade into the ground. This act marks the end of unjust rule and declares the land judged, consecrating it in the name of Utris. It is expected that the Godbound will establish a place of worship on the site.

beacon rites

- On the annual day of Conjunction (see Chapter 20 - The Setting of the Broken Empires), a beacon is lit from a high place to symbolize Utris's constant watch. Agreements made in view of this flame are believed to carry divine weight.

Displays of Faith

daily devotion

- Draw a line in the dirt with a blade before speaking judgement. Strike a shield at dawn to awaken truth. Recite the deeds of one honored dead each evening.

vestments

- White and red robes or bronze-colored armor marked with the Weighing Shield.

holy symbols

- The symbol of the Weighing Shield, a shield flanked by scales over a lawbook. Some carry a chain that must be lengthened each time they fail to speak the truth.

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Church Hierarchy

Structured, militant, and formalized, the Church of Utris is a military order fused with spiritual authority.

- A Acolyte of the Scales : Novice clergy, training in law and service.
- A Blade-Ward : Ordained priest; acts as judge and battlefield chaplain.
- A Justiciar : Itinerant enforcer, authorized to deliver sentence and verdict.
- A High Arbiter : Regional overseer of legal and ecclesiastical matters.
- A Warden-Militant : Commander of religious military forces.

Atonement Examples

- A Challenge and defeat a corrupt greater champion in a sanctioned duel.
- A Enter the service of a powerful and unjust leader to quietly gather evidence of their crimes.
- A Settle an ancient blood feud, and force peace through duel, diplomacy, or sacrifice.
- A Defend a doomed settlement, pilgrimage, or convoy against overwhelming odds.
- A Journey into hostile territory to reclaim Saint Victris' hammer, a holy relic, from heretics.

Hold to your oaths, despite the cost.

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Ilosia

The Healer, She Who Mends, Bruxara the Merciful, The Planter, Springdaughter, Valora Garden-keeper

domains: Healing, Fertility, Fire, Protection

Ilosia is the goddess of healing, fertility, and devotion. She is called on by midwives, healers, farmers, and anyone facing illness, birth, or grief. Villages depend on her blessing for safe childbirth, healthy communities, and reconciliation after strife.

Her clergy serve as healers and caretakers. They tend the sick, comfort the dying, oversee marriages, and look after orphans. Folk of all stations call on Ilosia to preserve life, mend wounds, or restore bonds.

She is honored with small daily acts of care; in many homes, prayers to Ilosia are as common as lighting the hearth-fire.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

Hugh Forestborn (Nature) — Patron of herbalists, domesticated animals, and pets

Thalys the Peacekeeper (Communication) — Patron of diplomacy, reconciliation, family bonds, and loyal oaths

Myrrin of the Hearth (Earth) — Patron of households, midwives, children, and the hearth

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

A Godbound of Ilosia gains favor through tenderness, sacrifice, and the daily courage of kindness. Every act of care should cost something real: time, comfort, pride, or even safety.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Take no life, save only to protect another.	Protect life, even when it's easier to destroy.	Spare a treacherous enemy who surrenders. Heal someone who has harmed you. Step between fighters to stop bloodshed, even if it puts you at risk. Show mercy when revenge would be safer.
Give aid freely, and without pride.	Give generously without expecting anything in return.	Use your resources or miracles for others with no reward. Donate supplies or coin in secret.
Do not refuse a child in need.	Care for the lost and the young at personal cost.	Rescue an abandoned child or orphaned animal. Take on a dependent who slows your journey. Provide shelter, food, or teaching to someone helpless, even when it burdens your travel or mission.
Leave no wound of flesh or heart untended.	Mend what seems broken beyond repair.	Mediate between feuding families or comrades. Restore a ruined place to life through your effort.
Do not hoard beauty.	Share beauty instead of keeping it.	Gift a beloved item to bring joy to another. Create something beautiful--music, art, poetry--and give it away. Refuse to keep treasures you desire but do not need.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the blooming flame - Each dawn and dusk, the Godbound lights a small flame and offers a blessing. It can be kind words, a song, or a simple act of affection. Any gesture of care is a form of worship to Ilosia.

the rite of embrace - In times of grief or guilt, the Godbound may invite the sorrowful to share in a ritual embrace, dance, or shared meal, invoking Ilosia's warmth.

the festival of love's bounty - During the Feast of Spring Equinox, Godbound bless couples, write poems, and celebrate all forms of beauty, whether physical, emotional, or creative. This is a sacred time for lovers, especially those who have faced rejection or hardship.

the red veil - In times of births or outbreaks of illness, the Godbound wears a red veil and travels from home to home, offering healing and comfort and bringing the Song of Ilosia to adherents.

Displays of Faith

daily devotion - Watering gardens, preparing food for others, or tending the sick. Tender acts are sacred forms of prayer.

vestments - Flowing robes of red, white, and gold, embroidered with flowers, vines, or flames. The Maids of Ilosia, a mendicant sect, often go barefoot to symbolize humility and mindfulness.

holy symbols - Midwife's tools, fire-bowls or candles, or preserved flowers pressed into a locket. Many carry a personal "offering pouch" filled with letters, art, or tokens from those who have received comfort.

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Church Hierarchy

Gentle and nurturing, Ilosia's clergy are counselors, midwives, and celebrants of life's sacred cycles.

- A Mender : Novice; serves in rituals of birth, healing, and union.
- A Heart-Sister / Heart-Brother : Ordained healer and matchmaker.
- A Gracewarden : Regional head overseeing sanctuaries and orphan-houses.
- A Matron/Patron of the Circle : Elder cleric of high influence.

Atonement Examples

- A Reunite two who have sworn never to forgive.
- A Find someone condemned beyond redemption--a murderer, heretic, or traitor--and teach them compassion, witnessing it before their death.
- A Travel with the Scarlet Sisters (a monastic order of itinerant healers) through plague and war, healing without pay and refusing all violence until the sick and dying call you blessed.

Leave no wound of flesh or heart untended.

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Morrudann

The Patient, Saint Martin-Who-Sows, The Harvester, The Old Druid, He Who Stands Alone, Morghus the Wanderer, Mairay Lady of Bounty, Eadthar the Staff, The Beastfriend, Aedan of the Threshold

domains: Earth, Nature, Travel, Movement

Morrudann is the god of the journey, the harvest, roads, and seasons. He is prayed to when crops are planted, when floods threaten, when beasts fall sick, and when a traveler sets foot beyond home.

Morrudann governs life's labor. His is the patience of soil, the duty of those who work the land, and the humility of those who walk it. His followers believe that everything taken must someday be returned, and that honest work is its own reward.

Morrudann is rarely worshipped in temples. His altars stand beneath open sky--at the edge of plowed fields, beside wells and fords, beneath the shade of an old tree, or along the worn stones of a village road. Farmers pour him the first cup of ale after harvest; travelers leave a crust of bread where paths meet. Any place that bears the mark of work or the wear of travel is sacred to him, for Morrudann walks wherever hands have shaped the land and feet have followed its paths.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

The Elder Oak (Wrath) – Patron of druids and those who would avenge nature

Saint Thaliron (Healing) – Patron of wandering healers and ferrymen of the sick

Vormen the Giant (Protection) – Patron of caravan guards and wardens of crossings

Arric the Watcher (Air) – Patron of farmers and those who depend on the weather

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

Morrudann's favor is earned through effort, sacrifice, and humility. Each act of devotion must restore balance, honor life's cycles, or show endurance in the face of hardship.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Take only what you can give back.	Work the soil or mend what the land provides.	Spend days planting or harvesting for a poor village. Rebuild a ruined field, bridge, or home destroyed by neglect. Replant trees in a deforested grove. Return the bones of a lost villager or animal to their home soil.
The path belongs to all.	Roads, rivers, and fields are sacred commons. None may own a passage granted by the world. (This is often a point of contention with landowning nobles.)	Clear blocked paths, rebuild bridges, and aid travelers without asking who they are. Spend a night watching over travelers at a dangerous ford or crossroads.
Harm no creature without need.	Do no violence, even when warranted.	Free a defeated enemy instead of striking the final blow. Condemn hunting for sport despite the consequences. Heal a wounded dangerous beast rather than slaughter it.
Endure the land's trials without complaint.	Seek out natural hardship as sacred labor.	Travel barefoot through mud or snow to bless a distant field. Keep watch through a full storm, guarding livestock or crops from harm. Sleep outdoors for a week to experience the world as it truly is. Refuse magical or divine aid meant to spare you from toil or discomfort.
Do not chase glory.	Give away the fruits of your work.	Harvest or craft something of worth and gift it freely--to strangers, enemies, or the land itself. Lose wealth, comfort, or security as a reminder that all belongs to Morrudann.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the long walk - Every three years, the Godbound sets out with no destination. They mark how the land has changed and carry stories between villages. The journey, lasting at least one month, reminds them that nature is an eternal cycle that must be respected.

blessing of the furrow - At least once a year, the Godbound must help with planting or harvest, in a sacred act of gratitude to the land itself.

the tilling of names - At year's end, the Godbound tills a patch of barren or bloodstained ground and speaks the names of those who died far from home and who could not be returned to their own soil. The field is left unplanted so the land itself may remember them.

Displays of Faith

daily devotion - Clearing paths, marking safe trails, guiding the lost, burying dead animals.

vestments - Worn leathers, patched cloaks, grass-stained robes. Everything they wear speaks of use. Some wear garlands that decay naturally, a symbol of nature's eternal and unyielding cycle.

holy symbols - A walking staff marked with etchings; pouches of collected seeds; river stones etched with runes, each one a reminder of a place the Godbound has walked.

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Church Hierarchy

Decentralized and itinerant, clergy of Morrudann are often solitary, their authority coming more from wisdom and age than from hierarchy.

- A Pacekeeper : Apprentice who travels with a mentor.
- A Harvest-Keeper : Priest who blesses crops and conducts funerals.
- A Walker : Wandering preacher, protector of crossroads, camps, fords, and crossings.
- A Stoneward : Ordained priest who maintains a permanent temple. They bless new homes and ships.
- A Threshold-Warden : Regional, urban-based heads of the church, they arbitrate matters of inheritance, civic burial, and church dogma.

Atonement Examples

- A Track a sacred beast captured for sport, and lead it back to the wild alive, without killing a soul in vengeance.
- A Spend a winter walking the trade roads, eating only what is freely offered, until you have repaid every kindness the land ever gave you.
- A Haul a carved stone from the ruins of Vardesh to the summit of Mount Easthollow by hand, carving the names of every village you pass.
- A Carry the seed of a dead farmer's last crop across a kingdom and plant it at the kingdom's farthest border, so his harvest may live on.

Endure the land's trials without complaint.

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Devona

The Sea Bitch, Unpredictable One, the Protector, She of the Drowned, Lady of Storms, Keeper of Magic, Queen of Bargains, The Laughing Gale, Derrevass the Protector, Memory-Thief

domains: Wrath, Water, Luck, Magic

Devona is the goddess of storms, seas, and risk -- the unpredictable hand of fortune that can bless or destroy without warning. She is worshipped wherever life depends on chance: at sea, in markets, in games of luck, and when harnessing the chaotic power of the Weave. Sailors curse her when the wind turns against them, and call her name again when it changes back. Farmers beg her for rain, but fear her floods. Gamblers pray silently to her before every throw of the dice. Spellweavers call to her when they risk spells that might tear them apart. She is the patron of risk-takers and the desperate, and the only power who listens when all hope has failed.

Devona is feared as much as she is worshipped. She gives freely and takes just as quickly, keeping every bargain in ways mortals rarely expect. Called the Memory-Thief, she is known for demanding strange prices for her favor -- a secret, a truth, or even a precious memory.

Her faith is strongest in places that depend on water or fortune: ports, fishing towns, and river crossings. Shrines to her are built near the sea, or in caverns where the tide can reach. Offerings are personal: coins, hair, blood, or written confessions cast into the water.

Her clergy bless voyages, read dreams, and bear witness to oaths. A promise made "by Devona's tide" is binding. Breaking it risks not only the Sea Bitch's anger but, it is said, the loss of one's very memory. Priests wear salt-stiff robes and veils marked by the sea. Many of her temples are hidden underground: damp, candlelit chambers thick with briny air.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

Donlach the Mariner (Movement) — Patron of sailors, ferrymen, and pilots

The Hand (Protection) — Patron of all those seeking Devona's divine protection

The Soul Cage (Spirit) — Patron of those seeking answers from the dead, the lost, or the forgotten

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

Devona rewards risk, courage, and the keeping of one's word under pressure. Every act of devotion should involve chance, danger, or loss--the greater the risk, the stronger the faith.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Honor your bargains--but twist them if you can.	Keep your word, but find a clever way to turn it to your advantage.	Fulfill a promise in an unexpected way. Meet the letter of an oath while defying its spirit. Trick a cheater into paying their debt twice.
Face the storm instead of fleeing it.	Risk yourself to gain or save others.	Sail into a storm to rescue a crew. Gamble your last coin to feed your village. Stand in for another's sentence. Hold your ground when others run.
Never turn away from chance	Accept the throw of the dice, the deal, or the storm as it comes.	Let a coin flip decide your course. Act on a vision or omen, even if it leads to ruin. Refuse magical protections that guarantee safety.
Let deceit be a teacher, not a sin.	Use trickery to expose truth, cowardice, or greed.	Win a wager through bluff or misdirection. Fool a tyrant into freeing a captive. Use illusion or cunning to protect the weak.
Never scorn chaos or chance	Act on omens and embrace the unpredictable.	Follow a dream's warning into danger. Change course on a whim if the signs point that way. Refuse to rely on certainty or safety.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the tide oath - An oath sworn "by Devona's tide" is absolute. To seal it, both parties cut their palms and wash the blood in saltwater. Breaking the oath invites Devona's curse: loss of cherished or important memories.

the veiling flame - At new moon, the Godbound burns a scroll or token of knowledge as an offering to Devona. This may be a magic item, a True Name, or some secret truth.

the brine vigil - When a great risk looms, the Godbound stands waist-deep in a body of cold water until dawn, naming aloud every fear that tempts them to retreat. Each fear is carried off by the waves for Devona to keep, until the task is done.

Displays of Faith

daily devotion - Each dawn, the Godbound risks something small--tossing a coin into water before making a choice, walking a narrow ledge in high wind, or casting lots to decide which road to take. These acts affirm that life under Devona is a wager.

vestments - Fluid, layered robes in stormy colors--greys, blacks, indigos--often water-stained or ragged. Many bear tattoos of undulating waves upon their palms. Salt is rubbed into the skin and hair to keep the Godbound connected to the sea.

holy symbols - Water-carved driftwood staves, a small glass vial of seawater, a charm carved from a shipwreck's wood, or brine-soaked grimoire pages.

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Church Hierarchy

In Devona's church, rank is earned through risk and survival. The sea itself decides who rises and who is swept away; no priest holds authority for long if fortune turns against them.

- A Saltborn : Initiates who have sworn their first oath "by Devona's tide." They serve in harbor churches or river shrines, guiding travelers through rites of chance and cleansing.
- A Tidekeeper : Ordained priests who maintain coastal or riverbank shrines. They lead burials, commune with drowned spirits, and tend Devona's holy places. A Tidekeeper is expected to risk their life at least once each year in Devona's name, often by voyaging into storms.
- A Stormwarden : Regional high priests or priestesses who interpret the will of Devona through a Tidebook, a prophetic ledger that can only be read when submerged.
- A Tempestos : Regional leaders who command respect across the entire Broken Empires. They maintain the greatest of Devona's temples, built where mighty waterways meet.

Atonement Examples

- A Descend alone into the coastal catacombs of Vel Orren to recover the relic of the Drowned Saint and return it to the surface before the tide turns and floods the complex.
- A Sacrifice your most beloved memory, voluntarily erased by ritual, to Devona's altar, as proof that you will pay any price for her favor.
- A Sail into a storm alone and survive by chance, not skill, proving your faith in Devona.

Face the storm instead of fleeing it.

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Latheriel

The Talebringer, Suteus the Bard, The Bargainer, the Scales

domains: Communication, Travel, Knowledge, Wealth

Latheriel is the god of trade, knowledge, and performance. Merchants call on him for honest bargains, diplomats for safe passage, and bards for inspiration. His followers believe that stories and silver both gain value when exchanged.

His clergy oversee markets, libraries, and theaters. They settle disputes with rhetoric, record debts and oaths, and act as trusted witnesses to contracts. Their signatures and seals carry real weight in courts across the Broken Empires.

Latheriel is honored in every marketplace and crossroads where people gather to speak or trade. Invoking his name sanctifies an exchange of money, words, or art.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

Achiel Goldenhair (Fire) - Patron of poets, courtesans, and inspirers of passion

Vailis the Dancer On The World (Movement) - Patron of wanderers, teachers, and diplomats

Eryndor the Harmonious (Protection) - Patron of peacemakers

Caurin the Cupbearer (Fertility) - Patron of feasts, taverns, and communal joy

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

Latheriel's favor grows through fair trade, clever words, and the open flow of stories, silver, and truth. His followers keep commerce and culture alive by dealing honestly, speaking well, and keeping art and knowledge accessible.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Preserve and pass on stories.	Collect and share a tale that might otherwise be lost.	Record a dying soldier's last story. Pay a bard to learn a local song and perform it in another town. Copy a ledger, play, or map before it's destroyed.
Barter fairly, speak wisely.	Make a deal that benefits all sides--or expose one that cheats.	Negotiate peace between rivals. Refuse an exploitative trade. Correct a market swindle with words, not blades.
Deceive only with wit and purpose.	If you must lie, make it worth remembering.	Spin a clever tale or disguise the truth to teach, protect, or entertain. Fool the proud to humble them, or use performance to spare someone needless pain.
Do not hoard wealth or knowledge.	Ensure wealth, goods, or knowledge continue to circulate.	Fund a new guild hall, pay a fair wage to those cheated, or teach a trade secret to a new apprentice. Never let riches or lore gather dust.
Keep a record of debts owed and repaid.	Repay debts or hold others to their word.	Travel across a province to return an overpaid coin. Call in an old favor at the right moment. Enforce a broken contract in public view.
Respect languages and dialects.	Preserve and honor the languages of others.	Learn a local dialect and use it openly. Translate a lost document. Defend someone mocked for their accent or speech.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the circuit of silver words

- Once a year, the Godbound travels through unfamiliar places, trading stories for coin, and coin for stories. Each tale must be performed through music, acting, dance, drawing, or any form of art.

the ledgermark offering

- Latheriel honors what is passed on and recorded. At each solstice, the Godbound must count what they've gained--money, knowledge, or reputation--and give a portion to a church, archive, or court. The greater the portion, the greater the Piety gained.

the guild of honest tongues

- In towns and trade routes, Godbound must support or create spaces where arguments are settled through speech instead of violence. This can be satire, performance, or debate as long as it is done in Latheriel's name.

the golden story rite

- When a negotiation is tense, the Godbound can begin with a well-chosen fable that reflects the situation. If both sides agree on its meaning, any deal made afterward is considered sacred--and breaking it invites misfortune. (This can be a Performance, Wit, or Protocol roll at the beginning of a Competitive Social Encounter; every 2 SLs generated gives a 1 SL head start towards the Victory Condition.)

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Displays of Faith

daily devotion - Godbound of Latheriel begin each day with acts of mindful exchange: writing a proverb, trading a small item, or performing a brief tale or song, even if only for themselves.

vestments - Their garments are bright and colorful, adorned with flowing cloaks and golden jewelry. Many wear belts hung with conspicuously ornate coin purses, believing that only a fool would rob a servant of The Bargainer.

holy symbols - Common holy symbols include a weighted stylus, a wood or stringed instrument, or trade seals from faraway cities. Some clergy carry ledgers of past transactions, or collections of tales and songs from a lifetime of travel.

Church Hierarchy

Latheriel's priests are merchants, diplomats, and story-weavers who understand that a well-told tale can often move coins faster--and certainly safer--than a well-swung sword.

- A Ledgerling : Initiates who learn the sacred songs of barter and oath. They collect stories and songs as offerings.
- A Versewright : Ordained priests whose words seal bargains. Their signature carries legal weight across the Broken Empires.
- A Cantor : Senior clergy skilled in speech and song. They settle disputes with performance, and their voice is said to unmask lies.
- A Chancellor of the Masked Market : Overseers of a temple-bazaar, where trade, law, and performance mix.

Atonement Examples

- A Recover the writings or instrument of a silenced bard, heretic, or scribe, and see their story performed or read aloud once more.
- A Travel to the Monastery of Laerlann na Goath on Kyre without spending a single coin of your own, relying only on barter, wit, and story for the journey.
- A Earn a great profit through clever bargaining or daring commerce, then publicly donate every coin to rebuild a ruined market or fund a school of speech.

Preserve and pass on stories.

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The Spinners

The Black Reapers, Holder of the Strands, Fate, The Old Crones, The Disinterested, Keeper of the Undead, Bringers of Sleep, Preservers of Knowledge, Witnesses of the Third Eye, Ashura the Sand Seeress

domains: Curse, Dreams, Knowledge, Spirit

The Spinners are the keepers of fate, death, and endings. They are invoked at funerals, by families seeking closure, mourners dealing with grievous loss, and those troubled with restless spirits. Most avoid them unless necessity demands, for the Spinners bring little comfort; yet necessity always and inevitably does demand their presence, for death comes for all beings, eventually.

Their clergy preside over burials, guide dreams and visions, and deal with the undead when they rise. Most people fear their presence, for it means that something--someone--is about to end. But all know their work is necessary.

Shrines to the Spinners are built in graveyards, ruins, and crossroads--anywhere the boundary between the living and the dead thins. Offerings are simple: a lock of hair, a handful of ash, or a meaningful token from the departed.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

Thur'zaan the Unsleeping (Magic) - Patron of necromancers and the thinking undead

The Hourglass (Wrath) - Patron of executioners, assassins, and those seeking vengeance

Kalith the Wardweaver (Protection) - Patron of gravediggers and those who appeal to the night

Onna the Ash-Keeper (Fertility) - Patron of ancestors, lineage, and family continuity

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

The Spinners reward those who bring things to their rightful end--be they lives, memories, grudges, or lies. Their Godbound earn favor by helping others accept loss, finishing what's left undone, and refusing to cling to what's already gone.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Weep not for what ends.	Bring a restless soul or doomed thing to its rightful end, even if it pains you.	Put an undead spirit to rest. Destroy an item tied to your past. End a comrade's suffering when no one else will.
Do not act in revenge.	Leave vengeance in fate's hands rather than your own.	Leave a captured enemy to their fate rather than executing them yourself. Return a stolen heirloom to the community rather than exacting blood for it. Refuse to perform a revenge rite, even when doing so would win you honor.
Embrace the dream and the vision.	Accept or deliver prophetic dreams.	Act on a troubling dream. Carry a vision's message to its rightful recipient. Spend a night in a haunted place to understand what it wants.
Leave no legacy of power.	Give up influence or recognition.	Step down from leadership willingly. Refuse honors or reward. Create a large tapestry with images of the truth of your life and make a gift of it to someone who wishes you harm.
Do not abandon the unfinished.	Complete unfinished duties or end broken oaths.	Complete a fallen ally's quest. Destroy a creation left incomplete. Revisit a failed duty, relationship, or goal, and bring it to its final resolution.
Let decay take its course.	Allow transformation or decay to take its course.	Tear down a crumbling structure instead of rebuilding it. Let an old friendship die cleanly. Help a town abandon an unsalvageable place.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the thread offering

- At dusk on the first day of each month, the Godbound cuts a single thread from their robe and buries it somewhere forgotten--a ruined altar, an overgrown crossroads, an abandoned graveyard. Over time, their original garment falls to pieces, symbolizing their devotion to the natural unraveling of all things.

the dreamchain vigil

- Once a year, the Godbound crafts a set of "dream tokens"--carved stones or bones--each representing their dreams across seven nights. On the final night, they place the tokens in a circle and sleep inside it, asking the Spinners to send a dream meant for someone else. The vision is written down, sealed, and kept unread until fate reveals who it's meant for.

the curse without cause

- Once each season, the Godbound must speak a curse into the wind. It must have no target, no reason, and no explanation. The words should be sincere and spoken as if meant. The curse doesn't take direct effect--but it's believed to loosen the Weave, inviting unraveling somewhere in the world. Some believe this rite contributed to the Grey Wailing that felled the Old Vestrian Empire, and that it may one day bring final death upon the Broken Empires, as well...

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Displays of Faith

daily devotion - The esoteric Godbound of the Spinners meditate among graves, observe deathly silences as holy, and interpret the small patterns of decay as omens.

vestments - Layered robes of black and grey stitched on the inside with spiralling funerary runes. Veils or masks are common, as are golden adornments to hair and belt.

holy symbols - Finger bones carved with names, hourglasses filled with black sand, urns of ash, or oblong pendants of the Third Eye.

Church Hierarchy

Mysterious and half-shadowed, the Spinner church keeps its rites and rituals a guarded secret, known only to the initiated.

- A Threadling : Initiate who has only just entered the Spinner's rites.
- A Weaver-in-Waiting : Acolyte learning to guide dreams and read fate.
- A Dream-Keeper : Full priests who guide spirits, preside over burials, and protect the boundary between life and death.
- A High Weaver : High priest or mistress of a Spinner temple. They decide when something or someone must meet their end.

Atonement Examples

- A Recover a forbidden scripture from the catacombs of Ashmere, commit every word to memory, and burn the original beneath a new moon.
- A Seek out a spirit or revenant that has defied death for centuries and end it through battle or sacred rite, alone.
- A Find a person marked by prophecy and ensure they never fulfill it, whether by convincing them to abandon the path, making the prophecy itself moot, or ending their life.

Let decay take its course.

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The Elements

Foundation, The Four, The Primal Source

domains: Air, Earth, Fire, Water

The Elements are not gods in the usual sense. They are the four primeval forces that shape the world. Together, they are called Foundation, the source from which all life, thought, and matter arise. Worshipping them is less about seeking favor than it is about finding balance with the natural world.

The faithful believe that everything in creation--flesh, stone, and even magic--comes from the constant motion between wind, fire, earth, and water. The Elements do not punish or reward; they simply are. Followers accept their cycles of growth, decay, and renewal without fear or desire for control.

Temples to Foundation are rare. Worship takes place in natural places where the forces meet: a cliff that faces the wind, a sparkling spring within a cave, a place where ash meets sea foam. Elemental priests do not proselytize, and admission into their ranks requires the supplicant to endure grueling tests involving all four elements.

Celestial Servants and their Domain

The Elements have no Celestial Servants. As a result of the intense focus (and limitations) that worship of these gods brings, any Piety roll made by a Godbound of the Elements enjoys a +10 bonus. (This does not affect the amount of the Godbound's Piety--only the roll. For example, a Piety of 57 rolls as though it is 67.)

Core Strictures & Embodying Acts

To serve the Elements is to align rather than command. Godbound of Foundation show devotion by enduring the natural world instead of resisting it, and by restoring balance where mortals have broken it.

Core Stricture	Embodying Act	Examples
Do not command the Elements--move in harmony with them.	Accept the natural world's will, even when it frustrates your own.	Delay a journey until the storm subsides, or walk directly into it if it rises on your path. Refuse shelter during harsh weather. When traveling, follow the natural course of a river, forest line, or mountain range, though it takes you miles out of your way.
Endure the Four.	Expose yourself to the elements without protection or complaint.	Walk barefoot for a day. Sleep exposed to rain or snow. Cross a desert without shelter.
All rivers return to their source.	Return what is taken, repair what is spoiled, or dissolve what no longer belongs.	Bury the dead with your own hands where they fell, no matter who they were. Tear down a building to give its stones back to the earth. Return looted relics to their resting place. Burn an excess harvest or hoarded treasure to balance the cycle.
Teach through example, not argument.	Act in silence so others may see what faith looks like.	Demonstrate endurance by staying awake through a storm while others rest. Spend a week in silence among others, guiding only through gesture and deed.
Restore balance through sacrifice.	Destroy something valuable to restore balance.	Participate in the Flame Spiral Rite (see below). Shatter a valuable weapon that's brought too much harm. Cast a personal heirloom into the sea.

Godbound Rites & Practices

the breath cycle

- A daily ritual of slow, patterned breathing performed while facing the wind or standing beneath the open sky. It teaches surrender to change and the rhythm of the world's movement. Still air during the rite is seen as a sign of change to come.

the stone fast

- Held once per year, the practitioner descends into a cave or earthen chamber to fast in total silence and darkness for a full cycle of the moon. It teaches endurance and stillness. Many return with revelations; some never emerge.

the flame spiral

- Performed at night, the practitioner walks a spiral of lit braziers while chanting in rhythm with the fire. At the center, they cast a cherished object into the flames, symbolizing transformation and release.

the water path

- Alone, the practitioner immerses themselves in a cold, flowing stream and remains until they understand what must be let go. Leaving the water in silence completes the rite, as the stream carries the burden away.

the trial of the four

- One who wishes to join the cult of Foundation must first pass this rigorous test. The details are spoken of only among the Aligned, but it is known that each element is invoked through a symbolic ordeal: the heat of fire, the pressure of stone, the pull of water, and the absence of air. The trial is not meant to break the body, but to test the will's ability to surrender without panic, and to endure without resistance. The trial may take a day or a season, depending on the individual and the region. Those who emerge become Aligned, marked by the Four and trusted to carry the rites forward.

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Displays of Faith

daily devotion - Each morning begins with the Breath Cycle rite. Godbound also observe elemental omens in the shape of clouds, the feel of dust, the taste of ash, and the movement of rivers.

vestments - Layered robes of faded blue, red, green, and grey, often weathered or scorched. Many wear cords or beads marked for each element.

holy symbols - Symbols vary by element: a gemstone with a meaningful fracture, a feather burned black, a vial of glacial meltwater. Most Godbound carry symbols of all four Elements.

Church Hierarchy

Foundation's church uses the following titles:

- A Attuned : Those who approach Foundation but have not yet undergone the Trial of the Four. They may observe rites but cannot speak in them.
- A Aligned : Devotees who have survived the trials and now guide others. Most adherents of Foundation remain at this level their entire lives.
- A Deepbound : Those rare few who have undergone a second, more personal trial within each element--often facing death--and returned changed. Their voices are measured, their presence unsettling. Communities may send offerings to secure their wisdom and guidance.
- A Boundless : Esoteric and distant, the Boundless are those who have walked fully into the Four and emerged with total enlightenment. They do not speak; they do not lead; they simply are. No one knows how many Boundless exist, or whether they serve Foundation, or have become one with it.

Atonement examples

- A Carry a single sacred flame across wild or hostile lands without letting it die; if it does, the journey must begin anew.
- A At Mount Vehlastra's peak, where storm, flame, wind, and stone devour each other, survive until dawn and collect a handful of solid mist to dissolve in the tide below.
- A Descend alone into a living cavern and seal the entrance behind you; for three days, endure the dark without food, flame, or tool, and emerge only when the earth itself presents a way out.

Do not command the Elements.
Move in harmony with them.

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Omnus the One - The New God

There is a new religion recently emerged from the vastnesses of the Fanged Desert: the church of Omnus the One. His adherents believe that all gods are merely aspects of Omnus; they are all his faces. Most clergy of the accepted faiths consider this religion deeply heretical, but few in the wider Broken Empires know much of Omnus or his cultists at all. But no doubt the church of Omnus will come marching out of the deep deserts one day, and what effect that will have no one can tell...

This new god out of the shifting sands and forgotten tomb-cities of the southern desert is intended to be a mystery, whose motivations--or even very existence--are largely unknown to the wider world. What this new religion looks like, what their clergy espouses, and how the group will ultimately change the religious fabric of the Broken Empires is left up to you.

The Deep Cold Gods of Mountainholme

These are a group of entities of unknown number believed to be the progenitors of the Dwarven race. They answer no prayers and grant no miracles--at least not by any standard a contemporary God-bound would recognize--but they are included here among the list of gods, nonetheless.

The Deep Cold Gods are not officially worshipped by the dwarves--their veneration has been outlawed by the dwarven Sky-priests, and those who still keep the ways of the Deep Cold Gods do so in secret--but they are still respected, and more than a little feared. The dwarves believe that these beings reside in the Void of Night, where utter silence reigns. As such, those hidden Dwarven ceremonies to the Cold Ones involve ritualistic silence, and dwarves who are born unable to speak are revered as Silent Ones. The zealous Sky-priests, when discovering a mute Silent One child, insist on exiling them to the World Below (the dwarven term for the earth-bound kingdoms of Men), as they are reminders of the Before Time: the time before the stoneships, a time the Sky-priests would much rather banish from history. "The past is filled with fire," the Sky-priests say, "and staring into it will incinerate the future." What role the Deep Cold Gods had in that "fire" is lost to history, but many dwarves secretly believe the Cold Ones are still listening, and will one day return.

Mountainholme

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cHAPTER 17:

gamemastering the broken empires

The Roleplaying Game has been around in its current form for (at the time of writing) over 50 years. During those years, the game has survived multiple evolutions, offshoots, and parallel developments. It has risen to the height of popularity, and fallen back into obscurity--only to suddenly rise again. It has been a wild ride.

It has seldom been a smooth one. Since the beginning, players and GMs alike have endlessly bickered over every conceivable aspect of the game and its rules--even over what the very definition of a roleplaying game is. Suffice to say that there is no end of opinions on the "correct" way to play.

Of course, there is no One True Way to play roleplaying games. Everyone's table is different, everyone wants different experiences out of their games, and everyone has an opinion. Every game system is different, but beyond that, the focus is different from one ruleset to the next. Certain games try very hard to curate a particular type of experience. This game is no different.

Keywords in this Chapter

Adventure Site
Bottlenecks
Death and New PCs
Dramatic Structure
Environmental Zone Features
Obstacles
Pace
Return On Time Invested (ROTI)
Session Zero
Success With A Cost
Streamlining the Game
T.U.N.I.C.
Travel Event Creation

The following section is not a general tutorial on how to be a Gamemaster; this book assumes you already have some experience in that. Rather, it is a collection of tools and philosophies--mini-essays, really--about what I consider to be important when running TBE. This game is trying to bring a specific kind of experience to your table, and this section will talk about how to do that. It represents much of what I have learned over the years about making my games more fun for both me and my players. It is by no means the Be All And End All of GMing advice, but it does illustrate the kind of game I like to run. It will hopefully be a useful perspective on how to approach a goal-focused game like this.

chapter 17: gamemastering the broken empires

the heart of the game

Dramatic Fantasy Sim-Lite Roleplaying?

The Broken Empires RPG is a dramatic fantasy sim-lite roleplaying game. What does this mean exactly, and how does this affect the intended play style? Let's look at each term on its own.

dramatic. All role-playing games, and in fact, all drama ever made, are about a character wanting something, and then making a choice to overcome the obstacle in his way in order to get what he wants. So too is it with the Player Characters. They must want something, or else there is no drama. They must want to push on the world, and when they do, the world pushes back. This creates the cycle of drama: action/reaction. The only way to advance your character in this game is by pursuing your goals. A goal must have something at stake: that which is at risk of being lost (or standing to be gained) from the character's actions. Either the character has to have something tangible to gain by pursuing the goal, or they have to have something tangible to lose by not pursuing the goal. Obstacles presented in the session should ideally challenge the characters' goals. Without goals, there is no conflict; without conflict, there is no game.

fantasy is the genre of the game. The world of the Broken Empires is Eurocentric and medievalist, with flavors of Arabia, ancient Egypt, and medieval-era central Asia. Despite containing magic, monsters, and adventure, it is still familiar to us--it has a frame of reference that allows us to identify with its cultures and people, its landscapes and seasons. Gravity still works here much as it does on Earth. Water flows downhill. Human emotions are the same here as they are in our own world. And while there are strange powers, interfering gods, and otherworldly forces at work in the Broken Empires, by default, the world is on the "low fantasy" side of things. This is a setting where magic is known to few, and practiced by fewer. Kingdoms are peopled mostly with *Homo sapiens*, and monstrous humanoids civilly wandering the streets of a major city are a rare sight indeed. Not every countryside hilltop conceals a lich's tomb, nor do mad wizards routinely build labyrinthine dungeons and inexplicably populate them with treasure-hoarding monsters.

Unless, of course, in your version of the Broken Empires, they do. Adventure comes in many forms, and you are free to make this world your own. The fantastical elements of the genre can be dialed up or down as the GM needs, but whether low or high fantasy, remember that the world must always be internally consistent. It must never break its established setting rules, unless there is a very good explanation (indeed, such explanations can fuel interesting new adventures!)

If the players have a strong frame of reference, it helps them understand the world in which their characters exist. If they don't understand the setting, or if the setting is inconsistent and radically switches between one set of natural laws and another, they cannot make meaningful choices. Whatever changes you make to the world, make sure your players can still recognize it when you're through.

sim-lite. Every game exists on a series of spectrums, one of which is "detail of outcome versus speed of resolution". A simulationist game--these terms have been debated for years within the RPG community, and I unapologetically present my own interpretation here--concerns itself with simulating the details of a fantasy world in a believable way, and so falls closer to the detail end of the spectrum. A rules-light game, which is less interested in the granularity of representing a believable world (or verisimilitude, if you will), falls closer to the speedy resolution end. TBE tries to find a balance that is satisfying to my particular tastes, a philosophy I call Sim-Lite: plotting the system firmly on the detailed resolution side of the spectrum, but then pulling it back a bit towards the center, facilitating maximum detail with a reasonable speed of play.

For example, we do not merely do 5 hit points of consequence-free damage when we hit a foe. Instead, we cause a 3-point slashing wound in the right forearm, causing them to drop their sword. But what about whether the blow was cutting or stabbing, and whether the particular piece of armor in that hit location has greater or lesser protection versus that mode of attack? Here is where design preferences come in: for me, that level of distinction would be a step too far along the "detail" spectrum, as it slows down play, yet gives what I consider to be little value. In designing games, I often use the term "ROTI", or "Return On Time Invested". That's a little like the currently fashionable phrase, "The juice ain't worth the squeeze", and just means that some details aren't worth the time it takes to implement them. Others, of course, will disagree; hence, the spectrum.

But regardless of the exact granularity of these details, they are not meaningless. They show specific consequences arising from specific actions. The mechanics take a little longer to resolve--certainly, there are more things to track, like hit location, reductive armor pieces, and individual wounds--but they provide vital information that paints the picture for the players. The Sim-Lite game respects and values that trade-off.

The mechanics take a little longer to resolve--certainly, there are more things to track, like hit location, reductive armor pieces, and individual wounds--but they provide vital information that paints the picture for the players. The Sim-Lite game respects and values that trade-off.

roleplaying game. Both of these words are of equal importance to this term. Roleplaying is to assume the role of a character in a fantasy world and make decisions that the player thinks that character would make in those circumstances. This is also known as character immersion (another "controversial" term to which I affix my own interpretation). In this game, we attempt to immerse ourselves in our characters to try to experience the world through their eyes. And yes, most of the time we speak from the first-person perspective ("I attack the orc" versus "My character attacks the orc"), but we don't have to: merely describing what our characters say still focuses us on their intentions. So, playing the role and inhabiting the character in a game of "let's pretend" is a huge part of the experience.

However, game is just as important. This isn't story time: we don't simply sit around and lob our internally-crafted backstories at each other, self-indulgently exploring the inner lives of our characters and decreeing outcomes by fiat. No, we are here to pursue a character's goals by taking action! We use the game's rules and roll dice--dice that represent chaos, and all the unknown factors we can't possibly account for--to see if our characters overcome obstacles and get what they want. The game's ruleset is the structure upon which we truly come to know our characters; it is the crucible in which epic RPG sessions are forged. Our characters' fates teeter at the whims of the unfeeling, uncaring dice. Learn to revel in their judgement!

General Approaches to TBE

Some aspects of The Broken Empires RPG system apply concrete rules to situations that most games either leave out or resolve with one or two dice rolls. This is especially true of the Social and Travel rules. In testing and teaching the system, I have found there is a predictable progression as the GM and players work their way toward system mastery.

As always, your previous experience and learning style may alter this slightly, but I felt it was useful to walk you through the steps to expect, even if it's just so you know you're not alone.

1. Initial Reading . A quick skim will only get you so far--the rules differ from most systems enough that a full read is essential. Start with a light overview, then read the Core Mechanics, Combat, Travel, and Intrigue chapters carefully before your first session. If you have players who want to be Spellweavers or Godbound, going over the basics of Weave Magic and Divine Magic is a must.

2. First-time Playthrough . The first time using the rules is going to proceed slowly. This is a natural part of learning something new. Focus on making sure everyone understands their options and how they can engage with the rules through their roleplaying. Even so, this may lead to...

3. Feeling Like This is Too Procedural . Depending on the group, the first few times using each sub-system will probably feel like the rules are getting in the way. I encourage you to give them a chance and push through. It's worth it!

4. Mastery . The Broken Empires RPG rules are relatively complex, but that complexity has been carefully balanced to give the best possible return on the time you invest (the ROTI). Once you push through the challenges and internalize the basics, the game will start to flow, the nuances will present themselves, and the processes will become second nature. At that point, I'm confident you'll find the same thing I have--that these rules provide excellent tools to capture the tense, dramatic moments we all crave in our games, and in far more than just combat situations.

the shape of play

"What do you do?"

This is the most important question you can ask your players, and you should be asking it all the time. The players' choices need to drive the game.

We've touched on this idea earlier, but it is so crucial, I'll state it again: the Player Characters need to do something. They take action and move towards their goals by pushing on the world, and the world (played by you) pushes back by throwing new obstacles in front of them, which in turn forces them to take further action, and on and on and on. This is the game.

When the players pursue their characters' goals, it keeps the game focused. If the players in TBE are always driving toward their characters' goals, they'll never get bored or sidetracked. The adventures the GM cooks up should be heavily inspired by those goals--in fact, the characters' goals are a kind of roadmap to show the GM what the players are interested in, where to take the adventure, and what kind of obstacles to throw in their way.

Give Them Enough to Go On

There is a crucial aspect to all of this: always make sure the players have enough information to make meaningful decisions. Describe, describe, describe (but only what the characters would logically be able to perceive). Don't hold back crucial details simply for "dramatic effect" or to keep them "in suspense". If there's something that the characters would know, then the players need to know it. Communicate it to your group as efficiently as possible. The players cannot make meaningful choices if they are working on bad or incomplete information. In the vast majority of cases, it's better to give them too much information than not enough.

Don't "Tell a Story"

Plot--the sequence of events in a story--is a tool for authors and directors. A GM is neither, although you'll use certain techniques of both. You are not a "storyteller". The act of "telling" a story implies

one person knowing the details of a preordained plot and imparting it to passive listeners. That is not at all what a GM's job is. What's more, that idea diminishes the true potential of what a roleplaying game can be for its participants.

A GM's job is to have the world react honestly and believably to the character's actions, and to challenge their goals by throwing obstacles in their way. The players drive the game--not you.

If you plan a "story", you'll be tempted to force it to come to pass--regardless of the players' actions. That leads to a syndrome called "railroading", where no matter what the players do, their choices always lead to the result that you, the Master Plotter, have predetermined. This is, most of the time, ineffective GMing. The "story" shouldn't be known to anyone--including the GM--until after the session is over.

But while an RPG adventure should not be structured as a prefabricated story, there is no denying that a story necessarily emergesfrom the exploits of the Player Characters. The story is simply those events that transpired as a result of the characters' choices.

So don't plan stories--let them instead emerge through the interplay of the PCs and the world. Understand your PCs' goals and develop obstacles to throw in their way. The very act of characters overcoming the obstacles in their way becomesthe story.

If those obstacles are NPCs, give them clear agendas. Know what they want, and how they intend to get it. Imagine how the Player Characters might interfere with those agendas, and then provide ample opportunities for them to do so. Design some NPC agendas to conflict with the PCs' goals, and allow that to happen at a moment that will cause the most tension for the players.

Prepare situations, not set pieces. Don't prepare solutions to problems. If you do, you will be tempted to either ignore the players' solutions or to inadvertently lead them towards your own preferred solution. This is all too easy to do without even knowing you're doing it, and every time you do, it robs the players of their agency.

None of this, however, means we can't borrow from the tools of drama, as described below.

The Dramatic Structure

While GMs are neither directors nor authors, the tools of drama can still be enormously useful when trying to create a satisfying gaming experience. Although "story" shouldn't be the primary concern for a GM, knowing basic dramatic structure will help you when considering the world's responsesto PC actions.

There is something inherently satisfying about having a beginning, middle, and end to our characters' adventures. It is ingrained in the human psyche to appreciate such structure, so it would be foolish to ignore it. You can use the tools of drama to structure sessions, adventures, or even whole campaigns, and none of it requires the dreaded "railroading".

There is a reason why all good stories ever told have very similar elements: there is a beginning (the setup), a middle (the action), and an end (the resolution). But how do you ensure your RPG adventures have a beginning, middle, and end if you don't impose a prewritten story on them? How do you know what the end is if you haven't written it beforehand?

You don't know the ending--and you shouldn't. An ending is just a big solution to a problem, and your job as GM is to come up with problems, not solutions. You begin by setting up the world and the forces within it that the PCs may come into conflict with. Their choices will inform the middle--the rising action--as those forces respond to the characters' actions. It is your job to portray those forces honestly and logically. They should respond to the PCs in a manner that makes sense. The players shouldn't necessarily be able to intuit the methods and machinations of their adversaries while they are unfolding, but in hindsight, everything should be clear. The ending belongs solely to the players; it is their job to find a solution, not yours. Throw obstacles in their way, and they'll figure out a way around those obstacles. Let's look deeper at this process.

The Beginning

The beginning is straightforward. The players have their characters, who each have strong goals (in TBE, this is crucial; see the Goals chapter for information on crafting effective PC goals). They exist in a world that is clearly defined, with immediately obvious (and maybe not so obvious) friends and foes, allies and enemies. This is the setup: we know what the PCs want, we have a sense of what they're up against; now it is up to them to decide how to go about getting it. Your job is to lay out the world before them logically and thoroughly, giving them opportunities and options to pursue their goals in whatever manner they see fit. Come up with and present tantalizing hooks that tie into their goals, suggest ways forward, and spur the PCs into taking action.

The Middle

The process of them setting out to get what they want, of achieving their goals, is the middle: the rising action. They take steps to further their goals, and the world responds, throwing new obstacles in their path. The PCs must confront and overcome those obstacles, which forces them to make new choices, which causes the world to respond with even steeper obstacles, and on and on, until the tension reaches a crescendo: the PCs have come through many trials, and are finally at the very brink of getting what they want, whether that's to mark a gain or avoid a loss.

The Ending

Now comes the ending: the moment to which all of these obstacles and choices have logically led. This is the final conflict: the PCs must resolve the problems that were set up at the beginning and deal with the consequences of the choices they made in the middle. If you have portrayed the world logically and honestly, if you have organically connected unfolding events to the characters' goals, and if they have made good faith efforts to pursue those goals, the ending will flow naturally from the beginning and middle and will feel satisfying. Will they succeed or fail? Live or die? Their actions--and the dice--will decide.

Then repeat for the next adventure: action taken to overcome obstacles creates future obstacles which demand further action.

Pace

Understanding dramatic structure is great, but what is of equal importance is having a sense of pace in your game: the forward momentum of events, and how quickly you as the GM move from one moment to the next.

A GM is not a director, but you can frame scenes like one, in that you choose which part of the moment to focus on and bring to the players' attention. Don't waste time and energy on dull non-events, minutiae of day-to-day living, or meaningless details. Get right to the heart of the action and keep things moving. Understand that "action" doesn't mean a violent confrontation or chase--it is simply a moment where the PCs must make a choice and overcome an obstacle.

The "buying equipment" scene can be a classic pace killer. If the party arrives in town looking to sell gear, there is probably no need to give a lengthy description of the supply store or the merchant within, nor is there a need to ask how the players approach the shop, or to have them haggle over every single transaction. unless, of course, it is related to a character's goal. Is one of the PC's looking to gain as much silver as they can to pay off a known crime lord? Or is the party in possession of a treasure item that this particular merchant has a burning and unusual interest in possessing? Now the action becomes about the PC pursuing their goal to accumulate coin, or investigating an NPC's agenda. Now they have the choice to haggle with the merchant using the Commerceskill, or to even get drawn into a full Social Encounter, if the stakes are high enough.

If, however, no character has any such goal-related interest in the procurement of goods and services, or there is no interesting NPC agenda to interact with a character's goals, then just get the transaction over with and use a director's technique to cut to the next "scene", which should set up the next moment of action--the next decision

point. Keep the forward momentum--the pace--going. Know when to "cut away" to the next scene, and remember that short, tight scenes are almost always better than longer, drawn-out ones. (Just make sure you're not ending the scene before the players actually get to do what they want to do--don't sacrifice player agency on the altar of pace.)

The player's choices drive the game, but the GM sets the pace. And the pace shouldn't always be fast. Don't think that just because your job is to throw obstacles in their way, that you should be relentlessly doing so. Part of understanding pace is understanding when to pause the action and let the players catch their breath. Sometimes, a meaningful scene is the characters merely talking to each other at the campfire, or stopping to marvel at a breathtaking mountain lake after emerging from a three-day trek through a dark tunnel. Not every scene needs to be a life-or-death situation. High-octane chases and lethal sword fights are less effective if they erupt every ten minutes. Consider such challenges like a strong spice in a meal: overdo it, and it quickly becomes unpalatable.

T.U.N.I.C.

Ben Milton of the YouTube channel Questing Beast has a great methodology for pacing games, encapsulated in the acronym T.U.N.I.C., which stands for "Time Until Next Impactful Choice". TBE(and every RPG, really) is all about the choices the players make. It is our job as GMs to provide them with fuel for those choices. A GM should always be thinking, "What's the next logical moment where I can present an obstacle to the PCs' goals, and give them a choice to make?" If you always keep that in mind, then pacing events becomes almost reflexive. Just pay attention to the players, to what they are saying and doing. Always be looking for how they are pushing on the world or against some NPC's agenda. What logical action can the world take in this moment to push back against them and force them to make a choice?

A key word here is logical Don't force obstacles where none should exist. Every obstacle, every choice the players must make, should arise logically out of the events and circumstances surrounding them. Bandits bursting in with crossbows certainly forces the PCs to act, but if those bandits come out of literally nowhere and are not connected to anything that has happened before, it's probably going to feel disruptive and arbitrary.

Starting and Ending a Scene

A GM's job isn't to be an author, but sometimes understanding a writer's techniques can be valuable. There's a useful old trick in screenwriting: "Come in late and get out early". This means that a scene should start in the middle of the interesting bits and end by leaving us wanting more. (This is related to the concept of in media res, or starting a scene "in the middle of the action", which is in itself a very useful pacing tool, and a great way to start an adventure.) For our purposes, a scene should start as close as possible to a spot where the characters must make a decision--get the players taking action as soon as possible!--and it should end at a moment of tension (either resolution or cliffhanger, depending on the context).

If you can, start a scene at a point where the PCs must make a choice and take action. What that starting point is, of course, will be based largely on their goals and what's at stake.

Imagine that after days of weary travel, the party has arrived at a lord's castle to take part in a noble's council. You as the GM know that there is danger in this place, and you want to start the scene with the players having an immediate opportunity to get into it. You narrate away all the minutiae of the PCs stabling their horses, announcing their arrival, etc., and dive right into the middle of the conversation with the lord's Seneschal, who has been impatiently awaiting their arrival: "...and although you are later than expected, it is of course my duty to welcome all guests to my lord's home--regardless of their apparent lack of respect for schedules," you say, as the Seneschal. "You must be tired--we should get you to your rooms as soon as possible." You roleplay him as uncomfortable and distracted, almost resentful of the party's presence here. Then, at one point during the conversation, one of the PCs notices a strange-looking servant with wide, sunken eyes staring at them from the cloak-

ing shadows across the room. The servant makes a strange sign with his right hand, surreptitiously drops a note on the floor, points at the observant PC, and then disappears into a corridor.

You have started the scene in the middle of a mystery, and now it's on the players to choose whether to take action. Maybe they carefully ask questions of their host, or make Insight rolls. Maybe one of them sneaks over to the note and reads it when no one is looking. Maybe they keep their suspicions to themselves and wait to learn more. It doesn't matter what exactly they choose to do--they just need to be given opportunities to do it.

Ending a scene is also an art. When possible, a scene should go out on a moment of tension: either a resolution of some sort--the PCs have figured something out or found an answer to a question which leads them to their next course of action--or on a cliffhanger, an ambiguous scene ending that leaves them unsure of what comes next, but desperately wanting to find out. Either way, the players should want to move forward with whatever information they have gained. They should be eager to make the next choice and take a new action in pursuit of their goals. Even if a scene brings a goal to a conclusion, the events in that scene could provide fodder for new goals.

framing the campaign

Shared Histories

The character creation process is designed to inspire goal ideas as well as to craft an explanation for how the party all know each other--besides the old "You all meet in a tavern..."

As stated in the Shared History section of Chapter 7 - Character Creation, two characters can share a common Life Event in their past, which both develops their relationship and gains each a small skill bonus. There may be a temptation for players to link two or more Life Events: "Oh, you were raised by barbarians in your Youth Event? That ties together with my Recent Event about learning how to ride horses with the Sattagoyan tribesmen--clearly that's the same Event!"

As the rule states: "...two players may agree that one character's Life Event provides an explanation for how their characters first knew each other, or why their paths crossed before the start of play." It reinterprets one Life Event to involve two characters.

Trying to link two character's Life Events can lead to convoluted, unbelievable backstories as players twist their events into pretzels to justify how they all interlink. That's almost never worth the trouble. It is better to let one Life Event be the focus, in which two characters explain how that one event connects them.

However, sometimes those Life Events will just begto be narratively tied together. If that's the case, then let your players' creativity run wild--but always remember that no character can have more than 2 Shared Histories, and each must be with a different character.

Also, don't worry too much about the character ages implied by 'Origin,' 'Youth,' and 'Recent.' ("How could I possibly have been part of your Origin event? You were just a child at the time!") These aren't strict timelines. If one character's 'Origin' overlaps another's 'Recent,' that's fine--the point is to create shared history, not synchronized calendars. The players are free to alter the Event's details in whatever way makes the most sense.

Honest Outcomes and Session Zero

The choices of the PCs will move the world. Their actions will change the status quo of the setting in ways both big and small. This doesn't mean the characters are special. They are not. They are just a few of many struggling to survive in the Broken Empires. They are not "heroes" simply by virtue of being controlled by the players. A hero is defined by their actions, not by their abilities. Most would-be

heroes die early deaths, alone and far from home, but some actually succeed and change the world. And even if they don't, each player should feel that whatever fate befalls their character, it was honestly earned.

Use character goals to inspire adventures. If a player makes a goal about retrieving an artifact from the southern jungles, that is a solid indication of what kind of game that player wants to be involved in. Juggling all the players' goals can be tricky this way. But that is what Session Zero is for. This is the first time the group sits down and talks about the game the GM is planning to run. They make their characters together, find common ground within their Life Events, and collaborate with the GM and with each other on what their characters' starting goals will be.

The PCs are free to try anything their characters can try. If one of their goals is to build a fortress on a mountain peak, let them try it! That character will have to secure large amounts of silver, permission from any current landholders, and copious amounts of labor to help, but it is within the realm of possibility. Let them pursue their goals however they wish, as long as it doesn't break the rules of the world. Any honest attempt at action should be allowed, but dishonest ones should not. A PC can flap their arms as hard as they might, but they'll never be able to fly to the moon.

A hero is defined by their actions, not by their abilities. Most would-be heroes die early deaths, alone and far from home, but some actually succeed and change the world. And even if they don't, each player should feel that whatever fate befalls their character, it was honestly earned.

Start Small and Get Personal

It is tempting to make every campaign about Saving The World From The Big Bad Evil Guy. While these can be epic and fun, they can also make the game impersonal and overlong; the sad reality is that most campaigns fizzle out after a few months, so committing to a multi-year epic world-saving campaign is always a gamble on ever reaching the conclusion.

The real question is, "Whose world are you saving? And will you care if you fail?"

Some of my best campaigns have taken place (or at least started) in a small, manageable area, like a village on the outskirts of the kingdom, a single neighborhood in a large city, or aboard a single ship as part of her crew. The PCs were locals, and if they weren't, they at least had ties to the community. They knew the important people and what the immediate threats to the area were. They had a home to protect; they had reasons to adventure beyond the mere acquisition of treasure.

In one game, when the local lord (whom they knew and were in service to) sent them to investigate reported disappearances of herdsmen in the hills nearby, they knew some of those herdsmen; one of them even came from a PC's background Life Event. When the threat turned out to be a troll establishing its hunting grounds, they knew they had to act--not to "kill a monster and take its stuff", but to save the lives of their fellow residents. When barbarian raiders started to attack outlying farms, the PCs chose to ride out and stop them--not out of a need for experience points to level up, but to protect their homeland and the people within it. When the forest village the players had spent years working to protect held a moot to elect a new leader, and that election was corrupted by the nomination of villains and ne'er-do-wells, the PCs expended every social resource they had to get personally involved, to influence the election in

favor of a candidate who they knew would protect the village's interests.

In every case, the world they saved was their own. They cared about the outcome, and they could immediately see the effects of their successes. Conversely, they could also see the effect of their failures: when friends and loved ones died in a war that they failed to prevent due to their own inaction, that affected them on a personal level, and was all the more impactful because of it.

This doesn't mean that every campaign has to be about local adventurers saving their town from small-scale threats. The campaign can grow in whatever direction you want. The village could be pulled into a war with a bloodthirsty army of orcs, with the PCs on the front lines or helping to plan battles; or the lord's brother could be secretly planning to betray him to a foreign power, roping the PCs into court intrigues that span nations; or the PCs could discover that the true source of the threats to their home is a lich halfway across the world, and decide to travel there and stop it.

But it does mean that an excellent way to start a campaign is small and personal. Help the players create goals that are tied to a localized area with NPCs and conflicts that matter to them, then let their goals evolve in whatever direction the campaign takes them. This way, no matter where the PCs wind up, they'll still be connected to their roots and have a stake in what's at stake. Do that, and it will keep them coming back to the table session after session.

GMing is Not Adversarial

An RPG is not a board game. The players are not playing against anyone, except the fictional NPCs and forces that are controlled by the GM. He represents both the adversaries and the allies that the players will encounter; he represents the world, the forces of nature, and the passage of time. But--and this is crucial--the GM himself is not an adversary. Your job as GM is to portray the world coherently and consistently, to push back on the characters' actions when they push on the world, and to do so in a way that makes logical sense. A GM must provide obstacles for the Player Characters to overcome. And you should be cheering for them! But that doesn't mean you need to explicitly help them. A GM wants the players to "win" by having them succeed at their objectives. But he also wants to ensure that they are sufficiently challenged so that their victory is earned.

Playing the Enemies

As the GM, you are almost omniscient--but the enemies you portray shouldn't be. In the interests of impartiality and fairness, the GM should play adversaries honestly, according to their abilities, preparation, and intelligence. Clever opponents should use every tool and resource at their disposal to get what they want, including taking advantage of any mistakes the PCs make. Dimwitted brutes, on the other hand, will more easily fall for tricks and are prone to tactical mistakes. In a combat situation, put yourself in the enemy's shoes: what would they reasonably know about the PCs, or their plans? Are they smart or prepared enough to put that knowledge to good use? Have them use whatever advantages they possess appropriately, but don't give them information they wouldn't have.

It is tempting to sometimes tilt the scales for or against the players in a given situation because you feel it would "be better for the story". Beware of this. Imposing a preordained "story" from on high removes the players' agency. You are not there to "tell your story"--you are there to facilitate and respond to the players as they pursue their characters' goals. They should know that they will live or die by their own choices, and of course by the whims of fate (the dice). An unearned victory is unsatisfying for either side.

running the game

Types of Conflict

Without struggle, there is no game. Conflicts are the heart of every campaign, of every adventure, of every scene (well, of most scenes; characters sitting around the campfire discussing their next destination doesn't have to be a matter of life and death). There are three principal types of conflict to understand and utilize in your adventures: Man vs Man, Man vs Nature, and Man vs Himself (where "Man" simply refers to an individual). The most dynamic adventures use a mix of all of these.

A Man vs Man conflict is entirely about people, but it doesn't have to be violent or life-threatening. This is any event in which one character is pitted against another, and includes physical confrontations, social encounters, battles of wits, or any other conflict that is about one character trying to get something from another. The rules of TBE are designed to handle all kinds of conflict that often come down to Man vs Man. Conflicts with a character's society can be included as part of this type, where a person is struggling against what their own culture considers normal or good (after all, a society is just a bunch of individuals, or "Men").

Man vs Nature is any conflict in which the environment is an obstacle. Travel models this type of conflict. This could be an Event, like a flash flood in the desert, or an obstacle like a stuck door in a dungeon. It includes dealing with flora and fauna, the weather, or any other location-based obstacle. Most Man vs Nature conflicts must be solved with quick thinking or physical exertion (after all, it's difficult to talk your way out of a hailstorm).

Man vs Himself is an internal struggle, where a character is pitted against his own beliefs or principles. Any time in which a PC's goals are competing with themselves could be an opportunity for this type of conflict; always keep an eye out for it. These kinds of conflicts can be resolved through pure roleplaying, skills like Willpower, creative interpretation of personality traits, or any other approach that seems fun and interesting.

Obstacles are crucial to goals. You cannot strive for something unless there's something in your way, and striving is the source of all conflict--and without conflict, there is no gameplay. An obstacle is a thing or situation standing in the way that the character must use skills to get past.

Obstacles

Character goals are crucial to the game. Through them, the players get focused gameplay, a sense of accomplishment, and the tangible reward of Experience Points to make their characters better. Without them, the PCs cannot progress, and the game becomes a meandering, rudderless affair. Goals are the players' responsibility to create, but goals without obstacles are meaningless--and creating obstacles is the GM's responsibility.

Obstacles are crucial to goals. You cannot strive for something unless there's something in your way, and striving is the source of all conflict--and without conflict, there is no gameplay. An obstacle is a thing or situation standing in the way that the character must use skills to get past. A good obstacle allows multiple avenues of approach, ideally,

each one being within the character's skill set. How exactly they approach the obstacle is up to them. If my character's goal is to disrupt the sorcerer's ritual at the top of the tower, an obvious obstacle is the physical tower itself: I can't disrupt the ritual until I get up there. But how? Do I have a good Athleticsskill? Then maybe I scale the walls. Or is my Stealth good enough to sneak past the guards in the entry hall? How are my Social skills? Do I disguise myself as a servant and get past them using Deceive, Persuade, or some other such skill? Or do I charge in with my axe, relying on my Combat skills? Whatever the case, I choose the best way around the obstacle, relying on my most appropriate skills.

Good obstacles challenge a character's goals without stymying them. The last thing a GM should do is put up obstacles that can't be overcome by these particular characters. If everything I suggest to get in the sorcerer's tower is shut down by the GM before I can even try it ("No, you can't climb the walls because they're too slick with rain"; "No, you can't sneak your way past the guards because they're too vigilant"; "No, you can't disguise yourself because they know the face of every servant"), or if my character possesses no appropriate skills to the situation ("Mr GM, it sounds like you're saying the only option my Loremaster character has left is to charge in with my axe... do I even have an axe??"), then the obstacle is essentially impossible, and the game stops dead in its tracks. Impossible obstacles frustrate the players and halt the game's forward momentum.

Now, if the PCs have a reasonable chance to succeed, but simply fail to overcome an obstacle, that's another thing. Failure is a necessary possibility of any task worth trying; without the possibility of failure, victories have no meaning. But failing shouldn't prevent all progress, just that one approach. If you tried to climb the tower wall but failed the roll, you can still try to sneak, bluff, or fight your way in. After all, "if at first you don't succeed, try, try again". If you failed to persuade the bandit leader to spare the village from his attacks, maybe you threaten him instead. If that obstacle proves too great for you, perhaps you try to trick him into attacking a different village; or maybe you convince the villagers to escape under the cover of darkness, leaving the bandits nothing to plunder; or maybe you simply resort to violence and attack him directly; or you come up with some other ingenious way of dealing with him.

As GMs, we want the players to succeed, and we want to celebrate with them when they find a way around an obstacle. But they still have to earn it. Since there are no character "levels" or "challenge ratings" in this game, it is up to you, the GM, to set the obstacles at a level that is challenging but ultimately resolvable by the characters. Present problems that you know they actually have a shot at overcoming, but let the players come up with their own solutions, using whatever skills they think are valid (with your approval). Any reasonable or creative solution they propose should have at least a chance of succeeding; let the dice decide.

There is a caveat to this philosophy: if they insist on getting involved in a situation they have been repeatedly warned about--a situation that they know is far too dangerous for them to handle in their current state--and they don't make adequate preparations, then impossible obstacles are likely what they're going to get. This goes too for when they blunder into a situation that is obviously beyond their ability to deal with (stumbling into a randomly discovered dragon's lair and sticking around for any length of time will undoubtedly prove suicidal for most parties). If they do find themselves in that position, well... he who runs away lives to fight another day.

> Before every session, try to come up with three obstacles you could throw at each player that directly relate to their goals. You don't need to have all the details, just some rough ideas of what you might throw in their way to challenge them. Roll on the randomizer tables elsewhere in this book for inspiration if you need it.

Using "Success With a Cost"

Success with a cost--where a failed skill roll still succeeds, but introduces an additional unforeseen consequence--is a very useful rule for ensuring that failure has meaning without making the Player Characters feel like incompetent buffoons.

The consequences of succeeding with a cost should, if at all possible, still be related somehow to the skill roll. For example, if you're inside an enemy fortress trying to pick the lock to the treasure vault, failing your Locks & Traps roll might mean that you open the door anyway, but several of the fortress guards come around the corner and catch you just as the door swings open. This forces the player to make a choice in the face of the new consequence: What do they do now?

That is an example of a consequence that makes sense within the context of the situation. What wouldn't make sense is if you failed to open the door, and then, out of nowhere, a dragon attacks the fortress. That kind of consequence runs the risk of making the players feel like their characters' actions affect the world in randomly chaotic and unbelievable ways.

The key phrase here is "out of nowhere". Try to have consequences arise naturally from the situation at hand. And don't allow success with a cost on every roll--save it for when it really makes sense in the moment. When used well, it moves the action forward while preserving the Player Character's sense of competency.

Tough Choices and Moral Quandaries

Since much of the game's action is influenced by player choices, it is in a GM's interest to make those choices hard whenever possible. If a choice is between an obviously positive outcome versus an obviously bad one, that isn't really a choice at all: of courseone would take the beneficial result. Choices are only truly interesting when the PCs must choose between evils (or, in some cases, between good outcomes; although that should be as rare and wonderful as finding a golden ring of invisibility in a cave).

Since much of the game's action is influenced by player choices, it is in a GM's interest to make those choices hard whenever possible. If a choice is between an obviously positive outcome versus an obviously bad one, that isn't really a choice at all: of course one would take the beneficial result.

Introduce moral quandaries by tying tough choices to a character's goals, personality, or principles. Take what is important to the character and have some element of the world offer to give them what they want, but at a cost. If the character has multiple related goals, see if there are ways you can bring them into conflict with each other. Any time you can, strive to ensure that the choices the PCs face are a result of their own previous actions (this isn't always feasible, but it is so much more satisfying; it contributes mightily to the feeling that the world is alive and responsive to the players).

Say there's a barbarian PC with the goals of "I will forge a lasting peace between the tribes" and "I will find a way to convince my true love to join my group". He and the daughter of a rival chief have fallen in love with each other and have been involved in a secret affair. One night, the daughter reveals to the PC that her father has just arranged a marriage between her and the PC's stern, cold-hearted chieftain. That impending marriage is likely the only thing that will stop the two tribes

from going back to war after a fragile, temporary peace that our barbarian PC was, over the course of many game sessions, instrumental in achieving. However, she tells him that she is willing to stand up to her father and refuse to marry the chief. She wants to travel the world with the PC instead; she loves whom she loves, and all among the tribes shall know it! But she cannot bear to make such a decision alone and desires his counsel.

All our PC has to do is give the word, and she will walk away from the engagement. If she does, they will no longer have to hide their love, and she will join him in his adventures (it doesn't hurt that she is also an accomplished ranger and would be a great asset to the party!). However, this will almost assuredly shatter the delicate peace between their tribes, and it may also make him an outcast among his own people for undermining his chief for his own selfish purposes. His goals are now in conflict: what does he choose to do?

As another example, does a PC have a Self-serving Personality Trait? Perhaps they must choose between keeping a valuable artifact and sacrificing it to ensure a potential ally's cooperation. On one hand, they get to keep the powerful item but might lose the ally; on the other, they lose the item but earn a needed NPC's trust.

These are "Devil's Bargains", and they are at the heart of challenging your Player Characters' goals. But the choices on offer must make sense, and arise naturally out of the situation: don't try to challenge a goal just to provide conflict for its own sake. The challenge must emerge logically from the given circumstances.

"Devil's Bargains" are at the heart of challenging your Player Characters' goals. But the choices on offer must make sense, and arise naturally out of the situation: don't try to challenge a goal just to provide conflict for its own sake. The challenge must emerge logically from the given circumstances.

Integrating Goal-Oriented Play with Other Styles

The goal-oriented play of TBE is the default method, usually created in the moment based on the character's immediate choices and the plethora of random tables found in this book. But not every scenario needs to be improvised in the moment; there's nothing wrong with playing pre-written adventures (not all of us want to be thinking on our feet all the time!). There's also nothing wrong with pure exploration-based sandbox play, where revealing undiscovered hexes on the map is more the focus than fulfilling personal goals. These are just two different sorts of fun to be had in the game. They can even be freely integrated and mixed and matched with the default goal-oriented style. Each method requires a slightly different skill set and focuses, although of course, they have many commonalities.

Pre-written adventures should always have a way of rewarding characters with goal-related XP. This could mean tailoring the adventure's XP awards to particular PC goals, or encouraging the Player Characters to take up new goals that relate directly to the objectives of the scenario.

Pure exploration-based games can easily have the PCs create appropriate goals ("I will explore every part of the map from this village to the Southern mountains"), or you could devise a hex-per-XP system, whereby every five explored map hexes grants them 1 XP (or something like that).

Retroactive Goal Awards

There will be times when the players get so caught up in an organically arisen situation that, by session's end, they realize they completely forgot to pursue their established goals. Perhaps they were swept along by a side quest, or simply got caught up in the moment--they just never declared their new pursuit as a goal. A cruel GM might cackle, "Too bad! No current goal pursuit, no XP for you! Mwa-ha-ha!"

Don't be that GM. Don't punish players for being engaged. Instead, retroactively declare whatever they were pursuing to be a goal, and award XP accordingly.

Using Zones

The spaces where scenes unfold--battlefields, ruins, busy streets, cramped castles, fog-shrouded docks--are more than scenery. Their physical details matter, and characters who cleverly interact with those details should gain real advantages.

Environmental features are the zone elements either explicitly described by the GM, or reasonably assumed from the description to be present: a collapsed wall, a hanging tapestry, a loose floorboard, a narrow ledge, knee-deep water, drifting smoke, a thundering crowd, or a slick stone floor. Players are encouraged to notice (or suggest themselves) these details and describe how their characters use them--ducking behind a toppled column as arrows fly, kicking debris into a charging foe's path, swinging from a chain to reposition, or leveraging high ground for a tactical edge. A list of random environmental features can be found at the bottom of this section.

When a player meaningfully incorporates the environment into their action, the GM may grant a circumstantial benefit, impose a penalty on an opponent, or allow an alternative approach that would not otherwise be possible. These effects should make intuitive sense within the context. A typical advantage might be a +10 or +20 bonus to a relevant skill roll, a chance to attempt a particular maneuver, or the opportunity to bring a situational rule into play.

This principle applies in any type of scene, not just combat. A character might gain leverage in a negotiation by commanding attention from a raised pulpit, or earn a bonus to Athletics while chasing someone across a rooftop studded with handholds and outcroppings. The key is simply this: If the player engages with the environment in a believable way, the environment should matter.

- **Show the terrain:** Describe the shape and features of a space clearly enough that players can act on those details.
- **Reward creativity:** If a player uses the environment in a clever way, be sure to give them an appropriate bonus.
- **Context is king:** Bonuses or penalties should match what the described action plausibly accomplishes.
- **Don't overdo it:** A single meaningful detail is enough to give the scene texture.
- **Build on what's already there, but avoid redundancy:** Rules for cover, rough footing, elevation, or hazards already provide bonuses and penalties; no additional environmental feature should step on these pre-existing conditions, and should arise naturally from description and common sense.
- **Be generous:** It is better to give too many bonuses rather than too few. Rewarding players for their creativity will encourage them to continue engaging with the game world, providing a richer experience.

Finally, while a zone could be filled with as many environmental dangers as opportunities, Zone Hazards already incorporate a lot of penalties; don't magnify those penalties by applying too many additional negative environmental factors. Engaging with the environment is supposed to reward creative thinking with opportunities to find bonuses, not provide even more reasons for a cruel GM to make things harder!

Random Environmental Zone Features I

d20	Forest	Plains	Streets	Swamp
1	Exposed tree roots	Tall grasses	Market stalls	Thick muck
2	Stumps	Dirt/Snow mound	Crates and barrels	Quicksand
3	Thick bushes	Ditch, gully, or trench	Wagon	Tall reeds
4	Moss-covered logs	Streambank	Doorway	Thorny plants
5	Fog/Mist	Tree stand	Windows	Fallen logs
6	Thorn bushes	Fallen trees	Horse/Mule/Ox/Camel	Swamp gas
7	Bee hives/Wasp nests	Slippery mud/Snow patch	Sparse Crowd	Water snakes
8	Poisonous plants	Pollen-filled flowers	Fence or barrier	Deep pool
9	Hollow tree	Rusted pitchfork	Well/Cistern	Vines
10	Steep slope	Ruined wagon	Smoke/Cook fires	Water Lillies
11	Boulders	Boulders	Ladder	Floating deadfall
12	Muddy streambank	Low stone fence	Stairs	Waterlogged stumps
13	Dry underbrush	Ruined building foundations	Piles of refuse	Lizards/Frogs
14	Old fire pit	Fire pit	Animal trough	Bucket
15	Logs over a stream	Wheat stalks	Wooden bench	Fishing net
16	Rusted axe head	Dead animal	Hitching posts	Bloated carcass
17	Animal bones	Ground-dweller's nest	Ceramic pots	Rotting boat
18	Bird's nest	Sloping hill	Sewer entrance/Trapdoor	Waterfowl nests
19	Hanging vines/branches	Wagon ruts	Running water/ Snowdrifts	Wooden planks
20	Water-logged ground/ Snowdrifts	Rotting backpack	Dense Crowd	Slime-covered rocks

Random Environmental Zone Features II

d20	Mountains	Desert	Badlands	Interiors
1	Mountain goats/ Animals	Sand dunes	Hoodoos	An old table
2	Loose rocks	Limestone foundations/Ruins	Cracked, broken ground	Hanging light sources/Chandeliers
3	Cliff face	Sand-covered stone outcroppings	Desert lizards	Bookshelves or cabinets
4	Sloping hill	Low shrubs	Spiked cacti	A heavy curtain bisecting the room or on a wall
5	Cliff edge	Dry well/Cistern	High cliff walls	Loose floorboards
6	Boulders	Dry streambed	Loose rocks	Wall-mounted shelves
7	Mountain stream	Dust devils	Boulders	Large rug or carpet
8	Snowbank	Jagged rocks	Dust clouds	Cracked floor tiles
9	Coniferous trees	Spiked cacti	Rocky outcroppings	Gaps in the walls
10	Cave entrance	Animal/Humanoid bones	Crevice	Chair(s)
11	High ledge	Desert trees/Palms	Twisting vines	A hearth, lantern, or brazier
12	Low clouds	Snakes	Poisonous, thorny plants	A stack of crates
13	Mossy ledges	Scorpions	Low dry brush	Barrels filled with a liquid
14	Pile of scree	Salt flats/hard pack	Snakes	Mirrors or reflective surfaces
15	Thorny bushes	Loose sand	Dry riverbed	Ropes or chains hanging from the ceiling
16	Rocky pathway	Desert tent	Ruined barrels	Loose ceiling beams or structural supports
17	Avalanche debris	Stone slabs with sigils or writing	Tall rocky spire	Piles of clutter or refuse
18	Rotting rope/ Climbing gear	Half-buried statue	Narrow canyon	Coil of rope
19	Old campsite	Sand-covered cart	Cave	Pillars or columns
20	Exposed tree roots	Mirage	Seeping groundwater	Wall-mounted torch sconces

Preparation Before the Fight

When the players know a fight is coming and have the time to plan, encourage them to use the Prepare the Battlefield situational rule. Each successful roll allows the party to shape the environment to their advantage--set traps, study the enemy's approach, erect barricades, dig in. Each success converts into a pool of Favor, which anyone in that zone can later spend for +10 per point, up to +30 total per roll, provided the bonus is narratively justified ("I lure the orc toward the snare Simon set earlier"). That bonus Favor can stack up and turn the tide of battle.

Combat Difficulty

There are no levels or "challenge ratings" in this game. Normally, you can get a sense of how skilled a combatant is by looking at their, well, skill. Compare that to the average combat skill of your warrior-type PCs, and that will give you some idea about how tough that enemy will be. But also consider AP , Toughness, Death Threshold, and any special abilities they might have. With familiarity and practice, you will be able to easily eyeball these attributes to judge the overall difficulty.

Also, more enemies than PCs is a big disadvantage to the players, regardless of enemy skill. Keep that in mind when designing combat encounters. Outnumbering is a big deal!

For more specific guidance on how to interpret adversaries' difficulty levels, see Chapter 18 - Bestiary .

Let Them Talk

Not every band of aggressive enemies will attack the moment they see the party. Often, they will want something first: money, information, submission, gear, promises of cooperation...whatever. These moments create golden opportunities for socially oriented characters: a chance to try words before swords, possibly even circumventing bloodshed altogether (gasp!).

If the players want to bluff, persuade, bribe, intimidate, or otherwise deal with the enemy without having to resort to violence, let them try. There's no guarantee it will work -- but allowing such attempts thwarts the presumption of inevitable combat, and rewards novel approaches. A victory won through words is still a victory. And we do have these detailed Social Encounter rules, after all!

Of course, not every foe will listen. Some are too bloodthirsty, fanatical, or inhuman to parley. Encounters with such types are equally vital to maintain the world's harsh tone, and they serve as reminders that sometimes words will fail, leaving only the sword to do the talking.

A Thought on Combat Maneuvers

Because you must choose your Combat Maneuver before any Wound Die is rolled (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils), choosing Trip or Disarm on a Leg or Arm hit respectively might feel redundant, as the foe's Wound Die might force him Prone or to drop his weapon anyway. Think of the Trip and Disarm Combat Maneuvers as guaranteeing a Prone or Disarmed foe, rather than merely hoping for a wound to cause it.

The Spellweaver Thread Economy

Spellweavers build their magic from three parts: their Strand values, the SLs from their Bind roll, and whatever extra stability they can scrape together from Threads and Resolve.

Of those, only Resolve naturally comes back--and even then, it recovers quite slowly unless the party is resting in a Safe area. A Spellweaver who has used up a lot of their Resolve can still cast spells, but doing so without the Resolve to stabilize it pretty much guarantees Weave Reactions, the dangerous, unpredictable consequences of uncontrolled magic.

Hence, a Spellweaver with a depleted Resolve pool hasn't "run out of spells." They can still cast, but they have entered a state where every spell becomes a gamble. The Spellweaver must decide how much risk they're willing to tolerate.

Because of this, you should keep two things in mind when there's a Spellweaver in the party:

Resolve recovery is a real limiter. If the group spends long stretches without resting in Safe hexes, a Spellweaver who has overspent will feel that pressure most of all. That's by design, but don't unfairly limit the availability of Safe areas.

Threads are their long-term arcane currency. Threads are more valuable than gold to the Spellweaver. They allow the caster to attempt far more powerful spells than they would otherwise risk. They will hunt for them, trade for them, or sometimes even kill for them. That said, Threads shouldn't be common exactly, but the world should offer occasional, meaningful chances to gain them--at least as often as treasure or the other usual rewards.

Threads can come from many places and circumstances. The party might uncover them in ancient arcane laboratories, discover them in strange locales where the Weave manifests physically, claim them as treasure from the hordes of slain monsters, harvest them as remnants of creatures or entities suffused with magic, receive them as rewards from powerful patrons, or stumble across them during unusual Events.

characters and relationships

NPCs

Unless the NPC is an obviously violent antagonist, it is often more useful to know who they are and what they want, rather than the details of their stat blocks. If you do need skill values, it's easy enough to assign them in the moment using the Enemy Difficulty guidelines (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary).

The NPC Trait Table (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary) can be used to inspire randomly determined appearances, personalities, agendas, and Special Reaction Triggers.

A If the NPC could be significant to the PCs, choose or roll a name. (There are Name Tables in Appendix D.) Then come up with the following elements:

» The NPC's appearance, and/or their profession. The appearance is the description you give the players upon first encountering the NPC. It should tell the players something about that NPC: unwashed clothing and greasy hair paint a very different picture than manicured nails and dirt-free boots.

» An overarching playable aspect that you can convey through role-playing or description (or both). This is a hook you can use to give the NPC some instant, simple characterization. It is a roleplaying aid that makes the NPC memorable and cements them in the players' minds. Keep it subtle and grounded; you don't want to make the NPCs silly caricatures (unless that's what you're going for explicitly). This is a very useful tool. Most times, I can develop an entire NPC out of a single playable aspect.

» Their immediate personality. This is a general guide on how to portray the NPC, and may or may not be related to the playable aspect.

» Their agenda, something specific they want. This is the meat of a complex NPC, and can be used in creating obstacles or fueling goals for the PCs. The agenda list on the NPC Trait Table gives general

ideas that can be fleshed out using the Event Randomizers Tables (see Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying in the Broken Empires).

» Any Special Reactions the NPC might have to a certain topic, a particular skill's use, or a particular group to whom they're biased. A typical NPC should have between 0-3 of these (1d4-1 if you want to keep it random).

The more important the NPC, the more fleshed out each descriptor can be.

An example of a simple NPC might be Rory, a rotund tavern keeper with an ironic sense of humor that often prompts a knowing wink, who wants to apprentice his teenage son to any knight who'll have him.

A more complex NPC might be Sir Edmund of Arlsbury: a frail and sickly Westlander marcher-lord-turned-diplomat, who harbors a light, incessant cough. He is suspicious of the motives of the lowborn, and treats them with disdain (if Sir Edmund is engaged in a Social Encounter with someone whom he perceives as lower class, the Tolerance will be one less). He considers himself an amateur historian and is easily impressed with displays of Ancient Lore. He is eager to deliver a message to the Duke of Trefette (a response to his query regarding a trade treaty with Arlsbury), and will pay a handsome sum to any who can safely escort him.

Not every NPC needs a name and a backstory, just the ones the players are going to have significant interactions with. If you spend your precious time and energy fleshing out every minor NPC the players come across, you'll quickly exhaust yourself and get distracted from the true focus of the game, the PCs. It really is ok to just describe the guard at the city gates as "a gate guard".

Modelling Complex NPC Relationships

Since this is a "dramatic" fantasy roleplaying game, very often characters will develop complicated relationships with NPCs (and some of these are also great candidates for character goals). These can be great fun to play, and help to create an intense, believable world. Having a conflict with an NPC who plays an important role in your character's life (preferably a conflict that must be resolved in some way other than sticking a sword through them) can provide deeply memorable roleplaying experiences. The evolution of these NPC relationships can reveal character growth over time, creating even richer, more believable characters. But how to model the delicate and changing relationship between a PC and an NPC believably and satisfyingly? Not every interaction needs to be a full-blown Social Encounter, but tracking a relationship can be useful to gauge its status. Consider using an extended roll to do that.

Let's say a PC has the goal, "I will mend my broken relationship with my father, and make him proud of me." Let's also assume that the father is a minor lord, and the PC is a slightly disgraced second son who has no interest in following the knightly path. This could be handled with an extended roll with, the GM decides, an SL requirement of 12, where every skill roll represents a role-played "scene" with the father.

In one scene, the son has returned home after a long journey and secures an audience with his father in the family keep. The GM and player play out the scene as normal, interacting with each other "in character". This isn't a proper Social Encounter where every statement requires a skill roll; rather, when the GM feels the roleplaying exchange has reached some kind of natural conclusion, he assesses the overarching approach that the PC used and asks for a skill roll to match. Only one skill is chosen for the entire scene. If the player was mostly using logic and reason to speak with his father, the GM may ask for a Persuade roll; if he was generally emotional and sarcastic, possibly a Wit roll; or if he found himself mostly telling his father lies to placate him, a Deceive roll would be called for.

The assessed skill is rolled, and any SLs are tracked. It is very unlikely that a character could regain his father's respect in a single roll (or scene!); the next roll would have to wait until the next encounter with the father. This could be in a day, a week, a month, a year... whatever plays out based on the character's choices and the machinations of fate. By the time the PC reaches the SL requirement and proves himself to the father, it may have been a very long while indeed --but the father will finally have come around and become proud of the son (completing that goal). This will have transformed that relationship, possibly even inspiring a new goal.

Borrowing further from the mechanics of extended rolls, the GM could also decide that the PC must engage in at least 3 meaningful interactive scenes with the father before the task can be called completed. Moreover, the GM could decide that for every 3 SLs the PC gains, the nature of the relationship incrementally improves. Perhaps after 3 SLs, the father starts smiling once in a while during their conversations; or after 6 SLs, perhaps he admits some deeply-held secret to the character. Of course, as per the rules of extended rolls, if the character critically fails a roll, the current SLs are cut in half. In addition to setting him back in general, this may undo the incremental advances that the character has earned, causing him to have to earn them all over again.

Further, the GM could determine that certain outside actions the character has performed count as SLs towards the goal, as long as those actions a) required skill rolls, and b) would be appropriate to moving the gauge with that NPC. If our second son succeeded in an adventure to vanquish a bandit lord and the father hears of it, that might count as a couple of extra SLs towards completing the extended roll the next time the PC has a scene with the father.

The extended roll system is a useful way to track complex interpersonal relationships without the need for every conversation to be a full Social Encounter, while still employing skills to represent the roleplaying choices of the player.

Social Encounters, and When to Use Them

The rules for Social Encounters can be very fun and rewarding, but it is important that you only implement them when there is something at stake for the PCs. When engaging in any conversation with an NPC, if there is no meaningful consequence to failure, then handle it via standard rolls, or even just straight-up roleplaying. Trying to force the full Social Encounter framework onto a casual exchange will often make the scene feel slower and less natural. In fact, the Social Encounter rules will actually fight against you if you try to use them without the characters having something important on the line.

> Having a conflict with an NPC who plays an important role in your character's life (preferably a conflict that must be resolved in some way other than sticking a sword through them) can provide deeply memorable roleplaying experiences.

If, for example, the PCs chat with the Lady of Blackharbor, hoping to learn a few personal details that might be useful later, ask yourself--what's at stake if they fail?If the answer is "not much," then you can safely resolve it narratively. They simply don't learn anything new this time. But if they're pleading with her to stay her husband's hand and spare an innocent life-- now there's real weight behind the outcome. That's when the Social Encounter system belongs at the table.

Like so many parts of this game, it comes down to judgement. Use the structured rules when tension and consequences demand it; otherwise, keep things loose and let the conversation breathe.

One final note: the Social Encounter system is not a form of "social combat". Social combatimplies that one side is trying to harm or break the other by targeting their reputation, integrity, or mental or emotional state. The Social Encounter system, by contrast, reflects moments when the PCs are trying to influence or obtain something from an NPC whose stance or position matters to their goals. We do not do "social hit point damage" to our opponents in Social Encounters; we instead use Social skills to get what we need from them.

The Social Encounter system is not a form of "social combat". The Social Encounter system, by contrast, reflects moments when the PCs are trying to influence or obtain something from an NPC whose stance or position matters to their goals.

Using Social Skills Outside of Social Encounters

The Social Encounter system regulates the use of skills within a framework designed to create maximum tension. Rules like, "A skill can't be used three times in a row", or "You can't try the same skill after it's just failed" are designed to prevent players from spamming the same skill over and over again. Tolerance is a limit that exists to restrict the number of skill attempts the PCs can make.

But outsideof the Social Encounter framework, what is stopping a player from continuously using Persuade with the same NPC until they get what they want? There's no Tolerance in that scenario, so the players can keep rolling until they get enough SLs, or otherwise achieve their social objective, right?

No. Outside of a proper Social Encounter, these same key rules still apply: a Social skill can't be used on an NPC three times in a row, and a skill can't be attempted again right after it has just failed. In general, only allow each PC one Social skill attempt per NPC . Think of it as an extended roll with a limit of one roll per PC.

This applies whether or not you are counting SLs to determine the outcome (although if you are, and there's something at stake for a PC's goal, it's probably time to make it an official Social Encounter). If, for example, the objective is to bribe a gate guard, a single successful Persuade(or Wit, if persuasion fails) might be required, and if the first PC tries Persuadeand fails, the next PC must try something else; whereas on a standard success, the guard would let the party pass. If, however, the objective is to accumulate 12 SLs to get a Baroness' maidservant to reveal her Lady's schedule, then the SLs from each PC's single roll contribute to the total--but each PC can only try something once.

A Note About Insight

Often, players will treat the Insight skill as a kind of lie-detector: "Can I roll Insight on the knight to see if he's lying?" That only works if the knight in question actually is lying, in which case it will require an opposed roll of the character's Insight vs the knight's Deceive skill--both rolled secretly by the GM to preserve the social "fog of war". The Insight skill is not a mind-reading skill. It can't reveal specific details about what an NPC is thinking. Regarding NPCs, it is only useful when confronted with an actual lie (as in the previous example), or in a proper Social Encounter, where it may help the party by providing Leverage. Don't allow blanket Insight rolls to reveal NPC intentions.

Insight can, however, be used to provide flashes of understanding in situations where the GM feels the players could use a little help figuring out the meaning of clues or other information. Apply this sparingly, though, and always at your discretion.

investigations, clues, and bottlenecks

TBE isn't primarily a game of investigation, but mysteries and inquiries can make for compelling adventures. A note of caution, though: avoid bottlenecks, situations where the entire investigation depends on a single successful roll or a single line of inquiry.

If the PCs make even a minimal, reasonable effort to investigate what you consider a core clue, they should receive that information automatically. No roll required. Why? Because it's poor design to let the progress of an adventure hinge on a single Perception roll, Track attempt, or moment of luck.

Imagine the party is pursuing a killer through the sewers. Unbeknownst to them, the killer dropped a locket at a key intersection--a vital clue that ties him to one of the city's noble families. If the players all fail their Perception rolls to find it, the investigation stalls. The adventure grinds to a halt, and there's nowhere for the group to go next.

Instead, if the players make any reasonable attempt to search, simply tell them they find the locket. Or better yet, design your investigations so there's more than one way to uncover essential information. The dropped locket might be one clue; a witness's testimony or a suspicious ledger could serve as others.

(For further reading, I highly recommend Justin Alexander's So You Want to Be a Gamemaster and his "Three Clue Rule": always include at least three independent ways for the PCs to obtain any critical piece of information. It's an excellent safeguard against bottlenecks.)

chapter 17: gamemastering the broken empires

managing time and travel

Tracking Time

There are three main ways of handling time in the game:

- Daily Time : This is the default state: any time you're not on a Journey or in Tactical Time, you are in Daily Time. It covers day-to-day living or exploration, where the PCs make rolls for Rations, Recovery, and other routine considerations. Traveling in Daily Time is called HexMarching . A GM can also have large amounts of Daily Time pass in the background ("Three weeks pass while you're waiting in the village"); if so, simply disregard daily rolls and narrate events as you see fit.
- On a Journey : This is an abstracted measurement of time, used only while on longer expeditions.
- Tactical Time : This represents Combat, Social Encounters, or any other situation where time is measured round by round.

When you see "for the duration of the scene" or a similar phrase, it means while the current encounter or roleplaying moment lasts. It's subjective, so it's up to you when to "cut to the next scene" (see Starting and Ending a Scene).

Travel

A Journey is designed to transport the players in their minds to the forests, deserts, and mountains of the Broken Empires. Ideally, it should give them the same sense of exhilaration and danger that their characters feel.

GMs principally do this through language. Just remember, you're a Gamemaster, not an author--keep your descriptions short and evocative. But by all means, read fantasy books as often as you can; we can learn much from authors. Tolkien, Moorcock, Martin, Jordan, Le Guin, Lovecraft, Howard, C.S. Lewis--learn how they describe things, and use what inspires you. Then use that to better immerse your players. A roleplaying game, as some have said, is just a conversation--and conversations are composed of words. Learn how to harness their power like the best authors do, and it will transport your table.

The focus of a Journey should never be on its mechanics. The travel process should never be reduced to simply ticking off boxes on a checklist or making a series of tedious die rolls. The GM should internalize the travel procedures as much as possible in order to make the Journey flow smoothly from one step to another.

Travel Events

It is important to describe the details of a travel Event to the players, and then let them react and choose how to handle it. Don't start making suggestions on how to deal with it--an Event is (probably) an obstacle the characters must overcome, whether it's one that threatens them in some way or one that stands in the way of them gaining something positive.

Your job is to set the scene; their job is to find their own way to play it.

- A good inspiration for coming up with how narrative details affect the event is to consider the weather. An event in a rainstorm will play out much differently than on a bright sunny day.
- Then look at the current hex's terrain. Being in a forest will create different circumstances than in a desert; being by a river will be different than being in a high mountain pass.
- Is the party on a road? Then it could be an ambush, or something they see in the distance.

- Then consider the time of day when the event transpires. Is it at night? They're probably making camp. Are they stopped for a midday meal? They could notice something on the road behind them, or notice something about their supplies or mounts. Is the sun low in the sky and blinding them as they strain to notice the impending ambush?
- Finally, look at the character goals. Is this an event that might be connected in some way to something one of them is pursuing? (Don't overuse this, though, otherwise it will feel like the world is revolving around the PCs, and that feels contrived.)

It is good practice to telegraph the coming event (especially if the Scout was successful) so that the players can choose how to manage it.

> If you roll an event that suggests a mudslide in the mountains, describe the rumble of the earth, the quickening cascade of rocks and mud, the screeching of birds as they suddenly take flight from the trees on the slope, etc. The Difficulty, you decide, is Hard: each person will take a 6-point bashing Wound to a random location unless they make an opposed roll to reduce or eliminate it. The players now must describe what they do in response to the slide.
>
> If the Scout has succeeded on the Perception roll, the group would have access to skill bonuses based on the Perception roll's SLs, which they could use to deal with the mudslide.

Preplanning Events

Not everyone is a natural improviser, and there can be a lot going on behind the screen for the GM. Having to randomly come up with Events, detail them, and stat up any monsters or opposition based on a set of descriptors from multiple tables--in addition to keeping track of your NPCs, the PCs' goals, and everything else a GM has to juggle--can be a lot for some people (including myself, on an off day).

Luckily, GMing doesn't have to be an improv skills test. There is nothing wrong with pre-building set Events between sessions and putting them on a list for your future use. That way, you can take as much time as you need to come up with some really satisfying encounters, without the pressure to "perform in the moment". When you have some time to yourself and you're feeling creative, simply roll up a few random Events and detail them at your own pace. Then, add each one to a numbered Event list of your own, and cross them off as you use them.

Event Creation on the Fly

The trick to improvising an Event is to go with your first instinct. The combination of prompts will (hopefully) suggest something immediate to you, even if it's just a fleeting, unformed idea. Grab it and use it! Don't judge it, don't try to come up with the "perfect" encounter. Just allow your imagination to fire and trust your gut. Everything else will flow from there.

And if the prompts give you nothing? Then roll again until they do. But don't keep rolling, looking for the perfect result. Roll just until something--anything--strikes you, and use it as a foundation to build on.

If you're not good at this process at first, practice! Trust me, it's not rocket science. It just takes a little faith in your own creativity. Enjoy it! Indulging your creative force is a big part of the appeal of GMing.

Here's a concrete example of how I might create an Event on the fly:

- I start by rolling for the danger of the current hex. I roll 5: Precarious. This tells me that the Event will likely be dangerous, but probably not lethally so.
- I know that the terrain of the hex where the Event occurs is deep in the mountains. This gives me a lot of specific atmosphere to draw from: the earthy scent of the alpine forest, the thin, chilly

air, the sweeping views of the valleys below, the mountaintops crowned with white clouds.

A Since the season is Autumn, I declare that the weather is cold and clear, especially at this high altitude. There are strong winds coming off the nearby snow-covered peaks, which may cause a penalty to missile weapons fired at longer ranges.

A I'm imagining a daytime Event, but I'm willing to wait and see the result of the Scout's Perception roll.

A There are no particular character goals that seem appropriate at the moment, so I go straight to the Initial Prompt Table. I roll 96 (Translate) and 32 (Festival).

A My first instinct is that there is some barbarian tribe up here in the mountains performing some ancient religious rite, their shaman chanting and ululating in a strange, cacophonous tongue. Where did this idea come from? I have no idea--but I go with it.

A Is this a danger? Likely, as the barbarians will not appreciate being disturbed by outsiders--especially if their rite is a nefarious ritual designed to bring some forgotten elder spirit into the world to unleash upon their enemies.

A This is an instant interesting potential encounter! How will the players handle it? Will they try to sneak away? Investigate further? Call out in parley? Draw steel and attack the obvious heathens? That will be entirely up to them, and dependent on the Scout making her Perception roll and seeing the barbarians before they see the PCs!

A I decide to roll on the Event Difficulty Table and get 11: Easy. I interpret this to mean that the barbarians are so engrossed in the rite that they won't immediately be aware of the PCs. If the party decides to sneak away, they will each have to make a Stealth roll, but at +10. (I could also handle this with a Group roll, in which only the PC with the lowest Stealth skill rolls, at +10.) If they are detected, the barbarians will come after them, at which point the PCs may flee, fight, try to talk their way out of violence, or do whatever else they choose.

A I now get the Scout's player to roll Perception. If she succeeds, she may earn skill bonuses for the group, and the party will have the opportunity to act before the barbarians detect them. If she fails, they get no bonuses, and the party is detected before they can do anything. (Because the Event is an Easy difficulty, I might even give the party a chance to sneak away even if the Scout failed the Perception roll--but I am a kind and generous god.)

The above example was pure gut instinct, based solely off of the images and ideas created from combining two words. But let's say I got no inspiration from Translate Festival. I could keep rolling, but instead I go to the Event Type by Hex Danger Table and roll on the Precarious column:

A I roll a 10: "Major Threat".

A I consult that subtable and roll Type (12: "Corrupted or cursed wildlife"), Behaviour (53: "Displays power before striking"), and Possible Consequences (61: "Long-term condition--infection, curse, poison, disease, etc.")

A Ok! I'm getting an idea of a pack of cursed wolves trapped up in these mountains, who are led by a werewolf--a very major threat. Part of this werewolf's curse is that he feeds on fear as much as flesh: he must reveal himself and strike terror into his prey before he attacks. This will give the PCs an advantage, as they won't be subject to an initial surprise attack!

A I have the stats for a werewolf (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary); this could become a Combat encounter if the Scout fails the Perceptionroll and any subsequent rolls to leave the area undetected (if that's in fact what they choose to do; that'll be up to them, not me). Fighting the werewolf may also risk one or more of the party getting infected with lycanthropy.

A Since the party is made up of 4 experienced PCs with a host of skills in the high 80s and many useful combat Talents, I decide to bump it up a notch and add a few wolves: the werewolf is accompanied by members of his pack, who will fight in a defensive screen to protect him. I also have stats for wolves (see Chapter 18 - Bestiary), but if I didn't, I'd probably give them combat skills in the 50-60 range; the werewolf is already a formidable foe, and I don't want to overwhelm the party.

A But what if I want to give the players an option besides immediate violence? Well, unlike a normal lycanthrope, I've determined this creature is under a curse--and every curse can be lifted. Maybe the source of this curse is nearby, and if the PCs can figure out what it is, they might actually free the werewolf from its plight instead of having to fight it.

A I roll on the Event Randomizers Tables in Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying in the Broken Empires. I could just as easily have rolled again on the Initial Prompt Table, but I wanted to change it up a bit), first Action(07: "Ask"), then Subject (88: "Transaction"), to help me flesh out the curse and how it might be removed.

A This response, "Ask Transaction", immediately suggests an idea to me. There is an old witch who lives in a cabin nearby, who holds the key to the situation: she is willing to undo the curse, but the werewolf must ask her himself to do it. But if it's that simple, why won't the lycantrope just go and ask? Does he not know that this is the answer? Or--and this gets interesting--does he begrudge the witch for some reason, and is he refusing to ask her for help, despite his condition? What does that say about the nature of the relationship between the witch and the werewolf? Were they lovers?

A I think that's a great answer, and decide to go with that: the witch is punishing her ex-lover with the curse of lycanthropy because he refused to commit to loving only her. He walked out on her one night, shouting, "I don't need you!" She intends to keep him trapped in beast form until he willingly comes to her and admits that he needs her help, and that he can't live without her.

A Now the party has an option to avoid violence. Maybe I start the encounter with the party stumbling across the witch's cabin: she's not there, but there are clues in the room that suggest she is controlling a wolf somehow--strange, wolf-fur talismans, necklaces of wolf's teeth, maybe scraps of ritualistic writing (or successful Arcana rolls) that suggest these items are Arcane Tethers to an individual. Maybe there's even a journal that details the conflicted feelings the witch has about teaching her beautiful, prideful lover "a hard lesson".

A To tie it back to the Behaviour result of "Displays power before striking", the journal also describes her lover as a remarkably handsome man--and that he has ensnared her with his good looks for too long. "Not so pretty now, are you, my darling? If you want that beautiful face back, you'll admit that you need me, and only me!" While this isn't strictly necessary, it's good to use all the prompts if you can; this creates a richer, more internally consistent Event.

A And finally, as all these ideas are coalescing in my mind, I ask the Scout to roll Perception!

You get the idea. The tables are designed to ignite your imagination. There are no wrong answers, as long as you are able to tie the elements together in a way that hooks your players and gets them wanting to engage with the Event.

Switching Modes: Risk vs. Time

Players may choose to drop out of a Journey and enter Daily Time at the end of any leg. This switch is never trivial, as it immediately exposes the party to the dangers and demands of Daily Time.

When the party exits a Journey to treat wounds or regroup, they must immediately resolve all Daily Time procedures for that day: Rations Die rolls, the Infection Die, and the nightly Hostile Encounter roll. Daily Time nights are far more hazardous than Journey travel Events; they are virtually guaranteed to involve something in the wilderness trying to murder the PCs.

Only after surviving the night may the party attempt Wound Recovery or Purge Infection rolls. Even then, treatment is not guaranteed--recovery rolls may fail or critically fail (causing new infections!), and purge attempts may be unsuccessful. Once these morning checks are resolved, the party is free to resume a Journey or remain in Daily Time.

This flexibility is, of course, intentional. Dropping into Daily Time allows a group to address dangerous conditions without sacrificing long stretches of travel, but it comes at a price: immediate exposure to unpredictable hazards. Sometimes stopping is the wisest decision; other times, pressing on despite wounds may be less dangerous than risking a night in hostile territory. The choice is always up to the players; it's one of many that adds to a journey's satisfying tension.

A note in general about travel: despite all of these fancy procedural rules, and all these random tables and tools, sometimes you can just...skip it. Sounds like heresy after everything I've said so far, right? Well, it's true. Sometimes you can merely handwave away the travel bits and get to what you consider the good stuff. Of course, I think you're letting some of the best parts of this book go to waste, but it's your game--run it as you will.

world-building and consistency

But Where Are All the Dungeons?

So you've done all this traveling. But where are you traveling to? Where are all the dungeons?

In TBE, dungeon-delving for its own sake--fun though it can be--isn't the default focus. The loop of Find Dungeon, Explore Room, Fight Monster, Take Treasure, Explore Next Room, Deal With Trap, Explore Next Room, Fight Monster, Rest to Replenish Resources, Explore Next Room... that's not the experience this game is trying to provide (and there are already an endless number of RPGs that do that in spades).

What TBE does strive to provide is a broader set of rules that adjudicate the pursuit of a character's goals. But these goals need obstacles, and sometimes, exploring a dungeon is the perfect obstacle to a goal (and it's an exciting thing to find at the end of a long journey!). But what makes for a good dungeon--or adventure site, as I'll call it here--in the Broken Empires?

An adventure site is any contained area that the PCs can explore or otherwise interact with, that has:

- A an original purpose;
- A current condition;
- A possible occupants (who have their own purposes and activities);
- A and some threat or challenge, ideally to one or more of the PCs' goals.

The random tables in Chapter 12 - Travelare invaluable for generating these elements.

There is Always a Reason

Whatever form the adventure site takes, make sure it has a reason for being there. In the Broken Empires, mad wizards don't usually go around populating underground labyrinths with marauding monsters just to give Player Characters the chance to get rich by killing them and taking their stuff. A "dungeon" can be a forgotten four-room tomb of a barbarian prince whose treasures have remained undiscovered all these years; a series of natural mountain caves being used as a base by hobgoblins to ambush travelers in a nearby pass; a centuries-old ruined temple to a forgotten god filled with the restless spirits of murdered priests; a literal dungeon, an old prison fallen into disuse by a regime that no longer exists; a village where all the inhabitants are being mind-controlled by an undead monstrosity hiding under the graveyard; or anything else that would have a believable reason for existing in that location.

The rule of "there has to be a reason" applies to more than just adventure sites, by the way; it applies to every unusual new development. Using the random tables inChapter 12 - Travel can lead to some interesting and unexpected discoveries. If you roll up something that seems out of place or improbable, first think, "There has to be a reason for it to be here". If something interesting occurs to you--perhaps with the assistance of a randomizer table--and it feels like it is consistent with what has come before, incorporate it.

In "Me, Myself and Die!" Season One, when Simon of Argoston was exploring a subterranean undead temple, a randomly generated encounter revealed a hidden exit to the surface, and a broken sword that looked a lot like his missing father's. Why would that be here? Well, in an earlier session, we had learned that his mother had been secretly imprisoned in this place; since both his parents went missing at the same time, it seemed plausible that his father would have also been imprisoned here. Finding the broken sword and the open secret door suggested that the father had managed to escape! Suddenly, a random broken weapon had a plausible reason for being there--and naturally led to the next step in Simon's adventure: follow his father's tracks and find him.

This kind of "retconning" is all in the service of giving shape and meaning to randomness; of using present discoveries to explain past mysteries. Just be sure not to stretch credulity too thin--the connections between new developments should feel natural, and be consistent with what has already been established. And sometimes connecting the dots just doesn't work: it doesn't make sense, or it would feel a little "too convenient". That's okay, too. Not every random discovery or incident has to be tied to a previous event or encounter. In fact, it shouldn't--not if you want to preserve a sense of objectivity and verisimilitude.

See alsoSolo Tools as GM Tools and Random Encounters on the next page.

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Grounding your adventure sites within the world gives them a purpose. It makes the game world make more sense and feel less arbitrary or "gonzo". An adventure site with a definitive function helps the players make both reasonable predictions about what to expect, and meaningful decisions on how to proceed. Understanding a location's form and function helps the players choose how to explore it.

If a dungeon is just there "because of game" or because the GM found a neat-o map and module online that they really wanted to drop into the game without considering why it would be there, it runs the risk of feeling out of place. Mega-dungeons with rooms that serve no practical function, illuminate nothing about the dungeon's overall purpose, or are just weird for weird's sake; monsters roaming around in proximity to other beasts who would definitely be competing for the same resources; rooms filled with magical weapons that are inexplicably not being used by the humanoid monsters who know about them--all these kinds of things can break the internal consistency we're striving for. Worse, if there's no way for the players to make meaningful choices about their actions because the adventure site's details feel random or arbitrary, or the place just doesn't make any sense, they will be frustrated by the experience.

All it takes to avoid these kinds of complications is to consider the site and its details through the lens of internal consistency and overall logic. Things have to make sense, even if at first they seem mysterious. And ideally, uncovering and understanding the mysterious purpose of a site should help the players overcome its challenges.

Again, the "Site" random tables (see Chapter 12 - Travel) are great for this. Tie as much of what you generate as you can into the setting: who built it, and why? Is there a reason why it's in this particular place or area hex? Why did it fall into ruin or disuse? What condition is it in now? Who or what is occupying it? What dangers does it hold, and what secrets or opportunities does it contain for the PCs? What will happen if the PCs don't explore or engage with it? How does this adventure site challenge the PCs' goals, and how can it or its inhabitants provide obstacles to those goals? You can still use that kewl online dungeon you found, but asking yourself these questions first will transform it from some random thing into something that belongs in your world. It will help the players make sense of it and ultimately enjoy it more.

Answering these questions will make the adventure site--dungeon or otherwise--feel like a natural extension of the world. It will make it feel like it's supposed to be there. It will help convey the verisimilitude of the setting, and hopefully draw your players deeper into the game experience.

Solo Tools as GM Tools and Random Encounters

Not every GM is able to think on their feet "in the moment". Coming up with ideas on the fly in response to your players' actions is something that requires practice. Luckily, there are tools to help you do that. The solo tools in this book, including the "Ask the Weave" oracle, can be used to help a GM react in real time to what their characters do. By using the various randomizers and other tools, you will be empowered to think on your feet and have the world react to the actions of the players, creating a sense of true agency for them. Solo rules aren't just for solo players; they can be life-savers for GMs, too.

The solo tools (and all the tables in Chapter 12 - Travel) are great for coming up with random encounters, which, to me, are the soul of this game. Such encounters happen when the players act on their own agency, set their own agenda, and go off to unexpected places, where the GM has to improvise to see what the world provides. Improvisation may seem daunting at first, but don't be afraid of it. Trust your gut. Go with your first instincts. Allow your imagination to spark off of the players' choices.

Remember too that random events, even if rolled blindly on some table, should rarely feel random; do your best to connect new random events to what has come before. This will create a sense of continuity in your world. Randomness is yours to weave into threads that make narrative sense in light of what has already happened. Narratively connecting the details of previous random encoun-

ters as you go ("ret-conning", if you will) is, if done with care, an excellent way to build a sense of dramatic coherence. Use past events to explain unclear present randomness; tie in their details and find connection points. Find meaning in the madness!

The chaos of random events can push your creativity to unexpected places. Use the tools in this book to embrace that, and take your game into exciting, unpredictable new territory.

behind the screen

Choosing the Right Roll

TBE offers several ways to resolve tasks--standard rolls, opposed rolls, DoS results, fixed numbers, and extended rolls--and all of them exist to help you model different kinds of situations at the table. But which type to choose?

First, consider whether a roll is needed at all. If the outcome is binary and the character's relevant skill is high enough to meet the needs of the situation, you may allow them to succeed without rolling, gaining the equivalent of 1 SL (or their Expertise value, if higher). This keeps play moving and lets high skill values speak for themselves, especially for Lore skills, Perception-based searches, or straightforward social tasks.

If you've determined that a roll is required, then ask yourself one question: "Is anything actively resisting the character?" If not, call for a standard roll--it's the simplest option and usually all you need. Use task modifiers only when the task itself is inherently easier or harder than normal; this should be relatively rare, since a PC's skill value is meant to be the player's primary guide to the task's difficulty.

If something is resisting the character--a guard's Perception, an enemy's defense, a poison's effect--use an opposed roll instead. Remember, don't apply task modifiers to opposed rolls.

If the difference between the rolls should matter (extra damage, shorter duration, partial resistance), then count the DoS: the loser's SLs reduce the winner's.

If the opposing force isn't a being but a fixed effect-like a trap that does 10 damage or a poison lasting 1d4 minutes--treat that as an opposed roll vs a fixed number, using DoS if SLs would reduce the result. Otherwise, require meeting or beating the number to fully resist.

Finally, use extended rolls when the task takes more time and effort than a single roll could resolve: climbing a high cliff, researching at a library, negotiating a treaty, chasing someone across rooftops. Extended rolls build tension and track accumulated progress over time.

In every case, choose the roll type that answers the situation clearly and keeps the game moving. If you're unsure, don't sweat it; default to a standard roll or a simple opposed roll and trust the system to do the rest.

Choosing the Right Roll: Summary

- If the character is skilled enough to succeed automatically, consider whether a roll is necessary at all.
- If nothing is pushing back, use a standard roll. Add a task modifier only when the task itself is inherently easier or harder.
- If something is resisting--creature, trap, effect--use an opposed roll. That could be versus a skill roll or a fixed number.
- Use DoS when the difference in SLs matters. If partial resistance changes the outcome, difference counts.
- Use extended rolls for tasks that unfold over time.
- When in doubt, choose the simplest roll that answers the moment and keeps the game moving.

Cooperative Rolls: When to Let the Party Actually Help Each Other

Players love to say, "I help!" And sometimes they really do. Other times... they're simply Bonus Hunting. Supporting skills and Group rolls exist to make teamwork matter when it should, not to give everyone a +20 just for showing up. Here's some advice on when to use them.

Use a supporting skill when another character's involvement (or another of the rolling character's skills) genuinely improves the roll in the context of the scene. Ask yourself: Would things meaningfully change if this other skill weren't helping? If the answer is yes, great--let it support the roll. If the answer is "not really," then skip it. The Godbound quoting scripture with Divinity to bolster a Persuade attempt? Sure. Someone standing behind the rogue whispering, "You can do it!" while she picks a lock? Not so much. Support should feel earned, not assumed.

Use a Group roll when the party is acting as a bona fide unit, and you don't want five people rolling five times to do the exact same thing. Sneaking past guards? One clumsy adventurer can blow it for everyone--lowest skill, please. Scanning a room for hidden doors? One sharp-eyed character is all you need--highest skill works fine. The trick is deciding whether one person's lack of skill should pull down the whole group (or whether one person's experience should make up for everyone else's lack thereof). If yes, call for a Group roll and keep things moving. If no, let individuals roll their own fates.

In short: only use cooperative rolls when they make the scene cleaner, clearer, or more interesting. If they slow things down, or let everyone dog-pile bonuses onto a roll that should belong to one character... just stick with a normal roll. These tools are here to help the game run smoothly, not to turn every action into a team-building exercise.

Organization

For a GM, organization is critical. It can be the difference between a frustrating slog and a fun satisfying session. In a game with detailed hit locations, reductive armor, individual wounds, Combat Maneuvers, and more, knowing who got hit where is vital to running a smooth encounter. Knowing how to organize information behind the screen is crucial (this is true even in a digital environment; although the placement and organization of physical templates for quick access are of concern mostly to a GM at a table, keeping your information structured for ease of use and speed of access in a VTT serves the same purpose).

Keep well-organized notes about NPC motivations and plans, faction movements and activities, and the facts and details of events in the evolving world. Anything that may have an impact on the PCs or the status quo should be highlighted, as it can serve as inspiration for future sessions. Make a record of each session's events, especially how it relates to the PC's goals. Did they do something that directly impacts an NPC's agenda? Be sure to note that, and build that NPC's response (if any) into the next session.

Keep well-organized notes about NPC motivations and plans, faction movements and activities, and the facts and details of events in the evolving world. Anything that may have an impact on the PCs or the status quo should be highlighted, as it can serve as inspiration for future sessions.

Changing Rules

This rulebook presents a certain way to play, but not the only way. If you find a rule you don't like, change it. But understand that rule changes have ripple effects; what seems like a minor adjustment on the surface can cascade through the system, causing problems in places you never expected. Hence, before you go changing rules, try it rules-as-written first. This game was designed to provide players and GMs with a very specific experience. See if you like it before you change it into something else, something that may not provide you with the expected results.

I say this from long years of experience. Very often, I would see a new game, give it a read, and immediately leap to the conclusion that "this rule doesn't work", based on my previous experience with RPG systems. And very often I would be wrong. How a rule reads is often very different from how it plays at the table. You can't know until you try it. But once you do, if you don't like it--change it. It's your game, after all. Just be sure to communicate major changes to your players so you're all on the same page... and so they know who to blame if it all falls apart!

If you find a rule you don't like, change it. But understand that rule changes have ripple effects; what seems like a minor adjustment on the surface can cascade through the system, causing problems in places you never expected. Hence, before you go changing rules, try it rules-as-written first.

This is Not a Legal Text

I have tried very hard to make these rules as clear and understandable as possible. However, that does not mean that this rulebook should be treated like a legal document. It is always the Gamemaster's prerogative to adjust, change, or interpret rules as he or she will, based on the needs of the table.

No game is perfect, and "rules lawyers" will always try to find a loophole, or take advantage of a situation by manipulating the exact wordingof a given rule. Only you can prevent such pedantic, time-wasting chaos at your own table. Do it gently, but firmly.

Streamlining the Game

TBE is not a rules-light game. There are many procedures and subsystems, all of which are designed to create a very particular experience. For some of you, this may produce a much higher cognitive load than you're comfortable with.

On the next page you will find ideas on how to streamline certain things to reduce the cognitive load. Use some, none, or all of these, as you will. But understand that these little pieces all work together; the more of them that you remove, the more of the intended game experience you remove as well. (This may also negatively impact certain skills and Talents the PCs might have sunk valuable XP into.) So, while you can create a faster game, understand that speed of play is not the be-all-end-all consideration that it is in some other games, and you will wind up depriving your players of some of the defining connective tissue of TBE.

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CORE MECHANICS AND SKILLS

- If you're ever in doubt, the most straightforward way to resolve a task is to have the character make a standard roll. Avoid Opposed rolls unless absolutely necessary.
- Don't use Task Modifiers. Situations like Charging in a Rough zone, being Prone, or shooting into melee all have associated modifiers already. Task modifiers can muddy the waters and complicate things. Just assume that the character's skill will speak for itself.
- Using the Timer Die on extended rolls is a really interesting mechanic, but it can also slow things down. Don't use it.
- If the PC has a high enough skill value, assume they succeed and move on (see Chapter 3 - Skills: Succeeding Without a Roll).

EXPERIENCE & ADVANCEMENT

- Goals are the beating heart of a TBE character...unless you don't want them to be. If your party is having trouble with defining goals for themselves, or pursuing the ones they already have (or if you as a GM are forgetting to incorporate the PCs' goals into sessions), just give every character a flat 3 XP per session. Now, that eliminates one of the defining features of TBE characters--and, dare I say, rips out that beating heart--but some players prefer a completely freeform character who acts only according to the player's momentary whims. Give them their 3 XP and move on.

COMBAT

- Use the Quick Resolution option, as detailed at the end of Chapter 10 - Combat. That's probably your number one fastest way to speed up combat. However, you will lose most of the granularity, detail, and tactical options that make TBE combats so interesting.
- Have "minion" or "rabble" enemies flee, collapse, or surrender upon taking a single Impairment or reaching half their Death Threshold. The Ferocity rules already essentially model this, but you can make the explicit choice to inflict these consequences on a "lesser" enemy if it makes things easier for you.
- This is an option for those of you who don't like the "whiff factor" of missed melee attacks. If a character fails a melee attack roll outright (as opposed to succeeding but being beaten by the defender), they suffer the effects of the Unbalance Combat Maneuver (-20 to their next skill roll). While this option doesn't streamline the game as much as the other suggestions in this section, it does make sure that every attack roll produces some kind of result.

WOUNDS, HEALING, & PERILS

- Don't use the Infection rules. I love infection as a mechanic, and I think it's one of the most interesting and suspenseful ways to interact with wounds in a gritty world. Above all, it makes players think twice about solving every conflict with violence. However, it can add more to the mental plate, and is easily removed.
- Ignore Recovery Bonuses and Recovery rolls, and instead assume everyone heals 1 WP per wound per night of rest.

TRAVEL

- Don't use Travel Lore.
- Remove the Check for Infection step if you've decided to get rid of infection rules.
- Make several predesigned Events so that you don't have to come up with things on the fly, or borrow encounter ideas from the bazillion other RPG supplements out there. The tools in this book are designed to help the GM create interesting, spontaneous encounters of all kinds, but not everyone is comfortable with improvising in the moment.
- Simply cut to the destination and dispense with the Journey mechanics entirely: describe how the party arrives at the destination after a certain amount of travel time. Then, based loosely on indicators like the terrain, whether the party did a forced march, or any other relevant difficulty, assign each character between 3-10 Fatigue. Finally, allow each PC an opposed Endurance roll against that Fatigue, with every SL reducing it by 1.

INTRIGUE

- Let the players roleplay the situation and simply eyeball the outcome based solely on that, or on the outcome of a couple of key rolls.
- Don't use Competitive Encounters; keep them all Static.
- Don't bother with the Timer Die.
- Don't use Leverage.
- Ignore NPC Special Reactions.

MAGIC

- Have Godbound keep track of their own Piety.
- Besides the optional rule for NPC Spellweavers presented in the Bestiary, the Weave and Divine Magic rules are difficult to streamline; other than specifically deciding on the final magical effect and having a target simply roll a resistance against a fixed number, there is no real shortcut I could suggest that wouldn't dismantle the whole system. Either use the system as it is, or replace it wholesale. I leave that utterly effortless task up to you...

Now, having a look at these shortcuts, do they really save you time? Well, yes, they do. But I contend that the time you save is probably not worth the detail that you lose. Presumably, you're playing TBEbecause you want a more granular experience. So, eliminating rules also eliminates that experience. But, only you know what works best for your own table. Do as you will!

Death and New PCs

If a character dies in play, the replacement character should be given additional "Rounding Out" XP to spend during creation to make the new character more in line with the power levels of the rest of the party (and as an analgesic to the pain of losing a character!). If the deceased character was fairly inexperienced, the new character should get 0-25 XP; if seasoned, 25-75, and if experienced, 75-200. This is at GM discretion.

cHAPTER 18:

bestiary

The Broken Empires teems with threats Human and non-human, mundane and monstrous, bestial and banal. What follows is a selection of various creatures and NPCs that you can use as obstacles for your PCs to overcome in pursuit of their goals.

Keywords in this Chapter

Creature Hit Locations
Creature Special Abilities
Enemy Difficulty
Ferocity
NPC Traits
Size

NPCs do not have to be given full stats like a PC (although a GM with time on their hands always has that option). Certain rules presented here modify or replace the standard rules to make the GM's life easier (NPC Spellweavers, for example, are handled differently; see the Spellweaver Creature Special Ability).

enemy difficulty

Enemies are composed of skills, attributes like Toughness and Death Threshold, and sometimes special abilities. There isn't a hard and fast formula to compute the "correct" difficulty for an encounter; what follows are just rough guidelines to help you eyeball how hard it might be to defeat a particular foe.

A GM is free to assign whatever skill values to a foe they think appropriate, but to keep things easier to manage, here are some techniques to quickly stat up an enemy.

Difficulty by Skill

Each enemy has a Difficulty Rating, which provides their Average Skill value in the skills most relevant to their function (a violent foe's Difficulty would reflect their Combat skills, a social adversary's Difficulty their Social skills, etc.). These are just guidelines, and can be adjusted as desired. A couple of skills can be chosen to be +10-20 more than the Average Skill, which is often useful for leader types. An enemy will usually have one or two skills at their Average Skill value as indicated by their Difficulty; three or four more at their Average Skill value –10; and everything else at -30. In most cases, the minimum skill for any enemy at any Difficulty is 35.

A Challenging bandit's main skills are Melee: Medium Weapons and Dodge, both at 65. He has Endurance, Athletics, and Missile at 55, and every other skill is at 35. A leader of the Challenging bandits might have Melee: Medium at 75.

An Easy hobgoblin's skills are all 35. A hobgoblin leader might have 55 in its primary weapon skill.

Difficulty by Category

A quicker method is to simply give enemies a skill value in each Category (Combat, Adventuring, Social, Lore, Magic), which covers all the skills in that category. Assign the category most relevant to the enemy's function the Average Skill by Difficulty, one other category at -10, and all other relevant categories at -30 (to a minimum of 35).

In the case of a Challenging bandit, the most relevant category will be Combat, with all those skills at 65. His Adventuring skills are 55, Social and Lore skills 35, and Magic skills 0.

Enemy Difficulty & Ferocity

Random (d100)	Enemy Difficulty	Average Skill	Typical Ferocity
01-15	Easy	35	1
16-55	Medium	50	2
56-85	Challenging	65	3
86-95	Hard	80	4
96-99	Severe	95	5
00	Extreme	100+	6

General Framework for Combat-focused Opponents

These are some general principles when creating your own enemies:

- Easy enemies have combat skills of 35.
- Medium enemies have average skills of 50.
- Challenging enemies have average skills of 65, their Toughness may be 1-2, and they have better armor on more areas.
- Hard enemies have skills of up to 80, higher Death Thresholds, may have Toughness 2-3, good armor, Initiatives of 16, and may have one or more creature special abilities. They may also have Expertise in one or two skills, and may make tactical use of zone features.
- Severe enemies have average combat skills of up to 95, higher Death Thresholds, Toughness of 3-4, good armor, Initiatives of 18, and/or a few creature special abilities. They have at least Ex2 in one skill. They will make use of zone features and may have Resolve.
- Extreme enemies have skills of 100+, very high Death Thresholds, Toughness of 5+, great armor, Initiatives of 20 or more, and/or multiple creature special abilities. They will have 3 Expertise (Ex4) in their primary skill, and 2 in a secondary. They will use zone features, and will probably have Resolve.

Within this framework, you can dial up or down the difficulty using skill values, armor, Toughness, Death Threshold, Initiative, Expertise, Talents, or special abilities.

Remember that enemy numbers matter! Being outnumbered is a big disadvantage. Having to fight off 3 hobgoblins can be just as difficult, if not more so, than facing a single powerful opponent.

Enemy Initiative

As stated in Chapter 10: Combat, enemies act on a static Initiative value.

Enemy Initiatives should range from 5-25, where 14 is the average, and anything over 20 is supernaturally fast.

Option: Enemy Rolled Initiative

Subtract 5 from the enemy's Initiative value and add it to a d10 every round. An enemy's default Initiative is 14; if rolling, that translates to d10+9.

size

Every creature has a Size, from Minute to Colossal. Humans are Size Medium. Size affects reach, grappling, Maneuvers, and physical power.

These Size effects are already accounted for in the Bestiary stat blocks.

Combat Effects by Size Difference

Initiative

- Add 1 to the creature's Initiative for every Size category under Medium. Subtract 1 from the creature's Initiative for every Size category over Medium.

When 2 or More Sizes Apart

- Reach: A creature gains +1 Reach for every 2 Sizes it is larger than its opponent.
- Grappling: You can only Grapple creatures up to 2 Sizes larger or smaller than you.
- Might Bonus: In a Grapple, the larger creature gains +20 Might per Size category of difference.

When 3 or More Sizes Apart

- Maneuver Limits: You cannot use Drive Back, Trip, or Disarm against a creature three or more Sizes larger than you.
- Monstrous Attacks: A creature three or more Sizes larger makes melee attacks that cannot be parried, only Dodged
- Easier to Hit: All Combat skills used against a creature three or more Sizes larger are at +20.

Creature Lethality Levels & Dying

If an enemy creature drops in Shock, it is no longer a threat, and in most cases, the PCs can disregard it. Don't bother with creature Lethality Levels or the "Dying" condition; just assume the creature is dead (or remains in Shock for the Wound Die roll in minutes if it dropped from NL wounds).

If the characters want to keep the enemy alive for some reason, and it's still within about 10 rounds after the creature dropped in Shock, then roll the Wound Die + its Toughness when they check on it. If it rolls over its most wounded hit location's WP, it has stabilized and can be treated; if it rolls equal or less, it's already dead by the time the PCs get to it.

If you want to track an "important" NPC's round-by-round dying status, assign them LLs. For humanoids, start with the standard of 1/3 Death Threshold, and adjust as needed. For monsters, assume an LL of half its Death Threshold.

Minute - Diminutive - Tiny - Little - Small - Medium - Large - Huge - Massive - Gargantuan - Colossal

ferocity

Very few beings will fight to the death. Most living things will abandon a conflict ("break") as soon as they are seriously hurt. That could be fleeing, surrendering, playing dead, offering a bribe to be allowed to escape--whatever saves their hide.

Ferocity is a number between 1 and 6 that represents a creature's willingness to continue fighting once fear, pain, or hopelessness begin to take hold.

Ferocity	Description	Typical Examples
1	Breaks at the first sign of injury or fear.	Herd animals, terrified peasants
2	Holds briefly, but falters once hurt or outnumbered.	Bandits, hungry beasts, most living beings
3	Average courage; fights until badly wounded or half their allies fall.	Trained soldiers, mercenaries
4	Grim and loyal; holds until death feels certain.	Veteran guards, loyal knights
5*	Fanatical or nearly mindless; only breaks when utterly doomed.	Zealots, berserkers, demons
6*	Implacable. Never breaks under any circumstance.	Undead, constructs

*A creature with Ferocity 5 or 6 isn't subject to Compel Surrender unless the GM rules otherwise.

Ferocity Modifiers

Ferocity is a kind of built-in "morale check" that is based on the context of the situation, and can therefore change based on circumstances.

Increase Ferocity (+1 to +2) if the creature is:

- defending home, kin, or sacred ground
- in a berserk rage
- compelled by spell, faith, or command

Decrease Ferocity (-1 to -2) if the creature is:

- at a significant tactical disadvantage
- demoralized by fire, magic, or terror
- facing a superior foe or hopeless situation

A soldier may normally be Ferocity 3, but if given orders to hold the gate to his home city as long as possible, he may increase to Ferocity 4, 5, or even 6.

A Thessian bear (Ferocity 2) encountered in the woods will fight only until it is driven off in pain from an Impaired location. The same bear in its lair defending its young becomes Ferocity 6 and will die to defend them.

Ferocity Test

The GM calls for a Ferocity Test when the situation would realistically force a creature to reconsider the fight. Typical triggers include:

- Having any location Impaired or taking WP up to half the Death Threshold
- Seeing a leader or champion defeated
- When half their number has fallen
- Becoming surrounded or cornered
- Clearly facing overwhelming odds

When a Ferocity Test is triggered, roll 1d6: If the result is greater than the creature's Ferocity, it breaks--fleeing, surrendering, or otherwise abandoning the fight.

Ferocity: Roll or Decide

Ferocity is a guide, not a straitjacket. The GM may forgo the roll whenever the outcome is obvious. If the creature is hopelessly outmatched or badly wounded, and it makes sense that it would flee or surrender, simply have it do so. The roll exists for uncertain cases, not to constrain the GM's judgement.

creature special abilities

animal - Does not suffer the effects of the Compel Surrender or Disarm Maneuvers. Unless otherwise indicated, cannot perform the Compel Surrender Maneuver. Most animals will Dodge rather than parry. An animal has Natural Weapons. If the animal can Grapple, it does not become Prone when charging.

battering attacks - Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

breath weapon - The creature breathes a substance affecting the indicated target(s) for the listed damage, or having the listed effect. A breath weapon has a usage die like a Supply Die: every time the breath weapon is used, the die is rolled; on a 1-2, the weapon cannot be used again for at least an hour.

elusive - The creature can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Further, its Move is increased by 1 during its Elusive movement.

fae glamour - With a successful Willpower roll, the creature can make itself look like anyone an observer would consider friendly or desirable. This lasts for a few hours, or until the creature does something the observer would consider suspicious, at which point they get an Insight roll to see through the effect. Further suspicious actions grant a cumulative +20 to the Insight roll.

fast - The creature moves 2 zones during Movement, and/or 2 zones during a Run action.

fear rating - The creature has a Fear Rating, a fixed number in an opposed roll against a character's Willpower (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Perils: Fear).

flight - The creature can fly the listed number of zones during Movement or during a Run action.

godbound - Servants of a deity have a Piety value and listed Domains their god can draw from to provide divine effects.

grit (location) - In the specified hit location(s), the creature does not automatically drop in Shock until suffering a third impairment there.

hard-headed - The creature does not become stunned from Head impairment.

immunity - The creature has a total immunity to the listed attack forms or effects.

incorporeal - The creature is insubstantial and can travel between walls and other barriers at will. It is not affected by zone hazards of any kind. Only magic or magic weapons can affect it.

infectious wounds - Upon taking a new wound, the target must roll an Infection die + Toughness vs the new wound's value. Failure marks the wound as Infected.

knockback - When using the Drive Back Maneuver, the creature sends its opponent flying into an adjacent zone, rendering them Prone if a -20 Athletics roll is failed. The creature can choose whether or not to follow.

low-light vision - The creature can see in near-darkness as though it was full daylight.

mindless - The creature is immune to the Compel Surrender Maneuver and any mind-affecting magic or effects except Command or Bond Effects. It cannot be communicated to or reasoned with by anyone other than their controller (if any). It will never take the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

monstrous attacks - Regardless of the creature's Size, its attacks cannot be parried, only Dodged.

monstrous charge-through - If a Charge attack is successful, for 3 SLs the creature may use this ability as a Combat Maneuver to leave the Engagement and move back out to Close range, on the opposite side of the zone from where they came. Further, any foes engaged with the creature at the moment of the Charge must make a standard Dodge or Endurance roll or be knocked Prone. The creature may not become Engaged with any new foes while Charging-through.

monstrous constitution - The creature rolls a d20 Wound die.

monstrous grit - The creature never goes into Shock. (Its locations can still become Impaired on a failed Wound Die roll.)

multi-legged - A multi-legged creature has more than four legs and only falls Prone from impairment if half or more of its legs are impaired (and if the Wound Die indicates). A multi-legged creature with half or more impaired legs cannot Run or Charge. Knocking a multi-legged creature Prone using the Trip Maneuver costs an extra 4 SLs.

multiple turns - The creature acts 2 or more times per round. Each Initiative value allows for 1 action and 1 move on that Initiative.

natural weapons - A creature with Natural Weapons (claws, teeth, etc.) is considered armed, and does not suffer the -20 Might penalty against armed opponents. Natural Weapons cause lethal damage, and cannot be Disarmed. Natural Weapons can be used normally in a grapple. Non-Animal creatures with Natural Weapons can parry with them if desired.

never surrender - A creature can resist the Compel Surrender Maneuver more effectively. It makes its opposed Willpower roll with a +20 bonus.

night vision - The creature can see in the dark, like a cat.

pack tactics - When Outnumbering an opponent, all the creature's Maneuver costs are lowered by 1.

poison - The creature uses poison via stinger, fang, etc. The venom opposes the target's Endurance (see Chapter 11 - Wounds, Healing, & Poison), causing effects as detailed in the creature's description.

quadruped - A four-legged creature only falls Prone from impairment if two or more legs become impaired (and if the Wound Die indicates). A quadruped with one or more impaired legs cannot Run or Charge. Knocking a quadruped prone using the Trip Maneuver costs an extra 3 SLs.

resistant - The creature gets additional protection from the listed types of attacks in the form of AP.

resolve - The creature has the listed amount of Resolve points it can spend.

slow - The creature cannot take the Run action.

smaller - The creature is at least 3 Sizes smaller than Medium, which increases a Medium attacker's Reach against the creature by 1 per 2 Sizes. The creature can only Dodge such attacks. It has Size-based Maneuver limits: it cannot perform Drive Back, Trip, Grapple, or Disarm on Medium or larger enemies.

spellweaver - Instead of crafting spells like a player would, the GM may use a simplified system for NPC spellweavers. See example.

talent - The creature has the listed Talent as described in Chaper 4 - Talents

terrain mastery - The creature can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without the need for Athletics rolls. It will not fall Prone if being Driven Back into a Rough zone.

undead - Undead ignore all aspects of living processes (breathing, sleeping, being affected by poison or disease, etc.). They are immune to the Compel Surrender Maneuver and any mind-affecting spells, including illusions. All Undead are Hard-headed and have Monstrous Grit. They are Vulnerable to Spirit magic, and any rolls to resist such magic are at -20. They only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

unearthly - Only magic or magic weapons can hurt the creature.

vulnerable - If a creature takes damage from the listed sources, add 3 WP to any resulting wound (after armor and other reductions). There may also be additional penalties as listed.

NPC Spellweavers

The GM chooses the desired magical effect, along with a Bind and Strand, ensuring the spell's effect conforms to the laws and assumptions of Weave magic. Magnitude is abstracted into the roll and does not require separate consideration.

NPCs do not track Resolve. Instead, make their Bind roll:

- Success: The spell is cast. The Bind roll sets the spell's resistance, as usual.
  - » If the ones die is equal to or less than the Strand, the spell is controlled--no Weave Reaction.
  - » If the roll's ones die is greater than Strand, or a natural "0" regardless of Strand value, the spell is uncontrolled--roll 1d20 on the Weave Reaction Table.
- Failure: The spell fails. No Weave Reaction occurs.
- Critical Success: Add +3 SLs. No Weave Reaction occurs.
- Critical Failure: The spell fails and immediately triggers a Weave Reaction (roll 1d20+5 on the Weave Reaction Table). The NPC may cast only one more successful spell in this encounter before their "Resolve" is spent.

Some Weave Reactions will not meaningfully apply to NPCs (for example, gaining 1d4 Fatigue); simply step down to the next lower result until landing on something that makes sense.

When an NPC's attack spell hits:

- Roll a d10 to determine the general hit location (replacing the standard rule where the caster's ones die sets the hit location).
- Then, use the target's ones die from their defense roll to determine the detailed location struck.

Magical skills and pre-crafted spells are provided for convenience and inspiration in the NPC's entry, with spells in the following format:

Bind Strand vs resistance skill; Spell Effect

Control Air vs Endurance: Cause an existing wind to lash out at a single target at Close range, Dmg 6 external

Option 1: If the NPC is listed with a full Resolve score, the GM may instead use the standard rules for crafting spells via Weave magic. However, do not combine this with the Spellweaver shortcut--choose one approach.

Option 2: A GM can just assume a fixed number for a particular spell and avoid making the spell roll altogether (see Chapter 2 - Core Mechanics: Opposing a Fixed Number).

(See Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying in the Broken Empires: NPC Spellweavers for another variant.)

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creatures of the broken empires

These creature entries are examples of an average specimen of its type. It is easy enough to adjust skill values, Death Thresholds, Armor Points, etc., to whatever you need them to be. Each entry uses the following stat block format:

Creature Name

Difficulty

Description

Size X Init X Move X Ferocity X

Common skills listed by Category and alphabetically

Weapon Attack, Parry, Reach, Expertise (Ex), Damage (Dmg)+Piercing (P)(CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5), Traits, Range + Any Shield (AP)

1-5 Body Armor+Shield AP
6 RArm Armor+Shield AP
7 LArm Armor+Shield AP
8 RLeg Armor+Shield AP
9 LLeg Armor+Shield AP
0 Head Armor+Shield AP

Toughness X DeathThreshold X

Special Abilities

Only the most relevant skills are listed. If you wish to add skills to the creature, do so using the Difficulty by Skill section as guidance.

Creatures capable of using different weapons may include multiple numbered weapon examples (#1, #2, etc.) so the GM can conveniently arm groups of the same creature with different weapons. These are examples only; equip them with whatever weapons best suit the encounter.

If special abilities or Talents are listed, any relevant modifications have already been made in the stat block. For example:

A The -1 Disarm cost for the Talent Disarming Hit: Medium Weapons is already incorporated into a Guard Captain's Broadsword entry.

A A Highland Giant's +1 Reach for greater Size is already listed under its attack (assumes a Medium Size PC).

AP assumes armor as listed in Chapter 9 - Equipment If wearing armor, assume the creature is trained in its use. Any relevant armor penalties have been factored in. If a creature has natural armor of 4+ AP , it can be bypassed with the Pierce Armor Combat Maneuver.

Combat Maneuvers commonly used by the creature will be listed with their cost. Unless otherwise stated, non-weapon specific Combat Maneuver costs are standard (UnB1, DB3, PA4) and commonly available to the creature.

If a creature has multiple attack forms listed, unless otherwise specified, choose which one attack they use on their turn. If they have multiple turns in a round, they may alternate attack modes as desired, and their Initiative will show what turns they act on (12/6, for example).

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Assassin of the Silent Death

Hard

An ancient organization operating in Ansharir and the Red Wastes, the Silent Death is a secretive group contracted only by the most powerful and depraved interests. It is whispered that their true purpose is to serve the labyrinthine machinations of the Sleeping God, a long-forgotten deity out of the deepest desert. They are known as much for their ability to walk almost unseen as they are for their prodigious use of deadly poisons.

Size Med Init 17 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 80, Might 60, Athletics 60, Endurance 60, Perception 60, Stealth 90, Willpower 40

Scimitar 80 Ex2, Dmg 4 + Poison (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5) + Small Shield (3 AP)

Shortbow 70, Dmg 2 (CL4, CS5, Dis5, T5) 2H, Range 3

1-5	Body 3+3 AP	8	RLeg 1+3 AP
6	RArm 2+3 AP	9	LLeg 1+3 AP
7	LArm 2+3 AP	0	Head 3+3 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 20

Poison, envenomed weapons : Shadowshade, Endurance DoS vs 6: Suffer 6 Internal damage, reduced by SLs. Delivery: Weapon coat. Onset: Instant. First hit only.

Talent - Precise Strike : CL with Missile costs 1 less SL.

Bandit

Medium

A ruffian met in the wilds, who, for their own reasons, is bent on accosting and robbing travelers.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 1

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 40, Endurance 50, Perception 40, Willpower 35

Hand Axe 50, Dmg 2 (CL3, CS2, Dis5, T6) + Small Shield (3 AP)

1-5	Body 3+3 AP	8	RLeg 1+3 AP
6	RArm 2+3 AP	9	LLeg 1+3 AP
7	LArm 2+3 AP	0	Head 2+3 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 13

Bandit, Experienced

Challenging

A seasoned and embittered thief, unafraid to kill in pursuit of larceny.

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 70, Might 50, Athletics 70, Endurance 80, Perception 50, Willpower 40

Bearded Axe 80, Parry 60, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS2, Dis3, T5) + Med Shield (4 AP)

1-5	Body 4+4 AP	8	RLeg 2+4 AP
6	RArm 3+4 AP	9	LLeg 2+4 AP
7	LArm 3+4 AP	0	Head 3+4 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 15

Bandit Lord

Hard

A hardened thug fancying himself a lord among criminal scum, who strikes out at unsuspecting victims from his wilderness stronghold.

Size Med Init 10 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 70, Might 70, Athletics 80, Endurance 80, Perception 60, Willpower 40, Insight 60, Intimidate 70

Spear 90, Parry 70, Reach 1, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL3, CS3, Dis5, T5), Thrown, Range 1

Broadsword 90 Ex3, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)
+ Med Shield (4 AP)

1-5	Body 5+4 AP	8	RLeg 2+4 AP
6	RArm 4+4 AP	9	LLeg 2+4 AP
7	LArm 4+4 AP	0	Head 7+4 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 25

Never Surrender : Opposed Willpower roll to resist the Compel Surrender Maneuver +20.

Barbarian Warrior

Challenging

Every area of the Broken Empires contains remote tribes of humans living in the wilderness, unconstrained by national laws or borders. Most are hostile to outsiders.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 60, Might 70, Athletics 80, Endurance 60, Perception 60, Willpower 40, Insight 40, Intimidate 60

Spear 70, Parry 50, Reach 1, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL3, CS3, Dis5, T5), Thrown, Range 1
+ Med Shield (4 AP)

Longbow 70, Dmg 3 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), Range 4

1-5	Body 4+4 AP	8	RLeg 2+4 AP
6	RArm 3+4 AP	9	LLeg 2+4 AP
7	LArm 3+4 AP	0	Head 4+4 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 20

Basilisk

Medium

The basilisks of southern Sattagoya are sluggish, nocturnal dog-sized lizards with a paralyzing venom transmitted through their bite. Those who fail the opposed Endurance roll are temporarily paralyzed, giving the basilisk enough time to feed. The paralysis effect has given rise to legends of basilisks turning people to stone; little do people know that those legends are in fact real, but only in the form of the seldom-seen greater basilisks...

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50 Ex2, Might 55, Athletics 50, Endurance 60, Perception 60, Stealth 50, Willpower 50

Bite 40, Dmg 3 + Venom (CL3, CS2, Dis3, T3)

1-3	Body 4 AP	7	LMidLeg 1 AP
4	RFrontLeg 1 AP	8	RRearLeg 1 AP
5	LFrontLeg 1 AP	9	LRearLeg 1 AP
6	RMidLeg 1 AP	0	Head 5 AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 10

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Paralyzing Venom : Endurance DoS vs 3; Paralyzed for 1 hour per DoS.

Multi-legged : Only falls Prone from impairment if 3+ legs are impaired. If 3+ legs are impaired, it cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs creature costs +4 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Basilisk, Greater

Challenging

The feared greater basilisks are known by the tribesmen of the Sar'Lor Mountains as "stone dragons", as unlike their lesser cousins, these terrifying lizards actually do have the power to turn a creature to stone. Anyone who falls under the gaze of a greater basilisk must make an opposed Willpower roll against the basilisk's Gaze skill to keep their eyes averted; failing results in transformation into a living statue for up to several days. In stone form, the person is in a kind of unconscious stasis and does not feel the effects of hunger, sleep deprivation, environmental effects, or anything else. However, whatever damage is done to their statue form is reflected on the person upon recovery; this can often prove fatal. Luckily, the greater basilisks are reclusive creatures who mostly rely on fear of their petrifying gaze to keep predators away.

A cadre of local tribal warriors known as the "Eyeless" have taken to training these creatures as mounts. But even they steer clear of the highest mountain peaks in the Sar'Lor range, for there are rumors of a terrifying "true" basilisk species lairing up there, whose petrifying effect lasts for years.

Size Large Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 40, Might 80, Athletics 45, Endurance 70, Perception 70, Stealth 60, Willpower 40

Bite 60, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS2, Dis3, T2)

1-3	Body	5 AP	7	LMidLeg	2 AP
4	RFrontLeg	2 AP	8	RRearLeg	2 AP
5	LFrontLeg	2 AP	9	LRearLeg	2 AP
6	RMidLeg	2 AP	0	Head	5 AP

Toughness +2 DeathThreshold 23

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Petrifying Gaze : 70 vs Willpower; turn to stone for 1 day per DoS.

Multi-legged : Only falls Prone from impairment if 3+ legs are impaired. If 3+ legs are impaired, it cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs creature costs +4 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Boar

Medium

Feral pigs with a wild temper and razor-sharp tusks, these creatures are prized for their pelts and succulent meat. Hunting a wild boar specifically requires a full day's hunt in an appropriate region, a Track roll, and a successful combat. Wild boar meat produces 1d4+1 Ration Supply steps.

Size Small Init 16 Move 1 Ferocity 5

Dodge 50 Ex2 , Might 50 , Athletics 50 , Endurance 60 , Perception 60 , Stealth 65 , Willpower 50

Tusks 60, Dmg 3 + P2 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T3)

1-5	Body	3 AP	8	RRearLeg	2 AP
6	RFrontLeg	2 AP	9	LRearLeg	2 AP
7	LFrontLeg	2 AP	0	Head	3 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 10

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Quadruped : Prone from impairment only if 2+ legs become impaired. If one or more legs impaired, cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs quadruped +3 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Bolg Fiir Sorcerer

Challenging

Trained in the destructive arts, this Bolg Fiir spell-weaver uses their natural affinity with the Weave to maximum effect.

Size Med Init 15 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 60 , Might 55 , Athletics 50 , Endurance 55 , Perception 65 , Stealth 55 , Willpower 75

Broadsword 50, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-5	Body	3 AP	8	RLeg	1 AP
6	RArm	2 AP	9	LLeg	1 AP
7	LArm	2 AP	0	Head	3 AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 20

Spellweaver :

Binds : Change 45 , Conjure 35 , Control 65 , Destroy 75 Ex2 , Witness 40

Strands : Body 4 , Fire 5 , Spheres 2 , Thought 3

Destroy Body vs Willpower; corrupts flesh, Dmg 4.

Control Body vs Willpower; controls the target like a puppet for 1 minute.

Control Fire vs Endurance; causes an existing fire to lash out at a single adjacent target at Close range. Dmg 5 external.

Talent : Unerring Bolt (Fire attacks +1 dmg).

Bounty Hunter

Challenging

Many criminals seek to escape the law by fleeing into the vast wildernesses of the Broken Empires. Bounty Hunters are often tasked by their employers with bringing those criminals back to face justice--or whatever passes for justice in the employer's jurisdiction.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 65 , Might 60 , Athletics 55 , Endurance 65 , Perception 60 , Stealth 70 , Survival 60 , Track 75 Ex2 , Willpower 45

Longbow 70, Dmg 3 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), 2H, Range 4

Whip 65, Reach 1, Dmg 1 (CL2, CS2, Dis5, T3), cannot parry

Broadsword 55, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-5	Body	4 AP	8	RLeg	3 AP
6	RArm	3 AP	9	LLeg	3 AP
7	LArm	3 AP	0	Head	2 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 20

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Brutesworn (Brakk-Thuun)

Challenging

The Brutesworn (Brakk-Thuun in Tusker) are a degenerate offshoot of the Ogre species--descendants of ancient clans whose entire bloodlines collapsed into the Breaking and never recovered. Over generations, that psychic catastrophe became hereditary, warping both mind and body. A Brutesworn resembles an Ogre only in silhouette: hunched, overmuscled, with a jutting bone-cracker jaw and long, dragging arms built for tearing prey apart. Their skin is thick and swollen and their tusks serrated, though they do not possess the swirling horns of the Ogres.

They do not speak, laugh, or think in anything approaching reason. What remains is instinctive cunning, a predator's focus, and a compulsion to feed on anything living. They drift in loose mobs rather than true packs, drawn together by the scent of blood or the promise of slaughter. When roused, a Brutesworn charge is less a coordinated attack than a devouring stampede--clumsy, loud, and utterly unstoppable until every source of meat is consumed.

Among Ogres, the Brutesworn are a glimpse of what their people might become if the Breaking ever fully triumphs.

Size Large Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 40, Might 80, Athletics 50, Endurance 80, Perception 55, Stealth 40, Willpower 50

Claw 65, Dmg 6 (CL3, CS2, Dis4, T4)

Biting Maw 70, Dmg 3 + P4 (CL2, CS2)

1-5	Body 4 AP	8	RLeg 3 AP
6	RArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 3 AP
7	LArm 3 AP	0	Head 5 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 25

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Brutesworn Feast : After dealing any WP with a Biting Maw attack, the Brutesworn heals up to 3 WP on a random wound.

Grit : Does not automatically drop in Shock until suffering a third impairment in the Head or Body.

Knockback : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with Claw.

Dark Fae: Changeling

Variable

The Dark Fae are bizarre faerie creatures, resembling the now-vanished Duanan Seethe or even lordly Men, but cold, ethereal, and utterly inhuman. They have a penchant for stealing Human children (and sometimes even adults) and replacing them with a changeling, a magical duplicate that resembles the original in every way, even possessing the victim's memories up to the point of abduction. The imposter ages as the original would, and develops skills as expected to better fit in and continue the ruse.

The resemblance of a changeling to its replaced victim is only skin deep, however; no blood flows through the changeling's constructed veins, and cutting the flesh reveals twigs, bits of string, metal wire, colored paper, and other materials as one might find in a bird's nest. With concentration, the changeling can heal such wounds.

A changeling is an imperfect copy of the original, and possesses all the original's skills, but at -10. It wears whatever armor the original would, but it has its own Toughness and Death Threshold. It cannot change shape or revert to its "original form", as it was made specifically to replace its intended victim. When a changeling is slain, it dissolves into an oily puddle of sticks and string, releasing the eerie sound of wailing children wafting away on the wind.

Size X* Init 15 Movex* Ferocity 2

*As original

All skillsas original, -10

Weapon skills as original

1-5	Body AP X+3	8	RLeg AP X+3
6	RArm AP X+3	9	LLeg AP X+3
7	LArm AP X+3	0	Head AP X+3

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 16

Immunity : Immune to charm or other mental effects.

Mesmerize : Willpowervs 4 or be Charmed as per the Weave magic Mental Effect for 1 hour.

Regeneration : As an action, a changeling can heal every wound by 1 WP .

Resistant : +3 AP vs non-magical weapons.

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Dark Fae: Queen's Huntsman

Challenging

When a Replaced escapes captivity and finds his or her way through the Thorns, the Dark Fae send forth the Queen's Hunt, a pack of four or five misshapen faerie creatures whose sole purpose is to track down the Replaced and bring them back to the Fae Queen. Though they take on many shapes, they are all gifted with the power of glamour and illusion so as to hide their true nature from the world at large. But if a Huntsman is ever viewed in a reflective surface--a mirror, a placid pond, the eyes of an innocent--the creature's true form can be seen. For this reason, they avoid such reflective surfaces and will momentarily recoil from a mirror, giving a victim a brief opportunity to flee. This clever trick only effectively works the first time a Huntsman is encountered: each further use gives the Huntsman a +20 on the Willpower roll.

Huntsmen will try to take their quarry alive, seeking to render them Unconscious or in Shock so they may transport them back beyond the Thorns.

The Huntsman detailed below is but one typical humanoid example. They can look like small goblin-like creatures, wolves with heads of vultures, hulking hairy Ogre-like brutes, or anything else.

Size Med Init 14 Move 2 Ferocity 3

Dodge 65, Might 65, Athletics 65, Endurance 65, Perception 70, Stealth 85, Willpower 60

Claws 65 Ex2, Dmg 3 (CL2, CS3, Dis4, T5)

Sling 70, Dmg 1 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5)

1-5	Body 3 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
6	RArm 2 AP	9	LLeg 1 AP
7	LArm 2 AP	0	Head 3 AP

Toughness +2 DeathThreshold 20

Fae Glamour : Willpower to make itself look like anyone an observer would consider friendly or desirable for a few hours, or until the Huntsman does something the observer would consider suspicious, at which point they get an Insight roll to see through the effect. Further suspicious actions grant a cumulative +20 to the Insight roll.

Fast : Moves 2 zones during Movement, and 2 zones during a Run action.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with Claws.

Pack Tactics : When Outnumbering an opponent, all the creature's Maneuver costs are lowered by 1.

Recoil : If seeing their own reflection, a Huntsman must make a Willpower roll or be stunned as if from a Head Impairment for 1d4 rounds.

Death Knight

Extreme

An unliving abomination who in life was tricked or lulled into the service of a greater undead creature, like a lich. Only great warriors are compelled to service as a Death Knight, and are encased in forbidding black plate armor. They wield enormous two-handed runeswords, which they wield one-handed. With a gesture, they can draw the life-force from a victim and use it to repair their own wounds.

Size Med Init 14/4 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 50, Might 85, Athletics 70, Endurance 90, Perception 60, Willpower 60

Runesword 120, Parry 100, Ex3, Dmg 6 (CL5, CS5, Dis3, T2, DB2)
+ Large Shield (5 AP)

1-5	Body 7+5 AP	8	RLeg 7+5 AP
6	RArm 7+5 AP	9	LLeg 7+5 AP
7	LArm 7+5 AP	0	Head 7+5 AP

Toughness +8 DeathThreshold 30

Fear Rating 6 : Target rolls Willpower vs 6.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Multiple Turns : Acts on 14 and 4.

Soul-drain 70 : Action. Target in Close range rolls opposed Endurance, suffer 1 "Soul drain" WP per DoS to the Body; remove equal WPs from any combination of the Death Knight's wounds.

Talent - Enhanced Defense : Opponents only get +10 Outnumbering bonus.

Talent - Stable Stance : Trip Maneuvers vs Death Knight +1 SL.

Talent - Strong Grip : Disarm Maneuvers vs Death Knight +1 SL.

Undead : Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Vulnerable : +3 WP to any resulting wound caused by Spirit magic. Any rolls to resist at -20.

Devonan Cultist

Medium

Fanatical cults of Devona exist in many port cities or on islands throughout the Broken Empires. Though most are not proper Godbound, cult adherents try to enact Devona's seemingly chaotic desires as best as they understand them; which, with Devona, is a confusing task at best.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 35, Endurance 40, Perception 40, Willpower 50

Mace 50, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

Lt Crossbow 55, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), 2H, Range 2, Reload 1

If Godbound: Piety 60, Domains Wrath, Water, Dreams, Magic

1-5	Body 2 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
6	RArm 1 AP	9	LLeg 1 AP
7	LArm 1 AP	0	Head 1 AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 15

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Dragon

Extreme

The great fire-breathing lizards out of legend are extraordinarily rare, thankfully. An enraged dragon is easily the most dangerous creature in all of the Broken Empires.

A dragon spends most of its time asleep on its treasure hoard, unless roused to anger or vengeance. The wrath of a dragon is terrible to behold; they slay any who stand between them and the source of their fury, and will not rest until sated or avenged.

Some speak the languages of Men and Elves (High Vestrian and High Court Fionnan), while others are incapable of speech. Regardless, their great weakness is their pride: lavishing praise on a dragon is a good way to distract it from eating you. Any successful Wit, Protocol, or Perform roll of an appropriately flattering nature is opposed by a dragon's Insight: each SL of difference keeps the dragon's attention on the speaker for 1 round (after which subsequent flattering attempts suffer a cumulative -20 penalty). These tactics fail immediately if the dragon feels its treasure is threatened, or if it is attacked in any way.

Size Gargantuan Init 12/5 Move ? Ferocity 4

? Creature can fly

Dodge 40, Might 90 Ex4, Athletics 50, Endurance 105, Perception 80 Ex3, Willpower 90 Ex3, Insight 60, Wit 65

Claws or Bite 95, Reach 2, Ex4, Dmg 10 + P3 (CL4, CS5, Dis5, T3)

Tail Sweep 70, Reach 3, Dmg 8 + Knockback (DB 3)

1-2	Body 6 AP	7	RWing 4 AP*
3	RFrontLeg 5 AP	8	LWing 4 AP*
4	LFrontLeg 5 AP	9	Tail 6 AP**
5	RRearLeg 5 AP	0	Head 7 AP
6	LRearLeg 5 AP		

Toughness +15 DeathThreshold 60

*Impaired Wing: no Flight possible

**Impaired Tail: no Tail Sweep possible

Breath Weapon, d12 : All individuals in one adjacent zone make Dodge DoS rolls vs 1d12+5 external fire damage to all hit locations.

Crushing Landing : Flying Might attack (5 + SL damage + opponent Pinned: as Grappled)

Elusive : Can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Move 2 during Elusive movement.

Flight 2 : Can fly 2 zones during Movement.

Fear Rating 3 : Target rolls Willpower vs 3.

Knockback (with Tail attack) : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Low-light Vision : Sees in near-darkness as though daylight.

Monstrous Attacks : Attacks can only be Dodged

Monstrous Constitution : Rolls a d20 Wound die.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Multiple Turns : Acts on 12 and 5.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with Claws.

Never Surrender : Opposed Willpower roll to resist the Compel Surrender Maneuver +20.

Quadruped : Prone from impairment only if 2+ legs become impaired. If one or more legs impaired, cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs quadruped +3 SLs.

Resolve : 10

Talent - Great Defense : Opponents only get +10 Outnumbering bonus; one opponent of your choice gets no outnumbering bonus.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Earthbinder Spellweaver

Challenging

While the druids seek to work within the balance of nature, the Earthbinders seek to subjugate it to their will. They force the Strands of Earth to do their bidding, even to the outrage of the Weave itself. Consequently, Earthbinder spells have a tendency to be of higher Magnitude, leading to more volatile castings.

Size Med Init 16 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 45, Might 35, Athletics 35, Endurance 45, Perception 50, Willpower 65

Staff 65, Parry 75, Reach 1, Dmg 4 NL (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-5	Body 3 AP	8	RLeg 3 AP
6	RArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 3 AP
7	LArm 3 AP	0	Head 3 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 15

Spellweaver

Binds : Change 65, Conjure 35, Control 65 Ex2, Destroy 45, Witness 35

Strands : Air 2, Beast 4, Earth 5, Plants 3

Control Earth vs Dodge; hurls boulders at 1 target. Dmg 8 external.

Control Earth vs Willpower; Restrains 2 targets in 1 zone for 1 min.

Change Plant; add 3 AP in all locations on self until Sun. Already cast before combat.

Destroy Earth; create Blocked zone (a pit under the enemy), vs Athletics to get out.

Elder Tree

Hard

Elder Trees were originally awakened by the Duanan Seethe millennia ago to function as sentinels of their forest borders. They exist there still, carrying on their vigilant watch despite their old masters having long since disappeared.

Size Huge Init 10 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 50, Might 75, Athletics 50, Endurance 80, Perception 70, Willpower 85, Insight 80

Tree limb arm strike 85 Ex2, Dmg 6 (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T2); either arm can be used for this attack.

1-5	Body 6 AP	8	RLeg 5 AP
6	RArm 4 AP	9	LLeg 5 AP
7	LArm 4 AP	0	Head 6 AP

Toughness 4 DeathThreshold 30

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Knockback : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with arm.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Vulnerable : Add 3 WP to any resulting wound caused by fire.

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Fire Elemental

Challenging

The Weave sometimes infuses out-of-control fires with a power all of their own, bringing a fire elemental into existence. These primal, unthinking creatures are pure flame, and seek only to consume and grow. The more flame they spread, the stronger they become: their damage increases by 1 after each successful hit on a target (no wound necessary). Only magic and water can quench these burning terrors.

Size Med Init 16 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 55, Might 65, Athletics 55, Endurance 75, Perception 55, Willpower 35

Flame Tendril 65, Dmg 3 + special (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T3)

1-0 FlamingForm 0 AP

Toughness - DeathThreshold 12

Flame Tendril : Damage increases after each time it hits any target, to a maximum of 7 damage.

Immunity : Fire, normal weapons, impairment

Mindless : Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting effects except Command or Bond Effects. Cannot be communicated to or reasoned with. Never takes the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

Monstrous Attacks : Attacks can only be Dodged

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Vulnerable : Add 3 WP to any resulting wound caused by water-based attacks.

Ghost

Hard

When someone of strong will is murdered, dies through another's negligence, or meets an unusual or mysterious end, there is a small chance their spirit resists the call to the next world and instead remains to haunt either the killer, or the place of their death.

Ghosts are perpetually trapped within the moment of their demise, reliving the moment over and over again in their undead minds. They may freely project the pain and suffering of their torment onto the person (or anyone in the area) they are haunting. This prevents the victims from getting any sleep for as long as the ghost persists. Their wail of misery and anger can cause fear and physically age anyone it's directed at, causing necrotic wounds. The wail can be used once per victim, per encounter. Critically failing a resistance roll to the wail turns the victim's hair stark white.

Not all ghosts are aggressive. Some even experience a form of supernatural dementia, with brief "moments of clarity" where they suddenly understand that they are no longer alive, but not altogether dead either. These moments rarely last, but they present an opportunity: in its brief lucidity, the ghost could reveal a truth about its fate that could allow the living to help the tormented creature find release.

"Killing" a ghost only causes it to reform between a day and a year later, depending on the ghost. A ghost cannot be permanently dispatched until the cause of its death is revealed and it believes justice has been done.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 50, Might 50, Athletics 80, Endurance 65, Perception 90, Stealth 90, Willpower 75 Ex3, Insight 50

Ice cold touch 70, Dmg 3 + P6 (CL2, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-0 GhostlyForm 0 AP

Toughness - DeathThreshold 15

Fear Rating 4 : Target rolls Willpower vs 4.

Ghostly Wail : Willpower DoS vs 6; take 1 "Necrotic" internal damage per DoS to the Body + age 1 year per DoS.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Immunity : Impairment.

Incorporeal : Insubstantial, can travel between walls at will. Not affected by zone hazards. Only affected by magic or magic weapons.

Monstrous Attacks : Attacks can only be Dodged

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Undead : Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Unearthly : Only affected by magic or magic weapons.

Vulnerable : +3 WP to any resulting wound caused by Spirit magic. Any rolls to resist at -20.

Golem

Variable

A construct animated through Weave magic to serve its creator. A golem can be made from any kind of material represented by the Earth Strand: stone, metal, gemstones, etc. (See Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Ritual Examples)

Size Large Init 8 Move 1 Ferocity 6

All skills 1?2 Caster's

Fist (1?2 Caster's skill), Dmg 5 (CL1, CS2, Dis3, T4)

1-5	Body 5 AP	8	RLeg 4 AP
6	RArm 4 AP	9	LLeg 4 AP
7	LArm 4 AP	0	Head 4 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 25

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Knockback : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Mindless : Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting effects except Command or Bond Effects. Cannot be communicated to or reasoned with. Never takes the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with Fist.

Guard Captain

Challenging

A skilled commander of the town watch, a guard captain tolerates no law-breaking within his jurisdiction.

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 55, Might 60, Athletics 55, Endurance 65, Perception 50, Willpower 65, Insight 55, Intimidate 65, Law-wise 70

Broadsword 75 Ex2, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T5)
+ Med Shield (4 AP)

1-5	Body 5+4 AP	8	RLeg 3+4 AP
6	RArm 4+4 AP	9	LLeg 3+4 AP
7	LArm 4+4 AP	0	Head 7+4 AP

Toughness +2 DeathThreshold 21

Never Surrender : Opposed Willpower roll to resist the Compel Surrender Maneuver +20.

Talent - Disarming Hit : -1 SL Disarm with Medium weapons.

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Guard, Gate

Medium

Large walled settlements throughout the Broken Empires will have their gates tended by well-trained guards. Gate guards are often stationed in pairs and armed with halberds.

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 50, Might 50, Athletics 40, Endurance 50, Perception 50, Willpower 40, Insight 50

Halberd 50, Parry 30, Reach 1, Dmg 6 (CL5, CS5, Dis3, T2), +10 vs mounted, Overbearing (DB2)

1-5	Body 4 AP	8	RLeg 2 AP
6	RArm 2 AP	9	LLeg 2 AP
7	LArm 2 AP	0	Head 5 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 15

Guard, Town

Medium

Every settlement will have a local constabulary who tend to look unfavorably on heavily armed adventurers wandering into their town.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 50, Might 50, Athletics 40, Endurance 40, Perception 50, Willpower 40, Intimidate 50

Spear 50, Parry 30, Reach 1, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL3, CS3, Dis5, T5), Thrown, Range 1

Broadsword 50, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-5	Body 4 AP	8	RLeg 2 AP
6	RArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 2 AP
7	LArm 3 AP	0	Head 5 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 15

Half Giant (Fomor)

Hard

The twisted, malformed giants known as the Fomor are the forgotten debased cousins of both the Bolg Fiir and the Duanan Seethe. The half giants stand almost 8 feet tall, with patches of coarse hair spottily covering their warty flesh. Hunchbacks, bulbous uneven eyes, and other deformities dominate their appearance, and they have a pungent odor that often heralds their appearance. Half giants are filled with a hatred of most other living things (especially their fairer kin, the Bolg Fiir), and they have the unholy strength to tear a man in half. Luckily, they are not known for their intelligence, but most possess a low cunning that still makes them threatening opponents. They can be found throughout the north, most often haunting the far highlands of Dunblaine in small groups of three or four. They carry massive clubs, and their tough, calloused hide gives them 3 AP everywhere.

Size Large Init 10 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 40, Might 80 Ex3 , Athletics 60, Endurance 70, Perception 50, Stealth 50, Willpower 40

Greatclub 75, Parry 55, Reach 1, Dmg 6 (CL5, CS5, Dis3, T2, ClSh), 2H

1-5	Body 3 AP	8	RLeg 3 AP
6	RArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 3 AP
7	LArm 3 AP	0	Head 3 AP

Toughness +4 DeathThreshold 22

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Highland Giant

Hard

Before the race of Men came and imposed their will on the Weave, the giants were friends to the Dwarves, and almost as highly regarded for their architectural prowess. It was they who first taught the Dwarves how to build the magnificent stone arches and domes so often seen in ancient Dwarven craftsmanship. Alas, the magical raising of the Iron Veil took its toll upon the gentle giant folk, somehow rendering them into little more than simple-minded cave-dwellers. No one knows the causal connection between the world-shaking magics used to create the Veil and the fall of the giants, but today, all that is left of their artisanal heritage are overgrown ruins of towers and castles, hidden away in the secret places of the world.

As they are now, the giants of the Broken Empires are 12-15' tall solitary creatures who keep to themselves most of the time. Foolish is the adventurer who unknowingly sets foot in a giant's cave, for their fury at having their home invaded is terrifying to behold. Their hide is tough, granting them variable AP on their hit locations, as indicated.

Loremasters claim that Highland giants have a peculiar vulnerability to the long-forgotten songs and stories of their ancient past. If a giant hears anyone singing the Dwarven songs of old Mountainholme, sung in the original Kharzhad, it must make a Willpower roll opposed to the singer's Perform. Failure indicates it sinks to the ground, morose and full of nostalgic despair, unwilling to fight any further unless its life continues to be threatened.

Size Massive Init 10 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50, Might 85, Athletics 60, Endurance 95, Perception 55, Willpower 50

Log 85, Parry 65, Ex2, Reach 1, Dmg 8 (CL5, CS4, Dis3, T2)

1-5	Body 4 AP	8	RLeg 2 AP
6	RArm 2 AP	9	LLeg 2AP
7	LArm 2 AP	0	Head 3 AP

Toughness +6 DeathThreshold 35

Elusive : Can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Move 2 during Elusive movement.

Knockback : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Monstrous Attacks : Attacks can only be Dodged.

Vulnerable : Special (Kharzhad songs)

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Hobgoblin

Easy

Assumed to be a branch of the Dark Fae, the race of Hobgoblins seems at first glance like a cross between orcs and ogres, although they are smaller in stature than either. Hobgoblins carve labyrinthine lairs out of the hearts of mountains, with vast underground tunnel networks crisscrossing whole ranges. It is said that they stole their knowledge of tunnel-craft from the Dwarves millennia ago, a touchy subject best avoided while within the hearing of any Dwarf. Whatever the truth may be, the hobgoblins wasted no time occupying the deserted underground cities and way stations the Dwarves abandoned after the fall of their empire. Beware crossing the mountains of the Broken Empires during a storm, for the hobgoblins use the thunder and lightning as a distraction to mask their approach. They can appear out of nowhere to drag an unsuspecting party down into their dark cities to be eaten... or worse.

Hobgoblin runts are called goblins. They are smaller and faster (Dodge and Athletics 50, Might and Endurance 20, Death Threshold 5), but just as ferocious and cunning. They are rarely seen outside the mountains.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 35, Might 35, Athletics 35, Endurance 45, Perception 40, Stealth 55, Willpower 35

#1 - Bearded Axe 40, Parry 20, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS2, Dis3, T5)
+ Small Shield (3 AP)

#2 - 1H Spear 45, Parry 25, Reach 1, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL3, CS3, Dis5, T5), Thrown, Range 1
+ Small Shield (3 AP)

#3 - Shortbow 35, Dmg 2 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), 2H, Range 3

1-5	Body 4+3 AP	8	RLeg 2+3 AP
6	RArm 3+3 AP	9	LLeg 2+3 AP
7	LArm 3+3 AP	0	Head 6+3 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 10

Low-light Vision : Sees in near-darkness as though daylight.

Horse

Medium

A standard riding horse, used as a mount. Horses can move 2 zones instead of 1, and can carry an extra 12 Inventory ENC (in addition to the rider). To spur a non-warhorse into combat, roll Ride (does not count as an action). A failure means the horse will not move toward the danger. If a horse receives any wound, it must make a Willpower roll or break and flee. The rider may make a Ride roll as an action to regain control. A horse can wear barding (horse armor) on its Head and Body, but that may affect its Athletics skill.

Size Large Init 16 Move 2 Ferocity 1

Dodge 60, Might 60, Athletics 80, Endurance 70, Perception 50, Willpower 50

Kick 50, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-4	Body 1 AP	8	RRearLeg 1 AP
5	Tail 1 AP	9	LRearLeg 1 AP
6	RFrontLeg 1 AP	0	Head 1 AP
7	LFrontLeg 1 AP		

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 25

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Fast : Moves 2 zones during Movement, and 2 zones during a Run action.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Quadruped : Prone from impairment only if 2+ legs become impaired. If one or more legs impaired, cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs quadruped +3 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Husk

Severe

A Husk is what remains of an Ironlander reaver who abandons his humanity in pursuit of a goal fueled by rage and vengeance. It is neither living, nor dead, nor undead. In fact, Loremasters are puzzled as to what fell force compels the Husk onwards to complete its foul purpose. Whatever that may be, a Husk is an implacable foe that will drive itself to the ends of the earth in pursuit of its goal. Occasionally, desperate vikings and raiders of the very lowest character will fall into the service of a Husk as it relentlessly pursues its quarry.

Once per combat, a Husk can emit a horrifying wail that causes fear in anyone within Medium range.

A Husk also has the power to cause visions of paralyzing terror. This is a special action, opposed by Willpower, where every DoS Paralyzes the foe for 1 round. The victim may make a new resistance against the original roll every round to break free.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 80, Might 75, Athletics 85, Endurance 105 Ex3, Perception 65, Willpower 85

Longsword 90 Ex3, Dmg 5 (CL5, CS5, Dis3, T2) + Med Shield (4 AP)

1-5	Body 5+4 AP	8	RLeg 4+4 AP
6	RArm 5+4 AP	9	LLeg 4+4 AP
7	LArm 5+4 AP	0	Head 7+4 AP

Toughness +4 DeathThreshold 25

Fear Rating 5 : Target rolls Willpower vs 5 (horrifying wail, once per combat).

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Low-light Vision : Sees in near-darkness as though daylight.

Monstrous Constitution : Rolls a d20 Wound die.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Talent - Powerful Blow : +1 dmg with Longsword.

Terrifying Visions : 70 Ex2 vs Willpower; Paralyzed 1 round per DoS.

Undead (not a true undead, but has this modified trait): Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Unearthly : Only affected by magic or magic weapons.

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Ironlander Raider

Medium

The vikings of the Ironlands rarely find a passage through the Iron Veil, the shimmering, mystical wall that separates their exiled island continent from the Broken Empires, but when they do, the sight of their dragon-prow longships slicing through the water strikes fear into the hearts of sailors and landsmen alike. The Ironlanders have much in common culturally with the Haedravik islanders, although neither would claim the other as ally.

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 50, Might 55, Athletics 50, Endurance 50, Perception 40, Sail/Boat 70, Stealth 50, Willpower 45

Bearded Axe 60, Parry 40, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS2, Dis3, T5) + Med Shield (4 AP)

Spear 60, Parry 40, Reach 1, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL3, CS3, Dis5, T5), Thrown, Range 1

1-5	Body 4+4 AP	8	RLeg 1+4 AP
6	RArm 3+4 AP	9	LLeg 1+4 AP
7	LArm 3+4 AP	0	Head 5+4 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 20

Lich

Extreme

A Spellweaver's greatest enemy is the Fraying, the inexplicable and inevitable fate that awaits all those who gain too much of the Weave's attention. Though many have tried to find a solution to the Fraying, all have failed--and none more spectacularly than those who wind up as a terrifying undead monster known as a lich (pronounced litch).

A lich is a powerful Spellweaver who, in seeking an escape from the Weave's final notice, has instead found an eternity of undeath, trapped in a prison of their own corpse. It is frightening, and its very touch radiates a damaging, supernatural cold that bypasses armor and causes "Cold" wounds. Its unearthly power gives it 2 AP everywhere.

A lich hides the remains of their mortal essence in a receptacle known as a phylactery: a magic-infused jar, box, or other container containing what remains of the lich's soul. A lich cannot be truly slain unless its phylactery is found and destroyed; otherwise, its body dissolves and reforms again next to its phylactery three nights after it is "killed". Naturally, liches keep their phylacteries well-hidden and guarded.

The secrets to making the transformation to lichdom are known to very few, but those Spellweavers who are successful add the lich template, below.

Size Med Init 18 Move 1 Ferocity 6

All skills as Spellweaver; add +30 to Willpower, Insight, Arcana, and all Bind skills; add Ex4 to 2 Binds; and distribute an extra 20 points among Strand scores

Touch 65, Dmg 3 + P4 (CL3, CS4, Dis5, T5), Cold wounds

1-5	Body 2 AP	8	RLeg 2 AP
6	RArm 2 AP	9	LLeg 2 AP
7	LArm 2 AP	0	Head 2 AP

Toughness +3 to original Spellweaver's Toughness

DeathThreshold +10 to original Spellweaver's DT

Fear Rating 3 : Target rolls Willpowervs 3.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with claw.

Spellweaver : Resolve 30

Talent - Weave Resistant : +20 to Willpower rolls vs magic.

Undead : Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Unearthly : Only affected by magic or magic weapons.

Vulnerable : +3 WP to any resulting wound caused by Spirit magic. Any rolls to resist at -20.

Lizardman Guardian

Hard

Humanoid crocodiles 10 feet at the shoulder when rising to their full height, the Guardians were ancient protectors of the hidden Lizardman communities scattered throughout the misty jungles of the Serpent's Teeth Isles. The reptilian sentinels were thought to be extinct, existing only as illusions created by Lizardman shamans to ward off intruders. Recently, however, a Dunblainish soldier discovered their preserved and forgotten tadpoles in a ruined Devonan temple, and returned the embryos to the lizard folk to raise once more. The Guardians evolve rapidly, growing to full size within the span of a month if fed a diet of fresh blood. They are fiercely loyal to their providers and a terror to anyone else. The statistics provided are for a fully-grown Guardian.

Size Large Init 16/8 Move1 Ferocity 5

Dodge70, Might 70 Ex2 , Athletics90, Endurance80, Perception70, Stealth 80, Willpower50

Claws and Teeth 80 Ex3, Dmg 6 + P2 (CL2, CS3, Dis4, T4)

1-4	Body6 AP	8	RLeg 5 AP
5	Tail 4 AP	9	LLeg 5 AP
6	RArm3 AP	0	Head 6 AP
7	LArm3 AP		

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 25

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Knockback : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Multiple Turns : Acts on 16 and 8.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with claw.

Talent - Enhanced Defense : Opponents only get +10 Outnumbering bonus.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

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Lizardman Shaman

Medium

The reptilian Lizardmen of the Serpent's Teeth Isles are a secretive, reclusive people who still worship the sea goddess Devona, in her aspect as Derrevass the Protector, the Icy Lady of Storms. A primitive species, the Lizardmen rely mostly on their fierce reputation and mysterious legends to scare away interlopers from their swamps and jungles, but occasionally one of their more adventurous number feels the call to the sea, and will venture forth from their misty islands to explore the wider world. But they pay a price for leaving the safety of their island homes; their strangeness causes other races to instinctively recoil from Lizardmen, making it much harder for them to integrate into different societies.

Size Med Init 16 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 40, Endurance 40, Perception 50, Stealth 50, Willpower 60, Divinity 60

Staff 55, Parry 65, Reach 1, Dmg 4 NL (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-4	Body 3 AP	8	RLeg 2 AP
5	Tail 2 AP	9	LLeg 2 AP
6	RArm 2 AP	0	Head 3 AP
7	LArm 2 AP		

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 15

Godbound (Wrath, Water, Dreams, Magic): Piety 80

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Orc

Medium

Their origins lost in the mists of time, the orcs of the Broken Empires are, with rare exception, savage raiders with an irrational hatred for all other races. There are no females or children among them; they are birthed fully grown from amniotic sacs in underground lairs. They emerge armed with an instinct for slaughter, carrying within them the fury of countless predecessors.

They are not a people, but a contagion. Each warbrood--known in their own black tongue as a Vrul--is driven by the will of a distant Ulgath ("Bloodfather"), its unseen progenitor. Beneath him march the Skarns ("Underfangs"), the great enforcers who drive the lesser orcs to battle.

They are biological war machines, bred for carnage--but bred by whom? And for what purpose? Some say the orcs appeared alongside Humans when they first emerged from the south; others, that they were the product of a Duanan Seethe ritual gone wrong; still others suggest they are a kind of invasive species not of this world at all. Whatever their origin, the orcs are a blight upon all lands, a hatred made flesh that can never truly be destroyed.

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50, Might 50, Athletics 40, Endurance 50, Perception 40, Willpower 35

#1 - Mace 50, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)
+ Small Shield (3 AP)

#2 - Shortbow 40, Dmg 2 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), 2H, Range 3

Dagger 50, Dmg 1 + P5 on Prone or Grappled (CL2, CS2, Dis5, T6), Thrown, Range 0

1-5	Body 3+3 AP	8	RLeg 1+3 AP
6	RArm 2+3 AP	9	LLeg 1+3 AP
7	LArm 2+3 AP	0	Head 3+3 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 15

Orc Chieftain (Skarn)

Hard

A Skarn ("Underfang" in the guttural Orcish tongue) is the brutal overseer of a Vrul--a monster among monsters. Towering and scarred, it rules through pain and terror, cowing lesser orcs into obedience with sheer force.

A Skarn fights with unrelenting ferocity, wielding its jagged axe and rusted shield as extensions of its rage, often using the Cleave Shield Maneuver to devastating effect.

Size Med Init 10 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 60, Might 60 Ex3, Athletics 50, Endurance 70, Perception 50, Willpower 50, Intimidate 70

Battle-Axe 80, Parry 60, Dmg 6 (CL5, CS5, Dis3, T2), 2H, ClSh

1-5	Body 5 AP	8	RLeg 3 AP
6	RArm 4 AP	9	LLeg 3 AP
7	LArm 4 AP	0	Head 5 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 20

Talent - Shield Breaker : +2 to Cleave Shield rolls.

Pirate

Medium

Corsairs from the world over that ply the waves in and around the Serpent's Teeth Isles looking for rich vessels to prey upon.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 50, Endurance 40, Perception 30, Sail/Boat 60, Willpower 40

Cutlass 50, Dmg 2 (CL2, CS2, Dis5, T6)

Lt Crossbow 40, Dmg 3 + P1 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), 2H, Reload 1, Range 2

1-5	Body 3 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
6	RArm 2 AP	9	LLeg 1 AP
7	LArm 2 AP	0	Head 0 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 13

Pirate Captain

Challenging

A skilled navigator, sailor, or killer who's in charge of a pirate vessel, likely dreaming of one day counting himself among the League of Free Lords.

Size Med Init 16 Move 1 Ferocity 4

Dodge 65, Might 50, Athletics 55, Endurance 55, Perception 45, Sail/Boat 75, Willpower 65, Deceive 70, Insight 55, Intimidate 70, Wit 65

Rapier 75, Parry 85, Ex2, Dmg 2 (CL2, CS2, Dis4, T7) + Parrying Dagger (AP 1), Secondary Attack (3 SLs)

1-5	Body 4+1 AP	8	RLeg 2+1 AP
6	RArm 3+1 AP	9	LLeg 2+1 AP
7	LArm 3+1 AP	0	Head 1+1 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 21

Never Surrender : Opposed Willpower roll to resist the Compel Surrender Maneuver +20.

Talent - Barbed Tongue : If you win an opposed Intimidate or Wit roll against a target's Willpower, they or their side suffers -20 to their next Social roll. For every 3 DoS, an additional -10. Each subsequent use of Barbed Tongue against the same target in the same encounter suffers a cumulative -20 to your Intimidate or Wit roll.

Talent - Feint : As part of melee attack, make Hard (-20) Deceiveroll to mislead your opponent, who defends at -10. If you fail, your opponent defends with +10 instead. Feint can never be used twice in a row on the same opponent.

Talent - Two-Weapon Fighter : Access the Secondary Attack Combat Maneuver: 3 SLs, make an immediate -20 unopposed attack with the parrying dagger against any Engaged opponent. It also adds +1 AP, but does not count as a shield against ranged attacks.

Rat, Giant

Medium

These dog-sized rodents can be dangerous due to their infection-causing bites. Their lesser, normal-sized cousins can form a Swarm (see Swarm in this chapter).

Size Small Init 18 Move1 Ferocity 1

Dodge60, Might 35, Athletics50, Endurance40, Perception 60, Willpower30

Bite 50, Dmg 2 + Infection (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T3)

1-5	Body 1 AP	8	RRearLeg 0 AP
6	RFrontLeg 0 AP	9	LRearLeg 0 AP
7	LFrontLeg 0 AP	0	Head 0 AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 5

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Infectious Wounds : Target must roll Infection die + Toughness vs new wound's value. Failure marks the wound Infected.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Quadruped : Prone from impairment only if 2+ legs become impaired. If one or more legs impaired, cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs quadruped +3 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Roc

Challenging

Solitary and rare, these gigantic birds prey upon horses or sheep herds, and also the occasional unfortunate shepherd. Their massive eggs are worth their weight in silver, but only the foolish or truly desperate attempt to steal them from these deadly monstrous avians. Luckily, rocs are easily scared off by fire.

A roc in flight can make a special grab attack with its claws. If a roc hits a foe in its Body location with a Claw attack and performs its Monstrous Charge -through Combat Maneuver, instead of knocking the foe Prone, the roc may grab them in its claws. It may then immediately complete the Monstrous Charge-through and fly another zone straight up. On the victim's next turn, they are considered Grappled and may only take actions allowed under the Grapple Combat Maneuver rules.

If the leg holding the victim becomes Impaired, the roc immediately releases the grabbed victim--potentially resulting in a deadly fall if the roc is still airborne.

Size Massive Init 16 Move2? Ferocity 3

? Creature can fly

Dodge50, Might 65, Athletics70, Endurance70, Perception 60, Willpower50

Claw 65, Dmg 6 + P2 (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T2)

1-5	Body3 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
6	RWing2 AP*	9	LLeg 1 AP
7	LWing2 AP*	0	Head 5 AP

Toughness +5 DeathThreshold 35

*Impaired Wing: no Flight possible

Afraid of Fire : After being damaged by any fire-based attack, the roc must make a standard Willpower roll. If it fails, it drops anything it's carrying and flees on its next turn.

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Flight 2 : Can fly 2 zones during Movement.

Monstrous Attacks : Attacks can only be Dodged

Monstrous Charge-through + Grab : See creature description.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Sattagoyan Horse Archer

Medium

Lightly armed and armored cavalry, they excel in harassing enemies from afar before charging through them with a slashing scimitar attack.

Size Med Init 14 Move 2* Ferocity 3

*On horse

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 50, Endurance 40, Perception 40, Ride 80 Ex2, Willpower 40

Shortbow 60, Dmg 3 (CL6, CS5, Dis5, T5), 2H, Range 3

Scimitar 50, Dmg 4 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T5)
+ Buckler (1 AP)

1-5	Body 3+1 AP	8	RLeg 1+1 AP
6	RArm 2+1 AP	9	LLeg 1+1 AP
7	LArm 2+1 AP	0	Head 4+1 AP

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 15

Talent - Mounted Charge : +1 SL to any successful mounted Charge attack.

Talent - Horse Archer : Ranged attacks on horseback not capped by Ride skill.

Talent - Powerful Blow : +1 dmg with shortbow.

Scorpion, Giant

Medium

Common in the Red Wastes, these giant arachnids carry a paralytic poison injected through their tail stingers. They cover themselves in sand and lie in wait to ambush unsuspecting prey. After rendering a victim immobile from poison, they will slice them up into meaty chunks and devour them.

Size Large Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 60, Endurance 50, Perception 60, Stealth 70, Willpower 10

Pincer 50, Dmg 4 (CL2, CS2, Dis4, T4)

Tail Stinger 50, Reach 1, Dmg 2 + Poison (CL 3, T3)

1-2	Body 4 AP	7	RRearLeg 2 AP
3	RPincer 3 AP	8	LRearLeg 2 AP
4	LPincer 3 AP	9	Tail 4 AP
5	RFrontLeg 2 AP	0	Head 3 AP
6	LFrontLeg 2 AP		

Toughness +2 DeathThreshold 12

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Multi-legged : Only falls Prone from impairment if half or more of its legs are impaired. A multi-legged creature with half or more impaired legs cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs creature costs +4 SLs.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Poison : Endurance DoS vs Paralysis 5; Paralyzed 1 round per DoS.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

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Skeleton

Easy

An animated Human skeleton filled with hatred for the living. Many skeletons are former warriors and still wear scraps of armor.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 35, Endurance 40, Perception 40, Willpower 20

Mace 50, Dmg 4 (CS3, Dis4, T5)
+ Med Shield (4 AP)

1-5	Body 4+4 AP	8	RLeg 0+4 AP
6	RArm 1+4 AP	9	LLeg 0+4 AP
7	LArm 1+4 AP	0	Head 4+4 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 10

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Mindless : Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting effects except Command or Bond Effects. Cannot be communicated to or reasoned with. Never takes the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Undead : Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Vulnerable : +3 WP to any resulting wound caused by Spirit magic or blunt weapons (mace, club, staff, etc.).

Skeleton, Four-Armed

Hard

Undead guardians of foul temples to death, these four-armed monstrosities wield a scimitar in each bony hand in defense of whatever dark sepulcher their unliving masters left them in. They wear scraps of various armor as protection.

Size Med Init 16/12/5 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 55, Might 50, Athletics 55, Endurance 75, Perception 50, Willpower 35

Scimitar 65, Dmg 4 (CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-3	Body 5 AP	7	LowerLArm 3 AP
4	UpperRArm 3 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
5	UpperLArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 1 AP
6	LowerRArm 3 AP	0	Head 3 AP

Toughness +2 DeathThreshold 15

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Mindless : Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting effects except Command or Bond Effects. Cannot be communicated to or reasoned with. Never takes the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Multiple Turns : Acts on 16, 12, and 5.

Undead : Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Vulnerable : +3 WP to any resulting wound caused by Spirit magic or blunt weapons (mace, club, staff, etc.).

Slumberpede

Medium

Common throughout the world's mountainous areas, these giant predatory arthropods have mandibular glands that store an anesthetic toxin that they aerosolize and project as a pressurized gas cloud through tiny holes in their mandibles. Slumberpedes tunnel through the ground just below surface level and use their antennae to detect unsuspecting surface prey before bursting from the ground to attack. They have even been known to break through wooden floorboards this way. After rendering a victim immobile from their "sleeping gas", they will drag their prey into their underground burrow and devour them while still alive.

Size Med Init 14 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 50, Might 30, Athletics 50, Endurance 40, Perception 50, Stealth 70, Willpower 35

Pincer 50, Dmg 3 (CL4, CS3, Dis4, T3)

1-3	Body	4 AP	7	LMidLeg	3 AP
4	RFrontLeg	3 AP	8	RRearLeg	3 AP
5	LFrontLeg	3 AP	9	LRearLeg	3 AP
6	RMidLeg	3 AP	0	Head	2 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 15

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Breath Weapon, d8 : Poison sleep gas targeting all other individuals in the creature's zone (Endurance DoS vs 1d4+1 hours of unconsciousness).

Multi-legged : Only falls Prone from impairment if half or more of its legs are impaired. A multi-legged creature with half or more impaired legs cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs creature costs +4 SLs.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Snake, Venomous

Easy

Adders, rattlers, or other poisonous serpents. They are usually only aggressive if startled, hungry, or threatened. A victim of multiple snake bites only suffers the poison from the first bite.

Size Little Init 18 Move 1 Ferocity 1

Dodge 50, Might 35, Athletics 50, Endurance 40, Perception 70, Stealth 70, Willpower 35

Bite 35, Dmg 2 + Poison (CL2, CS3, Dis5, T5)

1-8	Body	1 AP	9-0	Head	2 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 5

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry.

Elusive : Can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Move 2 during Elusive movement.

Immunity : Cannot become Prone.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Poisonous Bite : Upon a wound, Endurance vs Poison 1d6; 1 Poison internal damage per DoS.

Smaller : Increase a Medium attacker's Reach against the creature by 1. The creature can only Dodge such attacks. Cannot perform Drive Back, Trip, Grapple, or Disarm on Medium or larger enemies.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls.

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Speaker, Human

Challenging

This could be a diplomat, a courtier, a royal messenger, etc.

Size Med Init 15 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 40, Might 35, Athletics 30, Endurance 30, Perception 60, Willpower 70, Insight 60, Inspire 55, Persuade 70, Protocol 70, Wit 65

Rapier 60, Dmg 2 (CL2, CS2, Dis4, T7)

1-5	Body 2 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
6	RArm 1 AP	9	LLeg 1 AP
7	LArm 1 AP	0	Head 0 AP

Toughness 0 DeathThreshold 18

Talent - Barbed Tongue : If you win an opposed Intimidate or Wit roll against a target's Willpower, they or their side suffers -20 to their next Social roll. For every 3 DoS, an additional -10. Each subsequent use of Barbed Tongue against the same target in the same encounter suffers a cumulative -20 to your Intimidate or Wit roll.

Talent - Honeyed Words : In a Competitive Social Encounter, +20 to the first use of Persuade or Seduce

Spider, Giant

Challenging

These man-sized monstrous arachnids are adept at hiding in dark corners and ambushing prey. Their bodies are protected by a chitinous carapace, and their fangs drip a paralytic poison.

A giant spider can shoot a sticky web at an individual target at Short range with a skill of 70. An opposed Dodge roll evades the web. Getting stuck in the web Restrains the target until they can break free (Might roll opposed to the original web attack, 1 attempt per round as an action). The webs can be burned away, but the restrained victim will take 3 internal fire damage to a random location.

Size Med Init 16 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 70, Might 60, Athletics 80, Endurance 50, Perception 70, Stealth 80 Ex3 , Willpower 40

Fangs 65, Dmg 3 + Poison (CL3, CS3, Dis5, T5)

Web 70 (Short range, opposed Dodge to evade, see description)

1-3	Body 6 AP	7	LMidLeg 3 AP
4	RFrontLeg 3 AP	8	RRearLeg 3 AP
5	LFrontLeg 3 AP	9	LRearLeg 3 AP
6	RMidLeg 3 AP	0	Head 2 AP

Toughness +2 DeathThreshold 15

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Multi-legged : Only falls Prone from impairment if half or more of its legs are impaired. A multi-legged creature with half or more impaired legs cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs creature costs +4 SLs.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Poison : Upon a new wound, Hard (-20) Endurance or be Paralyzed for 1 hour; no effect on a victim already suffering from the poison.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Wall-crawler : Can climb walls and along ceilings.

Summoned Creature

Challenging

There are many worlds besides the Broken Empires, and many other creatures dwell there than can be conceived of (see Chapter 14 - Weave Magic: Summoning for a more thorough discussion). A creature summoned to our world from the Realms Beyond can take almost any form imaginable: a tentacled flying kraken, a wolf with 8 legs and iridescent fur, a divinely-sent Dream Beast of infinite variety of appearances--there are as many possibilities of summoned creatures as there are otherworldly realms themselves. Such creatures can only be summoned by a Spellweaver who possesses an Arcane Tether associated with the beast.

Below is but one example. This monstrosity, summoned from a realm of pure Chaos by the Mad Wizard Ur-Osvathe, is an airborne, tentacled, pteranodon-like beast, with scintillating purple armored scales and the ability to "fly" by making brief teleporting jumps through the sky.

Size Large Init 12 Move 2? Ferocity 3

? Creature can fly

Dodge 50, Might 70, Athletics 75, Endurance 65, Perception 70, Willpower 45

Claw 65, Dmg 5 + P2 (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T4)

1-4	Body 6 AP	8	LWing 2 AP*
5	R Leg 4 AP	9	Tail 5 AP
6	LLeg 4 AP	0	Head 6 AP
7	RWing 2 AP*		

Toughness +1 DeathThreshold 20

*Impaired Wing: no Flight possible

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Elusive : Can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Move 2 during Elusive movement.

Flight 2 : Can fly 2 zones during Movement.

Monstrous Charge-through : If a Charge attack is successful, may use a 3 SL Combat Maneuver to leave the Engagement and move back out to Close range, on the opposite side of the zone. Any foes engaged with the creature at the moment of the Charge must make a standard Dodge or Endurance roll or be knocked Prone. The creature may not become Engaged with any new foes while Charging-through.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Swarm

Challenging

Rats, insects, or other creatures can form a massive swarm that is difficult to defeat with weapons alone. On its turn, a swarm deals 1d8 automatic damage to anyone it's engaged with. This attack cannot be Dodged, but worn armor protects, and an Endurance roll can be made to mitigate the damage.

A swarm takes only a single point of damage from any attack except fire, which does full damage. It never rolls a Wound Die, can't be Impaired, and never drops in Shock. When a swarm exceeds the Death Threshold, it is dispersed and no longer a threat.

Size Large Init 10 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge N/A , Might N/A , Athletics 60, Endurance 60, Perception 60, Stealth 65, Willpower 50

Endurance DoS vs 1d8 external damage to a random location (no defense roll or shield AP)

1-0 Swarmmass 0 AP

Toughness N/A DeathThreshold 10

Animal: Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm.

Immunity : To shock, impairment, grapples, becoming Prone, all Combat Maneuvers, and mind-affecting magic or effects.

Infectious Wounds (rats and other disease-bearers only): Target must roll Infection die + Toughness vs new wound's value. Failure marks the wound Infected.

Mindless : Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting effects except Command or Bond Effects. Cannot be communicated to or reasoned with. Never takes the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

Special : Swarms take only 1 damage from any attack, but full damage from fire.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls.

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Thessian Bear

Hard

The northern wilds of the Westlands and Thessia are home to the fierce Thessian bear. This ursine monster is unafraid of humanity and will fearlessly attack small hunting parties if they blunder into its territory. Despite their lumbering appearance, these brutes are incredibly fast and can climb trees with ease.

If it can, a Thessian bear will attempt to grapple an opponent with a Might attack, following up with a bite or bear hug in subsequent rounds.

Size Large Init 16 Move 2 Ferocity 4

Dodge 40, Might 80 Ex3, Athletics 75, Endurance 80, Perception 50, Stealth 50, Willpower 20

Claw 60, Dmg 6 (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T3, Gr2)

Bite 40 Ex2, Dmg 3 + P5 (CL2, CS3, Dis5, T5)

1-5	Body 3 AP	8	RRearLeg 2 AP
6	RFrontLeg 3 AP	9	LRearLeg 2 AP
7	LFrontLeg 3 AP	0	Head 3 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 25

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Bear Hug : If already grappling foe, make an opposed Might roll (80 Ex3) for lethal Dmg 8.

Grit : Does not automatically drop in Shock until suffering a third impairment in any hit location.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Quadruped : Prone from impairment only if 2+ legs become impaired. If one or more legs impaired, cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs quadruped +3 SLs.

Talent - Wrestler : When making a Grapple Combat Maneuver, reduce the SL cost by 1.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Tical Dondallan Soldier

Medium

The military of Tical Dondala is trained to fight on land and at sea, although those dispatched to service onboard a naval ship set aside their heavier armor in favor of leather and padding. The typical soldier will be armed either with a halberd or a cutlass and shield.

Size Med Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 2

Dodge 50, Might 40, Athletics 50, Endurance 50, Perception 35, Sail/Boat 50, Willpower 40

#1 - Halberd 50, Parry 30, Reach 1, Dmg 6 (CL5, CS5, Dis3, T2), 2H, +10 vs mounted, Overbearing (DB2)

#2 - Cutlass 50, Dmg 2 (CL2, CS2, Dis5, T6) + Small Shield (3 AP)

1-5	Body 5+shield AP	8	RLeg 2+shield AP
6	RArm 3+shield AP	9	LLeg 2+shield AP
7	LArm 3+shield AP	0	Head 6+shield AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 18

Troll

Challenging

A troll is what an Elder Tree can degenerate into after millennia of detachment from its forests. After the Elves' departure, some Elder Trees became dark of thought and intent, and without the guidance of their Duanan Seethe masters, they became bitter and angry at having been abandoned. Sharing this resentment, some trolls can now be found serving powerful Bolg Fiir bandit lords.

Trolls have devolved into large plant-like humanoids somewhat resembling an Ogre, but their tree-like origins are unmistakable: the rough bark-like skin, the long root-like fingers and gnarled facial features, the mossy fur covering their body that acts as armor. A troll has developed a taste for the flesh of the warm-blooded, making them a menace to foresters everywhere. This threat is only increased by the troll's ability to regenerate damage done to it by anything other than fire.

Size Large Init 12 Move 1 Ferocity 3

Dodge 40, Might 65, Athletics 55, Endurance 65, Perception 45, Stealth 65, Willpower 55

Log Club 65, Dmg 6 (CL5, CS5, Dis4, T3)

Claw 60, Dmg 4 + P1 (CL3, CS3, Dis4, T4)

1-5	Body 4 AP	8	RLeg 4 AP
6	RArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 4 AP
7	LArm 3 AP	0	Head 2 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 22

Battering Attacks : Target can only parry this creature's attacks if using a shield.

Knockback : Drive Back Maneuver sends opponent flying into adjacent zone; -20 Athletics or knocked Prone. Can choose whether or not to follow.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with claw.

Regeneration : Once per round, every wound not caused by fire automatically heals 1 WP .

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Ursowl

Hard

This fearsome bipedal beast has the body of a massive bear with the head of a beaked owl. It is thought by Loremasters that the Ursowl is a creature from another realm, summoned to the Broken Empires by a careless Spellweaver. The creature seemingly broke free of its captivity and somehow bred with a normal bear, creating a vicious hybrid race that now roams the desolate wilds in search of prey. An Ursowl will fight to the death. It is said that the preserved beak of an Ursowl can be used as a Beast Thread.

Size Large Init 14/8 Move 1 Ferocity 5

Dodge 50, Might 70, Athletics 45, Endurance 70, Perception 65, Willpower 35

Claw 80 Ex3, Dmg 7 (CL3, CS2, Dis4, T2)

Bite 60 Ex2, Dmg 4 + P3 (CL3, CS3, T4)

1-5	Body 4 AP	8	RRearLeg 3 AP
6	RFrontLeg 3 AP	9	LRearLeg 3 AP
7	LFrontLeg 3 AP	0	Head 4 AP

Toughness +4 DeathThreshold 25

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Grit : Does not automatically drop in Shock until suffering a third impairment in any hit location.

Monstrous Attacks : Attacks can only be Dodged

Multiple Turns : Acts on 14 and 8.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Talent - Stable Stance x2 : +2 SLs to Trip or Shield Bash an Ursowl.

Void Demon

Hard

The Tapestry encompasses all of reality, but there are places outside the Tapestry, collectively known as the Void (also called Hell, Limbo, Oblivion, the Place Of Non-Being, and many other names). Creatures from the Void are known to Loremasters by many classifications, but the uneducated simply call them demons. These otherworldly beings have no form of their own and take shape only after crossing over into our world and invading a host body. When they do, they become ravenous for all the experiences available to a material form: flesh, wine, food, laughter, rage, pain--they desire all of it, all at once, and in voracious quantities. A Void demon is a frenzy of insanely contradictory actions: one moment adoringly caressing an innocent, the next tearing the flesh from its skull in orgiastic laughter.

Each demon has a True Name, which can be used to contact and summon it through Weave Magic, or, more rarely, through a direct pact with the demon itself. If summoned into a magic summoning circle, there must be a host body waiting to contain the entity.

When a Void demon (intentionally summoned or not) forcibly inhabits a host--they prefer Humans, but will gladly invade the body of any available creature--it traps the being's mind in a prison of its own skull, slowly corrupting and distorting the flesh until it resembles a grotesque cross between the host's original form and some eldritch creature out of nightmare. To do this, the Void demon must win an opposed Willpower roll against the victim. The next round, the demon will possess the host and begin to manifest, which is a process lasting anywhere from a few weeks to a few moments.

No two Void demons manifest in exactly the same way, but very often the host's eyes will go completely black, and its skin will become hot to the touch until it inevitably bursts into black flame, sloughing off the bones. A pair of extra-long, taloned arms erupt from the host's midsection, and the being grows several feet taller. Spiny wings explode from its back, and the jaw becomes elongated and filled with row upon row of tearing teeth. Yet still the original host is identifiable within the ruined form, and the demon will always resemble it on some basic level. Hence, a Dwarf-demon is immediately distinctive from a Human-demon--although if they could, either would beg for death, the only release possible from the twisted prison the host's own body has become.

It is difficult to save someone possessed by a demon. Attacking the body will only damage the host, and killing it will simply free the Void demon's essence to return from whence it came. To hurt the demon directly requires Spheres magic, to which a demon is vulnerable. The remains of a Void demon's host often act as a Spheres Thread.

There is, according to Loremasters and knowledgeable Spellweavers, a breed of greater demon, which possesses a physical form outside the bounds of reality (a paradox necessary to the discussion of such things), and which can be physically summoned and commanded (or at least consulted). Such a summons would surely be performed under only the most desperate of situations...

Below is a typical example of a fully transformed Human-demon.

Size Large Init 18/10 Move 1 Ferocity 5

Dodge 70, Might 75, Athletics 60, Endurance 75, Perception 65, Stealth 50, Willpower 75 Ex3

Talons 75 Ex2, Dmg 4 + P5 (CL2, CS3, Dis4, T5)

1-5	Body 5 AP	8	RLeg 2 AP
6	RArm 3 AP	9	LLeg 2 AP
7	LArm 3 AP	0	Head 6 AP

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 20

Flight 1 : Can fly 1 zone during Movement.

Fear Rating 2 : Target rolls Willpower vs 2.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Multiple Turns : Acts on 18 and 10.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Resistant : +3 AP vs fire damage.

Resistant : +20 to Willpower when resisting any mental manipulation.

Unearthly : Only affected by magic or magic weapons.

Vulnerable : -20 to resist and +3 WP to Spheres magic.

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Water Drake

Hard

Related to dragons, but lacking true intelligence, water drakes are large aquatic snake-like beasts that lair in subterranean lakes and sea caves. They lack the breath weapon of their larger cousins, but their armor-piercing bite injects an acidic venom that corrodes armor before dissolving the flesh beneath. Water drakes are very fast while in the water, with a Move of 2, and can freely disengage from enemies.

Size Large Init 14 Move 2* Ferocity 3

*Creature can swim

Dodge 60, Might 80, Athletics 70, Endurance 85 Ex2, Perception 75, Stealth 80 Ex3, Willpower 50

Bite 75 Ex2, Dmg 4 + Poison (CL3, CS4, Dis3, T3)

1-8 Body 6 AP 9-0 Head 5 AP

Toughness +4 Death Threshold 25

Acidic Poison Bite : In addition to Bite damage, any location armor AP is reduced by 1d3. Any remaining damage is transferred to the struck location as Acid damage.

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Elusive (in water only) : Can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Move 2 during Elusive movement.

Fast (in water only) : Moves 2 zones during Movement, and 2 zones during a Run action.

Monstrous Constitution : Rolls a d20 Wound die.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Werewolf

Hard

Lycanthropy is a parasitic disease that temporarily transforms a humanoid into a hulking, ferocious humanoid wolf-like creature. This metamorphosis occurs three nights after infection, and then again on random nights when any part of the moon is visible. The disease causes a frenzied need in the host creature to infect others through its bite. Consequently, a werewolf will often attack from stealth and retreat as soon as it has bitten a new victim. When the sun rises, the host creature transforms back into its original humanoid form, retaining no memories of either the transformation or its nocturnal activities.

Only silver weapons can permanently kill a transformed werewolf. When slain by silver, the parasite is forced from the host's body as a black, oily liquid, leaving the host dead. Unless immediately doused with quicksilver, the parasite remains infectious and propels itself by pseudopod into the nearest sentient creature's mouth to infect it (Dodge vs 3 to oppose).

Damage over a transformed werewolf's Death Threshold from any other attack merely forces it back into its unconscious humanoid form and resets the damage taken to zero. The parasite remains dormant within the living host, who will transform again on a random upcoming moonlit night.

Size Med Init 18/12 Move 2 Ferocity 5

Dodge 80 Ex3, Might 75, Athletics 80, Endurance 70 Ex3, Perception 80, Stealth 90 Ex4, Willpower 60

Claw 70 Ex2, Dmg 4 + P3 (CL3, CS2, Dis3, T4)

Bite 80, Dmg 5 + Special (CL3, CS3, Dis3, T4)

1-5 Body 10/0 AP 8 RLeg 10/0 AP

6 RArm 10/0 AP 9 LLeg 10/0 AP

7 LArm 10/0 AP 0 Head 10/0 AP

Toughness +5 Death Threshold 20

Fast : Moves 2 zones during Movement, and 2 zones during a Run action.

Fear Rating 3 : Target rolls Willpower vs 3.

Grit : Does not automatically drop in Shock until suffering a third impairment in any hit location.

Immunity : To mind-affecting magic, fear, & Compel Surrender.

Lycanthropic Bite : Endurance vs the first successful Bite attack roll or contract Lycanthropy.

Multiple Turns : Acts on 18 and 12.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Resistant : 10 AP to anything except silver weapons, 0 AP to silver; unaffected by Piercing quality or PA Maneuver; can only be killed by silver.

Talent - Stable Stance : Any Trip Maneuver attempts made against the beast cost +1 SL.

Wolf

Medium

The wild canines of the Broken Empires inhabit virtually every area and are not normally aggressive. They will target a humanoid's legs when possible, in hopes of tripping them, then go for the throat.

Size Small Init 16 Move 2 Ferocity 2

Dodge 60, Might 45, Athletics 60, Endurance 50, Perception 60, Stealth 65, Willpower 40

Bite 50, Dmg 3 (CL2, CS2, Dis4, T3)

1-5	Body 2 AP	8	RRearLeg 1 AP
6	RFrontLeg 1 AP	9	LRearLeg 1 AP
7	LFrontLeg 1 AP	0	Head 1 AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 8

Animal : Does not suffer Compel Surrender or Disarm. Will Dodge rather than parry. Does not become Prone when charging into a Grapple.

Fast : Moves 2 zones during Movement, and 2 zones during a Run action.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Pack Tactics : When Outnumbering an opponent, all the creature's Maneuver costs are lowered by 1.

Quadruped : Prone from impairment only if 2+ legs become impaired. If one or more legs impaired, cannot Run or Charge. Trip Maneuver vs quadruped +3 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : Can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without Athletics rolls. Will not fall Prone if Driven Back into a Rough zone.

Zombie

Easy

Zombies are mindless animated corpses. Their claws and nails can cause infected wounds.

Size Med Init 5 Move 1 Ferocity 6

Dodge 35, Might 40, Athletics 35, Endurance 50, Perception 35, Willpower 20

Claw 45, Dmg 1 + Infection (CL3, CS4, Dis3, T5)

1-5	Body 1 AP	8	RLeg 1 AP
6	RArm 0 AP	9	LLeg 1 AP
7	LArm 0 AP	0	Head 0 AP

Toughness +0 DeathThreshold 10

Hard-headed : Does not become stunned from Head impairment.

Infectious Wounds : Target must roll Infection die + Toughness vs new wound's value. Failure marks the wound Infected.

Mindless : Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting effects except Command or Bond Effects. Cannot be communicated to or reasoned with. Never takes the Fighting Withdrawal or Stand Your Ground actions.

Monstrous Grit : Never goes into Shock.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed.

Slow : Cannot take the Run action.

Undead : Ignores all aspects of living processes. Immune to Compel Surrender and mind-affecting spells, including illusions. Only recover from wounds through magic. Non-lethal damage does lethal wounds to undead.

Vulnerable : +3 WP to any resulting wound caused by Spirit magic or fire.

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NPC Traits

d100	Appearance	Playable Aspect	Personality	Agenda	Special Reaction Triggers even roll=positive reaction, odd roll=negative
01-02	Athletic	Accent-heavy	Adaptable	Evade a blood debt	Bias: People wearing foreign fashion or garb
03-04	Burly	Chatterbox	Charismatic	Prove their worth	Skill: Persuade
05-06	Gaunt	Cryptic	Courteous	Ascend to a position of authority	Bias: People who ask many questions
07-08	Lean	Drawling	Determined	Spread the Faith or seek converts	Topic: Art, music, or performance
09-10	Portly	Eloquent	Empathetic	Usurp a noble house	Bias: People with overt confidence
11-12	Slender	Fast-talking	Generous	Find a relic	Topic: Superstitions, omens, or folk beliefs
13-14	Stocky	Monotone	Honest	Rescue a prisoner	Bias: People who follow strict etiquette or ritual
15-16	Towering	Muttering	Humble	Undermine a rival	Topic: The ruling nobility
17-18	Stout	Soft-spoken	Loyal	Map lost lands or territories	Bias: People with strong religious beliefs
19-20	Wiry	Verbose	Optimistic	Stay hidden from pursuers	Topic: Taxes and levies
21-22	Angular	Fidgety	Patient	Atone for a family curse or past mistake	Bias: People with military bearing or discipline
23-24	Broad-faced	Gesticulating	Perceptive	Profit from resources in a specific region	Topic: Magic-users or the use of magic
25-26	Chiseled	Humming	Resourceful	Pursue knowledge	Bias: People from a certain area or culture
27-28	Round-faced	Impatient tapping	Steadfast	Spy on a rival	Skill: Protocol
29-30	Scarred	Nail-biting	Witty	Secure an ally	Bias: Half-Orcs
31-32	Sunken-eyed	Nervous laughter	Ambitious	Become a priest or Godbound	Topic: Trade guilds and merchants
33-34	Weathered	Pacing	Curious	Maintain a secret relationship	Bias: Dwarves
35-36	Bearded	Snapping fingers	Diligent	Deceive a ruler or authority figure	Topic: Bandits and outlaws
37-38	Freckled	Whistling	Dreamy	Impersonate an important figure	Bias: People with noticeable scars
39-40	Wrinkled	Yawning excessively	Independent	Build a stronghold or settlement	Skill: Intimidate
41-42	Balding	Always disheveled	Introspective	Recover a stolen item	Bias: People with a certain color of hair
43-44	Curly-haired	Flourishing gestures	Observant	Take revenge on a traitor	Topic: Rumors of corruption or scandal
45-46	Flowing	Fastidious groomer	Reserved	Take over or influence a criminal organization	Bias: People who seem wealthy
47-48	Long-haired	Piercing stare	Stoic	Change or reform the system	Topic: Tales of heroes
49-50	Messy	Laughs at odd moments	Tenacious	Assemble a mercenary force	Bias: People who seem poor
51-52	Shaven	Confident bearing	Abrasive	Find a suitable husband/wife	Topic: The natural world--forests, beasts, and landscapes
53-54	Short-cropped	Overreacts to temperature	Arrogant	Learn forbidden magic or rituals	Bias: Rangers or woodsmen
55-56	Slicked-back	Pauses mid-sentence	Cynical	Reconcile with a family member or friend	Topic: A past war or recent conflict
57-58	Thick-haired	Whispers to emphasize	Deceptive	Blackmail an adversary	Bias: Rogues or thieves
59-60	Unkempt	Always tilts head	Greedy	Write a book (chronicle, history, biography, etc.)	Topic: Commonfolk grievances
61-62	Bright-eyed	Avoids eye contact	Impatient	Break free of an oath or vow	Topic: Academic knowledge and scholars
63-64	Cold-eyed	Clingy	Impulsive	Solve a mystery	Bias: Warriors
65-66	Piercing	Excessively polite	Jealous	Build a strong reputation	Skill: Wit
67-68	Sharp-eyed	Forgetful	Melancholic	Seek out justice for a wronged party	Topic: Foreign trade
69-70	Soft-eyed	Overly familiar	Reckless	Eliminate a rival or enemy	Bias: Merchants
71-72	Sunken	Overly formal	Ruthless	Pay off crippling debts	Topic: Foreign kingdoms or cultures
73-74	Warm-eyed	Superstitious	Selfish	Rid a location of evil/enemies/curse	Topic: Honor and oaths

75-76	Heavy-lidded	Suspicious	Sullen	Protect a child	Bias: Loremasters or scholars
77-78	Wide-eyed	Tactless	Suspicious	Gain control over a strategic location	Skill: Inspire
79-80	Narrow-eyed	Too trusting	Vindictive	Amass great wealth	Topic: Ambition, power, and personal advancement
81-82	Bony	Always punctual	Compassionate	Flee a pursuer	Bias: Priests or Godbound
83-84	Dimpled	Chews on a twig	Courageous	Keep a secret from being discovered	Skill: Deceive
85-86	Knobby	Toys with odd trinkets	Dependable	Regain their dignity	Topic: Secrets, whispers, and forbidden Knowledge
87-88	Pale	Constantly scribbling notes	Encouraging	Create a network of spies or informants	Bias: Spellweavers
89-90	Petite	Fixated on symmetry	Fair-minded	Win a contest or tournament	Skill: Perform
91-92	Rugged	Hates being touched	Gracious	Restore a lost or fallen religious site	Topic: Mortality and loss
93-94	Sallow	Laughs at their own jokes	Resilient	Gain followers for a cause	Bias: People who talk softly/loudly
95-96	Sinewy	Obsessed with cleanliness	Trustworthy	Find and claim a hidden treasure	Skill: Seduce
97-98	Weatherbeaten	Talks to themselves	Visionary	Protect their family	Topic: The established Church
99-00	Well-groomed	Uncomfortable in silence	Supportive	Establish a dynasty	Bias: People who smell of travel

NPC Special Reaction Effect Table

(Roll or Choose)

d100	Special Reaction
01-20	Increase or Decrease initial Tolerance based on a particular bias.
21-40	A skill automatically fails when used.
41-60	±2 SLs to the party's SL total when attempting a particular skill.
61-80	±2 SLs to the party's SL total when incorporating a particular topic into the skill roll.
81-100	±2 SLs to the party's SL total if the skill is attempted by a character of a particular race, profession, or cultural group.

Creature Hit Locations

Dragon or Winged Quadruped

1-2	Body	7	RWing
3	RFrontLeg	8	LWing
4	LFrontLeg	9	Tail
5	RRearLeg	0	Head
6	LRearLeg		

Serpentine

1-8	Body	9-0	Head

Insectoid

1-3	Body	7	LMidLeg*
4	RFrontleg	8	RRearLeg
5	LFrontleg	9	LRearLeg
6	RMidLeg*	0	Head

*Count as Wing if winged

Horse or Quadruped

1-4	Body	8	RRearLeg
5	Tail*	9	LRearLeg
6	RFrontleg	0	Head
7	LFrontLeg*		

*Count as Body if no tail, or Trunk or other if applicable

Winged Humanoid

1-3	Body	7	LLeg
4	RArm	8	RWing
5	LArm	9	LWing
6	RLeg*	0	Head

Finned Aquatic

1-5	Body	8	LFin
6	Tail	9	DorsalFin
7	RFin	0	Head

cHAPTER 19:

solo roleplaying inthe broken empires

The Solo Roleplaying chapter is presented in two parts. In the first, I will talk about general principles of solo play that I have found useful over the years. The second part contains the actual solo rules system entitled "Ask the Weave".

Here's the dirty little secret about playing solo: You don't actually need an RPG system to do it. If you are solely interested in the narrative of what happens to a character, then all you need is an oracle, a table of randomizers, and your own imagination. That's it.

Keywords in this Chapter

Ask the Weave
Empires List
Event Randomizer Tables
NPC Tags
NPC Spellweavers
Oracle
Random Events
Subverted Scene

But that's not why I play solo. And I suspect that's not why you play solo either. Otherwise, why would you be reading this book filled with moderately complex Sim-Lite rules? There are plenty of more rules-light "narrativist" games out there.

When I played Savage Worlds solo in Season One of "Me, Myself and Die!", it wasn't because I was interested in a narrative, or to "tell a story". No, it was because I wanted to play the Savage Worlds roleplaying game. The narrative was just something that was going to emerge naturally out of playing the game and using the Mythic GM Emulator. This is why I play games: I am interested in using the rules of that game to determine what happens to the characters. I want to experience the mechanics of that specific ruleset to resolve conflicts.

Consider what it is about these rules that you're interested in exploring. This is a big game with a lot of moving parts. For some of you, that will be no impediment, and you will be looking forward to engaging with the rules in their entirety. For others, that may seem like an overwhelming proposition, but worry not: you are free to pick and choose whichever aspect of the rules interests you most. Do you love the ideas of detailed combat, but aren't so interested in the procedures of the travel mechanics? Well then, focus on the combat rules as written, but use the solo methods discussed here to accommodate travel situations. Are you really interested in Social conflicts, but not so much in detailed wounds and their immediate consequences? Consider using the Quick Resolution system for any unavoidable combats. Tailor the game to suit your own pace, and never be afraid to "wing it" in the moment.

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solo play general principles

In solo play, the Ask the Weave oracle stands in for a Gamemaster: you ask the oracle a question, interpret the answer according to the current context, and implement it using the specific game rules. There are a few core principles I keep in mind when playing solo, especially using TBE.

Principle 1: Always ask the oracle a question that assumes a complication. Instead of asking, "Is the treasure chest safe to open?", you should instead ask, "Is the treasure chest trapped?" Or instead of asking if the room is empty, you should be asking if the room contains a threat. Why is this? Because any game--solo or otherwise--needs conflict, and the best thing an oracle can do for you is to provide the opportunity for that conflict.

Principle 2: Trust your instincts. You are harnessing your own creativity in solo play, and the game rules are here to facilitate that, not to replace it. Without your own imagination, there is no game. You have to ask questions and interpret the answers. Go with your first gut instinct. If nothing comes to you from a prompt, then either re-roll or ignore the results and move on. Nothing will kill your game faster than second-guessing yourself.

Principle 3: Always be taking action and driving toward your goals. Everything in this game is about pursuing a character's goals. Every action, every question, every deed should be about the character trying to get what they want.

This is especially true when you don't know exactly how to begin a scene or encounter. Start in the middle of a decision point for the character, where the character must make a choice and take action.

In the very first episode of Season One of "Me, Myself and Die!", I knew Simon had a friend, Vilborg, who was helping Simon in his goal of finding out what happened to his parents. What I didn't know was how to start the first scene. So, using the oracles, I discovered that Vilborg was being led off to execution for a crime he didn't commit. That immediately put me as the player in the position of having to take action: I have to do something to save Vilborg's life! I immediately set to preparing an ambush to rescue him, using skills and rolling dice (spoiler alert: it didn't go quite as planned...). Taking action and driving toward Simon's goals propelled the narrative forward and led naturally into the next scene.

It may seem obvious, but it bears highlighting: if you don't take action and have your character do something, nothing's going to happen. You must be proactive in pursuing your goals, even (and especially!) in solo play.

Principle 4: Cut to the heart of the matter. There's a principle that I follow when I'm writing a script for television or stage, and it's the same one I use when structuring a scene in a solo session: "Come in late and get out early". Don't waste time on aspects of the scene that hold no interest for you, or that don't further the action in some way.

When you're playing, you want to get to something fun and exciting, something that's going to make you excited to get into the scene. I'm not saying to always start with a chase or a fight (although that is certainly an option); I mean, start at a point where the character must make a choice that is crucial to their interests and goals.

If your character is going to infiltrate a noble's masquerade ball to discover where the secret MacGuffin is hidden, then get right to the ball. You don't have to waste time with all of the preparations the character would have to make in order to get invited to the ball. You can bypass the attempts to forge an invitation, or the casing of the joint looking for a quick exit, or the bribing of the guards to get in (unless, of course, all of that is what's fun for you; in which case, go wild and play through it all!). If all that preparation seems pedantic to you, then just skip it and get to the heart of the action, to what's most interesting to you.

Principle 5: Don't drown yourself in solo tools. There are about a bazillion supplements out there to help you randomly create everything from wandering monsters to galleon names to the contents of a drunken goblin's pouch. Some of my favorites are *The Perilous Wilds* by Jason Lutes, the various *Books of Random Tables* by Matt Davids (both Jason and Matt contributed greatly to the various random tables in this book), and virtually anything by Kevin Crawford, of *Stars/Worlds/Cities Without Number* fame. They are all huge sources of inspiration. But having too many tools to choose from creates choice paralysis, and you wind up spending more time flipping through supplements trying to find the perfect one, rather than going with your first instinct and getting on with the game!

So do yourself a favor: start small. Use only a basic oracle and randomizer tool to begin with, like the ones we have in this chapter. Wring every bit of creativity out of that before you start piling up the sourcebooks beside your game table and distracting yourself with trying to find the Best Possible Random Table For This Scene. Your gut instinct will serve your game far better than the ten minutes you waste looking through solo supplements.

Solo Combat

Combat in *TBE* is very dangerous, especially if your character is alone. So get some NPC friends. One of the great time-honored techniques of gaming yesteryear was to seek out hirelings and henchmen to help your party get through the killer dungeon. This technique is still extraordinarily useful, especially when playing with a single character.

Finding help can be the stuff of adventure all on its own: in the first season of "Me, Myself and Die!", Simon was in a tavern looking for some help to raid an undead temple. Who he found was Edbert, a randomly-rolled NPC who went on to become not only a fan favorite, but also the main protagonist of his own season of the show! And all because I wanted Simon to have some hired help to go into the dungeon. So don't go it alone: find some help. You'll need the extra firepower to survive, and you never know just where a random NPC hireling will wind up taking your narrative.

NPCs don't need to be fully fleshed-out characters, either. Simply jot down details you think are relevant, assign some quick numbers to them, and away you go. There's more about NPCs for solo play later in this chapter.

Some general combat advice (and this is for GMs running for groups, too): a combat is made up of more than its participants. It's also about the tactical space in which the conflict occurs. When describing the environment of a combat encounter, make it interesting! Envision the area in your mind while describing it. Give the location qualities that provide tactical opportunities: different elevations (the enemy is at the top of a winding staircase or low cliff), an environmental effect (the floor is extremely slippery with mud; it's in the middle of a blizzard; the forest is on fire), or interesting or unusual terrain features (the area is covered with large boulders giving cover from missile fire, or there's a narrow gorge with a river far below, providing the possibility of a daring escape). These features help to make your combats dynamic and memorable.

There are two special solo-friendly Talents that will greatly improve your chances of survival. I encourage every solo player to consider giving their character these two Talents for free:

- Enhanced Defense, Solo: No foe gets outnumbering bonuses on you, and you don't take the -20 penalty for defending against two or more ranged attacks.
- Solo Constitution: Roll a d20 Wound Die for yourself instead of a d10.

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Solo Travel

TBEhas detailed travel rules designed to make the party feel like they've been out there on the road for a while. These rules are great fun, but can be a lot to keep track of when playing solo. Never fear! You can simplify the process while still keeping true to its intentions by going back to the source and inspiration for the process itself: the show where this all started.

In Season One of "Me, Myself and Die!", I simply used the Mythic GM Emulator to handle the rules of travel. If Simon set out on a journey, the main question I always asked was, "Does anything of interest happen to Simon along the way?"

To answer that, I would consider the following:

- A the distance to the destination
- A the method of travel
- A the terrain through which he traveled
- A if he was lacking in any critical supplies or resources for the trip
- A the weather
- A the hazardousness of the areas traversed, including the given circumstances

A great deal of information can be discovered just by asking those questions, and answering one can lead naturally to answering another. (These are all the same core considerations underpinning the Travel rules, by the way; I just systematized the instinctual methods I had been using for years to create the Journey system.)

For example, if I know the distance to my destination is 100 miles, and I'm on foot, that tells me that on a road or in open terrain, I can get there in about five days (20 miles a day through open terrain with a standard adventurer's kit is reasonable, if I don't dawdle). But what if I'm going through a forest for most of that? Well, rough terrain like that is going to slow me down (10 miles a day), so I'll add an extra few days based on movement rates on foot. (I use terrain and travel rates slightly differently in the Journey system; see Chapter 12 - Travel.)

> Put yourself in your character's shoes. In your mind's eye, see what they see, hear what they hear, feel what they feel. The more you imagine the details of the character's surroundings and circumstances, the richer your oracle questions and results--and your whole travel experience--will be.

So now I know I'll be on the road for upwards of ten days instead of five. Do I have enough supplies for that? If not, how will I cope? I'll have to do hunting or foraging skill rolls (Survival rolls in these rules), which may slow me down or even add days to my trip. These rolls may be impacted by the terrain, too: am I near a river to get fresh water? Is there plenty of game to hunt? If not, why not? Each of these answers tells me something about my surroundings, which provides further context and fodder for the next question, whatever it is.

What effects will the weather have on my progress? Will it produce any obstacles that I'll have to deal with, like storms or heat waves? The feel of slogging through endless rain and drizzle is very different from striding pleasantly along during a warm spring day. Each of these weather scenarios will create different types of obstacles. Rain can cause floods or mudslides, and the grey and drizzle can penalize Perceptionrolls: it's easy to slip and twist an ankle, or miss an ambush. A pleasant spring day, on the other hand, can increase visibility and make an ambush less likely, but it could also mean that any enemies might see you before you see them. Or what if there's a type of strange spring pollen in the air that causes problems for your

character? Allergens aren't typically the stuff of heroic fantasy, but hey--this is TBE, where everything can be an obstacle!

What about encounters? Am I traversing civilized lands, or going through the wilds? Or am I straddling the borderlands? The concept of Dangerous and Precarious hexes in the Travel rules comes from simply looking at the map and deciding how likely a dangerous encounter is to happen based on my position relative to Safe areas. While playing solo, if the danger levels of the area aren't obvious, you can just Ask the Weave: "Are these dangerous lands? If so, is there a danger I have to contend with here?" If the answer is yes, roll randomizers to determine what it is, and deal with it using the rest of the game rules.

Always remember: encounter questions should be about obstacles and dangers, not combat specifically. Fighting is only one danger you can face on the road, and if you use it as a default, it may quickly lose its fun and significance (or bring a premature end to your character's life). The possibilities for non-combat obstacles to overcome are nearly infinite. Simon spent most of an entire episode recovering from a twisted leg, and it was one of the most satisfying and immersive sessions I had. If you're stuck for ideas on what might befall your character, use the various Event Tables for inspiration (see Chapter 12 - Travel).

Put yourself in your character's shoes. In your mind's eye, see what they see, hear what they hear, feel what they feel. The more you imagine the details of the character's surroundings and circumstances, the richer your oracle questions and results--and your whole travel experience--will be.

If you are going to engage with the full Travel rules, I recommend giving yourself the Lone Wanderer Talent for free. This will make it easier to survive the wilds without a party to back you up.

» Lone Wanderer : If journeying by yourself, you may perform all three travel duties without the -40 penalty.

Solo Social Encounters

Solo social encounters are played out just like anything else you do in solo play. However, because the mechanics simulate round-by-round statements and responses (and you're just one person sitting by yourself in a room), you'll need to have a fun way to simulate the NPC "dialogue".

This depends greatly on how you play. I tend to "act out" the conversation, but this is easy for me, a professional voice actor who has spent the past 30 years having conversations with myself in different character voices. This will not be the default method for most of you. You may imagine the words spoken and jot down notes, or speak only your character's words and simply describe the NPC's reactions, or write out extensive dialogue scenes, or use some other method. However you do it, you'll need to depend on the natural back-and-forth of the conversation to make logical choices about what is said next.

For me, I keep in mind my character's preferred skills and how he or she would try to maximize their use; the particular NPC's character traits, biases, and preferences, and how those factor into their reactions; and above all, the goal I am pursuing by engaging in the Social Encounter in the first place. Once my character says the thing they want to say, I decide logically on what Social skill that would trigger, and roll it. Based on that result, I assume the NPC response--again basing it on the logic of the conversation--and keep a careful track of SLs gained, Timer Die results, etc., according to the Social Encounter rules.

In general, it's a good idea to increase an NPC's Tolerance by 2 when engaging in a solo Static Social Encounter. This will give you room to make some mistakes without failing miserably every time.

chapter 19: solo roleplaying in the broken empires

ask the weave

If you find yourself in a party of one, or in a group where everyone is the player, you can venture into the Broken Empires without a Gamemaster using these oracle rules.

Unless otherwise stated, all the mechanics of TBEstill apply when playing solo or GM-less.

Asking the Weave

When you have a question about what happens next in your adventure, you can Ask The Weave, a Yes/No oracle . This can be tapped at any time to determine what you find in a location, to see what an enemy does, to learn a new detail, or to advance the adventure any way you see fit.

When To Ask

You can Ask The Weave anything, at any time. However, TBE is about adventure, and the last thing you want is for your quest to crawl along while you ask lots of questions.

Ask The Weave when you aren't sure of something, or if the answer can have a big effect on the course of the adventure. Otherwise, consider answering the question yourself without rolling, using your best judgement.

For instance, upon entering a small town you've encountered, you might think to ask questions to see how developed the town is. You might decide, however, that it doesn't matter at this point, so you answer the question yourself by deciding the town is small but still well-resourced. In other words, it's exactly what you expect.

Within the town, you seek an herbalist to locate a rare plant you need for spellweaving. This is a much less sure situation, and should call for Asking The Weave, "Do I find a vendor of such a plant?"

Ask And Answer

To Ask The Weave, form a Yes/No question. Assign Odds for how likely you think the answer is "Yes".

Neutral Odds are 50/50. Use these Odds when you think the answer can go either way, or you have no idea what the Odds should be.

Positive Odds are Likely and Certain. Negative Odds are Unlikely and Impossible.

Why would you use Odds of Certain or Impossible, if the chances are certain or impossible? Even if you're sure of a result, if you decide to test it by Asking The Weave, then you're opening up the possibility that your assumptions are wrong. If that Certain thing doesn't happen, or the Impossible thing does happen, then it probably means you discover something you hadn't previously known.

Ask the Weave Chart

You have your Yes/No question. You have your Odds. Now roll d100 and check the Ask The Weave chart for the answer.

Ask the Weave (d100)

Odds	Extreme Yes	Yes	No	Extreme No
Certain	01-25	26-90	91-98	99-00
Likely	01-17	18-70	71-93	94-00
50/50	01-10	11-50	51-90	91-00
Unlikely	01-07	08-30	31-83	84-00
Impossible	01-02	03-10	11-75	76-00

Interpret Your Results

Depending on your roll, the answer will either be Extreme Yes, Yes, No, or Extreme No.

Follow your expectations about what those answers mean. Go with your gut. A "Yes" is usually easy to interpret; it's confirming what you expected. If the question was, "Does the soldier attack?" a "Yes" means they attack.

A "No" may be easy to interpret if the answers to the question are a simple binary. For instance,

"Is the door locked?" For questions where there are multiple possible interpretations for a "No", treat it as what you expect most after a "Yes" interpretation. For instance, if the question was, "Does the soldier attack?", and you get "No", maybe the next most likely thing they would do is threaten you: "Go away or you will be dealt with harshly!"

If you roll an Extreme answer, then interpret that Yes or No to the next level: take it to an extreme. An Extreme No to "Is the door locked?" could mean that not only is the door unlocked, but someone has busted it down. An Extreme Yes to "Does the soldier attack?" could mean not only does he attack, but he calls down the hall for reinforcements to join him in the attack.

Random Events

Rolling a critical (when doubles are rolled: 11, 22, 33, 44, 55, 66, 77, 88, 99, or 00) when Asking The Weave generates a Random Event. This is something that happens above and beyond the question you asked and the answer you received.

Whatever happens can be related or unrelated to the question that resulted in the Random Event. Choose an interpretation that makes sense and fits the context of the adventure.

The Random Event is something unexpected that the adventure is throwing your way. You can resolve the answer to your question first, to keep things simple, then generate the Random Event if you like.

Creating the Random Event

To create a Random Event, roll on the Random Events Table for a general idea of what happens, then roll a two-word combo: one word from Event Randomizers: Part I and one word from Event Randomizers: Part II .

Combine the results together and make an interpretation about what happens.

For example, after finding a plant vendor, your PC triggers a Random Event. A roll on the Random Events Table results in "Who Is This?", indicating a new NPC enters the adventure in an important way. Event Randomizers: Part I gets "Close" and Event Randomizers: Part II gets "The Weave".

The Player interprets all of this to mean that the plant vendor takes an interest in the PC's actions. Not only do they know why you need the plant, but they have a suggestion on where you can find more ingredients that will help with the spell you intend to cast. The vendor is helping you to get "Close" to "The Weave".

Random Events Table

d100	Event
1-10	NEWS : Learn news of something. This could be someone telling you, or you find evidence of it.
11-25	WHO IS THIS ?: A new Non-Player Character enters your adventure and gets involved in some way.
26-40	SUPPORTS A LIST ELEMENT : Roll on your Empires List for an adventure element. This Event supports it in some way. For instance, if it's a Player Character goal, then they catch a break in making progress. If it's an NPC, then the Event works in their favor somehow.
41-60	UNDERMINES A LIST ELEMENT : Roll on your Empires List for an adventure element. This Event undermines it in some way. For instance, if it's a Player Character goal, then they experience a setback. If it's an NPC, then the Event works against them somehow.
61-75	GOOD FOR YOU : Whatever the Event is, it's a positive development for the Player Character or their group.
76-95	BAD FOR YOU : Whatever the Event is, it's a negative development for the Player Character or their group.
96-100	GOAL OPPORTUNITY : The Event has something to do with a Player Character goal. This can be any of the PCs, if there is more than one, and any of their goals. Choose a goal or, if you prefer, roll to determine which PC and which goal. This Event should offer an opportunity to interact with the goal, maybe make progress on it, or even resolve a short-term goal, and give a chance to earn experience.

Event Randomizers: Part I

d100		d100	
01	Acquire	51	Forget
02	Action	52	Free
03	Agree	53	Frenzied
04	Amazing	54	Gain
05	Arrive	55	Give
06	Artificial	56	Good
07	Ask	57	Guide
08	Assistance	58	Heal
09	Attack	59	Help
10	Bad	60	Hide
11	Block	61	Hinder
12	Break	62	Hurt
13	Build	63	Imitate
14	Cast	64	Instruct
15	Celebrate	65	Intimidate
16	Challenge	66	Invade
17	Change	67	Investigate
18	Close	68	Large
19	Combat	69	Leave
20	Communicate	70	Loud
21	Complete	71	Lucky
22	Conclude	72	Maintain
23	Confine	73	Move
24	Conflict	74	Mundane
25	Consequence	75	New
26	Control	76	Normal
27	Cooperate	77	Observe
28	Create	78	Obstruct
29	Damage	79	Old
30	Dangerous	80	Open
31	Dark	81	Oppose
32	Deceive	82	Progress
33	Defensive	83	Protect
34	Deny	84	Reveal
35	Destroy	85	Risk
36	Discover	86	Setback
37	Disrupt	87	Slow
38	Divide	88	Socialize
39	Drop	89	Start
40	Encounter	90	Stop
41	Escalation	91	Strange
42	Excessive	92	Strengthen
43	Exchange	93	Struggle
44	Expected	94	Succeed
45	Exploit	95	Surprise
46	Fail	96	Take
47	Fast	97	Talk
48	Fight	98	Travel
49	Fill	99	Warm
50	Find	100	Weaken

Event Randomizers: Part II

d100		d100	
01	Advantage	51	Mental
02	Appearance	52	Message
03	Benefit	53	Mysterious
04	Building	54	Nature
05	Clothing	55	Near
06	Cold	56	Needs
07	Commerce	57	Night
08	Commitment	58	NPC
09	Conflict	59	Object
10	Container	60	Obligation
11	Creature	61	Obstacle
12	Crisis	62	Others
13	Danger	63	Pact
14	Day	64	Past
15	Deity	65	Path
16	Dilemma	66	PC
17	Disadvantage	67	Peace
18	Distant	68	People
19	Emotion	69	Physical
20	Empty	70	Plan
21	Enemy	71	Portal
22	Energy	72	Power
23	Environment	73	Protection
24	Equipment	74	Rarity
25	Expected	75	Resource
26	Faction	76	Reward
27	Fear	77	Rules
28	Followers	78	Safety
29	Fortune	79	Self
30	Fragility	80	Simple
31	Fragrance	81	Soon
32	Friend	82	Strange
33	Full	83	Stranger
34	Gift	84	Strength
35	Goal	85	Target
36	Goods	86	The Weave
37	Group	87	Tool
38	Hardship	88	Transaction
39	Health	89	Transportation
40	Hint	90	Treasure
41	Idea	91	Unknown
42	Illness	92	Unpleasantness
43	Important	93	Useful
44	Information	94	Valuable
45	Known	95	Vulnerability
46	Leader	96	Warning
47	Leverage	97	Weakness
48	Liquid	98	Wealth
49	Location	99	Weapon
50	Lore	100	Weather

Subverted Scenes

Asking The Weave is helpful for figuring out the detailed beats of your adventure narrative and where the action is.

As you enter into a new "scene", though, you will have expectations of how the scene should start. Those expectations might be altered. If they are, it will shape how you play through the new scene.

What is a Scene?

A scene is simply a period of time in which the PCs participate in some kind of focused activity. If the party is discussing their next move in a dungeon hallway, that roleplayed conversation is the scene. If they are traversing a dangerous ravine, then that is the scene. If they are in a fight for their lives against ravenous trolls, then that is the scene.

Changing Scenes

How do you know when one scene ends, and another begins? It's mostly a matter of dramatic timing. When the focus of that action seems to come to a natural conclusion, or leaves them asking "What happens now?", then it's time to switch scenes.

Starting a New Scene

If it's obvious how the next scene should start and you don't think it warrants any alterations, simply have the scene start as expected. If, however, you are uncertain about how the next scene should start, roll on the Subverted Expectations Table .

For example, say at the end of the last scene, your PC Spellweaver detected a tear in the tapestry a short distance away: someone had initiated a magical effect in a nearby forest clearing. That scene ended, and now a new one begins in which the character decides to investigate: "I move forward through the woods cautiously, trying to get closer to investigate the magical disturbance." Their expectation for the start of the new scene is simply what they say they are doing: moving through the forest to investigate.

Rolling on the Subverted Expectations Table could indicate their expectation happens: they move forward, cautiously, and get to the disturbance; or the table result may change what they expected to happen.

If the table indicates Less, maybe they don't have to move through the trees after all: the Spellweaver responsible for the disturbance steps out right in front of them.

A roll of More calls for rolling on the Event Randomizers Table for something additional happening, which could be just about anything. Maybe they roll "Conflict, Fragrance" and interpret it to mean that as they move forward, they smell something burning.

Rolling Unexpected means something other than what they expect happens: they roll an Event to determine what. Maybe they roll "News: Damage, Group" and interpret it to mean they come upon a group of mercenaries they had partnered with earlier. They're all dead, blasted by what appears to have been a fireball. This is the lingering magical effect the PC Spellweaver detected.

Subverted Expectations

d100	Result
1-50	EXPECTED : The scene starts as you expected.
51-63	LESS : The scene starts with less than you expected. Choose something from your expectations to remove.
64-76	MORE : The scene starts with more than what you expect. Roll two words on the Event Randomizers Tables and add your interpretation of the results into your expectations about how the scene starts.
77-100	UNEXPECTED : Something interrupts the scene's expected start. Generate an Event, as if rolling a Critical Event when Asking The Weave, and interpret the Event as what happens next in your adventure. This replaces your initial expectations about the next scene.

Using the Results of the Table

If you roll Expected on Subverted Expectations , then your expectation happens just as you thought it would.

The other results require changes to your expectations. You have a lot of leeway in how you interpret these results. Go with whatever feels best and is the most interesting to you.

For instance, if you test "We ride to the castle of the Death Knight" and roll Less, you have a choice of which detail to remove. You might decide that you have an encounter or get stopped along the way. Or you might decide that you ride to the castle, but the Death Knight is not there. Why? What happened to him? Play through the scene to find out.

Results of More and Unexpected call for using the Random Events and Event Randomizers Tables . With a result of More, include the interpreted pair of words along with your expectation. With a result of Unexpected, the Event replaces your expectation with a new interrupting scene.

Empires List

To help keep track of important NPCs, Player Character goals, and general "narrative threads" that emerge during the course of play, include them on the Empires List (see the Resources section at the back of the book). This is a list of up to 20 elements from your adventure that you consider most important. Using the List is a way to randomly interact with those elements in your adventures. Goals acquired in the course of an adventure can also be included.

Rolling On The List

Roll on the Empires List when you want to incorporate a random List element into an interpretation. For instance, you may have generated an Event when Asking The Weave. When interpreting the Event, you feel it should include something from the Empires List .

Consider rolling on the List when:

- A Generating an Event while Asking The Weave, especially if the Event is News, Supports A List Element, Undermines A List Element, Good For You, or Bad For You
- A Rolling More or Unexpected on the Subverted Expectations Table .

To roll on the List, roll d100 and look for the corresponding box. If the box is filled, then incorporate that element into the interpretation you're making. If the box is empty, then choose an existing element from the List that you think best fits into your interpretation.

Adding And Removing Elements

Add NPCs, Player Character goals, and general narrative threads to the Empires List as you wish. You can also remove these elements at any time.

You may want to eliminate List elements when they no longer apply to your adventure, or when the List is full and you want to make room for new, more important List elements.

If the List gets too full, or too riddled with crossed-out entries that it's become a mess, then it may be time to print out a fresh List and transfer your active elements over.

Empires List (Examples)

1-5	Find out how Edbert got on this beach
6-10	Pirates of the Drunken Ghoul
11-15	Captain Aaro Nikula
16-20	Deal with the pursuing Order
21-25	Help Nikula find the Soul Cage
26-30	Veil & Carlos are marooned
31-35	Cherilyn Spiritbane (ghost)
36-40	
41-45	
46-50	

Non-Player Characters

When a new NPC enters your adventure, you can randomly generate details about them by rolling four words from the Event Randomizers Table : twice from Part I and twice from Part II. These four words are the NPC's Tags , representing everything about them.

Tags At Work

Use any of these four words to interpret who this NPC is, how they act, what they look like, their personality... everything. By using only these words, the NPC behaves consistently throughout the adventure without having to make additional rolls, but as the Tags are applied to new situations and different contexts, you'll get different interpreted results as you go.

For instance, say a Player Character was hired by a merchant to find a lost treasure box, taken when the caravan transporting it was waylaid by an Ursowl in the woods. The PC believes the cave they are exploring is the lair of the beast.

The Player determines that their character encounters an NPC while exploring the cave. The Event Randomizers Table words rolled are "Combat, PC, Action, Goal".

The Player interprets that "PC, Goal" means the NPC has a direct link to the goal the Player Character is pursuing: the NPC was a member of the ambushed caravan.

"Combat" means he is badly wounded, presumably by the Ursowl who likely dragged him back to his lair along with the treasure.

By Asking The Weave, the Player determines that the man was held in captivity, but escaped and has been staggering through the cave system looking for a way out.

When asked if he'll stay and help guide the PC to the creature, the Player decides that the NPC agrees to help because of the Tags "Action, Goal" ... he will take action to help the PC with their goal.

He's also willing to take a weapon and fight, because of the Tags "Action, Combat".

Whenever you need to interpret something about an NPC, derive that interpretation based on at least one of the Tags.

Skills, Talents & Attributes

Determine whether an NPC has a particular skill or Talent when the opportunity arises, based on their Tags. For instance, in the example above about finding a survivor in the cave, the Player may determine that the man has an appropriate Combat skill because of the Tag "Combat".

If the PC was dealing with an enemy Spellweaver with the same Tags, they might decide their foe is of the Battlemage Convocation because of the "Combat" Tag.

If unsure whether an NPC has a skill or Talent, Ask The Weave.

Determining Skill Values

Choose a skill value that you think is most fitting to the NPC based on their Tags, the skill you're considering, and the context of the adventure.

After deciding the value you expect for a skill, you can opt to Ask The Weave, "Is this value correct?" Assign the question Odds based on how confident you are in your guess and roll to answer it.

Yes means the skill value stays at what you guessed it should be. No means the value is a little lower than you guessed. Extreme Yes means it's a little higher than you guessed, and Extreme No means it's a lot lower than you guessed.

The final value assigned to the skill is up to you, but packing it into an Ask The Weave question gives it random variability and an element of surprise.

NPC Skill Table

Random d100	Degree of Skill	NPC's Skill Value
01-15	Easy	35
16-55	Medium	50
56-85	Challenging	65
86-95	Hard	80
96-99	Severe	95
100	Extreme	100+

Determining Other Values

NPCs are also made up of Attributes and other scores, such as DT, Ferocity, etc. These can also be guessed at when needed and adjusted the same way skill values are, by Asking The Weave.

As Needed

There's no need to fully stat out an NPC as soon as they are encountered. It's enough to just generate their Tags. Skills and other statistics can be figured out as you go and as they come into play.

Smoothing It All Out

Don't worry about the values for skills and Attributes all being correct as you go. You're constructing the NPC piecemeal, one detail at a time, as you need to. If you generate a value that doesn't seem accurate based on what you've seen of them already, then adjust the value to fit.

For instance, you're dealing with a Spellweaver of some renown. His primary Magic skill should be quite high, so you start with a value of 80 Ex3. However, Asking The Weave says Extreme No, indicating to lower it by a lot.

That just doesn't make sense for a character who is known to be powerful, so you decide to leave the value at 80 Ex3.

Weapons, Armor & Equipment

Use the NPC's Tags and your expectations to determine any equipment they possess. A warrior is likely to be armed and armored, for instance.

If you aren't sure or think they may have a special piece of equipment, then Ask The Weave.

NPC Actions

When deciding NPC actions, such as how they attack in a fight, refer to their Tags and follow your expectations about what they would likely do.

For instance, a guard with a Tag of "Obligation" may fight to defend their boss, because it is their obligation to do so. But once the boss is safe and away, the guard may withdraw from the fight, because their obligation has been satisfied.

If you're not sure what an NPC will do, or you have conflicting expectations, then choose an expectation and Ask The Weave if that is the action.

NPC Spellweavers

The following NPC magic system intentionally simplifies most of the rules of Weave magic and does not require you to know anything up front about a Spellweaver's powers or Resolve.

Instead, you can randomly determine the spell effects an NPC Spellweaver may produce. Roll on the Spellweaving Effects: Action and Spellweaving Effects: Subject Tables for a pair of words as inspiration for both what the spell is intended to do, and what Bind and Strand might be used to do it.

Keep the context of the moment in mind. For instance, if you're generating a spell for an NPC who is trying to enter a locked castle, whatever the spell does will have something to do with getting into the place. Maybe it helps them scale the wall, or walk through solid matter, or make the lock on the door spring open.

Rolling "Counteract" and "Portal" may indicate that the Spellweaver magically seals the exits to a room the PC is in. That might suggest Change Plant if the door is wood, or Destroy Earth to collapse a doorway made of stone.

The Spellweaving Effects Tables can also be used to interpret a Godbound's miracles. Just keep the interpretations of the miracle effects within the bounds of the deity's domains.

Spellweaving Effects: Action

d100	
01	Acquire
02	Ambush
03	Animate
04	Assist
05	Attack
06	Benefit
07	Bestow
08	Block
09	Bludgeon
10	Bolster
11	Bombard
12	Break
13	Brighten
14	Change
15	Charge
16	Combine
17	Command
18	Complete
19	Conceal
20	Confine
21	Conjure
22	Control
23	Counteract
24	Create
25	Cure
26	Damage
27	Deceive
28	Defend
29	Delay
30	Deny
31	Destroy
32	Disappear
33	Discover
34	Duplicate
35	Expand
36	Explode
37	Fast
38	Find
39	Free
40	Freeze
41	Gain
42	Give
43	Grow
44	Guide
45	Harm
46	Heal
47	Help
48	Hinder
49	Imbue
50	Initiate
51	Immobilize
52	Increase
53	Inflict
54	Inform
55	Inject
56	Inspect
57	Install
58	Intuit
59	Learn
60	Lessen
61	Lift
62	Limit
63	Make
64	Manipulate
65	Move
66	Multiply
67	Noise
68	Obfuscate
69	Open
70	Protect
71	Pursue
72	Reduce
73	Remove
74	Replace
75	Resist
76	Reveal
77	Reverse
78	Rush
79	Shoot
80	Shrink
81	Slow
82	Speak
83	Start
84	Stop
85	Strengthen
86	Strike
87	Stun
88	Summon
89	Support
90	Surprise
91	Take
92	Transform
93	Transport
94	Trick
95	Trigger
96	Undermine
97	Usurp
98	Warm
99	Weaken
100	Witness

Spellweaving Effects: Subject

d100	
01	Action
02	Air
03	Animal
04	Appearance
05	Area
06	Armor
07	Art
08	Barrier
09	Battle
10	Beast
11	Blood
12	Body
13	Clothing
14	Cloud
15	Clue
16	Cold
17	Color
18	Communication
19	Consumable
20	Container
21	Curse
22	Darkness
23	Death
24	Defense
25	Distance
26	Dreams
27	Earth
28	Emotion
29	Enemy
30	Energy
31	Environment
32	Equipment
33	Expected
34	Fear
35	Fire
36	Food
37	Friend
38	Goal
39	Goods
40	Group
41	Health
42	Ice
43	Identity
44	Illness
45	Illusion
46	Information
47	Language
48	Life
49	Light
50	Limb
51	Liquid
52	Location
53	Lore
54	Luck
55	Meaning
56	Mind
57	Missile
58	Mist
59	Monster
60	Mysterious
61	Nature
62	Near
63	Necromancy
64	Needs
65	Object
66	Obstacle
67	Oracle
68	Ornament
69	Plants
70	Poison
71	Portal
72	Power
73	Price
74	Radius
75	Recovery
76	Resistance
77	Resource
78	Ritual
79	Rune
80	Self
81	Senses
82	Size
83	Skill
84	Social
85	Speed
86	Spheres
87	Spirit
88	Surface
89	Tapestry
90	Thought
91	Time
92	Trap
93	Undead
94	Wall
95	Water
96	Wealth
97	Weapon
98	Weather
99	Worlds
100	Wounds

Casting the NPC's Spell

A Spellweaver must still successfully roll the appropriate Bind skill for the spell to take effect. Choose the caster's skill level or roll on the NPC Skill Table.

If your PC is pursuing a Spellweaver across a rope bridge and the NPC casts a spell, the results of "Weaken" and "Resource" could be interpreted to mean the NPC uses Change Plant to weaken a rope of the bridge until it snaps. You decide this caster has a "Challenging" Change bind of 65.

Resisting NPC Spells

- If the spell must be resisted, the caster's rolled Bind skill sets the resistance, as normal.
- Critical success adds +3 SLs.
- If the roll failed, the spell does not go off.
- If the roll critically failed, the spell does not go off, and the caster rolls a Weave Reaction with 1d20+5, ignoring any effects that don't apply.

Magnitude is abstracted into the roll and does not require separate consideration, but if you feel the spell effect would have a high Magnitude, you can always decide that a Weave Reaction happens even on a normal success (roll 1d20+5 on the Weave Reaction Table).

Attack Spells and Damage

If the spell is an Attack spell, use the caster's "ones" die to determine general hit location, and the defender's "ones" die to determine the detailed hit location.

If you need a numeric effect for the spell, roll 1d10+2. This presumes the caster is expending various amounts of Resolve to power the spell, which you don't need to track.

An NPC Spellweaver casts a bolt of fire at your PC. You have given the caster a "Challenging" skill value of 65. He succeeds with a roll of 43, setting the resistance. You fail to oppose, rolling 67 on your Dodge skill of 50. You roll 1d10+2 and take a total of 5 external fire damage to your Body: Stomach location, as the caster's "ones" die was a 3 (Body), and your defense "ones" die was a 7 (Stomach).

Casting Normally

If the NPC is a major Spellweaver with a listed Resolve score, you can instead use the full spellcasting rules for them. Don't combine the two systems--just choose whichever makes sense for the scene.

Spellweaver Styles

If an NPC Spellweaver is going to be around for a while in your adventure, you can build up their style of spellcasting using the Spellweaver Style List Table (see the Resources section at the back of the book). Each Spellweaver gets their own table, which helps you craft a distinctive kind of magic they create while still generating the spells randomly when you need them.

Recording Styles

To build a Spellweaver's style, when generating the first spell for them using the Spellweaving Effects Tables, record the Effect words on a copy of the Spellweaver Style List Table. Each word gets its own entry. For the Effect: Action word, write in the Bind skill you chose and its skill value. For the Effect: Subject word, write in the Strand you associated that spell with.

> When the Counteract (Action) Portal (Subject) spell was first rolled on the Spellweaving Effects Table, you decided to interpret that as a Destroy Earth spell with a Bind skill of 65.
>
> In the first space, you write "Counteract (Bind: Destroy 65)". In the second space, you write "Portal (Strand: Earth)".

Spellweaver Style List (Example)

d100	Effect
1-5	Counteract (Bind: Destroy 65)
6-10	Portal (Strand: Earth)
11-15	
16-20	
21-25	
26-30	
31-35	
36-40	

When the NPC casts again, instead of rolling on the Spellweaving Effects Tables, roll for two Effect words on the NPC's Spellweaver Style List Table. If you roll an empty box, then roll on the appropriate column of the Spellweaving Effects Table and use that word, recording it on the Style list. If you interpret the new Action as a Bind skill that is already represented on the Style list, use its skill value.

The Spellweaver Style List Table indicates these are the NPC's go-to Binds and Strands.

Duplicate Results

As a Spellweaver list fills out, it's possible to get duplicate entries. That's fine, fill the spaces with the duplicates. The Spellweaver Style List Table doesn't just indicate what the NPC knows, but what they are most likely to cast. Multiple entries of the same words can mean either that is the limit of their knowledge or that is what they favor casting.

Getting Started

To get a solo adventure started, roll an Event. If you feel the interpretation of this Event isn't enough to start an adventure, then roll a second or a third Event and combine them all together.

Play out this starting moment, leading you into Asking The Weave and What Happens Next, carrying you along into the rest of the adventure.

cHAPTER 20:

the setting of the broken empires

The Weave permeates all of existence. Its subtle threads of invisible force are bound together into the Tapestry of Reality, upon which every event that has ever occurred plays out in exquisite detail, from the capricious dance of the tiniest mote to the most cataclysmic celestial event.

Amidst this unimaginably complex pattern, in an unremarkable and insignificant corner of the Tapestry, a slight fraying can be discerned; a subtle imperfection to mar the otherwise impossible beauty. It is in this corner that the patterns and threads spin together to form the world of Theryn, which contains the lands known as the Broken Empires: a vast realm of diverse nations and cultures, each uniquely forged by the struggle to survive and prosper in a treacherous age.

Here, great powers rise to prominence and inevitably fall back into obscurity as the coarse patterns of the Weave play out over the long centuries. The Duanan Seethe once dominated the land, but vanished an age ago, leaving only silence, lingering questions, and crumbling ruins to hint at their once-great powers.

Likewise, the Dwarven Empire flourished in their mountain fastness before a great cataclysm forced them to flee in their massive stone airships. Today, they wander aimlessly, while their ancient homeland has become the domain of ghosts, demons, and worse.

Ascendant after the fall of the elder empires are the realms of Men, but these too are prone to misfortune and hubris. There are some who believe that the Pattern is already asserting itself, that the fortunes of humanity have already turned. Some even whisper that the raising of the Iron Veil was the catalyst for a multitude of phenomena that will hasten the doom of Mankind. Indeed, from the craggy mountains of Dunblaine to the shifting sands of the Red Wastes, from the sun-drenched beaches of the Serpent's Teeth Isles, to the ancient forests of the Westlands, each nation faces its own challenges and existential threats.

However, the Tapestry encompasses not only lands, but the individuals that inhabit them. The actions of these individuals have the power to affect their own destinies, along with the destinies of others. In effect, they have the power to save these empires...or break them.

chapter 20: the setting of the broken empires

Timeline of Significant Events

All dates are marked as either before or after the Great Dread (GD), the catastrophe that ended the Imperial Vestrian civilization.

-628 GD	The Dwarven Cataclysm occurs, scattering the civilization of a once mighty 2000-year-old empire to the skies aboard a fleet of stone ships.
-554 GD	The original four Tetrarchs dissolve the Vestrian Senate and declare the rule of Imperica Vestria.
-390 GD	After declining in population for centuries, the last of the Duanan Seethe depart the Broken Empires, leaving behind their Bolg Fiir cousins, along with the legacy of the Seethie Ancestor Stones.
-256 GD	In an initial experiment to create a magical barrier between worlds, a group of powerful mages has their magical energies spin out of control, isolating and banishing a large geographical area into an unknown limbo. This area comes to be known as the Shroud.
-223 GD	A group of Spellweavers raises the Iron Veil. Various kingdoms begin sending prisoners into exile in the Ironlands that lie beyond it.
-157 GD	A group of prisoners bound for the Ironlands wins their freedom and settles upon Haedravik.
1 GD	The year of the Great Dread. The last-ditch effort by the Tetrarchs' Spellweavers to halt the growth of the Grey Wailing backfires. The Grey spreads like a wildfire, killing tens of thousands of Imperial citizens, including three of the Tetrarchs. The heartland of the Imperium is abandoned and forevermore becomes known as "The Haunted Fiefs." Chaos engulfs what remains of the Imperium as the coastal cities struggle to support the flood of refugees. A succession crisis for the three unoccupied thrones results in a short and bloody civil war. By the end of the year, Vestria as a power is no more, and the rule of the Tetrarchs has ended.
324 GD	Thessian scholars begin to notice that the glaciers of the far north are advancing.
405 GD	The Creeping Ice halts its advance after consuming all of Thessia save for its extreme southern fringes.
623 GD	A group of scholars and Spellweavers disappears while investigating claims of strange phenomena in the badlands of Angevarre's southern colonies.
891 GD	A lich known as "Mother" slays the Angevarran royal family and begins a reign of terror in that land.
893 GD	Angevarre's southern colonies use the chaos caused by Mother's rule to break free of Angevarran rule. They become the largely lawless land known as "the Baronies."
896 GD	A group of powerful Spellweavers comes together to defeat "Mother". They form the Order of the Purifying Flame, dedicating themselves to hunting down and destroying the abominations Mother had let loose upon the land.
902 GD	A series of grave injustices perpetrated by the new monarch sparks the Angevarran Civil War.
905 GD	The Angevarran Civil War ends with the Rebel Lords fleeing to the Westlands where they find safe harbor with new allies.
906 GD	Thane Samuel Keighton, the First and Last King of the Westlands, is mortally wounded at the Battle of Bramblewash Ford. The City of Keighton is founded, as is the Westlands' Ruling Council of Seven Lords.
941 GD	The Weeping Plague, also called "Ashblood" and "the Blacktears", strikes Tical Dondala and wipes out a quarter of the population. The disease, which causes the victim's blood to run black as coal and leak from the eyes, spreads quickly throughout the surrounding kingdoms, killing off a great portion of the Human population.
1023 GD	The first expedition departs for the land that will become known as "Devona's Spine".

1060 GD	Hohenvall discovers a lucrative trade route to exotic, unexplored lands to the west, bringing in a fortune in trade. Over the coming years, this economic imbalance will have a devastating effect on the economies of the other Great Powers.
1109 GD	The Massacre of Caerdun Innis. Keir Kempoch MacDonn becomes the Black Laird of Dunblaine.
1115 GD	Cherilyn Spiritbane is killed in an avalanche. The Order of the Purifying Flame blames her bodyguard, Edbert.
1116 GD	A series of murders occurs in Keighton. Simon of Argoston is considered the chief suspect.
1117 GD	A splinter cult of Devona starts an uprising in Hundatora, in which the city narrowly escapes destruction. Simon of Argoston finds his parents and is found not guilty of the Keighton murders.
1118 GD	Arn Kalapunki breaches the Iron Veil and travels to the Ironlands to fulfill his vow. Shal'Umar Ghant emerges from the Fanged Desert and begins preaching about Omnus the One in Drangia.
1119 GD	Edbert finds the Soul Cage and frees himself of Cherilyn Spiritbane's ghost. Hohenvall sends a diplomatic missive to the other great powers in the Broken Empires, declaring the lands west of it to be off-limits to all but their Trading Guild. They promise dire consequences to any who would defy the ban.
1120 GD	The assassin Veil and the Dwarf Thragg Drakebane, both of the Order of the Purifying Flame, travel to the Red Wastes to challenge the quasi-lich Mot-Zaroth. Veil is lost to the strange city-between-worlds of Nor-Carthe, and fails to return.
1121 GD	Current year.

There is no "common tongue" in the Broken Empires. The closest thing to a lingua franca is Low Vestrian, the remnant language of those ancient rulers of the known world a thousand years gone--and there are not many in any kingdom who could now claim mastery of that precursor tongue, save those whose trade depends on it.

Whenever PCs are speaking with someone, keep in mind that person's native speech; if they do not share a language with the Player Characters, they will struggle to communicate, which itself both creates interesting obstacles and enshrines the value of keeping company with a good merchant or Loremaster.

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regions of the broken empires

Angevarre

Geography

The Kingdom of Angevarre is a heavily populated land in the heart of the Broken Empires, bounded in the north and east by large mountain ranges, in the south by the Rivier Lemasse, and in the west by the Great Western Ocean. The western part of the country, where most of the population resides, is a land of rugged hills, intercut with deep, fertile valleys and deciduous woodlands, with plenty of water supplied by numerous small rivers and lakes. The great Rivier Sarroux cuts a long, meandering line from the southern foothills of the Vargonarre mountains in the north, to the large coastal harbor city and capital, Dineol, providing an important artery for trade along its impressive length.

In the north, the lands gradually become less populated as one approaches the Vargonarre mountain range, which forms a border with the Westlands beyond. Only a few small passes provide routes across the mountains, none of which are without their dangers. The Carpsbourg Pass is the closest to civilized lands; however, its high altitude and narrow gullies make it treacherous in the summer and almost impassable in the winter. The Vale of Bones--named for the skeletons of impossibly huge sea creatures that are inexplicably embedded within the cliff faces along the path--is a more forgiving route, but much harder to reach due to rough highlands and deep ravines. Finally, the remote Huntchester Gap, located deep within the wilds of northeastern Angevarre, is frequented by orcs, making it much less attractive than the alternatives.

The northeast is not wholly uninhabited. Several major rivers flow into Angevarre's largest lake, Lac Mirelha, upon which can be found numerous fishing towns and villages. There are perils associated with living so far from the centers of power, however. These settlements are forever plagued by bandits, and even some wayward bands of orcs, both of whom find the plentiful forests in the region convenient refuges when the Queen's road wardens pass through.

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Further south and east, the surprisingly large city of Caelbourg sits at the base of the rugged Attany canyon. Taking advantage of the generous seams of iron ore running through the mountains at its back, Caelbourg is a thriving trade center, with a near-constant stream of ore-laden barges pushing off from its river docks at all hours, and fresh barges bringing back luxury goods and workers in return. Some of the miners have brought back tales of wondrous underground cities that they have stumbled across deep within the mountain roots, resulting in an influx of adventurers eager to explore the tunnels for themselves.

Running west from Caelbourg for several hundred miles, the lands rise, forming the Cheleme Highlands and the massive Grande Anciens Uplands, separated from each other by the mile-deep Massandy Canyon. These highlands are predominantly grassy, with large sections of the underlying bedrock forming outcrops in the thin soil. Aside from a few small sheep and goat herding enterprises, these lands are mostly unproductive and empty. Where the Massandy and Attany Canyons meet, sits Manier Ar'Salle, a city that serves as an important trade hub for goods traveling not only upon the Rivier Lemasse, but also between Angevarre and the Baronies to the south.

Finally, in the extreme southwest of the country is a region of coastal plain between the mouth of the Rivier Lemasse in the east and the Moritas Mountains in the west, that is only nominally under Angevarran rule. Here, the presence of the Order of the Purifying Flame looms large and dominates the lives of the petty lords in the area to a degree that is envied by the Queen herself.

History

Angevarran society is rigidly stratified, with a strong social hierarchy ranging from poor villein sharecroppers, up through free merchants and craftsmen, landless knights, barons, viscounts, counts, dukes, princes, and finally, the monarch. The rural economy focuses on agriculture, herding, fishing, hunting, and mining, depending on region. In contrast, the economies of the various cities are much more elaborate, with a complex and interconnected series of guilds, taxes, and levies designed to ensure that the nobles, merchant lords, and guildmasters are all able to make a profit from the labors of those who answer to them.

Though today Angevarre enjoys a degree of stability and prosperity, there was a time not so long ago when the very Kingdom was on the verge of collapse. Just over two centuries ago, the passing of an elderly and ailing King, with multiple children of questionable legitimacy, touched off a fierce succession crisis. In the midst of this chaos, one of the supposed heirs was eventually able to gain the upper hand and capture the throne in Dineol.

Though such a coup was not unprecedented, what occurred in the aftermath certainly was. Shortly after she ascended to the throne, the new Queen was revealed to be not only an imposter, but a lich most foul. Those who tried to resist her would prove too late, for not only were her undead minions unleashed upon the land, but she had also enthralled many of the living to her service.

As the lich, who her living thralls referred to as "Mother," tightened her grip on the Angevarran heartland, those who could resist did. Most notable was the secession of the Angevarran Southern Colonies, which had never sat easily under the yoke

Caelbourg Dineol Hundatora Manier Ar'Salle

of the crown, and now found an opportunity for freedom. Mother was too busy consolidating her rule of the Kingdom to concern herself with the Colonies, and so they were free to go their own way. The various Colonies began to rule themselves independently, and eventually devolved into a state just short of chaos, becoming the lands now known as the Baronies.

Some, however, were able to resist from within Angevarre and act against the lich where they could. These groups were successful enough that Mother retreated to the safety of the fortress known as Stormhold Keep, famous for its formidable defenses. From the Keep, Mother continued her reign of terror, releasing countless undead creatures upon the land, as well as armies of living servants, all purporting to be in search of something the lich would only refer to as her "son."

As the resistance continued, the various groups grew more organized, and out of the more scholarly of these was born the Order of the Purifying Flame. After several years of struggle, the Order managed to defeat Mother and dispatch her essence from the Weave itself. In the aftermath, they took Stormhold Keep for themselves, vowing to rid Angevarre of the undead scourge the lich had given birth to. Over the intervening centuries, their mission has expanded to include all undead across the lands.

As Angevarre struggled to recover, its lords elected a strong new ruler, King Hugh II, a cousin of the previous King. Unfortunately, he turned out to be a poor choice, for shortly after his ascension to the throne, Hugh became afflicted with the Barrens Pox. Over the course of years, the disease twisted his mind, and he grew both paranoid and cruel.

After the erroneous arrest and execution of several influential lords and ladies, thirteen of them rebelled, touching off the Angevarran Civil War. Three years of brutal conflict proved devastating to the Rebel Lords. In the end, after losing much of their forces and most of their allies, only four of the original thirteen Rebel Lords remained. Rather than surrender to the mad and capricious King, these lords retreated, escaping Angevarre by ship, along with their families, households, and military forces. They made a new home for themselves in the Westlands, where they were welcomed as allies by King Samuel in his struggles against the orcs.

> Angevarran society is rigidly stratified, with a strong social hierarchy ranging from poor villein sharecroppers, up through free merchants and craftsmen, landless knights, barons, viscounts, counts, dukes, princes, and finally, the monarch.

Although Hugh never relented in his obsession with seeking vengeance on the Rebel Lords, several ill-fated expeditions finally drained his resources to the point where he could make no further attempts against them. Almost a decade and a half of conflict--first against Mother, and then the Rebel Lords--had exhausted Angevarre's resources, and even in his madness, Hugh was forced to relent.

King Hugh died only a year after the end of the Angevarran Civil War, still wracked with fury and hatred for those who would defy him. Thankfully, his heir, and her heirs to follow, were not susceptible to the disease that had so ravaged the Kingdom during his reign. In the years following, the people of Angevarre rebuilt their Kingdom out of the ashes of its near-destruction. The nation has prospered and become a powerful force within the Broken Empires, although it is still plagued by scheming nobles and grasping clergymen who spin far-reaching webs of political intrigue that ensnare even those nobles farthest from the palace.

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The Present Situation

The scars of Angevarre's past still remain. Despite the best efforts of the Order of the Purifying Flame, pockets of Mother's undead minions lie hidden in remote areas, occasionally appearing to trouble unwary villagers. The continued threat of the undead has only strengthened the influence of the Order itself, whose growing secrecy--and rumored withholding of discoveries beneath Stormhold Keep--has become a source of unease at court. Relations between Angevarre and the descendants of the Rebel Lords in the Westlands remain difficult. Recent diplomatic overtures have largely collapsed amidst mutual accusations, border disputes, and growing fears that neither side truly desires peace. And now, a young and ambitious Queen, Elena Valbeaux, seeks to erase the memories of a weakened past, rise above the petty intrigues and gross appetites of nobles and clergy alike, and rekindle the fires of Angevarran glory. A mighty new fleet has been commissioned that has seen Angevarre once again ascend to its former status as one of the three "Great Powers", a trio of kingdoms--Angevarre, Tical Dondala, and Hohenvall--in competition for naval supremacy and colonial control over the Serpent's Teeth Isles. The battle for control over the islands is likely, as the first step in a much larger scheme to remake Angevarre into the sole inheritor of Old Vestria's imperial legacy.

And the old embers of internal strife have started to smolder once again. In recent years, Queen Elena has increasingly bypassed the old noble houses in favor of newly elevated military officers, naval commanders, and lesser lords personally loyal to the crown. This has caused growing resentment amongst the great houses, many of whom fear that the Queen intends to permanently weaken their influence in favor of a more centralized monarchy. Several powerful families have already begun quietly strengthening their private armies under the pretense of defending against increased orc incursions in the northeast. Many fear this will lead to a new civil war.

Rumors

Rumor : After several disastrous and insulting diplomatic incidents, Queen Elena of Angevarre may have decided that now is the time to look north to the Westlands, with an eye toward conquest. A small, but vocal faction of minor lords in the court believes they have the means to dissuade her, and avert war. Some among them even believe the Queen is being manipulated by foreign powers.

Rumor : The lich, Mother, gathered a veritable trove of treasure during her rule of Angevarre. This wealth still sits, untouched, in the depths of Stormhold Keep. There is a disgruntled former member of the Order of the Purifying Flame who knows a secret way into the keep, and who is seeking a small group of skilled individuals to help her, with the treasure as the promised reward.

Rumor : There has been increased orc activity in the northeast. These orcs seem to be particularly well organized and disciplined, far outside the norm for their kind. The people of Chergard are offering a substantial reward for anyone who investigates these claims.

Rumor : Several ports along Angevarre's western coast have recently imposed stricter inspections upon foreign vessels after reports of a strange wasting sickness appearing amongst crews arriving from the south. Officially, the crown insists there is no cause for alarm. Unofficially, memories of the Weeping Plague remain strong enough that even rumors of a new pestilence have begun causing panic in some harbor districts.

My Dearest Friend,

You once asked what frightened me the most. As is my habit, I laughed and made a jest of it. I did not then know the depth of your commitment to our cause, and this has made me realize that I did you a grave disservice. So now I cry for your pardon and answer your question plainly, in writing, for I do not know even now if I could bring forth the words in any other form.

Well do you know the tale of the Lich known as Mother. How over the course of a few short months, she managed to do what so many great powers had tried and failed at: conquering Angevarre and bringing it to its knees--all in service of her mad search for whatever thing it might have been that she kept referring to as her "son." In the process, she released horrors upon the land that we struggle to contain even to this day, despite our continuing efforts.

It has been well over two centuries since her defeat and utter destruction at the hands of my predecessors. Yet still I wake in the depths of the night with a chill upon my heart when I contemplate the fact that she never found this "son." What was--or is--the nature of this thing? Why did she never find it, and why was she searching here in Angevarre of all places? Most importantly, what if it is still out there, somewhere, searching for its Mother?

-- A letter from Cherilyn Spiritbane
to Vicomtesse Triselle Valcroix
de Varleon, 1113 GD

Ansharir

Often mistaken from afar as a mirage, the city-state of Ansharir rises out of the desert like a gleaming gem. The Jewelled River runs like a green ribbon at its feet, winding through the many miles of farms and orchards that populate the waterway's rich flood plain. Called the Shimmering City for the way its image dances upon the hot desert air, it is a beacon to weary travelers that promises food, water, and rest--as well as more sophisticated pleasures. The homes and shops of the city are painted with bright pigments that bring their walls and roofs alive with vibrant color. The city is an explosion of sights, sounds, smells, and tastes. Any exotic dish, cloth, song, or weapon can be found in its sweltering, teeming marketplaces.

History

For a long age and more, venerable Ansharir has sat upon the banks of the river, regal and elegant like an empress upon her throne. A city has always stood in this spot; Ansharir is built upon the layered bones of its predecessors, whose history stretches back into dim memory, to a time when the Red Wastes were green with life, and water flowed in abundance across what is now lifeless sand.

In that time, Ansharir was but one of many city-states in a densely populated land of warring sorcerer-kings, petty tyrants, and fledgling republics. Over the countless centuries, the city's ruling Emirs guided it carefully as civilizations rose and fell around it, until finally, some long-forgotten calamity turned the entire region into a wasteland.

--Translated fragment of the Sacred Scrolls of Zargarian, Prophet of the Ardent Flame, Seer to Vizier Rahtalu Elumkan of Ansharir. Season of the Crocodile, Year of the Thirty-first return of Petrehk's Comet

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In the bitter years that followed, Ansharir's unique location gave it the resources needed to survive the catastrophe, but also made it a tempting target for the desperate. Rival city-states, weakened and facing extermination, made common alliance and attempted to take the city by force. Histories of the time are vague and difficult to separate from folk tales, but they all tell of the legendary Emir, Ahkatrem, who eschewed armed conflict and instead used clever diplomacy to maneuver his enemies against one another. Within a generation, Ansharir stood alone as a power in the Red Wastes. All its former rivals were reduced to either crumbling ruins dotting the desert landscape or small enclaves eking out a meagre existence in the harsh wastes.

Over untold centuries, Ansharir's fortunes waxed and waned. Golden ages came, often followed by decline, poverty, and destruction, only for the city to rebuild itself and rise once again. At some point during this time, the last Emir died without leaving an heir, and the reign of the Viziers began, though such a change meant little to the city or its inhabitants.

Few Viziers through this long history are as infamous as the brothers Rahatep and Rahtaal Tumkamet. It was the elder brother, Rahatep, who first welcomed the tribal sorcerer, Mot-Zaroth, to the Ansharirri court and acted as patron to the ambitious young man. This proved to be his undoing, for an increasingly powerful Mot-Zaroth aided Rahtaal in betraying his brother and taking the high seat of the city, while Rahatep was forced into exile.

It was in Rahtaal's court that Mot-Zaroth first encountered the seer, Iblis Zargarian, who was already the head of a growing cult known as the Ardent Fire. The Ardent Fire was an apocalyptic faith that demanded radical social upheaval to bring about a golden age. It soon became apparent to Mot-Zaroth that the cult was not above using violence to meet its ends, and he set out to earn its trust to better manipulate it. The sorcerer led Iblis into the desert to the Temple of Baal'lan, a demon of the Outer Darkness. There, Iblis gained a great deal of power and returned to Ansharir, intending to bring his vision to fruition.

The ensuing chaos almost destroyed the city. Eventually, the Ardent Fire was driven from Ansharir, and the survivors--including Iblis, now known as the Mad Seer of the Sands--escaped into the wilds where they would regroup and eventually launch a campaign of conquest that would become legendary. Mot-Zaroth, in the meantime, was able to take advantage of the chaos and trick Rahatep into returning to the city to challenge Rahtaal. Due to the sorcerer's manipulation, the two brothers fought each other to the death, leaving Ansharir leaderless--a state that continued for many years while Mot-Zaroth continued to pull the strings from the shadows. It was around this time that Mot-Zaroth began his pursuit of lichdom, seeking eternal life as a powerful undead Spellweaver. In the end, the only thing that saved the city from the sorcerer's machinations was that he apparently achieved his goals. After years of strife and chaos, one day Mot-Zaroth abruptly vanished from Ansharir--though rumor always held that his minions remained to keep vigil for his eventual return.

Ansharir

The Present Situation

Today, life in Ansharir is much as it has been throughout its history. Its survival and prosperity depend on agriculture made possible by the annual flooding of the alluvial plains along the banks of the Jewelled River, as well as by offering hospitality to the trade caravans making their way across the Wastes. Ansharirri society is based on a rigidly structured caste system. Members of the lowest caste do not even reside in the city--these are the sharecroppers who work the farm and orchard estates owned by the Noble Houses, and in return are allowed small plots of their own land on which to subsist. In slightly better circumstances are the city laborers, followed in turn by the members of the servant class, entertainers, artisans, merchants, and finally the nobles at the top of the social hierarchy.

Though in theory the Vizier is the absolute ruler of the city, he is a reclusive figure who only appears to those outside his inner circle once every thirteen months at a Palace event. The day-to-day running of Ansharir falls to the various factions, which constantly struggle among themselves in an attempt to accomplish their goals. The factions are many and varied, and include the multitude of Noble Houses; the Artisan Guilds such as the Builders' Brotherhood, Courtesans' Guild, and Firetamers' Guild; and the enigmatic House of Reeds.

While not officially a Noble House, the House of Reeds holds a great deal of influence over Ansharirri society. Ancient and mysterious, none know who the members of this House truly are or even the provenance of their fortune. All transactions are made through foreign proxy-servants. No Ansharirri are employed or even allowed on the highly secure House compound. The origin and upkeep of the House's wealth is equally cryptic; unlike the Noble Houses, it owns no agricultural land outside the city, nor any stakes in any merchant caravans passing through the city gates. If it engages in trade at all, none of it passes through the House of Reeds' compound. Nevertheless, the House of Reeds makes its influence known, often at key moments during negotiations between the Nobility. A short message from the House of Reeds has even been known to sway the Vizier's decisions.

Finally, there is the group of killers known as the Silent Death Assassins. Like the House of Reeds, the Silent Death practices its influence over Ansharir from the shadows. Rather than silver or land, its preferred trade is death, and the threat of death to meet its aims. Its services are available to any for a price, but that price is often taken in the form of favors rather than coin. Identified by the tattoo of a dagger behind their right ear, Silent Death assassins can come from any caste and often lead double lives, so that even their closest friends and kin are unaware of their true occupation.

Rumors

Rumor : The leaders of the House of Reeds are vampires. As ravenous as they are ancient, their nightly forays are responsible for many of the murders that constantly plague the city.

Rumor : Beneath the sewers, the ruins of previous iterations of Ansharir are still accessible. Some of these can even be reached through caves in the bluff below the city walls. Many treasures and bits of lost lore await any brave enough to face the dangers that lie within.

Rumor : One of the Red Waster tribal nomad leaders claims she is the true heir to the last Emir of Ansharir. While it is almost impossible to prove such an ancient kinship, she does have the crocodile birthmark and two different-colored eyes that once marked the members of that lineage. She is an inspiring speaker, and many have flocked to her cause, including some Anshararri Noble Houses.

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The Baronies

Dear Captain,

Those damned landjacks we drank with back in Dengmarsh wasn't lying about this place. A man (or a woman for that matter--there's a few around here as ferocious as a hungover Thessian bear) can carve out a tidy little fiefdom up here in the Baronies, and none of the so-called great powers will lift a finger to stop 'em. Has somethin' to do with some big obsidian fort in the badlands--they're scared spitless of it. Don't want to go near it. Not sure why--I heard it just sits there like a lump.

Me and the lads arrived a few months ago and promptly set up shop in an old rundown watchtower. Weren't there but a fortnight a'for some local callin' hisself a Baron come on by with a handful of sorry looking gits he called "soldiers," sayin' we're on his land. Owed him taxes, he said. Well, I'm not one to let someone like that get uphanded with me, so we got ourselves into a little tussle. No need for all the details, but now I'm the Baron, and have me a nice cozy little castle to put my feet up in.

Here's the thing. This castle has this little village around it, with farmers and all. I guess they pay me taxes now. Now here's the part that you'll ken. I guess the ordinary folk around these parts ain't treated so good by a lot of these other Barons. Remember what you always told me about treatin' the deckhands well, and they'll always be loyal? Well, I tried that with these folk, and now all their family and friends are comin' round wantin' to live here too. I swear by good Morghus this town has tripled in size in just a few months.

So what I'm sayin', Captain, is if you ever get tired of the salt and wind, and chasin' the Dondalese, come on up here and join us. There ain't no treasure but dirt, but a man can live like a crackin' king just the same.

Your friend and bosun, Crispin Trelawney

--A letter to Captain Domingo Alarcon of the Golden Heron

The Obsidian Citadel

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Geography

The Baronies is the informal name used to refer to a mostly lawless region lying between Angevarre and Tical Dondala. The vast interior of the Baronies is characterized by arid plains in the north and rugged badlands in the south, with more fertile lands lying around the perimeter. Particularly desirable lands are found along the south banks of the Rivier Lemasse which forms the border with Angevarre, as well as the areas between the Tarnavaux Highlands and the coast, in the foothills of the Grande Eastern Mountains, and on the slopes of the Quille and Carbec River Valleys.

The plains along the north face of the Albancia Mountain range would, in theory, also make for good cultivable land. However, this region is dominated by the mysterious and ancient Iluneous Forest, which has thus far proven impenetrable and stubbornly resistant to any large-scale attempts at taming or clearing. Many who have tried to settle in the area soon give up, citing hostile wildlife as the primary reason, though some also speak fancifully of huge walking trees thwarting their attempts. Whatever their reasons, it is clear that something in the forest is inimical to settlement.

Although today the Baronies are inhabited by fortune seekers from all corners of the Broken Empires, the majority of the population are still descended from the original inhabitants. These people are closely related to the Angevarrans, but possess a distinct culture, and speak a dialect of Low Angevarran that borders on unintelligibility to outsiders.

History

This difference of culture caused a great deal of difficulty for the Angevarran crown after the fall of Vestria, when it occupied these lands and sought to bring them under its control as colonies of the Dominion. The peoples of the Southern Colonies--as they were referred to in Angevarre--chafed under what they considered to be foreign rule. They resisted wherever they were able, culminating in violent insurrections on multiple occasions.

Hoping to increase influence and pacify the locals, the crown began offering land and titles in the region to the second sons and daughters of Angevarran nobles. Thus, "the Baronies" was born. This ploy backfired, however. Though at first the new rulers successfully suppressed dissent, within a couple of generations, the heirs of these newly-minted Barons and Baronesses had almost fully assimilated into the local culture. Rather than create an aristocratic core of loyalists to help control the region, Angevarre had succeeded in bolstering the colonies' ability to resist by giving them strong leaders to organize around. By the time Angevarre experienced its next major crisis--the usurpation of the throne by the undead lich-Queen known as Mother--the Baronies were able to take advantage of the chaos to throw off Angevarran rule with very little effort.

As unwelcome as Angevarran rule had been, the resistance against it had at least provided a unifying element within the region. Once it was removed, the Barons and Baronesses soon began plotting against one another and fighting amongst themselves, often resorting to hiring help from abroad. As foreign mercenaries began to enter the picture, and chaos increased, the rulership of individual baronies began to change hands. At times, several baronies might be consolidated under a single ruler in an attempt at empire-building, but eventually a rough equilibrium would usually break these small kingdoms apart once again.

Marchais Nanconne

The Present Situation

Today, the political situation in the Baronies has not much improved from those early days, and continues with no overriding political structure or universal agreement. Many fiefdoms co-exist, ranging in size from a few small farms with a fortified house to serve as the lord's "manor" to the entire Guille River Valley, united under the self-styled Doge of Marchais. While some of these fiefdoms are still ruled by the descendants of the original Angevarran Barons and Baronesses, many have been captured or carved out over the years by foreign adventurers, mercenaries, and other fortune seekers, often using whatever titles suit them. Thus, you might find a Dvoryan, a Jarl, and a Baron, all ruling areas in proximity to one another. Whatever their title, these rulers contend with each other for land and resources, forming and breaking ever-shifting alliances for advantage and protection.

Though rival lords and treacherous politics claim many lives, there are a multitude of other dangers to trouble unfortunate souls in the Baronies. Angevarran lords whose lands lie along the north banks of the Rivier Lemass maintain a vigilant watch on the border, but are not above sending raiding parties across it when it is to their advantage. In the east of the land, although the volcanic Mount Qarasin lies many leagues across the Grande Eastern Mountains, sudden shifts in wind patterns can bring deadly falls of ash along the western foothills, sometimes giving rise to plagues of Ash Wights. Further to the south, massive saltwater crocodiles have been known to migrate up along the Guille and Carbec waterways from the rivers' swampy delta mouth on the coast of the Sunless Sea. Along the fringes of the Iluneous Forest, travelers speak of wildly aggressive animals and dangerous encounters with mysterious tree-like beings.

No discussion of the perils of the Baronies is complete, however, without mention of the Obsidian Citadel. During the early years in the conquest of the Southern Colonies, a group of Angevarran prospectors became lost in the Harzach Badlands while scouting for ore deposits. In their wandering, they came across a gorge that looked promising, but soon turned deadly. Whatever it was they encountered there wiped out nearly the entire expedition, and when the few survivors made their way back to civilization, their tales so alarmed the authorities that a council was convened to discuss the danger. That the Tical Dondallans--traditional adversaries of Angevarre--were included on the council gives an indication of how serious and far-reaching the threat was considered to be.

The council commissioned a group of Spellweavers from both Angevarre and Tical Dondala to contain the threat. It took over a decade, but they succeeded in constructing a huge obsidian citadel over the gorge, winding it with enchantments preventing both ingress and egress. Both nations agreed to take turns guarding the citadel, watching for any sign of a breach. This arrangement held until the Baronies broke away from Angevarre, at which point the watch on the Obsidian Citadel was abandoned and its purpose almost forgotten.

Over the intervening years, some have attempted to investigate the structure, but have been unable to gain entry. Every expedition reports that the citadel's stone remains cool even in the glaring heat of the badlands summer, and that it has a strange, almost greasy texture. They have also observed the structure crumbling and cracking in places. If it was indeed built to keep something in, it is clear that one day it will no longer be able to do so.

Rumors

Rumor : The Baroness of Dallebrec is adamant that her five-year-old son has been kidnapped by the Dark Fae and replaced by a changeling while on a hunting trip with his father in the Tikia Wood. His father and other hunters swear they never took their eyes off the boy and that the Baroness must be mistaken. If the boy is indeed missing, there is surely a reward for anyone who can find him.

Rumor : Travelers across the badlands have been reporting signs of recent activity around the Obsidian Citadel. They speak of a crack in the ground appearing at the base of the structure, with a heavy mist issuing from it. Those passing by at night also speak of eldritch lights hovering nearby. None who witnessed these things were willing to investigate further.

Drangia

Rural Drangia is a land of barbarian clans vying for survival upon the arid plains that make up most of the country. Though warfare between clans is common, they often come together in peace to trade at many of the permanent markets (Naqiri) that dot the land. The Naqiri are considered sacrosanct, and any violence committed in one is dealt with harshly by the enforcers hired by the local traders.

Though permanent, the Naqiri are not towns. Rather, the buildings give shelter to the ever-shifting population of traders and travelers who come and go. Each Naqiri is named after the dominant commodity of its region, but goods of all sorts will be found there. Hence, you have such examples as Tuz Naqiri (Salt Market), Min Naqiri (Copper Market), and Bal Naqiri (Honey Market).

Over the centuries, the largest and oldest of the Naqiri have evolved into towns and cities. Though the people of these centers disdain their warlike "barbarian" kin of the countryside, they still follow the traditional clan structures. The head of the richest clan is that region's Sultan or Sultana, responsible for collecting taxes, providing common justice, and presiding over inter-clan disputes. The very richest Sultans and Sultanas are granted the title Prince or Princess, respectively.

The mightiest of the Sultans, known as the Great Shaah, rules Drangia from the majestic Kun Palace

--A letter by Prince Zhanbolat to the other Great Lords of Drangia was delivered before he was beheaded for treason weeks

Sunder's Keep

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in Kezdes Orini, the greatest of all Nariqi. The market city specializes in the trading of silks from across the Great Western Ocean to the Sattagoyans, who prize it dearly. Over the centuries, Kezdes Orini has grown into a great city of wide boulevards, shaded courtyards, and bubbling fountains.

Geography

Drangia is a land of open steppes and rugged hill country. After a journey of over three hundred miles, the River Qalidam flows out of the Shroud, through the open plains, and into the vast Sunless Sea, so-called due to its black and murky depths. Some quality of the water does not allow light to penetrate more than a few feet below the surface. Though the Drangians of this region do make a living from the sea, fishing out on the open waters is not for the faint of heart. The depths are home to packs of a particularly large and vicious squid known to the locals as "Red Devils"--named for their deep russet coloration. The red devils are intelligent, hunt in packs, and have been known to swamp fishing boats, attempting to knock the fishermen into the water where they can be preyed upon. The shallows are not any safer, for they are home to massive saltwater crocodiles lurking just under the surface, awaiting the unwary.

The south coast of the Sunless Sea has been retreating for centuries, creating a vast salt flat known as the Alqali Coast. However, salt is not the only thing left behind by the drying sea. Strange coral-like structures rise out of the land--some as tall as a tower. Those brave enough to venture inside the cavernous openings speak of rooms, galleries, archways, and other artifacts that suggest these structures were purpose-built, rather than being some naturally grown phenomena. Who built them and why is just one of the many mysteries remaining hidden in the sea's inky waters.

Further east, the Istam Lowlands give way to the Basilisk Hills, named for the fearsome creatures that roam the uplands and can turn any person who looks upon them to stone. Somehow, the tribal peoples of the Sar'Lor Mountains have found a way to live alongside the basilisks and even tame them. Indeed, it is said that their formidable Na'Shara (literally "eyeless") warriors ride the beasts into battle.

In the far west of the land, upon the Plain of Cinders, and in the shadow of the actively volcanic Mount Qarasin, sits the mysterious and ancient castle known as Sunder's Keep. In recent months, power-hungry tyrants, greedy merchants, loremasters, adventurers, and many others have flocked there to use it as a launching point for their expeditions. They seek to explore the Shroud, which they claim has suddenly become accessible. After more than a thousand years of isolation, they are eager to see what lies within.

History

The people of Drangia have a long memory. Their elders tell of a time when a mysterious group of Spellweavers came to their land. This group conducted long and convoluted rituals under the black skies of the new moon every month for thirteen months.

Barpaq Jer Kezdes Orini Zentarki Qara

As the final ritual was completed, there was a huge upheaval in the land. The sparsely populated northern parts of Drangia, along with the western fringes of Sattagoya and the southern marches of Veiksgrad, were lifted high up out of the ground, forming a massive plateau hundreds of miles across. With sheer cliffs rising over a thousand feet, the plateau was not easy to reach, but those who somehow managed reported being blocked from going further than a few miles inward by a barrier that seemed to be composed of shifting mists. The land that was to become known as the Shroud had been created.

The creation of the Shroud had a disastrous effect on Drangia. The plains surrounding the plateau were shattered into broken and twisted ground for miles, destroying land that had once been filled with productive farms, groves, and vineyards. These lands are now dotted with the ruins of settlements long abandoned, the most noteworthy being the ruined city of Dar Qara, long rumored to be haunted by malevolent forces. Many rivers that had once emptied onto the plains of Koz Nalai simply ceased to exist, turning what was once a lush and fertile part of the country into desert. Today, only the River Qalidam flows out from the Shroud, and while it and its tributaries provide a lifeline for those who live in and around its valley, it does little to feed the dry plains in the rest of the land.

Drangians themselves tend to harbor a superstitious dread of the Shroud and its environs--especially amongst the barbarian clans. Rare is the Drangian who is willing to travel within visual range of the thousand-foot tall cliffs ringing the mysterious land.

The Present Situation

The people of Drangia have never forgotten the dire cost the creation of the Shroud placed upon them. As a result, Spellweavers are reviled in Drangian society. Anyone demonstrating such abilities is viewed with suspicion or driven into exile at best, or simply executed at worst. Many nascent Drangian Spellweavers flee to other lands where their talents will be more welcome.

Of late, there has been great unrest within Drangia. A ragged man named Shal'Umar Ghant arrived out of the depths of the Fanged Desert some time ago. Some call Ghant a madman, some revile him as a cunning opportunist, while others still venerate him as a prophet. For Ghant has come preaching of a new god--or perhaps more accurately, a new face for all the gods--Omnus the One.

Though initially dismissed as a madman, Ghant has been able to display the power of Omnus, and has acquired a large number of converts for his church. These come primarily from the rural clans, but the poor and disaffected of the cities and towns have proven receptive as well. Indeed, some of the more wealthy families have begun to listen to his words. While those who follow him swear that they have witnessed the divine in Ghant's displays, many accuse him of being a powerful rogue Spellweaver, using his abilities to gain wealth and power.

This development has the Sultans and Sultanas worried, for the very social structure of Drangia is what gives them their power. Those who have expressed their concerns to the Great Shaah have been met with silence if they were lucky--with beheadings if they were not. The Great Shaah has invited Ghant to the palace as his guest. The devout of Omnus say that the Great Shaah has become one of them; skeptics say that he has fallen under the sway of a charlatan.

More troubling still are whispers that certain lesser Sultans have stopped forwarding taxes and levies to Kezdes Orini altogether, claiming uncertainty regarding the Great Shaah's judgement. While no lord has yet openly defied the throne, many fear that Drangia now stands balanced upon the edge of open civil war.

Rumors

Rumor : There is a secret society of Spellweavers known as the Quorum of Whispers who operate in the shadows, doing the bidding of the rich and powerful. They exist across all walks of life, and in every corner of Drangian society. Anyone you meet could be a member.

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Dunblaine

Geography

Across the Sea of Maclirr from the Westlands lies Dunblaine, a land steeped in myths and legends, where once giants are said to have walked, and whose current people are nearly as fierce. Dunblaine is situated at the end of a large peninsula, jutting off from a much larger, mysterious land mass to the west. The reason so little is known about what lies to the west is due in part to the Hohenvallan strictures on sea travel in that region, but also due to the Western Wilds--a country of steep mountains, rugged hills, and deep river valleys that makes travel difficult at best.

Dunblaine proper is not without its own ruggedness. The massive mountain range, the Cairnfaeril, dominates the northeast coastal regions, sheltering the rest of the peninsula from the almost constant icy storms that batter the northern shores. Beyond the mountains looms the Iron Veil, its shifting curtain a constant, shining reminder in Dunblaine's cold night skies of the vast power pent up in the Weave that lies just off the coast.

In contrast, the eastern coast is relatively gentle, characterized by long beaches and rolling hills, giving way to the large boreal forests, the Bheithe and the Taen of the interior. Two main waterways flow south out of the Cairnfaeril. The Carywick follows a rugged course north of the Bheithe, its wide mouth providing Carn Taermann with an excellent natural harbor. Meanwhile, the more easterly Eorhainn flows through the Bolg Fiir lands of the Breag and provides them a convenient conduit for trade with the towns of Liscoille and Glasdruin.

The Taen itself is rumored to have once been a major center for the Bolg Fiir's cousins, the Duanan Seethe. Legend tells of an ancient Elven city hidden amongst the maze-like pathways of unknown provenance that meander and shift throughout the timeless woods. Few who have gone seeking it have returned unscathed.

North of the Taen, and the icy Lough Croifuar, the lands become much more rugged, cold, and empty--especially along the foothills of the Cairnfaeril. That is not to say that they are uninhabited. Small settlements can be found here and there, folk living a harsh semi-nomadic life in a difficult land. Fortune-seekers can sometimes be encountered in these lands as well, usually following tales they have heard of a ruined castle in the mountains, the remains of the fortress from which the Spellweavers of old willed the Iron Veil into existence. If such

-- From "The Cold Sands of Caerdun", a song of lament for the fallen at the Battle of Caerdun Innis. Outlawed on pain of death throughout Dunblaine

tales prove true, who can say what treasures--and what horrors--might remain locked within.

To the west, the land also becomes more difficult. The Inn of the Five Hearths upon the River Tor'Lynn, and the small fishing village of Fionmonadh represent the last civilized settlements of notable size before the great frontier of the Western Wildlands.

The people of Dunblaine are open and friendly for the most part, but they are also mercurial. Quick to take offense, but often just as quick to forgive if their honor is satisfied--often by some contest of strength, or merely of fisticuffs. Hospitality is extremely important in Dunblainish culture, and its many elaborate traditions and rules are taken very seriously. Breaking a rule of hospitality is a grave offense that can see the guilty party shunned, exiled, or even executed, depending on the infraction.

Although the growing season is short so far north, agriculture features predominantly in Dunblainish life. Some wheat is grown, though hardy root crops are favored. Herds of cows, sheep, and goats are also raised. Secondary economies include fishing, hunting, and the mining of iron ore, which can be found in abundance in the southern regions of the Cairnfaeril.

The hierarchy of government in Dunblaine is relatively flat. Local Counts and Countesses (Tarn and Tarnain the Dunblainish tongue) are given wide latitude to rule over their territories. All men and women are free folk--the Dunblainish are a hardy and independent people who view the keeping of slaves with disdain. However, poorer folk can, and often do, sell themselves into indentured servitude in order to pay off debts. While it is possible to earn one's way out of such servitude, it is extremely difficult to amass the resources to do so, and the vast majority of such serfs remain so until death. Any children remain in servitude until they come of age, at which point they are considered free, regardless of whether their parent's debt has been paid.

Dunblaine as a whole is ruled over by the Laird in Carn Taermann. When the Laird dies, the title is passed to their eldest child. If there is no child, a complex set of rules determines who the next heir would be. On the rare occasions where more than one candidate can show an equal claim to the title, the Counts and Countesses of the realm must gather to make the choice. These elections can often be contentious and even violent affairs--the most recent being a particularly gruesome example.

History

Eleven years ago, during the Yule season of 1110 GD, the old Laird died of a fever, leaving no heir. In this case, two candidates, both hailing from the island of Caerdun Innis, had claim to the Lairdship. They were Keir Kempoch MacDonn, Count of Donn, and his cousin, Ciaran, lord of Barker Point.

Early in the new year, the Counts and Countesses gathered in council at the great castle of Alcarraig in Carn Taermann to choose between them.

There was no love lost between the two lords, and it was not long before violence broke out between their men. In an event that shocked those assembled, Ciaran accidentally slew MacDonn's daughter, a young woman renowned for her humor and gentle nature. Knowing his cause was lost, Ciaran fled with his retinue back to Barker Point while MacDonn was elected Laird. His first act in his new role was to raise a small army.

Carn Taermann

In his rage, he led his army to Barker Point, where he forced Ciaran to watch as he slew the would-be usurper's entire family, the staff of his keep, and every soldier who served under his banner. Once done, MacDonn put the keep at Barker Point to the torch and ordered Ciaran to be thrown into the sea saying, "Let him be Laird to the crabs."

Though revenge was to be expected, MacDonn's brutality shocked even the most seasoned veterans. It was not long before people began to refer to him as "The Black Laird of Dunblaine". It is not a moniker that MacDonn bears willingly, and it is worth any man or woman's head should they utter it within earshot of his enforcers.

The Present Situation

Though few dare speak openly against MacDonn, resentment has steadily grown amongst several lesser Counts and Countesses who fear the Laird's brutality has dishonored the ancient traditions of Dunblaine. Many accepted the vengeance at Barker Point as justified; far fewer are certain that such violence can remain exceptional.

Incidentally, it was at the battle of Barker Point that a young soldier in the service of MacDonn, named Edbert MacFein gained a reputation for bloodthirstiness, and the nickname "Butcher of Barker Point" for his actions during the fiercest of the fighting. Unable to escape this reputation, Edbert left Dunblaine shortly after these events, hoping to seek his fortunes elsewhere in the Broken Empires.

Rumors

Rumor : Ciaran's youngest son was secreted to safety shortly before Barker Point was stormed. He has recently come of age and is eager to seek revenge upon the Black Laird.

Rumor : Recently, a number of Thessian Spellweavers have been arriving by ship at Carn Taermann. They stay only long enough to purchase a large amount of supplies, as though for a long journey before traveling north into the Cairnfaeril. Some have been asking locals for stories about the mythical ruined castle of the mountains.

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Haedravik

As I try to write this legibly from the heaving deck of the Pride of Varleon, I can see the Hraunsland fade back into the mists that seem to perpetually hang over this region of the Western Ocean. I must confess that, as much as I hunger for new places to explore, and new peoples to encounter, this ship cannot travel away from Haedravik quickly enough for my liking.

This is a rough and jagged land filled with rough and jagged people. Though "filled" is perhaps overselling it. One may wander for days upon the barren hills before coming across any sort of habitation. At which point, one would be wise to ready themselves for a fight rather than hope for any sort of hospitality, for the folk here are mean and suspicious; prone to quick and brutal violence.

The land itself has little to recommend it. Standing upon one of the Hraunsland's black beaches, staring out at the grey ocean, with the clouds lowering above, one could indeed be forgiven for believing themselves to be lost in Devona's fifth hell--a place where all color is said to be leached out of the world; where joy and love are nowhere to be found. I certainly felt a distinct lack of either during my mercifully brief stay in this land.

I urge anyone reading this, to stay as far away as they can. And if you somehow find yourself here, it would be wise to leave as quickly as possible, lest you be sold into thralldom by one of the Jarls, or worse--end up in the cookpots of the Law Speaker.

-- Excerpt from The Environs of the Great Western Ocean: My Travels aboard the Pride of Varleon by noted explorer Lady Olivia de Nanconne

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Geography

By the time the warm, azure waters off Vestria's Rilium Coast travel north with the currents, past Angevarre and the Westlands to kiss the Iron Veil, and then turn back south to flow past Haedravik's jagged shores, they will have turned slate grey, impenetrable, and icy cold. Such words can also be used to describe not only the land itself, but those who people it as well.

Haedravik is an archipelago situated in the Great Western Ocean, roughly equidistant between Dunblaine to the north and Hohenvall to the south. Though there are many islands in the archipelago, the only ones of note are the two largest: Orkaey and the Hraunsland. These islands were formed in some long-forgotten age by volcanic activity, and the volcanoes that form the mountainous spines of the two main islands are sporadically active to this day.

Both main islands are characterized by moss-grown lava fields and black sand beaches along the coasts, giving way to windswept, grassy hills, and finally small central ranges of low volcanic mountains in the interior. In the interior, volcanic fissures and boiling hot natural springs await the unwary, while the jagged coastline and frequent storms make navigating a path along the coast very often treacherous. Steam from underground volcanic activity escapes from the ground at a number of locations through the islands, and numerous hot springs, with temperatures ranging from lukewarm to boiling, dot the countryside. What few trees that haven't been harvested by the locals are small, hardy varieties, twisted and gnarled by the cold hard land.

Wildlife on the islands is of limited variety. Seabirds proliferate in the thousands on the smaller islands, and in difficult to reach areas of the main islands. Small packs of dog-like jackals roam the uplands, primarily hunting the numerous island hares, but are also known to harass the domestic sheep kept by the locals. Finally, many of the beaches on the smaller islands are home to large populations of seals. It is said that among these seals can be found shape-shifting Selkies, who take human form to lure sailors and fishermen into the water, to their doom. Despite their treacherous nature, many folktales tell of Haedravikingur taking Selkies to wed, and indeed, some among the population bear the webbed fingers or toes that are said to be a sign of such a union.

Legends also tell of a monster, known as Eoten, who roams the uplands of Orkaey, hunting for victims. Indeed, a strange, shambling creature has been seen of late, haunting the hills around Bryggholt, while the brutally mangled bodies of several villagers have been found in the vicinity.

History

Haedravik was not settled until shortly after the Iron Veil was raised. Oral histories of the Haedravikingur tell of prisoners aboard a ship, being taken north to exile in the Ironlands. These prisoners revolted and were able to gain control of their vessel. From there, they freed the prisoners aboard several more ships before sailing as best they could back south. Their ship ran aground upon the Hraunsland, where their descendants remain to this day.

Haedravik

What little government that exists is heavily decentralized. Local Jarls rule over territories established when the land was first settled. These Jarls do not meddle much in the lives of the free men and women under their rule, but do act as judges in cases where Low Justice is called for. Any cases that require High Justice--for example, beheading or exile--are presided over by the Speaker of the Law.

The Speaker is chosen every five years by the Jarls from amongst their number at a special Lawmoot. The Speaker must demonstrate their wisdom, and must be able to cite the entire body of Haedravik law--known as the Kodhax--from memory. The Speaker's duties include traveling the islands throughout the year to preside over High Justice cases, investigating serious crimes where a guilty party is not readily apparent, and at every midsummer's Lawmoot, singing the entirety of the Kodhax for any who would listen.

The Speaker of the Law is also a central figure in a very peculiar ritual passed down from the earliest settlers of these islands. In the first few years after Haedravik was settled, a series of earthquakes and eruptions threatened to render the islands uninhabitable. Folklore tells that the Speaker of the Law at the time entered into a pact with the Black Reapers--a local term for the Spinners. Haedravik would be spared if the Speaker would enact an annual ritual. Thus, from that year forward, at the end of every midsummer Lawmoot, a great contest was held amongst the warriors of the land. The least worthy was sacrificed to the Black Reapers, and was ritualistically consumed by the Law Speaker and his guests at a special feast. Today, though the sacrifice is still made, the ritualistic cannibalism has been abandoned, and a prize lamb is served at the feast, though a pretense is still made that it is the sacrificed warrior.

The Present Situation

The population of Haedravik is small and scattered, with most families living in remote farmsteads. Laugovik, the largest town, and home of the Speaker of the Law, boasts about 1500 heads, though this number swells to several times its normal size during the annual Lawmoot. The people of Haedravik largely make a living from raising sheep and goats on the sparse grasses of the uplands as well as hunting the great variety of fish and sea mammals that bless their waters. However, the vast bulk of their wealth comes from raiding the coastlines of surrounding kingdoms.

Every summer, able-bodied men and women from across the islands take to the sea upon the infamous Haedravikingur longships. From these, they terrorize remote Dunblainish, Thessian, and Westlander settlements in search of thralls, gold, and glory. They rarely stray into southern waters, as the combined dangers of the Hoenvaller Weavers Over The Water and the cannons of the Tical Dondallan navy present too great a challenge for even the most threatening longship. Still, several mainland rulers have recently begun discussing the possibility of a coordinated naval response to Haedravikingur raids. Such alliances have been proposed before and always failed, but the increasing boldness of the raiders has caused many to wonder how much longer the southern kingdoms will tolerate them.

Rumors

Rumor : The local Jarl is in the process of arranging a hunt for Eoten, and has put out a call for volunteers to join him. The creature spotted roaming the hills of Orkaey, however, is not actually Eoten. Rather, it is a mad old hermit, clad in a discarded bearskin cloak three sizes too large for him. Far from being able to subdue and brutally mangle able bodied adults, this raises the question: who, or what has been mauling people across the island?

Rumor : It is not lamb on the Speaker of the Law's trencher at the Lawmoot Feast. It is whispered amongst the Jarls as well as the servants that the current Speaker of the Law has revived the ancient pact with the Black Reapers, and along with it, the practice of consuming the ritually sacrificed warrior.

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Hohenvall

From this day, and henceforth: all seas and lands west of Hohenvall's western coast are the exclusive domain of the Thalvorn Trading Guild. While we enjoy peace and prosperous trade with your lands and peoples, we will not tolerate any incursions into our protected regions. Foreign ships are, as always, welcome at designated docks throughout Hohenvall. However, any attempts by foreigners to enter forbidden regions, or to sail past Hohenvall, will be met with deadly force by our Weavers over the Water. This is your only warning.

Peace and prosperous days ahead.

-- From a diplomatic missive sent to the courts of all the great powers in the Broken Empires by the Great Council of Hohenvall, 1119 VI. To date, only one vessel foreign to Hohenvall has sailed into their protected regions and returned.

Geography

Physically, Hohenvall is a stunning island. Tall granite peaks dominate the interior, plunging down into deep, lush valleys carved by azure streams wending their way to the sea. The rolling highlands offer little opportunity for traditional farming, but the Hohen have developed a form of polyculture, carving out terraces for the growing of olives and grapes on the lower slopes, while maintaining large herds of both sheep and goats on the upper.

The idyllic-seeming land is not without its natural dangers, however. The forests are the domain of a form of pygmy brown bear not found on the mainland. What these bears lack in size, they more than make up for in ferocity, leading some scholars to speculate that they are the result of some sorcerous mingling of both bear and badger.

The heights are not without their terror either, for the mountains are home to giant rocs. Though solitary and rare, they often prey on the local herds and the occasional unfortunate shepherd. These giant birds do present an opportunity for the daring or the desperate: the massive eggs are worth

Thalvorn

their weight in silver, and can often be found on the dining tables of the Hohen nobility during high holidays and special occasions.

The Dwarves never built here as they did throughout the rest of the Broken Empires, but the countryside is dotted with the ruins of some mysterious civilization. No one knows who they belonged to or exactly how old they are, but the capital city, Thalvorn, is rumored to have been built on the foundations of one of these ruins.

Much of Hohenvall's wealth comes from trading with lands to the west that are inaccessible from the rest of the Broken Empires. This is partly due to geography. The Sargei Maelstrom makes for a formidable navigational hazard to east/west shipping to the south, while in the north, the Trading Guild's Weavers-over-the-Water use their magics to detect and sink any foreign vessels attempting to make the crossing. Thus, Hohenvall maintains a monopoly on the silks and precious ores obtained from the mysterious West. In fact, so lucrative is the trade with the West, that when this route opened up almost a century ago, the vast amount of gold that flowed into the Broken Empires had a devastating effect on the economies of several countries.

Dovedain Thalvorn Valkengard

History

Hohenvall society has always been rigidly stratified with little mobility between classes. Those occasional peasants or shepherds who manage to improve their circumstance usually accomplish this by joining one of the seagoing merchant ships, hoping to strike it rich, or sometimes simply by escaping to less restrictive lands. Outsiders are generally viewed with suspicion and are only welcome at trading ports unless given special dispensation by the Monarch or one of the Noble Houses. Special dockside guesthouses cater to foreign traders and sailors to prevent them from mingling with Hohenvall citizens.

The land is ruled by a 13-person Great Council made up of six Grafs, representing the Hohenvaller noble families, six Gildenmeisters, representing the Trading Guild, and the King or Queen. Each member of the Great Council has an equal vote on matters of law and decisions of State; however, new laws must be ratified by the King or Queen before coming into effect, giving them de facto veto power.

The Grafs are elected to the Great Council by their peers at an annual Moot, and are expected to represent the interests of the nobility in general. In reality, a great deal of gold, silver, and sometimes livestock trades hands in the form of bribes that greatly influence the Grafs' decisions. The process through which the Trading Guild representatives are chosen is shrouded in secrecy and known only to the upper echelons of the Guild bureaucracy. While these representatives generally serve for life, the tenure of many representatives over the years has been tragically cut short by unfortunate accidents after making decisions unpopular with the Guild.

The Present Situation

While this three-legged system of governing leads to its share of intrigue and backstabbing, it is generally stable. Recently, however, there have been some developments that may pose a danger to this stability. One is simply that new discoveries in the West have been vastly increasing the wealth of the merchant class, which in turn increases the power

of the Trading Guild. Both the King and the Noble Families are acutely aware that the Guild could probably succeed at a coup simply through force of arms if its Gildenmeisters desired it.

The other threat to stability comes from the rise in power and popularity of an ambitious young Lord within the Noble Families. What makes this both unprecedented and dangerous is that he is also somehow a member of the Trading Guild--an organization that does not generally allow the nobility within its ranks. It is theoretically possible that this Lord could acquire a Great Council seat from both the Noble Families and the Trading Guild. Should he achieve this, it would be the first time in Hohenvall's history that so much power was invested in the hands of a single individual, and what he might do with it is a subject of great speculation.

The rise of this controversial figure has already resulted in several violent confrontations between rival retainers in Thalvorn's streets and docksides. While the Great Council officially dismisses rumors of factional conflict as exaggeration, armed guards have become an increasingly common sight around the estates and counting houses of both the Guild and the Noble Families.

Rumors

Rumor : The Trading Guild is a cult, worshipping Devona, which is how the Weavers-over-the-Water get their powers.

Rumor : The capital city, Thalvorn, is built upon the ruins of a much older civilization. If one knows where to look, there are multiple entry points into these ruins from the city's catacombs.

Rumor : Several members of the Great Council have already died under suspicious circumstances in the last two years, though no accusations have been made publicly.

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The Ironlands

The northern landmass called the Ironlands appears on no map of the Broken Empires, for the Ironlands no longer exists within the Broken Empires. Centuries ago, great and mighty rulers from all over the known world convened to deal with their mutual problems of rising banditry, rogue sorcery, heretical teachings, and revolutionary sentiment. It was decided that all of the very worst criminals and ne'er-do-wells would be rounded up and transported to the bitterest north, a continent known as the Ironlands, which would serve as a permanent prison. To ensure there was no possibility of escape, a conclave of Spellweavers erected the Iron Veil, a shimmering barrier whose purpose was to cut off the Ironlands from the rest of the world, sealing the criminals beyond forever.

The raising of the Iron Veil was not without cost, however. In their experimentation with such lofty magics, the Spellweavers caused vast areas east of the Grande Eastern Mountains to effectively vanish into an impenetrable cloud, an area now referred to as the Shroud. It also had other, less obvious effects, the repercussions of which are being dealt with to this very day.

But the Iron Veil did its job--so well, in fact, that the entire landmass making up the Ironlands began to drift from the world. Every year, the Ironlands recedes further and further from the Veil itself, moving towards a wholly unknown fate. There are those who know their way through the few remaining secret corridors between the Ironlands and the Broken Empires, but every year those passages grow harder and harder to find. It is speculated that one day the Ironlands will become truly inaccessible--finally fulfilling the promise of those who banished it in the first place.

PCs from the Ironlands are those who have successfully found their way through the Veil, knowing that it was a one-way trip. Culturally, they are similar to the people of Haedravik and Dunblaine.

Rumors

Rumor : Among the Ironlanders, there is a tale of the "First Hundred"--the very first prisoners sent north--whose descendants still carry an invisible mark placed on them by the Spellweavers. This mark is said to bind them to the Veil's magic, ensuring that even if they cross into the Broken Empires, the Veil will call them back in their final moments. Healers and hedge-witches in the Far North sometimes claim they can see the mark under moonlight, a faint lattice of silver lines beneath the skin.

Rumor : Arcane theorists argue that each year, the Iron Veil demands tribute from the Ironlands in the form of storms, frost, and life itself, stripping the land until nothing remains to sustain it. When that day comes, they say, the Veil will collapse--not because it failed, but because it has eaten its fill.

For further information on the Ironlands, see the Ironsworn RPGby Shawn Tomkin.

-- A Westlander fisherman's prayer

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Mountainholme

Mountainholme is an enormous valley situated between the eastern and western arms of the Grande Eastern Mountain range. It was the heartland of the Dwarven Empire until the Cataclysm struck in -628 GD, which flooded the area with demonic entities who haunt the ruins of the Dwarven civilization to this day. Mountainholme was the starting point of the vast underground tunnel system by which the Dwarves controlled trade with both the Duanan Seethe communities and the fledgling Human kingdoms. That tunnel system, set with regular waypoints along its almost 1,000-mile span, ran under the spine of the Grande Eastern range from the Dwarven capital region in the north, all the way to its terminus just north of the Sunless Sea, in modern-day Drangia. It is said that travel through those endless tunnels was once accomplished along the "ore-way," a strange and long-forgotten method of passage in which travelers became one with the glittering mineral veins running through the stone, borne through the deep places at impossible speed. Today, the tunnels function only as a lair for hobgoblins, demons, and worse horrors hiding down in the darkness.

Mountainholme is barely accessible by modern travelers and avoided by most. The evils still stalking that land are sinister and otherworldly, a scourge even the most learned of Loremasters know very little about. The high Duvokar pass leads from the old Dwarven realm into the western Ussurgan valley of Vieksgrad, but only the most desperate dare to use it. To Mountainholme's west, there is no easy access to either Thessia or the Westlands--a fact residents of both nations are grateful for, as the mountains are the only things separating them from the horrors of what the Dwarves unleashed on the world over 1500 years ago. Mountainholme remains cut off from the world by overland travel; trying to infiltrate it via the old tunnel system would mean somehow finding one of the hidden entrances, then making one's way through miles of dark, ruined tunnels infested with all manner of dangers. There are adventurers who, their heads filled with dreams of finding the lost treasures of the Dwarves among the ruins of Mountainholme, have tried. Few of them have ever returned alive.

Rumors

Rumor : Loremasters of Thessia tell of vaults deep beneath Mountainholme that still burn with the forge-fires lit by the First Smiths. These vaults were said to have been sealed before the Cataclysm, locking away weapons so potent they could shatter kingdoms. The rumour persists that the demons now guard these places not to protect them from intruders, but to keep anyone from unleashing what is trapped inside.

Rumor : Travelers in Vieksgrad speak of a colossal iron gate hidden high in the Duvokar Pass, its surface carved with the names of every clan that fell during the Cataclysm. Locals claim it was forged by the last surviving Dwarves to block the demons' advance, and that each name is not merely engraved, but burned into the metal by the dying touch of its bearer. Those who camp too near say the names whisper in the wind at night, warning travelers to turn back.

A letter from the Thessian ranger, Cadran Blackthorne, in response to a request by His Lordship Baristan Volmer for Blackthorne to lead an expedition to Mountainholme

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Old Vestria

The Grey Wailing awoke slowly at first. Too slowly. By the time it had claimed its first victims, it was too deeply rooted.... Today, all that remains of the mighty Imperica Vestria are a few scattered city-states clinging to the dubious safety of the coast. That, and a few hardy souls, dubbing themselves Grey Rangers who brave the Grey to scavenge artifacts of the past.

-- An excerpt from The Loss of Empire: A History of Vestria from the Republic to the Fall by Master Domingos of San Elethea

Of all the known lands, it is perhaps Vestria that has had the longest-lasting and greatest-reaching legacy. With its imperial roots dating back almost 1700 years, and its origins as a nation lost centuries ago to the mists of time, Vestria has had a massive cultural and political impact on every corner of the Broken Empires. That today it is a largely abandoned realm of a few coastal city states, belies the influence that it once held and strength it once projected across both land and sea.

Geography

Physically, it is a country of large open plains, rolling hills, and lush forests, rising ever eastward toward the foothills and various ranges that are collectively known as the Border Mountains. The largest of these is the massive Terminus Mountain range, which stretches over 800 miles from north to south, with peaks said to be the tallest in the known world. The tops of these mountains daunted even the ancient Vestrians, avid explorers though they were. Legend does tell of one adventurer from the Imperial era who launched an attempt to crest the highest peak, but was forced to turn back, still far from the summit, citing a mysterious inability to breathe as he pushed upwards.

Many deep valleys and canyons fill the miles between the Border Ranges, carved by rivers that become mighty cascades spilling out onto the flats, forming the marshes and lakes, and feeding the forests and fertile plains that make up the interior of the land. It was these waterways that connected trade and communication within Vestria and allowed it to remain a cohesive whole for centuries. It is indeed ironic that at least one of these rivers may today be helping to spread the very doom that claimed the Imperium.

Markronia, City at the Edge of Night

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History

From its very earliest days, the Imperium was ruled by four emperors, called the Tetrarchs. Though this caused instability at times--even open war between Tetrarchs happened upon occasion--Vestria always righted itself, and the Rule of Four was always re-established over the centuries. "The Vestrian Imperium never sleeps" was a saying attributed to the fact that the Tetrarchs maintained a staggered sleep schedule. This was so that at least one was always awake and alert in case of a crisis. The saying was never so apt as during the reign of Tetrarch Colimax Baltrius. Legend tells that, from his early adult years, Baltrius was cursed with an affliction that made sleep impossible. As he slowly descended into a tortured madness, the other three rulers were eventually forced to fight a brutal and costly civil war in order to depose him.

Markronia Odun Verestrium

Even before, but especially during the Imperial Era, Vestrians explored the Broken Empires extensively, establishing colonies closer to home, and trade envoys further afield. It was through these that Vestrian influence and culture spread far and wide, from Dunblaine to Vieksgrad, from Hohenvall to the Red Wastes. Even as far as fabled Onamorru in the utter East, the name Vestria commands attention, and it is rare, no matter where you are, to find someone who cannot speak at least a smattering of the Low Vestrian tongue, even centuries later.

For a civilization that lasted for close to a thousand years, its twilight and fall came relatively quickly. Even today, the agent of the Imperium's destruction is the subject of much mystery and speculation. Despite a vast amount of study and scholarship, ongoing observations, experimentation, and exploration, very little is known about the phenomenon that killed the Imperium: the Grey Wailing. Some scholars believe that the Imperium would have collapsed eventually regardless. Whatever the case, Vestria was not prepared for what was to come.

The very earliest indications of an issue occurred roughly twenty years before the Year of the Great Dread. Rumors began to circulate about troubles in the village of Drusus close to the center of the Tythian Plain. Tales were told of farm animals afflicted with a strange disfiguring disease that made them aggressive and hostile. Not much later, the farmers themselves, along with their families, began to be affected, and attacks on passing travelers escalated. Soldiers who were brought in to deal with the outbreak reported that the farms were covered in a fine coating of grey dust that appeared to be issuing from the tops of strange black spires that dotted the fields. These same spires seemed to be emitting a wailing noise, almost like a living thing. Even more strangely, they told of twisted trees and bushes that also attacked any who came near. Sadly, those same soldiers soon became overcome by the disease as well.

When it became clear that the phenomenon was spreading, the entire region was evacuated. Efforts to use fire to purge the Grey Wailing--as it had begun to be called--failed. Flames that encountered the grey dust simply sputtered and died. Over the next several years, the Grey spread at an alarming rate through the most fertile regions of the Tythian Plain, destroying many square miles of productive lands, and killing many of those too

slow to make their escape. Expeditions sent to investigate found that they could avoid infection by remaining upwind of the black rock spires, which seemed to erupt almost overnight in infected areas. These expeditions also reported that the dust was many feet thick in some regions, and that the twisted plant and animal life became increasingly dangerous the deeper they ventured.

As the pace of the Grey Wailing's advance began to accelerate, the Tetrarchs turned to their Spellweavers for a solution. The Imperium was already strained to the breaking point due to strife, both internal and external, and they could ill-afford to lose their best lands to something they couldn't even define. The Imperial Spellweavers devised a ritual that they believed would halt, and possibly even reverse, the spread of the Grey. As they dispersed to towns and villages around the infection's perimeter, they were joined by three of the Tetrarchs, eager to see their day of triumph over this most mysterious foe. Tetrarch Corvus Salvianis, whose terror of the Grey Wailing knew no bounds, refused to take part and remained in the relative safety of the Zephyr Palace in Odrun.

It is said that, at the moment the ritual was enacted, a great booming cry could be heard clear across the Imperium, from Terminus Arce in the hinterlands of the east to the thriving port city of Verustrium. Whether truth or legend, what is known is that something went very wrong with the attempted Weaving. In moments, the Grey Wailing began to spread at a staggering rate. Only fortunate souls upon the swiftest of horses could outpace it and escape. Even many of those were swallowed as their mounts faltered from fatigue, for the Grey did not stop expanding for many hours. Finally, its explosive increase abated; but by then, the Grey had spread across several hundred miles of Vestrian heartland, claiming tens of thousands of lives--including the three Tetrarchs who had journeyed out to witness what they had believed would be their final victory.

This disaster was the final nail in the coffin of a declining Imperium. Fear of a second expansion of the Grey Wailing gripped the people of Vestria, who abandoned the interior of the land, hoping for safety along the coast. Chaos engulfed what remained of the Imperium as the coastal cities struggled to support the flood of refugees. Violence and disease ran rampant as local authorities were overwhelmed, while a succession crisis for the three unoccupied Tetrarch thrones touched off a short and bloody civil war. By the end of the year--the Year of the Great Dread--Vestria was no longer an Imperium, and the rule of the Tetrarchs had ended.

The Present Situation

Today, Vestria is a cluster of independent city-states and fiefdoms ruled over by Viceroys, descended from the original imperial rulers of these regions. While there is no overarching government in the area, the individual city-states often cooperate and consult with one another on matters of trade and mutual defense. The latter issue has become increasingly important in recent years in the face of Tical Dondallan expansionism.

The Vestrian people, while practical, tend to take a very romanticized view of their illustrious past. Current fashion and architectural styles tend to imitate and exaggerate those of the Imperium's golden age, and if one wishes a taste of Old Vestrian life, one merely needs to wander the crowded markets of Odrun, or take in a gladiatorial contest at the coliseum in Verustrium. The matter of the Grey Wailing is simply not discussed. It is considered the height of poor taste to mention it, and outsiders who do so run the risk of beatings, arrest by authorities, or worse.

The interior of Vestria is a mostly lawless region, still abandoned by all but a few hardy souls, eking out a living in small settlements huddled in the shadows of once-great cities. The lands of the Tythian Plain are now referred to as the Haunted Fiefs, its deserted cities and towns having been left to crumble back into the dust. The largest still-inhabited settlement of note upon the Plain is the Black House Inn, a large self-sufficient enterprise run by a mysterious proprietor. The Inn's main clientele seems to be the Grey Rangers, who make it their business to explore the lands infected by the Grey Wailing for reasons as varied as the Rangers themselves.

The Grey Wailing itself is still expanding, albeit at a much slower rate than it had been prior to the Year of the Great Dread. The intervening millennium has seen its perimeter extend roughly twenty miles outward; however, more troubling is evidence that its infection is being spread downstream along the River Utania. Black spires and grey dust characteristic of the Grey have been found along the river in places almost as far as the coast. Loremasters are divided over which possibility is more concerning: that the Grey might start to spread across the seas to the other nations of the Broken Empires, or that most of those nations dismiss such warnings as the ravings of frightened scholars and doomed wanderers.

Rumors

Rumor : Jacobo Selveris of Markronia (known as the "City At the Edge of Night" for the breathtaking sunsets visible from its western shores) is afflicted with the same disease that robbed Tetrarch Baltrius of his ability to sleep. It is well-known that Selveris claims Baltrius as an ancestor, and of late, he has been exhibiting symptoms that the long-dead Tetrarch had early in his illness.

Rumor : The proprietor of the Black House Inn is none other than Corvus Salvianis, the last Tetrarch of Vestria, cursed with immortality by the gods for his cowardice in the face of his nation's greatest crisis. He established the Inn as a center for scholars to study the Grey Wailing in hopes of one day destroying it.

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The Red Wastes

Geography

Stretching across hundreds of miles in the southeast of the Broken Empires, the Red Wastes is a vast desert region comprising many terrain types from endless flat plains to rearing mountains; from giant ever-shifting sand dunes to serene deep-desert oases. Despite the name, the sands of the Red Wastes run across a spectrum of colors, from the bright, almost blinding white of the flats near the Khabar Mountains, to the unnaturally light-absorbing black of the treacherous Draugland Ghul. It is the land itself, including the very rock of the mountains, that is stained in myriad shades of red.

In the west, the Red Wastes are bounded by the massive Terminus Mountain range. The ancient Vestrians explored across this range, but refused to venture far into what they considered to be an uninhabitable waste. Ironically, the land first encountered by these explorers--the scrublands between the Terminus and Khabar Mountains--are amongst the most welcoming in the Wastes. Although not terribly fertile, the scrub offers plenty of streams, rivers, and lakes, with an abundance of wild game. The Vestrians eventually did establish a fort further to the south, where the mountain passes are easier to navigate. Terminus Arce was built for the express purpose of trading with the caravans that brought goods across the desert from the far east. Today, the fort still stands, the only Vestrian settlement to still exist east of the Grey Wailing. Caravans no longer stop here, preferring other routes far to the north, but the fort continues to subsist on trade with the local tribespeople, as well as providing housing to adventurers who seek the treasures they believe can be found deep in the desert.

It is east of the Red Mountains of Khabar that the Wastes truly begin. The hundreds of miles of desert sands lying between the Khabar and Denareh Mountains are as harsh and unforgiving an environment as any that can be found in the Broken Empires, avoided by all but the foolish, mad, or desperate. Even the most desert-wise of the tribal peoples will not cross here. They have a saying: The paths of death on the Adrur Flats are as numberless as the grains of its sands. Here, the noonday sun is said to be able to literally cook someone in their armor (should they be unwise enough to be wearing any), the

scorpions grow so large that their molted shells can be used for housing, and ifriti--pact-making demons of the deep desert--are said to roam the great emptiness in search of mortal victims.

The flanks of the Denareh Mountains offer little solace for those hoping for a place of safety. On the north end of the great red sandstone range, caves and crumbling ruins provide refuge for thieves, bandits, and outlaws--when they are not already home to even more dangerous creatures. Men and women exiled from their tribes for heinous acts, as well as criminals escaping the rough justice of the Vizier in Ansharir, often make their way here to join groups of their vicious brethren in order to survive.

Further to the south, the Denareh Mountains become even more dangerous for travelers. Along the western flanks, great rents and crevasses have opened into the deep abyssal places of the earth. Not only do these pose hidden falling hazards for those navigating the rough terrain, but they also offer enticing exits to the surface for those unnameable things long trapped in the stygian depths for countless aeons. Besides the crevasses, perhaps the greatest danger of these mountains are the ash fields created by the volcanic Mount Nilah. The ash that spews from the caldera is said to affect the bodies and minds of all who become exposed to it, producing a feral madness as well as a monstrous strength. The lands around the volcano are filled with twisted, ash-covered creatures who relentlessly roam the land in search of prey until they drop from exhaustion.

East of the Denareh mountains lies one of the rarest sights in the Red Wastes: a lush, green valley, winding its way east out of the highlands, carved by the Jewelled River. Water that comes from deep within the underground springs of the mountains brings life to the parched desert sands, especially in the Anshari lowlands, where it overflows its banks and floods the plain every Season of the Ibis, allowing agriculture in the area to thrive and the City of Ansharir to exist (see Ansharir).

Further to the east, the massive dunes of the enigmatic Sea of Shifting Faces pose a significant barrier to anyone traveling north from the safety of Ansharir. It is said that the dunes form the screaming, tortured faces of all those who have vanished while traversing the sands. Whether or not this is just a series of mirages or hallucinations, the effect has driven many wanderers mad. Those seeking to skirt the western dunes must pass between the ancient, demon-haunted ruins that dot the foothills of the Denareh Mountains and the perilous, blasted wasteland left by meteorite impacts that destroyed a civilization in this region ages ago.

The Red Wastes are replete with the ruins of ancient temples, marketplaces, and entire lost cities. It is clear to the scholars who study such things that many civilizations have risen and fallen here over the passing millennia. Many of the ruins appear to be of Human origin, but some evidence hints at a long-extinct race of serpent people--perhaps related to the Lizardfolk of the distant Serpent's Teeth Isles. Many of the ruins appear to be of much greater antiquity than others found elsewhere, which has led scholars to theorize that Humans may have originally entered the Broken Empires through the Red Wastes in some long-forgotten age. There are also tantalizing clues that the Wastes were perhaps once a much more fertile land, and only became a desert as a result of some great calamity.

The Present Situation

Today, the land is sparsely populated by nomadic tribes who survive through the herding of camels and goats, or by acting as guides for the occasional caravan braving the Wastes for the promise of exotic goods. These people live in small bands who roam throughout the seasons, seeking water and grazing land for their animals. Though they are materially poor, they have a rich cultural tradition of hospitality and are reputed to be masters of storytelling and song. They are also peerless navigators, for they use the stars to chart their travels across the desert, avoiding its dangers with skill and precision. Lacking paper, or even reliable sources of papyrus, the tribal peoples of the Red Wastes record the movements of the stars and planets, as well as other important information, by carving runes into the bones of their dead. These rune bones are collected by the tribe's shamans and worn upon their clothing.

The Red Waste nomads rely on more mysterious forms of wisdom as well. The tribes employ wise women, devoted to "reading the sands," who can determine a wealth of information about the area they are in by studying the color and consistency of the local sand. The presence, proximity, and even direction to water, valuable minerals, and dangers of all kinds are said to be deduced by these women through a careful examination of the subtle hues and textures of the sand.

Besides the nomadic tribes, Anshiri citizens, outlaws, and caravans, many other small groups brave the Red Wastes for a variety of reasons. Whether they be mystics in search of ancient wisdom, or historians seeking to prove their theories, many scholars are drawn to the ruins of the region. Often, they will hire adventurers for protection on their expeditions. Adventurers might have their own reasons for visiting the Wastes as well, the search for hidden treasures being the most common, though bounties on bandits or even local monsters might prove to be a draw as well. The Monks of the Petrified Staff can be found eking out a precarious existence in the most remote corners of the desert. These ascetics search the Wastes, seeking fundamental truths about the Universe, which they claim are hidden within the future constellations of the stars.

Finally, there is the Cult of the Ardent Fire, an apocalyptic faith founded by Iblis Zargarian, the so-called "Mad Seer of the Sands." Instigated by then-mortal sorcerer Mot-Zaroth for his own ends, Zargarian's long-ago conquests threatened Drangia, Sattagoya, and even parts of Tical Dondala. By the time of the Seer's defeat, Ansharir was almost destroyed from within, and his name had become a curse upon the tongue of civilized people throughout the Broken Empires. Despite all this, the descendants of his followers still survive and practice his teachings, in the southwest regions of the Red Wastes.

Rumors

Rumor : There is a tower at the center of the Black Sands of Draugland Ghul, which has corrupted the entire region. It is said that if anyone should succeed at destroying the evil at the heart of the tower, the corruption will be purged and the land will become abundant once again.

Rumor : The Monks of the Petrified Staff carve their eponymous weapons from fossilized trees found in a secret grove whose location is known only to them. At the center of this grove is an ancient still-living tree that is the oldest living thing in the Broken Empires. Any who brings an appropriate sacrifice to this tree will be granted a vision of that which they most long for.

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Sattagoya

Geography

Sattagoya is a vast region of mainly flat short-grass prairie known as the Uyangar Steppes. The Steppes stretch over a thousand miles eastward from Sattagoya's western border with Drangia, to the hills and mountains of the far east. The area of the Steppes is so huge and flat that in its deepest regions, it appears as though the world is made entirely of grass, with no mountains or hills visible at all. In such regions, devoid as they are of landmarks, the Sattagoyans have learned the art of navigating by the stars from the denizens of the Red Wastes.

Sattagoya is not entirely Steppe, however. The Glazny and Pyastel Mountains, along with their associated foothills, dominate the north. The rivers and lakes along the south slopes of these mountains make this a lush and fertile region, and it is here that the only permanent Sattagoyan settlements can be found, including the Great Khan's clanhouse at Hasaihan.

To the northwest, a fifty-mile-wide passage, known as Khoridor Pass, runs between the mountains and the thousand-foot cliff face of the Shroud, representing one of the only viable pathways be-

-- A fragment of a much longer epic poem,
translated from Ancient Khannish.
Author unknown

tween Vieksgrad and the rest of the Broken Empires. Despite the extremely difficult terrain, Vieksgradian travelers often choose this route over the others, usually paying a toll to the local Khans at Kurubat and Bunwugei. Despite the potential for profit offered by these travelers, the Sattagoyans have not settled any further up into the Pass than Kurubat, as the terrain in the heart of the pass is too rough and inhospitable.

South of the Pass, the western border of Sattagoya is marked by the shattered plain that surrounds the cliffs of the Shroud, and then further south, by the neighboring nation of Drangia. In the far south of the land, the Sattagoyans avoid the Hills of Erhikhanai, home to the fearsome tribal peoples of the Sar'Lor Mountains, who are said to breed basilisks for use against their enemies. East of the hills, the Khurai Alsdan is a region of desertification that has been slowly consuming the southern areas of the Steppes for decades. Seventy years ago, all land north of the River Qasmeh was grassland, but the Fanged Desert has been encroaching at an alarming rate, causing much internal and external strife for the Sattagoyans.

History

The Sattagoyans themselves are a mainly nomadic people, maintaining a strong horse culture. Horses are extremely important both as a means of transportation on the vast Steppe, but also as a spiritual focus for the Sattagoyans. They see themselves and their horses as mirrors of each other, and as equals upon the land. Such is their reverence for the horse that a tradition of healing these animals was created centuries ago, and the practitioners of this art--the so-called Horse Shamans--are more respected than many a fine warrior. "Horse Shaman" is a bit of a misnomer in that their art is not rooted in the Weave or any sort of divine communion, but in the same practical healing wisdom drawn upon by chirurgeons. Indeed, their skills are so renowned that many nobles from other lands eagerly seek out Sattagoyan Horse Shamans to serve as their household physicians.

The main way of life amongst the Sattagoyans is the raising of cattle, sheep, and goats upon the grasses of the Steppe, though the more stationary clans of the north also practice small-scale agriculture and fishing. Raiding is also a fact of life, as the clans often prey upon each other, as well as outsiders, making off with cattle, food, valuables, and prisoners to be kept as thralls or hostages.

Though they are not overly friendly with the peoples of Drangia, Sattagoyans are often found at the Drangian markets, trading for metals and other goods that are difficult to come by on the Steppes. One luxury good that Sattagoyans are particularly fond of is the silks from the far western lands, which they use decoratively to give their yurts a unique look. They use this as a show of status--the more colorful a yurt is, the higher the status of its owner.

Sattagoya

Much like their Drangian neighbors, Sattagoyans are organized into large clan structures, spread out across the wide Steppes. Each clan is headed by a Khan, usually the strongest warrior, though some Khans have been known to achieve their position through feats of cleverness or other means. The position is not hereditary, and any member of the clan can challenge their Khan at any time. It is important to stress that popularity is also very important to keep the position--the most powerful warrior claiming Khanship will be swiftly ousted by the other clan members if their actions are not generally accepted.

All clans are nominally ruled over by the Great Khan in Hasaihan, but in reality, the Great Khan's political power is very limited. A major reason for this is the clans' constant fighting amongst themselves, so it is very difficult for the Great Khan to achieve any consensus. This is largely a relief to Sattagoya's neighboring lands, for a Great Khan who could unite the clans under their banner would be a power to rival the strongest nations of the Broken Empires.

The Present Situation

A unified Sattagoya is unlikely for more reasons than just the infighting between the clans and the degree to which they are spread out. As vast as they are, the Steppes will only support a limited population. Unlike more fertile regions, a large amount of land is required to support a single family. The past few decades have seen the Fanged Desert spread onto the Steppes, bringing a sharp rise in rogue clans and large groups of dispossessed Sattagoyans encroaching on the holdings of other clans. Fighting amongst the clans has increased, and of late, there have been reports of raids on Vieksgrad travelers through the Khoridor Pass, as well as on some of the smaller Drangian markets. Retaliation by Vieksgrad and Drangia has become inevitable, much to the worry of the wealthier and more established Khans.

To make matters worse, rumors have begun to spread that the desert encroachment on the Khurai Alsdan has been growing at an accelerated rate and that it has claimed more grassland in the last year than in the entire previous decade. Such a growth is unlikely to have a natural cause, and one development in particular has caught the attention of the Great Khan's advisors. News has arrived from Drangia that the Shroud--cut off from the rest of the world for over a thousand years--has suddenly become accessible. Whether the two events are related is unclear, but the Great Khan has offered handsome rewards to those who would brave the dangers and mysteries of the Shroud in order to investigate the matter.

Rumors

Rumor : The Great Khan is not well. It is whispered that he has been frail, and that the events of the last year have been causing him undue stress. Word is that the Khans of several of the more important clans plan to visit Hasaihan, ostensibly to pay respects, but more likely one or more of them plan to challenge the Great Khan for his seat.

Rumor : The attacks on Vieksgrad travelers in the Khoridor Pass are not the work of rogue and disaffected clans from the Khurai Alsdan. Rather, the Khan of Orantai seeks to gain access to the travelers' wealth before they pay their tolls at Kurubat and Bunwugei.

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Serpent's Teeth Isles

Sandros II, by the grace of the Gods, King of Tical Dondala:

To our well-beloved and faithful advisors, the officers of our Admiralty of Salecino, Avidoba, Pelfetta, and San Elethea, and to each one of them in their own right, and to the extent of their powers and jurisdictions, Greetings. We have, for many important reasons, ordered, commissioned, and established the Lord of Agueriz, Gentleman Ordinary of our chamber, our Lieutenant-General, to people and inhabit the lands, shores, and countries of the Serpent's Teeth Islands, and other surrounding areas, and there to establish our authority, and otherwise to there settle and maintain himself in such a way that our subjects will henceforth be able to be received, to frequent, to dwell there, and to trade with the savage inhabitants of the said places as we have most expressly declared in our letters patents sent and delivered for this effect to the said Lord of Agueriz the eighth day of last November in the year nine-hundred-and-ninety-eight since the Great Dread, following the conditions and articles, in consideration of which he is charged with the conduct and execution of this undertaking.

-- From the Charter of the Islands of the Mer de Cristal, granted by Sandros II, King of Tical Dondala, making Ferran, Lord of Agueriz, the first Governor of Stormsworth

Geography

Curving north and west from the tip of Devona's Spine, to within several days' sail of Hohenvall's eastern shores, the great archipelago known as the Serpent's Teeth Islands cuts across a vast swath of the warm, azure waters of the Mer de Cristal. Hundreds of islands form this chain, from the smallest of sandbars to mountainous landmasses seventy miles or more across, supporting a diversity of biomes ranging across windswept dunes, lowland jungle, grassy plains, marshy wetlands, and rugged alpine.

The peoples of the archipelago are as varied as the islands themselves, a result of many successive waves of colonization over the centuries. The original inhabitants are thought to have been the Lizardfolk, who still dot the islands in small, hidden groups. The ruins of their once-great civilization can be found throughout the chain, calling like beacons to curious scholars and greedy treasure seekers alike, for the depth of their lore and the craft of their artisans were eclipsed only by the Dwarves and the Duanan Seethe. These ruins are not without their dangers, however, for the Lizardfolk are said to have left traps for the unwary, and many of the creatures they had once subdued for their own use now run free and feral in the crumbling marketplaces and temples of their former homes.

Stormsworth

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History

Many centuries ago, an influx of barbarous orc clans, displaced by Human expansion on the continent, made their way to the islands on crudely constructed vessels and brought an end to the already declining Lizardfolk civilization. Being true to their nature, however, the orcs soon turned upon each other, and their numbers in the area dwindled due to warfare, disease, and a dearth of suitable resources. Rumors do persist, however, of surviving orc clans still to be found deep in the dense jungles and dank caves of the most remote islands.

When Humans first came to the Islands is unknown. The very earliest Vestrian explorers, sailing out of Markronia in pre-Imperial times, wrote of islands as densely populated as the cities of their homelands, and of veritable fleets of massive canoes engaged in vigorous trade across the entire region. The explorers who returned a generation later did not find nearly such abundance, though there were certainly still tribes of Humans throughout the archipelago. Whether the original explorers had been exaggerating, or some calamity had wiped out large portions of the islanders in the intervening years, is not known.

Whatever the case, the Vestrians established small colonies on several of the larger islands, to act as forward ports in their efforts to trade and explore northward along the coast of the Broken Empires. However, once more suitable colonies in Tical Dondala were founded by the Vestrian Tetrarchs, the island settlements were largely forgotten and became backwaters--largely lawless places where the poor, the desperate, the fugitive, and the ambitious gathered to seek their fortunes in the decaying infrastructure of former imperial glory.

The Present Situation

Over the centuries, a rough balance of power arose, with each settlement governing itself as best fit its needs. Some were ruled by iron-fisted tyrants; some formed councils of elders; others elected their most talented Spellweavers. The governing principles of the individual towns were as varied as the towns themselves. The last hundred years has seen a massive change in the status quo, however, brought on by a confluence of factors, including Hohenvaller discoveries across the Western Ocean, Tical Dondallan expansionism, and the discovery of gunpowder.

Tical Dondala responded to Hohenvall's trade monopoly in the west by seeking to found its own overseas territories. To do so, it began establishing a presence in the Serpent's Teeth Islands much in the same way the Old Vestrians had built their original colonies as steppingstones to the rest of the Broken Empires. Establishing a major harbor and city at Stormsworth under a Governor was to be the first step in a much larger Tical Dondallan empire.

Stormsworth

This did not go as planned, but the discovery of gunpowder--which for arcane reasons can only be produced in the islands--has proven to be almost as lucrative. Thus, the Dondalese have spent their efforts seeking to consolidate their power in the region.

These efforts are not uncontested, however. Many of the local islanders have banded together with recently-arrived fortune seekers to form the League of Free Lords, a loose organization of sailors, sea-dogs, and adventurers, with the common goal of curbing the excesses of the Tical Dondallans. That the League has often resorted to piracy to achieve its aims is not lost on the Governor in Stormsworth, who has outlawed the organization and placed bounties on its leaders.

The League of Free Lords is not the only competition faced by the Tical Dondallans in the islands. Other nations of the Broken Empires have taken note of the riches to be had in the archipelago, and have begun their own colonization efforts. Angevarre, the Vestrian City-States, as well as some of the wealthier coastal Baronies such as Nanconne, have all begun establishing bases in the area, hoping to benefit from both the production of gunpowder and a closer proximity to Hohenvall's exotic goods market.

The result is an environment in which there are multiple competing factions in possession of innovative weaponry, all within a relatively small area in which a great deal of wealth is in transit. Violence, intrigue, and skullduggery have become as commonplace in the islands as sandfleas, and cut across the social order, from the lowliest rum dens of Dengmarsh to the Governor's lavish council chambers. Those seeking to escape these man-made dangers by taking ship to uncharted islands should be wary, however. The Lizardfolk and tribal Humans do not take kindly to interlopers, and the uninhabited islands often harbor even more exotic and deadly dangers.

Rumors

Rumor : Following a recent event in which the flooded catacombs beneath the Governor's Mansion in Stormsworth were breached by unknown parties, an ancient treasure room of unknown origin was discovered. The catacombs are extensive and largely unexplored, and more treasure may lie hidden in the depths. Security around what had once been a hidden dock entrance has been increased to a great degree, but there is a woman in Stormsworth who claims to know another way in.

Rumor : Two days out of Dengmarsh, to the south, there is a small island where Humans and Lizardfolk live together in peace. They guard a cave, within which is a shrine said to be able to heal the condition of Fraying, but only in the most worthy of Spellweavers. Some say that the cure is legitimate, but others warn that the whole setup is a trap laid for unwary Spellweavers, to use them for some sinister purpose.

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The Shroud

In -256 GD, the Vestrian Imperium was beset with internal strife, blamed mostly on the growing numbers of bandits, criminals, and revolutionaries active throughout the lands under imperial control. To counter these dangerous groups, a bold plan was proposed: round up all the undesirables from every corner of the Empire, and ship them off to a remote island location, imprisoning them far from the mainland. This would not only remove the troublesome elements, but also serve as a warning to others of the fate that would befall all such traitors to the Empire.

A suitable site was chosen: the large and distant landmass to the north, known as the Ironlands. However, the Tetrarchs conceived of something quite beyond a conventional prison. They wanted to ensure that whoever was sent to the Ironlands would have no hope of ever returning. To that end, a group of powerful imperial Spellweavers was assembled. Their goal was to find a way to remove the Ironlands from the Tapestry of reality itself, so that after the last prison ships sailed north, a magical curtain would fall behind them, forever cutting the Ironlands off from the rest of the world.

This would require the mightiest ritual magic ever performed, and the risks were great. Before the Spellweavers could bring down the Iron Veil in the north, they needed to test their theories. A small geographical area on the eastern slopes of the Grande Eastern Mountains was picked as the site of the experiment. It contained a few petty frontier fiefs ruled by rebellious lords and bandit groups--nothing the Empire would mind losing in case something went wrong. (And despite the experiment's rather unfortunate results, the test would still be considered a success, as several years later the Iron Veil was in fact erected, barring the Ironlands from the rest of the Broken Empires.)

The initial ritual went as expected, and though it cost the participating Spellweavers dearly, they were able to isolate and remove a small keep from the surrounding countryside, ripping it out of the

Tapestry of reality and banishing it to some unknown place beyond. But at that moment, two things happened at once that would doom the entire surrounding area.

First, one of the participating Spellweavers, in a zealous and power-mad state, altered and enhanced the ritual mid-stream. This caused the Weave to react in an unexpected way, ripping the tear in the Tapestry even wider.

Second, at the very moment the raving mage was expanding the tear in Reality, something on the Other Side noticed, and took an interest.

Was it a demon of the Void? An interfering god? To this day, no one knows for certain, but it seems the combination of one mage's passion with the influence of the Thing On The Outside tore the gap in the Tapestry much wider than intended. The magic spun wildly out of control; what was supposed to be a small rift in space encompassing a single village suddenly expanded into a colossal rent in the Tapestry. It expanded with alarming speed, swallowing up an area several thousand square miles in size. The Spellweavers were only barely able to escape, witnessing the affected landmass being pulled up out of the ground, with high cliff sides appearing around it. The sky roiled overhead, as the Weave strained to repair itself; churning, grey-black clouds manifested over the new plateau, illuminated by near-rhythmic flashes of white lightning, choking off all but the highest mountaintops from sight.

This impenetrable ring of cliff and cloud stood fast for hundreds of years, with neither explanation nor solution. Of the fate that befell the inhabitants of the plateau, subsequently referred to as the Shroud, no one knew: nothing was ever able to get past the blocking mists. Where did all those swallowed-up lands go--if in fact they went anywhere? Was the plateau still within our world? What transpired within the cloaking fog? Was a new portal to some other realm opened within? For generations, the Shroud remained wrapped in mystery... until now. Recently, the roiling clouds atop the plateau suddenly parted, giving observers the first glimpse in centuries of the Shroud's interior. The thousand-foot cliffs still remain, but the obscuring, magical clouds have diminished--and whatever still lies within the Shroud now stands ready to be discovered by any intrepid explorer who has the courage to brave its unknown mysteries.

Many such would-be explorers have congregated at Sunder's Keep in northwestern Drangia (see Drangia, in this chapter). While their motives are many--and their ethics few--all share a desire to discover the lost realms of the Shroud.

Rumors

Rumor : Caravaneers in Drangia speak of an unnatural rhythm to the lightning over the Shroud, claiming the flashes are not random but pulse in measured intervals. Some insist the light is a form of signal, perhaps a warning--or a summons--from whatever now rules within. Scholars of the arcane note that such regularity is more often found in ritual magic than in any natural storm.

Rumor : Miners from the Glazny Mountains claim that, on rare clear mornings, a second, dimmer sun can be seen rising within the clouds of the Shroud. It appears larger than the true sun yet casts no warmth, and vanishes the moment the real sun breaches the horizon. Some say it is not a sun at all, but the open mouth of a portal to another sky.

Meet me by month's end at Sunder's Keep. If we hurry, we can be among the very first inside. If them mages did rip open a portal to Somewhere Else, like them stories say... why, just think of the riches that must be lying around for the taking! We shall be like kings ourselves! Just be certain to outfit yourself with rope and such from Sunder's. They say all it'll take to get inside is a little climb.

From a letter on an adventurer's smashed corpse, found at the base of the Shroud's thousand-foot cliffs

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The Southern Peninsula

History

Since before the rise of Tical Dondala as a naval power, the peoples of the Serpent's Teeth Isles have been aware of a large landmass to the south. Through wisdom passed down from the dawn of time, these lands were forbidden, and it was considered death to venture there.

If the original inhabitants of the Isles were loath to travel to the Southern Lands, the Tical Dondallan invaders were not so cautious. The rising naval empire had long harbored grand ambitions of colonizing faraway lands as a way of competing against the Hohenvallers and their trading monopoly to the west. They saw the Serpent's Teeth Isles as mere steppingstones to the much larger and--they assumed--richer lands to the south.

This turned out to be a fatal error for many would-be conquistadors. The first expedition, under the command of Captain Balbino of Avidoba and sponsored by King Sandro III of Tical Dondala, sailed in the year 1023. At first, all was well. The expedition's ship, the Zephyr, sailed out from Salecino in calm waters and reached Stormsworth with no incident. Less than a week after embarking from Stormsworth, the peaks of the Southern Land's great peninsula were spotted by the ship's lookout. Another day's sailing brought them to a protected cove along the coast, with an inviting-looking beach. The Captain ordered the Zephyr to drop anchor and for a ship's boat to take a dozen crew members ashore for a scouting party.

According to the ship's log, some of the scouting party returned later that day to report that they had found odd not-quite human-looking footprints on the beach, and that some sort of music could faintly be heard, seeming to come from the forested hills of the interior. The crew said that they felt "drawn" to the music. Half the party set off to search for the source, but they had not returned at the appointed time.

The Captain led a large search party ashore. Despite being heavily armed, none from the search party returned to the beach by sunset. In the meantime, the ship's first mate had ordered the swift construction of a fortified encampment on the beach. She remained there with a dozen crew members to await the party's return.

The ship's bosun wrote in the log that strange shifting lights appeared in the approximate location of the encampment that night. The lights seemed to hover in place for a time before moving along the shore at "a pace that could outmatch the swiftest Sattagoyan pony". He wrote that he considered sending a crew to check on the camp, but felt sure that the first mate would have blown the horn if she required any help. He also strongly hinted that the crew would, at that point, likely refuse any order to go ashore.

Though they heard no noise coming from shore that night, the morning sun shone down on an empty beach encampment. With difficulty, the bosun was able to round up a small shore party to

From a message found in a bottle washed up on the shores of The Red Isle

go investigate. He wrote that while there was no sign of the strange footprints they had found the previous day, the encampment looked as though it had been ransacked. Strangely, although everything had been rifled through and much destroyed, it didn't appear as though anything was taken. Of the first mate and the crew, there was no sign.

With a thoroughly unnerved crew to deal with, the bosun ordered the shore party back to the ship. There they waited another three days, hoping for any sign of their missing companions. None ever came. During the days, the beach appeared abandoned by all but the seagulls. The nights were mostly quiet as well, but occasionally hints of a strange, compelling music could be heard drifting across the water.

On the morning of the fourth day, after gathering for a prayer to Morghus to honor their lost companions, the crew weighed anchor and sailed back northwards as swiftly as they could. For a time, the return of the Zephyr and the tales told by its remaining crew touched off a sensation in Tical Dondala. It was widely believed that only a truly magnificent treasure would be so thoroughly guarded, and many adventurers hoped to make their fortune.

More expeditions were sent, and many approaches were taken. Some expeditions attempted to find the same beach that the Zephyr had anchored at, while others attempted landings at various other points along the great peninsula that the Tical Dondallans had begun calling "Devona's Spine". Some Captains brought along Spellweavers, hoping that they could divine the nature of the lights, while others brought Godbound of Morghus, hoping for the sea-god's protection. Some fired volley after volley of their ship's cannon into the woods before disembarking, while some even set the very forest alight. Efforts were even made to leave gifts of appeasement to whatever lurked within the shadowy darkness of the jungle.

The Present Situation

The results have never varied. Anyone venturing more than a few dozen yards into the forest never returns. Sometimes camps set up on the beach are left alone for many nights, but eventually the mystery lights show up, and those in the camps are gone come morning. Crews on ships passing along the coast have occasionally reported seeing humanoid figures in the forest fringes along the beaches, but these have been but fleeting glimpses. Crude temple-like stone structures have also been sighted, but seem to be as elusive as the land's inhabitants: when crews return to the location where one had been reported, invariably they find nothing there.

A final official expedition was ordered by Sandros III in 1035: three warships with a full complement of Tical Dondallan marines, a veteran Spellweaver, and a senior priest of Morghus. It met with the same fate as all the others. Since that time, attempts to pry the land's secrets from the Southern Peninsula have mostly been conducted academically, and from afar.

Theories about Devona's Spine vary widely. One very commonly held belief amongst scholars is that the inhabitants are Elves, and that this is where they fled to when they left the Broken Empires. Others believe that perhaps the Southern Lands are some sort of infernal Fae Realm ruled by creatures out of nightmare. There is even a cult that has arisen in Tical Dondala who believe that the Southern Lands are an earthly paradise where every want is met and every wish granted. They believe that no one has returned out of an unwillingness to leave such a place. The goal of each cult member is to amass enough wealth to pay for passage south. They call themselves "The Southbound."

The reality is that there is very little evidence to support any of these theories, but until the mystery is solved, the Southern Lands are likely to remain inaccessible to the peoples of the Broken Empires.

Rumors

Rumor : The Southbound cult hierarchy is a criminal organization dedicated to taking the wealth of the members as "passage fees" and then getting rid of them somehow--probably in some violent manner--after they have embarked.

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The Westlands

Geography

Sandwiched between Thessia to the north and Angevarre to the south, the Westlands is a large region in the northwest characterized by diverse landscapes such as rough coastal highlands, pastoral farmlands, dense forests, fetid swamps, high mountain passes, and grassy plains. The Westlands is a relatively new nation amongst the Broken Empires, which provides its people a vibrancy and frontier spirit often found lacking elsewhere--qualities that have earned it the attention, and often envy, of the older powers.

Two large forests cut a swath across the Westland plains. In the southeast sits the impenetrable Black Oak Forest, whose eaves are braved by occasional woodsmen, hunters, and charcoal burners, but whose interior remains largely a mystery. Rumors abound of a large lake at the center of the Wood, and of a capricious Druid who makes his home there.

In the northwest lies perilous Goldenheart--the last remaining home of the Duanan Seethe before their disappearance over a millennia ago. Though it is a long age since the footsteps of the Seethie have fallen there, their presence looms large. Ancient ruins and Ancestor Stones provide a temptation for those seeking treasure or wisdom, but the Seethie also left behind hazards--both intentional and otherwise--that can easily prove fatal for the unwary. Few who have ventured further than a few miles under the golden boughs have returned to speak of it.

Between the two great forests is a vast network of marshes known as The Skein, the fringes of which are a favorite of hunters and fishermen. Those seeking to venture deeper would be wise to hire a guide, as the marshes become increasingly difficult to navigate, and dangers from quicksand, venomous snakes, and rumored orc encampments become greater the deeper one travels. Nevertheless, some do seek the deepest part of The Skein, for it is said that very special medicinal plants and herbs grow only there, and no place else within the Broken Empires.

The Skein is fed from the great Woodwater River, which flows out from the Grande Eastern Mountains to the east, and forms a natural border with Thessia to the north. There are many legends and tales told about the Woodwater, but none as enduring as that of the Queen of the River. There is--so the legends tell--some sort of female spirit

who inhabits the River, and who will sometimes help those who find themselves imperiled upon it, but who more often punishes those who would pollute or otherwise disrespect the River. No one who has gone deliberately seeking this Queen has ever found her, but there is no denying that the River and its surrounding valley possess an almost supernatural beauty that takes the breath away of even the most jaded traveler.

The easternmost regions of the Westlands, which run uphill toward the foothills and finally mountains of the Grande Eastern range, are most perilous. This is not due to the land itself-- indeed, this part of the Westlands is characterized by low rolling hills and fertile plains, cut through by the cold, deep waters of Lake Liathmor. The peril of this area comes from the fact that it is the domain of several ever-warring orc tribes who were driven east by the Lords of Keighton following its founding. The people of the Westlands have never quite been able to rid themselves of this scourge. Several campaigns have been waged against them, but the orcs have always returned and multiplied. Today, the people of the Westlands content themselves with protecting their borders and trust that a generous bounty will take care of any wayward orc raiders that find their way further west.

If the Grande Eastern Mountains form the eastern border, their smaller offshoot, the Vargonarre Mountains, make for a much-needed barrier between the Westlands and its southern neighbor, Angevarre. It was these rugged mountains that gave pause to any Angevarran forces in pursuit of the Rebel Lords when they fled to the Westlands, none of the passes being particularly navigable for large armies.

The vast majority of the Westlands' population lives within the rough triangle formed of the lands between the great forests in the north, the Vargonarre Mountains in the south, and the rough coastal highlands to the west. Here, the lands are at their most fertile, and most of the people live simple pastoral lives of farming as well as raising sheep, goats, and cattle. The only large urban center in the region is the city of Keighton, which itself is small when compared to the great cities of the south.

The towns and villages of the Westlands generally see to their own affairs through local councils and Thanes (local lords), though each area's ruler is still a sworn vassal to one of the Great Houses--the Westlands' ruling nobles--whose representatives make up Keighton's governing body, the Council of Seven. The Council presides over cases of High Justice, and is composed of the six District Lords as well as the Lord Mayor of the City. Though the Westlands is technically a kingdom, there has only ever been a single king: Samuel Keighton, known as the First and Last, who ruled for only a few short years. Since that time, the Council of Seven has ruled in the absence of any monarch.

Keighton

History

The reason for this unusual political situation is a matter of history. Just over two centuries ago, the area of the Westlands was much more dangerous. Small farming settlements were islands of stability in a sea of banditry and roving orc bands. While the settlements could usually hold out against smaller attacks, they were isolated from one another and often fell prey to larger groups.

In the midst of this chaos, Samuel Keighton of Keldingham returned home after several years traveling abroad, serving in various mercenary companies. No stranger to combat and tactics, Keighton began training the young men and women of Keldingham to defend their village. His popularity soon saw him elevated to the status of Thane, and he used his new authority to instruct the local masons to construct a stone wall around the village.

The bandit lords and orc chieftains would not abide the growing strength of Keldingham or its new Thane. Each sent increasingly stronger forces against it, but those forces were dashed against the village walls like waves against rocks. Word spread, and at first local, then more distant towns and villages began to send envoys to learn from Samuel's

success. Samuel took the opportunity to form pacts with the other settlements. Armed villagers began to patrol the roads, making trade safer, and allowing these nascent road wardens to intervene if a nearby village was under attack.

Over the next couple of years, the people of the Westlands grew to understand the strength that they could find in unity. The other Thanes gathered and unanimously agreed to elect Samuel to be their king. Samuel reluctantly accepted, realizing the effect refusing would have on the morale of his people. For his coat of arms, he took a stag on a green field, representing the wild places of the Westlands, and a lion on a red field, representing the ferocity of its people.

King Samuel's success in defending the Westlands greatly increased his status and popularity, but it also earned the wrath of the orc tribes. After much internal strife, the creatures united under a single, brutal chieftain known only as Vargmoth, meaning "Blackhands" in the Orcish tongue. They gathered in force at an old Vestrian ring fort on a bluff along the Bramblewash River, and from there began a campaign of terror against the Humans.

The Orcish campaign very nearly succeeded. Over the course of a few months, they managed to overrun Keldingham and push the Westlander forces all the way to the coast. King Samuel and his people chose to make what they thought would be their last stand at the coastal fort at Tulliebrook. They were joined there by a small group of Bolg Fiir scholars who had been traveling through and got caught up in the fighting. As the fighting grew to its fiercest, a small cluster of sails was spotted on the horizon. To the utter surprise of the Westlanders--and consternation of the orcs--four Rebel Lords fleeing the Angevarran Civil War had arrived, along with their households and forces, seeking asylum at what they thought would be a safe harbor. When the lords saw that battle was afoot against the orcs, they deployed their armies outside the walls of the fort, and the orcs, caught between the Angevarrans and the Westlanders, were utterly defeated.

In the aftermath of the battle, the famous Council of Fort Tulliebrook took place. Captured in countless tales, paintings, and tapestries, the council between Samuel, his lieutenants, and the Angevarran Rebel Lords resulted in an agreement that would shape the governance of the Westlands up to the present day. Samuel agreed to grant the Angevarran lords asylum, and to give them lordships and land under his rule. In their turn, the Rebel Lords agreed to swear fealty to the crown of the Westlands and to give up all titles and claims to their Angevarran holdings. In symbolic recognition of this, the lords gave up their Angevarran names and took new Westlander names. In addition, Samuel granted lordships to several of his most loyal lieutenants. Thus the Seven Great noble Houses of the Westlands were born: Houses Mordain,

> ... and though the victorious Westlanders,
> Through spill'd blood and val'rous sacrifice,
> Did smash the orcs and drive them from the field,
> Yet no rest can now be afforded them.
> For lo! the Blackhands still lives, and does flee
> Only to reshape
> His menace
> Into fouler form.
> And Keighton, lordly, given heartened mind,
> And mortar'd soul by the coming of his
> Newfound Angevarran allies, knights all,
> Craves the final blow to make an end of 't.
> But where shall that decisive blow now fall?
>
> An answer to that, dear friends, let our humble players now present: allow our winged words to take flight, and upon them bear thee swiftly to Fort Tulliebrook--to the very chambers of Lord Keighton himself, as he and the Rebel Lords hold now a counsel of war..."
>
> An excerpt from the opening monologue of the play "The Rebel Lords", by famed playwright Wayhlem Catchstaff of Marford

Redwyne, Harrowmont, Rookhaven, Thornefield, Marroway, and Vexley.

With his alliances established, a newly resolved King Samuel began the campaign to retake the Westlands from the orcs. The fighting lasted for over a year, but finally Samuel's forces pushed the orcs back until they were forced to seek refuge in their last redoubt, the ring fort on the Bramblewash River. Still facing a challenging battle ahead, Samuel walked out ahead of his army and stood at the base of the bluff upon which the fort was built. There, he bellowed out a challenge to Vargmoth. The orc chieftain, not known for his restraint, strode out with his army to meet the challenge head-on.

The Battle of Bramblewash Ford was brutal and vicious. In the end, the Westlander forces were victorious, though at a great cost, for in the act of slaying Vargmoth, Samuel was mortally wounded. With the Westlanders falling into despair at the prospect of losing their beloved King, the Bolg Fiir scholars, who had remained with the army since Fort Tulliebrook, offered the slimmest ray of hope. Their legends spoke of a life-giving tree hidden in the deepest parts of the Seethie wood, Goldenheart. Though it be of the greatest peril to themselves, they offered to attempt to bring Samuel there, hoping against hope that it could heal his great wound. Knowing there was no other chance for Samuel, the Seven Lords agreed, and the small party of Bolg Fiir set off, bearing the King upon a bier between them. They were never seen by mortal eyes again, though to this day there are those who hold out hope that the King will one day return.

The Present Situation

With the orcs defeated, the people of the Westlands began the arduous task of rebuilding their homes. The Seven Lords ordered the orc-tainted Vestrian ring fort burned down. Upon its ashes, they constructed a new fortress, which they named Keighton Castle, to honor their fallen king. To maintain the hope of the common people for Samuel's return, they chose not to elect a new king. Rather, they agreed to rule as a council in his name. As the years passed, and Samuel still did not return from Goldenheart, the status quo remained, and the Westlands Council of Seven remains its ruling body to this day.

A small village grew up around Keighton Castle, eventually becoming a town, and then a city. At the foot of the bluff, in the very spot that Samuel stood to shout his challenge up at Vargmoth, no building was allowed. Instead, a large square now sits, with a twenty-foot-tall statue of King Samuel Keighton, facing defiantly upwards, towards the top of the bluff, as he did in life.

Though most Westlanders strive to carve some measure of peace from their rugged and mysterious land, recent events have made that dream harder to realize. Increased orc activity along the frontier has led some lords to demand compulsory military levies from smaller settlements, causing unrest amongst freeholders already burdened by years of poor harvests and rising taxation. Though the descendants of the Rebel Lords remain influential within the Westlands, tensions between them and older Westlander families have steadily worsened

over the generations. Some accuse the descendants of the exiles of attempting to reshape the Westlands into "a second Angevarre." At the same time, quiet fears persist that recent diplomatic impasses with Angevarre spell trouble, and that Queen Elena's recent military expansion is aimed not southward toward the Serpent's Teeth, but northward through the mountain passes into the Westlands themselves. Whether those fears are justified or not, many now believe the long peace between the two nations may soon be coming to an end.

Rumors

Rumor : An ambitious orc chieftain has braved the terrors of Mountainholme and returned with a great prize: an ancient Dwarven weapon of tremendous power. Even now, they mass in their eastern foothills, gathering for a push westward into the heart of the Westlands.

Rumor : Fishermen of the Skein and the people of Aelfwood both have reported increased activity in the fringes of Goldenheart. Some have even sworn that they have spotted Duanan Seethe in the vicinity, though only ever for a few brief moments, and only ever from a distance. It is clear something is happening in the great wood, but what that might be is yet to be determined.

Rumor : Sheep and goats have been disappearing from the outlying fields around Marford. Normal predation by wolves or slumberpedes always takes a few of these animals, but lately, around half of the missing animals reappear after a week or two of being missing. The troubling part is that the returned animals have all been maimed in some way--often missing eyes or other organs--with the wounds expertly stitched, as though by a master chirurgeon.

Rumor : House Vexley is the only Great House without a current seat on the Council of Seven. Eight years ago, Aldous Vexley was forced to abdicate his position of Lord Mayor in disgrace, being quickly replaced by a foreign-born Hohenvaller lord called Manfred of Dovedane. Ever since, the Vexleys have been searching for a way to regain their position on the Council. Now, it is whispered, they have uncovered a very disturbing piece of Manfred's past, which could be the very thing they need to publicly discredit him. Shadowy figures have been seen coming and going at all hours of the night from the Vexley estate, and strange men with foreign accents have taken up service with the House.

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Tical Dondala

Geography

The nation of Tical Dondala, nestled between the Baronies to the north, and Old Vestria to the south, occupies the entirety of the large Ricarian Peninsula, as well as extensive territory inland, where the country is bounded by mountains--the Herrun and Sargasia ranges to the south, and the massive Albancia mountains to the north. In the far east, between the mountain ranges, the land descends into a deep and wide valley, much of which is flooded, forming the treacherous marshes of the mysterious Witchfens.

With the exception of Balbom, which is situated on the high plains of the interior, and the mountain city of Tolender, most of Tical Dondala's population can be found in the coastal regions, or along the nation's few major waterways. Much of the peninsula's interior is dominated by low-lying marshy rainforest, poorly suited for any sort of agriculture, and unable to sustain large settlements. These areas are not wholly uninhabited, however. Descendants of the original peoples of this land live in small tribes throughout the forests, amidst rugged highlands, and especially along the salty marshes at the base of the Tucca Mountains. Though the Tical Dondallans largely consider these peoples to be barbarians, they are happy to engage with them in trade, and relations are generally peaceful.

A message sent to the Great Council of Hohenvall from the Court of Sandros III , King of Tical Dondala, in response to the diplomatic missive warning other nations away from Hohenvall's Protected Regions

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Traditionally, the Tical Dondallan way of life has been based around the growing of fruit, olives, and grapes for wine, as well as extensive fishing along the coast and in the rivers. The more inland regions depend to a greater degree on the herding of sheep and goats, and the raising of pigs. Over the last century, however, a large influx of wealth from increased overseas trade as well as a series of plagues have caused a great deal of economic upheaval. In the countryside, this has resulted in the failure of many farms and vineyards due to prohibitively high labor costs. In the cities, a burgeoning merchant class has begun to exercise the power and privilege that comes with the newfound wealth, much to the consternation of the existing aristocracy.

History

The earliest large settlements in Tical Dondala were founded by the Vestrian Tetrarchs, eager to expand their territories and absorb foreign wealth into the imperial treasuries. Over time, the settlements grew into cities, and a unique Dondalese culture developed out of a marriage of Old Vestrian and local indigenous customs. By the time of the year of the Great Dread--when Vestria ceased to exist as an Imperium--Tical Dondala already functioned as a largely independent nation, with its imperial governor acting as a king in all but name. Once Vestria fell, the sitting governor shrugged off the last vestiges of pretense and declared himself King Edras I, Ruler of Tical Dondala. Edras was able to successfully fight off the feeble attacks by the remaining Vestrian authorities, as well as aggression from opportunistic Angevarran lords, in order to establish a strong and lasting kingdom.

The Present Situation

Today, Tical Dondala remains a monarchy, ruled by a king or queen, supported by a large and complex system of aristocracy. The Crown, as well as all noble titles, are hereditary. However, Tical Dondallan inheritance is based upon Old Vestrian law, which is extraordinarily complicated and allows for a great deal of creative interpretation when it comes to translation. This, coupled with the fact that Tical Dondallans of all social strata tend to have very large families spread across multiple partners, makes for a great deal of chaos when it comes to succession. Even relatively minor families are not immune to the political infighting, backstabbing, and assassinations that seem to accompany any noble title. The recent rise of extremely rich merchant clans into Tical Dondallan society has only exacerbated the problem.

Any hopeful heir to the Tical Dondallan Crown has more than just these relatively mundane--if extremely treacherous--dangers to avoid if they hope to take the throne. There is also a very old tradition, rooted in the earliest days of the nation's colonial past, that each heir apparent must take part in before they may assume power. According to legend, this was a ritual required by the Tetrarchs of the very earliest imperial governors. How or why it came to be is lost to the depths of history.

When the previous monarch dies, and all challenges--legal or otherwise--to the heir's claim have been cleared, the aspiring King or Queen must enter the marshes of the Witchfens alone and seek a being known only as the Old Man of the Swamps. The heir then undergoes a test. Those who pass the mysterious test are given a single Solenaria flower, a plant that blooms only in the deepest part of the

Avidoba Balbom Pelfetta

marsh, as proof of their success. Those who fail simply do not return, beginning anew the choosing of the next heir in line--with all the associated intrigues that that process entails.

The Solenaria flower is not merely proof of a passed test: it is a symbol of the new monarch's reign itself. The flower is kept in a place of honor in the throne room of the Cerulean Palace in Salecino, for all subjects to look upon. As long as the flower is kept alive, the monarch's rule is said to be strong and hale. Once it withers and begins to die, however, public trust in the King or Queen begins to falter. Fortunately for the royal family, some property of the flower allows it to thrive for many years after it has been picked, so rare is the reign that has been sullied by a dying bud. Nevertheless, it is almost certain that the Tical Dondallan monarchs secretly employ Spellweavers on a regular basis to prolong the lives of their regnal flowers.

usable at sea (a restriction the islanders call "Devona's Edict"), gunpowder has enabled the use of shipboard cannons that have changed the nature of naval warfare. TicalDondala has been very vigilant in maintaining a strong control over gunpowder exports to other nations, and only smuggling by the League of Free Lords and other freebooters keeps the Kingdom from being able to exert a complete monopoly.

Not all is going according to plan, however. The Serpent's Teeth Islands were only ever meant to be a steppingstone to new territories, further abroad. Tical Donadala's attempts at establishing such territories have proven fruitless. Explorations of Devona's Spine in the south have met with disaster, as have all the kingdom's attempts to flout the Hohenwallese blockade, in order to explore to the west. The situation has been particularly vexing for the current King, who has been strongly considering launching a war against Hohenwall. Sentiment

Salecino San Elethea Tolender

Even during its days as an imperial colony, Tical Dondala was a strong naval power, a tradition that it has always maintained. Over the last century, however, the Tical Dondala's Royal Navy has grown immensely in both strength and size. This aggressive expansion is a direct response to the Hohenwallese monopoly over the western trade regions, and recent Tical Dondallan monarchs have been actively pursuing the goal of procuring their own territories abroad.

Establishing a major presence in the Serpent's Teeth Islands has been a key part of the Kingdom's efforts at expansion, and business ventures there have proven very profitable. One particular success has been obtaining a steady source of gunpowder, called "Devona's Kiss". Nowhere else in the Broken Empires can this mysterious substance be produced, and though it has the strange property of only being

in the court has long been that the Tical Dondallan naval stockpiles of cannon and gunpowder should be enough to counter the mastery of Hohenwall's Weavers-over-the-Water, and that war with the island nation is inevitable.

And though open war has not yet broken out between Tical Dondala and Angevarre, naval confrontations in the Serpent's Teeth have become increasingly common. Both powers officially blame pirates and privateers for recent attacks upon merchant shipping, though few sailors believe such denials any longer. The rise of Queen Elena has alarmed many within the Dondalese court, particularly amongst admirals and merchant princes who fear Angevarre seeks not merely influence, but outright domination of western trade routes. Calls for naval expansion and military preparedness have grown increasingly common in recent years.

Rumors

Rumor : The Old Man of the Swamps is a hoax. The tradition began as a plot by the Imperial Vestrian Tetrarchs to rid themselves of popular, but politically inconvenient nobles. A coalition of noble families have been using the tradition to control the outcome of the Royal Succession ever since.

Rumor : An alchemist living in the eaves of Basa Ligronas, near Navila, has discovered a method of curing gunpowder that allows it to be fired inland from the ocean. Such flagrant disregard for Devona's Edict is bound to have dire consequences, but if it's true, whoever holds this secret would hold the keys to great power.

Rumor : Officials in several Dondalese ports have grown increasingly frustrated by what they describe as "malicious foreign hysteria" regarding a recent fever affecting a handful of sailors and dockworkers. Though the illness is said to be no worse than any common port sickness, foreign merchants have already begun spreading wild tales comparing it to the ancient Weeping Plague. Some in Tical Dondala fear these rumors are being deliberately encouraged by rival powers seeking to damage Dondalese trade and provoke unrest amongst the population.

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Thessia

The land that is today known as Thessia is, in fact, merely the southern marches of what was once a vast and powerful Thessian Empire. The far north was always cold and forbidding, but the Thessians were able to thrive and spread across the frozen tundra, building up a vibrant and cultured civilization. This was in part thanks to the long traditions of survival in that harsh climate, passed down by their forebears. But it was in greater part due to the ministrations of the Empire's Spellweavers, who were able to coax healthy crops out of even the most frozen of fields while somehow avoiding the worst of the Weave reactions.

That all ended several centuries ago, when the glaciers of the far north began to slowly advance south. At first, only the northern marches were swallowed, but it soon became apparent to the Ruling Council that the very heartland of the Empire was in jeopardy.

They enlisted their storied Spellweavers to halt the Creeping Ice, but to no avail. Despite the efforts of their best and brightest, they failed, and within a century, the Ice had consumed all of Thessia save the distant southern fringes of the Empire. There, the Ice halted, and though what remained of Thessia was allowed a respite, too much had already been lost. The Thessians were never again able to restore even a portion of their former power or glory.

Geography

Today, Thessia is a poor, sparsely populated land. The only towns of notable size shelter in the foothills of the Eastern Mountains, where hunting is good, and the rainfall makes some small-hold agriculture possible in the summer.

There are also some small towns along the coast of the Western Ocean, whose inhabitants make a living on the abundant sea life. However, the proximity of the Iron Veil makes the harvesting of such sea life hazardous, as the Veil tends to shift and stretch without warning; not a few fishing vessels go missing each year--especially during the winter months when the Veil seems to be at its most active.

Between the coast and the towns of the foothills lies the vast stretch of tundra and stunted grasses known as the Plains of Merthynir. During the winter, icy winds whip down the plains from the Creeping Ice to trouble the Westlands to the south, while in the summer, the Plains become an unexpected source of beauty as they bloom with an unimaginable variety of wildflowers. These sparsely-forested, rugged rolling fields are inhabited by nomadic barbarian tribes like the Wyrmgald, who trade with southerners via the waterways of the Skein; and the Hrethlingas, violent raiders who believe in a "burning god" that will consume their enemies.

Carved in ancient Thessian runes
upon a rock found along the road from Cilfrydd to
Maen Hendril

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To the north, the vast glacial feature known to the Thessians as "The Creeping Ice" forms a natural barrier and the northern border of their land. It is clear to anyone who lays eyes on it--even from a distance--that the Ice is no normal glacier. Eldritch lights seem to pulse from deep within, and unnatural groans and shrieks pierce the air, as though the Ice were some living, tormented thing.

Only the mad or the desperate venture onto the Ice. Few return, and those who do speak of unnamable horrors. Beasts that speak with the voices of men, and hurl foul magics from afar; blue flames that spout from the Ice with no warning and burn with a terrible cold; menacing shadows that flit about, even in the intense brightness that comes from the noonday sun in summer.

Some few of those lucky souls who manage to survive the Ice have borne home great treasures--mostly ivory, harvested from the carcasses of the beasts they managed to slay. But some have found treasures even more precious: Threads, pieces of the Weave made manifest through some sort of cataclysmic action. Some scholars speculate that these Threads are leftover byproducts from the raising of the Iron Veil, scattered across the land when it came into being.

Indeed, some Spellweavers in Thessia believe that the Creeping Ice itself was an unintended side effect of the Veil's creation. These Spellweavers have formed a conclave at Cigfrynn Crag, known as the Sons and Daughters of the North. Their purpose is to study the Iron Veil with the goal of one day destroying it, in hopes that this will free the north from the scourge of the Ice altogether. How close they are to this goal is known only to them. However, there are many organizations that believe this action could pose a greater threat to large areas of the Broken Empires, and so work towards trying to thwart the Sons and Daughters of the North.

The Present Situation

Most Thessians try not to concern themselves with the Creeping Ice even while it often looms large and threatening in their hearts. Though they live in a harsh climate, summer brings respite for a few short months, during which Thessians spend as much time as they can out of doors. Hunting, games of sport, and even working outside are favorite pastimes during the long summer days. The long winter nights are generally spent inside by the hearth, preferably with hot beverages, and even more preferably in pleasant company.

There is no central government in Thessia. It is no longer even an Empire in name. Rather, scattered lords--descendants of the original Ruling Council of Spellweavers--keep care of their own lands. Nominally equals, some of these lords enjoy greater wealth and prestige than others. Notably the lords of Din Dyrthas, Maen Hendril, and Cilfrydd, with the lord of Keyll Nor possessing the greatest share of power. These lords seldom concern themselves with events outside of their domains, but may come together in whole or in part, to discuss matters that could affect Thessia as a whole.

Keyll Nor

The lords of Thessia enjoy good relations with the Westlands, engaging in trade with their southern neighbor--importing wine and grains from the south, exporting ores and woolen goods, as well as ivory harvested from sea mammals along the coast. Along the southeast border, there is open hostility with the orc clans. Small-scale skirmishes and raids along the tributaries of the Woodwater are common during the summer months, but usually quiet down once winter takes hold.

To the east, the Thessians are extremely wary of Mountainholme's presence. Though the Dwarves have long since abandoned their ancient homes, there are numerous openings into the underground cities along the western flank of the mountains. A fact that the Thessians regard with a superstitious dread. Much like the Creeping Ice, only the mad or the desperate venture anywhere near the former Dwarven lands.

Rumors

Rumor : In the last few years, the Creeping Ice has begun moving again. Though it started off slow, last year the Ice advanced nearly a mile and a half toward Keyll Nor.

Rumor : The Sons and Daughters of the North have been very active of late. Many have been spotted on the roads to the south, but now they seem to have all gathered at Cigfrynn Crag--an unprecedented event. What could possibly have made them so excited? Or do they fear something?

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Vieksgrad

Vieksgrad presents an interesting case study. Its relative isolation has produced a level of cultural stagnation not seen in many other nations. This has had the effect of preserving a number of ancient Vestrian cultural artefacts that can no longer be found anywhere else--not even in the modern Vestrian City States. In some ways, Vieksgrad is more Vestrian than Vestria. Nowhere is this more apparent than in their system of government...

-- Excerpt from How One Became Legion: A Study of Ancient Vestrian Influence On Our Nations by Viscount Gevalin LaCourte, Royal Library of Dineol

Geography

Vieksgrad is a mysterious land, cut off from the rest of the Broken Empires over a thousand years ago by the unnatural raising of the Shroud. The topography ranges from the perpetually frozen tundra in the north, to the temperate forests in the south. Rugged and unforgiving in the west and southeast, where rocky foothills give way to the Grand Eastern and Glazny Mountain ranges, Vieksgrad is otherwise characterized by rolling hills and large lowland plains with occasional regions of muskeg. The centrally located Khinza Muskeg is the most notable of these.

Two major river systems feed into the often-frozen Leyovesk Bay in the north, providing vital highways for the transportation of goods and people within Viekgrad. In the west, the Deyev, Mulma, and Kamevny Rivers flow out from their tributaries in the Grand Eastern Mountains before merging a hundred miles west of the notorious city of Keminyev. In the east, the Glazny Mountains give birth to the Yakyl and Morska Rivers, which meander northwards some three hundred miles before filling Lake Podolsk basin. The Kaversk River then

flows north from the Lake for several hundred more miles. The city of Melovka, high seat to the Voiyod of Vieksgrad, sits upon the mouth of the Kaversk.

When it isn't frozen over, Leyovesk Bay provides an opportunity for Vieksgradian sailors to reach the wider ocean to the east, opening up trade with Onamorru and other, more distant lands. Some scholars believe that these far-off lands are the very same ones that Hohenvall holds a trade monopoly over in the west. This is mere speculation, however, and since the Bay is usually frozen for much of the year, the opportunity to investigate such claims is limited.

While there are numerous smaller temperate deciduous woodlands throughout the south of Vieksgrad, the north is dominated by two massive forests: the Rozuluk and the Kamezov. Each hides its own secrets.

their skin begins to slough off and they die an agonizing death. This horrific condition is known as "The Melting". Traders upon the Kaversk travel past this region as quickly as possible, and the people of Sjepra, on the other side of the river, believe that it is ill-omened to even speak of the Charred Lands.

The other great northern wood is the mighty Kamezov. A mix of coniferous forest in the north and temperate deciduous in its southern regions, the Kamezov covers a quarter of Vieksgrad itself. Like the Rozuluk, this forest also contains dangerous mysteries, albeit of a different sort. A massive and intricate network of paths winds through the Kamezov. Who laid these paths and why is unknown, but they have existed for as long as the Vieksgradians have lived in these lands. Many of those brave or foolish enough to venture along the paths disappear. Some have returned decades after

Keminyev Melovka Noyakamsk

The great boreal forest known as the Rozuluk Wood occupies most of the lands between the Kaversk and Kamevny River valleys, thinning out along the western edge only when forced to by the stony terrain of the Dubirsk Highlands. Its eastern fringe harbors a deadly mystery. A giant patch, making up the entire eastern end of the wood, is charred black, as if scourged by a massive fire. However, in all the history of Vieksgrad, there has never been a fire here. The woods have simply always been in this state, never recovering. Not one bit of green is visible throughout the area, not even a blade of grass--not that many go looking, for the area is also deadly to any who venture into it. Those unlucky souls who spend more than an hour or two in what are known as the Charred Lands gradually begin to deteriorate. Over the course of days, their bodies betray them, becoming weaker and sicker until

they first set out, looking no older than when they left, and with little or no memory of what befell them in the woods. Naturally, this leads to talk of the woods being a doorway to the Otherworld, into which it is said the Duanan Seethe vanished all those lifetimes ago.

The people of Vieksgrad are a hardy and dour lot. They are a warrior culture, who value strong deeds and quick action. Prone to violence, they are also fiercely loyal and honest to a fault. Rural Vieksgradians tend to gather in large clan holdings (a Dom,led by a Domur/Domura), while in the cities, social structures larger than immediate family are rare. Most settlements are found along the major rivers where Vieksgradians fish, hunt, and engage in small-scale agriculture during the summer months. The rivers offer easy access to the larger markets where they can sell off any surplus, and

Boundary of the Charred Lands

purchase those necessities that they cannot produce for themselves.

Other, smaller industries include lumber harvesting, goat and sheep herding, and some iron mining in the Glazny mountains. There is rumor of gold being present in the northeastern horn of the Grande Eastern Mountains, but the risk of encountering Void Demons from Mountainholme makes the mining of it incredibly dangerous.

History

In times long gone, the Vestrian Imperium had a profound cultural impact upon Vieksgrad. This is reflected in many of the customs of the common folk, who, through their strong oral storytelling tradition, seem to possess unusually specific knowledge about the World That Was; Loremasters believe that--for some unknown reason--much of the history that was lost after the fall of the Imperium survives today in these collected stories.

One of the effects of Vieksgrad's long isolation is that the old imperial influence can still be felt today in many aspects of Vieksgradian daily life, including the government. The ruler of Vieksgrad is known as the *Voiyod*, which is a localized bastardization of the Old Vestrian title of Viceroy. It is a hereditary title, passing to the Voiyod's oldest child.

The Present Situation

The current Voiyod is a brutal lord who is shrouded in dark rumors and mystery, but what is known is his affinity for impaling his enemies on long pikes. In Melovka, at the well in the center of the town square, sits the Voiyod's Chalice, a golden cup of inestimable value. Anyone is free to drink from it--doing so is said to bring long life--but the Voiyod has decreed it may never leave the square. Such is the fear he instills that no one, local or visitor, has ever dared to take this priceless artifact.

Under the Voiyod, there is a rigid hierarchy of nobility, collectively known as the *Dvoryanin*. These nobles range in titles from lowly *Barostavs* (barons) and *Barostavas* (baronesses) all the way up to Grand Dukes and Duchesses (*Volestyr* and *Volestyra*). These nobles are granted stewardship over various regions within Vieksgrad (*Stavory*, or baronies), and the serfs who dwell there (the *Krepostniki*). There are only ever two Volestyr or Volestyra at one time--one rules over the western half of the land (the western *Volestarch*, or Grand Duchy) from their high seat in Keminyev, while the other rules the east from Noyakamsk.

Besides the Dvoryanin and their Krepostniki, there is a large class of free people, known collectively as the *Svobory*, who comprise Vieksgrad's warriors, traders, priests, scholars, artisans, and more. It is this class of Svobors, more so than the noble landowners with their serfs, that drive the country's economy. Over the last couple of generations, this fact has become more apparent, as many free folk--especially merchants--have become richer and more influential than the Dvoryanin, leading to hostility and resentment on both sides of the divide. The result has been a much less stable rule for the current Voiyod, who has been considering sweeping and oppressive new laws to limit the ability of the Svobory to prosper. There are already groups organizing resistance to the Voiyod and his nobles, making the risk of a rebellion very tangible.

To make matters worse, Sattagoyan raiders have lately been targeting Vieksgradian merchants who regularly travel through the gap between the Pyastel Mountains and the cliffs of the Shroud, in hopes of trading at Drangian markets. This has effectively cut off almost all trade between Vieksgrad and the rest of the Broken Empires, prompting enterprising adventurers to seek new routes--a perilous undertaking considering the dangers involved in the few likely candidates.

Any seeking passage through the Grande Eastern Mountains would be forced to travel through the abandoned Dwarven domain of Mountainholme, a region widely known to be demon-haunted. Those hoping to reach the west by traveling north of the mountains would have to navigate the treacherous Frozen Plains of Nakhon, and their path would travel dangerously close to the Creeping Ice before finding haven in Thessia. Finally, anyone attempting to make their way around the Glazny Mountains to the east would find themselves traveling

through territory claimed by Vogara, a Necromancer who took up residence on Lake Yadi a decade ago, and who has been terrorizing the area ever since. Those who enter her domain seldom return to speak of it.

Rumors

Rumor : There may be one more possible route to the rest of the Broken Empires. Rumors have come to Vieksgrad that the lands under the Shroud--long blocked by some mysterious barrier--are once again accessible. If so, one could possibly chart a much more direct course to Drangia. All one would need to do is find a way to reach the top of the thousand-foot plateau, and face whatever unknown dangers await within.

Rozuluk Wood

organizations

the order of the purifying flame

An order made up mostly of Spellweavers, but with some individuals with non-magical talents and abilities as well, this organization has dedicated itself to combating the undead and stamping out the necromantic arts. Its headquarters is located on the west coast of Angevarre. Though now few in number, the members of the Order still wield a significant amount of political power and influence at the court of Angevarre. This, inevitably, has led to attempts by certain members of Queen Elena's court to discredit the Order and strip it of its influence.

The Order of the Purifying Flame was formed over two centuries ago. At the time, Angevarre had fallen victim to its own corruption and had been conquered from within by the mysterious Lich known only as "Mother". A group of Spellweavers defied the Angevarran authorities and laid siege to Mother at Stormhold Keep, the nigh-impregnable fortress from where she ruled and terrorized the land.

The details of Mother's defeat at the hands of these brave individuals are locked away inside the Order's famous archives. However, it is known that they were only partially successful at banishing the evils wrought by the Lich. Those few who survived the attack on Stormhold Keep vowed to continue their work and stamp out the undead that had escaped. Thus, the Order of the Purifying Flame was born. Over time, their mission has expanded beyond dispatching the escaped minions of Mother, to include all manner of undead from all over the Broken Empires. Their most recent leader, the late Cherilyn Spiritbane, was convinced she had found a way to permanently banish all undead from the face of the earth--but she died before this mission could be completed, and whatever plan she had died with her.

There are rumors that some of the evil that the Order failed to destroy lies waiting beneath Stormhold Keep itself. Perhaps this is the reason the Order claimed the Keep as their headquarters--to better guard against this possibility.

There are also rumors that the entire time Mother ruled Angevarre, she was searching desperately for her "son". Who or what this son might be is unknown, but he is often the subject of scary tales told around campfires, or on cold, dark nights inside Angevarran taverns and alehouses.

the grey rangers

Stepping onto The Grey for the first time the thing I was least prepared for was how the ground moves. It heaves slowly, but rhythmically, like the breathing of some great beast. Which is one of the reasons some scholars believe that the entire phenomenon is indeed a living thing--a thought that comforts me not at all. Especially when I stand upon it and feel the movement firsthand.

There is also the dust--that which gives the Grey Wailing its color. Or colors, I should say, for it is like a million different shades of rock dust, coating the land for as far as the eye can see--one inch thick in some places, many feet in others. But as we know, this is not mere dust, but uncountable dead spores given off by the multitude of black rock spires that have thrust up throughout the countryside since the onset of this terrible scourge. Thankfully, the dead spores are mostly harmless as long as you don't let them touch bare skin.

No, it is the living spores that one needs to watch out for. Even as we approached from a distance, I could see clouds of them, puffing out from their black rock chimneys, to disperse on the wind. One must be careful to always remain upwind of the spires. It is also vitally important to be able to distinguish clouds of live spores from mere dead ones being whipped up by the angry winds that perpetually lash these lands. Hard to believe that less than a hundred years ago, these were idyllic vineyards, farms, and pastures.

And finally, one's first experience of The Grey would be incomplete without The Wailing itself. Though I would describe it as more of a tormented moan. It comes and goes upon the wind, rising and falling in volume. Markelos says that it gets louder as you get closer to the center of The Grey. Not that he--or anyone for that matter--has been within a hundred miles of the center. Not and returned, that is. They also say that the spores and dust get darker as you move inwards, and the infected plants and animals become correspondingly more twisted and dangerous. Mayhap I will someday find out for myself.

This day, however, was a simple patrol.

-- Excerpt from the journal of Teodoro of Pelfetta, a Grey Ranger of some renown who disappeared into "The Grey" several years after this entry was made

The name is a bit of a misnomer. For a couple of reasons. First, it is not an organization, per se, but rather a loose collective term used for the individuals and groups who have taken it upon themselves to brave the wastes of The Grey, waiting for a multitude of reasons. Some could range from the simple looting of the abandoned cities and towns that lay within, to a desire for revenge on the thing that killed their family, or perhaps to study that dangerous and twisted land and the animals populating the area. Indeed, some of the more scholarly Rangers hold hopes that by studying just the right aspect of the Grey Wailing, they might find a way to stop, or even stop and reverse it.

The second reason why the name is a misnomer is that Grey Rangers come from many different walks of life. Not all need to be woodsmen or survivalists. Indeed, many spell weavers make up the ranks of the Grey Rangers.

While Grey Rangers might base themselves just about anywhere within the Free Victoria, a favorite base camp seems to be the Black House Inn, a large way station run by a mysterious proprietor, and one of the last remaining properties with ties within the Haunted Fiefs.

Though most commonly talk dismiss tales of the Grey Wailing as exaggerations, drunken fantasies, or apocalyptic cult nonsense, a small number of scholars, spell weavers, and nobles have begun quietly funding Grey Ranger expeditions. Whatever their personal motivations for it, many Rangers indeed find that interest has grown substantially in recent years.

There are persistent rumors that certain plants, minerals, and animals recovered from the Grey possess unusual chemical or magical properties. Officially, such claims are denied by nearly every scholarly institution in the Broken Empire. Unofficially, these materials can fetch astonishing prices amongst private collectors and clandestine buyers.

chapter 20: the setting of the broken empires

a note about the elves

The Elves of the Broken Empires were known as the "Duanan Seethe" (Do-AHN-nan SEETHE), called "Seethie" (SEE-thee) or "Aelfs" (AY-ulfs) by common folk. Now long gone from the world (so it is said), they were a truly mysterious race that held sway over every corner of the lands now known as the Broken Empires. Majestic and distant, angular and inhuman, some scholars suggest that they were related to the otherworldly Fae, who are whispered to steal Human babies in the night for their own dark purposes.

Regardless of such purported supernatural lineage, the ruins of the Seethie's ancient dominion can be found buried in overgrown forests, standing silhouetted on mountain peaks, and hidden in long-forgotten vales. Once upon a time, it is believed they ruled these lands jointly with the Dwarves, making use of their bizarre creations to sculpt the world to their liking. It is said they harnessed the power of the Weave in ways that confound current-day Spellweavers, achieving feats of magic now considered impossible.

Ruined settlements are not the only legacy left behind. From their first arrival in the Broken Empires, the Seethie had constructed large mysterious circles of standing stones. A mystery known only to them, these stone obelisks, arranged in circles, were referred to as "Ancestors". They were borderline conscious, and contained the collected memories of the Duanan Seethe. When a Seethie was about to die, they would perform a strange ritual in which they would transfer their memories into an Ancestor stone, preserving them perfectly. In times of need, the Seethie would consult the Ancestors and draw upon the wisdom and experience of hundreds of generations who came before them.

Sadly, after the Seethie left, the Ancestors weathered and decayed; their memories became muddled and confused over the long centuries. Unbeknownst to the people of the Broken Empires, their lands are dotted with immense intellects, housed in stone, filled with the knowledge of forgotten civilizations--and going slowly mad.

The last of the Seethie passed into the mists of the Otherworld generations ago, leaving behind their bitter and estranged cousins, the Bolg Fiir. Although there are always the occasional frightful rumors of reported "Aelf-sightings" in the far-flung northern outposts of Men, most such stories are dismissed as fanciful. And yet...

chapter 20: the setting of the broken empires

the old vestrian calendar

The current year is 1121 GD, a commonly used term that tracks years from the Great Dread that effectively ended the Vestrian Empire in the south.

The Broken Empires uses a calendar that has 12 months of 30 days each (divided into 3 "tenday" weeks per month) and five additional Feast Days, producing a yearly total of 365 days of 24 hours each.

The 5 Feast Days

- A The Vernal Crossing (Spring Equinox)
- A The Zenith Pyre (Summer Solstice)
- A The Autumn Weighing (Fall equinox)
- A The Long Night (Winter Solstice)
- A Conjunction - A day that falls at various times during each year, when several heavenly bodies intersect with the sun to cause an eclipse (the length and fullness of which varies from year to year). This day is often associated with portends, omens, prophesies, and magical rituals.

Days of the Tenday

Each day has a set of traditionally performed activities associated with that day:

Forgeday	Work, building, crafting
Coinday	Trade, taxes, contracts
Roadday	Travel, messengers depart
Oathday	Courts, vows, official business
Bladeday	War councils, duels, executions
Hearthday	Family, community, meals
Saintsday	Religion, shrines, offerings
Marketday	Festivals, fairs, public life
Quietday	Reflection, mourning, burial
Restday	Universal rest; most labor forbidden

The Months of the Year

The months are named after their associated astrological signs, but are more often referred to by their common name.

#	Month Name	Common Name	Season	Astrological Association
1	Scolopendra (January)	Crawling	Winter	The Centipede
2	Trailborn (February)	Tracking	Winter	The Hound
3	Ouroboran (March)	Turning	Winter	The Serpent of Galinose
4	Scaleborn (April)	Flood	Spring	The Crocodile
5	Axeborn (May)	Cleaving	Spring	Hyundor's Axe
6	Ashborn (June)	Rekindling	Spring	The Phoenix
7	Tideborn (July)	Deeping	Summer	The Leviathan
8	Rootborn (August)	Burden	Summer	The Tree
9	Bladeborn (September)	Cutting	Summer	The Dirk
10	Shipborn (October)	Crossing	Autumn	The Barge of the Damned
11	Shadowborn (November)	Stalking	Autumn	The Hunting Cat
12	Shieldborn (December)	Watch	Autumn	The Guardian

appendix a: mass combat

appendix a: mass combat

These are small-unit mass combat rules I developed many years ago and have used for virtually all of my low fantasy campaigns. They allow the players to control their side's units, even if their characters might not be in a command position (the PCs can influence the battle in various ways, as we shall see). I present the rules here with some modifications to better fit within TBE.

Unit Cards & Facing

A unit is a body of troops--foot, horse, or missile--acting together on the field. Each side should have at least one Commander (with Battle-wise Lore) to direct strategy and one or more Leaders attached to specific units.

A unit's information can fit on a small index card, and that index card can be placed directly on the table to show its position on the battlefield. (The card itself acts as its own rectangular counter, in a nice throwback to the hex-and-chit wargames of old.)

Draw an arrow at the front of the card to indicate the facing of the unit. This determines which direction a unit can attack and helps adjudicate flanking and rear attacks.

For larger-scale battles, a unit can be represented by a bingo chip, cardboard token, paper marker, or anything else, as long as the unit name and facing are both clearly marked. Miniatures can also be used, representing either the entire unit or, if you have the table space, each individual in the unit. Be warned, these abstract rules aren't really optimized for using minis as one-to-one representations of unit individuals, but if you really want to get your war-game on, go for it.

A unit's card lists its key stats:

numbers - The number of individual soldiers in the unit. Each soldier corresponds to a box on the Casualty Bar. The unit card also shows where Morale checks occur, typically at 25%, 50%, and 75% casualties. To simulate larger armies, assume each box represents a larger number of individuals.

melee - A die type representing the unit's ability in hand-to-hand combat. This die is used for both attack and defense.

missile attack - A die type used by units with ranged weapons. If the weapons are one-use (such as thrown spears), they may be used once per battle from one zone away. Reusable missile weapons (bows, crossbows) may fire every round, limited by range.

missile defense - A die type representing armor, shields, and training against ranged fire.

morale - A percentile value representing the unit's discipline and resolve.

move - The number of zones the unit can travel per round, unless engaged in melee.

initiative - A number from 1-10 determining when the unit acts each round and how easily it can withdraw.

casualty bar - A row of boxes representing the individuals in the unit. Each slash (/) is a wound; an × marks a casualty. The first mark always goes in the leftmost empty box, and all marks--be they slashes or ×'s--fill from left to right without gaps.

Die Types

Unit quality runs from d3 (untrained rabble) to 2d12 (legendary or monstrous elites). Here is the full range: d3 , d4 , d6 , d8 , d10 , d12 , 2d6 , 2d8 , 2d10 , 2d12 .

Most human troops fall between d6 and d12. Multi-die values (2d6 and above) represent highly disciplined or exceptionally well-equipped formations whose training smooths out luck.

Modifiers for various tactical situations are applied as flat numbers (for example, d8 + 2). The higher total in an opposed roll inflicts the difference in damage.

A modifier of +1 or -1 is meaningful; +2 or more represents a major advantage.

Zones and Engagement

The battlefield is divided into abstract zones representing terrain features or sections of the field--forests, slopes, walls, open ground, rivers, and so on. Each zone may include descriptors that influence movement or combat: rough ground, marsh, steep slope, shallow water, thick forest.

A unit is engaged when its card is touching any part of an enemy unit card within the same zone. Engaged units cannot move except to Withdraw or Break. To make a melee attack, a unit must be facing the enemy and in contact.

Zones should be large enough to contain several units but small enough to allow movement and flanking. Moving within a zone counts as one zone of movement.

Battle Rounds

Each round represents about one minute of combat. Units act in descending order of Initiative. If two units share the same Initiative, roll a d10; the higher acts first. Initiative order remains constant throughout the battle.

Unit Actions

On its turn, a unit may perform one of the following actions:

A Move : Travel up to its Move value in zones, minus terrain reductions (to a minimum Move of 1 zone). Most terrain reductions are -1 unless noted otherwise. Particularly severe ground (deep mud, steep hills, rubble, etc.) may impose -2 or more. Move reductions are cumulative--add them together to find the total difficulty of the zone. For example, Sloping -1, Marsh -2, Ditches -1, Heavy Forest -2.

A A unit can only move forward in the direction it's facing . It can't move sideways or backward unless it first turns. A small pivot--say up to 45°--is fine as part of a Move to follow the ground or skirt an obstacle. Anything bigger requires a Change Facing action.

A Change Facing : A unit may change facing instead of moving, or while engaged. Doing so may expose it to flank or rear attacks, but the formation reorients toward a new direction, allowing it to move forward that way next round.

A Fire Missiles : Attack an enemy unit within range and line of sight:

- » Spear or javelin 1 zone;
- » Shortbow 2 zones;
- » Crossbow 3 zones;
- » Longbow 4 zones.

A Move and Fire : A unit may move one zone and fire at -1 to its roll.

A Move and Engage : Move up to one zone into engaged contact with an enemy unit and attack in melee.

A Charge : Move directly forward at least one zone, up to full Move, to engage an enemy.

- » If the charge path includes no more than one point of terrain reduction, the attacker gains +2 to its melee roll.
- » Charges cannot pass through or end in zones with two or more points of terrain reductions.

A Withdraw : An engaged unit may attempt to pull back by rolling equal to or less than its Initiative on d10.

- » Success allows movement straight backward up to its Move value while keeping facing.
- » Failure means it remains engaged or may choose to Break and flee.

Melee Attacks

When a unit attacks, both sides roll their Melee dice and apply all currently applicable modifiers . The higher total inflicts damage equal to the difference between the rolls. If the rolls tie, each side takes a single wound (one slash). Melee damage is applied immediately.

A modifier only applies when its condition is active. For example, a unit that charged gains its +2 bonus only for its own attack, not when defending against a counterattack later in the round.

Missile Attacks

A ranged unit rolls its Missile Attack die against the target's Missile Defense. If the attacker's total is higher, the difference is inflicted as damage. If the defender's total is equal to or higher, there is no effect.

A Line of Sight (LOS) : Missile attacks require clear line of sight. Forests, ridges, or other obstacles block LOS. Cover may still exist within line of sight, granting defensive bonuses.

A Cover : Terrain or fortifications provide +1 to +3 to Missile Defense, depending on protection.

A Firing into Melee : When firing into a melee that involves friendly troops, the enemy does not roll Missile Defense, but the resulting damage must be divided as evenly as possible between friend and foe.

Modifiers

The following cumulative bonuses and penalties apply to combat rolls. Add them directly to the die result.

Attack Modifier

Modifier	Bonuses and Penalties
Charge	+2
Flank	+1 (attacking to the side of a unit card)
Rear	+2 (if casualties are inflicted, defender must make a Morale roll)
Outnumbering	+2 (attacking a unit that's already engaged)
High ground	+1
Leader attached	+1
Commander's tactical roll	+1 (if successfully directed this round)
Creative use of terrain or descriptor	+1 to +3 (GM discretion)
Ambush	+2 (first round only)

Outnumbering

A unit is outnumbered when it's attacked from more than one direction by enemy formations that are not themselves engaged with another unit.

Each outnumbering attacking unit gains +2 to all Melee rolls against the defending unit.

Units already engaged with a different enemy unit cannot contribute to an outnumbering bonus--they're too occupied to assist.

One Westlander unit faces two orc units pressing in from the front. Each orc unit rolls with +2 Melee this round, since the Westlanders are outnumbered.

If one of the orc units is engaged by a new Westlander unit, that orc unit no longer contributes to outnumbering the first Westlander unit.

Defense Modifier

Modifier	Bonuses and Penalties
Fortified or behind wall	+1 to +3
Cover vs missiles	+1 to +3
Defensive position	+1 to +3
Broken	cannot defend

Damage and Injuries

When a unit loses an opposed roll, it takes injuries equal to the difference between the two results. Record injuries on the Casualty Bar:

- A single slash (/) marks a wound.
- A second slash in the same box (×) marks a casualty.

Injuries must always be recorded left to right with no gaps. The defender chooses how to allocate new marks, following these rules:

- The first injury always goes in the leftmost empty box.
- Later injuries may either add to an existing box (turning a slash into an ×) or go immediately to the right of the last filled box.
- You cannot skip boxes.

Taking injuries can cause penalties to a unit's Melee and Missile attack rolls and also force Morale rolls (see Morale and Casualty Penalties).

Spreading wounds keeps more soldiers alive but risks morale collapse; concentrating them kills individuals faster but steadies morale.

A unit that loses all boxes is wiped out and removed from the battle.

An uninjured unit takes 5 injuries. The player could mark ///// or ××/ or any other combination, so long as there are no empty boxes between marks.

Stronger Units

Heavy cavalry or monsters have double rows on their Casualty Bars; each individual can suffer two ×'s before being removed. A single slash still counts as a wound for morale purposes.

appendix a: mass combat

Morale & Casualty Penalties

Each unit's Casualty Bar is marked at 1?4 (25% of its individual soldiers), 1?2 (50%), and 3?4 (75%). When the number of boxes marked (slashes or ×'s) meets or exceeds those points, the unit must make a Morale roll on percentile dice. Failure means the unit immediately Breaks and flees.

Casualties at...	Morale Roll with Modifier	Melee & Missile Attack Penalty
25% (1?4)	+20	None
50% (1?2)	+0	-1
75% (3?4)	-20	-2
100%	Destroyed	Destroyed

Broken Units

A broken unit immediately turns away from the enemy and flees at double its Move, moving in as straight a line as possible. It cannot defend against any attacks. Any engaged enemy unit that isn't otherwise engaged gains an immediate free attack. If a broken unit passes through friendly troops, those units must make immediate Morale rolls or also break. A Leader or Commander may attempt to Rally a broken unit later.

Rallying

A Leader attached to a unit may forgo other actions to Rally instead. Use Inspire, Intimidate, or Protocol:

- A To bolster morale: a successful roll grants +1 to the unit's next attack roll (or +2 on 5 or more SLs).
- A To Rally a broken unit: make the same roll at -20. Success ends the unit's broken state at the start of the next round.

An unattached Leader may Rally a broken unit that is one zone away.

Player Characters in Battle

A PC fighting as part of a unit may take individual actions against enemies within that unit's engagement. Resolve the PC's personal combat first; the GM may then grant a +1 or -1 modifier to the unit's next roll depending on the result.

A PC acting as a Leader grants +1 to Melee or Missile rolls and may attempt Rally actions as above.

A Commander may spend their round directing tactics instead of fighting. Roll Battle-wise; on success, grant +1 to one unit's next attack or defense roll, or +10 to a unit's Morale until it breaks. For every 3 SLs, choose an additional unit. A critical failure results in 1 randomly determined friendly unit suffering -1 to its next roll (or -10 if it's a Morale roll).

PCs can also undertake special missions during mass combat--sabotage, assassination, or diversion--which may apply narrative modifiers to specific units or objectives. That is up to the GM to develop.

Spellweavers in Battle

Spellweaving during mass combat is abstracted into three possible battlefield effects: Assault, Protect, or Manipulate.

Each effect uses a Bind + Strand combination appropriate to intent and can result in a Lesser, Moderate, or Greater effect.

Magnitude, spell shaping, and Threads are abstracted into these rules.

1. Declare the effect based on its Bind + Strand.
   - » Assault - Harm an enemy unit within one zone.
   - » Protect - Bolster or shield a friendly unit within one zone.
   - » Manipulate - Alter the battlefield terrain or conditions within a zone.

2. Roll the Bind skill:
   - » 1-3 SL: Lesser effect
   - » 4-6 SL: Moderate effect
   - » 7+ SL: Greater effect
   - » On failure, lose 1 Resolve. On a critical failure, lose 1 Resolve and roll immediately on the Weave Reaction Table.

3. Spend Resolve to Suppress Weave Reaction:

   Each spell effect has a Resolve cost to suppress a Weave Reaction:
   - » Lesser: 3 Resolve
   - » Moderate: 5 Resolve
   - » Greater: 10 Resolve

   If the caster pays less than the required amount, they must roll on the Weave Reaction Table with a +1 modifier for every point of Resolve unpaid.

   A Moderate effect requires 5 Resolve; if the caster only pays 3, he rolls 1d20+2 on the Weave Reaction Table.

4. Apply the effect: A Spellweaver may have only one battlefield effect active at a time. Creating a new Assault / Protect / Manipulate effect immediately ends the previous one.

Effect Table

Assault: Inflicts damage directly on an enemy unit	Lesser	Inflicts 1d4 injuries
	Moderate	Inflicts 1d8 injuries
	Greater	Inflicts 2d6 injuries
Protect: Bolsters a friendly unit	Lesser	+2 to next Defense roll or +10 Morale
	Moderate	+3 to next Defense roll or +15 Morale, or remove 1 slash (not ×'s)
	Greater	+4 to Defense for 2 rounds or +20 Morale for 2 rounds, or remove 1d3 slashes (not ×'s)
Manipulate: Alters the battlefield within a zone in a way that imposes tactical consequences	Lesser	For 1 round, the affected zone becomes unstable or obscured. All attacks, defenses, and missile shots made into, out of, or within the zone suffer -1
	Moderate	For 2 rounds, the affected zone becomes Difficult Terrain: - Movement through the zone is at -1 Move - Charges cannot be declared into or through the zone - Units withdrawing through the zone suffer -2 to their Initiative check
	Greater	For the rest of the battle, the affected zone becomes a hazardous, magically twisted battlefield feature: - Movement through the zone is at -2 Move - Charges cannot be declared into or through the zone - Units withdrawing through the zone suffer -2 to their Initiative check

example units

Westlander Knights (foot)

Numbers	20 (5/10/15)	Morale	65
Melee	d10	Move	2
MissileAttack	-	Initiative	5
MissileDefense	d8		

25%	50%	75%
	-1	-2

Angevarran Mounted Knights

Numbers	10 (3/5/8)	Morale	75
Melee	d12	Move	4
MissileAttack	-	Initiative	7
MissileDefense	d10		

25%	50%	75%
	-1	-2

Tical Dondallan Archers (foot)

Numbers	20 (5/10/15)	Morale	50
Melee	d4	Move	3
MissileAttack	d10	Initiative	6
MissileDefense	d6		

25%	50%	75%
	-1	-2

Orc Warriors (foot)

Numbers	30 (8/15/23)	Morale	50
Melee	d8	Move	2
MissileAttack	d6 Spear	Initiative	5
MissileDefense	d6		

25%	50%	75%
	-1	-2

appendix b: naval combat

appendix b: naval combat

The following is a set of house rules I developed for the Dominion Rules RPG, which I used in Season 3 of the main show on "Me, Myself and Die!". I have converted them to be used with The Broken Empires RPG

Naval combat is a heavily abstracted mini-war game that is all about maneuvering and relative position. While the charactersmay not be in command of a ship, the playersshould be. They will be the ones to make strategic decisions about how to maneuver and manage their battle resources.

A naval round represents several minutes of maneuvering and exchange.

Each ship should be represented on the table by a ship mini or some other object, as this helps visualize relative position. Use trackers between each ship to represent relative distance, referred to here as abstracted "cable lengths".

ship skills

Every ship has three skills: Maneuvering (the ship's speed and agility), Crew (the fighting strength of the sailors in boarding actions), and Weapon (the accuracy of the ship's arsenal, whether cannon, arrows, ballistae, or other artillery). These skill values can all be degraded when taking damage.

A ship also has a Hull value. It is a "skill", but it is never rolled; it simply represents the integral structure of the ship and any armor it might have. If the Hull value is reduced to zero, the ship sinks or is otherwise destroyed.

An individual character's Resolve cannot be spent on ship skill rolls.

Starting Range

At the beginning of a naval engagement, either choose or roll 2d10 and consult the following table to determine the starting distance between the ships:

Starting Range Table

2d10	Starting Range
2	4 cable lengths
3-6	6 cable lengths
7-14	8 cable lengths
15-19	10 cable lengths
20	12 cable lengths

The GM may modify this result depending on weather, visibility, surprise, pursuit, coastline, or other circumstances.

Maneuvering

At the beginning of every naval round, each ship selects a target enemy ship and declares its intended strategy, in any order. A ship can try to either:

- A Change Distance between itself and the target, sacrificing the chance to fire, or
- A Vie for Firing Position , giving up the chance to meaningfully change the distance, but allowing the ship to try to line up a shot against the target.

All ships then make simultaneous opposed Maneuvering rolls. Each ship's Maneuvering skill can be supported by its captain's Sail/Boat skill. The winning ship alone gets to perform its declared action.

- A If Changing Distance, the winning ship moves up to its DoS either toward or away from the target ship. Adjust the tracker between them.

- If Vying for Firing Position, the winner gets an opportunity to make a Weapon skill roll to shoot at the target ship (see Firing). If the Vying ship wins the Maneuvering roll with a DoS of 5+, they have "Crossed the T" (the broadside batteries perfectly line up to potentially rake the enemy ship from stern to bow), and the Weapon roll will be at +20. If the Maneuvering roll succeeds by 8+ DoS, the Weapon roll will be at +40.

If both parties fail, neither ship gains an advantage, and the situation remains unchanged.

After three mutually failed rolls in a row, roll for a random event (see Chapter 19 - Solo Roleplaying in the Broken Empires:Event Randomizer Table), and have something interesting change up the status quo: a fog descends, the winds shift, the sea grows violent, the ships drift toward hidden reefs, a sea creature appears, a sudden gust grants one vessel the weather gauge, a traitor sabotages one of the vessels, etc.

Multiple Enemies

When several ships are involved in combat, only one captain can gain the decisive advantage.

When three or more ships are involved, all ships still declare a single target ship and roll Maneuvering as normal. Only the ship with the highest successful result acts.

- If the winning ship declared Change Distance, it changes the distance between it and its declared target by up to its DoS vs that ship.
- If it declared Vie for Firing Position, it may fire on its declared target ship, as long as the target is in firing range.

Other distances remain unchanged unless the GM decides the fiction clearly demands a minor adjustment.

Three ships are circling each other amidst heavy seas. The pirate barque Black Gull declares that it is attempting to Change Distance away from the Hohenvaller man-of-war Crown of Iron , whilst the Crown of Iron declares that it is Vying for Firing Position against the Black Gull . Meanwhile, the Serpent's Teeth sloop Widow's Wake declares that it is attempting to Change Distance toward the Black Gull in hopes of joining the fight.

All three ships roll their Maneuvering skills. The Black Gull gets 5 SLs, the Crown of Iron gets 2 SLs, and the Widow's Wake gets 3 SLs. The Black Gull has the highest successful result and therefore gets to perform its declared action. Since the Black Gull declared its maneuver against the Crown of Iron , it calculates its DoS against the Crown of Iron 's result, winning by 3 DoS. The Black Gull may therefore increase the distance between itself and the Crown of Iron by up to 3 cable lengths. The Crown of Iron and the Widow's Wake do not get to perform their declared actions this round.

Pushing

Before making a Maneuver roll, a captain may decide to push either the crew or the ship itself. Take between +5 and +30 to this round's Maneuver, but degrade one of your ship's three skills by an equal amount (overhauling the lines, pushing the crew to exhaustion, expending too much ammo, etc.).

Chases

In a chase, there is the pursuer and the pursued. If the pursuing ship closes to within 1 cable length, the pursuer has successfully closed to boarding position and may grapple and board the enemy ship (see below). If the fleeing ship puts 15 cable lengths between herself and her pursuer, the fleeing ship has escaped and leaves the battle.

appendix b: naval combat

Forts

A coastal fort cannot Change Distance, only Vie for Firing Position (as the coastal batteries try to line up a shot against the moving ship).

Firing

Rolling successfully on Vie for Firing Position gives you the opportunity to fire one ship's weapon at your declared target, as long as it is within range (in cable lengths) of that weapon. Because cannons are so new to the seas of the Broken Empires, many ships will still use archers or ballistae/catapults/trebuchets. Some may have a combination of cannons, archers, or artillery. Only one type of weapon may be fired per round.

Roll your ship's Weapon skill. If you succeed, multiply the SLs by the weapon's damage multiplier. Inflict this much damage on one of the target's skills, determined by your Weapon roll's ones die:

Firing Table

SL	Firing Position
1-2	Maneuvering*
3-4	Crew
5-6	Weapon
7-9	Hull
0	Shooter's choice

*If firing on a fort, treat results of 1-2 as Hull.

Weapons Table

Weapons	Range
Cannons	Range 10, dmg ×5 SL
Trebuchets	Range 8, dmg ×3 SL
Catapults	Range 7, dmg ×4 SL
Ballistae	Range 6, dmg ×2 SL (×3 SL vs Crew or Maneuvering)
Arrows	Range 3, dmg ×1 SL (×2 SL vs Crew)

Effects of Damage

- When a ship's Maneuvering skill is reduced to zero, the ship's sails are rent and tattered, her rudder is in splinters, or she is otherwise dead in the water, unable to move.
- The Crew skill being reduced to zero renders the ship defenseless to boarding attempts, as her sailors have suffered too many casualties to mount an effective resistance.
- If the Weapon skill has been reduced to zero, the ship's cannon magazine compartments have exploded, its stores of arrows or artillery ammunition have been spent or lost, or too many gunners/archers have been killed. In any case, the ship is unable to fire.
- If the Hull is reduced to zero, the ship quickly starts to sink.

Unlike normal skill rolls, there is no minimum 5% chance to succeed on a skill that has been reduced to 0.

Cannon Malfunctions

Cannons are a new development in the Broken Empires, and are unpredictably dangerous. If you roll a critical failure on your Weapon roll when firing cannons, magazines explode, causing damage to crew, ship, or weaponry.

Make a d10 roll:

Cannon Malfunctions Table

d10	Malfunctions
1-3	Reduce your ship's Maneuvering skill by 5
4-6	Reduce your ship's Crew score by 5
7-9	Reduce your ship's Weapon by 5
0	Reduce all three of your ship's skills by 5

Boarding

As soon as a ship moves to within 1 cable length of another vessel, the crew may immediately grapple and board it.

Both ships make opposed rolls of their Crew skills. Successful rolls deal DoS ×5 to the opposing ship's Crew stat. If a ship's Crew is reduced to zero, they are defeated and likely killed. Surrendering before the death spiral renders you ineffective is often a wise choice.

Boarding continues until one crew is defeated or retreats.

Feel free to use the standard Combat rules to resolve any fighting between PCs and the enemies. The PCs' actions can also affect their crew's subsequent Crew roll. For example, if they immediately move to kill the enemy captain and succeed, then the PCs' Crew might get a +20 bonus on their next opposed roll. As a rule of thumb, assume 3 standard Combat rounds pass between each opposed Crew roll during a boarding action.

Retreat from Boarding

If the hand-to-hand battle is going poorly, the attackers can attempt to retreat to their ship by making an opposed Crew roll at -10. If they win, they remove themselves to their vessel, throw off the grappling lines, and move their ship to 1 cable length away. If they lose, they suffer damage as above.

Making Repairs

When making repairs at a friendly port, choose one ship skill to be repaired up to 5 per day.

- Repairs of Maneuvering, Weapon, or Hull skills cost 100 sp per point restored.
- Restoring Crew is a matter of hiring more sailors, which, depending on the port, is around 50 sp per point restored (or the PCs can make a new shared goal to press new sailors into service!).

When in the wild, the crew may make emergency repairs.

- The ship must first find a safe harbor with plenty of wood available to be harvested.
- Each day the crew devotes to repairing the ship restores 1 to either Maneuvering or Hull (only these skills can be restored in the wild). If the leader of the repair crew makes an Intimidate, Sail/Boat, Craft: Practical, or appropriate -wise roll (Carpentry-wise, Shipwright-wise, etc.), every 2 SLs increases one day's worth of repairs by 1 point, to a maximum restoration of 5 per day.

A Tical Dondallan Galleon has taken damage to its Maneuvering skill (max 50, now down to 15) and finds a quiet cove to hide in whilst it makes emergency repairs using the thick jungle on the island. Every day, the crew restores 1 to the Maneuvering skill. On the first day, the repair leader spurs the men into action by making an Intimidate roll, getting 5 SLs. This increases that day's repair by 2, for a total repair of +3. The galleon's Maneuvering skill goes from 15 to 18.

appendix b: naval combat

ship examples

Tical Dondallan Galleon

Maneuvering 50 Weapon 75 (Cannons)
Crew 65 Hull 80

Tical Dondallan Navy Brigantine

Maneuvering 60 Ex2 Weapon 65 (Cannons)
Crew 60 Hull 65

Pirate Barque

Maneuvering 60 Weapon 55 (Cannons)
Crew 50 Hull 60

Serpent's Teeth Sloop

Maneuvering 70 Weapon 30 (Arrows)
Crew 30 Hull 35

Angevarran Pirate Hunter Frigate

Maneuvering 60 Ex3 Weapon 65 (Catapults)
Crew 60 Hull 70

Haedravik Longship

Maneuvering 80 Weapon 50 (Arrows)
Crew 70 Ex3 Hull 25*

*can be repaired in the wild to full

Hohenvaller Man-of-war

Maneuvering 50 Weapon 85 Ex3 (Cannons)
Crew 80 Hull 80

Cannons and Gunpowder

In the Broken Empires, the gunpowder that makes the navies of the Great Powers so threatening is known as "Devona's Kiss". It is said to be her gift to mankind--but one granted under unusual terms. The cannons that use it only function when fired at sea, or near enough as to make no difference--working just as well aboard a ship as on a coastal fortress, but failing utterly the moment they are fired inland. As the sailors say, the Sea Queen only lets her toys be played with in her own yard.

"The Edict", as this restriction is known, is also the reason that no gunpowder weapons such as muskets or flintlock pistols exist in the Broken Empires. It's not a matter of science or technology: despite the efforts of craftsmen and Loremasters alike, gunpowder cannot be made to function in anything other than cannons--and only in those fired within the confines of Devona's salty realm.

The Angevarran folk tale "Ignace's Place" illustrates the fickle nature of Devona's Kiss:

The children of Chergard always asked Hector Dumont about the rusted-out old cannon sitting out in the middle of his wheat field so far from the sea. When he became tired of spinning elaborate tales about it, he finally gave in and told them about old Ignace, the farmer who worked the land before him. Back in Ignace's day, bandits were a much more commonplace problem in this corner of Angevarre, before the new Duke cleared them out. Old Ignace fell victim to them one too many times and swore that they would not rob him again. They laughed at him as they left his lands, laden down with armloads of his crop and what valuables he apparently had left. As soon as they were gone, he dug up the silver he had been hoarding, got his oxen and wagon out of the barn, and set off. When people asked where he was headed, he simply said, "The sea," but wouldn't say why.

Upon his return, word traveled quickly, and the people of Chergard marveled at his new acquisition: a brand-new cannon, purchased from a merchant ship captain for all the silver Ignace had left. He left it sitting in his wheat field, determined to use it against the bandits the next time he saw their cloud of dust heading up the road to his farm. Alas, as he was pocketing Ignace's silver, the merchant captain had failed to mention Devona's Kiss: the mysterious spark that only allows cannons to fire while in Devona's realm--the sea. The next time the bandits paid old Ignace a visit, they laughed even harder at him, as he struggled to light the fuse, frustratedly kicking and cursing at the unfired cannon. In the end, it was too much for the old farmer. He once more packed up his remaining belongings and set off in his cart, never to be seen in those parts again.

When he finished the story, the children asked Hector why he left the cannon just sitting there. Why not haul it off, or even sell it for the scrap iron? "Because," he told them, "it is a good reminder that everything has its place".

appendix c: personality traits

In the core rules, Personality Traits are simple descriptors that help the player envision their character's general outlook and attitude, and may grant a small bonus or XP reward. At the request of several backers, I have included my original Personality Trait rules as an option, which provide more mechanical guidance: Personality Traits as Opposing Pairs . These optional rules, if used, replace the Personality Traits rules in Chapter 7 - Character Creation.

Personality Traits as Opposing Pairs

Personality Traits act as a snapshot of the character's overall demeanor and address how likely they are to behave a certain way in any given circumstance. They're a roleplaying tool to help a player behave according to the character's personality instead of the player's.

Personality traits are presented in opposing pairs. There is a score between them, from 10-90. If you want to know how a given character reacts in a certain situation, roll a d100. If you roll that number or less , the character acts according to the Trait on the left ; if you roll over the number , the character acts according to the Trait on the right .

If you roll a critical result, the trait immediately changes 1d4 points in favor of that trait. A critical roll equal to or under the number increases the score by 1d4; a critical roll over the number decreases the score by 1d4.

> Fane Rezada has Cautious 40/Fearless (Roll 40 or less and act carefully, 41+ act recklessly). If he rolls a 22, he then rolls 3 on a d4. The score becomes 43, meaning he is more likely to be Cautious in the future. If he had rolled 77 and a 3 on the d4, it would become 37, increasing his likely fearlessness for the next time.

When your character's personality shifts and develops like this, make a note of it, and give yourself +1 XP roll at the end of the session. You can only gain the bonus +1 XP once per session, regardless of how many traits shift in that session.

Once per session, per Trait pair, if you choose to roll the Trait and agree to be bound by its outcome, you may take a +20 on a skill roll that is relevant to the immediate situation. You must justify its use, and the GM, as always, has final say.

Assign the starting value of each of your Trait pairings as you wish. Starting scores should start between 30 and 70. Alternatively, roll (1d6×10)+20 for each, producing results of 30-80. At no time can any personality trait go over 90 or under 10. While not every NPC has specified Personality Traits, a target's traits can also be generally considered when making Social rolls against them.

> Having been captured and imprisoned by raiders, Arn is trying to rile up his lone guard in order to provoke him into opening the cell door. He knows by their previous actions that the raiders are full of hubris, so he makes an Intimidate roll. The GM decides that this guard is in fact sufficiently Proud, and awards Arn a +10 circumstance bonus: Arn starts belittling and demeaning the guard's parentage, suggesting he's not man enough to come inside and fight him one-on-one, and rolls Intimidate with a +10.

Personality Traits Table

Trait	Description
Altruistic/ Self-serving	Focused on others or focused on yourself. The choice between such things as forgiveness and vengeance, generosity and selfishness, or charity and greed.
Measured/ Passionate	Deals with the difference between calmness and volatility, rationality and emotion.
Cautious/ Fearless	Includes bravery vs cowardice, deliberateness vs spontaneity, care vs recklessness, etc.
Friendly/ Callous	Reacting in a favorable, approachable way as opposed to a cold, unkind way.
Honest/ Deceitful	Telling the truth (or not) to others or yourself. The choice of following laws or duties (could also be Compliant/Defiant).
Humble/ Proud	Graciousness vs hubris. Choosing whether to boast or to keep quiet.
Curious/ Indifferent	Choosing whether to investigate a mystery or not. Questioning the world around you or barely caring.
Trusting/ Suspicious	Assuming a better nature from others, or expecting the worst.
Hopeful/ Pessimistic	Looking on the bright side and having a sense of optimism about current events, or trending towards cynicism and despair.
Compliant/ Defiant	Following the rules vs not being bound by authority. Duty vs freedom.

Consider how your character's Personality Traits might apply in the following example situations:

- A I am being offered a bribe.
- A I realize I am being manipulated.
- A I am faced with a matter of life or death.
- A I've detected that I'm being lied to.
- A The hopes/fates of innocents are being placed in my hands.
- A I'm being asked to do something that goes against a fundamental belief or principle.
- A I'm facing two, or more, "bad" choices and have to pick one.
- A I've been stripped of (or lost) a skill, rank, or power that defined me. Do I hide it or lean into it?
- A The tide of battle has changed (for good or bad). How do I react?
- A My orders have been disregarded or disobeyed. How do I react?
- A How will I react to an unexpected Weave Reaction?
- A I am being accused of something I didn't do.
- A I am being publicly humiliated or insulted.
- A I am being taunted, bullied, or goaded.

appendix d: name tables

human names

Angevarre (Angevarran)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Albrisse	Alarine	Beaumont	26	Delcour	Courcelle	Desmarais
02	Alcelin	Alionne	Belcourt	27	Dorelmont	Courvielle	Desmarchais
03	Alcendre	Alisande	Bellemont	28	Dorvain	Delisse	Desroches
04	Alveric	Alverette	Bellerive	29	Eremand	Delisseine	Devalcourt
05	Balmeric	Audeline	Belmontaine	30	Estion	Derrette	Deveraine
06	Baultier	Aurine	Belville	31	Fainceur	Doucelle	Dufontaine
07	Beauclain	Aurivelle	Boisfer	32	Farelmont	Elorine	Dufresne
08	Bertoul	Beleine	Boisvert	33	Faubert	Eresanne	Duvalette
09	Brenard	Beletine	Boncoeur	34	Faubric	Esmerine	Duvalier
10	Brenoux	Berenelle	Bonlac	35	Florentel	Evalaine	Duvalmont
11	Brevinard	Briandelle	Boulain	36	Fortame	Evelaire	Duvernois
12	Calvain	Brionelle	Chalevoie	37	Garanne	Evralisse	Fauremont
13	Celmar	Brivaine	Charvenne	38	Garceval	Falarine	Fauville
14	Chalmeau	Carvienne	Chaumont	39	Geridain	Faubrette	Fauvrelle
15	Charnois	Celoraine	Chavalier	40	Gerond	Faulisse	Ferrandelle
16	Charveaux	Celrisse	Chavigny	41	Gerrand	Fenorine	Ferremont
17	Chauvain	Chantaine	Clairmond	42	Gevalin	Ferlaine	Ferrevoux
18	Cherveaux	Charlette	Clairvaux	43	Gilvain	Flaubelle	Fontenois
19	Chrespin	Charvienne	Clerisseau	44	Grenvel	Florisse	Forecelle
20	Clarvion	Chavelle	Courbetin	45	Guilmar	Gelisette	Forvel
21	Clemontine	Cherlaine	Courtemanche	46	Guissard	Gervelle	Garenne
22	Courcel	Chevrisse	Daubenton	47	Halbart	Gevrine	Jardinier
23	Courdane	Chirelle	Dechant	48	Halrion	Gillette	Jourdaine
24	Darvelle	Clarielle	Defermont	49	Harvigne	Giselanne	Lacourte
25	Daumard	Corisande	Delafleur	50	Helouin	Helisanne	Laforet

Angevarre (Angevarran)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Herbinel	Helouise	Laforte
52	Herlad	Hulienne	Lavalle
53	Hulon	Isendre	Lavandelle
54	Iscelin	Jiselle	Lavarne
55	Isembart	Joliette	Lavoisine
56	Joret	Jorvienne	Lavoissier
57	Jorvel	Laiselle	Lejardin
58	Joubertin	Linelle	Lestrange
59	Jourdain	Lisandre	Levraux
60	Leomand	Lisselle	Malreaux
61	Lisbert	Lorienne	Marbois
62	Lorand	Malarine	Marchandier
63	Lourel	Marceleine	Marechal
64	Louvain	Marchelle	Marleaux
65	Malion	Marcienne	Marquant
66	Maroche	Margeline	Martelot
67	Marvion	Marivelle	Mervant
68	Mauverin	Maurine	Montagne
69	Montelain	Melisande	Montargis
70	Morvin	Melouise	Montclair
71	Nelmont	Mirenne	Monteillet
72	Nerival	Morianne	Montelard
73	Olrion	Neuville	Monteloire
74	Paltrin	Orivelle	Montreve
75	Pelrion	Orlisse	Montvert
76	Perrique	Palrette	Pelrieux
77	Philain	Paulisse	Pradeau
78	Quentrel	Pelvienne	Prevois
79	Radain	Perrelle	Remorant
80	Raimen	Quirisse	Rivelle
81	Raynard	Quirline	Rochefort
82	Renardel	Remelisse	Rochelieu
83	Roiselle	Renise	Rosmare
84	Rouvenel	Rillette	Roussain
85	Salien	Rosilene	Tisseur
86	Savineux	Rousette	Valbonne
87	Savrel	Savelle	Valcourt
88	Talbert	Savienne	Valcroix
89	Telmar	Seralette	Vallencourt
90	Theolais	Talisse	Vallon
91	Thibour	Thavienne	Valrenard
92	Turbeau	Theolisse	Vanneaux
93	Valcair	Triselle	Varcellon
94	Valcer	Valaine	Varenne
95	Vaubert	Valrene	Vaubourg
96	Vaubreux	Vanelisse	Vaubreton
97	Vautrin	Vaurette	Vaucourt
98	Vilcourt	Vaurice	Vaudrille
99	Villette	Violenne	Verlaine
100	Viltran	Vioraine	Verrande

appendix d: name tables

human names

Ansharir (Anshari/Ellaric)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Amarekh	Ankhema	Ankhesa	26	Kasam	Khuremet	Nahrekem
02	Amkhan	Ankhenet	Ankhrem	27	Kaseth	Khureset	Nakhotep
03	Amunkhet	Ankheset	Arenset	28	Kemnah	Khurima	Paremsek
04	Ankhan	Ankhetmah	Bahremet	29	Khafrem	Menaret	Pasetrek
05	Ankhset	Ankhranet	Besaret	30	Khamrek	Meneshnah	Penthot
06	Ankhura	Besetnah	Besnah	31	Khennek	Menetrek	Pentremet
07	Anksen	Haretmeh	Djerhot	32	Khenru	Menharet	Rekamur
08	Ankure	Henaret	Djesur	33	Khepran	Meniret	Rekheset
09	Asarut	Henetmeh	Hetrem	34	Kheprem	Mereremet	Remeset
10	Besam	Henetnah	Horet	35	Khepren	Meretnah	Remnah
11	Besket	Hentaret	Hotsek	36	Kheprenah	Merkamet	Rethor
12	Besrem	Hentrek	Kamset	37	Khomare	Merkaset	Retnemet
13	Hamen	Hentrinet	Kamuret	38	Khorsek	Minareh	Samaret
14	Hatnuh	Hotaret	Karemnah	39	Khuare	Minsaret	Saremrek
15	Hatnuk	Hotekma	Kasremet	40	Khurek	Minseth	Sarhotep
16	Hatrem	Hothret	Khasebet	41	Khuseb	Naharet	Sephemet
17	Henreh	Hotrenet	Khenuret	42	Manket	Nahkaret	Sepmuh
18	Henrek	Huthure	Khurema	43	Mankhem	Nahkemet	Setarem
19	Henrem	Kasetmah	Mahetrek	44	Mehren	Nahkenet	Setkarem
20	Henteh	Kasetmeh	Maremnah	45	Menhat	Nahkhet	Setnah
21	Hotru	Kasinah	Menkhot	46	Menkhat	Nahremet	Sihetrem
22	Hotsek	Kasrenet	Menremet	47	Merkes	Nahreteh	Sihotrek
23	Hureb	Kharema	Meretnah	48	Minhotep	Nahsetra	Tahremet
24	Huretet	Kharene	Mertuseh	49	Nahkem	Nahteret	Tahsetrek
25	Hutrek	Khartemet	Nahkaret	50	Nahset	Neferet	Taremsek

Ansharir (Anshari/Ellaric)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Nahseth	Nefkaret	Tarhetrem
52	Nahurek	Nefreka	Tarhot
53	Nakhem	Pansaret	Tetrekem
54	Nakrek	Pasaret	Thesur
55	Nakset	Pasetmeh	Thetkarem
56	Narekh	Pasirah	Thihotep
57	Neferhot	Pasrene	Thotremet
58	Pankhet	Pasretmeh	Thutarek
59	Panshet	Pentareh	Tihuret
60	Pasem	Pentareh	Tumarek
61	Pashet	Pentekmeh	Tumaremnah
62	Pasnek	Penteset	Tumaret
63	Penhet	Penteth	Tumaretneh
64	Pentrek	Pentetmeh	Tumaretrem
65	Pentrekh	Pentrekh	Tumaretsek
66	Pentu	Rekarem	Tumaretset
67	Pentuh	Rekarem	Tumhesneh
68	Rahetep	Rekaset	Tumhesur
69	Ramahur	Rekhamet	Tumhetrem
70	Rekanem	Rekhat	Tumhotnem
71	Rekhet	Rekhenet	Tumhotram
72	Rekhut	Reknah	Tumhotrek
73	Rekmen	Reknemah	Tumkamet
74	Rekneb	Sarhenet	Tumkamnah
75	Remaht	Sarhenet	Tumkarem
76	Remhetep	Sarhotmeh	Tumkhot
77	Remnah	Sarinah	Tumkhotrek
78	Remnes	Sarinahmeh	Tumnahsek
79	Remteh	Sarnah	Tumramket
80	Sarhot	Sarnetmeh	Tumrekem
81	Sarneh	Senetneh	Tumrekhet
82	Sarnet	Separeh	Tumrekhot
83	Sarpuh	Sepkaret	Tumrekneh
84	Sebrek	Sepkemah	Tumrekseh
85	Sekhen	Sepkhenet	Tumreksek
86	Senkhot	Sepmenet	Tumremarek
87	Senmose	Sepnet	Tumremes
88	Sepket	Seprah	Tumremet
89	Sepnuh	Sepremet	Tumremnah
90	Seprem	Sepret	Tumremset
91	Setkem	Septheret	Tumremurah
92	Sutekham	Serenet	Tumremurah
93	Thekre	Tharemah	Tumretmur
94	Thepnak	Theprenah	Tumseh
95	Thepren	Theprenet	Tumseket
96	Thuhen	Thetremet	Tumseth
97	Thurek	Thuharet	Tumsetrek
98	Thutran	Thuhenret	Tumurek
99	Tuhmose	Tuhkemah	Tumuret
100	Tuhsek	Tuhset	Tumuset

appendix d: name tables

human names

Dunblaine (Gael)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aerdan	Aerin	Aerdal	26	Cairdhal	Cairlith	Dhrathar
02	Aeric	Aerlin	Airdhain	27	Cairic	Caolana	Dhronn
03	Aidanach	Aislinne	Baedhlin	28	Calinor	Ceannan	Dornach
04	Airdhan	Aithne	Bairchaid	29	Caltran	Cearin	Dornath
05	Alachor	Alandis	Beacairn	30	Cearmon	Ceorlain	Draerach
06	Althor	Aobhra	Braedoc	31	Ceilain	Cridha	Draethor
07	Ardhain	Ardhara	Breacach	32	Ceolam	Cridhe	Faelagh
08	Baethor	Beathla	Breacain	33	Crionan	Daelith	Faenair
09	Balcan	Beodhla	Brochaid	34	Crionin	Daerna	Finlith
10	Banlach	Bheara	Brogenan	35	Daegran	Daoghin	Finradh
11	Bealach	Braenna	Broghan	36	Daerlin	Darbha	Gaelach
12	Beolan	Branla	Bryndoch	37	Daervan	Deiran	Gaelin
13	Beoron	Branwen	Cadhran	38	Dairlin	Derna	Gaelinach
14	Branach	Breacan	Caelach	39	Donlach	Dheannan	Gaordhal
15	Branith	Breana	Caerdal	40	Dorcan	Dhearan	Kilgorran
16	Brannor	Breannach	Caethor	41	Driagan	Dhoilidh	Kilthron
17	Breacan	Brogan	Cairdan	42	Drumnor	Draessa	Kincar
18	Breagon	Bronna	Cairdel	43	Drustan	Eirnan	Kinnach
19	Brognan	Bronnagh	Cairlan	44	Eamonach	Eithline	Kinnagh
20	Cadhal	Caedhra	Ceardha	45	Edbert	Erleith	Kinnor
21	Cadorn	Caelan	Crionach	46	Edron	Ethine	Laochain
22	Caelen	Caella	Daellan	47	Eirnad	Faerin	Lochairn
23	Caethin	Caellinn	Daevaran	48	Eodan	Faoira	Lochdir
24	Caillan	Caerlin	Dairgan	49	Faelan	Faolanna	Lochlanach
25	Cairdan	Cairlea	Dhoirlin	50	Faerdan	Fianla	Lochwyn

Dunblaine (Gael)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Ferach	Fianna	MacAern
52	Fialdar	Fionla	MacAirlin
53	Fialin	Fionneth	MacAlorn
54	Fionach	Gaelin	MacBreann
55	Fionlan	Gaeline	MacDrin
56	Gaeltin	Gaelith	MacFain
57	Gaerdor	Gaerith	MacFion
58	Gaerlin	Gaerla	MacGaeran
59	Gaeron	Ionan	MacGoraidh
60	Gairith	Iorna	MacLeir
61	Galinor	Keirne	MacNael
62	Gaolan	Laeith	MacOrdan
63	Goranach	Laerith	MacRiada
64	Gordan	Lairde	Maeleach
65	Kaedor	Leithin	Maelgorn
66	Kaelan	Liadhan	Maellorn
67	Keir	Loredh	Maerrin
68	Kilduin	Maegith	Moirdal
69	Lachdun	Maelle	Moirnin
70	Lathain	Maevin	Morach
71	Loarnan	Maevith	Morvran
72	Lorcan	Moirgen	Muirlach
73	Lormac	Moirin	Naornach
74	Maelion	Moirla	Neachal
75	Maerdin	Moirnith	O'Baelan
76	Maethin	Muirin	O'Braen
77	Marloch	Muirlinn	O'Brathin
78	Morchain	Muirnith	O'Crion
79	Mordan	Naodra	O'Fealon
80	Myrnan	Naomhan	O'Gairth
81	Orland	Nevalda	O'Grallan
82	Osgar	Rhiobhan	O'Muir
83	Raoden	Riathna	O'Naordan
84	Riordan	Riona	O'Ruinn
85	Ruadan	Ruanne	O'Saenla
86	Ruanor	Saedhna	O'Thorran
87	Ruard	Saewen	Rhiddal
88	Saethar	Saodhla	Roinnar
89	Saolan	Saoilith	Ruadhan
90	Scathlan	Saoiran	Saerdach
91	Seodhan	Saolanna	Siodha
92	Sorcan	Sioran	Siorcan
93	Taelan	Sorcha	Taorlan
94	Taelan	Sorfa	Taormach
95	Taernin	Teadhan	Teaghain
96	Teigan	Teighre	Teornach
97	Teiron	Teolagh	Teornan
98	Tiernan	Teorla	Teorwyn
99	Truinor	Tiarna	Uainlan
100	Uainlan	Tierana	Uainlith

appendix d: name tables

human names

Haedravik/The Ironlands (Vikstongue/Iron Tongue)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aesir	Alfrun	Aegirsson/dottir
02	Aethelir	Arnbjorg	Arnlaug
03	Arnvid	Arnhild	Agardsson/dottir
04	Arvendir	Arvala	Arvidsson/dottir
05	Arvindr	Aslaug	Aslind
06	Asger	Astrid	Baldarsson/dottir
07	Asvald	Audra	Bjollir
08	Baldar	Bergdis	Bjornirsson/dottir
09	Bardil	Birna	Brandasson/dottir
10	Bjallar	Bjornia	Bryndal
11	Bjornir	Bjornyn	Bryndalsson/dottir
12	Brandir	Bredla	Brynja
13	Breidr	Brundis	Draegor
14	Breindir	Brynhild	Eilind
15	Bryndor	Dagmara	Einarsson/dottir
16	Dagrim	Eilunn	Eindsson/dottir
17	Egilfar	Einla	Einlund
18	Eilmar	Eira	Einvar
19	Eindir	Eirla	Eiriksson/dottir
20	Einrik	Eldgunn	Eldthor
21	Eirikur	Eldrid	Eorlang
22	Elmdir	Eldun	Eydrimsson/dottir
23	Eorik	Elida	Fenrisson/dottir
24	Eorlund	Elsin	Fjorlind
25	Eydrim	Elska	Fjorlor
26	Fenrik	Elva	Folkar
27	Folger	Erla	Folkgard
28	Freimar	Esla	Freysson/dottir
29	Freyrin	Eydrun	Freylund
30	Frodir	Eyra	Fridlund
31	Galdur	Finna	Galdrir
32	Garmir	Finvar	Gardsson/dottir
33	Geirr	Folkrun	Geirsson/dottir
34	Gellir	Folkrun	Grimnir
35	Gellir	Frega	Grimsson/dottir
36	Grimdal	Freka	Gudmarsson/dottir
37	Grimr	Freydis	Haelgard
38	Grimvor	Fridla	Haldsson/dottir
39	Gudmar	Froya	Halgir
40	Haelgar	Fryddis	Halvadr
41	Hakonar	Gaerdla	Halvarsson/dottir
42	Haldrir	Geirda	Hjalmarsson/dottir
43	Hallvor	Geirith	Holvir
44	Halvarn	Gilda	Hrolfsson/dottir
45	Halvi	Grima	Hrothir
46	Hardor	Groa	Hrundir
47	Helmir	Gudrith	Idalsson/dottir
48	Herjorn	Gudrun	Ingalfsson/dottir
49	Hjalmar	Gunnlaug	Ingmund
50	Holmir	Gunnvor	Jarlasson/dottir

Haedravik/The Ironlands (Vikstongue/Iron Tongue)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Hrolf	Halda	Jormundsson/dottir
52	Ingmar	Hallgerd	Keldarsson/dottir
53	Ivarn	Helga	Kjallson/dottir
54	Jormund	Hella	Kjarson/dottir
55	Jorund	Helvird	Kjartansson/dottir
56	Jorvin	Hildr	Kolfrun
57	Keldar	Hjordis	Kollersson/dottir
58	Ketlir	Idalia	Kolvad
59	Kjall	Idunna	Lindsson/dottir
60	Kjartan	Inga	Lofring
61	Kolgar	Ingalf	Magvald
62	Kollinn	Jorhild	Mjoaldr
63	Kolrinn	Kari	Mjolgar
64	Lofgar	Kjara	Njallsson/dottir
65	Magrin	Kolfinn	Olversson/dottir
66	Mjornir	Kolga	Ormsson/dottir
67	Njall	Kolva	Raelund
68	Olfrik	Laerdin	Ragnsson/dottir
69	Ormver	Linna	Runarsson/dottir
70	Ragnar	Lothna	Sigbjorn
71	Rorik	Mjoll	Sindral
72	Runar	Odrun	Skaldir
73	Siggurd	Ragnara	Skallsson/dottir
74	Sigvor	Runa	Skarlisson/dottir
75	Sindrur	Saedis	Skarsson/dottir
76	Skaddur	Saedis	Skogsdal
77	Skaldin	Signy	Sturlsson/dottir
78	Skarli	Sigrda	Sturlisson/dottir
79	Skogar	Sigrun	Styrsson/dottir
80	Steinir	Sigvarr	Sverndal
81	Sturli	Skardis	Sverth
82	Sturmar	Skjana	Thorgeir
83	Styr	Skogla	Thorgridr
84	Svertir	Solveig	Thorild
85	Thorkir	Steinvora	Thorstein
86	Thorlek	Svala	Thorvorr
87	Thorvorr	Thora	Thrainsson/dottir
88	Thrain	Thorgith	Tryggsson/dottir
89	Throndir	Thorla	Valbjorn
90	Trygvar	Thurid	Valdursson/dottir
91	Ullvir	Ulfara	Valfreya
92	Vagnir	Ulfla	Valgunn
93	Valdur	Vaetilda	Vidarsson/dottir
94	Valkir	Valgunn	Vigsson/dottir
95	Valmund	Valkja	Vindla
96	Varmund	Vigdisa	Vogard
97	Vidar	Viglun	Volkir
98	Vig	Yrrith	Volksson/dottir
99	Volger	Yrsa	Volmar
100	Yrnir	Yrskla	Yrnmund

appendix d: name tables

human names

Hohenvall (Meersreich)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Adelbert	Adelheid	Alberts	26	Egbert	Elsbeth	Eisenhart
02	Adolphus	Agnes	Albrechtshof	27	Eike	Else	Erichs
03	Alaric	Albrada	Altmann	28	Elias	Emeline	Eschweiler
04	Albertus	Alburgis	Andreasen	29	Engelbert	Emma	Fels
05	Aldemar	Alheit	Arnoldsen	30	Ernst	Engelberta	Feuermann
06	Alwin	Alina	Bach	31	Ewald	Erentrudis	Fischer
07	Anselm	Amalie	Bauer	32	Falko	Ermentrude	Fleischer
08	Arend	Anastasia	Becker	33	Ferdinand	Eva	Fluss
09	Arnulf	Anna	Berg	34	Folker	Frida	Friedrichs
10	Baldwin	Annika	Berger	35	Frederick	Frieda	Frostwald
11	Berengar	Anselma	Berthold	36	Gero	Gerda	Gerber
12	Bernd	Ava	Brandt	37	Gerold	Gerlinda	Gernhardt
13	Berthold	Beata	Braun	38	Gerwin	Gertrud	Glaser
14	Bodo	Benigna	Breit	39	Godfried	Giselle	Goldhain
15	Bruno	Berna	Breitenbach	40	Gunther	Gudrun	Goldschmidt
16	Carloman	Bertha	Breuer	41	Gustav	Hannelore	Gottfried
17	Caspar	Birgitta	Bucher	42	Gotz	Hedda	Groß
18	Christoph	Catharina	Bohmer	43	Halmar	Hedwig	Grunenwald
19	Conrad	Clara	Claessen	44	Hartmut	Heilwig	Hagen
20	Dietmar	Clotilda	Dietrichsen	45	Heinrich	Helene	Hain
21	Dietrich	Dorethea	Dornfeld	46	Helmut	Hilda	Hammerstein
22	Eberhard	Edelgard	Drachenfels	47	Hermann	Hildegard	Hardt
23	Eckart	Edwina	Dunkel	48	Hugo	Ida	Heinrichs
24	Eckbert	Elfrun	Eckhardt	49	Immanuel	Ilsa	Hellwig
25	Edmund	Elsa	Eichmann	50	Ingmar	Imma	Hermannsen

Hohenvall (Meersreich)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Isenbert	Irmgard	Hochwald
52	Jakob	Isabel	Holtzmann
53	Johann	Jutta	Jacobi
54	Jurgen	Katarina	Johannes
55	Karl	Klara	Jager
56	Klaus	Kunigunde	Keller
57	Lambert	Lenora	Kirchhof
58	Leopold	Liesel	Klausen
59	Lorenz	Lieselotte	Klein
60	Ludolf	Lorelei	Konrads
61	Ludwig	Luisa	Kramer
62	Lutz	Lutgardis	Kurz
63	Manfred	Magda	Lang
64	Markus	Magdalena	Lauterbach
65	Matthias	Marga	Lindemann
66	Maximilian	Margarethe	Ludwigs
67	Meinrad	Marta	Lustig
68	Nikolaus	Mathilda	Mondschein
69	Norbert	Mechtild	Moller
70	Otto	Minna	Muller
71	Peter	Odilia	Nachtfrost
72	Rainald	Otilie	Nebelheim
73	Reinhard	Petra	Nikolausen
74	Reinhold	Radegund	Rabenstein
75	Richardis	Regina	Reinhards
76	Roland	Reinhild	Roth
77	Rudolf	Richildis	Schattenberg
78	Sigfried	Rosamund	Schlosser
79	Sigmund	Rosina	Schneider
80	Stefan	Sabina	Schnell
81	Theobald	Sibylla	Schumacher
82	Thilo	Sigrid	Schwartzen
83	Tilman	Sophia	Silberthal
84	Tobias	Susanna	Sonnenfeld
85	Ulrich	Theodora	Stark
86	Valentin	Theresia	Steinhauer
87	Volkmar	Tilda	Sturmfels
88	Waldemar	Truda	Thalberg
89	Waldo	Ursula	Tiefengrund
90	Walter	Valentina	Waldheim
91	Werner	Verena	Weber
92	Wilbert	Walburga	Weiss
93	Wilhelm	Wanda	Wellenbruch
94	Willibald	Wendela	Wildemann
95	Winfried	Wilhelmina	Winter
96	Wolfram	Winifred	Wolfsbach
97	Wulfgar	Wulfrun	Wusten
98	Wulfric	Ysolda	Ziegenwald
99	Zacharias	Zenobia	Zimmermann
100	Zeno	Zita	Zornig

appendix d: name tables

human names

Old Vestria (Low/High Vestrian)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aelianus	Aemiliana	Aemilianus	26	Dentorian	Curiana	Domitianus
02	Agricanus	Aethelia	Agricanus	27	Draconus	Deltricia	Draconis
03	Albinor	Albina	Albioris	28	Egnatius	Denteria	Egnatior
04	Altarius	Altriana	Altorius	29	Elarion	Draconia	Elarianus
05	Ambrus	Ambrinia	Ambrianus	30	Embricus	Egnatia	Embricanus
06	Anicetus	Ancinia	Anicetis	31	Ennius	Elvenna	Ennionis
07	Artorian	Anthecia	Arcellius	32	Falxian	Embria	Falxianis
08	Arvianus	Arcelia	Artorianus	33	Fascanus	Ennia	Favonius
09	Atilius	Arminia	Asellianus	34	Favonius	Etriana	Feltranius
10	Baltrus	Asellia	Aurelius	35	Feltrius	Falvia	Fimbrianus
11	Barbianus	Atariana	Baltrius	36	Fimbrus	Favonilla	Firmior
12	Bellator	Aurellina	Bellatoris	37	Firmianus	Feltricia	Floranius
13	Beltrius	Baltricia	Bellicus	38	Florinus	Firmia	Gallianus
14	Calvinius	Belinora	Bellorian	39	Gallion	Floriana	Gavrinor
15	Carenius	Bellia	Calvinius	40	Gavianus	Gallia	Gellinius
16	Casianus	Cadorina	Casianus	41	Gellianus	Gelliana	Hadrionis
17	Castorion	Caeliana	Castorix	42	Hadrion	Helviora	Helvinus
18	Censorinus	Calviria	Censorian	43	Helvior	Hostilia	Hostilianis
19	Cirenus	Cantricia	Cirenicus	44	Hostilian	Illunara	Imberis
20	Claudian	Castoria	Claudicanus	45	Imberius	Imbricia	Jullianis
21	Corianus	Censorina	Corvinus	46	Jullianus	Julina	Junicianus
22	Corvus	Clarentia	Crassior	47	Junicetus	Junicilla	Laetor
23	Crassianus	Cloviana	Curionis	48	Laetorian	Laetoria	Larcius
24	Curio	Corvina	Decimaris	49	Larcius	Larina	Lentulius
25	Decimus	Crassia	Dentorianus	50	Lentulus	Lentulia	Licinianus

Old Vestria (Low/High Vestrian)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Licinian	Licinia	Longior
52	Longinus	Longinia	Lucanoris
53	Lucanir	Lucanira	Lurianis
54	Lurian	Luriana	Macrinian
55	Macrinus	Macrina	Magnori
56	Magnar	Magnilla	Marinianus
57	Marinian	Marinia	Mauricanus
58	Maurianus	Maurina	Mercurialis
59	Mercurion	Mercurina	Mettior
60	Mettianus	Mettia	Narbanis
61	Narbanus	Narbanilla	Narsicianus
62	Narsicus	Nautilia	Nautioris
63	Nautianus	Nestorina	Nestorix
64	Nestoris	Numida	Numidianus
65	Numidor	Obellina	Obellian
66	Obellius	Octavia	Octavius
67	Octarion	Oltrica	Oltricus
68	Oltricus	Palladia	Palladius
69	Palladian	Palmilla	Palmorius
70	Palmus	Peltrina	Peltrinius
71	Pelagonus	Plancia	Plancianis
72	Peltrius	Polliana	Pollianor
73	Plancian	Proclia	Proclior
74	Pollianus	Quintilla	Quintior
75	Proclian	Regalia	Regalianis
76	Quintarus	Rellina	Rellorian
77	Regalian	Sabinia	Sabinianus
78	Rellius	Salvia	Salvianis
79	Sabinus	Scaevina	Scaevior
80	Salius	Selverina	Selveris
81	Scaevian	Senoclia	Senoclianis
82	Selverian	Silvana	Silvanis
83	Senocles	Soranilla	Soranianis
84	Silvanus	Taltia	Taltorian
85	Soranus	Tarquinia	Tarquinius
86	Taltian	Tertia	Tertioris
87	Tarquinius	Tullia	Tullianus
88	Tertianus	Turinia	Turianor
89	Tullian	Ultina	Ultorius
90	Turianus	Umbria	Umbrior
91	Ultrius	Valentilla	Valentinor
92	Umbrius	Valerina	Valerianis
93	Valentinor	Vastinia	Vastinianis
94	Valerion	Ventorina	Ventorix
95	Vastinius	Verilla	Verinus
96	Ventorix	Volciana	Volcianis
97	Verianus	Xenara	Xenarius
98	Volcianus	Zephyrina	Zephyrinus
99	Xenarus	Zoriana	Zorianor
100	Zorianus	Zunaria	Zunarianis

appendix d: name tables

human names

Red Waster (Sandspeech)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Anvari	Amaneh	Abanpour	26	Firouzan	Farizan	Firouzan
02	Ardashir	Amelina	Afshar	27	Gorandasht	Farnaz	Firouzgar
03	Arfarid	Anahita	Ahrimanian	28	Gudarz	Gavina	Golbahar
04	Armanesh	Arazan	Alizadeh	29	Havandor	Golanar	Golestan
05	Arshiman	Ashira	Amiri	30	Havarash	Golidar	Gudarzi
06	Ashkan	Atousa	Amuzegar	31	Hormizd	Golnar	Haftvadi
07	Bahram	Azadeh	Anvari	32	Hormoz	Golriza	Heshmatian
08	Bahrouz	Azarom	Ardalan	33	Imanesh	Haftanaz	Homayoun
09	Barmir	Bahar	Ardeshirian	34	Isfandeh	Hamira	Hosseinian
10	Bijan	Bahareh	Ashtari	35	Iskander	Harizeh	Ilkhanian
11	Charvand	Bahareh	Azadpour	36	Jahandir	Hasti	Isfandari
12	Chosro	Bahina	Babakian	37	Jamiran	Heshineh	Javidan
13	Cyrus	Behnaz	Bahrami	38	Jamshid	Hoda	Kamali
14	Dariomand	Casira	Baramian	39	Javed	Jaleh	Kavehpour
15	Dariun	Cheshmeh	Barzin	40	Kamardesh	Jamaneh	Kayani
16	Darius	Darvand	Bistami	41	Kamran	Jasmin	Khalajian
17	Divandar	Darya	Chaharbaghi	42	Kaveh	Javaneh	Khalili
18	Ebrahim	Delara	Cyrusian	43	Kayhan	Kamareh	Khorramian
19	Esfandiar	Delya	Darvishi	44	Keyvan	Karima	Kianpour
20	Eskarom	Deravan	Daryanpour	45	Khaldoran	Katayoun	Kohanlou
21	Esmarash	Elfarah	Delnavaz	46	Khalvoran	Kiana	Lohraspian
22	Farhad	Elham	Divanian	47	Khoramir	Kivanah	Mahdavi
23	Farhadom	Elnaz	Esfahani	48	Kianoush	Laleh	Mahjouri
24	Fariborz	Farangis	Farhangian	49	Lalomid	Lalivar	Mehrabi
25	Faromash	Farideh	Farrokhzad	50	Lohrasp	Leyla	Mehrdadian

Red Waster (Sandspeech)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Mahavand	Leyomand	Mehrnoush	76	Sarvand	Samina	Sadeghi
52	Mahrosh	Mahdiva	Minavi	77	Shapur	Sarindeh	Safavian
53	Mahyar	Mahin	Mirzadeh	78	Shivanesh	Sarivat	Samandar
54	Majid	Mandana	Mobasheri	79	Siavash	Sepideh	Sepahpour
55	Mehraneh	Marita	Mokhberi	80	Sorandar	Shaghayegh	Shahrbani
56	Mehrdad	Marjan	Monfared	81	Soraneh	Shaheda	Shahrivar
57	Namireh	Marnaz	Narimanian	82	Soroush	Shirehnaz	Shariati
58	Nariman	Mina	Nasrallah	83	Sorush	Shirin	Siminpour
59	Nima	Nargis	Noorani	84	Tabramor	Simin	Soroujian
60	Omid	Narisha	Nouri	85	Tahmasp	Soraya	Tabandeh
61	Ordanesh	Nasrin	Omidvar	86	Tavarad	Sorvara	Tabarzin
62	Ormazd	Niloofar	Ormazdi	87	Tirdad	Taheera	Tahmasebi
63	Oshvanar	Niranom	Oshidari	88	Tisfaram	Taraneh	Tavanian
64	Paridom	Oshana	Parandian	89	Vahid	Tavandis	Vahdati
65	Parviz	Parimon	Parizad	90	Varamir	Tavriza	Varaminian
66	Parzand	Parindeh	Parnian	91	Xeradom	Vandena	Vatanpour
67	Peyman	Parisa	Pourmand	92	Xerxes	Vardeh	Yazdani
68	Qasimor	Parvaneh	Qadirian	93	Yadarash	Yalda	Yektaian
69	Radamiz	Qamareh	Qazvini	94	Yashar	Yasmin	Zadeh
70	Ramash	Ramaneh	Radpour	95	Yashtan	Yasomir	Zafarani
71	Ramin	Raminaz	Rahbar	96	Zand	Zahra	Zandian
72	Rostam	Rojina	Rahimi	97	Zaramir	Zaraleh	Zarandian
73	Saeed	Roxana	Rashidi	98	Zarir	Zarrin	Zargarian
74	Samandar	Safira	Rostami	99	Zarivand	Zeinab	Zarnegar
75	Samindar	Safonaz	Saadatian	100	Zeynabesh	Zivaneh	Zarrinpour

appendix d: name tables

human names

Sattagoya/Drangia (Khannish)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aibat	Aiyka	Altan	26	Hadan	Galdanaa	Ganbold
02	Altan	Altantsetseg	Altansukh	27	Hadanbaatar	Ganbileg	Gansukh
03	Arban	Amara	Amgalan	28	Hulagu	Ganmaa	Gantumur
04	Arslan	Anara	Arbanbat	29	Ilikhan	Gansuren	Gerel
05	Bagatur	Arigh	Arigbayan	30	Jagun	Geremaa	Hulagu
06	Batu	Ariunchimeg	Arigh	31	Jamukha	Goyol	Ilkhan
07	Bayar	Bagana	Bagatur	32	Janibek	Gulnar	Jalair
08	Bektash	Balzhan	Bayad	33	Jargal	Hada	Jamukha
09	Bektemir	Batul	Bayan	34	Jochi	Hadgal	Janibek
10	Belgutei	Bayan	Bayanbat	35	Jochigen	Hishig	Jargal
11	Borjin	Bayartuul	Belgutei	36	Kadyr	Ikhtiyar	Jochi
12	Chagatai	Bilegmaa	Bolor	37	Kanat	Ilgamaa	Kadan
13	Chimbai	Bolormaa	Borijin	38	Khasar	Inkara	Kanat
14	Daisan	Burin	Borjin	39	Khash	Irdyn	Khansol
15	Dalan	Chimeg	Buriyat	40	Khorijin	Jamila	Kharchin
16	Dargan	Chimegen	Chagatai	41	Khubilai	Janjin	Khatanbaatar
17	Dashgin	Chingisua	Chimeg	42	Khudai	Jargalan	Khatansuren
18	Delger	Chulunnaran	Chingis	43	Kokochu	Khaliun	Khoshuud
19	Dorje	Dalantai	Dalantai	44	Kundal	Khasar	Khubilai
20	Erdene	Delgermurun	Delger	45	Kurban	Khashaa	Kirgiz
21	Galdan	Duriya	Delgerkhan	46	Mergen	Khorijin	Kokochu
22	Ganbold	Ereljin	Dorje	47	Munkh	Khulan	Kulan
23	Gansukh	Erhiimaa	Erdene	48	Naran	Khursuul	Mandukhai
24	Genghar	Erhim	Erdenetsetseg	49	Nasr	Kokonur	Mergen
25	Gerel	Erzhina	Ganbaatar	50	Nurzhan	Kulan	Merkit

Sattagoya/Drangia (Khannish)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Odval	Lhasaa	Munkh
52	Ogedai	Mandukhai	Naiman
53	Olzii	Munkhsaihan	Nergui
54	Oron	Munkhtsetseg	Nomin
55	Otgon	Namgar	Noyan
56	Oyunchimeg	Narantsetseg	Odval
57	Pavlun	Nergui	Oirat
58	Qadan	Nomin-Erdene	Olzii
59	Qorjin	Nyamdelger	Onggirat
60	Qutlugh	Odval	Oron
61	Sabdan	Ongon	Otgon
62	Saikhan	Oyuun	Pavlun
63	Samandar	Qadan	Qipchaq
64	Saran	Qorjin	Qonggirad
65	Seljuk	Qulan	Qorjin
66	Senge	Saikhan	Saikhan
67	Shamsir	Sairaa	Sainkhuu
68	Sorghaghtani	Sarnai	Sarnai
69	Subotai	Satsyal	Seljuk
70	Sulde	Sechen	Senge
71	Suyun	Sengema	Shamsir
72	Taimur	Shaimaya	Sorghaghtani
73	Tamir	Sorkhokhtani	Subotai
74	Tangutai	Sulde	Sulde
75	Tarkan	Surya	Taimur
76	Temudjin	Tamura	Tamir
77	Toghon	Tangyn	Tavan
78	Toghrul	Tansag	Temudjin
79	Tolui	Tanysh	Toghrul
80	Tsetseg	Togoldor	Togulu
81	Tumur	Togtuya	Tolui
82	Tungalag	Tserendolgor	Torguud
83	Turgen	Tsetseg	Tsagaan
84	Ulaan	Tungalag	Tsetseghuu
85	Ulagan	Ulaana	Tumat
86	Ulus	Ulgimaa	Tumur
87	Usun	Uurtsaikh	Tungalag
88	Uyen	Uzura	Turgen
89	Yeke	Yamala	Ulaan
90	Yeruzak	Yasamin	Ulus
91	Yesugei	Yesugen	Urainkhai
92	Yisui	Yisun	Urtana
93	Yisun	Zaisaa	Usun
94	Zaisan	Zambaga	Uyghur
95	Zerden	Zaya	Yeruzak
96	Zogii	Zeren	Yesugen
97	Zuljin	Zhalaya	Yesui
98	Zurag	Zorig	Zerden
99	Zurgan	Zulganai	Zogii
100	Zuun	Zuljina	Zuljin

appendix d: name tables

human names

Serpent's Teeth Isles (Pirate's Cant)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Abel	Adelina	Aker	26	Bertram	Catrijn	Charpentier
02	Adelmo	Agnes	Alarcon	27	Bertrand	Cecily	Chastain
03	Adriaan	Alba	Arana	28	Clement	Celestine	Clearwater
04	Aernout	Aleid	Archambeau	29	Coenraad	Chantal	Cleeve
05	Alain	Alejandra	Ashdown	30	Corbin	Clara	Cloutier
06	Alard	Alida	Aubert	31	Cornelis	Clarice	Colborne
07	Alejandro	Almera	Bainbridge	32	Corwin	Constanza	Coralbane
08	Alfonso	Amandine	Barbeau	33	Crispin	Cybele	Corvera
09	Alric	Amaya	Barranca	34	Cuthbert	Cecile	Courtemanche
10	Alvaro	Ameline	Barrow	35	Denis	Delmira	Crayton
11	Amador	Ana	Bazan	36	Diederik	Delphine	Cardenas
12	Ambroise	Angeline	Beaulieu	37	Diego	Edith	Darkwater
13	Andres	Anke	Bellerose	38	Dirck	Eleanor	De Witte
14	Ansel	Anne	Berkenbosch	39	Domingo	Eliza	Desmarais
15	Archer	Anore	Blackreef	40	Domenic	Elodie	Dijkstra
16	Armand	Anseline	Blackwood	41	Dorian	Elvira	Dreadspire
17	Aubert	Aveline	Blaylock	42	Edmund	Emeline	Dunsmore
18	Baldwin	Beatrice	Bloodstone	43	Edric	Emeraude	Dupont
19	Bartel	Bente	Brightwell	44	Edwin	Emma	Emberline
20	Bartolome	Bernadette	Buckwald	45	Elias	Esperanza	Escobar
21	Basilio	Bettina	Cartwright	46	Ellis	Estelle	Evershed
22	Bastiaan	Blanche	Carvajal	47	Enrique	Evelina	Everts
23	Bastien	Camila	Castellano	48	Esteban	Evette	Fallow
24	Benedict	Carmina	Cervantes	49	Etienne	Felicia	Fangward
25	Benoit	Catalina	Chadwick	50	Fabien	Feliciana	Fauchard

Serpent's Teeth Isles (Pirate's Cant)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Fernando	Femke	Ferrera
52	Floris	Fiorella	Fontaine
53	Francisco	Fleur	Gagnon
54	Frederik	Florence	Galindo
55	Gaspard	Gertruida	Gallowglass
56	Gaston	Giselle	Garro
57	Gael	Graciela	Geelen
58	Geoffrey	Gwendolyn	Groeneveld
59	Gerrit	Hendrika	Guzman
60	Gilles	Idony	Hargrove
61	Godfrey	Ines	Hendriks
62	Gonzalo	Isabel	Hightide
63	Guillen	Jacinta	Hoogland
64	Gerard	Janna	Hurtado
65	Halbert	Jimena	Ironshard
66	Halmar	Joan	Ironwood
67	Halvor	Juliette	Janssen
68	Harold	Katherine	Koeman
69	Hendrik	Katris	Kuyper
70	Hernan	Leonor	Langridge
71	Hubert	Lettice	Laredo
72	Hugo	Liora	Lemoine
73	Iago	Lisbeth	Lowtide
74	Ignacio	Lotte	Marwood
75	Jacques	Lucrecia	Meijer
76	Jan	Lysandra	Mercier
77	Jasper	Leonie	Montagne
78	Joost	Maike	Montalvo
79	Julian	Marcelline	Moorstone
80	Klaas	Margery	Morel
81	Lambert	Margot	Mulder
82	Laurent	Margriet	Nightshade
83	Lionel	Mariana	Olivares
84	Lucan	Mariken	Pacheco
85	Leon	Mireille	Redmane
86	Maarten	Melisande	Riviere
87	Marcel	Neeltje	Roeland
88	Marco	Norena	Sauvage
89	Mateo	Paloma	Seabourne
90	Nicodemus	Rhoswen	Silverfin
91	Orellan	Rosalia	Stormbringer
92	Oswin	Saskia	Tidemark
93	Pieter	Selene	Trelawney
94	Reinier	Sigrid	Valverde
95	Reynaldo	Sylviane	Van Alphen
96	Rodrigo	Tanneke	Van Breukelen
97	Remy	Thalassa	Van Dalen
98	Sebastien	Violeta	Verhoeven
99	Theo	Willemina	Visscher
100	Willem	Ysabeau	Wyrmsbane

appendix d: name tables

human names

Thessia (Thessian)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aedrain	Adgitha	Aelfredson	26	Cenhelm	Cerdwynn	Ceredith
02	Aelric	Adheldis	Aelfric	27	Ceolfred	Ceredith	Cuthwulf
03	Aethelfrith	Aelgith	Aerithson	28	Ceolric	Ceridith	Cynelad
04	Aethelric	Aelinor	Aeronson	29	Cormand	Cwenric	Cynemar
05	Aldred	Aelinor	Aethelwine	30	Cuthred	Cyneld	Cynric
06	Alric	Aerilith	Aldgar	31	Cynelad	Cynelith	Cynstan
07	Alwund	Aerith	Aldredson	32	Cynemar	Cyneswith	Cynwulf
08	Arngar	Aeronwen	Alricson	33	Cynfrid	Cyneswitha	Drustan
09	Athelgar	Aethelda	Arngar	34	Cynfrith	Cynewen	Drusthelm
10	Balwain	Aethelwyn	Athelgar	35	Cynstan	Cynith	Dunric
11	Beornel	Alfraeth	Beornhelm	36	Drustic	Duneth	Dunric
12	Beorulf	Annetith	Beornstan	37	Drustulf	Dunwila	Dunwold
13	Berhthelm	Audwen	Beornwulf	38	Dunstan	Dunwynn	Ealdwulf
14	Breodan	Berild	Breckwin	39	Dunwold	Eadwen	Eardhelm
15	Brethil	Blodwen	Breowine	40	Eadhelm	Eadwina	Eardwine
16	Briavel	Blythwen	Breowulf	41	Eadred	Ealdgyth	Edricson
17	Brinhere	Brenna	Briocwin	42	Eadstan	Ealwynn	Eldgar
18	Brynach	Brenwen	Brynach	43	Ealfrid	Edhilda	Eormenwulf
19	Bryngar	Briafa	Brynhelm	44	Eardwin	Edwynne	Eorric
20	Cadran	Briocwen	Brynwold	45	Eldric	Elfrith	Faelan
21	Cadric	Brithwynn	Cadwulf	46	Eofor	Elfruna	Faelgar
22	Cadwulf	Bronwynn	Caedhelm	47	Eorlwulf	Elgith	Faelgar
23	Calwen	Brynwen	Cedrichelm	48	Eormen	Elsinne	Faelhelm
24	Cedric	Cedwynn	Cedricson	49	Eorric	Eorlaeth	Faelstan
25	Cenfrith	Ceolwen	Ceolfrid	50	Eorwin	Erwen	Freowulf

Thessia (Thessian)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Ervein	Ethelwynn	Garanor
52	Faelan	Faeldith	Geldwine
53	Faelwin	Faelith	Gereintson
54	Freowulf	Faella	Gildan
55	Frideric	Ferlaed	Grendal
56	Frithelm	Gelwen	Grendelhelm
57	Garanor	Gildith	Grifenor
58	Geldwine	Gildreth	Grimhelm
59	Gerent	Gredwen	Grimwulf
60	Gildan	Grendeth	Grithwold
61	Grifarn	Griselda	Gwendal
62	Grifenor	Grithwen	Haligwin
63	Grimbald	Gwenaella	Herlric
64	Gwendal	Gwendith	Herlwin
65	Gwynfael	Gwenora	Hleogar
66	Hadran	Gwineth	Hrothgarson
67	Herewin	Gwynhild	Hrothhelm
68	Herlwin	Haligwen	Ingelm
69	Hleogar	Hareth	Leofhelm
70	Hroden	Helweth	Leowin
71	Hrothgar	Hildaeth	Lothgar
72	Ingelm	Isilith	Maerhelm
73	Ithric	Isolda	Medric
74	Leofgar	Leofwen	Medwulf
75	Leowin	Linwynn	Mylfryd
76	Lewgar	Lothwen	Osfridson
77	Lothgar	Maeldith	Owainhelm
78	Medric	Maelis	Owennor
79	Myrddin	Maerwynn	Redwaldson
80	Osfrid	Maredith	Rhodfael
81	Owainel	Mergith	Rhodgar
82	Owennor	Meriel	Rhodhelm
83	Penric	Mildryth	Saelgar
84	Redwald	Mylfryd	Saelred
85	Rhenwulf	Oswitha	Saelwold
86	Rhydderch	Rhedgith	Sighelm
87	Saelgar	Rhedwyn	Tancredson
88	Saewin	Rhodelith	Theodric
89	Sighelm	Rhoneth	Torhelm
90	Tancred	Saelith	Torwin
91	Theodric	Saewynn	Trevelgar
92	Torwen	Serild	Winfridson
93	Trevelgar	Sigrith	Wistan
94	Uthergar	Teithwynn	Wulfgar
95	Wilstan	Theolwen	Wulfran
96	Winfrid	Treowen	Wulfrid
97	Wistan	Wynelith	Wulfstan
98	Wulfran	Wynflaed	Wynhelm
99	Wulfric	Wynfreth	Wynstan
100	Wulfstan	Wynhild	Wystan

appendix d: name tables

human names

Tical Dondala (Dondalese)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Adelmo	Adelina	Abadia	26	Erico	Celima	Cantero
02	Ademar	Adira	Agramonte	27	Ermano	Cendra	Carbajal
03	Aldano	Aitana	Alba	28	Esdras	Cinta	Carmona
04	Almaz	Alanza	Alcazar	29	Ezteban	Dalinda	Carrasco
05	Amancio	Aldara	Almendra	30	Fabro	Damira	Castellano
06	Andelio	Alodia	Altamirano	31	Fadrique	Daria	Cerezo
07	Arcelio	Amara	Amador	32	Faraldo	Delmira	Cerrato
08	Aristeo	Amaya	Aranda	33	Fermin	Dericia	Colmenar
09	Arman	Anisa	Arellano	34	Ferran	Dorina	Coria
10	Arnaldo	Aracelia	Argote	35	Gael	Edelmira	Cuellar
11	Azar	Arcadia	Arroyo	36	Galeno	Eira	Dehesa
12	Balduino	Armanda	Asencio	37	Gaspar	Elodia	Del Bosque
13	Benat	Azenor	Azcona	38	Gaudio	Elvira	Del Valle
14	Berenguer	Azucena	Baquero	39	Gilan	Emerita	Delgado
15	Bermudo	Belarmina	Barranca	40	Gordiano	Endrina	Duran
16	Cantar	Belisa	Barrera	41	Grimaldo	Esmeralda	Echevarria
17	Carlos	Benita	Benavente	42	Guarion	Estriana	Encina
18	Casimiro	Berenguela	Berrocal	43	Hamil	Fabiana	Esparza
19	Dario	Bianza	Bisbal	44	Haro	Faina	Estevez
20	Demar	Calida	Borrego	45	Hidalmo	Fiora	Fajardo
21	Duero	Calvina	Bravura	46	Iban	Floriana	Falcon
22	Ebrardo	Camila	Caballero	47	Ilian	Fatima	Ferrer
23	Edras	Canisa	Cadenas	48	Isandro	Galena	Figueroa
24	Eladio	Carisa	Calderon	49	Jacobo	Garina	Fonseca
25	Elbio	Casilda	Campomar	50	Jandro	Gaudila	Galindo

Tical Dondala (Dondalese)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Jaret	Gilena	Galvez
52	Jarilo	Guadiana	Garro
53	Jofre	Gualteria	Gijon
54	Justo	Ibira	Godoy
55	Laertes	Iliana	Gorrion
56	Leandro	Inara	Goyena
57	Lisardo	Isana	Granado
58	Lorenz	Itzara	Guerrera
59	Lazar	Jarima	Guijarro
60	Maurel	Jasmira	Herrero
61	Mederico	Justina	Hinojosa
62	Melian	Ladina	Hurtado
63	Mendel	Lamira	Ibanez
64	Miro	Lauret	Jauregui
65	Nahuel	Leandra	Ladera
66	Naldo	Ledicia	Lagunas
67	Nelio	Lenira	Leoz
68	Nerian	Liana	Llamas
69	Olmo	Liria	Lobo
70	Onofre	Lisandra	Longoria
71	Orlan	Llerena	Lorca
72	Orsino	Lorina	Lucero
73	Palmiro	Lucrezia	Madrono
74	Patricio	Maela	Malpica
75	Peral	Mairen	Manzanares
76	Raimundo	Maricela	Mendieta
77	Randel	Marisol	Montero
78	Remigo	Mayrena	Montoya
79	Roban	Manera	Marmol
80	Roldan	Mirabel	Narvaez
81	Roman	Mireya	Najera
82	Saulo	Morana	Olmedo
83	Sain	Nalda	Ortuno
84	Segismundo	Nalia	Otero
85	Selmo	Nerisa	Padilla
86	Serildo	Nivara	Palacios
87	Silvio	Noira	Pereda
88	Siro	Olalla	Pizarro
89	Tarso	Oricia	Quesada
90	Teobaldo	Orlinda	Quintana
91	Tobar	Perla	Ramiro
92	Tormo	Remigia	Rascon
93	Ubaldo	Romina	Requena
94	Urraco	Sabela	Rincon
95	Valentin	Selmira	Robledo
96	Velasco	Solina	Tejada
97	Verdano	Tabita	Valderas
98	Vinal	Tamira	Valverde
99	Xalvador	Tesandra	Zamudio
100	Zalban	Yara	Zarza

appendix d: name tables

human names

Vieksgrad (Slahvac)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Abram	Agafya	Abramov	26	Feofan	Elena	Efimov
02	Afanasiy	Agnessa	Aleksandrov	27	Gavriil	Elisaveta	Eremeyev
03	Akim	Agnia	Andreev	28	Gennadiy	Elizaveta	Ershov
04	Aleksey	Akilina	Anisimov	29	Georgiy	Eudokia	Fedorov
05	Alexei	Aksinya	Antonov	30	Gleb	Evdokia	Frolov
06	Anatoliy	Alena	Arsenyev	31	Grigori	Faina	Galitzin
07	Andrei	Alexandra	Babkin	32	Igor	Feodora	Gavrilov
08	Aristarkh	Alina	Balabanov	33	Illarion	Feodosia	Golubev
09	Arkhip	Anastasia	Baranov	34	Ilya	Fevronia	Gorsky
10	Artyom	Anfisa	Bazhenov	35	Innokentiy	Galina	Gromov
11	Averkiy	Anna	Belov	36	Ivan	Ganna	Guryanov
12	Bogdan	Antonina	Berezin	37	Izbor	Glafira	Ignatov
13	Bogumil	Apollinariya	Bogatyrev	38	Jaroslav	Glebova	Ilyin
14	Boleslav	Ariadna	Bogdanov	39	Kazimir	Irina	Ioannov
15	Borimir	Ariya	Bolkhovsky	40	Kirill	Ivanna	Isayev
16	Boris	Bogdana	Borodin	41	Klim	Iya	Ivanov
17	Bronislav	Bozhena	Chernov	42	Konstantin	Katerina	Kalashnikov
18	Daniil	Bronislava	Chistyakov	43	Kornil	Kira	Karelin
19	Dmitri	Darina	Danilov	44	Lavrentiy	Klavdiya	Kazakov
20	Dobrynya	Darya	Demidov	45	Leonid	Kseniya	Kiselov
21	Efim	Dobrava	Dmitriev	46	Lev	Lada	Klimov
22	Egor	Dobrina	Dobrynin	47	Luka	Larisa	Knyazev
23	Evgeniy	Dominika	Dorofeyev	48	Maksim	Lavrentia	Kochubey
24	Fedir	Efrosinia	Drozdov	49	Matvei	Lubov	Korolev
25	Feodor	Ekaterina	Efanov	50	Mikhail	Ludmila	Koshelev

Vieksgrad (Slahvac)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Miron	Lyubava	Kostomarov
52	Mitrofan	Marfa	Kovalev
53	Nikifor	Margarita	Kozlov
54	Nikita	Maria	Kravtsov
55	Nikolai	Marina	Kruglov
56	Oleg	Marta	Kurchatov
57	Osip	Melania	Laptev
58	Pavel	Militsa	Lazarev
59	Platon	Miloslava	Leonidov
60	Prokhor	Miroslava	Litvinov
61	Pyotr	Nadezhda	Lobachev
62	Radimir	Natalia	Lukyanov
63	Radislav	Nina	Makarov
64	Rodion	Ninel	Matveev
65	Rostislav	Oksana	Menshikov
66	Ruslan	Olga	Mikhailov
67	Semyon	Pelageya	Molchanov
68	Sergei	Polina	Morozov
69	Stepan	Praskovia	Nazarov
70	Svyatopolk	Raisa	Nikiforov
71	Svyatoslav	Rogneda	Nikolaev
72	Taras	Rostislava	Novikov
73	Tikhon	Rozaliya	Obolensky
74	Timofey	Rusalka	Odintsov
75	Trofim	Serafima	Orlov
76	Trofimovich	Snezhana	Osipov
77	Vadim	Sofiya	Pavlov
78	Valery	Sofroniya	Peresvetov
79	Vasiliy	Svetlana	Peskov
80	Velimir	Svyatoslava	Pimenov
81	Viktor	Tamara	Platonov
82	Vladilen	Tatyana	Pleshkov
83	Vladimir	Tsarevna	Polivanov
84	Vladislav	Uliana	Popov
85	Vlasiy	Ulita	Prokhorov
86	Voin	Ustinya	Radomirsky
87	Vsevolod	Valentina	Rakitin
88	Vyacheslav	Valeriya	Rogov
89	Yaroslav	Varvara	Romanov
90	Yeremiy	Vasilisa	Rostislavov
91	Yevgeniy	Veronika	Rurikovich
92	Yevstafiy	Vladimira	Semyonov
93	Yury	Vladislava	Sergeyev
94	Zakhar	Yana	Sobolev
95	Zaretsky	Yaroslava	Sokolov
96	Zavid	Yefrosinya	Stepanov
97	Zhdan	Yesenia	Svyatoslavich
98	Zinoviy	Yevgeniya	Timofeyev
99	Zoran	Zinaida	Ulyanov
100	Zosima	Zlata	Yaroslavov

appendix d: name tables

human names

The Westlands (Westronne)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Alan	Agnes	Ainsley	26	Fergus	Emma	Burnett
02	Ambrose	Agnesa	Archer	27	Florian	Enid	Burton
03	Andrew	Alice	Ashdown	28	Francis	Esther	Cadman
04	Anthony	Aliena	Ashworth	29	Fulke	Estrild	Calvert
05	Arthur	Alys	Athelstan	30	Geoffrey	Ethel	Camden
06	Baldwin	Amabel	Audley	31	Gerald	Eve	Carpenter
07	Bartholomew	Amice	Bancroft	32	Gerard	Felice	Cartwright
08	Benedict	Anne	Bannerman	33	Gilbert	Florence	Chalmers
09	Benedictus	Audrey	Barrow	34	Godfrey	Frances	Chandler
10	Bernard	Avis	Beckwith	35	Gregory	Gisela	Chapman
11	Bertrand	Beatrice	Belgrave	36	Guy	Grace	Chatham
12	Bors	Blanche	Bellamy	37	Halbert	Gwenllian	Chilton
13	Cedric	Bridget	Bentley	38	Harold	Gwyneth	Clayton
14	Christopher	Cateline	Blackwell	39	Henry	Gytha	Clifford
15	Clement	Cecily	Blount	40	Herbert	Hannah	Clyve
16	Cuthbert	Christina	Bower	41	Hugh	Helen	Colby
17	David	Clarice	Bracken	42	Hughbert	Hilda	Compton
18	Dominic	Clarimond	Braithwaite	43	Humphrey	Idonea	Corbett
19	Edmund	Constance	Brentwood	44	Isaac	Isabel	Courtenay
20	Edward	Cordelia	Briar	45	James	Isolde	Cresswell
21	Edwin	Cynthia	Broadhurst	46	Jasper	Jacoba	Dalton
22	Eldwin	Edith	Brock	47	John	Jane	Davenport
23	Elias	Eleanor	Brooke	48	Joscelin	Joan	Denholm
24	Eustace	Elinor	Buckland	49	Josias	Judith	Dering
25	Fabyan	Elizabeth	Burgh	50	Laurence	Juliana	Digby

The Westlands (Westronne)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Leonard	Katherine	Duncombe
52	Lionel	Lavinia	Dunstan
53	Lucas	Leah	Edgeworth
54	Lucius	Leofeva	Eldridge
55	Malachi	Letitia	Ellery
56	Mark	Lillian	Fairfax
57	Martin	Lucinda	Fenwick
58	Matthew	Mabel	Fitzhugh
59	Maurice	Margaret	Fitzroy
60	Miles	Margery	Gable
61	Nicholas	Marion	Gainsborough
62	Oliver	Marjorie	Giffard
63	Osmond	Martha	Gillingham
64	Oswald	Mary	Gladstone
65	Owen	Matilda	Godwin
66	Patrick	Maud	Grantham
67	Paul	Mercy	Greenwood
68	Percival	Millicent	Grey
69	Peter	Muriel	Halifax
70	Philip	Naomi	Harlow
71	Ralph	Nesta	Harwood
72	Randolph	Nicola	Hastings
73	Raymond	Olive	Haywood
74	Reginald	Philippa	Hereford
75	Regulus	Prudence	Hollingsworth
76	Reynard	Rachel	Huntingdon
77	Richard	Rebecca	Kenward
78	Robert	Rohese	Kirkwood
79	Robin	Rosamund	Langley
80	Roger	Rowena	Larkspur
81	Roland	Sabelina	Leybourne
82	Samson	Sabina	Linley
83	Septimus	Sarah	Loxley
84	Sigismund	Selina	Mansfield
85	Simon	Sibyl	Marlowe
86	Stephen	Susannah	Melbury
87	Terrence	Sybella	Mildenhall
88	Theobald	Tabitha	Neville
89	Theophilus	Temperance	Norwood
90	Thomas	Thea	Oakham
91	Tobias	Theodora	Ormond
92	Tristan	Thora	Redgrave
93	Valerian	Ursula	Ridley
94	Victor	Vivian	Sandford
95	Walter	Wilhelmina	Sedgwick
96	Waryn	Winnifred	Stanhope
97	Wilfrid	Ysabel	Thornton
98	William	Yseult	Wakefield
99	Wulfgar	Ysolde	Whitmore
100	Zachary	Zenobia	Wycliffe

appendix d: name tables

non-human names

Dwarf (Kharzhad)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Baldor	Balka	Anvilheart	26	Falzok	Falka	Deepkeeper
02	Baldrik	Bolna	Barrowkeeper	27	Fardrak	Falnris	Earthbreaker
03	Balkar	Bolrik	Bitterfist	28	Garlin	Falrin	Elderkeep
04	Bharmok	Bolzrin	Blackbeard	29	Gharlin	Falvra	Emberbrow
05	Bharzin	Borrin	Blackshield	30	Gharzul	Falzra	Emberglow
06	Bolgrim	Bralka	Blackspike	31	Gorath	Garvek	Emberhand
07	Bolkhan	Bralza	Boldhammer	32	Gornik	Gharnis	Emberheart
08	Boltor	Brelka	Boldsmith	33	Gornir	Gharnor	Fellcutter
09	Bolzar	Brenka	Brokenaxe	34	Gornok	Ghelna	Fiendcutter
10	Bralden	Brenna	Brokenhammer	35	Gralvek	Ghorna	Fiendsplitter
11	Bralvek	Brildra	Bronzebeard	36	Gralvok	Ghranda	Firebraid
12	Bregnar	Brindra	Bronzeforge	37	Gronir	Gralda	Firecloak
13	Brelvik	Brulda	Chiselhand	38	Grumek	Gralna	Firefeeder
14	Brelzar	Dhalra	Coldcutter	39	Grumir	Grenda	Firefinder
15	Bruldak	Dharmis	Coldshield	40	Haldor	Kharlis	Firefist
16	Brundir	Dharnis	Coppervein	41	Kharbek	Kharnis	Firefriend
17	Dharmek	Dhazra	Darkbraid	42	Kharnok	Kharnis	Firehammer
18	Dharzin	Dhorkha	Darkhand	43	Kharnor	Khazlin	Firekeeper
19	Dorrak	Dhorra	Darkshield	44	Kharvok	Khazra	Flintbeard
20	Dorrik	Drelka	Darkstone	45	Kharvorn	Khazven	Flintcloak
21	Drelgar	Drezka	Darkvein	46	Khazrik	Khorna	Flintshade
22	Drelvik	Drezla	Darkwatcher	47	Khazrin	Khradla	Foehammer
23	Drokar	Durtha	Deepdelver	48	Khradek	Khurlis	Forgehammer
24	Durn	Durvra	Deepflame	49	Khradorn	Khurna	Frostbreaker
25	Faldor	Durzha	Deepforge	50	Khradun	Khurnir	Frostforge

Dwarf (Kharzhad)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Khranok	Krandis	Frosthelm
52	Khurlak	Krilda	Gemcutter
53	Khurvak	Krinna	Gemheart
54	Khurvek	Thalda	Goldenteeth
55	Krandek	Thalora	Goldmantle
56	Krardor	Thalrik	Goldshield
57	Krulgar	Thalrin	Goldsmith
58	Mardrin	Thalzrik	Granitefist
59	Morkhan	Tharnila	Grayblade
60	Olzhar	Tharnir	Graycloak
61	Ragnor	Tharnis	Hardheart
62	Thaldok	Tharva	Heartstone
63	Thaldur	Thornis	Highforge
64	Thalmek	Thralda	Ironbraid
65	Thalrik	Thranna	Ironbrow
66	Thandor	Thranna	Ironflame
67	Thandrik	Threldra	Ironforge
68	Tharnok	Threnna	Ironhelm
69	Tharvel	Thrinda	Ironmantle
70	Tholmok	Thrindra	Ironsmith
71	Tholvin	Ulzhara	Ironspike
72	Thorlin	Ulzra	Ledgewalker
73	Thorran	Ulzrin	Minekeeper
74	Thorvek	Ulzvek	Moltenstone
75	Thralkar	Ulzvena	Orcbane
76	Thrangar	Varnis	Redshield
77	Thrazor	Vordra	Rockjaw
78	Throndal	Vundra	Shadowforge
79	Throndar	Zardis	Shalebreaker
80	Thulgar	Zarlen	Silverbeard
81	Ulzhar	Zarlin	Silverbraid
82	Ulzhor	Zarmina	Silverfist
83	Vundal	Zarva	Steelbender
84	Vundrik	Zarval	Steelgrip
85	Zarhon	Zarvel	Steelseeker
86	Zarhor	Zarvina	Steelshaper
87	Zarnok	Zarvra	Stillstander
88	Zarnor	Zhalra	Stonebender
89	Zarvek	Zhardis	Stonebreaker
90	Zarvik	Zharlin	Stonebrewer
91	Zarvikor	Zharna	Stonebrow
92	Zhadrok	Zheldra	Stoneclad
93	Zharlin	Zheldra	Stoneforge
94	Zharmek	Zhelka	Stonehammer
95	Zharmok	Zhelrin	Stoneheart
96	Zharvik	Zholrin	Thunderstone
97	Zholkar	Zholven	Tombkeeper
98	Zhorad	Zhorna	Warmaker
99	Zolrik	Zolnis	Whitebeard
100	Zolvir	Zorvin	Whiteheart

appendix d: name tables

non-human names

Fionnan, High Court (Seethie)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aedhor	Aelindharias	Aedranis	26	Daerionasairil	Eiliondrathil	Calethor
02	Aedhrionorath	Aelindhira	Aedrior	27	Daeriondraelor	Eiraenloris	Calior
03	Aelindhoras	Aeliona	Aelanor	28	Darion	Eiraenvalith	Calrias
04	Aelindhuirion	Aelira	Aelindor	29	Eilanorindhar	Eiranlorithar	Eilandor
05	Aeliorindhas	Aeriondrelas	Aelindor	30	Eilion	Eirawen	Eilion
06	Aelran	Aerith	Aelindris	31	Eiranndorilas	Elowen	Eiraelis
07	Aelrind	Belwyn	Aelirin	32	Eirenar	Elsinor	Eirenar
08	Aerindhorilas	Briallen	Aelrin	33	Eirenathor	Faelin	Eirenith
09	Aeris	Brialora	Aelvar	34	Eirenorindhar	Faelindhaelor	Eirenlor
10	Belenar	Brynara	Bealiris	35	Eolas	Faelindhuaris	Faelirin
11	Brialor	Bryndhoranir	Bealor	36	Eonir	Faeliondrilas	Faelithor
12	Brionor	Brynnionairis	Brialar	37	Faedrin	Faelioranris	Faelithor
13	Brynael	Caedwen	Brialith	38	Faeliorindril	Faelith	Faelrin
14	Bryniorindhael	Caelaenithar	Brialor	39	Faeriondharas	Fionella	Faerion
15	Brynorindhaelor	Caelanis	Brionar	40	Faeron	Galantha	Galindor
16	Caedhrialion	Caerionduilis	Brynaelis	41	Fialindrianor	Galinda	Galionis
17	Caedranis	Caerith	Brynnar	42	Fialiondrithar	Galiondhorilith	Galionor
18	Caelir	Cailin	Brynnor	43	Fialon	Galiondrasilis	Galorin
19	Caelorn	Caladhrialin	Brynor	44	Galinor	Galiondrithal	Gwennor
20	Caladhrionnas	Caladrionis	Brynoras	45	Galiondairis	Galionthariel	Gwionis
21	Calaris	Caladwen	Caelinar	46	Galiondrathil	Gwennor	Isildor
22	Calindhorisair	Caliondrisair	Caeliras	47	Galiondrathilas	Gwiondralithar	Isilion
23	Calion	Daelionnathil	Caionas	48	Galor	Isildhaelorin	Isilrin
24	Daelionthar	Daelith	Caladros	49	Galvar	Isilindhoril	Isilvar
25	Daerion	Eilinel	Calaris	50	Gilnor	Isilioranis	Isindor

Fionnan, High Court (Seethie)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Gwionindhualor	Isiliorindhasil	Laelion
52	Gwionis	Isilira	Laelith
53	Ilianor	Isolde	Lioran
54	Isilindhaelor	Laelionrasin	Lioras
55	Isilionnathar	Laelith	Liorindor
56	Isiliorindharin	Laeriondhuir	Lioris
57	Isilvar	Laerionthael	Lurian
58	Laelion	Lileath	Lurinor
59	Laeriondhuir	Liorindhaelor	Luthion
60	Leoris	Lioris	Maerindor
61	Lioran	Lirael	Maerith
62	Liorindhaethil	Lurinel	Maerlor
63	Lorion	Maelindhaelris	Maeronar
64	Maeliondrathil	Maelwen	Maeronis
65	Maeliorinras	Maerindhorin	Naelion
66	Maelor	Maeriondhuairis	Naeliras
67	Maerin	Maerith	Naelith
68	Maeriondhuirlin	Maerriondaelis	Naelor
69	Mirion	Mirenna	Naeloris
70	Naelith	Miriondhuaril	Nualith
71	Naerindhualis	Naerindhaelor	Raelion
72	Naeriondhorin	Naevia	Raeloris
73	Nioras	Niaelis	Raenor
74	Niorhonrasil	Niamhara	Rhaelion
75	Nualith	Nualaith	Rhialor
76	Orian	Nualindhoris	Rhianar
77	Raenor	Raelith	Rhianor
78	Rathor	Rhianna	Saelithar
79	Rhaelindhuris	Rhiannonvasir	Saelor
80	Rhaelionadhuis	Saelindhuailis	Saelvar
81	Rhaelionvaris	Saeliondralis	Saerin
82	Rhaelor	Saelionvalis	Saerlor
83	Saelindhorin	Saelwen	Seranor
84	Saelion	Serelith	Serindar
85	Saelionathrin	Serenia	Serion
86	Taeliondrithar	Serenitharil	Taelion
87	Taelor	Serina	Taeliras
88	Tarion	Shaelith	Taenor
89	Thalion	Taeliondhrialis	Thalion
90	Thalionasuiril	Taelya	Thalionor
91	Thaliondhuilar	Taerindhalor	Thalior
92	Thaliondraril	Taeriondrelis	Thalioris
93	Thaliondrithar	Thalia	Thaliris
94	Thalor	Thaliondrithar	Thalirith
95	Tharion	Thalira	Thaloras
96	Ulaenvarathil	Ulaena	Tharion
97	Uldranionasir	Ulaenvarithil	Ulandar
98	Ulvaris	Valena	Ularin
99	Valindhuairil	Valerina	Ularis
100	Valion	Valiondhrionas	Valenar

appendix d: name tables

non-human names

Fionnan, Low Court (Bolg Fiir)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
01	Aedric	Aelanis	Aelgwyn	26	Dunstan	Eirwen	Feralos
02	Aeldric	Aeliana	Althris	27	Eadric	Elaena	Gaelvor
03	Aelric	Aelindra	Anwir	28	Eirlas	Elira	Galdrin
04	Aelwyn	Aelith	Balaric	29	Eldran	Ellara	Galwen
05	Aerion	Aerilyn	Bellingar	30	Erelas	Elowen	Garwain
06	Baelor	Aeris	Bowge	31	Eryndor	Faelinn	Gorlas
07	Baren	Branwyn	Branor	32	Faerdan	Faelira	Gralwyn
08	Baren	Breena	Bryngar	33	Faldor	Farren	Grimnor
09	Borric	Brenna	Cadron	34	Farion	Faylen	Grynden
10	Borrin	Briallen	Caerwyn	35	Farnor	Fiora	Grynor
11	Brandon	Brylla	Caldagh	36	Faron	Fioren	Gwyrith
12	Brannor	Brynna	Corveth	37	Gaelan	Gaerith	Halgar
13	Breden	Caelin	Dagrith	38	Garland	Galaeth	Haroth
14	Brennor	Caerlin	Dalvar	39	Garren	Galena	Harvyn
15	Brydan	Cailen	Darnor	40	Garrin	Galwyn	Hwynar
16	Cador	Caldith	Dranthar	41	Gorath	Garlith	Ilbryn
17	Cadwin	Calindra	Draven	42	Haldor	Glynna	Ildor
18	Caedwyn	Carwen	Drynach	43	Halion	Halwith	Ildros
19	Caelen	Daraen	Dyrwain	44	Halric	Ilena	Isarnach
20	Colwyn	Dareth	Edris	45	Harion	Ilith	Kaldryn
21	Dainor	Davara	Elaren	46	Haven	Ilyra	Kelvric
22	Darel	Davina	Eldric	47	Ildur	Iselith	Kharos
23	Darion	Delyth	Faldric	48	Ilrin	Isenna	Korveth
24	Drannor	Derrith	Fenar	49	Isarn	Isoldis	Kynwyr
25	Dunric	Eilith	Fendris	50	Isildar	Kaelith	Lairnor

Fionnan, Low Court (Bolg Fiir)

d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname	d100	First Masculine	First Feminine	Surname
51	Isilthren	Kaerith	Lamnor	76	Osric	Orianna	Styrmir
52	Iven	Kailen	Loryneth	77	Othar	Orlina	Svaldir
53	Ivor	Kailis	Maedhros	78	Othric	Orlith	Tarnor
54	Kaelor	Kalyn	Maelorin	79	Raenir	Ostara	Tarthros
55	Kalric	Keldra	Malthar	80	Rhaelin	Pallara	Therwyn
56	Kendric	Laena	Mogthrasir	81	Rhaelith	Rhaelith	Torgal
57	Kenward	Lenora	Morcar	82	Rhaldir	Rhaena	Uldren
58	Khael	Leora	Morwyn	83	Rhianor	Rhianil	Ulfaric
59	Landon	Linnor	Naeldros	84	Saedric	Rilena	Ulveth
60	Leodan	Liora	Norvas	85	Sarren	Saenith	Vaerwyn
61	Lorian	Lirael	Nynor	86	Selric	Sariel	Valros
62	Lorien	Maelith	Odryn	87	Serin	Selaena	Valthar
63	Luthar	Maera	Orwain	88	Silvan	Selena	Vandros
64	Maerric	Maerilwyn	Penrith	89	Thalor	Serelith	Varyn
65	Malorn	Maevia	Penrose	90	Thalric	Taenya	Wraedan
66	Marin	Mairen	Prothero	91	Thandon	Tahlira	Wralen
67	Mathar	Meliora	Ragnor	92	Therian	Thalia	Wrelos
68	Meldrin	Miraen	Rathgwen	93	Theron	Thera	Wrythar
69	Naelric	Naera	Rhygar	94	Turindil	Tirith	Ygmar
70	Neric	Nareth	Rynthor	95	Ulric	Ulaena	Ymredor
71	Nethor	Niawen	Saegir	96	Ulrich	Ulwen	Yrvald
72	Norian	Niora	Saelmar	97	Uthar	Vaelira	Zandryn
73	Norvin	Nolwen	Selgar	98	Vaelric	Vaelwyn	Zarnor
74	Orran	Norwen	Selthor	99	Vandor	Valaena	Zathros
75	Orvin	Olwyn	Sorvryn	100	Vedelris	Vioren	Zorwyn

appendix d: name tables

non-human names

Orc & Half-Orc (Orcish)

d100	First Masculine	Clan	d100	First Masculine	Clan
01	Ak	Ash-Eater	26	Gulnash	Daggerheart
02	Argrak	Ash-Heart	27	Gurzan	Darkbinder
03	Balzug	Ashgrin	28	Haggor	Darkmire
04	Barosh	Banebringer	29	Harnuk	Darktusk
05	Borrak	Bark-Eater	30	Hrashor	Death-Caller
06	Borzok	Barrow-Digger	31	Kaggath	Deathlash
07	Bruvgar	Black-Eyes	32	Karnor	Deathroot
08	Burzol	Blackbrow	33	Karzak	Dimsight
09	Charrag	Blackfeather	34	Khazrul	Direwalker
10	Crugnar	Bloodbrand	35	Khorzug	Duskhorn
11	Dag	Bloodstone	36	Kraggor	Dustclaw
12	Dakrosh	Bloodtide	37	Kragnar	Ember-Eyes
13	Dorruk	Bloody-Claws	38	Krozok	Embercoil
14	Draghor	Bonebarrow	39	Krushgar	Emberthorn
15	Draglok	Bonebreaker	40	Largoth	Fangbreaker
16	Drashnak	Bonecoil	41	Lognar	Fire-Eater
17	Drozgar	Broken-Jaw	42	Lorgath	Fire-Hair
18	Fargul	Burning-Braid	43	Lughor	Flintbrow
19	Garrash	Burnthorn	44	Maggor	Foebinder
20	Garzuk	Charblade	45	Malgar	Four-Fangs
21	Gharlok	Charspike	46	Margor	Friendgutter
22	Ghorak	Coldclaw	47	Marnuk	Gloomfang
23	Gralor	Corpse-Kin	48	Morgash	Grave-Filler
24	Grashnak	Crowcaller	49	Nargul	Graveblade
25	Gruk	Crowfriend	50	Narok	Greedygut

Orc & Half-Orc (Orcish)

d100	First Masculine	Clan
51	Nogror	Grime
52	Orgnar	Grimstalker
53	Orzhok	Gristlegut
54	Prag	Gritfang
55	Raggath	Hardfist
56	Raghor	Hollow-Eye
57	Rokgar	Iron-Eater
58	Rorgath	Irontooth
59	Ruk	Ironskull
60	Sarlog	Jagged-Heart
61	Sarnuk	Lashmaster
62	Shaggor	Light-Drinker
63	Sharzak	Moon-Watcher
64	Skargoth	Nightgorge
65	Skolgar	Rage-Keeper
66	Snag	Red-Smile
67	Strogath	Redmire
68	Tarnak	Redscalp
69	Thorg	Riftwalker
70	Throkor	Rockshadow
71	Torgath	Rot-Eater
72	Traggor	Rust-Bringer
73	Trogosh	Rustfang
74	Trokzag	Saltspire
75	Urgnar	Scorched-Eye
76	Urlok	Shadebringer
77	Urog	Shadowgrin
78	Urthak	Shalebiter
79	Urzath	Shardkeeper
80	Vargul	Sharp-Nose
81	Vorzuk	Skull-Taker
82	Vrogash	Skullmantle
83	Vulgarok	Skullstride
84	Xargath	Snarlthorn
85	Xornuk	Soot-Tongue
86	Yaggor	Stinkrot
87	Yorgath	Stone-Breaker
88	Zaggor	Stone-Face
89	Zarnak	Stormrend
90	Zaroth	Stormseeker
91	Zharlok	Tall-Horns
92	Zog	Thorn-Eater
93	Zolgar	Thorn-Hands
94	Zorgrak	Thornspike
95	Zug	War-Maker
96	Zulgar	War-Master
97	Zundak	Warbrand
98	Zurok	Warseeker
99	Zurrak	White-Watcher
100	Zuzgar	Yellow-Eyes

appendix d: name tables

non-human names

Ogre Name Format

d100	Name Format
01-20	[Descriptor] [Name]
21-40	[Name] (the) [Descriptor]
41-60	[Name] [Epithet]
61-80	[Name] (of) [Place]
81-100	[Title] [Name]

Ogre (Tusker)

d100	Descriptor	Epithet	Place	Title
01-05	Backward	Bent-Nose	Big Log	Boss
06-10	Clumsy	Big-Belly	Blackmarsh	Chief
11-15	Crooked	Crook-Neck	Bone Hill	Cook
16-20	Drunk	Crooked-Tooth	Briarwood	Drummer
21-25	Grinning	Flat-Feet	Broken Bridge	Gentleman/Lady
26-30	Hungry	Greedy-Mouth	Crooked Ridge	Jumper
31-35	Loud	Heavy-Handed	Flowerfield	Killer
36-40	Lumpy	Iron-Jaw	Four Stumps	King/Queen
41-45	Lurking	Long-Legs	Frog Pocket	Loner
46-50	Muddy	Loud-Mouth	Hollow Stump	Lowlife
51-55	Quiet	Muddy-Feet	Lone Tree	Mayor
56-60	Rotten	Quick-Fingers	Moss Hollow	Mister/Missus
61-65	Shaky	Sharp-Tusk	Mud Hollow	Old
66-70	Sleepy	Slow-Step	Sad Creek	Plotter
71-75	Soggy	Small-Thumbs	Skulltown	Preacher
76-80	Stinky	Soft-Paws	Thornwall	Singer
81-85	Stubborn	Stone-Fist	Three Holes	Sir
86-90	Stupid	Thick-Skull	the Bog	Sir/Madam
91-95	Sweaty	Ugly-Ears	the Midden	Stinker
96-100	Woolly	Wide-Gait	the Old Quarry	Thumper

Ogre (Tusker)

d100	Masculine Name	Feminine Name	d100	Masculine Name	Feminine Name
01-02	Alfie	Adele	51-52	Jojo	Hilda
02-04	Alric	Aggie	53-54	Kalle	Josie
05-06	Armand	Amelie	55-56	Karl	Lia
07-08	Bart	Bertha	57-58	Lenny	Liesl
09-10	Bernard	Bessie	59-60	Louis	Lili
11-12	Burt	Blanche	61-62	Loulou	Lizzie
13-14	Charlie	Cara	63-64	Marcel	Lucy
15-16	Claude	Clara	65-66	Mick	Maggie
17-18	Dieter	Dolly	67-68	Ned	Maisie
19-20	Donnie	Doudou	69-70	Otto	Margot
21-22	Dede	Edwina	71-72	Percy	Mathilda
23-24	Emmerich	Elsie	73-74	Pierre	Mimi
25-26	Felix	Ethel	75-76	Reggie	Nanou
27-28	Freddy	Fifi	77-78	Rolf	Nell
29-30	Frint	Fleur	79-80	Ronny	Polly
31-32	Fritz	Flo	81-82	Roro	Rosie
33-34	Gaston	Franzi	83-84	Sepp	Sally
35-36	Gunther	Frieda	85-86	Sid	Sellie
37-38	Gus	Gina	87-88	Ted	Tillie
39-40	Hans	Ginny	89-90	Tim	Trudi
41-42	Hansl	Gizzy	91-92	Tom	Vera
43-44	Harry	Greta	93-94	Toto	Viv
45-46	Heini	Gretl	95-96	Ulf	Wilhelmina
47-48	Henri	Hanni	97-98	Vince	Winnie
49-50	Jack	Hattie	99-100	Will	Eloise

appendix d: name tables

ship names

Ship Name Format

d100	Name Format
01-20	(The) [Noun]
21-40	(The) [Adjective]
41-60	(The) [Adjective] [Noun]
61-80	[Noun] (of the) [Noun]
81-100	[Noun]'s [Noun]

Ship Names

d100	Noun	Adjective	d100	Noun	Adjective
01-02	Banner	Azure	51-52	Pearl	Mighty
03-04	Beacon	Black	53-54	Pinnacle	Noble
05-06	Blade	Blessed	55-56	Raider	Proud
07-08	Brigand	Bold	57-58	Revenge	Radiant
09-10	Crest	Boundless	59-60	Scar	Reckless
11-12	Crown	Brave	61-62	Sentinel	Relentless
13-14	Defender	Bright	63-64	Serpent	Resolute
15-16	Dragon	Crimson	65-66	Star	Ruthless
17-18	Eagle	Cruel	67-68	Storm	Savage
19-20	Falcon	Cursed	69-70	Sun	Shadowy
21-22	Flame	Dark	71-72	Sword	Shimmering
23-24	Fortune	Dauntless	73-74	Tempest	Silent
25-26	Fury	Dread	75-76	Terror	Silver
27-28	Gale	Fearless	77-78	Thunder	Stalwart
29-30	Glory	Fearsome	79-80	Tide	Steadfast
31-32	Hammer	Fierce	81-82	Triumph	Stormy
33-34	Hawk	Fiery	83-84	Valor	Swift
35-36	Heart	Gallant	85-86	Vanguard	Terrible
37-38	Herald	Glorious	87-88	Vengeance	Thundering
39-40	Honor	Golden	89-90	Venture	Untamed
41-42	Horizon	Grim	91-92	Victory	Unyielding
43-44	Leviathan	High	93-94	Voyager	Valiant
45-46	Lion	Invincible	95-96	Wind	Vigilant
47-48	Maiden	Iron	97-98	Wolf	Wild
49-50	Oath	Majestic	99-100	Wrath	Winged

appendix e: treasure

Although this isn't primarily a game about acquiring "stuff", who doesn't like finding goodies? Assign a Treasure Type (A through F) to monsters, enemies, or lairs as you see fit. Stronger opponents and more dangerous places will have higher Treasure Types, or possibly two or more types. A lowly bandit might have Treasure Type F, while a pirate captain might have Type B and D, and a dragon's horde could have A ×4, B ×3, and C ×1.

Roll on the Treasure Item Table with the following modifications for Type:

Treasure Type	Modifications
A	1d100+20
B	1d100+10
C	1d100
D	1d100-10
E	1d100-20
F	1d100-30

The Treasure Item Table entries are intended to provide ideas to get you started. Use them as inspiration for your own creations.

Treasure Item Table

d100	Treasure Item	ENC	d100	Treasure Item	ENC
01-02	1d6 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same*.	1/100	25-26	Torn banner with faded heraldry. Ancient/defeated/royal house. Worth 4d12 sp to the right buyer.	Small
03-04	Faded map. Leads to a distant hidden item or location.	Tiny	27-28	Faded painting. Has cultural/historical significance. Worth 3d20 sp to the right buyer.	Small
05-06	Leather journal. Contains detailed notes of a mysterious location.	Tiny	29-30	Thread, consumable. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d6 for total SLs available.	Varies
07-08	Anti-infection poultice. +1 Toughness vs Infection.	Tiny	31-32	Wooden Holy Symbol (+1 SL) of a random deity.	Tiny
09-10	Natural healing potion. Allows for 2 Recovery Rolls.	Small	33-34	Masterwork Item**** (roll 1d100-20 on the subtable).	Varies
11-12	Natural healing potion. Heals a total of 3 WP over a minute.	Small	35-36	3d10 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same* OR 1d6 Weave Reagents.	1/100
13-14	Old rusted key. It opens a door somewhere...	Tiny	37-38	Beautiful tapestry. Shows the story of the gods/the Shroud/historical events. Worth 2d100 sp.	Small
15-16	Object of writing**. Worth 2d10 sp.	Tiny	39-40	Jewelry worth 2d20+10 Silver coins.	Tiny
17-18	Enough supplies to replenish (d6) 1-2 : Gear; 3-4 : Medical; 5-6 : Rations dice up to 2d4 die steps.	Supply	41-42	Thread, consumable. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d8 for total SLs available.	Varies
19-20	2d6 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same* OR 1d4 Weave Reagents.	1/100	43-44	Anti-infection poultice. +2 Toughness vs Infection.	Tiny
21-22	Tattered cloak with unusual pattern or stitching. Worth 2d20 sp or more to the right buyer.	Tiny	45-46	Natural healing potion. Allows for 3 Recovery Rolls.	Small
23-24	Cracked chalice. Religious, worth 3d10 sp or more to the right buyer.	Tiny	47-48	Natural healing potion. Heals a total of 5 WP over a minute.	Small

Treasure Item Table

d100	Treasure Item	ENC
49-50	Masterwork Item**** (roll 1d100-10 on the subtable).	Varies
51-52	Thread, consumable. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d10 for total SLs available.	Varies
53-54	1d12×10 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same* OR 1d8 Weave Reagents.	1/100
55-56	Enchanted item. d4, Weave user only, random Bind & Strand effect***.	Varies
57-58	Object of writing**. Worth 5d10 sp.	Tiny
59-60	Ornate sword/dagger sheathe. Historical/artistic artifact. Worth 1d20×20 sp to the right buyer.	Tiny
61-62	Grimoire. Used in rituals. Pick 1d3 random Binds or Strands***. Roll 1d6 for Thread Die value: 1-2 : d4; 3 : d6; 4 : d8; 5 : d10; 6 : d12.	Small
63-64	Masterwork Item**** (roll 1d100 on the subtable).	Varies
65-66	Thread, consumable. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d12 for total SLs available.	Varies
67-68	Gems and jewelry worth 1d6×50 sp.	Small
69-70	1d100×5 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same* or 1d10 Weave Reagents.	1/100
71-72	Drinking horn. Covered in runes. Restores 1 Fatigue per day.	Small
73-74	Golden Holy Symbol (+1 SL). Pick a random deity.	Tiny
75-76	Enchanted item. d6, Weave user only, random Bind & Strand effect***.	Varies
77-78	Iron torc with garnet insets. Worth 1d100×2 sp to the right buyer.	Tiny
79-80	Object of writing**. Worth 1d100×3 sp.	Tiny
81-82	An Arcane Tether to a non-named Summoned Creature.	Varies
83-84	Enchanted item. d8, Weave user only, random Bind & Strand effect***.	Varies
85-86	Thread, Thread Die. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d6 for die type: 1-2 : d6; 3-6 : d8.	Varies
87-88	Masterwork Item**** (roll 1d100+10 on the subtable).	Varies
89-90	Anti-infection poultice. +3 Toughness vs Infection.	Tiny
91-92	Natural healing potion. Allows for 5 Recovery Rolls.	Small
93-94	Natural healing potion. Heals a total of 10 WP over a minute.	Small
95-96	Object of writing**. Worth 1d10×50 sp.	Tiny
97-98	Enchanted item. d6, any user, random Bind & Strand effect***.	Varies
99-100	Natural healing potion. Allows for 8 Recovery Rolls.	Small
101-102	Natural healing potion. Heals a total of 15 WP over a minute.	Small
103-104	Masterwork Item**** (roll 1d100+20 on the subtable).	Varies
105-106	Thread, Thread Die. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d6 for die type: 1 : d6; 2-3 : d8; 4-5 : d10; 6 : d12.	Varies
107-108	d100×10 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same* OR 1d12 Weave Reagents.	1/100
109-110	Gems and jewelry worth 1d6×100 sp.	Small
111-112	Enchanted item. d8, any user, random Bind & Strand effect***.	
113-114	Thread, Thread Die. One random (d6) 1-3 : Bind or 4-6 : Strand***. Roll 1d6 for die type: 1: d8; 2-4 : d10; 5-6 : d12.	
115-116	d100×15 Silver coins, or unique item worth the same* OR 2d6 Weave Reagents.	
117-118	Enchanted item. d10, any user, random Bind & Strand effect***.	
119	An Arcane Tether with the True Name of a unique Summoned Creature or a Spellweaver.	
120	Roll twice on this chart, re-rolling results of 120.	

*Roll on the Solo Roleplaying chapter's Event Randomizers Tables and interpret.

**Roll on the Objects of Writing Subtable .

***Roll on the Random Binds and Strands Subtable .

****Roll on the Masterwork Items Subtable .

appendix e: treasure

treasure item subtables

Objects of Writing

d100	Object (all tiny items)	Subject	Author
1-17	Vellum book with black ink	Letter	Loremaster
18-21	Stag antler with etched script	Biography	Royal
22-25	Set of wolf teeth with tiny script	Autobiography	Noble
26-29	Amber plate with iron letters suspended inside	Memoir	Godbound
30-33	Wooden tablet with text burned in	History	Spellweaver
34-37	Slate tablet with chiseled text	Essay	Peasant
38-41	Horizontal parchment scroll with silver ink text	Philosophical treatise	Warrior
42-45	Bone plaque with chiseled text filled with colored wax	Travel narrative	Squire
46-49	Vellum scroll with black ink	Fiction	Madman
50-53	Copper sheet with acid-etched text	Songs/hymns	Child
54-57	Dried leaves tied with twine with charcoal text	Treaty	Creature
58-61	Silk cloth with thread-embroidered text	Epic poetry	Spirit
62-65	Pottery shards with vermillion pigment text	Manual	Bard
66-69	Stone tablet with gold leaf inlay	Religious text	Rogue
70-73	Clay tablet with stamped pictorial symbols	Mythology	Merchant
74-77	Leather scroll with black ink	Journal	Ranger
77-80	Clasped parchment book with black ink	Play	Emissary
81-84	Paper book with sepia ink	Royal decree	Diplomat
85-88	Tree Bark with ochre pigment text	Folklore	Civilian
89-92	Ceramic tile with text baked into surface	Inventory list	Explorer
93-95	Linen cloth with dyed script	Deed	Mariner
96-97	Large seashell with text scratched in	Hidden map	Dwarf
98-99	Creature femur bone with lapis lazuli ink script	Skill book*	Bolg Fiir
00	Rough uncut stone with chiseled text	Grimoire	Duanan Seethe

*Determine random skill; spending one month reading gives a one-time bonus of +3%

Random Binds & Strands

d10	Bind	d10	Strand
1-2	Change	1	Air
		2	Beasts
3-4	Conjure	3	Body
		4	Earth
5-6	Control	5	Fire
		6	Plants
7-8	Destroy	7	Spheres
		8	Spirit
9-0	Witness	9	Thought
		0	Water

Examples of Threads

Bind	Examples of Threads
Change	A lump of clay; a butterfly; a stalk of sprouting wheat; a blooming flower; an autumn leaf; a rusting nail; a cracked egg; an icicle
Conjure	Two identical coins rubbing together; a small horn with an apple inside; a vial of smoke; a painter's brush in vibrant colors; a bundle of woven threads; a vibrating bell
Control	Iron manacles; puppet strings; a steel gauntlet; a coiled whip; a scepter; a length of sturdy rope; an iron lock; a small gear
Destroy	A broken dagger blade; a pinch of ash; a withered rose; a shattered mirror shard; a cracked gemstone; a fragment of a crumbled statue; a tattered flag; a scorched feather
Witness	A crystal ball; a desiccated ear; a pair of spectacles; a preserved eyeball; a magnifying glass; a weathered journal in a strange language; a piece of a window frame; soil from a footprint

Strand	Examples of Threads
Air	A hand fan; a brass whistle; a white feather; a delicate wind chime; a scrap of sailcloth; a weather vane; a dandelion puff; a colorful flag
Beast	A hawk's beak; a turtle's shell; a leather scrap; a stag's antler; a bird's nest; a snake's shed skin; a wolf's fang; a beetle's carapace; a horseshoe
Body	A preserved finger; a dried heart; white bandages; a broken fingernail; a bloodstained shirt; small surgical scissors; a vial of blood; a patch of skin with faded scars
Earth	An obsidian shard; a clump of soil; a heavy marble sphere; sand in a glass jar; a polished river stone; a hunk of iron ore; a steel ingot
Fire	An ever-smoldering ember; a candle wick; a shard of glass that always reflects sunlight; a charred branch; flint and steel; a blackened fire poker; a melted wax seal; a lantern; a firefly in a jar
Plant	A pinecone; a rose petal; a patch of moss; a bundle of dried herbs; a vine; a sheaf of wheat; an acorn; a cactus spine; a mat of woven reeds
Spheres	A crystal ball with a shadowy creature's face inside; a diagram of the constellations; an ever-spinning top; a mirror that reflects an empty room; an ever-changing map; a small clock that ticks backward; a silver coin that flickers between solid and immaterial form
Spirit	A mummified hand; a small stone grave marker; a vial containing a last captured breath; a lantern that flickers with no flame; a wreath of dead white flowers; a coffin latch; a bloodstained shroud; a rotting doll
Thought	A small silk pillow; a blank book; a portrait of a dreamscape; a weather journal with half-formed ideas; a chessboard with images of the pieces carved into it, mid-game; a sealed letter; a small patchwork quilt; a bookmark
Water	A vial of mist; a seashell; a pendant with runic waves carved on it; a fish-scale bookmark; a piece of coral; a waterskin; a ceramic water pitcher; a wooden bucket

appendix e: treasure

Masterwork Items

d100	Item and Skill Bonus	ENC
01-02	Well-made boots. Adds +5 to Athletics rolls.	Tiny
03-04	Sturdy waterskin. Adds +5 to Endurance rolls.	Tiny
05-06	Masterwork lockpick. Adds +5 to Locks & Traps rolls.	Tiny
07-08	Glass monocle. Adds +5 to Perception rolls.	Tiny
09-10	Sattagoyan horse warrior's stitched saddle. Adds +5 to Ride rolls.	Medium
11-12	Masterwork sail. Adds +5 to Sail/Boat rolls.	Medium
13-14	Soft leather gloves. Adds +5 to Sleight of Hand rolls.	Tiny
15-16	Tent and pegs. Adds +5 to Survival rolls.	Tiny
17-18	Dark cloak. Adds +5 to Stealth rolls.	Tiny
19-20	Field journal. Adds +5 to Track rolls.	Tiny
21-22	Meditation amulet. Adds +5 to Willpower rolls.	Tiny
23-24	Mask. Adds +5 to Deceive rolls.	Tiny
25-26	Calabash pipe. Adds +5 to Insight rolls.	Tiny
27-28	Horn inlaid with gold runes. Adds +5 to Inspire rolls.	Small
29-30	Facial tattoos. Adds +5 to Intimidate rolls.	N/A
31-32	Musical instrument. Adds +5 to Perform rolls.	Small
33-34	Wineskin with etched runes. Adds +5 to Persuade rolls.	Tiny
35-36	Garment of the Court. Adds +5 to Protocol rolls.	Tiny
37-38	Expensive perfume/cologne. Adds +5 to Seduce rolls.	Tiny
39-40	Book of Clever Phrases. Adds +5 to Wit rolls.	Tiny
41-42	Book of history. Adds +5 to Ancient Lore	Tiny
43-44	Crystal of arcane focus. Adds +5 to Arcana rolls.	Tiny
45-46	Merchant scales. Adds +5 to Commerce rolls.	Tiny
47-48	Well-written folk song. Adds +5 to Common Lore rolls.	N/A
49-50	Tool set. Adds +5 to (d6) 1-3 : Craft: Artistic; 4-6 : Craft: Practical.	Small
51-52	Holy finger bone relic. Adds +5 to Divinity rolls.	Tiny
53-54	Pain-relieving herbs. Adds +5 to Heal rolls.	Tiny
55-56	Mortar & pestle. Adds +5 to Naturewise rolls.	Tiny
57-58	Wanted poster. Adds +5 to Streetwise rolls.	Tiny
59-60	Foreign phrase book. Adds +5 to rolls of a specific Language. My hovercraft is full of eels.	Tiny
61-62	Masterwork weapon. +1 damage or +5 to skill. Roll d10: 1-2 : Light; 3-4 : Medium; 5-6 : Heavy; 7-8 : Missile; 9-0 : Thrown	As weapon
63-64	Masterwork armor piece. Roll 1d6: 1-4 : +1 AP; 5-6 : -1 Bulk. Roll d12 for location: 1-5 : Body; 6-7 : Arms; 8-9 : Legs; 10-11 : Head; 12 : Full suit. Roll d20 for type: 1-4 : Padding; 5-8 : Quilt; 9-11 : Leather; 12-14 : Reinforced Leather; 15-16 : Mail; 17 : Bone; 18-19 : Scale; 20 : Plate	As armor
65	Dowsing stick. Adds +1 SL to Survival rolls to replenish Ration dice in the wilds.	Tiny
66	Well-worn backpack. Adds +1 SL to Quartermaster Survival rolls.	Tiny
67	Book of Kings. Adds +5 to Ancient Lore rolls regarding history, and +10 to Protocol rolls if read before consulting nobility of any country.	Tiny
68	Sturdy leather boots. Adds +10 to Athletics rolls.	Tiny

Masterwork Items

d100	Item and Skill Bonus	ENC
69	Thick belt with intricate buckle. Adds +10 to Endurance rolls.	Tiny
70	Masterwork lockpick. Adds +10 to Locks& Traps rolls.	Tiny
71	Spyglass. Adds +10 to Perception rolls.	Tiny
72	Sattagoyan Khan's stitched saddle. Adds +10 to Ride rolls.	Medium
73	Masterwork sail. Adds +10 to Sail/Boat rolls.	Medium
74	A pair of weighted bone dice. Adds +10 to Sleight of Hand rolls.	Tiny
75	Rune-stitched waterskin. Adds +10 to Survival rolls.	Tiny
76	Shadowed hood. Adds +10 to Stealth rolls.	Tiny
77	Lodestone compass. Adds +10 to a Guide's Track rolls.	Tiny
78	Finely crafted circlet. Adds +10 to Willpower rolls.	Tiny
79	Disguise kit. Adds +10 to Deceive rolls.	Tiny
80	Book on social relations. Adds +10 to Insight rolls.	Tiny
81	Richly-colored banner. Adds +10 to Inspire rolls.	Small
82	Bloody brass knuckles. Adds +10 to Intimidate rolls.	Tiny
81	Richly-colored banner. Adds +10 to Inspire rolls.	Small
82	Bloody brass knuckles. Adds +10 to Intimidate rolls.	Tiny
83	The Collected Works of playwright Wayhlem Catchstaff. Adds +10 to Perform rolls.	Tiny
84	Masterwork instrument. Adds +10 to Perform rolls using music.	Small
85	Velvet cloak. Adds +10 to Persuade rolls.	Tiny
86	Signet ring. Adds +10 to Protocol rolls.	Tiny
87	Expensive perfume/cologne. Adds +10 to Seducerolls.	Tiny
88	Book of Clever Phrases. Adds +10 to Wit rolls.	Tiny
89	Loremaster's journal. Adds +10 to Ancient Lore	Tiny
90	Lich's phylactery, empty. Adds +10 to Arcana rolls.	Tiny
91	Merchant scales. Adds +10 to Commerce rolls.	Tiny
92	Traveler's almanac. Adds +10 to Common Lore rolls.	Tiny
93	Masterwork tool set. Adds +10 to (d6) 1-3 : Craft: Artistic; 4-6 Craft: Practical.	Small
94	Holy chalice. Adds +10 to Divinity rolls.	Small
95	Expert surgical tools. Adds +10 to Heal rolls.	Tiny
96	Portable herbarium. Adds +10 to Naturewise rolls.	Small
97	Black market coin. Adds +10 to Streetwise rolls.	Tiny
98	Advanced foreign phrase book. Adds +10 to rolls of a specific Language. Do you want to come back to my place, bouncy-bouncy?	Tiny
99	Masterwork weapon. +2 damage or +10 to skill. Roll d10: 1-2 : Light; 3-4 : Medium; 5-6 : Heavy; 7-8 : Missile; 9-0 : Thrown	As weapon
100+	Masterwork armor piece. Roll 1d6: 1-4 : +2 AP; 5-6 : -2 Bulk. Roll d12 for location: 1-5 : Body; 6-7 : Arms; 8-9 : Legs; 10-11 : Head; 12 : Full suit. Roll d20 for type: 1-4 : Padding; 5-8 : Quilt; 9-11 : Leather; 12-14 : Reinforced Leather; 15-16 : Mail; 17 : Bone; 18-19 : Scale; 20 : Plate	As armor

appendix e: treasure

example unique magic items

The following examples of special, unique magic items fall under the Law of Mystery : there is neither explanation for their existence nor instructions for their creation.

charcoal of the panther

This enchanted stick of black charcoal can be used to summon a magical, extra-dimensional panther. To use it, the bearer must draw the likeness of a black panther on parchment or vellum and, as an action, succeed on a Craft: Artistic roll. If successful, a magical panther appears from the image and serves the artist for a number of hours equal to the SLs of the roll. The artist may dismiss the panther before its allotted duration expires.

The panther is intelligent, understands all spoken languages, and will follow the artist's commands to the best of its natural abilities. It possesses the capabilities of a powerful great cat--able to track, hunt, scout, fight, or silently accompany its master.

The charcoal contains 100 SLs worth of summoning power. Each use deducts the number of SLs generated from this total. For example, a drawing that yields 6 SLs consumes 6 points, leaving 94 remaining. Once the total reaches 0, the charcoal loses all magic, and the panther may never be summoned again.

Only one panther may be active at a time. A new summoning cannot occur while a previous panther still exists. The panther's wounds can be treated (it doesn't suffer from infection), but it always appears uninjured when summoned. If the panther is killed, the charcoal immediately crumbles to dust.

Extra-dimensional Panther

Challenging

Size Med Init 16 Move 2 Ferocity 4

Dodge 80, Might 75, Athletics 90, Endurance 70, Willpower 40, Perception 80, Stealth 90, Track 90

Claws & Teeth 75 Ex2, Dmg 4 + P2 (CL2, CS3, T3, Gr2)

1-4	Body 3 AP	8	RRearLeg 2 AP
5	Tail 1 AP	9	LRearLeg 2 AP
6	RFrontLeg 2 AP	0	Head 3 AP
7	LFrontLeg 2 AP		

Toughness +3 DeathThreshold 15

Elusive : Can freely Run away from an engagement without having to perform a Fighting Withdrawal, and without provoking a free attack. Move 2 during Elusive movement.

Natural Weapons : Does not suffer -20 Might vs armed opponents, lethal damage, cannot be Disarmed. Can parry with Claws.

Night Vision : The creature can see in the dark, like a cat.

Quadruped : A four-legged creature only falls Prone from impairment if two or more legs become impaired (and if the Wound Die indicates). A quadruped with one or more impaired legs cannot Run or Charge. Knocking a quadruped prone using the Trip maneuver costs an extra 3 SLs.

Terrain Mastery : The creature can Run and Charge in or through Rough zones without the need for Athletics rolls. It will not fall Prone if being Driven Back into a Rough zone.

ember of the endless march

A coal split into three pieces and wrapped in dried grass. If a piece is eaten and a successful Survival or Enduranceroll is made, it wards off the worst effects of hunger, thirst, and weather: the user ignores the next SL×2 points of Fatigue accrued from any travel. The ember's effects expire at the turning of the moon (a month), and may only be used once per moon. It is used up after 3 uses.

fang of the dead trail

A blackened canine tooth strung on a leather thong. If planted into fresh soil and left overnight, it "feeds" on old trails. The next day, the bearer gains +20 to any Track or Survival rolls. If used on a Journey, one leg receives a +20 to either the Guide's Track roll or the Quartermaster's Survival roll. The fang may only be used 3 times before it turns to brittle ash.

lamp of the last hour

An old ship's lantern with a cracked green lens. If lit with a successful Arcana roll and placed near a corpse less than a day old, the flame flickers into the shape of the deceased's soul and speaks a single sentence. The message length and clarity depend on the SLs rolled. The lantern functions 7 times before the lens shatters.

mask of flowing faces

This pale grey mask has no features. If a character paints a face onto it using Craft: Artistic (or Craft: Practical at -10), and then wears the mask, they take on the appearance, voice, and mannerisms of that person for SL × 10 minutes. It does not grant memories or skills. The face must be of someone known to the user, and if the painted person has a True Name that is known to the user, the roll is made with +20. The mask allows 10 transformations before becoming stiff and unusable.

the liar's coin

A slim black coin engraved with a mask on one side. The coin has an inherent magical Deceive skill of 90 Ex3. If flipped and caught while telling a lie, one person of the user's choosing who hears it and fails an opposed Insight vs the coin's Deceive becomes convinced of the falsehood for the coin's DoS × 2 minutes--regardless of contrary evidence. The coin holds 6 uses. Each lie drains one use.

the murmuring quill

A feather from a black mockingbird. If used to write poetry, drama, or prose with a successful Craft: Artistic or Perform roll, the words take on a subtle enchantment. Those who read or hear the piece suffer -20 to Insight or Willpower against the writer's intent for the Craft: Artistic or Perform's SLs × 10 minutes. The quill contains 30 SLs worth of ink.

wax of stolen echoes

A sealed lump of black wax. If melted and poured into someone's ear (requiring a successful Heal roll to avoid causing a 1-point Head wound), that person can make a Perform roll and perfectly mimic any voice they've heard in the last 24 hours for SL × 10 minutes. The wax holds 5 doses.

the spirit mantle

One of several mysterious artefacts created by the legendary Spellweaver and member of the Order of the Purifying Flame, Cheryln Spiritbane, this cloth shroud was designed to trap the most powerful undead creatures that could not otherwise be killed - dreadful beings like liches or the most powerful Death Knights. If placed upon an undead (requiring an action and a Thrown or Athletics skill roll if in combat), the creature is put into a kind of stasis: it is rendered helpless and, for all intents and purposes, is "asleep". The creature can make a Willpower roll at -30 once every year to break free of the stasis. If the undead successfully breaks free, the Mantle is rendered useless.

resources

Empires List

d100	d100
1-5	51-55
6-10	56-60
11-15	61-65
16-20	66-70
21-25	71-75
26-30	76-80
31-35	81-85
36-40	86-90
41-45	91-95
46-50	96-100

Spellweaver Style List

d100	Effect
1-5	
6-10	
11-15	
16-20	
21-25	
26-30	
31-35	
36-40	
41-45	
46-50	
51-55	
56-60	
61-65	
66-70	
71-75	
76-80	
81-85	
86-90	
91-95	
96-100	

ability score descriptors personality traits

name race sex age

culture previous career size xp

combat	%	ex	adventuring	%	ex	social	%	ex	lore	%	ex	binds	%	ex	strands	lvl
dodge			athletics			deceive			ancient lore			change			air	
melee: light			endurance			insight			arcana			conjure			beast	
melee:medium			locks & traps			inspire			commerce			control			body	
melee: heavy			perception			intimidate			common lore			destroy			earth	
might			ride			perform			craft: pract.			witness			fire	
missile			sail/boat			persuade			craft: art			language	%	ex	plant	
thrown			sleight of hand			protocol			divinity						spheres	
			stealth			seduce			heal						spirit	
			survival			wit			naturewise						thought	
			track						streetwise					-wise	water	
			willpower						-wise					-wise	starting piety	

resolve & fatigue

attributes

max resolve initiative init penalty total toughness death threshold lethality level

wounds

total lethal wp base recovery shock? rounds dying

talents

BODY 1-5

imp

armor t? ap sund bulk

wp nl? wounds inf rb

head 0

imp

armor ap sund bulk

wp nl? wounds inf rb

right arm 6

imp

armor t? ap sund bulk

wp nl? wounds inf rb

left arm 7

imp

armor t? ap sund bulk

wp nl? wounds inf rb

right leg 8

imp

armor ap sund bulk

wp nl? wounds inf rb

left leg 9

imp

armor ap sund bulk

wp nl? wounds inf rb

armor penalties

athletics
rise from prone
stealth
dodge
perception

shield

split

size:

ap shb enc

detailed locations

body

1-5 . . . . chest
6-8. . . . stomach
9-0 . . . groin

head

1-2 . . . . skull
3 . . . . . left eye
4 . . . . . right eye
5-6. . . . face
7 . . . . . nose
8 . . . . . right ear
9 . . . . . left ear
0 . . . . . neck

arms

1-2 . . . . shoulder
3-4. . . . bicep
5 . . . . . elbow
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0 . . . . . foot

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name

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shared

shared

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